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I.I All Things were restored to Order



The day, eternally joyous and sad, the Son of God Made Man was placed on a cross, all things at once were restored to order, and in that divine order the cross was raised above all things created. Some of these manifested the goodness of God, some His mercy, others His justice.

The cross alone was the symbol of His love and the pledge of His grace. Through it the confessors confessed, and the virgins

were chaste, and the fathers of the desert led angelic lives, and the martyrs were firm witnesses who laid down their lives with manly and unshaken constancy. From the sacrifice of the cross proceeded that marvelous energy with which the weak astounded the strong, the proscribed and disarmed ascended the Capitol, and some poor fishermen conquered the world.

Through the cross all who conquer gain victory; all who combat, strength; all who seek it, mercy; the unprotected, protection; those who are sad, joy; and consolation, all who weep. Since the cross was raised in the air there is no man who cannot live in heaven before his mortal remains are consigned to the earth; for if he lives here in tribulation, he lives there in hope.

DONOSO CORTES

Posted on 2010-04-02 by Cologero

1.2 The Hermetic Method

Ask, and it will be given you
seek, and you will find;
knock, and it will be opened to you.

Luke 9:9

Hermetism differs from both religion and science, although it does not attempt to replace them. Unlike religion, which accepts things on faith, and unlike science, which is based on facts and theories, Hermetism seeks knowledge. Not knowledge of facts, no matter how mystical, sublime, or luminous, nor knowledge of articles of faith or scientific knowledge, but knowledge of the mysteries, a direct, unmediated, intuitive knowledge.

Hermetism is a way or a path, so it must be traversed. Reading another book or article, or following another guru, will not lead to Hermetic knowledge. Instead, spiritual practice is absolutely essential.

In the *Letter IV on the Emperor*, **Valentin Tomberg** explains the essential prerequisite of spiritual exercises:

One must establish the state of consciousness suitable for receiving revelations.

This requires the following four steps:

1. The state of concentration without effort
2. Watchful interior silence
3. An inspired activity of imagination and thought where the conscious Self acts with the superconscious
4. The conscious Self then stops its activity and contemplates everything which preceded

Tomberg recommends the *Gospels*, *John's Revelation* and parts of the Old Testament (e.g. *Genesis*, *Ezekiel*) as suitable subjects for meditation or spiritual exercise, not only the Arcana of the Tarot.

Now, it will happen that different Hermetists will develop skills in the respective areas they chose to meditate on. But that is not what unites them, since only the depths of their meditations can do so. To further clarify this point, Tomberg makes a distinction between the individual knowledge of Hermetists — which is knowledge of particular facts — and their common knowledge, which is of the mysteries and involves depth of consciousness.

For example, one may know his past lives as a fact, another may know about the chakras — that is their individual interest and vocation. If I, for

example, have no knowledge of past lives as a fact, then I simply ignore it; it is not something I am obligated to believe. So Hermetism is not an accumulation of facts to be studied and accepted uncritically.

Rather, Tomberg makes clear that Hermetism is a method. Just reading books will help no one become deep. Tomberg explains:

Spiritual exercises alone have taught [the initiate] — no theory or doctrine may in any way have rendered him capable of knowing how to know.

This will lead to a different kind of knowing, as represented by the Emperor. Hence,

Hermetism does not teach what one ought to believe about man, God, and nature, but it teaches rather how to ask, seek and knock in order to arrive at mystical experience, gnostic illumination, and the magical effect.

Only after having asked, sought, and knocked, can one know.

Posted on 2010-08-09 by Cologero

1.3 Spiritual Challenge and Renewal

A religious factor is necessary as the background for a true heroic conception of life that must be essential for our political alignment. It is necessary to feel in oneself the evidence that there is a higher life beyond this terrestrial life, because only those who feel this way possess an unbreakable and unconquerable strength, only they will be capable of an absolute enthusiasm.

JULIUS EVOLA

After the devastation of World War II, **Julius Evola** was asked to formulate a program for the political and spiritual renewal of post war Europe. Evola was able to recognize the ideal of highest spiritual tradition of Europe, which he described this way:

Certainly, if Catholicism were capable of making a program of high ascesis its own and exactly on this base, almost like a recovery of the spirit of the best Medieval crusader, makes of faith the soul of an armed bloc of forces, almost a new close-knit Templar Order, relentless against the currents of chaos, breakdowns, subversion, and the practical materialism of the modern world — certainly, in such a case, and also in the case that, at the minimum, it held firm to the positions of the Syllabus, there could not be a single instance of doubt about our choice.

JULIUS EVOLA, *Point II*¹

Unfortunately, after looking around — rather cursorily in our opinion — he determined that there was currently no organisation that supported such a spiritual orientation, as it perhaps had done in the past. Hence, he concluded that a “pure reference to a transcendental spirit” would suffice. Well, more than six decades later, it certainly has not sufficed.

We can start, for example, with the Syllabus² mentioned, which is the 19th century Syllabus of Errors. It is an easy to read collection of false opinions. Who today would deny all, or at least most, of those errors? We don’t see that even among *soi disant* Traditionalists. Evola’s attitude was that if George won’t do it, then he’ll go his own way. And he took many along with him. Despite his vast erudition, Evola always remained at the level of doxa (opinions) and dianoia (theories). He never — his writings and interviews show this — was able to reach the level of episteme, the goal of all valid Traditions. Obviously, a vague affirmation of some transcendental spirit goes nowhere.

¹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=4828>

²<https://www.papalencyclicals.net/Pius09/p9syll.htm>

The True Revival In point of fact, there has been, and still is, such a program. Although not centrally organised, there are texts and even small groups working in the USA and in Europe, that fulfil the conditions mentioned above. That is why, for us, there is no doubt about our choice.

For example, **Wolfgang Smith**, starting from the insights of Rene Guenon, has revived such a tradition within Catholicism. Specifically, he has written on the Christian Kabbalah, the chakras, different levels of existence, Jacob Boehme, Meister Eckhart, in an effort to bring more depth into the Western tradition.

Boris Mouravieff, working completely independently, has revealed and reformulated the teachings of a monastery on Mount Athos. A glance at his bibliography shows many familiar names, including Boehme, Eckhart, and Guenon.

But **Valentin Tomberg** has gone the furthest, particularly in his *Meditations on the Tarot*, which is the summa of his life's work. First of all, he addresses Evola's concern incidentally. As a spiritual reality, the Catholic Church is the Bride of Christ. However, as a human institution, it also has an egregore, a phantom being, which is a human-created parody of the spiritual reality. Many people get fixated on the egregore and reject the whole tradition. Those with spiritual vision, on the other hand, see a living stream of truth and life, as well as a way to achieve them.

An Incomplete Path The *Meditations* are a massive accomplishment. Nevertheless, there is much that is left out, and he expects the task that he initiated to be continued by those he considers his "friends". I know some of those who have indeed continued the work of Christian Hermetism, although not in such a public way as we have. Still, there is much more to be done.

Tomberg left us a long list of precursors. These include philosophers, saints, Hermetists, theologians, scientists, psychologists, inter alia. We have endeavoured to bring many of their writings to a wider attention.

However, as a precursor to some planned articles, we need to make here some specific points. In particular, we need to put his earlier writings into context with his later. Although he allegedly desired to be known by the Meditations, there are some allusions that make that impossible.

Relationship to Steiner Although Tomberg became quite critical of the Anthroposophical Society (and vice versa), he always held **Rudolf Steiner** in high regard. For example, he wrote this in Letter XV:

And yet Rudolf Steiner has certainly said things of a nature to awaken the greatest creative elan! His series of lectures on the four Gospels, his lectures at Helsingfors and Dusseldorf on the celestial hierarchies — without mentioning his book on the inner work leading to initiation (*Knowledge of the Higher Worlds and its Attainment*) — would alone suffice to inflame a deep and mature creative enthusiasm in every soul who aspires to authentic experience of the spiritual world.

Nevertheless, there is really nothing in the Meditations specifically referencing those works. I've read most of those lectures, and there are things in them that may be quite surprising. Nevertheless, we have to assume that they play a background role in the Meditations, even if not explicitly stated. This will be confirmed in the next section.

Cosmology A revived tradition requires a suitable cosmology, certainly one that can challenge the generally accepted scientific version. In *Letter X*, we are given some sources for the creation of such a cosmology.

Firstly, the Fall... here we are confronted with the Biblical account of paradise and the six days of creation; with the impressive tableau of natural evolution that science advances; with the contours of a majestic outline by the genius of ancient India of kalpas, manvantaras and yugas — a world of periodicity

and rhythm, a world dreamt periodically by cosmic consciousness; with the exposition (following the *Stanzas of Dzyan*) of cosmogony and anthropogony according to the Indo-Tibetan tradition, given by H. P. Blavatsky in the three volumes of her *Secret Doctrine*; with the grandiose tableau of the spiritual evolution of the world through seven so-called “planetary” phases that Rudolf Steiner has bequeathed to the dumbfounded intellectuality of our century; lastly, with the cosmogonies and eschatologies — explicit or implicit — of Hermes Trismegistus, Plato, the Zohar and diverse gnostic schools of the first centuries of our era.

That is a vast amount of material to master. Tomberg himself acknowledges this:

May I be permitted to say straight away that, although I have had actual experience of comparing the whole range of these ideas and documents for more than forty years, I cannot make use of them here in the sense of the treatment which they merit, i.e. to classify them, to extract the essential points of similarity or contrast, to make relevant quotations, etc. If I were to do so, I would drown the essential theme in a sea of secondary elements (secondary with regard to the main theme). Therefore I have to proceed in the following way: the spirit of all the various ideas and documents enumerated above will be present as a general background, but it will be necessary to refrain from any explicit use of the material which they comprise.

In particular, this general background includes Steiner’s *Outline of Occult Science*, which Tomberg alluded to. And this brings the entire story of the spiritual evolution of man, his various bodies, and the activities of the celestial hierarchies, both left and right, in the formation. These notions will be used in future articles.

Psychology Conventional Thomism teaches that man is composed of several sheaths: a physical body, a vegetable soul, an animal soul, and an intellectual soul. Moreover, it is the higher sheaths that form the lower, which is contrary to conventional scientific thought. Unfortunately, philosophers are content to leave it at that, and don't bother to explore the actual consequences of such a teaching.

The esoteric teaching, on the other hand, does so. It may use different names, viz., the physical, etheric, and astral bodies, but the essential elements are the same. The Hermetist, however, will make the efforts to observe the bodies or sheaths. In this way, he can also discern the influences of alien elements on them. That is not the end of the story, since the chakras are also part of one's interiority. The Hermetist will learn about the proper development of the chakras.

The main challenge is that the effort of the I to form the lower sheaths is not yet completed. There is resistance to that; besides, the awareness of the I is mostly dim and the will is weak.

The details cannot all be made public, but it will be shared with our groups at the proper time.

Finis With this being said, we can next complete the discussion of the three temptations in the wilderness.

Posted on 2018-09-09 by Cologero

* * *

Han Fei on 2018-09-10 at 15:56 said:

I wish to ask a question. Would the basic points of adherence required of a Christian be enough for the purpose of personal reintegration, or does the traditional church require the introduction of some sort of esoteric doctrines, morphed over centuries and even taken from exterior traditions such as Judaism and Hinduism? By basic points I mean regular attendance of mass, partaking of the sacraments, and obedience of the commandments. As Evola put it,

to follow the Syllabus, I think he meant more than the 19th century document, but rather the fundamental tenets and duties of the faith.

Mikkel on 2018-09-11 at 21:46 said:

Any points of adherence to anything can never be enough for the personal reintegration you speak of, forgive me if I am miss-assuming the direction of your question. Reintegration sounds to be something one would call more true than simply surface level action that we see today.

Many Catholics follow what some refer to as “Traditional Catholicism” and many at least follow the basic tenants of the faith, as referred to in the article, yet we are where we are today in the current state of things, so in short, no it is not enough. As to the Syllabus, it is being pointed to because of how stark in contrast the Church and anyone else compares points to the statements being made in it, but I believe your thought on how it is more than the document that JE refers to is correct. Maybe it would be better to ask what kind of mindset creates the Syllabus, especially if organic, and how does that mindset reflect the principles enacted (the source)?

The basic points must be followed but that is not the real action, the right action, behind the fundamental tenants and duties and what is incorporated as the body of the Church and the world of the people, more so closer I think to the mindset which I mentioned. The Church does contain truth regardless of how much people wish to distance themselves from it and look at it with disdain and no matter how the failures of the members and leaders of said church affect others it will contain it. No one, not one thing or person or excuse or motivation will excuse the lack of adherence to truth for anyone and the truth of heroic life however will always be within the Church regardless of what anyone does or says even within our time.

Though our cycle is referred to as the “Kali Yuga”, does this mean that truth somehow is gone now? That the validity of any sound tradition is gone? It reflects our manifestation in this world, “Ignorance of dharma will occur” does not mean that dharma is suddenly gone, but the ignorance has appeared. No matter how “pointless” it all is, no ladies wearing veils, kneeling for the Eucharist, or others chanting in Latin will somehow make that easier for “George” to be reintegrated or live in a heroic manner. But I do think that investigating the sources of something like the Syllabus would lead us beyond “doxa (opinions) and dianoia (theories)”.

As Guenon states, an elite is required for these ‘esoteric’ doctrines to be put out into the world, especially in our age. These doctrines need not be taken from others, since they are already reflected and perhaps transposed, even if the Church was lacking in such a doctrine, it should be understood from the source. A variation on a variation leaves much wanting. Maybe this could be done much like seeking the interior of man to understand, the Church must be understood from within or from the source, it has not lost any of its esoteric doctrines, only we need to remember better to then enact it. Tomberg found that all of his thought corresponded

with the what the Church taught, perhaps as the article mentions our way of understanding what the Church is trying to say is only “incomplete” so then it is up to us to complete it.

argusandphoenix on 2018-09-15 at 23:53 said:

We're living through the collapse of a civilization, and not just a culture. So the Church has gotten tangled up in some of the wreckage, or even contributed to it, at times, by dereliction. So the usual strategies (just go to Church, or be a good citizen) aren't going to necessarily place us in the context of the role we are meant to play. Unless you are fortunate, you'll have to go and dig, to some degree, and find deeper currents within and connected to the Church, and in elective affinity or sympathy with it. There's plenty of that material that C. Salvo has been unearthing or dusting off or pointing out on the website. If you just want to be saved and live a good life, the Church certainly still makes that possible. But there are specifically Christian groups of esotericists out there, if that is more of a comfort zone when dealing with “re-integration”.

Agnostia on 2020-09-09 at 23:30 said:

I am not at all convinced that a traditionalist re-invigoration of Catholicism, even within the exoteric domain, is outside the realm of possibility. What is lacking is vision.

It goes without saying that the Church has had little difficulty in incorporating foreign doctrines which are compatible with Catholic dogma or pre-existing doctrine. Perhaps my favorite example of such is that doctrine of ‘guardian angels’, which has it's own specific (let's call it) ‘parallel’ in the ‘personal daimons’ of Apuleius (see *On the God of Socrates*, by the same).

It should also be noted that the process of ‘perfection’, ‘divinization’, ‘theosis’ are not at all unlike the procurement of the ‘diamond-thunderbolt body’ or the discovery of the ‘stone of the philosophers’, the ‘VITRIOL’ic process, etc. when dripped of their otherwise heretical, ‘magical’ dross. One such funny example of this can be seen in the friar Roger Bacon, who in his “*On the Non-Existence of Magic*”, trashes any and all notions of sigils, talismans, spells, theurgical and thaumaturgical ceremonial operations, astrological influences and the like, before giving a near-perfect summation of the hermetic *Opus*, only half-allegorized as a recipe for obtaining gun-powder, all the while upholding himself as an orthodox Catholic and material scientist.

What is so great about hermeticism in particular, is that so many of it's key operations can easily be interpreted, re-contextualized and integrated within a Catholic framework. In fact to do so is hardly new. The concepts, ‘rituals’, and steps mentioned in such works as J. Evola's *Hermetic Tradition & Intro. to Magic* series (properly understood, as these require much review), Guenon's *Perspectives on Initiation*, and the alchemical texts themselves (my favorite being M. Maier's *Atalanta Fugiens*, but even in the more ‘magical’ grimoires like those of Agrippa or the Picatrix, where one finds simultaneously tables of magical correspondences alongside dissertations on the ‘virtue of religion’!) have their almost direct-correlatives in established and orthodox Christian tradition. With some research, and by dropping the superficial hermetic

conceptual labeling, it's not hard to find analogous practices in the *Philokalia* and the other writings of the mystics and Doctors of the Church. Among the certain circles today, there is also a re-awakening of a sense of an objective 'esoteric' meaning in the Biblical texts which are surprisingly neither anti-hermetic nor outside the purview of established Orthodoxy.

What must be done is a selection and compilation of these various techniques, yet presented within a new 'Active' framework, for a particular type of individual.

What about the sorts of mysticism and metaphysics common to the Medieval and Renaissance mystics? Can anything be done with these? There is certainly room for a Platonic-Augustinian Idealism. Recent Popes have affirmed this, among other ways, in their canonization of St. Hildegard and their appraisal of Pseudo-Dionysius. This is to say nothing of some of the honourable, if occasionally anti-traditional and often misunderstood intentions, of the 20th century pioneers of Vatican II.

What about the limitations of the 'mystical-devotional attitude' to which Evola so frequently lamented? This is, in my opinion, the hardest thing to grapple with. While there is obviously nothing inherently wrong with a purely devotional mindset, traditional Christianity, in my opinion, most certainly has been limited by this approach, which as currently practised transparently lacks the autonomous impetus desirable for the 'differentiated man'. It is this approach which has also found itself constricted within the paradigms of a strict Thomism and a rigid pre-occupation with ethics. Undoubtedly this is where the rubber hits the road, and will take the most effort. But to successfully tackle this phenomenon could have such an affect, as to re-vivify that spirit which had previously been crushed by that most famous declaration of Nietzsche, while simultaneously affirming the ideal which Nietzsche himself placed forth: that of the romantic 'free spirit'.

To aggregate and re-present these things, under an old-yet-new framework, has the potential to change the world. More importantly, it has the potential to do so within the range of an established institution and a traditional order. Perhaps there can be no greater 'holding action' than the implementation of this, no greater arsenal of which to use against the 'quantitative' and 'malefic' forces of this end of an era.

Santiago on 2022-03-10 at 21:36 said:

"[Evola] never... was able to reach the level of episteme."

I've been thinking about this line.

Compared to Guenon, Evola ("despite his vast erudition") does seem far less interested in metaphysics, and far more interested in methods, such as Tantric and yogic practices, cultivation of the chakras, empowerment of the will, visualization practices, and all manner of other techniques. Guenon, on the other hand, will discuss these, but always with the emphasis being on their place within a larger framework and a supreme goal.

It almost seems as if Evola was more interested in prolonging his individual existence,

rather than in transcending it entirely. Is this a fair criticism? And whether or not it is, to what extent do the two paths converge?

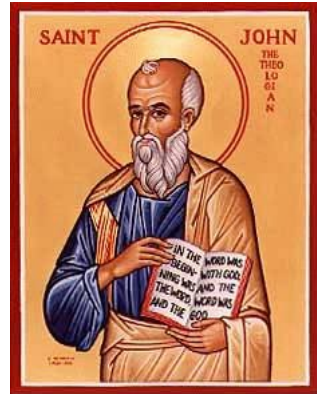
1.4 The Church of John

At the end of his Gospel, John mentions that Peter was questioning Jesus' relation with John. Jesus replied bluntly, "What's it to you?"

In *Meditations on the Tarot*, **Valentin Tomberg** brings up the often-made distinction between the Church of Peter and the Church of John, the former structured and hierarchical, the latter free and mystical. Someone asked me the question: "Does the Roman Catholic Church need Hermetism?" To answer properly, the question needs to be adjusted: "Does the Church of Peter need Hermetism?" and the answer to this question is "certainly not".

The real question is really about the Church of John, and there are several questions: "Does it even exist, has it existed continuously, is its core Hermetism?"

According to the theologian **Hans Ur von Balthazar**, it does exist³, although he calls the two churches "Official Church" and "Church of Love", and its source can be found in the Gospel of John. He says there is a two-peaked church in harmonious tension, although the Church of John respectfully gives precedence to the Church of Peter. There are no clear boundaries between the two. This interesting discussion concludes with this:



³*The von Balthazar Reader*, #66

Between these two impossible ecclesiologies, the Gospel of John leaves and dismisses us in a suspended middle point whose foundation lies solely with the Lord. The last thing said to the servant Peter, the last word of the Lord in the gospel, is the admonition (for the church and theology of all times), “What’s it to you?”

So the Church of John exists and has existed continuously. The next question is about Hermetism. There have been many clues about this. **Dionysius, Clement of Alexandria, Origen** are close to Hermetism. There were the alchemists, **Ramon Lull, Ficino, Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin** ... all clues that Hermetism has always existed in the Church and only occasionally makes a public appearance.

Rene Guenon claims that the Church used to have an esoteric teaching which he claims was Hermetism. He points to Dante as a member of an esoteric order, and even Thomas Aquinas. The Templars, the Grail Legend, the story of the Magi, Medieval Romances, St Bernard of Clairvaux, Ramon Lull, Michael Scott, and so on, all point to the existence of a Christian esoterism. In *Perspectives on Initiation*, Guenon writes in a similar vein about a dual church:

Within a single organization, a kind of double hierarchy can exist, especially when the apparent leaders are themselves unaware of any link to a spiritual center. In such cases there may exist beside the visible hierarchy made up by those apparent leaders, an invisible hierarchy of which the members may not fulfill any ‘official’ function but who, by their presence alone, nonetheless assure an effective liaison with this center. In the more exterior organizations these representatives of the spiritual centers obviously need not reveal themselves as such ...

Tomberg and van Balthazar agree on the Church of John. It is not separate from the Church of Peter on which it depends for structure and

support. Rather it is a less formal entity, in parallel with, yet not opposed to, the official church. Historically, there have been times they got along, and other times in opposition. With the destruction of the Templars, came the Rosicrusians who found themselves opposed to the Church. Then other Hermetists, such as Cagliostro, Giordano Bruno, or Thomas Campanella were imprisoned and even executed.

Yet to create a visible Church of John with its own separate structure, clergy, doctrine, and so on is, in my opinion, a mistake; actually I believe it to be impossible. That is because it will eventually degenerate into a vacuous, undifferentiated, and amorphous entity, not holding firm to anything in particular. As a witness to that, we need only point to the various so-called New Age and occult movements active today.

The Church of John is in your heart and mind, especially when you are joined with two or three others. So to any self-appointed guardians of orthodoxy, I ask “What’s it to you?”

Posted on 2022-11-20 by Cologero

Originally published on 13 Feb 2011 in medtarot

1.5 Précis

What follows is a brief précis of the fundamental point of view of the Gornahoor project.

Epistemology We hold to three degrees of knowledge:

- **Doxa** (*sensus*, opinion, sensual knowledge). Direct, intuitive knowledge through the senses. I taste the sweetness and moistness of a mango.
- **Dianoia** (*ratio*, rational knowledge). Indirect knowledge, discursive reasoning, science. I study the structure of the mango and its history as a crop.

- **Episteme** (*intellectus*, intuition). Direct, intuitive knowledge of the supra-sensible. I grasp the idea of a mango.

Ontology

- Spirit is prior to matter
- The great chain of being from God, to the spiritual hierarchy, man, animals, plants, matter

Anthropology This science describes the nature of man. Man, such as he is, exists in one of three states.

- The **sensual man** is focused on *doxa*, or the satisfaction of his material needs and desires. His opinions come ready-made from his social groups and are not questioned or investigated.
- The rational man seeks to investigate the sources of the sensual world. There are two options:
 - **Science**. Only the sensual world exists. Knowledge is achieved by investigating the facts of the sensual world and forming general laws to explain them.
 - **Religion**. A supra-sensible world exists, but there is no way to know it directly. Hence, it is accepted as a matter of belief, based on authority or revelation.
- The **intellectual man** has direct access to and knowledge of the supra-sensible realm.

Cosmology The sensual world is the reflection of the spiritual world and, thus, has no independent existence. It evolves, in the original sense of the world: as the unfolding of an originary idea. An analogy is that of a symphony, which exists as an idea until musicians perform it; thus the symphony is revealed in the sensual world. As a whole, the world process is the unfolding of the three fundamental ideals.

- **Beauty.** The world process is a creative process, revealing beauty and harmony.
- **Good.** The sufficient reason for the world is the Will. Hence, the world process is a moral action, based on virtue (manliness, strength). The world comes into existence through Power.
- **Truth.** The world is a reflection of the Logos (reason, law). Hence, the world process must follow the logos, or else descend into formlessness. The unity of the logos is highly differentiated and hierarchical, since it is infinite and subject to no limitation.

Politics Politics, as the “queen of the sciences”, describes the proper relations of men in their social groupings. As such, it must take into account the findings of all the other sciences, including Anthropology and Cosmology. Hence, all contemporary divisions into left and right are misleading, and ultimately ineffective.

As Evola pointed out, the correct political position is what “every well-bred man considered sane, healthy, and normal prior to the French revolution.” That is, the harmonious over the discordant, the good over the perverse, order over disorder and the undifferentiated mass.

The battle, therefore, is between those who would uphold the Traditional order, and the various revolutionary forces that seek to overthrow it. The revolution operates on multiple fronts.

Western Tradition The Western Tradition is based on the axis from Greece and Rome, and its prolongation in time to Paris (Charles Maurras). We would extend that back even further to its Indo-European roots in Egypt, Persia, India. We, therefore, see continuity from the classical period to the Catholic medieval era and even into modern times.

We acknowledge the existence of a Western esoteric tradition, which at various times has made itself known and at others, has had to hide itself. This tradition has been based on Hermeticism, whether the ancient pagan mysteries or Christian alchemy. The goal of this Tradition is the reintegration of man into his Primordial state; this is true, whether pagan or Christian.

Hence, we reject the typical superficial distinctions between pagan and Christian. This requires the simultaneous rejection of those vulgar expressions of paganism as the life of non-transcendent sensuality, and Christian other-worldliness unnourished by its esoteric sources.

Posted on 2010-05-08 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2010-05-08 at 21:15 said:

In thinking about the Western Tradition, and the Tradition in general, I have issues about where Sufism falls. The fundamental point in the Tradition (correct me if I'm wrong) is that the pure Self (not the everyday ego) must be realized and affirmed. And this fundamental point is stated in both the West (as seen in Hermeticism and the mystery schools), and the East (the Buddha's original doctrine, Vedanta and Yoga, Taosim) with the difference being how the sensible world should be treated. Yet with the Sufi view, it appears that the Self must not be affirmed, but annihilated in the divine (granted, Sufism may be alluding to the physical ego, and with going forward in studying it, that could very well be the case). So at least right now, I am perplexed as to where this Islamic mysticism falls under in the Tradition.

Francis Mercuri on 2010-05-09 at 02:11 said:

This "Precis" of the Gornahoor project is an inspirational and succinct statement of principles; your work and writings are appreciated.

Additionally, for those following a Christian path, this tertiary anthropology might also be extended to the correspondences with the “degrees” of the primitive Christian hierarchy:

1. Catechumens
2. The Faithful
3. Christians

Somewhat analogous to the Hellenistic:

1. Hylics
2. Psychics
3. Pneumatics

The Masonic:

1. Apprentices
2. Fellowcrafts
3. Masters

Mouravieff's:

1. Exoteric cycle
2. Mesoteric cycle
3. Esoteric cycle

And Robin Amis' “Three Renunciations”, of:

1. Physical asceticism
2. Psychological asceticism
3. Noetic asceticism, which his exegesis compares with:
 1. Proverbs
 2. Ecclesiastes
 3. The Song of Songs

Francis Mercuri on 2010-05-10 at 04:43 said:

Mark:

1. I'm in agreement with some others who say that Islam (and thus Sufism), is neither really “Eastern” nor “Western”; instead, the Islamic tradition represents something of a “amalgam” path, or a liaison between East and West.

2. Along the lines of Guenon's definitions, I don't perceive Sufism as a type of “mysticism”, as you call it. Guenon lucidly explained the differences between Initiation and mysticism in his “Perspectives on Initiation”, where, in brief, he noted that mysticism always remains an aspect of exotericism (and the theological domain), in that in the “mystical” experience, the individual still remains the same individual, albeit in a state of passive reception of Superior influences, which are always “colored” by a given theological clothing, and occur in a rather random way.

On the other hand, the Initiate goes beyond the theological domain, meeting the meta-physical, and intentionally seeks simultaneously to divinize his individuality, and individualize

the Personality...this is what the Sufis call the "Supreme Identity", attained in a conscious and permanent manner. While anybody can be a "mystic", the Initiate is set apart by specific "qualifications", and travels a well governed path, which is first defined by "psychic regeneration" (the "Primordial State"), and then, if possible Noetic regeneration (the "Transcendent State"). Echoes of this can be noted in the Western tradition, where a man being made a Priest by a Bishop is said to be "elevated" to the Priesthood, or a Mason, on becoming a Master is said to be "raised" to the Sublime Degree. The forum owner's recent explanations of the three types of epistemology, are another way of expressing the same things.

3. In Sufism, there is indeed, as you observe a emphasis on "extinction" (Fana), and beyond that "extinction of extinction" (Fana al-Fana). But, I'm not so sure that I'd agree that this implies a destruction of the individuality, so much as an "extinction" of what the Sufi psychology calls the Nafs (which are what we previously identified as the Christian "prilogs", "passions", or in any other words, false "i's"). After all, the state of "Fana" corresponds to the grade of Insan al-Kadim (Primordial man), while the higher (highest) of Fana al-Fana corresponds with Insan al-Kamil (Universal/Transcendent Man). Were this not so, the Prophet Himself, who is regarded as an exemplar of Insan al-Kamil, could not be spoken of as having any individuality! No, what is involved here, as explained in section 2, is an example of how traditional Initiation operates:

- a. The Prophet as Insan al-Kamil, is equivalent to:
- b. The "Nur" Mohammed
- c. The "Transcendent Man"
- d. The regenerated Nous, or Logos
- e. The esoteric Buddhist "Dianchi"
- f. The "Celestial Jerusalem"
- g. The epistemological "Episteme"
- h. The "Third Birth", aka "Resurrection"
- i. The Hermetic "projection"
- j. The Hindu "Avatar"
- k. The Masonic "Master"
- l. The Tibetan "Lama"
- m. etc.....

Matt on 2010-05-10 at 12:01 said:

I appreciated that response Francis.

Yes, I probably should have used initiatic teaching instead of mysticism. Some of what I have read about Sufism has probably not been from the best sources and as stated before, I will have to further study it. What you stated about fana has helped my insight though. Thank you.

Oh, and you got me confused with Mark. I'm Matt.

Roger Buck on 2010-05-17 at 15:27 said:

Very good to have this! For now I will only comment on one most striking phrase: "its prolongation in time to Paris"!

I don't really know Maurras, but find myself wanting to know more of either why he says this and/or why you Cologero include this in this précis.

It is quite stirring and moving for me, this phrase and I cannot help but wonder what connexions it might possibly have with the reasons why *Meditations on the Tarot* was written in French, and sought to incarnate into a stream of French Hermeticists who at least in some cases, would have shared similar notions.

Yes I wonder why is Paris singled out like this in the Gornahoor précis ...

Cologero on 2010-05-22 at 11:42 said:

We accept the general approach of Marcilio Ficino: Hermes → Pythagoras → Plato → Neoplatonism (simplified). After Ficino, we find the fulfillment of the Hermetic Tradition among the French: Louis-Claude de St-Martin, Joseph de Maistre, up to the French esoterists of the late 19th and early 20th centuries.

1.6 Restatement of Purpose

To whom it may concern.

Someone suggested there needs to be some "dialog", presumably between Gornahoor and some unidentified dialogist. That presumes there is something to discuss, necessitating some common ground, and resulting in a common goal. The ground is Tradition. The goal is the recovery of Tradition in the West. We have not deviated from that in over five years.

In January 2008, we set the stage in one of the first posts here on the Prophecies of **Rene Guenon**, Part 1 and Part 2. Some commenters seem to believe we are trying to be persuasive although we have been clear that we are only interested in facts, their consequences, and the various possibilities in give situation. These are the two relevant facts.

- The West had a valid Tradition up until the Medieval Era

- The Tradition was eventually lost, after the destruction of the Templars according to Guenon, and perhaps a little later in Evola's view

The following corollary immediately follows from those two observations:

- In order to fully understand Tradition, it is sufficient to look to medieval Europe, its spiritual tradition, and its social structure

In other words, it is not necessary to look to alien traditions, but rather to Europe's intellectual and spiritual past. This was brought to our attention by an essay by **Ananda Coomaraswamy**, in which he made clear that a European could not understand the Vedanta unless he was able to understand the great traditional writers of the West. There is a corollary to that observation:

- Anyone who scoffs at the spiritual tradition of medieval Europe is unlikely to recognize or understand the traditional elements in the Vedanta.

A project immediately presents itself, one which Gornahoor has endeavored to fulfill:

- Investigate the medieval spiritual tradition and demonstrate its teachings on metaphysics, psychology, anthropology, history, sociology, politics, and so on.

Now, all this is more than a mental exercise. The ultimate purpose is to point out a possible way for the recovery of Tradition in the West. Moreover, that purpose is not the result of a merely arbitrary and subjective preference. As the modern world cannot continue to sustain itself on its present path, Tradition will necessarily return. However, that return can be relatively peaceful or quite painful. As noted in the links to Guenon's predictions, there are three possibilities:

- Degeneration. If no effort is made to restore Tradition, the West will degenerate into barbarity. **Carl Jung** noticed that in the psychology of his patients. Concerning the abandonment of the Western spiritual tradition by modern men, he had this to say:

At a time when a large part of mankind is beginning to discard Christianity, it may be worth our while to try to understand why it was accepted in the first place. It was accepted as a means of escape from the brutality and unconsciousness of the ancient world. As soon as we discard it, the old brutality returns in force . . . This is not a step forwards, but a long step backwards into the past.

- Assimilation. Outsiders from the East will bring Tradition back to Europe, whether by consent or by force. In the former case, Europeans would adopt the Traditions of the newcomers. In the latter, the Tradition would come by force marked by painful ethnic or racial conflicts.
- Transformation. In this scenario, the West returns to Tradition spontaneously and voluntarily. This would be initiated by a group of men that Guenon calls the “elite”, in the sense that they understand tradition and “true intellectuality”. They would be the initial leavening that would eventually spread.

Since we are not interested in promoting the cause of degeneration, and since we are not “outsiders”, Gornahoor’s real project is almost too obvious to mention.

- To promote the spontaneous and voluntary transformation of the West.

There are several preparatory steps required. Here are some we are engaged in:

- Make clear what the elite must know, both intellectually and morally. That is why we have provided so many translations into English of rare works and have brought to light many ancient texts. Obviously, we read them in the light of Tradition and not as moderns who have little conception of their real meaning.
- Encourage readers to engage with writings that are known to be initiatory, such as Dante, The Romance of the Rose, Boccaccio, etc.
- Investigate spiritual and intellectual currents that still retain real and recoverable traces of tradition.

There are other initiatives in motion, but it is too early to discuss them.

There is absolutely nothing new or novel in all this, it all derives from Guenon and other writers on Tradition. Hence, there is really nothing to dialog about; you either accept the premise or you don't. We are interested only in the former. It is not dialogists that are required, but rather those who want to develop such ideas further, based on their own abilities and interests.

Posted on 2013-10-14 by Cologero

* * *

Thorsten on 2013-10-14 at 10:34 said:

Cologero,

thanks for the clarification. When I suggested a dialogue I was referring primarily to the fact that self-styled "traditionalists" in the New Right/Alt Right need to willing to be more open to traditional doctrine, especially in the shape it assumed in Medieval Europe, and to be more open to metaphysical reality in general. (Otherwise they really have no business calling themselves traditionalists.)

On the other hand I would like to humbly suggest that as prideful and sensually/aesthetically oriented [What else is left in the absence of a living tradition than tribal and racial identity and

old symbolic language (e.g. art) from a bygone civilization? These seem to be the default surrogates for tradition, and the only remaining alternatives to chaos when you were raised outside of tradition or have been heretofore fed such a degraded version of tradition that you cannot in good conscience submit to it.] these apostates are that they are not all beyond saving as a group, and should be handled as misguided rather than willfully contrarian. Now doubtless a number of the most strident voices in these circles are in fact willfully contrarian, puerile, and deliberately disrespectful of Western tradition to a degree that is shameful and they are probably not worth the time of Gornahoor or any other advocates of western tradition.

I'm confident that most of the New Right/Alt Right are not interested in Muslim overlordship and therefore are opposed the the option of Assimilation, although I'm not so sure that they would all be opposed to some level brutality and barbarity in terms of a more militarized society and harsher corporal punishment (It's undeniable that western society was markedly more brutal and barbarous until quite recently in this regard.) If brutality and barbarism refers to coarseness of taste, vulgarity, and surrender to hedonism I think its obvious that most of them would oppose Degeneration in this sense, as this is frequently the subject of articles of the New Right. On the other hand I think the third possibility of Transformation might actually be received quite well as this would appeal to those who were not born into an existing tradition or have been alienated the contemporary Christianity of any sort because they were raised on some anti-traditional low church protestantism which is devoid traditional values such as inequality, metaphysics as opposed to literalist readings of scripture, and the primacy of the intellect as opposed to blind faith.

I myself am not a member in any sense of the New Right, but I do think that there is more potential among those who frequent such circles than there appears to be if you only focus on the stance of the writers and editors. As a former Nietzsche-maniac, and stubborn materialist like so many of those frequent and comment on such websites I think that many of these iconoclasts could be esotericists in the making.

Kind regards,
Thorsten

Thomas Blanchard on 2013-10-14 at 14:01 said:
Thorsten,

I'll chime in since I am loosely involved in various New Right spheres, and can echo most of your feelings on this, although I think I've come to a different understanding of things.

I agree that the reformation of an authentic new second estate (warrior caste) will be a necessary step in an overall return to order in the west, just as it will be necessary to reform the third estate on healthy principles. Gornahoor's primary mission (and someone correct me if I'm wrong) is the recovery of the western tradition and and the spiritual development of individuals who will eventually form a truly legitimate first estate that will serve as its elite vanguard.

This being said, a parallel effort to build a true second estate does make sense, but the key is that it should be properly subordinated to a new first estate; the castes and vocations should have proper hierarchical relations with one another. All of the various New Right movements of today represent different manifestations of this impulse, but without a proper spiritual authority to guide them (and you are correct that the modern exoteric Church as the world sees it is rather weak and uninspiring), these efforts constitute a rebellious attempt to re-establish the Bronze Age (written of by Hesiod). In this case I respectfully disagree with Cologero's non-distinction between pure modernists and the New Right types that one might find at a place like Counter-Currents: modernists represent the Iron Age, the "Renaissance", the French Revolution, and the "Enlightenment", but the New Right truly wishes for the return of the Bronze Age and their writers are men like Homer and Nietzsche.

In a sense, the dialogue you have been talking about has been taking place for a long time – you can see it in Plato's works: Socrates' debates with Thucydides or especially with Callicles, where his opponents represent these more "New Right" sorts.

As a person who also has mixed proclivities and tends to sympathize with Nietzsche, I share your feelings, but it's best for the time being to focus on re-establishing a spiritual elite before trying to give direction to the chaotic mess of political agitators who are united only in their opposition to the Iron Age.

For your personal development, if you cannot commit yourself to a religion now, at least I would recommend taking up things like traditional martial arts and mountain climbing – Evola wrote primarily for people of our type, and some of his last advice to young people was not to worry about forming an "order", but to simply focus on building character. I believe that this is good advice.

Thorsten on 2013-10-14 at 20:06 said:

Thomas,

I'm on the same page with you and Gornahoor on the primacy of establishing a reformed spiritual/intellectual elite/oratores/brahmin caste (call it what you will). Thought precedes action and the wise must rule the strong and I say that is all the more reason to quash counterfeit spiritualities propagated by some in the new right and to formulate a working alternative. How to do this specifically I am not sure and won't presume to tell anyone.

I myself cannot say with certainty whether I am more a bellator than an orator but I do have some experience with rock climbing and I intend to take up some form of martial arts when I have the means to do so. Anyway I understand the necessity of rebuilding from the top down as has been reiterated here at Gornahoor many times, but if we don't get things rebuilt (bring about the Transformation) before society collapses into utter degeneracy do we simply allow some semblance of order to be imposed on the West by Wahhabi radicals (Assimilation) by means of brutality and barbarism which may make the barbarian incursions in the last days

of the Roman empire look merciful in comparison?

To be clear am no enemy of Islam. I am only pointing out that when the present ideology of materialism and egalitarianism implodes upon itself the most consistent (and forceful) ideology in the West will not only be Muslim but the most ferocious variant thereof.

Michael on 2013-10-14 at 20:25 said:

Cologero, I understand the concept of an elite, but I don't understand how the elite will act as a "leaven" to transform society. Is it purely through contemplation? Or will there also be action similar to the way that enlightenment ideas spread through society? From reading Guenon and Tomberg, I have the impression that it is an unseen spiritual leavening process.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:18 said:

@ Thomas Blanchard Those are mostly excellent suggestions ... more generally, besides rock climbing, there are other elements to master depending on your personal equation. See *Qualifications for Initiation* for example. If only the NR would follow your advice and stay out of religious and spiritual matters. Their proper domain is the manifestation which should be the focus. An important point you bring up is the "third estate", which does not get the attention it needs. The modern world is in the hands of that estate, not some decadent spiritual tradition as the NR seems to be obsessed with.

There is some subtleties with Socrates, who was executed for atheism and impiety. His call for the rule of philosophers in touch with the ideas replaced the Homeric vision of the rule of the gods. So you could see him as the precursor of modernity on the one hand, or else as someone who spread esoteric teachings prematurely.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:32 said:

@Thorsten

I put up the quotes from Alice Bailey to show how events happen on their own accord apart from the wills of men. She saw turmoil inaugurating a new age of one religion, one race, etc, although it is hard to be so sanguine about that. It is odd that the Theosophists seen eternal progress instead of the cycles of decline, considering their reliance on Asian teachings.

Back to the point, events will unfold as they do. Decisions made and actions executed today will have consequences down the road. I don't know how Guenon was able to see the possibly imminent ethnic conflict in 1921, but they are certainly foreseeable now. Yet it doesn't have to be that way.

I don't know why you feel any personal agitation or anxiety. It is not as though you are in charge of anything nor is the worst likely to happen in your lifetime. Besides rock climbing, seek out Seneca's 41st letter to Lucilius:

If you see a man who is unterrified in the midst of dangers, untouched by desires, happy in adversity, peaceful amid the storm, who looks down upon men from a higher plane and view the gods on a footing of equality, will not a feeling of reverence for him steal over you? ...

When a soul rises superior to other souls, when it is under control, when it passes through every experience as if it were of small account, when it smiles at our fears and at our prayers, it is stirred by a force from heaven. A thing like this cannot stand upright unless it be propped by the divine.

That is the ideal to strive for. Jung's commentary on that passage is also quite interesting, but I'll save it for another time.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:44 said:

Guenon ties it to a very specific event: the destruction of the Templars. The reason for this may be difficult to understand or even to accept, but it has to do both with the exodus of esoteric orders from Europe and the ties between esoteric Christian and esoteric Islamic orders. Guenon has left a very interesting clue about that, although I am not ready to make it public without understanding it more deeply. I have pointed out the clue on Gornahoor although it will take some digging.

I don't believe Evola dates it so precisely since he did not have the same interest in that topic as Guenon. Instead he refers to the regression of the castes over a longer time. As we have often pointed out, Evola said he believed what every well-bred person prior to the French Revolution considered normal and healthy.

Cologero on 2013-10-14 at 23:54 said:

I don't understand either, Michael, as the Spirit will blow where he wills. Yes, false ideas spread quite easily, but true ideas are longer lasting. There is always the feeling of having to "do something" but instead we need that interior silence, not unlike what Seneca described, which connects us to Heaven which allows the influx of forces.

1.7 Spiritual LARPing

The others, the mages, the theosophists, the cabalists, the spiritualists, the hermetics, the Rosicrucians, remind me, when they are

not mere thieves, of children playing and scuffling in a cellar. And if one descends lower yet, into the hole-in-the-wall places of the pythonesses, clairvoyants, and mediums, what does one find except agencies of prostitution and gambling? All these pretended peddlers of the future are extremely nasty; that's the only thing in the occult of which one can be sure.

J K HUYSMANS, *Là-Bas*

Role Playing There is the mistaken impression that esoteric studies are based on some secret knowledge, hidden from others. **Valentin Tomberg**, however, makes a distinction between a secret and an arcanum.

Secrets are only facts, procedures, practices, or whatever doctrines that one keeps to oneself for a personal motive, since they are able to be understood and put into practice by others to whom one does not want to reveal them.

You see, it has nothing to do with esoteric attainment; rather, it is a means to retain control and power. Those who are in on the secret can use it to identify in and out groups. At its worst, it only feeds the urge for self-inflation. For these reasons, we prefer to keep everything in the open.

It is not the text or the book that ultimately matters. The text is merely the reflection of the pure act of intelligence, as revealed in the Magician Arcanum. It is only possible to reach the pure act through spiritual exercises. Otherwise, as Tomberg points out, you are only doing philosophy at best, or just role playing at worst.

Our first goal here is to promote the ideal of self-mastery and to show ways to achieve it. This requires control of thinking, feeling, and willing. This control can only result from a purification of one's thinking, feeling, and willing. Without such purification, the mirror will be perturbed, and its reflections will distort the pure act of intelligence.

I have known and spoken to, in my travels, gurus, lamas, anthroposophists, theosophists, freemasons, rosicrucians, priests, gurdjieffians, Jungians, charismatics, channelers, and so on. Even giving the benefit of the doubt, many of the followers are role playing, i.e., they enjoy the fantasy of spiritual attainment without having to do the work. They try to act as they think a spiritual person should act. They dress a certain way, adopt a new diet, say the right words, while leaving their inner life untouched.

In actuality, you would not readily identify an initiate even if he crossed your path. He would have no reason to reveal himself to you, unless you expressed a sincere interest in the teachings.

The Christian Hermetic Tradition Our task has been to serve the living Tradition, which has been assigned by Valentin Tomberg to his unknown friends. To that end, we have described the various manifestations of that Tradition throughout time and space. We have also introduced a great many authors who have contributed to that Tradition. The goal has been to entice others to want to serve that same Tradition. We have been quite open with that material, since it hides itself from those unable or unwilling to understand it.

As a matter of principle, it is problematic to earn one's living from Hermetic teaching. It can lead to subtle distortions based on the need "give the customer what he wants". At its lowest, it is a form of simony, i.e., selling spiritual knowledge for a price. In the olden days, a Hermetist might take the role of a street performer or horse trader. In that way, he could travel from village to village without arising suspicions, and meet with other Hermetists. It would also provide a modest income. That was a motivation for the Tarot cards. Books were too expensive and bulky to travel with. So a deck of cards that encapsulated the teachings in symbolic form was a boon.

Once upon a time, someone was hectoring us every now and then

to rewrite or even remove certain posts, to delete comments, or to block links. It made no sense, until I was informed of the reason:

I thought it necessary to free Tomberg from rightist view and people who follow you

That is absurd. No one has the authority to decide who can read this blog or comment on Tomberg. First of all, we don't have any political or religious tests to join our groups. Instead, we rely on the Law of Affinity; that will bring the right people together if they belong together.

The Traditional way is not partisan, so the distinction between "right" and "left" is a meaningless creation of modernity. Tradition is the path of unity whereas partisanship is dual, hence devilish. **Louis Claude de Saint-Martin** explains:

Now, in order to show how [the numbers] are related to their base of activity, let us begin by observing the working of unity and of the number two. When we contemplate an important truth, such as the universal power of the Creator, his majesty, his love, his profound light, or suchlike attributes, we bear ourselves wholly towards this supreme model of all things; all our faculties are suspended in order to fill us with him, and we really only make ourselves one with him. This is the active image of unity, and the number one in our languages is the expression of this unity or invisible union which, existing intimately between all attributes of this unity, must equally exist between it and all its produced creations. But if, after having borne all our faculties of contemplation towards this universal source, we return our gaze to ourselves and fill ourselves with our own contemplation, in such a way that we regard ourselves as the origin of some of the inner light or satisfaction that this source has procured for us, from that moment we establish two centres of contemplation, two separate and rival principles, two bases which are not linked; lastly, we establish

two unities, with this difference—that one is real and the other is apparent . . .

But to divide being through the middle is to divide it into two parts; it is to pass from the whole to the quality of the part or the half, and it is here that the true origin of illegitimate twofoldness lies. . . this example is sufficient to show us the birth of the number two — to show us the origin of evil. . .

Choosing a Path In a recent comment, Mikkell asked a very good question:

How does one truly understand what “I want”? Due to the story of my experiences of my life, I find that I am more blind to this unfortunately in periods of distress.

Only by coming to that realisation, is it possible for a man to seek a way out. Most men live in ignorance of their real nature and what is truly good for them.

The Parable of the Coach explains our situation: our body is inefficient, our emotions are uncontrolled, our intellect is asleep, and there is no one in charge. Hence the coach moves without purpose or goal, in random directions.

It may happen that a more awake coachman may pass by and offer help. Usually the help is refused. Nevertheless, some few, due perhaps to karma, fortune, or grace, are willing to accept such help.

It sounds simple, except that in our world there are many offers to help, most asking for money. So it is right to be sceptical. People may spend more effort in choosing a car mechanic or doctor than in their spiritual development. It is reasonable to know what results to expect. The answer is an improvement in one’s thinking, feeling, and willing functions. You should ask those who have been helped previously about their

experiences. The results should be permanent, not just some emotional high after a rousing lecture.

Avoid cults. Apply this test when in doubt:

A cult is easy to join, but hard to leave. A free group is hard to find, but easy to leave.

If the goal is self-mastery, then clearly you cannot surrender your will to someone else. You need to understand your situation and learn to choose your own goals. Simply being told what to do is useless. Either you will dislike the advice and leave the teaching, or else you will like the advice and not bother with the exercises.

A contrary approach is offered by many others. Typically, it will include spiritual counselling, for a fee. The counsellor will then tell the student his karmic tasks and what his life goals should be. To repeat, the student needs to determine that on his own, even if it might require a little encouragement. I have never seen that approach work very well.

Uniting Hermetists I've always hoped for a loose coalition of Hermetists, each developing the Hermetic Tradition in its own way, despite the attacks described above. These different groups would cooperate in various ways, without regard for border. Tomberg's description is what I have in mind:

Spiritual exercises in common form the common link that unites Hermetists. It is not knowledge in common which unites them, but rather the spiritual exercises and the experience which goes hand in hand with them. If three people from different countries were to meet each other, having made the book of Genesis by Moses, the Gospel of St. John, and the vision of Ezekiel, the subject of spiritual exercises for many years, they would do so in

brotherhood. . . . What one knows is the result of personal experience and orientation, whereas depth, the level one attains — disregarding the aspect and extent of knowledge that one has gained — is what one has in common.

Tomberg tells us how to evaluate a teaching:

There are mirages above, as there are mirages below; you only know that which is verified by the agreement of all forms of experience in its totality—experience of the senses, moral experience, psychic experience, the collective experience of other seekers for the truth, and finally the experience of those whose knowing merits the title of wisdom and whose striving has been crowned by the title of saint.

In other words, blind belief based solely on authority or on unverifiable claims are not helpful on the Hermetic path. Too much emphasis on unusual or fantastic experiences will discourage students who should be content with slow but steady progress. Steiner, in *Knowledge of Higher Worlds*, warns several times about the expectation of fantastical experiences, for example he writes:

it is imperative to extirpate the idea that any fantastic, mysterious practices are required for the attainment of higher knowledge. It must be clearly realized that a start has to be made with the thoughts and feelings with which we continually live, and that these feelings and thoughts must merely be given a new direction.

Moreover, it is best to observe the Hermetic principle, “Be Silent”. Boasting of spiritual attainments, even if they are true, is not helpful. Steiner, in the same book, verifies that thought:

know how to observe silence concerning your spiritual experiences.

Mysticism and Initiation **Rene Guenon** distinguishes between mysticism and initiation. The former is passive, individualistic, subjective, and exoteric. Initiation, on the other hand, is quite different. He explains that

Initiation is the transmission, through appropriate rites, of a spiritual influence

Titus Burkhardt expands on the idea that the transmission of the spiritual influence must be conferred

by a master who also communicates the method and confers the means of spiritual concentration that are appropriate to the aptitudes of the disciple

Furthermore, he points out that in ancient times a mystic referred to someone who had knowledge of the mysteries. In other words, the mystic was initiated in the esoteric mysteries, but that is not how the word is used in our time.

Preconditions for Spiritual Science A period of self-purification is necessary before any effective initiation can take place. Otherwise, all sorts of mischief and misunderstandings can result when the unprepared receive esoteric teachings. First of all, it is best to keep one's physical body in good order, lest it bring distractions to spiritual practice. Proper diet and exercise are helpful. Moreover, the concentration required for physical disciplines like athletics or martial arts are a good preparation.

One's life should also be in order. Anxiety over relationships or money will make spiritual practice difficult. Then, work can be done on oneself. The Christian Hermetist **Willi Seiss**, in his commentary on Valentin Tomberg's *Course on the Lord's Prayer* claims:

A precondition is the purification of the three soul-forces of willing, feeling, and thinking.

He summarizes the specifics like this:

- The element of will is trained through the rigorous, many-sided process of cleansing from everything that is impure.
- Through refraining from destructive feelings, that is, all reprehensible emotions
- Disciplining of the thoughts, whereby the essential is freed of influences from fearful, corrupt, hate-filled and empty thoughts.

The Pagan Revival In our time, the neo-pagans are prime examples of this. Misunderstanding the cycles and subcycles in the flow of time, as well as the existence of castes, they claim to hearken back to the exoterism of their allegedly pagan ancestors. Anyone else, they say, are bugmen. Yet that have no idea what caste they descend from. Moreover, since they believe they are the “true” Traditionalists, they do not bother with the idea of purification, and don’t really understand the inner sense of the pagans. The pagans also had their bugmen.

It is true enough, however, that the strata of earlier pagan traditions remain in our psyches. The **Book of Revelation** contains messages about the ancient Indians, Persian, Egyptian, Greek, and Roman cultures. Their psychic residues remain in our collective unconscious. They must both be remembered and transcended.

Note Friday the 13th was the day the **Templars** were destroyed. This post is dedicated to them.

And God knows best.

Posted on 2019-09-13 by Cologero

* * *

James on 2018-09-23 at 10:54 said:

Your illness comes up in my meditative moments every now and then . When I focused on it , it always seemed to center around the idea of "filtration" . Kidneys , obviously , serve to filter the subtle substance of our blood .

Whenever I would ponder on it , I thought about how this illness affects that organ which is meant to filter and clean the liquid that is so often associated with the "esoteric" current in man . It seemed "appropriate" considering how so many self-proclaimed esotericists seem to only be "poisoning" the stream and there is no organ capable of filtering it out for the body of humanity .

The interesting thing about the Dante reading that I do is when I think about the circle of Violence and how in one part of it – those who blaspheme – are filled with so much internal burning that they burn more than the flames that descend from the "sky" . I can't help but imagine that condemning someone to Hell is some kind of blasphemy (the irony is not lost on me considering Dante allegorically does "exactly this" though the thin line is clear: Dante is conversing in the language of an "open secret" where he "condemns" people to Hell almost as a "test" for us to look beyond the particular person at the eternal work that he's created and what is being written about is not some canonization of individuals to Hell , but a canonization of sin into Hell – something which an eye looking at only phenomenon and not essences cannot achieve when reading Dante . This is part of the reason why Dante's greyhound and a mangy , emaciated she-wolf (the symbols of truth and deception respectively) look so "similar" [they are both so 'thin'] . Dante is speaking of one of the central mysteries of Christianity: "why is what is good so often so indistinguishable from what is bad superficially" [e.g. the symbol of death and torture being the symbol of salvation ; God dying being the vehicle for salvation . etc]) . Still , Dante was quite instructive to me in how the sin of blasphemy manifests: that it creates the hellish burning inside the person as they persist in that attitude . Thus , such a statement as , "you will die , die in horror , die for ages , you will burn in hell like no other" is already indicative of a burning interior life .

Naturally , I'm not claiming some kind of moral superiority nor am I gawking at a sinful act considering how much of a hypocritical sinner I can be , but I was merely pausing to think of it and realizing just how contemporary Dante's trek through Hell can be for me . Here , we pass yet another sinner suffering the effects of the sin itself . The beauty of Free Will is that it's so easy to see the Hell we create if we but look with the Pilgrim's eyes . The elegant beauty is that we truly get not just what we deserve but also what we wanted . Hell is the oddly poetic and beautiful synthesis of both free choice and justice . In eternity , we never escape these singularities whether they flow upward or downward . Everything always reaches synthesis . As Flannery O'Connor had put it as her title: "everything that rises must converge" . Obviously the opposite is also true : "everything that descends must converge" (tying it back to Dante's Satan) . The Author of Meditations speaks of the same thing with the synthesis to white and the

chromatic loss below when he used a colour analogy .

Still , I would consider what your friend spoke about to be interesting . She must consider you to be the blasphemer (I'm only guessing with limited information) . I wonder if , perhaps , she imagines that you do not treat the subject matter with enough rituality . That's not to say she's necessarily wrong even if her reaction might be counterproductive to her aims (again , I'm only guessing off grossly incomplete assumptions , but I decided to follow it to some 'logical' conclusion just to see if it might be at all helpful) .

In my encounters with Jungians , for example , there have been quite a few methods proposed to me that ought to be done "properly" and plenty have given me their prescriptions on what this "propriety" means . To do otherwise would invite danger and collapse . A friend of mine recently said that an encounter with one's Shadow or Anima , for example , could produce years of psychosis (and he might be right) . Nonetheless , I'm honestly interested in why your friend decided that you had been guilty of some kind of sacrilege that you deserve condemnation . It is not that I intend to take sides (that is rather puerile anyway) , but , rather , I wish to "understand" .

As for gornahoor itself . I find it fascinating . Perhaps it would have acted as a filter (to tie it back to the kidneys) to try and find one or two or three or however many in order to contribute to the "communal soul of art , science , and religion" together , but I personally , and perhaps quite wrongly , always saw it attract a certain type of individual who was more interested in using esoteric "knowledge" as clubs to swing at "others" . Evola become the new Nietzsche for fiery young people unable to accept reality .

I think your meditation on death and this whole endeavour with Gornahoor is instructive . After all , what I find most interesting about the appeal to sectarianism is that it often exposes a very clear insecurity: the fear of death .

"We" [whoever the "we" happen to be] "are afraid to perish from this earth" .

I have said it once before a long time ago : perhaps the solution is not to live by the sword and die by it , but to learn to accept one's cross in order to be resurrected . Esoteric knowledge seems to be used as a weapon by many who frequent these halls in order to scream by at the encroaching darkness . Perhaps these individuals need to learn how to properly accept death . It is not a call to cowardice or complacency , but a call to finding that strength in inner peace rather than inner fear .

Mikkel on 2018-09-23 at 14:40 said:

"my advice is to do what you want to do now, and not later."

How does one truly understand what "I want"? Do to the story of my experiences of my life, I find that I am more blind to this unfortunately in periods of distress. I think this comes in time with self-mastery...perhaps Evola (are we still speaking of him now?) said it well in the translation posted years ago (cited above):

"Against psychoanalysis the ideal of a Self (or "I") must be validated, a Self who does not abdicate, who intends to remain conscious, autonomous, and sovereign in the confrontation with the dark and subterranean part of his soul and the demon of sensuality; that does not mean either "repression" or a psychotic scission, but he brings about an equilibrium of all his faculties ordered to a higher meaning of living and acting."

Many individuals seem to want to "dominate" or be in power over those dark parts of his soul, but is that truly equilibrium? The analogy of the chariot/coach is far more apt, there are drivers and what drives (horses), but in totality it is a living system that must function together. Usually understanding and respect in a relationship goes much farther than the whip hand.

"There are some Christian Hermetic groups that prefer to work in private. In our opinion, since Tomberg that is no longer appropriate." What changed after Tomberg for this to be true? No true line to carry on his work? Sometimes others are far more open than we give them credit to a surprising extent or maybe I've been careful of who to associated myself with, the Spirit breatheth where he will.

Other times while reading about betrayals like the one mentioned above I notice the melancholy that surfaces within. I look forward to reading the material that comes out from the translation, my German is quite basic so I am sorry that I cannot be of much help. Similarly, I would love to take all of those books, but the sense of responsibility of research with those feels heavy in comparison to my current talents. Knowledge is more similar to that concept than I realized...we look to it earnestly at times, but what happens to us when we do nothing with it? Are we not to help others in some way? Maybe I need to learn my own place, isn't it always like that when one comes down to the essence of understanding any problem?

You and those of the 'community' are in my thoughts and prayers, this I know is true and something I want to do.

Cologero on 2018-09-23 at 16:07 said:

Mikkel, Tomberg made clear that the unknown friends are those who dare to plunge into the currents of Christian Hermetism. There is no secret group that controls who can be initiated or determines what "grade" someone is at. Any such organisation that tries to control a teaching always ends up protecting itself not the teaching. The Hermetist does not offer an alternative to religion nor to science, rather he strives to integrate all knowledge into a larger whole.

Cologero on 2018-09-23 at 16:27 said:

James, perhaps I am a blasphemer in someone's eyes. Of course, even a blasphemer deserves to know the charges and offer a defense.

Or maybe it is a difference in approach. Again, you put me in a position that may seem boastful, but there have been holy fools, zen masters, etc., whose techniques may not meet

certain standards of decorum. Then again, a man shouldn't take himself too seriously in these matters.

Maybe you should add Nassim Taleb to your reading list. Knowledge is not usually gained from the top down, but rather from a lot of experience. The Romans built aqueducts, sometime with a drop of 12 inches over the length of a mile. You probably know how to compute the slope, but I don't know how the Romans did that calculation with their numerical system. Nonetheless, water got to the city. Practicality trumps theory in this case.

That is why our method uses heuristics. We try a lot of ways to come to awareness; over time, one learns what works for him. All the theory in the world won't be helpful, and is usually a distraction.

For example, suppose I tell you that by awakening a certain chakra or invigorating some of its petals, then you will achieve inner peace. Does that knowledge bring you inner peace? Of course not. First of all, it is necessary to achieve inner peace — I prefer the term *ataraxia* — and then perhaps you can see how the chakras change in response.

The person of deep faith, with no esoteric knowledge, can achieve such a state. That is my model.

Auld Wat on 2022-05-11 at 08:12 said:

"First of all, it is best to keep one's physical body in good order, lest it bring distractions to spiritual practice. Proper diet and exercise are helpful. Moreover, the concentration required for physical disciplines like athletics or martial arts are a good preparation. One's life should also be in order. Anxiety over relationships or money will make spiritual practice difficult. Then, work can be done on oneself."

Thank you for the recommendations.

1.8 Intellectuality and Spirituality Redux

The "true" and the "desired" must find their synthesis in the "beautiful", for it is only in the beautiful that the urge to play renders the burden of the "true" or the "just" light and raises at the same time the darkness of instinctive forces to the level of light and consciousness. In other words, he who sees the beauty of that which he recognizes as true cannot fail to love it — and in loving it the element of constraint in the duty prescribed by the true will disappear: duty becomes a delight.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Since we began this sequence of gnosis meetings with the ideal of the alchemical marriage of intellectuality and spirituality several months ago, and now that we are finished for this year, it is worthwhile to circle back around on the topic.

Meditation Years ago, I learned centering prayer from Fr. Thomas Keating, not personally, but from some cassette tapes. In this brief video⁴, he asserts the necessity for daily meditation. For our purposes, note particularly his explanation that engaging with spiritual friends is an adequate substitute for a spiritual director. That — if you haven't figured it out that by now — is why we choose to work in groups. Hence, regular attendance is important, not just for yourself, but also for the commitments you've made to others.

Meditation, just like riding a bike or swimming, cannot be explained intellectually. One must simply begin. However, once the practice is established, you can get feedback from your spiritual companions. Just as your biking or swimming can improve, so can your meditating. After all, it is the first step to becoming a Bodhisattva.

The Hermetist and the Hermetic Path The Hermetic path is a gift, if you are called to it. It requires intelligence, resources, and time, so it is certainly not an option for everyone. However — and this is important — it is not “superior” to, or an alternative to, the exoteric path, it is simply our path. It would be a mistake to force these views on exoteric practitioners, or to use them as debating points. The exoteric path is perfectly adequate for salvation and a life of sanctity. There is a reason Hermetic groups used to be secret and closed to outsiders.

⁴<https://www.youtube.com/embed/pkDFaLdRck0>

The Hermetist often used to masquerade as a trader or street performer; the latter is the primary meaning of the first Tarot card, *Le Bateleur*. Under such cover, they could travel from town to town, allowing them to meet with local groups without attracting attention. Since books were heavy and expensive, the teachings were conveyed in diagrams (as in *Gnosis*), or even a deck of Tarot cards. On the one hand, they were compact and portable, but on the other, they required an accompanying oral teaching in order to be fully understood.

Years ago, I used to follow the books of **Carlos Castaneda**. I'm sure the teachings of the shaman Don Juan are still embedded in my soul somewhere, for better or for worse. The first thing to note is that it is difficult to find Don Juan. In one scene that I recall, Don Juan appeared at some government office on official business in a suit, just blending in with everyone else. This struck Castaneda, who had never seen him in that context, as something remarkable. Nowadays, shamans seem to be everywhere, peddling their books, courses, and so on. Those converts to some sort of spiritual life often feel they have to alter their outer appearance to be convincing. This is quite unlike Don Juan or even a Hermetist.

The real shaman Don Juan was indistinguishable from his surroundings. Therefore, you could not pick out the Hermetist in a room. He would look like everyone else and talk about the weather or sports to you. Only if you expressed some sort of interest in something deeper, might he open up to you.

St. Augustine tells us that God gives us everything we need for salvation. So if you are still searching, you may be missing the obvious. This might be as good as it gets for you.

The Quest for Novelty Some birds allegedly become fascinated by shiny objects on the ground, thereby forgetting the bugs that constitute their true nourishment. Similarly, we often become distracted by convoluted intellectual schemes or elaborate tableaux. Stay rooted in the core

principles, and be clear about the difference between an allegory or secret, and a genuine mystery. Tomberg warns us about this temptation:

Let us therefore not commit the error of wanting to “explain” a symbol by reducing it to a few general abstract ideas. Let us also avoid the error of wanting to “concretise” an abstract idea by clothing it in the form of an allegory.

The Arcana are not allegories in which a card is said to “represent” some qualities along the lines, say, of a work like John Bunyan’s *Pilgrim’s Progress*. In Tomberg’s words:

The Major Arcana of the Tarot are neither allegories nor secrets, because allegories are, in fact, only figurative representations of abstract notions, and secrets are only facts, procedures, practices, or whatever doctrines that one keeps to oneself for a personal motive, since they are able to be understood and put into practice by others to whom one does not want to reveal them. The Major Arcana of the Tarot are authentic symbols. They conceal and reveal their sense at one and the same time according to the depth of meditation.

In other words, if the meaning seems to “jump out” at you immediately, it may not be an “authentic symbol” in this sense. Ultimately, we will come to understand the mystery, but only plunging into its depths. An allegory, on the other hand, tries to “solve” the mystery:

Just as the *arcanum* is superior to the *secret*, so is the *mystery* superior to the Arcanum. The mystery is more than a stimulating “ferment”. It is a spiritual *event* comparable to physical birth or death. It is a change of the entire spiritual and psychic motivation, or a complete change of the plane of consciousness.

This cannot be overemphasized. A mystery cannot be resolved intellectually. Unless an arcane teaching leads to, or elicits, or acts as the midwife to, a spiritual transformation, it has not been understood. And worse, it may even become a distraction, with no more transformative power than a parlour game.

Cartesian Meditation Cartesian meditation, which is the search for clear and distinct ideas, is an intellectual task. **Rene Descartes** was a mathematical prodigy. As a boy, I was quite proficient in mathematics, although not at that level, so I enjoyed reading about the lives of the great mathematicians. Now, because of his intellect, the young Rene Descartes was pampered. Instead of being shooed out of bed in the morning, he was allowed to lounge, giving him the leisure to think.

There is no doubt that there can be great joy in the experience of intellectual insight or learning. Just watch the expression on a baby's face when he takes his first step and young children when they learn a new skill. I've seen people show great excitement in solving a puzzle or answering a question while watching some game show on TV. Adults still do crosswords or Sudoku just for the pleasure of it.

That feeling is magnified with more complex intellectual attainments, particularly in physics, maths, and metaphysics. For example, Newton's discovery of the equivalence of inertia and gravity is mind bending when it dawns on you, as is Descartes' discovery of the transformability of algebra and geometry. I personally can attest to the pleasures in physics and maths. One can struggle with an obscure maths problem, but, in a sudden insight, its solution simply appears, perhaps analogous to the experience of *Yesod*. Of course, the study of metaphysics can lead to a sort of bliss, especially with the realization that certain ideas bring you oh so close to the very nature of God. At this point, the search for Truth becomes the delight in Beauty.

So, back to the young Rene: following his example. I will often lie

in bed pondering some issue. Of course, Cartesian meditation is not the source. Rather, the real meditation reaches in the depths, often murky depths, not for the clarity of the atmosphere. Nevertheless, clear ideas are floating in the darkness of those depths, and they need to be coaxed out. Obviously, the discursive mind is required in order to turn those vague intuitions into text. That is the purpose of Cartesian meditation. Ultimately, however, there is not a shortage of ideas, but rather its opposite. There is actually an abundance of ideas, so cutting and pruning is necessary. Much more is discarded than is ever published.

If you allow your intellectual life to be nourished by the real nutrients hiding in the darkness, you will no longer be satisfied with dazzling baubles, word puzzles, or intellectual trivia. The goal of the intellectual life is to be a Sage, so seek the higher things like virtue, the life of reason, aesthetic beauty, the path of salvation, and the attributes of God.

Living in the Light of Tabor

Hermetism is an *athanor* ("alchemical furnace") erected in the individual human consciousness, where the mercury of intellectuality undergoes transmutation into the gold of spirituality. St. Augustine acted as a Hermetist in transmuting Platonism into Christian thought. Similarly, St. Thomas Aquinas acted as a Hermetist in doing the same thing with Aristotelianism. Both of them accomplished the sacrament of baptism with respect to Greece's intellectual heritage.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Letter on Justice*

If the goal of the intellectual life is to become a Sage, the goal of the spiritual life is to become a Saint. Of course, the latter quest is foolishness to the Intellect. Hence, only the Fool can show us the way. Tomberg explains:

The Arcanum “The Fool” teaches the “know-how” of passing from intellectuality, moved by the desire for knowledge, to the higher knowledge due to love.

The Fool is also a Trickster, since there are two ways of sacrificing the intellect:

- It can submit itself to the service of Transcendental consciousness
- It can simply be abandoned

Now, the temptation to simply abandon the intellect is quite strong. Deep meditation may be accompanied with intense sensations of pleasure, or even siddhis. The spiritual quest may then devolve to a quest for the repetition of such feelings as ends in themselves. Common practices such as postures, breath control, dancing, chanting, and so on may help focus the mind. When they fail, some schools resort to stronger practices such as drugs, alcohol, or extreme sexuality. However, the Spirit cannot be coerced by any sort of technique or mechanical practices.

Tomberg points to the Whirling Dervishes and Zen monks as those who have abandoned the intellect entirely. Some of this lies behind the Hesychast controversy. What concerned Barlaam was the ignorance and credulity of some of the monks, so, in compensation, he overemphasised the side of the Intellect. The monks, on the other hand, pointed out that the first disciples were simple men, not advanced scholars. Now that may be true in the Synoptic Gospels, but John’s Gospel explicitly identifies Christ with the Logos behind the creation of the world. We take the middle path between Barlaam and Palamas.

The Work In our time apart, we could focus on all the themes of the past few years. We can be Holy Fools, yet still be intellectually competent. Our meditations should be on the life of Christ or something analogous;

that is, something that requires an Active Imagination, not the passive imagination of a dream-like state. We concentrate without effort and have mastery over what thoughts and emotions are allowed to take hold in our consciousness.

To achieve the fusion of intellectuality and spirituality, we need to return up the Middle Pillar. That begins with the recognition of one's True Will and ends with the awareness of one's Real I. That is the gift of Integrity that was lost in the Fall.

Posted on 2017-05-26 by Cologero

1.9 Hierarchical Order among Mankind

Among the mature we do impart wisdom, although it is not a wisdom of this age or of the rulers of this age, who are doomed to pass away. But we impart a secret and hidden wisdom of God, which God decreed before the ages for our glorification.

1 CORINTHIANS 2:6-7

But I, brethren, could not address you as spiritual men, but as men of the flesh, as babes in Christ. I fed you with milk, not solid food; for you were not ready for it; and even yet you are not ready, for you are still of the flesh.

1 CORINTHIANS 3:1-3

The wise man will seek out the wisdom of all the ancients and will be occupied in the prophets and will enter withal into the subtleties of parables and will search out the hidden meaning of proverbs and will be conversant in the secrets of parables.

THOMAS AQUINAS, *Rising Dawn*

Paul could not pass on the solid doctrine to the Corinthians because they were not spiritually prepared for it. The doctrine itself is meaningless unless it fall on fertile soil, so it is with exoteric and esoteric teachings. It is not that the latter is the “true” meaning; rather, it represents a deeper understanding. A fundamental hermeneutic for spiritual texts is that they can be understood on four levels: the literal, allegorical, moral, and anagogical. The unprepared need not be concerned, as this passage explains:

Averroes was inspired by the idea that all minds have not the same degree of discernment: to some men the literal aspect, the *zahir*, is addressed, while others are capable of understanding the hidden meaning, the *batin*. He knew that if what only the latter can understand were revealed to the former, the result would be psychoses and social disasters.

HENRY CORBIN, *Alone with the Alone*

Science vs Esoterism In the *Introduction to Covenant of the Heart*, **Valentin Tomberg** makes a distinction between scientific and esoteric knowledge. Regarding the former, he writes:

The scientific approach is not to strive simply for the truth, but rather to strive for that brand of truth which is of **general validity**, i.e., that which can be comprehended fundamentally by everyone bestowed with healthy understanding and faculties of perception, and which should thus be concurred with.

In other words, the scientific approach does not require an inner transformation. Anyone, who is competent, can read the words and pass a multiple choice test, for example. Regarding esoteric knowledge, he explains:



Figure 1.1: The Hanged Man

[it addresses] itself only to those people who are capable of the concentration and inner deepening necessary for intuition. ... [it is] **a matter for an elite group of special people.**

He explains what that entails in *Letter I: The Magician* in *Meditations on the Tarot*:

All practical esotericism is founded on the following rule: it is necessary to be one in oneself (**concentration without effort**) and one with the spiritual world (**to have a zone of silence in the soul**) in order for a revelatory or actual spiritual experience to be able to take place. In other words, if one wants to practise some form of authentic esotericism — be it mysticism, gnosis, or magic — it is necessary to be the Magician, i.e., concentrated without effort, operating with ease as if one were playing, and acting with perfect calm.

Those who are just reading the words, and they are beautiful, will be missing the most sublime meaning of the text. Unless the reader makes efforts toward inner transformation, starting with concentration and quelling the perturbations of the soul, he will miss the point. Tomberg explains that the book

is written — and could only be written — for those who have the capacity and disposition to make use of the faculty of intuition as the direct sense for truth. Thus, it is addressed to those “who have ears to hear and eyes to see.

Angelic Hierarchy Like Averroes, Tomberg recognizes that few people are able to experience the Divine Light in its fullness. The task of the

angelic hierarchy, therefore, is to attenuate the Light in a manner appropriate to each one as it descends through the hierarchy. The esoteric path then is to reverse course and ascend through the hierarchy. To quote:

Each lower rank of hierarchy is a “moon” in relationship to the “sun” of the rank above it.

The **angels** transmit the tumultuous, strong impulses of the **arch-angels** in a bearable form, suited to human individuals, i.e., in the form of the soft light of moral clarity.

The **archangels** adopt the radical, valid-to-all-mankind commandments and prohibitions of the **principalities** (*archai*) to suit the special characters and capacities of the various peoples, thereby protecting them from becoming over-pressured.

And something similar is effected by the **principalities** in relation to the **powers** (*exusiai*), the **powers** toward the **virtues** (*dynamis*), the **virtues** toward the **dominions** (*kryriotetes*), the **dominions** toward the **thrones**, the **thrones** toward the **cherubim**, the **cherubim** toward the **seraphim**, and the **seraphim** toward the eternal **Trinity of God**.

Posted on 2022-05-29 by Cologero

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Jonathan Pageau on 2022-05-30 at 13:46 said:

Hey Cologero. Reading the Meditations myself and thought of you. Hope you are well. Haven't connected in a long time.

Michael DeJoy on 2022-06-09 at 10:18 said:

Concentration without effort requires the movement of energy. The areas of the thinking mind must be enlivened by the heart energy and the head energy acting together. When they are working together one finds the contentment they are looking for. The Magician will seem impossible as long as one is trying to figure it out, the ground must be established before that understanding is possible.

Cologero on 2022-06-09 at 14:34 said:

Concentration is the ability to focus energy on one thing, which is the opposite of movement. Movement is due to automatic or mechanical thinking, i.e., the distraction arising from random thoughts that appears in consciousness.

As Tomberg explains:

"concentration is the willed silence of the automatism of the intellect and imagination"

Max on 2022-07-06 at 07:54 said:

I am currently reading "The Julian Jaynes Collection" to complement "Origin of Consciousness". He has a useful analogy for understanding concentration: it is for the "mind-space" what attention is for sense perception. It is especially difficult to realize when the mind-space is not even properly acknowledged in the first place, as is so common today. It evidently cannot be comprehended fundamentally by everyone.

What is agreeable with Jaynes is that he accepts this mind-space without too much reductionist baggage, even though he has some blind spots as well. In particular how mind-space is explained as a product of language, as if the name preceded the named. At any rate, here is an interesting quote on the topic:

"As the body with its sense organs (referred to as I) is to physical seeing, so there develops automatically an analog 'I' to relate to this mental kind of 'seeing' in mind-space. The analog 'I' is the second most important feature of consciousness. It is not to be confused with the self, which is an object of consciousness in later development. The analog 'I' is contentless, related I think to Kant's transcendental ego. As the bodily 'I' can move about in its environment looking at this or that, so the analog 'I' learns to 'move about' in mind-space concentrating on one thing or another." -Jaynes

Of note is first that he seems to take the bodily I to be more "real" than this analog 'I'. That is obviously a prejudice which is not justified but taken for granted, since he subscribes to an evolutionary worldview. Secondly he describes its development process as "automatic", which is merely another way of saying that he does not know. To be strict, automatic would mean that the I acts by itself, making it unreducible to anything else. Lastly, he says that concentration includes the capacity to move about in this mind-space without, conversely, letting it dominate us.

Jaynes demonstrates, by his accurate descriptions from experience, that he knows concentration. That in itself makes him a more interesting author than the more scattered ones. He is aware of the important questions even though he does not have all the answers, which is an indispensable beginning.

1.10 The Personal Equation and Belief

I often receive correspondence from readers of various quality. In a recent one the interlocutor assumed that my “emotional attachment” to a tradition was preventing me from achieving detachment. Careful readers will not find that anywhere on Gornahoor. However, I noted that Bard — Google’s new AI system — made this evaluation:

Salvo’s writing is often dense and difficult to understand, but he has a large following of readers who appreciate his unique perspective on the world.

Well, if such a high machine intelligence finds us difficult to understand, then a merely human intelligence can be forgiven for its ineptitude. So consider what follows to be a brief summary of what is being asserted in many and various ways.

Exoteric and Esoteric Living traditions have an exoteric and an esoteric teaching. It is a common misunderstanding to confound the two. The exoteric both hides and protects the esoteric teaching. Moreover, outside observers often see the egregore of the exoteric side, which they presume to be the true teaching. That is unfortunate, yet is understandable.

Metaphysics Metaphysics is as objective and knowable as any science, including physics. However, physics only concerns itself with the working or the physical world, or gross manifestation. Metaphysics, on the other hand, recognizes that reality is much vaster than what science can conceive. There are subtle states which depend on consciousness and can be explored by the intrepid inner researcher. Beyond that, there are many degrees of existence with various qualities. Poets, mystics, and saints — of

many traditions — have described those states. Physics and metaphysics are not in conflict unless they intrude into the other's problem domain.

In this sense, Vladimir Solovyov asserted that Christianity did not introduce a new metaphysics. Rather it is based on Neoplatonic and Hermetic philosophy, which are the Western version of the Ancient Tradition. Its contribution comprises the historical events that culminated in the birth, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

History and Faith Although history is concerned with the gross world, unlike physics it cannot be known simply from external observations. The meaning of history requires an understanding of the intentions of the various actors.

Clearly, at that time some believed that Jesus was the Messiah, others that he was an enemy of the state, but most just saw an itinerant preacher. So which version are we to accept? Thomas Aquinas explains:

Believing is an act of the intellect assenting to the divine truth by command of the will.

There is nothing there about emotions or irrationality. Of course, exoteric believers will sound very emotional and sentimental about their beliefs, but not those with a deeper understanding. There are two aspects to Thomas's insight.

First of all, belief is a deliberate choice, i.e., an act of will. That is not at all an emotional reaction. Nevertheless, emotions may follow. However, these are higher emotions that follow from the intellect; they do not control the choice as the lower emotions do.

Second, the intellect assents implying that the belief is not compellingly false nor implausible. Without going into complete detail, I can assert this. The intellect sees that mankind is fallen in some sense from its primordial glory. We can also see that there is not worldly solution: no science, pharmaceutical, eugenic, psychological, economic, or social solution can

ever remedy that. Only the insertion of a force from outside the system can do so. That may not be a proof for you, but it is a justified belief.

Conclusion So I willingly embrace an exoteric tradition that is helpful to me personally and fits my personal equation. It has spiritually nourished my direct ancestors for 1500 years, so I am loathe to reject it arbitrarily. As I wrote above, there is simply no need to. My reader claims that, "I'm on the side of Man's increasing consciousness, not specifically the Christians, the Jews, the Hindus etc."

That makes as much sense as going to a restaurant and telling the server: "I am in favor of eating, but not specifically Italian, German, Japanese; just give me food."

Just as healthy food nourishes the body, whatever type of cuisine it is, so does a healthy tradition nourish the spirit. For me to abandon my Tradition to chase after some vague "increasing consciousness" means that I would have to reject the metaphysical teachings of Augustine, Boethius, Bernard, Dante, Thomas Aquinas, Eckhart, and so many others. But ironically, they are the very teachers of "increasing consciousness."

Moreover, there is also a rich source of teachings on spiritual practice, prayer, meditation, contemplation, and so on. It is hubris for anyone to think he or she can recreate all that *de novo*.

Posted on 2023-04-04 by Cologero

* * *

taivasvaeltaja on 2023-04-09 at 16:38 said:

Even though it may sound sentimental, the gift of tears is still a password for higher realms for many. When Jesus wept, did his tears make oceans?

Sylvan Savant on 2023-04-09 at 18:23 said:

If there's no orthodoxy, how could there be any heresy? If there is no right path to the destination, then how could one go astray?

Excellent quote by Thomas Aquinas. I find it very helpful in my current situation, thanks.

Taivasvaeltaja on 2023-10-23 at 09:28 said:

"In this sense, Vladimir Solovyov asserted that Christianity did not introduce a new metaphysics. Rather it is based on Neoplatonic and Hermetic philosophy, which are the Western version of the Ancient Tradition. Its contribution comprises the historical events that culminated in the birth, death, and resurrection of Jesus."

I've become to think that perhaps Christianity sort of restricted its metaphysical teaching to a certain level of understanding in order to make men focus on the process of salvation, where all the theology of the churches then sprang out.

That which does not make me doubt in any sense is that the symbolical and mythical life of Jesus Christ was a momentous happening on planet earth and in which the symbols that define the Christic Mythos, the turning of the wheel of involution towards the ascending arch of spiritual evolution, liberation of maya and matter as the bodies of Christ were crucified while his Solar Nature laughs upon the Cross. As Christ is the Light and Lucifer the Light-Bearer, the mental body of Christ is Sophia-Lucifer – the one whom even Gnostics struggled to understand – and the bodily cross of man is Lucifer's prison. Only the Logos could have done the turning of the wheel of involution, because "The Father and I are One."

I.II The Greater Mysteries

Omnipotence does not mean power to do absurdities. The compulsion of another's will is such an absurdity, and therefore no real omnipotence could force such a compulsion. Omnipotence is spiritual, and spirit acts not by brute compulsion but by knowledge and inspiration.

R. G. COLLINGWOOD

Over the past 150 years or so, we have been gifted with some extraordinary revelations which conceivably will buttress the foundation of a spiritual renewal. Apart from some small pockets of interest, the world continues on its downward path. If you are happy with your current spiritual reading, perhaps these revelations don't matter much. If you are entrenched

in materialism and scientism, these ideas may not be able to penetrate your minds. But for a few of us, these ideas form the foundation for the worldview of Tradition.

To commence, I shall mention these three in particular:

- **Vladimir Solovyov** revealed the inner connection between Egyptian theosophy and Christian doctrine.
- **Rene Guenon** revealed the existence of the Primordial Tradition.
- **Georges Dumezil** revealed the social structure common to traditional societies.

Hermetic Roots of Tradition In an intriguing footnote to his most metaphysical book, *Lectures on Divine Humanity*, Vladimir Solovyov noted the close connection between Hermetic philosophy and Christian doctrine. Specifically, the ideas of the Logos and the Trinity was known to the Neoplatonic philosophers. His conclusion was that Christian doctrine did not create a new metaphysics, but its originality is in its revelation of positive facts. Viz., the Logos was incarnated in Jesus, and the Trinity included three divine persons, beyond its abstract metaphysical principles.

There are those who regard the reawakening of Hermetic ideas in the Renaissance as some sort of aberration and the sign of a decline. Rather, it is a recovery of what was there in the beginning. The decline is because of the separation of Tradition from the exoteric organisation. The result is that the esoteric teaching veered off into phantasies and the exoteric lost its soul, and has been carried about with every wind of doctrine by the wickedness of men.

In our own time, we have the works of **Valentin Tomberg** and **Boris Mouravieff** who, in different ways, have reunited the two streams.

The Primordial Tradition Despite all of his works being readily available, Rene Guenon is still not properly understood. Some say he created a novel “School” of “Traditionalism” with certain beliefs and dogmas. To the contrary, he revealed the existence of the Primordial Tradition, which is not a matter of speculation.

The source of the Primordial Tradition is superhuman, and its metaphysical teaching is eternal. Hence, it is not contingent on any human activities and moreover it has always existed and will always exist. A fortiori, it is not the teaching of a particular “School”. Nor can one be a vague “traditionalist”; it is necessary to be part of a specific tradition.

Nevertheless, the Tradition does take form in various cultures and historical epochs. It is then expressed in doctrines, rites, and symbols appropriate to its exoteric manifestation. These manifestations of the Primordial Tradition also show the way to the mysteries:

- The Lesser Mysteries show the way back to the primordial state before the Fall of man
- The Greater Mysteries show the path to gnosis through self-knowledge

The primordial state is the natural state of humanity, even if its memory has been mostly lost. Since we have already, in multiple posts, discussed the Primordial Tradition unveiled by Guenon, there is not need to repeat it all here.

Trifunctional Social Organisation In his cross-cultural studies of myths and social institutions, Georges Dumezil discovered the tri-functional organisation of Indo-European cultures. These are:

- The function of the sacred
- The warrior function

- The producers

There correspond to three human types:

- Those who are strong by intelligence
- Those who are strong in courage and valour in battle
- Those who are wealthy

In the European Middle Ages, society was similarly organised:

- Oratores: those who pray (the clergy)
- Bellatores: those who fight (the nobility)
- Laboratores: those who work

Moreover, these three functions were hierarchically organised, so that the producers were under the nobility or the political power, who themselves were subject to the spiritual authority. There was no freedom of religion, since the whole society was based on spiritual unity. To be excommunicated was tantamount to exile from the group. Modern theories, on the other hand, try to achieve unity based on other contingent factors such as race, economic class, or political party. Such societies are fragile, whereas societies based on a common spiritual foundation have tended to persist.

Acres of Diamonds In *The Vedanta and Western Tradition*⁵, **Ananda Coomaraswamy** listed eight Western thinkers who, in their totality, come closest to the teachings of the Vedanta. These are, at a minimum:

I. Plato

⁵<https://gornahoor.net/?p=556>

2. Philo
3. Hermes Trismegistus
4. Plotinus
5. Gospel of John
6. Dionysius the Areopagite
7. Meister Eckhart
8. Dante

I would add four more:

1. Aristotle
2. Augustine of Hippo
3. Boethius
4. Thomas Aquinas

With that grounding, there can be found:

- Knowledge of the Absolute
- Cosmology
- The distinction between the worlds of Being and Becoming
- Hylomorphism
- The psychological constitution of human beings
- An ethical system based on virtues and excellence

- Political theory
- The three stages of spiritual life, and so on

Yet, of those claiming to be “traditional”, who takes this list seriously? Instead, we hear pointless arguments about what is tradition. For example, is European tradition pagan or Christian? If you decide on the former, then this list still applies to you; or else you are just role playing.

Other Westerners decide to look elsewhere, becoming Druids, Vedantic priests, Buddhists, etc. However, if they cannot understand their own tradition, can you really trust that they can understand another?

Russell Conwell wrote the famous essay *Acres of Diamonds*⁶ about a man who went off in search of diamonds, when there were diamonds scattered on his own property that he abandoned. That is the situation we are in today, always searching the next glittery thing elsewhere, instead of where it is actually found.

The Absolute and God The strictly philosophical point of view can only rise to the level of the Absolute. Starting with the realisation that all things and events are interrelated, one rises up to an understanding that encompasses increasing number of things in space and time. Ultimately, one is led to the Absolute. However, different thinkers have understood it in different way; for example:

- Plato: the form of the Good
- Aristotle: the unmoved mover and first cause
- Plotinus: the One
- Spinoza: Nature

⁶<https://americanrhetoric.com/speeches/rconwellacresofdiamonds.htm>

- Schopenhauer: Blind Will
- Francis Bradley: the True

Some philosophers believe that mankind is evolving toward the Absolute, while in most other systems, the notion of change is an illusion.

Hence, philosophy is part of a larger conversation. Sharing in that has its positive points. The intellectual contemplation of the Absolute can be accompanied by joy and peace. However, this is at the level of the lesser mysteries.

If the human being is a person, the question must needs arise about the Absolute: How can an abstract Absolute give rise to persons with their own interiority? The Absolute itself, then, must also have a centre of interiority. Once this is grasped, then the idea of revelation from, and relationship to, the Absolute makes sense. God reveals himself as the Absolute, yet is incomprehensible. An object can be known, but a subject, or person, always contains something hidden.

At the stage of the contemplation of God, unlike philosophical contemplation of the Absolute, there is no subject-object difference. There is just one Self. That is the goal of the greater mysteries.

The European Tradition A final point for those who haven't yet grasped the idea of Tradition. Since it is superhuman and transcendental, it does not depend on individual men and women. If the spiritual leaders fail, if their organisation fails, the Tradition itself perdures. This is timely, given the confused state of the organisation whose duty is to preserve the Western tradition. Keep this in mind:

The Church is not a man or even a mere collective of men, but the Mystical Body of Christ whose subsistence cannot be destroyed by any human error. Lost in the current mania of hyper-papalism is the infallibility of the Church as a corporate whole, extending

even to the faithful as a body, which obeys what has always been taught by the Church as a whole and rejects what is foreign to that teaching.

The Remnant Newspaper, March 31, 2019.

In other words, follow tradition, not the organisation.

Posted on 2019-06-26 by Cologero

* * *

Sam Viehweg on 2019-06-27 at 18:31 said:

Can I ask, regarding the following: "Nor can one be a vague "traditionalist"; it is necessary to be part of a specific tradition."

Where does this leave Evola? And where does this leave one who has no avenue externally to be part of a specific tradition?

Cologero on 2019-06-27 at 18:56 said:

We are in a mess

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AjplZXgodhs>

Tom on 2019-07-10 at 11:59 said:

Why is it automatically assumed that being is superior to becoming ?

Cologero on 2019-07-13 at 23:09 said:

"superior" simply means higher up. Our world of experience is the world of becoming. The modern world automatically assumes that this world is causally closed, thereby failing to recognize transcendence. Unfortunately, the sensory world of experience is unintelligible. This is too obvious to waste much time on it. Viz., people may agree on the facts of experience, but there is no agreement on the meaning of those facts. Surely you have noticed that. In Platonic terms, we can only have opinions about the world of becoming, but not knowledge.

Real knowledge is knowledge of essences, which are part of the world of being. I've spent a lot of virtual ink illustrating that in many ways, from many angles. Pick a particular sentence or paragraph, if you have a question.

I.12 The Mess We Are In

The idea that nature is a closed system of natural causes and that natural causes provide a complete account of everything that occurs in nature is deeply entrenched in the West.

WILLIAM DEMBSKI

The common sentimental idea is that the Garden of Eden was set up perfectly for Adam. This cannot be the case as it stands. The natural world existed as such, which we still experience. Adam was given supernatural graces that could never be given to animals, plants, and minerals. But animals still lived natural lives, and there were natural dangers from fire, and other events.

Moreover, Adam had preternatural abilities. Although preternatural abilities are beyond nature, Adam was the agent (not God). These abilities intrude willy-nilly into life even in our time, so we can presume Adam had more control over them. They go by the names paranormal, psychic, second sight, and so on. If they exist, their occurrences seem to be mostly random.

Adam's natural abilities were enhanced. So he was always aware of what was going on and was never distracted. His ability to think logically and act rationally were unimpaired. The reason I express it this way is to show that if the primordial state cannot be an aspiration, at least it can be understood (at least to the initiated).

There is no point to turn Adam into some sort of Prometheus as though we can now "think for ourselves". If that is so, the results have been completely underwhelming.

Fallen State The soul is spiritual and corporal. The former transcends the world and the latter is tied to the body and its function. The Fall indicates that the center of being descends from the Self of the spirit soul

to the Ego of the corporal soul. The Self is forgotten and largely subconscious, or better said, superconscious. The attributes of the Primordial State are suddenly transformed:

- **Knowledge** $\Rightarrow$ Ignorance, stupidity, opinion (in place of gnosis)
- **Integrity** $\Rightarrow$ inner confusion, lying to self and others, deception, doubt
- **Impassibility** $\Rightarrow$ motivated by unhealthy emotions and disordered desires. Malice and Concupiscence
- **Immortality** $\Rightarrow$ Death, with associated fear and anxiety

The Fall is never total, and there is always the possibility of access to the higher attributes.

Fallen World Multiply that by 7.6 thousand million and we have the modern world. Ignorance, malice, and concupiscence used to be considered faults to be overcome, like this

- Education to overcome ignorance
- Control of emotions to overcome malice
- Moderation to overcome excessive desire.

That is no longer the case. Propaganda replaces education. Malice is encouraged as a method of social control. Hardly any sexual desire is considered anti-social and even gluttony is defended.

The world, then, is ruled by conflicting opinions, not to mention outright falsehoods. This situation is represented in the diagram by small arrows going in random directions. These are called the “A” influences. If you remember your vector math, you can see that the sum of all the vectors amounts to zero. That means that the entire world process, under these A influences, is going nowhere.

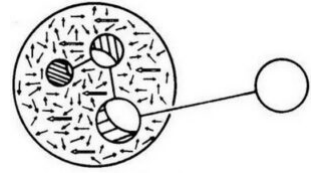


Figure 1.2: World influences

That is the global view. However, locally there may be clusters of A influences that are aligned together. In that section of the world, they can wield power because any opposition, being disorganized, again sums up to zero. Eventually, even that apparent unity dissipates into its opposite.

There are always attempts within the world process that promise unity. Thus, science, philosophy, political programs are proposed, but never achieve the goal. Science, for example, is simply too difficult for the majority of people to understand, and its conclusions—never really definitive—are perverted for political purposes.

The idea that there will be a scientific, philosophical, or political solution to the problems of human life—some day in the distant future—is widespread among the educated class. It is considered a marker for intelligence, despite all available historical evidence. For the person who comes to terms with this, there are two choices

1. Nihilism, the notion that there is no ultimate truth
2. The solution must arise from outside the world process system

So that is the ultimate result of Adam’s hubris to determine good and evil for himself. He can remain delusional, admit that his project ended in failure, or seek to return to the Primordial State that he had rejected.

Nausea and Repetition I sent the little ones youtube videos of one-celled animals eating each other, disintegrating, cloning themselves. The kids were delighted, especially the ones with microscopes. But I wondered why. For perhaps hundreds of millions of years, these critters have been reproducing the same drama over and over and over again. Eating, dying, attacking, reproducing for no purpose. Nauseating.

The ducks wandering about the neighbourhood are the same. Occasionally, one will nest and lay eggs behind the bushes around my house. A dozen ducklings hatch. They leave the nest, all following the mother. The next day some are missing. More missing on the day after. Maybe one or two reach adulthood just to start the cycle over again.

Who can live like that? But human life is no different. The same little dramas repeat and repeat, just with minor variations on the theme. A confessor used to ask me about Moses' neighbour. Who dat I asked. Exactly. No one cares about Moses' neighbour anymore. Ever since then, the same stories, the same situations, the same sins. Just different people, all 50 billion of them soon forgotten. Multi-celled paramecia.

The Way Out In the diagram, notice the longer and larger arrows all pointing in the same direction from right to left. These represent the influences of revealed religion. Some people, in despair, will respond to those B influences; the remainder will continue their neverending battles of opinion. Those exoteric influences show the path to escape the world process. For a few, there are the C or esoteric influences. Although the B influences are sufficient in themselves, the C (and higher) influences can lead to even higher states of being.

Infallible Obviously, to be of any benefit, these higher influences are necessarily infallible. The way out of the mess cannot be just one more opinion among the others. It will be countercultural, much different from the way the world thinks and acts.

Many are offended at the notion of infallibility. I can't understand why. I haven't met many people who would concede that their opinions about all manner of things might possibly be incorrect.

Many others will become interested in this Revelation. So they will read books about it, seek out teachers, even idolize their favourite authors. They will know much about the way out, and how predecessors described the way out, but they seldom bother to actually tread the path.

A few will claim to guide you on the way out, but they are wolves in sheep's clothing. They will often tell you how wonderful you are. And all the time how wonderful they are.

Salvation The story is misunderstood if it only about living in a perfect environment, like a mouse utopia. That is insufficient, because even the serpent inhabits the garden. Evil, therefore, was a possibility of manifestation, so it manifested. Salvation is something else, something much greater than the garden. And it involves the serpent, but that is another story.

Posted on 2020-09-09 by Cologero

* * *

Thomas on 2020-09-09 at 12:33 said:

"Adam's natural abilities were enhanced. So he was always aware of what was going on and was never distracted. His ability to think logically and act rationally were unimpaired."

How did he "fall" then ?

Cologero on 2020-09-09 at 16:49 said:

You need to read it to the end, and also in conjunction with the previous post.

I don't mind the conversation, though, because maybe some points can be clarified.

Sylvan Savant on 2020-09-11 at 16:25 said:

This might sound irrelevant but please bear with me. Everyone has likely heard of the MGTOW movement. Basically these are jaded men who came to the shocking realization that women are essentially insufferable.

Man has a certain idea in his mind about what a woman is, and when that idea doesn't correspond with empirical reality, he begins to make a generalization about what their genuine nature must be like. Some of them might even go to the extremes of delving into the age old perceptions of witches and skin changers, which I won't go into here. Besides, the reality of woman as a object that is sensed may be one thing, but how they are perceived by two different people is an entirely different matter.

This is especially true of a highly attractive woman, who since childhood, quickly finds out that certain things are "expected" of her from male company. This prevents her from putting forth a sincere impression of what she actually is in front of people, which further complicates matters.

In any case this isn't about women, but about perception. Already you can see here how brittle is the notion we live in a empirical reality the nature of which is entirely rationally intelligible.

Zhuge Liang was a very lucky man. His wife was hard working, loyal, intensely loving and they both had a shared taste for poetry. She was also incredibly plain. Not ugly, or even uncomely, just plain. I wonder how many times Zhuge had to fight back a feeling of insufferable regret as he turned down the advances of the many gorgeous women of the Shu court?

We can't say beauty is just skin deep. Actually in my opinion this is untenable even if it is true. To repeat the age old adage of "value integrity over appearance" may be wise, but it is practically speaking useless. This is because beauty is a window into the world beyond. Beauty makes no sense from a utilitarian point of view, it has no explanation from a naturalist perspective and it is inimic by nature to randomness and chance.

Of course a scientist would say that beauty is nothing but an evolutionary adaptation to a vital external stimulus, such as hunger or mating on one hand, and on the other hand a neurochemical-behavioral response that the need to satisfy such things prompt. This is akin to giving attributes to the higher functions of the mind in terms of the brain stem. The problem with that explanation is that science talks about what is perceived, but this isn't the reality that man finds himself in, nor can it ever be. Rather he inescapably finds himself trapped in the internal world of unperceived images, unrealized passions and unfulfillable desires.

To continuously grasp after them is his lot in life, in the only way that he knows how, through the acquisition of the fleeting experience that their facsimiles and reproductions can provide in the sensible world. Hence you have the modern world defining life as this verminous chase after money, women, cars, video game achievements, radical political ideologies and so on. We are all like this without exception. Breaking out of this state is unbelievably easy, but it requires a radical change in understanding of our nature, which is why it is impossible for most people.

This brings us back to the fall. In the end, you can't escape from the truth as laid out in the Scriptures, no matter how diligently one might try ridicule and trample it.

Cologero on 2020-09-13 at 14:35 said:

Good thoughts, Sylvan, but we are discussing quite different things. I am not as interested in the empirical, but rather in the psychological and even metaphysical. We may have many images of women in our heads, especially in our time when we are bombarded by images. Keep in mind that historically images were hard to come by.

The task of the alchemical marriage (from the male point of view) is to identify the true Anima and to distinguish it from all the false ideas. That, it turns out, is not so easy. Most men will reject the notion entirely, and it is not at all about "getting in touch with the feminine side".

As for Zhuge Liang: I don't want to be too explicit but a man has within himself a very reliable and objective judge of who is physically attractive enough. In any case, a man's life project cannot revolve around a woman. If he found a loving companion who would make the circumstances of his life more comfortable, then he was quite fortunate. He was considered intelligent and wise, so perhaps he is a good example to follow.

Thomas on 2020-09-14 at 10:02 said:

You said that " Evil, therefore, was a possibility of manifestation, so it manifested." The question is why was it a " possibility of manifestation ' rather than (to use the same terminology) a possibility of non-manifestation ?

Cologero on 2020-09-14 at 10:38 said:

Tom, that is a very good question and the answer may be more complex than it seems. ... assuming there is a good answer.

The serpent was in the supposedly perfect garden for some reason, so the possibility of a dual mind or doubt was baked into creation.

So why was evil manifested? There is the notion that evil is somehow not ultimately "real", and that it is merely the absence of good. That seems to imply that evil as such cannot be manifested.

Even if that is the case from the metaphysical point of view, it is not satisfying from the psychological point of view. Jung points that out and analyzes various symbols on that topic. The effects of evil certainly feel real.

Augustine wanted to avoid the Manichaeism that he left behind. It raised evil up to the level of the good, so there is an ongoing cosmic battle between god and evil. On the other side, movements like Christian Science or ACIM take the notion to the extreme and deny the reality of sickness, evil, etc.

I'm gathering material on the topic will post it when ready.

In the meantime, interiorly we can experience that same dual mind.

The Hermetic Tradition

2.1 Vincit omnia Veritas

Is the initiate preoccupied with exhibiting in forms that will astonish, amaze, or terrify ...

On the contrary, if there is anything radically opposed to the style of the true initiate, it is precisely this behavior. By definition, the initiate is an occult being and his path is neither visible nor penetrable. He is elusive, not to be pigeonholed. He arrives from the direction contrary to that toward which all gazes are fixed and takes the most natural seeming vehicle for his supernatural action. He may be an intimate friend, companion, or lover; he may be sure of possessing all your heart and confidence. But he will always be something different, other than what he lets be known. We will perceive this 'other' only when we've penetrated his domain. And then perhaps we will have the feeling of having been standing on an abyss.

Men desire that what they are be known, that what they do be acknowledged, and that we be pleased by the quality of their performance. In the words of Agrippa, we have learned how dif-

ferent the law is that governs the magus and the hermeticist. They judge all exhibitionism and personality to be puerile. There is no adept. He does not exist. He does not speak. They but seek to net the wind, who are diverted by such things. The hermeticist has reached a state that categorically avoids all reaction to human judgment. He has stopped taking an interest in what others may think of him, or say about him, just or unjust, good or bad. He knows only that certain things must happen: he provides the precise means and conditions for them and that is all. He does not pretend the action is his own. He is pure instrumentality. 'Self-affirmation' is a mania he does not recognise. And the farther he advances, the more deeply his centre sinks into a superindividual and superpersonal range, like one of the great forces of Nature, while those on whom he acts have the impression of being free.

JULIUS EVOLA, *The Hermetic Tradition*

The Masses In *The Crisis of the Modern World*, **Rene Guenon** describes the qualities of the masses, the called, and the elect or elite. Regarding the **masses**, he writes:

It is doubtless true that the masses have always been led in one way or another, and it could be said that their part in history consists primarily in allowing themselves to be led, since they represent a predominantly passive element ... but in order to lead them today it is sufficient to possess oneself of purely material means, taking the word matter this time in its ordinary sense, and this clearly shows to what depths the present age has sunk; and at the same time these same masses are made to believe that they are not being led, but that they are acting spontaneously and governing themselves, and the fact that they believe this to be true gives an idea of the extent of their unintelligence.

The Called The unintelligence of the **called** is more subtle. The Gospels say that “many are called but few are chosen”. That is because the called have an interest yet possess only the possibilities of knowledge. Therefore, they are prone to various seductions that will lead them astray. As Guenon warns:

Many efforts are thereby expended in vain, and thus it is that many of those who sincerely desire to react against the modern outlook have been reduced to impotence; having failed to discover the essential principles, without which all action is doomed to be ineffective, they have allowed themselves to be lured into blind alleys from which there is no possible way of escape.

This is quite unfortunate when sincere minds get closed due to an infatuation with those blind alleys. The modernistic spirit can be difficult to overcome. For example, egalitarianism, historicism, and psychologism are prevalent even among those who outward claim to be committed to Tradition. Guenon explains the sinister nature of this spirit:

Without any doubt the modernistic spirit, which is truly diabolical in every sense of the word, is striving by all the means in its power to prevent these elements, today isolated and scattered, from achieving the cohesion that is necessary if they are to exert any real influence on the general mentality.

The Chosen Next is the **chosen**, or elect, who will constitute the elite. Again from the Gospels: “For false Christs and false prophets shall arise, and shall show signs and wonders to seduce, if it were possible, even the elect.” But the chosen are no longer able to be seduced in virtue of the inner realisation they have achieved. Because this inner realization is certain and secure, Guenon is far from pessimistic and despairing. He concludes:

Those who will be successful in overcoming all these obstacles and in triumphing over the hostility of an environment opposed to all spirituality will doubtless be few in number; but, once again, it is not numbers that count here, for this is a realm where the laws are quite other than those of matter. There is therefore no occasion for despondency; and even were there no hope of achieving any visible result before the collapse of the modern world through a catastrophe, that would still not be a valid reason to refrain from embarking upon a work extending in scope far beyond the present time. Those who may feel tempted to give way to discouragement should remind themselves that nothing accomplished within the order can ever be lost, that confusion, error and darkness can enjoy no more than a specious and purely ephemeral triumph, that every kind of partial and transitory disequilibrium must perforce contribute towards the great equilibrium of the whole, and that nothing can ultimately prevail against the power of truth for their motto they should take the one adopted in former times by certain initiatory organisations in the West:

Vincit omnia Veritas

Posted on 2010-04-14 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-04-14 at 23:04 said:

The passage from Evola called to mind one from Boethius which is shorter but in essence the same: "For as often as a man receives the reward of fame for his boasting, the conscience that indulges in self congratulation loses something of its secret merit." Even more creeping, I have noticed, is silent self praise, when one behaves humbly but secretly thinks oneself superior, perhaps not even aware of the hypocrisy. Profane elitists succumb to this trap, one way or the other; and it's vital for us, when dealing in ideas like 'the elect' and 'the masses', to be careful we do not.

Mikkel on 2018-04-14 at 21:19 said:

Aurelius as well noted that “For that arrogance which grows in arrogance for its own lack of arrogance is the most irksome of all”. This is stated within a Evola book stating the differences between humility and modesty.

Work that is done with the heights in mind that correspond to the order of things will always be true and right, that is something that cannot be taken.

Alex on 2022-04-14 at 20:47 said:

Very often, when reading Evola, I find myself wishing he would get to the point or simplify his message. This quote from his “Hermetic Tradition” really took my breath away. If I should ever again feel that he is confusing me I will look up to this quote that I pinned to my wall board and tell myself here is your master.

2.2 Land of the Twice-born

Man has to love the past in order to remember it.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Those who see in Gornahoor nothing but an apology for New Age occultism are severely in error. While there are many claiming to expose alleged secret conspiracies, they offer nothing positive. Gornahoor, on the other hand, is revealing to those who can understand the hidden roots of Western civilization. Hermetism, as revealed by Ficino, is nourished by Hermes, Orpheus, Pythagoras, Plato, Plotinus, among others. We have mentioned other sources of Western thought¹. These represent the foundations of Western and European thought. The full history was known as recently as Donoso Cortes² and Vladimir Solovyov in the 19th century, and later by the recoverers of Tradition³. It would be to our detriment to forget our past.

¹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=556>

²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=223>

³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=735>

Europe was populated by the twice-born, millennia before Jesus' nocturnal visit to Nicodemus where he fully revealed the second birth of water and spirit. This makes Europe a spiritual reality and its true peoples, persons of intelligence, imagination and will. Those who have not experienced the second birth will continue to see nothing in a man but a biological entity who can be manipulated by thought and emotion. But worlds are not created by books, arguments or debate that can only appeal to the head. Rather worldviews⁴ must be grasped by the heart, the true center of a man's being. That is, a genuine worldview is an inspiration, born of the Spirit with its perfect reflection in the still waters of a people attuned to the transcendent.

Posted on 2010-11-23 by Cologero

2.3 Death by a Kiss

Modus quo rationales animae per archangelum Deo sacrificantur, qui a Cabalisticis non exprimitur, non est nisi per separationem animae a corpore, non corporis ab anima nisi per accidens, ut contigit in morte osculi, de quo scribitur praeciosa in conspectu domini mors sanctorum eius.

GIOVANNI PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA, *Cabalistic Conclusions XI*

The way in which rational souls sacrifice themselves to God through the archangel, which the Cabalists do not describe, occurs because of the separation of the soul from the body, not of the body from the soul, if not by accident, as seen in death by a kiss, about which is written "Precious in the sight of the Lord is the death of his faithful." [Psalm 116:15]. [My Translation]

⁴See Section 2.1 in this book.

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth: for thy love is better than wine.

Song of Solomon 1:2

Whosoever would [behold God] before they are cleansed and healed, are so stricken by that light of truth that they see in it not only no goodness, but even much evil, and therefore deny to it the name of truth, and with their lusts and miserable pleasures, refusing health, flee away in their darkness, which is even their death.

ST AUGUSTINE

Before there was a French Hermetic Tradition, there was the Platonic Academy⁵ in Florence. In particular, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola first synthesized Christianity, Hermes Trismegistus, and the Cabala, along with Neoplatonism, Aristotle, Pythagoras, Orpheus, and Zoroaster.

He summarized those teachings in the 900 theses. Some of which were adapted from Latin philosophers and theologians, Arabs, Greeks, Neoplatonism, Chaldeans, Hermes Trismegistus and finally the Cabala. The rest were his own opinions. The latter includes the mystical Cabalistic Conclusion #11.

Plato said that perfect or undying love required divesting oneself of human life by separating the soul from the body. Yet an understanding of such love requires first the love of beauty in one's youth. In the story of Eurydice and Orpheus, Orpheus was unwilling to part with his life and therefore saw only a shadow of his beloved. Hence, Orpheus failed Plato's test. Pico explains it this way:

Corporeal and sensible beauty can excite in the soul a memory of its intellectual part and cause it to run away from the earthly life

⁵[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Platonic_Academy_\(Florence\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Platonic_Academy_(Florence))

towards the eternal, where it is refined into an angel by the flame of love.

Pico understood the three worlds:

- Angelic or Intelligible
- Celestial or Astral
- Sublunar (world of darkness)

The sublunar world is known through the senses, but the angelic world is known by the intellectual part of the soul. That is because the angels don't have sense experiences, but know the forms or ideas intuitively. For example, in the sublunar realm we may experience heat through the senses, but the angels know the idea of heat through the intellect, and so on.

Only the world of sensual experience has reality for the common man. He does not experience the ideas directly, which are obscure or are considered to be mental or social constructs. As Augustine points out, the common man clings to his lusts, pleasures, and manufactured drama. The call for spiritual purification would destroy his factitious world, so he resists it in terror. It can only feel like death to him. Yet the Hermetist seeks this out deliberately. Pico describes the experience:

It is possible then through the first death, which is merely the separation of the soul from the body, for the lover to see the beloved celestial Venus and, face to face with her, meditating on her divine image, blissfully nourish his purified eyes; but whoever wishes to possess her still more intimately and, not content with seeing and hearing her, to be worthy of intimate embraces and fervent kisses, must separate himself in total separation from the body through the second death.

In other words, the erotic impulse must be purified of every sensual image in order to reach the beatific vision. He must die before he dies. This Platonic love still idealises the image the beloved, yet the sensual element is left behind.

Baldassare Castiglione asserted that sensual love is an evil, yet it is excusable in the young provided they show gentleness, courtesy, and valour. He writes:

When they are no longer of youthful age, they wholly abandon it, having that sensual desire, as the lowest rung of the ladder by which man climbs unto the true love.

Castiglione regarded the love of the 63-year old Michelangelo for the poetess Vittoria Colonna as an example of Platonic love. We have previously described how the loves of Wagner and Goethe at an advanced age led to periods of great creativity. Of course, Dante regarded Beatrice as his beloved celestial Venus, and was led into the celestial realm.

The kiss represents the union of the Soul with God. Pico was more modest than the Tibetans who used the image of the yab-yum. He explains why:

Take note that the most perfect and intimate union that the lover may have with the celestial beloved is signified by the union of the kiss, because all other coming together or coupling beyond that, as in the case of physical love, is in no way allowed to be used as a metaphor in this holy and most sacred love. And because the learned cabalists maintain that many of the ancient patriarchs died in such an intellectual rapture, you will find in their writings the expression the death of the *binsica*, which in our language means death by a kiss, which is said of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, Aaron, Mary, and some others . . . nor will you read more in their books than that *binsica*, or death by a kiss, occurs when the soul unites itself with those things separated from the earth

in an intellectual rapture to such a degree that being lifted out of the body it abandons it entirely.

What then is this *binsica*, *mors osculi*, death by a kiss. Ioan Couliano illustrates it with some examples:

It is a terrifying vision of the intelligible world that Pico rediscovers in the fable of Tiresias: because he saw Diana naked, which means nothing other than ideal Beauty, the source of all true wisdom, Tiresias went blind, losing the use of his sensual sight but receiving the gift of prophecy, or incorporeal sight. The same thing happened to Homer in the throes of the inspiration that made him contemplate the mysteries of intellect. And Paul too, after his journey to the third heaven, went blind.

The death by the kiss is therefore the contemplation of the divine intelligences. The body is in a state of catalepsy analogous to sleep paralysis⁶. There is still the question of the means to reach this state. We can start with **Marsilio Ficino**'s understanding of the angelic hierarchy in Table 2.1.

The angels are not "seen" in a sensual way, but one can see them incorporeally by ascending through deeper understanding of the higher intellectual centre. By developing spiritual vision, one learns to see the forms or ideas animating the conditions of the sensual world.

The Guardian angel is the prototype of one's own being, or one's more perfect double. Through understanding the archangels and principalities, one learns to discern large groupings. For example, in the sensual realm, one sees people as simply individual beings. However, on a higher level one sees the roles of nations, ethnicities, clans, families, and so on. Yet, that is never static. At the level of the powers, one discerns how everything is manifested in time.

⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sleep_paralysis

<i>Seraphim</i>	Speculate on the order and providence of God
<i>Cherubim</i>	Speculate on the essence and form of God
<i>Thrones</i>	Speculate, but some descend to work
<i>Dominions</i>	Architects who design what the rest execute
<i>Virtues</i>	Execute, move the heavens, and concur for the working of miracles as God's instruments
<i>Powers</i>	Watch that the order of divine governance is not interrupted and some of them descend to human things
<i>Principalities</i>	Care for public affairs, nations, princes, magistrates
<i>Archangels</i>	Direct the divine cult and look after sacred things
<i>Angels</i>	Look after smaller affairs and take charge of individuals as their guardian angels

Table 2.1: The Angelic Hierarchy and their Functions

Ultimately, one experiences the world as a reflection of the order and providence of God. Hence, in previous posts, we suggested meditations on Being, the Moral Order, and so on.

Yet there are real dangers there for the Magician. If he has not properly prepared himself through the purification of his will and his intellect, he risks contacting bad angels.

References:

H/T **Charlotte Louise** for alerting me to this Cabalistic Conclusion.

Eros and Magic in the Renaissance, by Ioan P Couliano

Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition, by Frances Yates

The Religion of Beauty in Women, by Jefferson Fletcher

Posted on 2019-01-23 by Cologero

2.4 The Hidden Tradition

For most men life is made up of two days:

1. In the first they believe everything.
2. And in the second, nothing.

For a few others, life also has two days, but what distinguishes them from ordinary men is that

1. In the first day they believe only in illusions, and these are nothing;
2. While in the second day, they believe in everything, for they believe in truth, which is all.

LOUIS-CLAUDE DE SAINT-MARTIN

Since **Rene Guenon** was an initiate into a **Martinism** order, it may be of interest to explore their teachings. Martinism derives its name from the two “Martins”: **Martinez Pasquales** and **Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin**. The former mysteriously appeared with an order based on theurgy or ceremonial magic. The latter joined that order, but eventually abandoned it when he felt that he moved beyond “operations”. There was a loose group that gathered around him, the S.I. for the Order of Superieurs Inconnus (Unknown Superiors) and initiation was decidedly less formal.

Now Martinism claims its origin from God which was communicated from Adam to Noah to Melchisedek and then Abraham, Moses, Solomon, and Zerubbabel. In other words, there has always been this hidden tradition. **Valentin Tomberg** called it the Church of John. In a sense Tomberg completes this teaching, since he claims there is no longer a need for an “order”. Furthermore, the uneasy, and often hostile, relationship between the Johannine and Petrine churches is to be rectified.

Martinist Doctrine The doctrine hinges on a particular view of the fall of man; these are the fundamental points:

1. Original Man (or Primitive Adam or Archetypal Man) was emanated by God and dwelt on a high plane where he enjoyed a privileged position.
2. Through the misuse of his free will, Primitive Adam sinned and as a result fell.
3. As a result of the Fall, Man, originally a unified being, became shattered into numerous individualities who are now the men and women of the material world.
4. Individual man's task is to reintegrate himself back to the Archetype. All men and women must reintegrate with the Archetype so that Primitive Adam can be reconstituted and unity be again achieved.

The purpose of the order was to provide a way to achieve that task of reintegration.

Gregory of Nyssa on Adam Lest anyone think that is absurd or even heretical, I refer you to **Gregory of Nyssa**, as explained by **Vladimir Lossky** in *The Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church*:

The person, however, transcends and is free from his nature, i.e., not determined by it. The individual, on the other hand, which is the material manifestation and individuation, is often confused with the person. Thus, it is the individual which must be transcended. The Person is in a formless state. After the Fall, human nature became divided and broken into many individuals. Man has a double character: as an individual nature, he is a part of a whole, but as a person, he is in no sense a part, he contains all in himself.

So in our language the individual is a lower state of being and the person is a higher state. Human nature is disintegrated into multiplicity; in theological terms, human nature lost the “Integrity” which Adam possessed. It is man as individual that is transcended, not man as person. In the latter state, he is in the image of God and able to reach the Divine Union.

Saint-Martin’s Principles Saint-Martin was attracted to the spiritual and esoteric life from an early age and remained a lifelong Catholic. He tells us the principle he discovered that guided his life:

1. Despite all the confusions of philosophy, he had attained certitude as to God and his own soul.
2. The seeker for wisdom had need of nothing more.
3. The foundation of happiness lies in contentment with the truth.
4. Absorption in material things was incomprehensible for those who knew the treasures of reason and the spirit.
5. Human science explained matter by matter, but after its putative proofs, there were other demonstrations needed.
6. The inmost prayer of his soul was for God to abide therein to the exclusion of all else. Thus Divine Union is the true end of man.
7. We are all widowed and are called to a second marriage.

Nothing could be clearer. He starts with knowledge of the self and knowledge of God. He ends with the Divine Union, which he relates to a type of marriage. In brief, we can refer to a couple of high points in his doctrine, specifically as they relate to recent discussions.

The Will and Silencing the Mind Saint-Martin makes clear that the Divine Union can be accomplished in this life, rather than postmortem. First of all, a man must become aware of himself as a Person. He writes:

When we have once sensed our soul, we are left in no doubt as to its possibility.

The individual whose inner content is filled with opinions, desires, emotions, likes, dislikes, and sensations will experience nothing but doubt. To overcome that, the will must be conformed. He tells us:

Let me affirm that divine union is a work which can be accomplished only by the strong and constant resolution of those who desire it; that there is no other means to this end but the persevering use of a pure will, aided by the works and practice of every virtue, fertilized by prayer, that divine grace may come to help our weakness and lead us to the term of our regeneration.

The Martinist way now makes sense. It is not a question of overcoming human nature, but of transforming the fallen nature into something higher. Without understanding the state of Fallen man, one can only interpret such writings as overcoming human nature itself. That is not so; rather the goal is to transcend the fallen state and rise back to the Primordial State ("reintegration"). Clearly, man in the fallen state cannot accomplish that on his own, but requires an impetus from above him. This is not an indication of passivity, since it is the Will, the very source of activity, that must be employed.

To recap thus far: first, a man becomes aware of the possibilities of his soul, which makes him dissatisfied with ordinary life. Then he purifies the Will, which is no longer interested in ordinary pursuits. However, he still does not know how to proceed without an impetus from above. Unfortunately, the lot of mankind, although steeped in ignorance, is to make stuff up. Saint-Martin writes:

It is a sad vision indeed, that when we start looking at Man, we see him at the same time tormented by the desire to know, failing to find a reason for anything, but daring nevertheless to give a reason to everything.

Hence, man must first admit that he knows nothing, so he can follow his path open to Divine Grace. Otherwise, the knowledge he imagines he possesses will form an insurmountable obstacle to his progress.

The Active Path Although Saint-Martin uses the word “mysticism”, he technique is more active. First of all, let’s see how he understand mysticism:

The only initiation which I preach and seek with all the ardour of my soul is that by which we may enter into the heart of God and make God’s heart enter into us, there to form an indissoluble marriage ...

Once again, there is that alchemical imagery with the idea of “work”. The marriage of the soul with God is both a union and a separation. That is the proper meaning of “non-duality” ... not two, but not one either. A marriage is the apt symbol, since it is a union without annihilating either one. For “God” to annihilate the man is a form of monism, not non-dualism.

The Inner Way of Saint-Martin is individual and particular for each person. Concentration and contemplation are actually active, not passive. Try it, and you will see how difficult it is to maintain the focus of the mind. In the book which we shall mention below, his way is compared to Saint John of the Cross, who says that contemplation is infused passively so that illumination is awaited rather than sought. Saint-Martin sought to establish the correspondence of the soul with the Divine by the active path of WORKS. For the path of the Inner Way, we

seek to explain material things by man, and not man by material things.

That certainly deserves more thought than the few seconds required to read it. Who is prepared to understand the entire course of his life and the manifestation of his inner states?

Acknowledgment For the source of the doctrines and quotations, I relied on the little book, *Five Christian Principals*, by "R.C.", which describes the spiritual sources of the Martinist Doctrine. What follows is my own interpretation of their significance.

1. Martinez Pasquales. The link to the hidden tradition of all ages.
2. Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin. The link from the hidden tradition to the Roman church.
3. Jacob Boehme. The culmination of the current of German mysticism that began with Meister Eckhart.
4. Thomas a Kempis. Another German, he provides the basis of the path as the imitation of Christ.
5. Emanuel Swedenborg. He restores the tradition of the symbolic interpretation of Scriptures.

Posted on 2013-05-20 by Cologero

* * *

Caleb Cooper on 2013-05-21 at 09:03 said:

It's worth noting that in 1917 Valentin Tomberg was initiated into Martinism at the age of 17, Providently right before the Communist Revolution convulsed Russia and forced his family to flee for their lives to the West. http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Valentin_Tomberg

Avery Morrow on 2013-05-21 at 11:06 said:

Is Swedenborg part of Martinism? He's certainly an integral part of the most ridiculous kinds of New Age spiritualism where all metaphysics goes out the window.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-21 at 13:58 said:

I have issues with this – if Saint-Martin was so Catholic why did he refuse the sacrament of extreme unction at his death ?

According to Abbe Barruel, *Memoirs sur l'histoire du Jacobinisme*, Tome 2, Martinism is egalitarian and a predecessor to the French Revolution.

Also, according to Barruel and Leon de Poncins, Martinez was a Jew. Could his "tradition" be seen as the introduction of false Judaic-derived cabalistic (countertradition) poison into Catholic France ?

Joseph de Maistre, speaking as the character of Le Comte in Dialogue 11 of *Les soirees du Saint-Petersbourg* refutes martismism (considered as part of the illuminist movement) and defends the Church.

Cologero on 2013-05-21 at 23:23 said:

Perhaps, Jason-Adam, Joseph de Maistre is an ambiguous source since he was an initiate into Martinism and knew Saint-Martin personally. Charles M Lombard's intellectual biography of de Maistre, although it border on hagiography, documents the subtle ideas of Martinism in de Maistre's works. It may be a good project someday to verify his references. I would see de Maistre's cautions about "illuminism" to be like Tomberg's, viz., it needs to be brought back into the fold, so to speak.

The point, however, is that Saint-Martin fulfills pretty well Evola's requirements for a Christian initiation. That will require a decision: to follow or to reject that path. Saint-Martin probably rejected last rites because he felt he achieved the "true immortality" that Evola described.

As for de Maistre's defence of the Church, who today is willing to defend him? Apart from Cioran and Gornahoor, that is. Stendahl complained that the Jesuits who trained the French priests were imbued with de Maistre, and therefore called him the "French St Paul". That would be inconceivable in our time.

Constantine on 2013-05-22 at 09:18 said:

I wonder would Evola or Guenon approve Mormonism?

Cologero on 2013-05-22 at 12:30 said:

Guenon wrote a rather longish essay contra Mormonism, included in "Miscellanea". What in it warrants approval?

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-22 at 13:17 said:

Plinio Correa de Oliveira wrote, the counterrevolution is taking place against the subversive elements within the Church. It is a hard fight we may not win but we fight for truth and honour, not for vain material victories. That is what it means to a knight. "Saint-Martin fulfills pretty well Evola's requirements for a Christian initiation" – but Evola believed in hierarchy, are you saying that the Abbe Barruel was wrong to classify Saint-Martin as an egalitarian and a predecessor of the French Revolution ?

Mercurius on 2013-05-22 at 14:19 said:

It is difficult to understand what Mr. Adams means by "false Judaic-derived Cabalistic derived counter tradition poison"–does this imply that Cabala is "counter-traditional" (not just anti-traditional either, but counter-traditional) as an esoteric doctrine, or is it counter-traditional because it is "Judaic derived"? In either case, Cabala certainly entered Christianity long before Martinez–examples can be found in primitive Christianity, and St. Jerome himself, who gives the Vulgate was considerably influenced by Cabala as seen in his letter to Marcella discussing the Divine Names (which are the names ascribed to the Sephiroth).

The question of whether Martinism "is" or "isn't" egalitarian is a bad question. If something represents an initiatic doctrine (and method), then by its nature, spiritual realization/the spiritual order is its sole concern–if, as Guenon pointed out, an organization having initiatic leanings at some point elevates social and political concerns to a rank of primary importance, it is no longer initiatic *de jure*, but a "secret society". So, to know what Martinism is one ought look first to its major "landmarks"–which can be said to be Martinez' "Treatise on the Reintegration of Beings", the "degrees" which became grafted onto an Masonic structure (so, the "form" they took for expression), and then, the writings of St. Martin, either as addendum, continuation, completion, or expression not of theurgical operations, but the "path of the heart" (it is interesting that a sort of similar thing can be observed in neo-Platonism, with say Proclus' school stressing contemplation, and representatives like Iamblichus arguing for theurgy; or the shift from Vedic ritualism toward Vedanta and the beginnings of yoga–but I digress). At any rate, there isn't anything in those landmarks pertaining to a social/political "egalitarianism"–consequently, the question doesn't have much meaning when thinking about Martinism as initiatic doctrine and method.

Now, on the other hand, if in time, certain lodges and individuals within Martinism have been, or promoted egalitarianism, then that was/is their proclivity, secondary or tertiary ideas caused to become associated with their initiatic work, basically innovations. Interestingly, in his book "Beyond Enlightenment", Harvey shows many arguments supporting the thesis that Martinism was anti-semitic, racist, and proto-fascistic! But again, if some lodges could be found as such–neither egalitarianism nor "proto-fascism" constitute the landmarks represented by

Martinez "Treatise" simply because it never was set forth as a social-political doctrine. "Bringing it back into the fold" as Cologero notes above.

Some of the criticisms above seem to be hinged around an "us versus them" criteria—or the (Roman) Church versus Martinism—but this too is a non-issue, as such a conflict doesn't exist. Martinism is not a religion, and never had desired to replace the Church—Martinez and St. Martin were Catholics, and did not repudiate exoteric religion; rather, they attempted to "complete" it with a doctrine/method suitable for the qualified (for the non-qualified, the Church always still remains).

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-22 at 18:14 said:

1. The Cabala is not Christian so therefore any system based on it is not a Christian initiation, am I wrong or right ?

2. Many writers have shown the anti-Western nature of Judaism, even Evola, a better writer in this regard is Leon de Poncins.

3. There are many supposed initiatic organisations that are egalitarian, Franc-Masonry to name one.....one area Evola was superior to Guenon was in his recognising Masonry as a false, evil group.....

4. I am relying on the Abbe Barruel, *Memoirs sur l'histoire du Jacobinisme*, Tome 2, for my information on the egalitarian and revolutionary nature of Martinism. If anyone would care to read my source and offer information that refutes it, I am willing to change my opinion.

Ash on 2013-05-22 at 19:27 said:

The writings from the eastern Church are rather apt, as Martin's doctrines appear to correlate very closely with the Orthodox doctrine of theosis. However, as I understand it, the Eastern Church goes beyond restoring man to the primordial state and intends to set man back on the path which they were on in Eden, suggesting that Adam in Eden has himself not yet attained his fullness; perhaps Adam is not yet Adam Kadmon? C. S. Lewis did a marvelous job exploring this idea in "Perelandra". Perhaps someone more informed on Martinist doctrine could elaborate on how that could affect Martinism as a traditional path.

Francis Mercuri on 2013-05-22 at 19:43 said:

Mr. Adam:

1. I suppose this entirely depends on how you define Christianity—my perspective understands it as being a union of the Hebraic and Hellenistic traditions. Yet, even if one were to disregard the Hellenistic elements, being Hebraic (at least in terms of having an OT relationship or foundation), one could certainly see how Hebrew esotericism would, or could be, part of Christian theosophy—I don't think that is stretching the logic too far. On the other hand, I'm not so certain we share the same idea concerning what Cabala happens to be.

Still, looking to our Traditional authors, in Schuon we find him several times insisting that there can never be a complete understanding of scriptures of any type in translation ("Gnosis is not Just Anything", "Some Difficulties Found in Sacred Scripture")—one must, he argues, always return to the sacred tongue—in terms of the Torah, naturally Hebrew. Then, in the essay "Keys to the Bible", he goes even further, saying:

"In order to understand the nature of the Bible and its meaning, it is essential to have recourse to the ideas of both symbolism and revelation....for the literal meaning of the Bible....affords sufficient food for piety apart from any question of symbolism, but this nourishment would lose all vitality and all its liberating power without an adequate idea of revelation or of superhuman origin....When approaching scripture, one should always pay the greatest attention to rabbinical and cabalistic commentaries—and in Christianity—to the patristic and mystical commentaries"

2. Evola wrote many things about "Judaism", often times in apparent contradiction—in *Men Among the Ruins*, he seems to say that he uses the word "Jew" and "Jewish" to denote an economic Judaism (and he draws much from Werner Sombart on all this), or "spirit"—akin to what he writes about the "races"—so, it pertains in certain contexts more to a "type", because in other places, such as "Revolt", he has positive things to say about Cabala, and quotes from the Zohar, with the particular quote representing he states, the very meaning of the traditional world. It isn't so easy to be cut and dry with such things.

I tend to agree with the Gornahoor position on the issue, as expressed in the post on "The Nine Worthies":

"The characters are also archetypal and the symmetry of the scheme reflects the Medieval view of history and destiny of European man. The Old Law prepared the way for the New. The Pagan law created the Pax Romana that allowed the spread of the New Law. And of course, medievals saw themselves as the true heirs of both the Hebrews and the Pagans, and their civilization as the fulfillment of God's divine plan".

<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=331>

3. If you considered what I previously wrote, i.e., there is a difference between an Initiatic Order, and a "secret society", you would see that the comment is null, because if Francmasonry can be regarded as "egalitarian", one is speaking not of an Initiatic doctrine and method or a metaphysics, but of a political-social construct, which is secondary. When it comes to Masonry, that is where I think Evola was often at his worst—for he could not see it beyond what had emerged as political Masonry, he could not, as the "conspiracy theorists" of today continue, disentangle an acquired Jacobinism from an Initiatic process and symbolism in Masonry—something Evola hardly touched upon, but is all through Guenon, and heavily in "Great Triad", "Esotericism of Dante", and of course his writings assembled into "Studies on Masonry and Compagnonnage".

4. One could say similar things about the Daoist "Triads"—with no, or minimal "Jewish" influences involved, Triads have historically gotten involved in "revolutionary" activities—often to the point of eliciting governmental crackdowns; yet, again, one can't simply take the political

activities of an isolated Triad as descriptive of Daoism—that is just kind of common sense. We are likely getting far afield though—so, since the essay “Hidden Tradition” pertains foremost to the doctrines of Martinism, I’d suggest our discussion center more on the Martinist treatises and symbolism—allowing them to do the speaking about themselves.

Cologero on 2013-05-22 at 22:54 said:

In the Spiritist Fallacy, Guenon points out that there are many nuggets in Swedenborg if one knows how to find them. However, he is to be interpreted symbolically, not in a new age fashion. Nevertheless, Guenon concludes that what is good in Swedenborg can be found elsewhere in a purer form.

Mihai on 2013-05-23 at 03:29 said:

“my perspective understands it as being a union of the Hebraic and Hellenistic traditions.”

To regard Christianity as nothing but this union of these two traditions is to view it the same way as the profane historians do.

Certainly, Christianity assimilated and made much use of Hellenistic thought, but the latter is the support, while the former the essence. There are essential points in which Christian doctrine clearly surpasses or fulfills the thought of a Plato, Aristotel or the neo-platonists. The failure to realize this is what caused the scholastic collapse. The same goes, I believe, more clearly in relation to Judaism.

“When it comes to Masonry, that is where I think Evola was often at his worst”

Evola considered the implications of political and subversive masonry, which, I believe, is all that truly remains of Masonry in the modern world. If there are any traditional organizations left in that field, they are probably so well hidden and reclusive that they are close irrelevant for all purposes regarding initiation and spirituality for those seeking them.

I have always stated that Guenon’s defense of Masonry, beyond showing what used to be traditional in the organization, marks the lowest point of his writings. For much of the time while he was in Europe he struggled to make Masonry act as an esoteric organization in order to fulfill what he thought was the entirely “esoteric-less” Christianity. Not only was such a point fruitless, but it may really fuel some of the subversive forces he so much tried to counteract.

He had really made better use of his time to find in the Patristic mystical writings the starting point for the reconstruction of a higher perspective for the West, instead of wasting time trying to revive a long dead and buried organization.

V.O. on 2013-05-23 at 10:46 said:

Christ annihilated the boundary between the esoteric and the exoteric. The only “initiation” now occurs exoterically in the Orthodox Church. Mysticism as the “estoeric” is practiced by forms

of the anchorite, perhaps away from the world, but still within the Orthodox Church. (Although the Orthodox Christian is always away from the world)

The ascetic alone with the wolves in the mountains is exoteric because the Church is universal and the Cross transforms the world. Mysticism as term is a terminological advancement away from the exoteric-esoteric split. The initiate as the preserver of the esoteric and exoteric split is Antichrist, because their absolute gap is not between God and the world, but within the world itself. They are only concerned with the world. The "secret" organizations are thus always practicing a form of counter-initiation and inevitably degrade into complete Satanism.

francismmercuri on 2013-05-23 at 12:06 said:

It was never suggested that Christianity was "just"-or "merely", anything-as if an external assembly of lifeless fragments from "cultures". One would assume that as understood though in such a forum as this, hopefully without needing to emphasize the obvious repeatedly. I'll try to be more lucid hereafter.

So called political and "subversive" Masonry are certainly not (and this can be looked at entirely objectively) "all that remains". What is there in regular Masonry are all the same landmarks, rites, symbols, and lectures that have been there since the operative went speculative-the very same things that Guenon would have worked with (granted, there are some variations between Grand Lodges in wording, and "floor work" due to pedestrian and insignificant details)-there is no need for anything to be "hidden and reclusive". Everything is entirely present if one desires a "virtual" initiation, and wants to receive such in the context of an "order". All this back and forth stuff about masonry is silly-if what is contained in Masonry in terms of the rites and symbols is "political and subversive", then the bulk of "esotericists" ought throw in the towel, because these are the same symbols and doctrines that are present in other forms of Western esotericism-say Hermeticism/alchemy for example.

Aside from all that, all this talk of political masonry is in day-to-day reality something of a tremendous exaggeration-if not completely false! "Political" lodges are likely the exception, if you can even find one-such topics are not even permitted in lodges, they just are not discussed. What lodges do is this: they occupy themselves with performing degree work (initiations)-this takes up 75% of members time, between practice, memorization, and performance-after which, it is up to the initiate to either penetrate the deeper meanings of the rites-or, do nothing at all-only "research lodges" with a "philosophical" bent talk about this stuff. The remaining time, members sometimes spend socially,relaxing, outings, and/or doing some charity work-hospitals, disaster relief-whatever. That is the true life a regular lodge-all these other things people talk about are fantasy.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-23 at 21:34 said:

I fully agree with you !!!!!

Eliphas Levi had said something similar in his History of Magic and so did Fritjof Schuon. not for nuttin but the first 2 sacraments are known as the sacraments of INITIATION.....

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-23 at 21:42 said:

Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin was a supporter of the French Revolution, I can provide sources for this if needed. How can you be a reactionay and support this doctrine then ?

Guenon ABANDONED Martinism when he realised its counterfit nature.

Mr Mercuri, how do you know that stories of political Masonry are exaggerated ? are you a Mason ? if you're not, you can't know for sure because Masons are sworn not to reveal what happens in the lodge to non-Masons. If you are a Mason then you may be trying to cover up your activities.....

I choose to trust the irrefutable testimony of many researchers who know the evils of Satanic Masonry.....

My interest in esotericism these days tends toward the Hieron du Val d'Or.....Cologero have you ever read about that group ? Guenon was associated with them for a time.

Cologero on 2013-05-24 at 01:09 said:

Jason-Adam, I've never located any primary literature from the Hieron; Guenon's involvement stems from his association with Regnabit and the correspondence between Guenon and Louis Charbonneau-Lassay. I don't know if that has been published but let me know if you can find it.

I've never found any writings from the founders of the Hieron, so I can't say if the description on Cesnur is accurate. Nevertheless, some of the themes have been taken up here. E.g., the common tradition, which has been mentioned several times. Another is the Christianization of Masonry; this, we believe, was ultimately the task of Valentin Tomberg. Apparently, that group was instrumental in promoting the feast day of Christ the King. I will write on that soon provided I can make it of general interest. I think it promotes a better societal vision than what any of the new pseudo-right groups have been able to do. The recent meaningless gesture at Notre Dame has made this suddenly a relevant topic.

Mihai on 2013-05-24 at 03:35 said:

Granted, when it comes to certain so-called conspiracy theories (although I really detest the term, since it is used by those who deny any hidden activities that influence historical events) there are many exaggerations.

But there is an old saying, which I strictly keep in mind when it comes to things such as these: where there's smoke, there's fire. It is a fact that Masonry has participated in almost every revolutionary movement of the last few centuries- including the American revolution, the French revolution, the 1848 movements and even the Soviet Revolution. If these days Masonry

has ceased to be so political is because there is no further need for it as a platform to spread certain subversive goals, since there are other, more adequate ones.

Anyhow, the fact that it was possible, back then, to use Masonry for subversive purposes, denotes that it had already degenerated beyond any relevance.

"Everything is entirely present if one desires a "virtual" initiation, and wants to receive such in the context of an "order". "

My question is: even if such were true, and there is still some spiritual influence acting in those lodges to pass a valid initiation , I don't see what good it could do if its members do not distinguish themselves, in their mentality, from the least of the profanes and can provide no significant guidance or knowledge to anyone.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-24 at 17:37 said:

I've had the same problem in detecting primary sources as well, Charbonneau-Lassay interests me greatly though, his train of thought today seems to be represented by Jean Borella whom I can recommend strongly.

As for the monsieur who was a suicide, I believe that is a representation of utter nihilism. For myself as a knight, I do not care what the world around me is like – it is sinful always. I follow God and do not depend on others for my inner serenity.

I did some more research and Eliphas Levi did admire Saint-Martin and said there was a revolt of the subversive illuminists (Weishaput and co.) against the legitimate authority, Barriel perhaps was too exoterically minded by lumping all the esotericisms into the category of egalitarian and atheist. I don't know enough yet. I still distrust Martinism due to de Maistre and Guenon's rejection of it but I keep my mind open to the future work Gornahoor will undertake on it.

2.5 The Spirit of Joseph de Maistre

Joseph de Maistre was an Hermetist (in the school of **Martines de Pasqually** and **Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin**), Traditionalist, Reactionary, European, and a source of the Russian Idea. In his Self-Defense, Julius Evola includes Maistre among those well-bred men holding sane and normal views common prior to the French Revolution. In this brief review of the Maistre's St Petersburg Dialogues Evola again reveals his high regard for de Maistre, despite their fundamental disagreement on religion and providence.

In *Materialism and the Task of Anthroposophy*, Rudolf Steiner says this about Joseph de Maistre:

With de Maistre, a personality of the greatest imaginable genius, of compelling spirituality but Roman Catholic through and through, appears on the scene.

High praise indeed, especially from a man who was in fundamental disagreement with de Maistre.

Digression To complete the circle, we have mentioned that Evola included Steiner's picture not once, but twice, as demonstrating "spiritual penetration", despite being in fundamental disagreement with Steiner's doctrines of Karma and Reincarnation. So here we have the example of three esoterists demonstrating respect despite their disagreements on specific issues. This is how men of high intellectual attainment behave, since they understand what "thinking" is. Lesser men treat thought as a weapon, and means of combat. They confuse the use of words and ideas, with the words and ideas themselves. Let this serve as a model.

Returning to the topic Steiner has some interesting things to say about de Masitre who represents the reactionary trend to Steiner's progressivist view of mankind. This is how he characterizes de Maistre's basic worldview:

All of humanity falls into two categories, one representing the kingdom of God, the other representing the kingdom of this world.

As we recently pointed out, this is also the view of **Vladimir Soloviev** (not to mention **St. Augustine**), and the reason for this seeming coincidence will become clear. But the point is that there is an essential difference in the quality of being between the two groups of humanity: one

spiritually aware, the other not. This is more than a superficial adherence to one system of belief over another, but represents a real change in the level of being.

Steiner writes:

there are those in Europe who cling to this view that since the beginning of the fifteenth century divine world rule has assumed a quite different position in regard to earth humanity.

Of course, this is not just representative of the Catholicism of de Maistre, but it also reflects the point of view of both Julius Evola and Rene Guenon, who saw the Reformation as the beginning of the end of the last vestiges of Traditional civilization in the West.

Steiner astutely points this out:

De Maistre had the grandiose idea to tie in with Russianism, particularly with the element that had found its way since ancient times from Asia into the Orthodox Catholic, Russian religion. From there, he wished to create a connection to Romanism. He tried to bring about the great fusion between the element living in the Oriental manner of thinking in Russian culture, and the element coming from Rome. already imbued with this view.

Here we see this revealed in the writings Soloviev who in his own way tries to tie the “Oriental manner of thinking” into contemporary Western ideas.

Steiner continues:

de Maistre refers back to what Christianity was in regard to its metaphysical view prior to the scholastic age, what it was in the first centuries and what was acceptable to Rome. De Maistre aimed for Roman, for Catholic, Christianity as a real power.

Again, as Evola also points out, the Catholic counter-reformation was not enough, it only went back half-way. It needed to return to the primordial sources of its spiritual power. Instead of being the opposite of a Reformation, it merely contented itself with being a reformation in the opposite direction. The spiritually weak state of Christianity today is the result.

Steiner's short essay puts the issue in perfect clarity.

- Is the human race on the way to some progressive, evolutionary, utopian future?
- Or is there a fundamental and irreconcilable divide between those on the side of Tradition and those on the side of Revolution?

If the latter⁷, then the task is to begin the reconstruction of Tradition from the insights given by de Maistre, Soloviev, Guenon, and Evola.

Posted on 2010-05-23 by Cologero

2.6 Before you think and choose

Avant que tu penses et que tu choisisses, la société s'empare de ton entité et la façonne, selon son droit. Des que tu penses et choisis, efface les plis reçus, c'est-à-dire libère-toi des habitudes contemporaines, selon ton devoir.

Pour choisir, sache que tu as trois destins : tu peux être un animal comme ce décadent que les superficiels nomment sauvage; un animique comme tout le monde, un spirituel comme saint Thomas, ou Dante. Animal, sois beau; animique, sois bon; spirituel, cherche le Graal.

⁷The idea the evolution and progress of the human race is one of the features that distinguish "New Age" teachings from Tradition.

Pour embellir, anime tes instincts ; pour t'adoucir, spiritualise tes sentiments ; pour tendre à l'absolu, développe en toi l'abstraction.

JOSÉPHIN PÉLADAN, *Comment on devient Mage*, II, La Société)

Joséphin Péladan was a key figure in the 19th century French occult revival. Along with Papus and De Guaita, he recreated the Rosicrucian order. Material that used to be secret — for reasons that will be obvious — were openly revealed. For the initiate, it doesn't much matter, because the uninitiated will not understand it. However, the misunderstanding can have consequences, especially in an open society that knows nothing of self-regulation.

For the initiate, the relationship with society can be problematic. Society operates under its own laws and facts, which supercede the individual and require him to be unconscious. The initiate, on the other hand, strives to become more conscious, transcending both the human state and society. In *How to become a Mage*, Peladan writes:

Baptism [as an initiation rite] makes us children of God, but Society dooms us to evil through its laws and education. Faith enlightens us, but it is in perpetual conflict with Society. The initiate, in order to make the grace of baptism full and effective, must renounce anew Society, its boundaries, its crimes, so that the fear of God makes him prefer the intimate greatness to the degrading favours of the country.

The following passage is taken from the chapter on Society. Note how it coincides with the Three Stages of Man⁸.

Before you think and choose, society takes over your being and moulds it, as is its right. Once you think and choose, remove those received imprints, that is to say, liberate yourself from contemporary habits, as is your right.

⁸<https://gornahoor.net/?p=214>

The uninitiated man takes as the norm the world as it appears to him; this is not the real world, but is a second reality, or a shadow world hiding its true source. Such a man lives in that second reality. The initiate begins to wake up and must see through that second reality in order to become fully conscious. Of course, in our day and age, everyone thinks he is a rebel and boasts about flaunting societal mores. Unable to conceive of any higher goal, this faux rebel can only act out against the taboos against sex, drugs, and other anti-social behaviour. This is just another trap, another way of being moulded. What better way to keep someone from liberating himself than to convince him he is already a “free spirit”?

In order to choose, know that you have three destinies. You can be:

1. an animal like the decadent that the superficial call savage;
2. a soulish man, like everyone else;
3. a spiritual person like St Thomas or Dante.

Your tasks:

- **Animal:** be beautiful;
- **Soulish man:** be good;
- **Spiritual person:** seek the Grail.

The three choices:

- I. One can act on instinct alone, like an animal. This is how many people would interpret “liberation”. Such a man should at least be a beautiful animal.

2. The soulish man experiences no distance between his thoughts and feelings and his self. Whatever he thinks and feels *is* his “self” at that moment. His option is to be “good”, as his perspective is moralism.
3. The destiny of the spiritual man, who transcends his thoughts and feelings, is to seek the Holy Grail.

In order to improve, soulify your instincts; in order to make yourself meek, spiritualise your feelings; in order to reach the absolute, develop within yourself a separation.

This summarizes his advice:

- Instincts need to be made self-conscious.
- Meek must be understood in the sense of the beatitudes: Blessed are the Meek⁹.
- Learn to transcend the Mind. Develop a sense of detachment — the Observer, the Unmoved Mover, the Self.

Posted on 2010-09-03 by Cologero

2.7 The Road from Dante to Guenon

Vintila Horia was a Romanian Traditional author. In a collection dedicated to the thought of Rene Guenon, titled *Rene Guenon Colloque du Centenaire*, he contributed an essay *Mon Chemin de Dante à Guenon*, or, *My Path from Dante to Guenon*. (The complete text is available in *Nouvelle Ecole*, #47.)

⁹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=359>

The Project Rene Guenon¹⁰ published some excerpts from it here¹¹. In the section below titled “Reading Notes”, there is my translation of the notes from French to English.

Even this little taste is quite suggestive. Usually applied to Sacred Texts, Horia points out that the Divine Comedy by Dante can also be understood on four levels. It is no surprise that he names **Rene Guenon** as providing key to the highest level of interpretation.

An interesting wrinkle is that Horia names **Soren Kierkegaard** as providing key to understand the Comedy at the moral level. That is certainly worth exploring. Kierkegaard describes the phenomenological states of consciousness for many types of men. Perhaps then, we should understand Dante’s descriptions of the punishments of hell for the various class of sinners as pictorial representations of their inner soul life.

Horia then points out the roles of the Cross and the Eagle, i.e., Church and Empire (or Spiritual Authority and Temporal Power, in Guenon’s terms). A one-sided effort is certain to fail.

Horia ends on a note reminiscent of Boris Mouravieff: a small group of the just will witness the coming Age of the Holy Spirit.

Reading Notes There are several keys to Dante. Rene Guenon provides us one: that of esoterism, which would make the “Divine Comedy” the poem *par excellence* from the standpoint of traditional studies. (p 93)

Among the studies devoted to Dante, the closest to the poet’s spirit are:

1. that of **Rene Guenon**
2. that of the Italian scholar **Luigi Valli**

¹⁰<https://elkorg-projects.blogspot.it/>

¹¹<https://elkorg-projects.blogspot.it/2005/10/vintil-horea-mon-c-hemin-de-dante-gunon.html>

3. that of the Spaniard **Asin Palacios**, entitled “Dante and Islam.”

“With the fourteenth century, and especially with Petrarch, the path takes a turning point, it tries to rise, with the return of Platonism to power, along the first part of the Renaissance at least, but it sinks, after Marsilio Ficino, into a hopeless landscape, or terminal end, of which the eighteenth century constitutes a type of spiritualist error, so to speak, by following the teaching that Guenon suggests to us as an example of what we should not do especially at times when poetry, like politics together, as in Dante’s time a tragic inseparability. Hölderlin, already at the beginning of the last century, placed in relation the “times of distress” and the “presence of the poet.” (p 94)

Our time is perhaps one of the closest to Dantean exegesis.

“Dante was above all a poet faithful to poesis and then to creation, and, in the most logical way, he found himself tempted by all the paths to the very source of creation, which is Truth. To reach it, he let himself be guided by the two poles of our poetic soul: inspiration, which proceeds in a straight line from the unconscious world, and reason, linked to the consciousness above any partial separation, classical in one sense, romantic in another, and which removed from his work that tone of impartiality — I would not say objectivity, because this word has no meaning in this context — that characterizes it despite permanent injunctions of his ego and of the historical sufferings that inspire it and, often, determine it in his creative action. Dante is a world, in the fullest sense, and it even lets us embrace it, even if we are situated almost seven centuries after his adventure.” (p 94)

There is a literary key of “The Divine Comedy” and of Dante in general. Next, there is an allegorical key, which is a first way to add a veil above the literal sense. Then a moral key, proposed by Kierkegaard. The last one, the anagogical key, was given by Guenon and Luigi Valli.

“What Guenon did for me and, I imagine, for most of those who found in him the same remedy, was to draw me away from minor or partial truths, to put me in contact, at least wavering, with Truth, which is one and that, by following ever more complicated and hidden paths, drew me to Plato and made me understand the most prominent and the most spectacular aspects of current physics, for example, through Heisenberg, to name a stage, as efforts as part of a broader effort whose aim was that to help me advance towards something after going through hell — the last two centuries of history Western form, in this perspective, the nine circles of hell and it is possible that we are going through the last, that of eternal ice and traitors, those who betrayed man — to lead us to an indispensable Purgatory to make the last jump, one that implies an end and a beginning, and that is surely one of the end and a new beginning, ‘Pure and disposed to mount unto the stars’, which is the last verse of Dante’s Purgatory.” (p 97)

The metapolitical goal of “The Divine Comedy” is to present to a sick mankind the double remedy of the **Cross** (the Catholic Church) and the **Eagle** (the Empire). The Cross has the role to cure ignorance and the Eagle, distress. Lust was to be annihilated by the victory of the Cross, and injustice by the victory of the Eagle.

“So don’t we owe our terrible entrance into the deterministic and entropic night to the separation between the Cross and the Eagle? The Cross alone would now solve the problems that it could solve neither at the end of the Middle Ages, when it was strong and universal, nor in the age of the Revolution, when it was abandoned by poets causing the flight of the gods which Hölderlin speaks about. The Eagle soared, too, on other worlds, very far away from us, imitated by fake eagles, imperial in space but not in time, which belongs to the reign of the Cross. We live under the oppression of invalid empires, not only because sick of tyranny

and inhumane separations, fated to protect the ultimate fall and decay, but also because they do not want the Cross, their most mysterious and fiercest enemy, alone but surviving. I think that Dante and Guenon complement each other on the threshold of the catastrophic loss of the relationship with being and of finding again complementary phases in the path of salvation that explain the history of this time with a clarity that other specialized disciplines are not able to explain because they are unable to understand. Beyond the end of time, that time already many centuries old, we may find ourselves in the fullness of Being, according to the voice full of the bitterness and hope of the best prophets. Everything will only be the pile of the useless, arrogant and vain. Only a voice of the righteous, that is to say, those that have been formed in a different light, will accompany us in the great alchemical change in the third millennium." (p 100-101)

Posted on 2016-01-07 by Cologero

* * *

Karl on 2016-01-23 at 14:54 said:

Seems you can buy here this journal which has the article by Horia in full: <http://www.revue-elements.com/nouvelle-ecole-Tradition.html>

???? ????? on 2017-10-07 at 06:12 said:

Mercy, peace, and love be multiplied to those who follow the Right Guidance! For those who master the Italian language and are eager to learn more about Dante's Path and The Sacred Tradition, I strongly recommend the Edizioni Orientamento, Publishing House directed by Lodovico Zamboni; and Le Edizioni all'insegna del Veltro, managed and directed by Professor Claudio Mutti. A special thank to the admin of this site for the dissemination of Knowledge and for raising the Word of Truth according to the correct methodology and with adequate spirit. Stay blessed. A.

2.8 Tradition on Italian Soil

From Pythagoras to Virgil to Dante, the chain of Tradition was never lost on Italian Soil.

RENE GUENON

In old Europe human life received its ideal content from the Catholic faith, on the one hand, and from knightly feudalism on the other

VLADIMIR SOLOVYOV.

Pythagoras Pythagoras established his first community in Crotone, bringing esoteric teachings onto the Italian peninsula. From Pythagoras, there is a chain leading back to Orpheus and ultimately to Hermes Trismegistus. The relationship of this Tradition to others is described in the *Our Father Course*¹².

Virgil Virgil continues this line, as revealed in his poem *Aeneid* and prophesied in the *Eclogues*¹³. The Western initiatic tradition was the story of the encounter with Divine Wisdom of Sophia. Aeneas, the progenitor of the founders of Rome, was a type of this tradition. Numa Pompilius, the second king of Rome often consulted the nymph Egeria who taught him wisdom.

Anticipating Dante's Journey, Aeneas descends into hell, led by the Cumaean Sibyl¹⁴. Following that, he is led to the Elysian Fields. There the righteous and the heroic lived lives of natural happiness, which was an extension to the pleasures they had enjoyed in life. This is equivalent

¹²You can find such course in its own book of this Series.

¹³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=5481>

¹⁴https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cumaean_Sibyl

to the Limbo of the Fathers. This is reserved to the righteous and heroic reflective of the two radically different conceptions of happiness¹⁵.

As pleasant as that may be, it ultimately falls short of deliverance, or better said, the Beatific Vision. It is imperative to remember that this is not some mystical experience, but rather a form of gnosis, that is the unmediated knowledge of God.

Hence, esoterism had to move on from paganism to Christianity. Although necessary from the perspective of initiation, the transition was not without its difficulties exoterically¹⁶. The transition disrupted social institutions and was marred by frequent and bloody wars.

Dante Dante acknowledges his connection to Virgil, who effectively replaces the Cumaean Sibyl while leading him through hell, and even into Purgatory. Virgil is gone before Dante could reach the Earthly Paradise, or the Primordial State. This is a state of supernatural happiness. In that state, God is known indirectly through creation or philosophical reasoning.

Nevertheless, it is still not yet the Beatific Vision. For that, Beatrice has to take over to begin that ascent. It is important not to confound two entirely different notions:

- **Metaphysical Intuition.** This is the immediate realization of the truth of metaphysical teachings. It is beyond any particular state of being, and beyond any particular experience. It is beyond nature.
- **Mystical Experience.** This is an experience of a state of being higher than the human state. Although such experiences may be rapturous, ecstatic, extraordinary, insightful, and peaceful, they still belong to the phenomenal realm. This is what distinguishes such an experience from metaphysical intuition.

¹⁵<https://gornahoor.net/?p=13>

¹⁶<https://gornahoor.net/?p=11451>

For example, Joan of Arc had mystical experiences. Dante, on the other hand, is not describing a mystical experience of a vision of planets, saints, angels, and so on. Rather, he is describing inner states of being and how to progress from one to the next.

Templars According to Rene Guenon, Hermetism was certainly known among the Templars, or the Order of the Temple, and included doctrines of Arabic origin. Dante himself knew of these. In particular, he knew of similar journeys through hell into Heaven, e.g., the nocturnal journey of Muhammed. Guenon makes this observation:

There was a time when there were not only hostile relations, as believed by those who stick to appearances, but also active intellectual exchanges between the East and the West, exchanges which took place mainly by means of Orders e.g., the Templars.

As we saw with the transition from pagan esoterism to Christian esoterism, this intellectual exchange came at a time of outer turmoil. Valentin Tomberg says that Saint Bernard's exhortation to the Templars needs to be understood like Krishna's exhortation to Arjuna. Arjuna reluctantly had to battle his cousins, but there was a higher purpose behind the appearances. In his words,

Nowadays many criticise the saint for his intervention sanctioning and encouraging the Crusade, but what he did was simply to make an appeal to "Christian Arjuna" on the new field of Kurukshetra, where the two armies of Islam and Christianity had already been assembled for a battle without mercy some centuries before him.

The Destruction of the Templars The politically motivated destruction of the Templars led to the diminution of esoteric knowledge in the

West. Those who maintained such knowledge were forced to do so clandestinely. Thus the alchemists had to disguise their true purpose. The Rosicrucians, who also continued the tradition, had to hide behind the story that they had all scattered to the East. That describes their state of consciousness, not their physical locale.

Guenon claimed to trace some evidence of esoteric teaching in Protestantism, although even Jacob Boehme ran afoul of the authorities. From there, the trail went dark, apart from occasional clues. Nevertheless, the Tradition can never disappear; there will always be a remnant.

Recent Developments Since Guenon's death, there have been other developments, of which he was unaware, that alter the picture. First of all, there is the remarkable case of Vladimir Solovyov¹⁷ who had his own realizations of Divine Sophia.

Vladimir Solovyov, in his trips to Egypt, came to the realization that Hermetism supported the theology of the early church fathers. Besides Hermetism, Solovyov claimed to be following in the tradition of Neoplatonism, Cabala, Swedenborg, and Boehme. However, he never did acknowledge any particular training.

Guenon claimed that the full recovery of esoterism in the West will depend on the reunification of the esoteric Templar teachings with exoteric teachings. Movements have been made in that direction. Boris Mouravieff has revealed the Hermetic roots of the esoteric teachings of Eastern Orthodoxy. For the Roman Church, that task was started more explicitly by Valentin Tomberg. He showed the way to reconcile the Church of Peter with the Church of John¹⁸.

However, esoteric teaching can no longer be restricted to secret groups guarded by initiations. Initiatic groups replace "organic growth" with

¹⁷<https://gornahoor.net/?p=9927>

¹⁸<https://gornahoor.net/?p=16881>

“making”; they depend on human effort rather than grace. Tomberg expands on this notion:

the only truly morally founded reason for keeping esotericism “esoteric”, i.e. for not bringing it to the broad light of day and popularising it, is the danger of the great misunderstanding of confusing the tower of Babel with the tree of Life, as a consequence of which “masons” will be recruited instead of “gardeners”.

The Church was always conscious of this danger. This is why it always insisted — whilst appreciating and encouraging effort as such — on the principle of grace as the sole source for advancing on the way of perfection. This is also why it was always suspicious of so-called “initiation fraternities” or such groups who formed themselves at its periphery or beyond it. For, leaving rivalry and other human imperfections out of account, the serious reason for the Church to take a negative attitude towards initiation fraternities is the danger of the substitution of building for growth, of “doing” for grace, and of ways of specialisation for the way of salvation.

Appendix on Rites Guenon has claimed that the Latin rites are no longer effective. That is an absurdity, as long as the apostolic succession remains intact. The efficacy of the rites does not depend at all on the character of knowledge of the priest, just his intention.

In a letter to L. C. d’Amiens from May 1935, he hedges a bit asserting that “the effects of Catholic rites are far from negligible”. Guenon responds to L C, apparently answering a question:

The Masons help themselves to the influence of the Catholic rites, as you say, I certainly do not see the slightest problem.

That would make no sense if the Catholic rites are not effective. Hence, they can be followed if no alternative is available. Obviously, being a Muslim in Europe today is much easier than it was in 1935. In my hometown,

for example, there are two mosques within a short bike ride. But, unlike Buddhists or Yogis, they don't offer Sufi initiations to the general public.

Guenon never tires of emphasizing the necessity for observing the rites:

For a "realization" of an esoteric order, we must not forget that the observance of the rites constitutes the necessary basis here; and it is also obvious that whoever wants the "more" must first, and as a precondition, do the "less" (i.e., observe the rites that are common to all).

In other words, realization requires following an exoteric tradition, even more assiduously than the commoners. Hence, there can be no "book learning only" esoterists. One must pray, meditate, participate in the rites or sacraments. Valentin Tomberg makes the same claim.

Posted on 2020-12-28 by Cologero

* * *

Michael M on 2020-12-28 at 12:49 said:

Thank you for the article, summarizes many important points of this project in a clear way.

I wanted to ask a question based on these two statements: "It is beyond any particular state of being" & "he is describing inner states of being and how to progress from one to the next."

Is this to say that Dante is describing the inner states of being themselves and how to progress, but not the specific metaphysical intuition, i.e. because this is beyond any communication or realm of experience, to put it in any terms of experience would make it dualistic and not beyond that? To borrow: "not made out of any kind of substance which needs maintenance from the point of view of the perceiver, but they just happen, as expression of silence and expression of emptiness".

Non-dualistic intuition then would be in contrast with mystical experiences, as they would be normally described in terms appropriate to the experiencer and what is experienced, i.e. Saints and Angels as St. Joan of Arc testified, not to speak of whatever inner state of being she was 'in' so to speak.

dionysos areopagite on 2020-12-28 at 19:50 said:

Thank you so much for this incredible post. I wanted to ask about what you think about the thesis that Catholicism is wholly exoteric and esoteric.. that it does not distinguish between them because it completely combines them.. I think this is a thesis of some Catholics who follow Guenon..

Cologero on 2020-12-29 at 10:23 said:

First, I don't understand what the thesis even means. Second, not to diminish the man's accomplishments, Guenon is not Procrustes, so we are not compelled to fit everything to suit him. What Guenon writes in terms of principles is one thing, but his opinions are not dogmatic. I think this post made the distinction clear. If you read Dante as poetry or theology, that is exoteric. If you understand him as describing inner spiritual states, that is esoteric. It is unlikely that anyone can make that transition without help and support of some kind from someone who has.

dionysos areopagite on 2020-12-29 at 15:24 said:

"First, I don't understand what the thesis even means. Second, not to diminish the man's accomplishments, Guenon is not Procrustes, so we are not compelled to fit everything to suit him. What Guenon writes in terms of principles is one thing, but his opinions are not dogmatic. I think this post made the distinction clear. If you read Dante as poetry or theology, that is exoteric. If you understand him as describing inner spiritual states, that is esoteric. It is unlikely that anyone can make that transition without help and support of some kind from someone who has."

I think I would completely agree on both points.. I was thinking specifically about Borella who seems to me to bring up valid points about Guenon in his book *Christ: The Original Mystery*.. He specifically mentions (Matthew 27:51; Mark 15:38; Luke 23:45), the veil being torn asunder, as evidence of Christ as the fully exoteric Revelation of the esoteric, in other words, full harmony between esoteric and exoteric. I thought this was a compelling thesis.. But I am not inclined to wholly agree with him in all his points of criticism of Guenon..

I would mention organizations like Opus Dei as a kind of example of combining the esoteric and exoteric aspects in Catholicism.. Perhaps at first it wouldn't appear so... I don't know how much you know about that organization.. But they are very interesting to me..

I also wanted to ask a further question which is what do you regard as the purpose of the distinction between esoteric and exoteric teaching.. for example, someone like Leo Strauss would probably say that the purpose of esoteric versus exoteric teaching is to maintain the harmony between the elites and the commoners.. I don't know how much the Guenonian perspective differs from this..

Perhaps you have written on this before so I of course do not intend to burden you if you'd like to point me to a previous post... But I am interested because I love this blog and respect your work very much..

Cologero on 2020-12-29 at 23:07 said:

Let me start with the basics. Due to health issues, I am extremely vulnerable to Covid; hence, I am living like an anchorite. My Priest calls me monthly to see if I'm ready for a visit. He asks me: are you praying the rosary?, are you making spiritual communions?, etc. NOT are you reading Borella?, what do you think of Dante?

We are called to know, love and serve God; these usually require different interests and abilities. For most people, going to Mass and receiving the sacraments are all they need. Some of us are more inclined to the "know" part, hence the interest in the so-called esoteric. In *Man and his Becoming*, Guenon writes:

Exoterism and esoterism, regarded not as two distinct and more or less opposed doctrines, which would be quite an erroneous view

So esoterism is NOT a secret teaching, but a deeper understanding of the exoteric. Why the interest? Because some of us are called in that direction. Why again? because it helps us understand better the teachings of the Fathers, Saints, Mystics, etc. Pace Borella, Jesus taught in parables and there were many things left out of the Gospels.

Guenon may be somewhat inconsistent in his definitions, so I'll stand by the one I quoted. Rather than argue with any of those fellows, I'll give a concrete example. You decide if it makes sense to you.

Metaphysical realization literally means making the metaphysical teaching, which are initially virtual, "real". That is a more fruitful starting point than debating esoteric-exoteric. Guenon emphasizes that such a realization requires concentration and meditation – skills that must be learned from someone else, apart from rare exceptions. Reading another book won't help, nor will intellectual debates, which is a lower form of knowledge than intuition. That is basic theology. We want to reach intuition.

EXAMPLE: The soul consists of a vegetative and an animal soul; those are both carnal and natural. Humans also have an intellectual soul, which is supernatural. You can read that and "know" it as a philosophical or metaphysical viewpoint.

However, there is a deeper way. You can know it through direct perception. Through training, you can learn to "see" how the three parts of the soul relate and interact with each other. As Paul reminds us, we are at war with ourselves. So this knowledge will help us develop a unified self, the more we learn about our inner states. "Know thyself" needs to be taken literally, and not in a trivial sense like "I don't like broccoli."

Maybe, you will begin to notice higher states. I have written posts on Dante's precursors like Augustine, Saint Bernard, the Victorines, who have described such states.

I think you can see how debate and quoting "authorities" gets you nowhere, just endless discussion and banter. There is a better way.

dionysos areopagite on 2020-12-31 at 10:57 said:

Very much appreciate your responses and all your writings, sir. Being given the gift of metaphysical realization or mystical experience is something very precious and rare indeed, and something to be very grateful for.. and has made me personally very interested in the question of the spiritual renewal of our religion and culture.. many people seem to live as if this isn't possible.. Or they feel some kind of desperation in regard the cultural situation.. It's very hard indeed to not feel this way.. Its hard to not to look at people in Church and find them lacking.. It is very hard to consider how God's plan can give them waters to soothe their thirst.. It certainly seems like a more than human task.. but thinking about it alone helps no one.. and so I also have zero interest in endless debate and citing authorities... I seek out conversation with people who are familiar with ideas and authors in order to seriously think through how genuine spiritual renewal is possible.. I think it is only possible as a cooperation between human and divine authority... So I see writings like your blog as possible signs of genuine interest in spiritual renewal.. So again, I thank you.. God bless and Merry Christmas..

Max on 2021-01-17 at 14:45 said:

On the question of esoterism in Guénon and Strauss. The latter is concerned with exoteric writing and politics. The aim of the social order is to allow for its members to develop their full human potential. Guénon makes the distinction between lesser and greater mysteries, and says that the "lesser mysteries effectively stop at the limits of human possibilities, and constitute in respect of the latter only a preparatory stage and are not themselves their own proper end". In other words, politics does not contain its own end, and therefore no secular politics is ultimately tenable. This is incidentally also the main point at which Strauss criticizes modernity, and is thus in agreement with Guénon.

Strauss is moreover critical of "historicism", while Guénon says that the ultimate goal of the lesser mysteries is beyond the temporal condition, where "freed from time, the apparent succession of things is transmuted into simultaneity". That means reaching the primordial state, or earthly paradise. As a Platonist, Strauss rejects the notion that time is a condition for knowledge, or the progressive one according to which "progressives" are better at understanding the world than anybody else. Although functioning as a guide for some of the more shadowy lower reaches, Strauss does not seem to be aboard the "move from paganism to Christianity", as this piece articulates above. He was very much concerned with the social disruptions that followed though, and which still appears unresolved. In principle, he does not like to discuss the Bible,

but the reason is not because it has been inconsequential for political philosophy.

I am not aware that Strauss treated of esoteric teaching in writing. He said that there is an outside, not necessarily what the inner meaning of the fact of there being an outside is. It quickly turns into a scandal for literalists that not everything is of surface level, believing it some kind of malevolent conspiracy. There are two conflicting reactions upon confrontation with the state of affairs of an interior/exterior divide. Some would seek to abolish it, and in effect make everything into mere surface, while realists instead accepts it as the nature of reality as we know it. The first practices secrecy out of lower passions such as fear, while the latter conceives of a kind of hiddenness in the world itself, that no human convention can ever overcome, but that nevertheless serves a secret purpose all its own.

Strauss naturally focuses his attention on the phenomenon of exoterism, while his readers are mostly obsessed with esoterism. He did not have a high opinion of people who believe that they understand an author better than he understood himself though. The difficult point to get across is that you will not find the esoteric teaching in a book, but perhaps pointers in the right direction. These are the options, as valid for Nietzsche as for us:

“...Nietzsche could choose one of two ways: he could insist on the strictly esoteric character of the theoretical analysis of life – that is, restore the Platonic notion of the noble delusion – or else he could deny the possibility of theory proper and so conceive of thought as essentially subservient to, or dependent on, life or fate...” -Leo Strauss

So in conclusion, either interiority is real in its own right, or it is merely an epiphenomenon of “life” or what have you. A public teaching accomodates the popular opinion, or the particular views of those it aims to reach. It might make use of the prevailing myths of the times, for example those of liberalism in our day. In writing then, ideas are perhaps expressed dialectically or polemically without demonstrating the reasons why, or it provides principles and definitions without drawing out the logical conclusions. The general idea is that something is always and necessarily left out. Good writers does that deliberately, while for the bad, it just happens accidentally. Silence does not speaks when it is merely an accident rather than concentrated.

2.9 Prophets of Electrum

Consciousness in man is pre-eminently intellect. It might have been, it ought, so it seems, to have been also intuition. Intuition and intellect represent two opposite directions of the work of consciousness: intuition goes in the very direction of life, intellect goes in the inverse direction, and thus finds itself naturally in

accordance with the movement of matter. A complete and perfect humanity would be that in which these two forms of conscious activity should attain their full development.

HENRI BERGSON, *Creative Evolution*

Here is the difference between the nature of intelligence and that of intuition of faith, between the principle of autumn and that of spring. The former is *understanding of that which is*; the latter is *participation in the becoming of that which is to be*.

MEDITATIONS ON THE TAROT, *Letter XVIII The Moon*

One of the tasks of Hermetism is to accomplish the alliance of intelligence and the intuition of faith — the alchemical marriage of the moon and the sun. Another way to put it is to obtain the alloy of silver and gold, which is called Electrum. Although some have come close to this ideal, it is a task still incomplete. Several thinkers have come close; these we will call the **Prophets of Electrum**.



At the top of those prophets is **Saint Thomas Aquinas** whose thought is silvered gold. More common is gilded silver as expressed by Origen, Dionysius the Areopagite, Jacob Boehme¹⁹, Louis Claude de Saint-Martin²⁰, Vladimir Solovyov, Nicolas Berdyaev²¹, Henri Bergson, and Pierre Teilhard de Chardin.

The importance of Thomas Aquinas cannot be overestimated, even for Hermetists. The *raison d'être* of scholasticism is the union of faith and

¹⁹See Section 3.10 in this book.

²⁰See Section 2.4 in this book.

²¹<https://gornahoor.net/?s=Berdyaev>

intelligence. Following his conversion to Catholicism, Tomberg wrote his graduate thesis on International Law from a Thomist perspective, so he was quite familiar with Thomas's work. In particular, he referred to Thomas's mystical experience near the end of his earthly life:

On the feast of St. Nicholas, 1273, Aquinas was celebrating Mass when he received a revelation that so affected him that he wrote and dictated no more, leaving his great work the *Summa Theologiae* unfinished. To Brother Reginald's (his secretary and friend) expostulations he replied, "The end of my labors has come. All that I have written appears to be as so much straw after the things that have been revealed to me." When later asked by Reginald to return to writing, Aquinas said, "I can write no more. I have seen things that make my writings like straw."

ALBAN BUTLER, *Lives of the Saints*

But that experience was not a rejection of his purely intellectual work, but rather its fulfilment. Thomism is the combustible that, when enflamed, gives rise to contemplation:

St. Thomas Aquinas was not the only one. Just as he arrived at contemplation through scholastic reasoning, so did the peak of the scholastic wave reach *gnosis mystique*, that is to say, intuition or the state of union of faith and intelligence, which is the aim of scholasticism. **Meister Eckhart**, **Ruysbroeck**, the Admirable Doctor, **St. John of the Cross** are in fact spirits amongst whom you will search in vain for a spirit of opposition to scholasticism. For them also it was true that scholasticism was "like straw", but they knew at the same time from their own experience that this straw is an excellent combustible. They certainly surpassed scholasticism, but after having attained its aim. For the aim of scholastic effort is contemplation, and it is *gnosis mystique* which is the fruit of the scholastic tree.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Letter XIX The Sun*

Some of the persons mentioned are controversial from the strictly metaphysical point of view. However, Hermetism is not concerned with dialectics but rather with mining their insights. Their faults are acknowledged, but left aside. That is why they are gilded silver.

Pierre Teilhard de Chardin is the scientist who approaches the ideal. He restored the subjective element to scientific objectivity, in the claim that there is an “inside” as well as an “outside” to everything. Any complete understanding of the world process needs to take that into account. Teilhard advanced the “postulate of the pre-existence of a prototype for all beings, which is the ultimate as well as the effective cause of the whole process of evolution, and this postulate alone tenders evolution intelligible.” Isn’t that essentially Platonism, where the divine ideas are expressing themselves in time?

Although Tomberg writes extensively about Henri Bergson, I’d like to add a little more background. Finally, I’ll conclude with the influence of Vladimir Solovyov which, I believe, provides a view into Tomberg’s motivation.

Henri Bergson

There is a centre from which worlds shoot out like rockets in a fireworks display—provided, however, that I do not present this centre as a thing, but as a continuity of shooting out. God thus defined, has nothing of the already made; He is unceasing life, action, freedom. Creation, so conceived, is not a mystery; we experience it in ourselves when we act freely.

HENRI BERGSON, *Creative Evolution*

Henri Bergson’s philosophy was born in the atmosphere of French spiritualism, a form of idealism prominent in Italy and France at the time.

One influence, for example, was **Emile Boutroux** who in the *Contingency of Physical Laws*, claimed that life, feeling, and freewill need to be part of any understanding of Physical Laws. He rejected determinism, and instead claimed that natural laws as a sort of “habit” of things: what originally was also able to be a free act, in repeating itself, automatizes, and mechanizes itself and ends up appearing to be a necessity. A fortiori, this applies to human beings, who cannot be determined by environment, race, etc.

Bergson married a cousin of Marcel Proust and his brother-in-law was Samuel Liddell MacGregor Mathers, a founder of the *Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn*. Although born Jewish, Bergson felt closer to Catholicism, which he regarded as the fulfilment of Judaism. He never officially converted, however, because of the rise of National Socialism.

Although from a strictly logical point of view, his philosophical system can be refuted. The Church even banned his books. Rene Guenon, too, was critical of Bergson. However, that is not the Hermetic reading of Bergson, which is more concerned with Bergson’s insights than its logical presentation. Any useful critique of his thought would have to advance the alliance of intelligence and intuition. The standard critiques remain on one or the other side of that alliance, and therefore fall short of what is necessary.

In Bergson’s view, the intellect treats matter as inert, and is unable to discern the life that animates it. It chops Being up into pieces, so that “whatever is fluid in the real will escape it”. We see this starkly in the abortion debate: science cannot determine when “life begins in the womb”. The intelligent course of action in this case would be to admit that shortcoming of “science” and rely on one’s intuition. That seldom happens, so the modern world loves death and sterility.

Solovyov and Egyptian Theosophy In a footnote to Lecture Six of *Divine Humanity*, Vladimir Solovyov informs us:

Although the close inner connection between Alexandrian theosophy and the Christian doctrine is one of the firmly established theses of Western scholarship, for one reason or another, this perfectly correct thesis does not enjoy common acknowledgement in our theological literature. Therefore, I consider it necessary to devote to this question a special appendix at the end of these lectures, where I will touch upon the significance of the native Egyptian theosophy (the revelations of Thoth or Hermes Trismegistus) in its relation to both the doctrines mentioned.

Unfortunately, this pregnant quotation is the theological equivalent of Fermat's Last Theorem, since the promised appendix was never published. This section will try to begin the proof. First of all, the two doctrines in question are the dogmas of the Logos and the Trinity. These doctrines were developed metaphysically by Egyptian Neoplatonists from Philo to Plotinus independent of Christian revelation. What Christianity brought was the revelation that this divine life appeared as a fact, as an historical reality. Only later was this fact connected to Neoplatonic metaphysics. Now we see how Solovyov became a prophet of Electrum, uniting the intuition of faith with the intelligence of metaphysics.

So, how does this relate to Valentin Tomberg? In a talk *Inner Impulses of Evolution*²², Rudolf Steiner mentions Solovyov in relation to **Ernest Renan** and **David Strauss**. Renan wrote a *Life of Christ* that presumes that Jesus was simply a man living in Palestine at a certain historical time. Hence, he strips out all supernatural and miraculous elements from the Gospels.

Strauss' *Life of Christ*, on the other hand, wrote from the perspective of Jesus' followers. The miracles, for example, were mythical, i.e., creations of the early Christians to express their developing conception of

²²https://web.archive.org/web/20251212133332/https://rsarchive.org/Lectures/GA171/English/AP1984/InnImp_index.html

Jesus. Since Strauss was a Hegelian, he did not deny spiritual reality in itself. Steiner interprets Strauss like this:

As Strauss sees it, in the course of mankind's earthly development, from the times of the first beginnings of the earth to its final end, mankind has and always will have a higher power in it than the merely external power that develops on the physical plane. A power runs right through mankind that will forever address itself to the super-earthly; this super-earthly finds expression in myths. We know that man bears something supersensible within him that seeks to find expression in myth since it cannot be expressed in external physical science. Thus, Strauss does not see Jesus in the single individual, but rather the Christ in all men.

Solovyov, on the other hand, focuses on Christ rather than Jesus, but on Christ as a living being, not as an abstract idea. Steiner describes Solovyov, perhaps with some exaggeration:

When we come to Soloviev, behold, Jesus is no more, but only the Christ. Nevertheless, it is the Christ conceived as living. Not working in men as an idea, with the consequence that its power is transformed in him into a myth, but rather working as a living Being who has no body, is always and ever present among men, and is, in effect, positively responsible for the external organization of human life, the founder of the social order.

Steiner's lecture made quite an impression on the young Tomberg, who was inspired to study Solovyov in depth. Tomberg describes that encounter:

A result was the conviction that this author had never encountered a work written before the time of Rudolf Steiner that contained such a profound concept of the nature and mission of Jesus Christ, a view presented against the background of cosmic history.

The obvious question is how did Solovyov arrive at such a deep understanding. This perplexed Tomberg, since Solovyov certainly did not argue himself into his understanding, despite presenting his understanding in a logical way to others. Solovyov does mention three divine experiences of Sophia, including one in the Egyptian desert. We don't know exactly what he was doing in Egypt, but we do know that Solovyov had become quite familiar with both the Kabbalah and Hermetism. He regarded Paracelsus, Boehme, and Emmanuel Swedenborg as "substantial individuals". He was also familiar with Johann Gichtel, so he would have known of Gichtel's correspondence of the chakras with the planets²³.

So we can read the Letters on the Tarot as the promised appendix to *Divine Humanity*. Tomberg explains in the Forward:

These Letters are intended only to serve, to sustain, and to support the Hermetic tradition — from its first appearance in the epoch of **Hermes Trismegistus**, lost in the remoteness of antiquity and become legendary.

Posted on 2022-04-21 by Cologero

* * *

Carol on 2022-04-22 at 15:22 said:

Hello, I don't usually comment on blogs, but I have been reading here for some time now and would like to express my appreciation for your posts!

I am a 58 year old American woman with very little formal education... but I have tremendous admiration for those who, being highly educated, combine their intellectual skills with spiritual pursuits.

I particularly enjoy posts such as this current one, as I have not got the mental fortitude to read entire works by such authors as you 'discuss' here.

But your writing is very 'accessible' to my understanding and thus, very helpful toward the limitations of my intellect in my pursuit of spiritual materials for contemplation.

Anyway, I just wanted you to know that you have a reader who is very grateful for your efforts!!!

²³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=16036>

Christian Gnosis

3.1 Gnosis, properly so called

What is now called the Christian religion already existed among the ancients, and was not lacking at the very beginnings of the human race. When Christ appeared in the flesh, the true religion already in existence received the name of Christian.

AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO

Augustine was involved both in Gnosticism and Paganism before his final conversion to Christianity, so there is reason to consider his claim with some seriousness. However, to do so will require a revaluation of the three ancient movements; this is an attempt to make that plausible.

It is known that the early Christians divided themselves into three levels: the Catechumens, the Faithful, and the Perfect. The Catechumens were not yet baptized; after that, they joined the ranks of the Faithful, or believers. The Perfect were the knowers. This internal division corresponds to the external division into pagans, Christians, and Gnostics as shown in the following schema.

Internal	External	Mode of knowing
Catechumen	Pagan	Reason
Faithful	Christian	Faith
Perfect	Gnostic	Wisdom

We know of the existence of the third level within Christianity through the writings of the Alexandrians, especially Clement. There are those who deny the existence of a separate esoteric doctrine within Christianity. In a sense this is correct, since the doctrine is the same; nevertheless, the understanding can be much different. There used to be four levels of understanding of biblical writings, of which the historical was the simplest and least important. However, in our time the obsession with a literal and historical interpretation of the Bible — which is common among Fundamentalists, Modernists, and even anti-Christian — occludes that earlier understanding. I read a book a few years ago that attempted to discredit Christianity by pointing out its symbolic nature and “borrowings” from pagan teachings; this is risible, since it does not refute, but instead, demonstrates our point.

Very little is known today about the pagan mystery cults. We can assume that many of them were simply drinking clubs, as is the case with many “secret societies” today. Although it frustrates the professors, the actual teachings of the authentic cults are irrelevant. We know that they would have taught the Logos and cosmic order, the meaning of gnosis, and the means to attain it through the three trials. **Rudolf Steiner** in *Christianity as Mystical Fact*, claims that the pagan mysteries were absorbed into esoteric Christianity, and even uses Augustine to make his point. He writes:

The *cognition* of the eternal which the ancient Mysteries withheld from the multitudes, when presented in this way by Christian thought and feeling, became an *article of faith* which by its very

nature was related to something unattainable by mere knowledge.

Thus, what the knower knows is presented as articles of faith, or dogmas, to be believed by those neither ready for nor capable of gnosis. **Julius Evola** alludes to that in *The Hermetic Tradition*, when he claims that if faith is lived intensely and coherently, then it can create the conditions for liberation at the moment of death.

Now Evola also writes of “the derivation of the hermetic tradition from a primordial royal and heroic vein” and its “concealment” within Christianity. Obviously concealment means nothing other than esoteric.

So the question arises as to the fate of the various movements that we categorize as Gnosticism and why they had to be suppressed. Arising also in Alexandria with many points in common with the genuine Gnosticism, many problems developed. As we see in the various “esoteric orders” of today, there is more interest in the external trappings of the grades rather than in the internal transformations that are the real meanings thereof. Hence, there were many who would claim to rank among the perfect or the knowers without having the necessary qualifications. They would misunderstand and misinterpret the genuine teachings and apply them in rather strange ways.

In effect, rather than an esoteric order within society, they created competing ideologies and belief systems. As we have mentioned repeatedly, there is no way to resolve and harmonize belief systems. Thus, a belief system based on genuine gnosis needs to be protected. This is the intent of the adage that the Sage does not disturb the peace of the faithful whereas the so-called Gnostics did indeed do so.

Thus, the Gnostics became a revolutionary force. The net result was that gnosis was separated from faith. The religious and political leaders seldom rose above the initial impetus of the faith doctrine, and the genuine gnostics were lumped together with the more bizarre elements within the various Gnostic movements, and had either to continue in obscurity or else to write using heavily symbolic language.

The Philosopher's Heaven

Man, once awakened to a will to create, wants to bypass the limits of the circles of necessity and master the power residing in Fire.

Corpus Hermeticum

In Chapter 12 of *The Hermetic Tradition*, Julius Evola interprets the statement in the Zohar:

“The visible is the reflection of the invisible” to mean “Earth is the visible part of Heaven”. Yet, as **Jacques Lacarriere** writes in *The Gnostics*:

Man, like the universe, is a failed creation, a lamentable imitation, the mere semblance of a man, a counterfeit man.

Although the Gnostics adapted much of the esoteric teachings of the early centuries of our era, they made a subtle error. The Marxist Lacarriere expresses it:

It seems a simple, obvious, and irrefutable fact that today, as in the time of the Gnostics, the alienation of man is global; it is also true that the economic, social, and political causes of alienation should be removed first.

Thus, he could recommend “modifying the means of production, transforming the nature of economic exchanges, and the distribution of wealth” as the task of the Gnostic, falsely so-called.

This puts him firmly on the side of revolution and we see this form of spirituality resuscitated in our own time in the various New Age movements. Instead of the futile and erroneous Gnostic path of liberation by throwing off any and all external and conventional structures, Evola quotes **Jacob Boehme**:

Paradise is still in this world, but man is very far from it, so long as he fails to regenerate himself.

Evola explains that it is “the power of Earth in man is that which forces on him, via the physical body, the materialistic vision of the world.”

This “petrification of the spiritual world created by the bodily senses” is conditioned by the “dualistic law of I-Not-I” which is “the main obstacle to modern understanding of the traditional sciences.” Evola writes that the solution is to become aware of the Air, Water, and Fire elements which “are other existential states, other modalities of consciousness, quite separate from the body, that can transpose all the principles of things according to their non-corporeal nature.” In contrast the Gnostics believed:

That which weighs us down, makes us heavy, and sends us to sleep, is the cloacal matrix, this borborian matter from which we were extracted; above all, it is this basic flaw in our very structures that renders us incapable of assuming our predestined mission.

In opposition to Evola, the Gnostics took a realist position, postulating that there is some entity that created *flaws* in our structure. Evola, on the other hand, sees matter, oppressive structures, and so on, as *privations*, created by ourselves spontaneously and unconsciously. Our task then is to elevate our consciousness and develop the Will to overcome such privations.

Unable to transcend the I-not-I perception, the Gnostics postulated Yahweh as an “evil” demiurge, opposed to the True, Transcendent God. Of course, this is a metaphysical impossibility. The perceived evil is a privation, in this case voluntary¹. The Traditional esoteric teaching, too, recognizes in Yahweh a being akin to the Demiurge, although with the assigned task of maintaining the laws and structures of the world.

¹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-void-and-the-fullness-are-indissolubly-bound>

Further reading:

JACQUES LACARRIERE, *The Gnostics*

JULIUS EVOLA, *The Hermetic Tradition*

GEORGE HEART, *Christianity: Dogmatic Faith & Gnostic Vivifying Knowledge*

Posted on 2011-05-05 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2011-05-06 at 11:52 said:

"Very little is known today about the pagan mystery cults. We can assume that many of them were simply drinking clubs, as is the case with many 'secret societies' today."

Well, some may have been 'simply' drinking clubs, but the drinking club as such was an important part of Classical culture viz, Symposium as well as the origin of the Christian 'love feasts' and churches see the recent book From Symposium to Eucharist .

Michael Hoffman has a collection of material, including both academic sources as well as his own speculations, here:

<http://www.egodeath.com/WineAndSacredMeals.htm>

James O'Meara on 2011-05-06 at 11:59 said:

"So the question arises as to the fate of the various movements that we categorize as Gnosticism and why they had to be suppressed."

The whole point of having freedom of thought is that some bad apples will appear. Why assume that ALL Gnostic movements "had to be suppressed" or that the orthodox were the blameless ones who "had to" do it. I prefer Freke and Gandy's theory: the NT is the exoteric, psychic story given the catechumens, Gnosticism represented the inner, pneumatic doctrine. The outer churches such as Rome were cut off from the inner members in Jerusalem by the revolt and diaspora, leaving them in ignorance of the real doctrine. Rising to power in Rome, then set about exterminating the "heretical" Gnostics Pope vs. Eckhardt writ large . End of story.

Cologero on 2011-05-07 at 00:09 said:

I thought that is what we wrote, James, and I apologize for not making it clear. However, we find the "inner members" in Alexandria, not Jerusalem. The Gnosticisms have not been totally repressed and can be found again at New Age gatherings.

logres on 2011-05-16 at 23:52 said:

Mr. O'Meara, the division of the Church into Gnostics & Orthodox probably did violence to both parties. Arguably more to the ecclesiastical party innerly, and arguably more to the esoterists in the physical/outer sense. Wouldn't (ideally) the two co-exist without being identical?

James O'Meara on 2011-05-17 at 13:16 said:

logres,

Ideally, yes. As Guenon points out though it seems to have escaped H. Smith and the other Schuonians the exo/eso division is exclusively Judeo-Christian. In China there are two distinct traditions, with different aims; in India, a sort of 'natural' exotericism, where anything can be heard, but only the 'right' people can understand. In these lands, metaphysics operates freely, without interference from social conformity and 'the good of the state.' Even in Islam, Guenon insisted that Sufism was 'Islamic esotericism' not 'Esoteric Islam'; metaphysics using the local religion's dress, rather than the pretense of being its 'inner level' and subsequent persecution.

logres on 2011-05-18 at 21:56 said:

It seems to me that the exoteric Church wants (or thinks it wants) esotericism "within" it, defined as safely within proscribed boundaries and subject to scrutiny, which (of course) would mean it not being esoteric by nature (properly) at all. The aim itself (or motive) is correct, but the standard and goal are delusionary – hence the disconnect and misunderstandings. Many like myself were initially confused and wanted the same thing, except with a proper goal added. I am convinced now that I am ignorant of anything but what it should "not" be, and have a general feeling for regrouping and a direction or tendency. These discussions have been very helpful.

Count Cagliostro on 2011-05-12 at 18:47 said:

"Earth is the visible part of Heaven"

Sometimes difficult to believe in, but still a wonderful quote!

logres on 2011-05-14 at 16:39 said:

Thank you, this actually helps – the "Forbidden Religion" tract by J.A. Aragon is really well written and done, and very convincing rhetorically, but that is precisely why I need such metaphysical grounding. Without that, Gnosticism is the ultimate "authenticity" and probably the growth of that movement in the past was due to precisely such shaky premises – namely, that of a decaying Semitic worldview influenced by popularized mystery religion.

Matt on 2011-05-30 at 17:40 said:

I have been reading Mouravieff's Gnosis and relating this post to that writing, I suppose one could say that the various Gnostic groups failed to see what Moravieff noted (assuming I

read it correctly) that the laws of the cosmos were in place for the legitimate reason of putting a limit on the destructive aspect of Time, to ensure that the creation endures (while the initiate works to transcend the laws, not destroy them), whereas the Gnostics saw them as inherently evil.

3.2 The Way of Gnosis

Gnosis is one of the Gifts of the Holy Spirit. It is not secret knowledge available for the few, nor is it the “real” interpretation of text, opposed to the orthodox. On the other hand, it is perhaps an Open Secret, since it is pursued by the few. It is not necessary for salvation, just one path for those so inclined, just as others may respond better to different gifts.

We are asked to know, love, and serve God. We cannot love what, or whom, we do not know. We cannot serve what, or whom, we do not love. So, in a sense, knowing, or gnosis, is fundamental to the spiritual life.

Gnosis is a method of depth. Hence, it is not merely intellectual, since it also affects the Feeling and Willing aspects of life.

Gnosis and the Text Gnosis is a direct knowing, as opposed to a rationalist or discursive knowing. This is the way it manifests:

Mysticism $\Rightarrow$ Gnosis $\Rightarrow$ Text

It necessarily begins with mystical experience, which is not earned, but is rather a free gift. That leads to gnosis, which then tries to explain itself through language. The resulting texts get debated while its source – gnosis – is forgotten and pushed to the background. The process cannot work in reverse. Viz.,

Text $\Rightarrow$ Gnosis $\Rightarrow$ Mysticism

Although texts certainly can be helpful, especially as road markers, all the study and debate over texts cannot induce gnosis, but often mis-

understanding.

Preparation It is first necessary to reduce the perturbations in one's soul life in order to reflect the Spirit more faithfully. These are the main preliminary steps in that process:

- Concentration without effort
- Moral purification of the Will
- Overcoming of the subjective element in the Intellect
- Non-expression of negative emotions

We can provide some examples.

Christian Initiation The three sacraments of Christian initiation can be expressed like this.

- **Baptism:** The natural born man is alienated from God. Through Baptism, he is restored and becomes a child of God by adoption. The popular view that those born of the flesh are children of God is incorrect. Being a child of God means to share in his nature; hence our task is the achievement of theosis.
- **Communion:** Ideally, communion is administered to children who reach the age of reason around seven years old. That does not mean that they can suddenly do logic puzzles, but rather that they can distinguish between good and evil. Thus, the child reverses the choice made by Adam and Eve who wanted to be their own arbiters of right and wrong.

- **Confirmation:** At confirmation we receive the gifts of the Holy Spirit. Most remain passive to those gifts, accepting them when given. On the path of gnosis, however, one must play an active role in order to make oneself available for the gifts of knowledge and understanding.

Inner Soul Life These are the elements in the philosophical understanding of the soul as described by Thomas Aquinas:

- **Sensitive soul:** In common with all living things
- **Animal soul:** In common with animals
- **Intellectual soul:** specific to man and angels
- These form a unity, i.e., the person or the I

That is correct philosophically. However, for gnosis, one learns to observe the activities specific to the different souls and how they relate to each other. One sees that the inner unity is only virtual and not fully actualized. In other words, there is a war in the soul as long as we are not pure of heart. Our task, then, is develop the I to be able to master the disparate elements of soul life.

Knowledge of God The Thomist philosopher **Edward Feser** describes Thomas' understanding of God as classical theism². This was the understanding of the ancients, with these examples provided by Feser:

- **Maimonides:** Jewish
- **Avicenna:** Muslim

²<https://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2012/07/classical-theism-round-up.html>

- **Plotinus:** Pagan

Although we share a common understanding of God with these philosophers, this does not imply a religious syncretism, nor agreement with different creeds and forms of worship. Yet we cannot deny the same basic understanding of God among them. Since Feser is a philosopher, he often argues against atheists. Moreover, he also opposes a different God conception called neotheism or theistic personalism. Not only is this view held by some contemporary theologians, it is probably the implicit understanding of common believers to one extent or another.

These are the main features held by neotheists:

- God is a being among other beings
- He is subject to time
- God has parts and is not simple
- He experiences human emotions, that is, He is not impassable
- He has a gnomic will and deliberates before making decisions
- His knowledge is propositional
- He has sensory experiences

However, when one has a direct experience of God, then classical theism is simply understood beyond argument. Atheism and neotheism are not just wrong, they are incoherent. Now I don't want to call neotheists heretics nor do I deny that they may provide some important insights into the nature of God. Yet their arguments never settle any questions.

God's knowledge is not propositional, since His knowledge is direct knowing of essences in the Divine Mind. When that point is understood, the understanding of Wisdom, or Sophia, arises. Hence the next steps

are to follow the paths described by the Christian Cabala, Jacob Boehme, and Vladimir Solovyov.

Posted on 2019-10-13 by Cologero

* * *

Fallen Adam on 2019-10-13 at 14:47 said:

Would our knowledge of the beings in the sensory world count as a low degree of mysticism? Referring here to our act of knowing what a being is through the perceptions we obtain of it through the senses. It's an intuitive and direct form of knowing, in that any reason we might give to justify such knowledge, is only posterior to the act itself. We can justify it by saying that we perceived through the senses is similar to other such group of perceptions, but we all know that we say "I saw a tree", we are referring to a being which shares in a certain nature and essence, and not to a bundle of sense perceptions.

Also, could the experience of observing and understanding what is happening in our inner life be a form of mysticism? For example, the moment in which we apprehend the fact that we are being moved by anger in a particular situation, or that negative emotions are triggered in us due to a certain cause. This might also be called a discursive process, in that we might use our memory and give our self reasons towards reaching a particular conclusion, but there is also an aspect of immediacy and direct intuition in such things.

Cassiodorus on 2019-10-13 at 21:12 said:

I don't see how the classical theism articulated by Feser is reconcilable with the nondualism espoused by Guenon .

Cologero on 2019-10-13 at 21:34 said:

We have already mentioned on various occasions that in principle Aristotle posited identification by knowledge, but also that this affirmation, in his works as in those of his Scholastic followers, seems to have remained purely theoretical, for they seem never to have drawn any conclusions from it as concerns metaphysical realization (From the Multiple States of the Being).

Classical theism is fine as far as it concerns Being. Guenon refers to non-being. Wolfgang Smith recognizes this incompleteness and uses Jacob Boehme and Meister Eckhart as the basis for a "Trinitarian non-duality". Ultimately, metaphysical realization – what we are calling mysticism and gnosis – is the final arbiter.

Sviatoslav on 2019-10-14 at 09:27 said:

It seems that everything starts with mystical experience. In this context, I guess mysticism has a broader meaning than Guenon or Evola understood that. Maybe more in Tomberg's version. But is mysticism only way, or one of the ways? Tomberg distinguishes three forms of mystical experience :

- the experience of union with Nature
- union with the transcendental human Self
- union with God

The first leads to intoxication, the second to sobriety and the third is a synthesis of both previous.

Are all of those ways valid, or one is better than others? Tomberg exalts union with God in love, in God-man duality while discourages from intellectual Vedantic path (including Guénon himself). Maybe I am wrong, but it seems to me, that there is a significant conflict between Guénon and Tomberg.

Cassiodorus on 2019-10-14 at 11:36 said:

I just do not see how the doctrine of maya in divinis in which Being is relegated to a lower level of Divinity can be squared with the classical theistic tradition of Aristotle, Aquinas, or even that of the Dvaitan Vedantan, Madhva .

Classical theism speaks of the ontological distinction and contingency of creation, insisting that differences are real.

The unqualified nondualism of Guenon, following Advaita Vedanta, rejects the reality of difference and claims that all that is relative is maya or "illusion" – including Being Itself which Schuon called the "relative Absolute".

These principles are fundamentally pantheistic , or panentheistic if you prefer, and run contrary to the doctrine of creation ex nihilo. Furthermore, the Trinity which is essentially a matter of relationship would also be relegated to the domain of maya or illusion. Problematic to say the least for the traditional Christian.

Cassiodorus on 2019-10-14 at 14:51 said:

Does the distinction between classical theism and theistic personalism relate to the distinction between "non-Being" and Being?

3.3 Prequel to the Three Worlds

Cornelius Agrippa, in *Occult Philosophy*, posited the existence of three worlds: the elementary, celestial, and intellectual worlds, hierarchically arranged, as illustrated, for example, in **Robert Fludd**'s Diagram³.

Since each inferior world is governed by its superior and receives its influence, so the mages believe that one can penetrate naturally by means of the same levels and for each one of these worlds up to the “archetypal world”, constructor and ruler of all things and from there to act not only on natural powers, but to also create new ones.

In the essay on **Hermann Keyserling**, **Julius Evola** added that as a footnote to some of Keyserling's ideas, in particular, “The representation creates reality, not vice versa.” Clearly, both Keyserling and Agrippa recognize that the subtle rules the dense. At this point, it is worth the time to consolidate the ideas about the three worlds.

Other terms for the three worlds are “hylic, psychic, and pneumatic” or “exoteric, mesoteric, and esoteric”. I was going to summarize these worlds in a post, but it became too long and involved. So, first there is this prequel which serves as the introduction.

What Is Spiritualism I recently saw part of a movie, which I don't recommend: you will meet a tall dark stranger. In it, the ditzy mother, a divorcee, met a man she described as “spiritual”, because he dabbled in séances, reincarnation, psychics, etc. Obviously, that is quite far from what we mean by spirit. Rather we mean interiority.

That is the heart of the Western tradition, also called “spiritualism” in other languages, but, unfortunately, that has much different connotation

³<https://www.gornahoor.net/wp-content/uploads/2011/03/hierarchy.jpg>

in the Anglosphere. So we are forced to use the term “idealism”. As we have pointed out many times, Plato is but one link in a long chain that goes back much further than him. It took different forms in 19th century Germany, moved on to France and Italy, where the trail goes cold in the second half of the 20th century.

In the mission to contribute to the living stream of Hermetism, it is imperative to revive this way of thinking. At a time when materialism and positivism are seen as the touchstones of rational discourse, the spiritual worldview may seem incredible. Nevertheless, an intellectual conversion is possible, in which case it will be understood as the most sane and intelligent view. Since Julius Evola consciously attempted to tie European idealism to Hermetism, his system of magical idealism is worthy of study.

For more background, I suggest reading through *The Science of Peace* by **Bhagavan Das**⁴, reviewed by Evola⁵. He connects Advaita Vedanta to German idealism, particularly Fichte.

Macrocosm Whenever some people hear of “occult philosophy”, “magic”, or “mages”, they tend to shut down, visualizing something heretical, dangerous, or even satanic. However, properly understood, it is the consequence of orthodox teachings. The purpose of exoteric practices is to create certain states of consciousness, although in a spontaneous and passive way. So a particular devotion may lead to one such state or another. As spontaneous, it is experienced by the practitioner as originating from the outside.

The esoterist, on the other hand, achieves the same states in an active way, as the free act of the will. He does not oppose the exoterist, but rather understands the teachings in a very different way. This can be revisited after the commentary on Keyserling on the topics of understanding and meaning. Since the exoterist cannot understand the esoterist, he assumes

⁴<https://www.gornahoor.net/library/ScienceOfPeace.pdf>

⁵<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=6328>

there is something false about it.

Another difference is the relationship to ideas. The exoterist uses ideas more as weapons to buttress an argument or to win debates. For the esoterist, an idea is a real, active, and living force. So let's take the idea of the three worlds into consideration. Basically, it is saying that the Divine creates the order of the universe, the angelic hierarchies are charged with the maintenance of that order, and the elementary world, i.e., the phenomenal or natural world, is the result. This is the principle that the subtle rules the dense on the macrocosmic scale.

The exoterist agrees with that, but sees it as something happening from the outside, with no further relevance. The Mage, as Agrippa points out, instead understands that teaching interiorly and then strives to “penetrate” into those levels. There is certainly justification for this. Since God and the angels are spiritual beings, there is no “outside”. Either they are known interiorly or else the possibility of gnosis is denied a priori. Those who have experienced gnosis know the answer.

Microcosm The analogy of being —as above, so below— is also orthodox. So corresponding to the three worlds in the microcosm is the spirit, the soul, and the body. These are definitely experienced interiorly. And they functionally correspond to Agrippa's three worlds. The spirit rules the soul and the body. The body is not independent; the spirit and soul are the form of the body. Hence, any mage who can penetrate into the knowledge of the inner workings of the spirit and soul can then have control over the natural world as represented by the body. This can even happen spontaneously in various psycho-somatic manifestations.

The point here is not a scholarly discussion of Agrippa, but rather to come to experience these teachings from the inside.

The Thirst for Action **Theophan the Recluse** pointed out that there are three stimuli that motivate the thirst for action:

Stimulus → Object of desire

The Necessary → Duty

The Useful → Service

The Pleasant → Pleasure

He writes that there are natural and legitimate activities of the will,

which is the master of our powers and our whole life. Its work is to determine the form, the means and the degree of satisfaction to be given to the different desires that arise from our needs, and to decide on substitutions so that life may flow smoothly and bring peace and joy to the individual.

The high-functioning Will, then, will balance the natural needs that relate to the soul, the body, everyday life, and to society. Unfortunately, the Will can be dissipated and “alien things stimulate desires that are foreign [unnatural] to us: anger, hatred, envy, miserliness, vanity, pride, etc.”

Active Spirituality The last time, I contrasted two spiritual perspectives:

- The desire for worldly things
- Detachment from the world

As such, they are both passive approaches, so what happens if we flip them around as active forces. Two things result from that. Rather than being two distinct incompatible approaches, they instead become complementary.

1. The prayers for worldly successes turn into the work of the mage to penetrate the archetypal world of ideas in order to bring them into manifestation. However, the desired manifestations should conform to our natural needs arising from our sense of duty, the utility of the manifestation, and legitimate pleasures.

2. Yet, there is detachment from the world and the results of our willing as described in the fruits of mental prayer.

As Theophan concludes, all is done for the greater glory of God. The Warrior-Monk will have complete confidence that his Will is in conformity with the Divine Will and his prayers will be answered. Yet he is also detached from the world.

Posted on 2014-07-28 by Cologero

3.4 The Esoteric Path

In this case it would be better, although not absolutely necessary, for the elite to be able to take as its basis a Western organization already enjoying an effective existence. It seems quite clear that there is now but one organization in the West that is of a traditional character and that has preserved a doctrine that could serve as an appropriate basis for the work in question, and this organization is the Catholic Church. It would be enough to restore to the doctrine of the Church, without changing anything of the religious form that it bears outwardly, the deeper meaning that is truly contained in it, but of which its present representatives seem to be unaware, just as they are unaware of its essential unity with the other traditional forms.

RENE GUENON, *The Crisis of the Modern World*

Western Tradition It was Guenon's position that, at least for those at a sufficient level of development, the choice of an esoteric path was a matter of personal choice and opportunity. In **Boccaccio's** *Decameron*, which Guenon regarded as the work of an initiate in the same Tradition as Dante, there is the story of the three rings. In that tale the true religion,

between Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, was represented by a golden ring. In the tale, two identical copies were made making it impossible to tell which of the three was the true religion. There are three possible interpretations of the story.

Nevertheless, Guenon thought that the Catholic Church was the natural basis for the re-establishment of Tradition in the West. Obviously, not as it was constituted, but presuming that a spiritual elite might arise who could restore the deeper meaning contained therein. In several of his early works, he provided clues to what they may look like.

We have mentioned Guenon's writings on the Crown of Creation⁶ as the basis for metaphysics and the Social Reign of Christ as the model for social organization. This is not the place for details, but it is certainly sufficient as a sound beginning for the restoration.

Certainly, it is a sound project to investigate the Medieval period as a model since all writers of Tradition regard that age as the most recent Traditional civilization in the West. Although Guenon saw its demise in the Renaissance, Evola referred to what "every well born man considered sane and normal prior to 1789." The spiritual basis of that sane and normal time is irrefutable.

Guenon believed that the revival of Thomism following Pope Leo XIII's encyclical left out an important element. Specifically, Thomism became too dependent on Aristotle, while leaving out the more important influence of Neoplatonism, Augustine, and Dionysus. In this he was opposed by Jacques Maritain who even lobbied to get Guenon's books place on the Index while he was the French ambassador to the Vatican. Therein lies a clue to the possible restoration, which should be further enhanced with a dialog of more the more ancient Vedic teachings.

⁶<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7768>

Adoption The three Western traditions are in continuity. We have pointed this out several times: Christianity is esoteric paganism⁷, Augustine referred to the one Tradition, Dante built on Virgil. More recently, **C S Lewis**, **Valentin Tomberg**, and **Joseph Ratzinger** regarded Christianity as the fulfillment, not only of the Hebrew religion, but also of paganism.

The idea of a new people founded by a God-man was not unknown at that time and would have colored the understanding of early Christians. In his studies of the spirituality of Ancient Rome, Evola focused exclusively on a given bloodline. However, birthright was not the only means to participate in a spiritual stream. A man who had no male heir was able to adopt one into his family. From the spiritual point of view, that served the same purpose.

For example, Romulus was the demigod son of Mars; this is not totally fictional since the martial spirit of Rome certainly existed, however you want to understand that. However, Jesus Christ was the Son of a virgin and of the Holy Spirit, hence, not a particular god of a certain spirit, but the Absolute God of all creation. This started a spiritual race, not of blood, but from adoption. We become sons of God by adoption. Sons share in the nature of their fathers and are entitled to an inheritance. This is much more than mere creaturehood. In our time, this notion has been sentimentalized to turn believers into perpetual children.

Initiation Guenon insisted that a valid initiation was necessary for an initiatic path; the validity was guaranteed by an unbroken chain of initiates. Certainly, this is not sufficient since Guenon himself pointed to several Hindus and Sufis who proclaimed heterodox doctrines despite their initiations.

Evola criticized Guenon in that regard for the bureaucratization of initiation. More important than the horizontal was the vertical, so Evola

⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=7152>

proposed that there was an initiation from above. He never really identified that. Tomberg, however, wrote that all initiation is from above and is the second birth in Christ.

Thus, in the West, Hermetic groups appear and go dormant, without a visible continuity. That is so it does not become as sort of counter-Church.

Buddhism

Guenon has made a commendable effort to interpret the true spirit of Hindu culture to the West in his many works ... The form of regeneration consists not in a fusion or synthesis of the two cultures, but in the West regaining, as the result of a dynamic turn in its present trend, those springs of true spirituality through the help of the East. It would be hazardous to forecast the time of the change or the precise manner in which it would be brought about.

T R V MURTI, *The Central Philosophy of Buddhism*

However, about 20 years ago, I took Guenon's point very seriously. If it was true that there was no available initiation in the West, I searched for another, which came done to taste and opportunity. I had a romanticized vision of Tibet. There were the tales from Alexandra David-Neel, the Roerich's, not to mention the various claims of the occultists. Tibet had been the last patriarchal, hierarchical, theocratic society. Since there were a few Tibetan centers locally of different lineages, I decided to get initiated at one of them, in the tradition of the **Dalai Lama**.

So for a few years, I followed that path. It was not so different. There was a priest, an altar, flowers, incense, a rite, veneration of relics, icons, prayers, meditations, heaven, hell, and a period of post-mortem purgation. I followed the precepts of the vows, which were very much like

the Tao described by C S Lewis. A minor transgression, or “venial sin”, could be rectified by suitable prayers. A “mortal sin”, such as stealing a freight train or having anal intercourse with your wife, put you outside the sangha and could only be rectified by retaking the vows.

Nevertheless, virtually every Westerner I met told me how they had surpassed the religion of their upbringing. From a practical point of view, I couldn’t see much difference. Clearly, they were ignoring several points of the vow. Instead, becoming a vegetarian or rescuing a dog from the pound became the main focus.

I never heard anyone of them advocate the desirability of a patriarchal theocratic Buddhist state in the West. Even the Dalai Lama ended the reincarnations of future Dalai Lamas and came to prefer a Euro-style parliamentary system for any future free Tibet. Hence, it was time to leave.

Can it be said that the initiation really made any difference, beyond a post hoc, propter hoc argument? Certainly the many hours spent in meditation with mala beads and the study of Madhyamika must have accomplished something. At the very least, it was the “help from the East” that Guenon claimed was necessary.

I am not recommending this choice, since I see that the same, or more, can be accomplished within the Western Tradition. Buddhism is a paganism and thus can be superseded while absorbing its best practices and metaphysical teachings. Then there is the matter of recognizing the real ring.

Posted on 2015-02-09 by Cologero

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Cologero on 2015-02-12 at 20:54 said:

I appreciate your comments, Mr Obscure, but I need to keep making the same point over and over again. The Tradition is one thing, the current management is another. That is a distinction to always keep in mind, especially given Guenon’s claim that the current leaders are not likely

to be aware of the full Tradition. As I've tried to show, this is not an idle opinion ... Guenon did indeed try to reinvigorate Tradition. There is also the model of Guido De Giorgio with his "Vedantized Christianity" as Evola called it.

I agree with your points, but what I reject is that we have to wait for George to do it⁸. We do not need more kibitzers and complainers, but men of action. This is George's motto:

Personal notice: Danger's my stock in trade. If the job's too tough for you to handle, you've got a job for me. George Valentine.

Is that clear enough?

Cologero on 2015-02-12 at 21:03 said:

I'll iterate these points since new readers may not have encountered them yet.

Evola developed an interest in Idealism (it was the dominant Italian philosophy at the time), so he taught himself German so he could read all the German Idealists (and Nietzsche). From that, he created his own philosophical system while still a young man. He was not concerned about any "suspicion" that his system would arouse.

A second point. Do you think that God chose Joan of Arc, a young woman, to save France? Not at all. First He went down the list but all the men, one after the other, refused the task. As He neared the bottom of his prospects, she was the only one not to refuse. I bet there is a lesson there.

3.5 The Kingdom of Heaven

Church of John We've mentioned the Church of John⁹ before. There is a direct connection from John to **Clement of Alexandria**:

St John the Theologian ⇒ Irenaeus ⇒ Justin Martyr ⇒ Clement of Alexandria

Subsequently, there is this intellectual chain:

Clement of Alexandria ⇒ Origen ⇒ Gregory of Nyssa¹⁰ ⇒ Maximus the Confessor

⁸http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Let_George_Do_It_%28radio%29

⁹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-church-of-john>

¹⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=6071>

More recently, **Hans Urs von Balthazar** and **Valentin Tomberg** are representatives of the Church of John.

In this tradition, there is the distinction made between exoteric and esoteric paths. The latter is reserved to those capable of and interested in pursuing that path. The goal is gnosis. In researching this post, I listened to a youtube lecture by a theologian who really had no understanding of gnosis. He thought it had something to do with passing on a secret. If you recall, Tomberg explicitly denies that gnosis is a secret. That is because gnosis is personal knowledge and cannot be shared. However, the means to achieve it can be shared.

This is a forgotten tradition and even a forbidden tradition. Recently a super-correct person informed us that we should ignore the Fathers because they held all sorts of heretical ideas. Don't get sucked into that vortex. Several years ago, I bookmarked several pages in Volume Two of the *Philokalia*. I don't recall why, but I am providing some of the texts from those pages. Note that images involving space and time are not understood literally. Instead, these need to be understood as representing different spiritual states. The next several sections are from *Two Hundred Texts on Theology* by **St Maximos the Confessor**, written in the second century.

Eternal Mansions Here we see that the mansions are not spatial locations but rather refer to spiritual qualities.

How does the difference between the eternal dwelling places arise?

Scholars propose two options:

1. The difference is in their actual locality
2. The difference arises from our conception of spiritual quality and quantity peculiar to each mansion.

Whoever knows the meaning of “the kingdom of God is within you” and “In my Father’s house are many mansions” will prefer the second explanation. [#89]

The Kingdom of Heaven This passage illustrates several ideas very densely:

- The inner essences of created things exist in God pre-eternally.
- By knowing those essences, we reach the kingdom of heaven.

The kingdom of heaven consists in possessing an inviolate and pre-eternal knowledge of created things through perceiving their inner essences as they exist in God. [#90]

Time and the Kingdom of Heaven Once again, a dense passage.

- The arrival of the kingdom of heaven is not an event in time.
- The kingdom of heaven is not material since it cannot be observed as an object of sense.
- The distance from the kingdom of heaven reflects the inner state of the individual

The text, “The kingdom of heaven has drawn near”, does not imply any temporal limitation. For the kingdom does not come in a way that can be observed: one cannot say, “Look, it is here” or “look, it is there”. The phrase has reference to the relationship which the saints have with the kingdom, each according to his inner state. For “the kingdom of God is within you.” [#91]

The Kingdom of God This section needs to be unpacked:

- The kingdom of God needs to be actualized in each believer.
- That is achieved by clearing out all worldly distractions from one's inner life.
- Then, my false self dies and my real self lives in me

The kingdom of God the Father is present in all believers in potentiality; it is present in actuality in those who, after totally expelling all natural life of soul and body from their inner state, have attained the life of the Spirit alone and are able to say, "I no longer live, but Christ lives in me." [#92]

Quality of Righteousness We see three options for understanding the kingdom of heaven. They are all correct, since they depend on the qualities (i.e., what he has attained) of the person. From lower to higher, these are:

1. It is a prolongation of the human soul as it had existed on earth.
2. The being reaches an angelic state as we described recently.
3. The third state is for the reader to try to understand.

Some say:

- The kingdom of heaven is the way of life which the saints lead in heaven
- It is a state similar to that of the angels, attained by those who are saved

- It is the very form of the divine beauty of those who “wear the image of Him who is from heaven”.

In my judgment each of these three views is correct. For the grace of the kingdom is given to all according to the quality and quantity of the righteousness that is in them. [#93]

Gnostic Philosophy Note here the method of biblical interpretation, since this is an example of the highest level. This is a commentary on the incarnation and ascension of Jesus understood as spiritual states.

- The Logos incarnates in us as the commandments from the Father to the extent that we engage in holy warfare.
- After success in spiritual warfare, we move on to contemplation and reach gnosis.
- “Return to the Father” means achieving a transcendent intellectual state.

So long as we are manfully engaged in the holy warfare of ascetic or practical philosophy we retain with us the Logos, who in the form of the commandments came from the Father into this world. But when we are released from our ascetic struggle with the passions and are declared victor over both them and the demons, we pass, by means of contemplation, to gnostic philosophy; in this way we allow the Logos mystically to leave the world again and make his way to the Father.

Hence it is that the Lord says to His disciples, “You have loved me and have believed that I come from God. I came from the Father and have come into the world; again I leave the world and make my way to the Father.”

- **World:** this means the hard task of practicing the virtues.

- **Father:** this means the intellectual state which transcends the world and is free from all material propensity.

When we are in this state, the Logos of God enters into us, putting an end to our battle with the passions and the demons. [#94]

Posted on 2014-10-05 by Cologero

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scardanelli on 2014-10-08 at 14:58 said:

"More recently, Hans Urs von Balthazar and Valentin Tomberg are representatives of the Church of John."

For whoever might be interested, I came across an interesting article by a fellow named Kevin Mongrain entitled Rule-Governed Christian Gnosis: Hans Urs von Balthasar on Valentin Tomberg's Meditations on the Tarot. It's actually quite good for a scholarly article. IT discusses Tomberg's aims in writing MOT and how these align with the work of von Balthazar.

[Admin]The referenced text is found here: <https://www.scribd.com/doc/238193631/Kevin-Mongrain-Rule-governed-Christian-Gnosis>

Bill McEnaney on 2014-10-13 at 13:23 said:

Catholics distinguish among kinds of Heaven that "kingdom of Heaven" signifies. For example, represents the Holy Trinity's presence in a person's soul. In another, it represents the condition a disembodied soul is in when it's seeing God face to face. In still another another one, it's about a physical place that Robert J. Siscoe describes in this article.

http://www.christianorder.com/features/features_2012/features_may12.html

Fish on 2014-10-28 at 19:34 said:

Is this Church of John related to the lost consolamentum and the baptism of fire of the medieval christian heretics?

Cologero on 2014-10-28 at 20:19 said:

Not at all, Mr Fish, since there is just one Baptism. The reference is to John 21:20-25

fish on 2014-10-28 at 21:32 said:

The Gospels speak of a baptism by fire beyond that of water. This double baptism and double regeneration corresponds to the two phases of initiatic work called albedo and rubedo in Hermetism.

Cologero on 2014-11-05 at 22:56 said:

Good point, fish, but that is not a sacrament that someone can do for you.

3.6 Esoterism and Christian Mysticism

This essay was originally published by **EA**, or **Julius Evola**, under the title “*Esoterismo e Mistica Cristiana*” from the third volume of *Introduzione alla Magia*. Obviously, Evola was quite interested in the topic since the essay runs to 20 pages and he was quite familiar with the secondary literature.

Note that Evola’s critique is serious and has no similarity with the puerile critiques by some neopagans who pretend to be following his lead. Ultimately, it is unclear what he accomplished, or what he hoped to accomplish. If this critique stands as is, it is a Pyrrhic victory, more like a man sawing off the tree limb he is sitting on than anything constructive. Certainly, there is no “ancient” tradition that can meet the standards he defines here, and of the non-European traditions, there is currently only one that offers a real possibility.

On more than one occasion it was said, in these pages, that Christianity represents a religious system which, if it contains various traditional elements, is nevertheless lacking an esoteric and initiatic counterpart. In comparison with what was typical of ancient, or non-European, traditional principles, this constitutes in a certain way an anomaly and is quite far from corroborating the claim of superiority asserted by the religion that has come to predominate in the West.

As to the traditional elements mentioned, they do not refer so much to Christianity as such, i.e., as the pure evangelical doctrine, but to the

corpus of Catholicism, with relation to the symbols, myths, rites, and dogmas by which its orthodoxy is defined. Here more than a few elements also apt to draw from a higher plane and to be catholic in the etymological meaning of the word, that is, universal, assume a merely religious form and validity.

Catholicism lacks an esoterism, because there is no regular elite in its hierarchy, endowed with adequate authority that, in order to be in possession of the corresponding knowledge, is aware of the deepest metaphysical and meta-religious dimension of those elements.¹¹

Regarding the experiential side, the rather complex problem of the importance of everything that in Catholicism is rite and sacrament should be confronted, establishing both the similarity and the difference of the religious plane compared to the initiatic plane. Also at the base of a religious tradition, such as the Catholic tradition, there is a spiritual influence and its transmission in an uninterrupted chain through regular and well defined rites. Such continuity in Catholicism is centered in the so-called apostolic succession. In its principle aspect, the transmission is tied

¹¹Related to one of the “intellectual gifts of the Holy Spirit”, to the comprehension of the deep meaning of the symbols and sacred scriptures that Thomas Aquinas mentioned. That remains however a simple announcement, no concrete example of an interpretation of the type being found in Thomas nor in the other authors of the Church. In patristics, e.g., in Origen, one finds the distinction of three meanings of scriptures, corporeal (historical), psychic (moral) and pneumatic (spiritual), that last of which is to be discovered through “analogy”, with the use of a “spiritual intelligence”. Here he proposed to transform the sensible Gospel to the spiritual Gospel”, on the basis of the principle that “the Saviour has willed to make symbols of his own spiritual actions”. But in the concrete, for the Old Testament this is reduced to an allegorical interpretation that tends to make it a prefiguration of the New; and in this the last word is always the Christian mystery, where the esoteric interpretation should bring back this mystery—as the particular expression—to a metaphysical, universal, and super-Christian plane. The fact that even these authors touch so many points of Judeo-Christian scriptures containing effectively initiatic elements without even realizing it, proves that it would be difficult for them to recognize the gift of “gnosis”.

to the ordination of priests and bishops. The other sacraments, the first being baptism, are intended to recover, aggregate, and establish the individual in the traditional current, in the middle of the transformation that by virtue of the principle rites would be held to produce in his nature.

Naturally, this structure is characteristic of not only Catholicism, but is found also in every traditional form, even those not specifically initiatic. Only that in Catholicism the claim is more explicit that the rite has the effect of a supernaturalisation and a divinization of human nature¹², which otherwise, through the effect of original sin, would be corrupted and vain: whence the idea that the Christian represents spiritual man par excellence in respect to whoever is not such, and whose salvation is only in the mystical Body of Christ, which is the same as saying in the Church as community and chain formed by the rite and carried by the corresponding spiritual influence. Objectively, this claim can only serve for “internal use” and is lacking every justification. Every regular tradition can propose it with the equal right as Catholicism, because every tradition is likewise formed on the basis of an influence from above, that transforms the naturalistic element of the individual and gives rise to a new current among the forces of the world. In fact, one cannot then see where the Christian shows himself superior to the members of other traditions and has a spiritual dimension that is nonexistent anywhere else.

We need to emphasize, which often is not done, the fact that in Catholic orthodoxy the rite is conceived with the same characteristics of objectivity, independence from sentiment, from “psychology”, and even from the morality that are typical in the magical and initiatic order. That is

¹²In this regard, the expressions of the liturgy of Holy Saturday with reference to the baptismal waters are characteristic: “Deem it worthy, Holy Spirit, to make fruitful with the secret mixture of your divine virtue, this water prepared for the regeneration of men, conceived by sanctification, may emerge from the immaculate womb of this divine font, a celestial race, a renewed creature.” [This is my adaptation of the translation from the the 1962 Roman Missal, modified to match Evola’s translation, which he apparently took from **Kremmerz**]

evident in the rite of baptism, since its effect would be independent of any intention and merit of the baptized (as is quite clear with newborns); so pure in fact that the sacred quality induced in the regularly ordained priest both acquired once and for all and is not even lost in the case of moral unworthiness and also of unbelief. And the same is valid, in terms of principle, for the other rites and sacraments of Catholicism.¹³

Nevertheless, even when the conditions are present for the real efficacy of the rite, and this does not live through itself on a plane of mere devout fervor and mysticism, even when, therefore, one admits a certain non-human and sacralizing power of the Catholic rite and sacrament, one cannot confuse the order to that which is typical with the initiatic order, and even less can one think that the former can take the place of the latter. Guenon indicated the difference, in this regard, in the following terms: the religious rite propitiates a participation in the supersensible order maintaining however the individual limit, while the initiatic rite would realize that of a super-individual character; the former would aim for the “salvation” of the soul of the individual, in terms of a prolongation of his individual existence beyond death; the latter would lead instead to true immortality. The most essential difference regards however the presence or the absence of the theistic premise in the concept of the sacred. Everything that is religion, and especially Christian religion, has as limit the idea of a personal God, distinct, as such, from the creature; for it, the idea of a plane in which this distance is abolished by the supreme metaphysical identity is unknown, with which both “liberation” and initiatic “awakening” are defined.

In a complete traditional form, religion and initiation are two domains that do not exclude each other but, though remaining firm in their

¹³Strictly speaking, in Catholic theory, one even goes beyond the sign, as far as the belief in the magical power of the rite. Regarding that, it is the case, for example, for the power of “dissolving” in the rite of absolution, that would certainly suspend the karmic law of cause and effect.

heterogeneity, admit a passage from where the possibility that has religious value to a higher degree, can also assume an initiatic one. But where, as in Catholicism, that does not occur, religious rites appear in a certain way as a useless and misleading parody of initiatic rites, that sometimes almost seems as profanation, while on the experiential side, the highest peak is represented only by mysticism.

Mysticism is one thing, initiation another, this is a point as essential as it is generally unknown. The tendency to reduce the most diverse states to mysticism is widespread. There are certainly cases in which the mystic passes beyond the sphere typical of his path leading to transcendent realizations; but that implies a true metanoia and always represents an exception — even prescinding from the fact that similar realizations indicate, in such conditions, almost always a fragmentary and confused character. Besides, in Christianity mysticism is presented in a characteristic form, constituting itself almost as a closed system, where the noted exceptions are extremely rare.¹⁴ Precisely in Catholicism mysticism is presented as the simple continuation of religious and sacramental experience, and the *cognitio Dei experimentalis*, the experiential knowledge of God, that would constitute its essence, in spite of the misunderstanding to which one can be led by some expressions, remains in the domain of subjectivity and affectivity, and has little to do with pure intellectuality, with the effective destruction of human nature and real deification.

Esoteric meaning of silence and homelessness Anyhow, it will not be useless for our readers to delve deeper into this question, considering at various points the meaning of asceticism and Christian mysticism according to an esoteric valuation.

Above all we have to notice, in the history of Christian mysticism, a process of degradation in a certain way. If we refer here to the first cen-

¹⁴After the period of Greek patristics, they are limited almost exclusively to German mystics, starting with Meister Eckhart.

turies of the Church, we find in patristics not a few elements still having a connection with initiatic teachings, and that due to the simple fact that it was formed in the environment in which the influence of the traces of the preceding and co-existing mystery wisdom and neoplatonism was still alive. From Augustine on, and then with the Spanish mystics, there is a rising humanization or psychologization of Christian mysticism, which not even the Thomist stream avoids. The subject of mystical experience becomes more the soul rather than the spirit, the affective aspect prevails, and moral views take the upper hand over the ontologico-existential.

The fundamental character of Christian mysticism is passivity. According to the Thomist conception “the fundamental element of mystical contemplation consists in a passive movement of love for God, which often depends on a certain feeling of his presence”.¹⁵ It “is not the product of our activity but rather it is usually preceded by asceticism and meditation, and is normally received as the reward of one’s own efforts. But it depends on God’s initiative; and our spirit is passive in it, although it reacts vitally under the divine impulse.”¹⁶ This idea of passivity is accentuated with the theory of double grace, one called “sufficient”, tied to normal Christian life, and the other extraordinary, due to the mystical gifts of the Holy Spirit, who would permit them alone a truly supernatural development. The same arising in the soul of the love of God—which takes the place here of the fire of intellectual initiatic asceticism—is conceived as an effect of divine grace.

Some positive aspects of Christian asceticism, as preparation for contemplation, were present especially at its origins. We will note them.¹⁷

A first guideline of asceticism is isolation and simplification. It, more-

¹⁵Padre F. D. Joret, *La contemplation mystique selon s. Tomas d'Aquin*.

¹⁶*Ibid*, p. 9

¹⁷On this topic we refer to two books by Father Anselmo Stoltz, *L'ascesi Cristiana* [AC] and *La Teologia della mistica* [TM], part of the current that is seeking to revalue Greek patristics.

over, is justified in terms of analogy, with reference less to Christ than to the Father, and reflects the earlier pre-Christian ideal of "deification".

"The man, who through the gifts of grace and his continuous esoteric effort will have to arrive at resembling God, must necessarily be an image of the simplicity and unity of God. . . Little by little deification increases, man approaches always closer to the perfect divine simplicity that asks nothing outside of itself, that is sufficoent in itself. It is obvious that a theology that (like the Greek) gives so important a place to the concept of deification and that conceives God first of all according to the aspect of a single, simple being, sufficient in Himself, will have to see the ideal of Christian perfection in man completely free from all passions and tends to God reproducing in him, as far as he can, unity and simplicity" [AS]

Originally, a not different base had the anchorite as the ideal, physical external isolation, in this case having to have, therefore, only a symbolic and ritual value, hence that of a discipline limited to the training period. In a higher degree, the *extra mundum fieri*, the isolation from the world, is no longer necessary to occur materially, but only in the spirit. In that regard, Christian and initiatic asceticism can meet halfway.¹⁸

Ascetic detachment can also assume the form of *instabilitas loci* and *xeniteia*. The detachment from one's own land and from one's family or people, eschewing a fixed home, wandering, bringing oneself to foreign and distant lands—all that can likewise have a symbolic or ritual value in order to bring to awareness the idea that one is not in this world as in a definite place and in one's own country, but rather as a wanderer and an exile, not forgetting one's celestial origin and end.¹⁹ This meaning, as was noted, was very alive in early Buddhism and, we can mention, with a more special connection to the life of action, was not extraneous to the chivalric

¹⁸Cfr. Islam, which has no monastic asceticism, the concept of *zuhd*, which is not actual material renunciation, but inner detachment.

¹⁹AC, 53-60. In such visual persecutions, expulsions, and similar situations, it would be of value as extraordinary means used by God to remind us of what is our true country.

ideal in the form of the “knight errant”. One must nevertheless note that in Christianity the premise for the coherent realization of a more general meaning is missing, because Christianity rejects the initiatic theory of the pre-existence of the soul to this terrestrial life, and only with reference to this theory can terrestrial existence signify the passage of one who came from far away and again turns towards other states of being.

Christian asceticism also knows the technique of silence. “That is not only a renunciation of communication with other men, but is also a positive factor of the interior life” [AC, 62]. We know, therefore, the part that the discipline of silence had among the Pythagoreans, as well as the meaning of yogic and initiatic silence in general. In Christian asceticism almost all the practice of the more interiorized degree of such discipline is lacking, that is “being silent” not only with the spoken word but likewise with thought (Ibn-Arabi’s “not speaking with oneself”). The so-called “prayer of quiet” is known, where we meet the expression *quies contemplationis* and Saint Gregory, among the conditions for mystical contemplation, touched on freeing oneself from the noise of thought [TM, 112]. A precise and active method, in this regard, which is known in the East, however is missing in Christian asceticism. And in the monastic forms, as the anchoritic ideal is supplanted by the cenobitic ideal, more consistent with the collectivizing tendency of Christianity, as well as the liturgic element, brought to a hypertrophy, predominates over the individual discipline of silence even in contemplative orders, such as the Carthusians, the Carmelites, and the Camaldolese.

In Christianity in the state of, what we call, “silence”, one is more inclined to follow the techniques than to cultivate certain internal dispositions. The so-called “cognition of external things” comes back to that.

“It is actually the knowledge of Satan’s kingdom, in deriving the power that this exercises on the sensible world and in intuiting the true place that material things must have in relation to the divine plane. This knowledge must not remain purely speculative: it is necessary that the

soul at the same time express it in practice, i.e., that it frees itself from the disordered affect for the creature, incompatible with the life of union with God". In such regard there are those who think that such "knowing" must be received from angels, no natural and human science being able to give it to the soul. [AC, 130-3]

Initiatically, "separating the real from the unreal" corresponds to that, that are achieved essentially through lives of pure intellectuality, loosened from emotional being; the neutralization of "demonic" forces is one of its natural consequences. In the second place, always with the same goal, it is said that the soul of the Christian must know what it is before God, which would be tantamount to "being convinced of his own nothingness", freeing himself from egoism, redeeming himself from his own will". Such a discipline undergoes nevertheless the deformation peculiar to the Christian way of understanding "mortification" and the "creaturely" passive attitude. Initiatically, it is about "disidentification" and surpassing oneself as simple individual being, a surpassing, that does not come about through degradation and humility, nor with reference to the image of God as a distinct being, but rather in conceiving one's own persona as a contingent mask and in itself irrelevant in relation to the true I, almost as in the consciousness of an actor who does not confuse himself with the part that he played. In every way, these are the two principle ways through which, the knowledge of external things of oneself as individual being achieved, Christian asceticism seeks to propitiate the quies contemplationis and to not be more susceptible to inner things, or to passions and frivolous desires.

Sacramental life and initiation If we now consider the grades in Christian asceticism beyond the preparatory levels, those which are realized in it and are actually mystical, the fundamental point, which is almost exclusive of references, is the imitation of Christ on a sacramental base. Here we will omit the purely devotional and emotional forms,

which lack any value for us; that they were able to take root in active and volitive races, in general, as are the Western races, remains an enigmatic point. The mystical view that is encountered on a slightly higher plane is the following: Christ has transfigured the human nature he assumed by incarnating himself in the body of the Resurrection and Ascension. And the glorification of the body of Christ must be likewise understood in its deepest sense, in relation to the Redemption as restoration and fulfillment of the life of our body in paradise. Christian asceticism considers moreover the event of Christ as the way to glorification with reference to the restoration of the Adamic state in which the body was completely subject to the soul, and its sensory part to the spirit. And since in the redemptive work of Christ the way toward a renewed harmony between the soul and the body is passed through death, and since we must only follow this way in order to assure for our body victory over the effects of original sin, so Christian asceticism has as its central point the concept of mortification, of dying and being reborn in Christ [TM 182,183].

That was accomplished previously in the sacraments beginning with Baptism. It is believed that redemptive and sanctifying grace shared in man by baptism already contains the seed of supernatural mystical life, because one is baptized in the sign of the death of Jesus and the crucifixion of ancient man. If in baptism, the faithful imitate and follows Christ into death, and in the Eucharist the food and nourishment of new life, they would participate mystically at the sacrifice, in the resurrection and ascension: a real participation already in the mystery of the sacrament, even if it is fulfilled in a veiled, invisible way, not accessible to our experience [AC 71-79].

Therefore, the idea prevails in the orthodox Catholic conception, that there is no essential discontinuity between the sacramental life of the common believer and the mystical life: the latter should not be exceptional, it was already contained germinally in the former. The mystic, instead of leaving the seed of union with God inactive, brings its energy

into actuality to the point of realizing this union as experience [TM 44-50]. A more concrete interpretation is the following: ritual (sacramental) participation in the death and resurrection of Christ does not transform the entire man in a single blow. It is first of all the interior man (*eso anthropos*, Rom 7:22) who is to be transformed. Then the ascetic, aided by a special grace, will have to kill little by little the “law of sin” in his limbs and to prepare in that way, according to the new supernatural principle of life received, a new body, the resurrection of the flesh, physical death ultimately to would divest man from the “body of sin” [TM 39-42]. In terms of dogma, this realization is nevertheless remanded to the time of the “universal judgment”. It is not admitted that one can accomplish that in life.

We now see how one can judge the whole of this doctrine from our point of view. In this area, there is no need to emphasize that the model of death that opens the way to the supernatural order is not specifically Christian; even if it is not essential for every way of spiritual realization (because it is not claimed that this must always entail a crisis), it can have initiatic value. Specific to Catholicism is the idea that it is not an exceptional and dangerous initiatic operation, but the religious rite accessible to everyone that has a power to induce in man a supernatural quality, even if only germinally and potentially, and to produce it in a certain way from the outside, without any participation of the person, even beyond his consciousness, as is evident in the case of infant baptism.

Even if, as was mentioned, one speaks of the further actions of the grace of the Holy Spirit for mystical development, this view contains the principle of a dangerous confusion of planes. If conceived in terms of reality, death, resurrection, and glorification in the sacraments, it cannot be other than symbols and prefigurations, concealing an order that transcends the generic sacralization connected to religious life. And it would be erroneous to suppose that the Christian, having had baptism and participating in the other sacraments of his tradition, finds himself for that

reason in any position of advantage through the realizations foretold by an effective initiation. The Alexandrian distinction between the pistikos and pneumatikos, i.e., between the simple believer and the gnostic or initiate, must be maintained. Only through mystical experience can the idea fit, that is does not necessarily imply a rift, but can be an almost natural development of life which, in the Christian, is supposed to be supernaturalized by the work of the sacraments. Sacramental life, as pure mystical life, cannot go beyond a psychological, subjective or moral plane, while the initiatic life has an ontological and super-individual character. In regard to the former one can speak, at most, of sanctity, not of deification.

As for formal correspondences, through some details we can point out that baptism is a simple ritual image of contact with the "Waters" of "dissolution" in the life-principle anterior and superior to every individuation or form: experience, that in its radical, exceptional, and even dangerous character cannot obviously have any comparison with whatever is happening—even if invisibly—in Christian baptism.²⁰ The notion of the "glorified body", in which the law of death is conquered, comes directly to Christianity from the earlier mystery traditions, losing nevertheless, in the form of the dogmas of the resurrection of the flesh or of purely eschatological perspectives in the afterlife, its concrete and initiatic meaning. The scheme, actually, is already found in the rite of the *transmutatio* [transmutation] of the Eucharist: the bread counts as the body, the wine as blood and soul. The one and the other principle are transformed and when, after that, a piece of the host is united to the wine, the meaning is the joining of the transfigured soul with the body in the manner proper to the resurrection body or immortal body of Christ.

Now it would be the case of speaking truly of superstitions whenever one presumes, in the Eucharistic participation, anything more than

²⁰The Gospels speak of a baptism by fire beyond that of water. This double baptism and double regeneration corresponds to the two phases of initiatic work called albedo and rubedo in Hermetism.

a simple allegory, with effects of moral elevation and, if one prefers, of mystical rapture: certainly not that which always is taken as the furthest limit of possible accomplishment on this earth to an adept. In regard to all this, whoever has a notion of what it actually is about, would come to think of it almost a profanation.²¹

Aside from the hoped for intervention of grace, in the purview of realization, i.e., of the development and the actualization of the influences induced by the sacraments, there is no precise way recommended to the Christian. The simple subjective dispositions corresponding to the so-called theological virtues, i.e., faith, hope, and love, remain. "Mortification" is conceived in essentially moral terms, with undeserved stress on the value of everything that is suffering and "penance". Here there is actually an incompatibility with what is typical to a healthy and normal Western type of man: on the basis of the sense of "guilt" and the congenital sinfulness which every man must be conscious of, we know that almost pathological tendencies have often appeared specifically in Christian mysticism. Moreover, prayer, oration, understood as a gift of the Holy Spirit, is conceived as the fundamental power of the mystical life, to the point that ecstasy itself is considered by some as a level of it, the highest level [AC 121].²²

²¹Cfr. the article on the "immortal body" in Introduction to Magic.

²²The contemporary writer, **Frithjof Schuon**, who strove to find initiatic prospects in Christianity, believed that the active counterpart of passive participation mediated by the sacraments was (with specific reference to the Eastern Church) the practice of the invocation of the saving name of Christ. This is one of the more primitive techniques for the "killing of the manas", i.e., for the neutralization of the mental ego, analogous to the continuous repetition of the "divine Name" in Islam. Moreover, the abuse of the liturgy in the Catholic contemplative orders does not have objectively any other end. That, beyond the negative aspect, the "virtue of the name" also enables certain states of illumination, is something problematic. In every way, it is a chance event, and it is necessary to have faith in the protective actions of the sacraments in order to unwrap the possibility of an action of the most diverse extra-sensible influences, once the manas is "killed". In any case, the mystic has little way of interpreting correctly the phenom-

The gifts of the Holy Spirit, the tollhouses after death, early Christianity and mystery cults. According to **Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite**, the fundamental phases of Christian mysticism were the purgative, illuminative, and the unitive ways, a schema which, in that form, can be also be found in the initiatic path. As a reality, however, things were quite different. Therefore, concerning the first phase, Guenon's comment is absolutely correct, when he points out the confusion due to the use of the terms "union" and "unitive way" by mystics.

This union does not have the same meaning as Yoga or its equivalents, so that there is only a wholly outward similarity. It is not illegitimate to use the same word, because even in current language, one speaks of union between beings in many different cases where there is obviously no degree of identification between them, but it is necessary to take the greatest care not to confuse different things under the pretense that a single word is used to designate them both.²³

Moreover, the frequency of the use of the symbolism of matrimony for the mystical union is significant. It does not mean a unity that maintains the distinction that occurs in uniting a man and a woman, in the same way that the relationship of an "I" and a "Thou" exists in prayer, even in its highest levels. Only by analogy can one speak of a *cognitio Dei experimentalis*—experiential knowledge of God—in Christian mysticism. A condition of "eccentricity" (in the sense of non-centrality) is essential, almost without exception. That, moreover, is indicated by the term "ecstasy" which means "to go out from oneself". Initiatically, it is more

ena that occur, because it is held on an emotive, rather than intellectual, level, and the Christian devotional framework, with its various images, rather than helping him, serves instead to lead him astray.

²³Guenon, Rene: *Direct contemplation and reflected contemplation*, from *Initiation and Spiritual Realization*.

about the opposite, i.e., of a coming back into oneself, of making oneself "central", through which someone correctly spoke of enstasy, instead of "ecstasy" for the states of Yoga.

The phase of the illuminative way could induced by putting it in relation with the effects of the gifts of the intellect of the Holy Spirit that are six [sic] in the Thomist conception: namely, to be able to discover

1. the substance behind accidents;
2. the inner meaning behind the words of sacred texts;
3. the truth behind the symbol;
4. the spiritual reality behind the sensible types, i.e., behind the phenomena which appear to common experience, and consequently also the hidden effects of a cause and the hidden cause of specific effects. [Joret, *Op. cit.*, p 274]

Formally, it would be a question of powers of an effectively initiatic character, connected more or less to "intellectual intuition". But it suffices to read the same examples made by St Thomas in order to see that there is none of that, or rather that it does not go beyond a theoretic framework.

Concerning the purgative way, again with the goal of indicating the reflections of initiatic views, let us reproduce this citation:

Many writers of Christian antiquity affirm that the souls, when leaving this world, must pass through various tollhouses of the demons of the aerial region. They examine the soul to see if they can find something in it that belongs to them ... The soul is not able to continue its voyage until it has been purified from all its dross. At the same time, beyond purification, the soul is also instructed by good angels in every divine science, so that it is capable of understanding the Mysteries of God. This whole process of purification and instruction is repeated until the soul has arrived at

perfect purity and the fullness of knowledge. This gradual purification after death generally is no longer admitted by Catholic theologians in all its particulars. It was however practical to the anticipation of our asceticism that is confirmed in the life of prayer, and in such applications, the aforementioned doctrine expresses some absolutely indisputable truth. [AC, 128-129]

Now, in all that, the reflection of the mystery doctrine is quite visible, such as the Mithraic, with the passage through the septenary or planetary hierarchy, which does not have to do with the world of prayer, but with that of initiation, in which, as the same “purifications”, were often distinguished by exactly seven grades.

Other “residues” not lacking interest are the views that, in the ancient Christian writings, were about the restoration of the Adamic state, understood as prior to the goal of Christian regeneration, because in patristics they insist exactly on the continuity on the fact that one must achieve the perfection characteristic of the primordial state, by embarking on the search for the lost terrestrial paradise.

It was the ancient Christian idea, maintained moreover up until the 16th century, that this place, from which our first parents were driven away, still exists, in a higher region, inaccessible to men, unless they are helped by exceptional divine grace, as would have been the case for Elijah, Enoch, and even Saint Paul (II Cor 12:1-5). This inaccessibility was expressed with the symbolism of desolate and impassable places, equivalent to that of the angel on watch with his flaming sword or a fire zone that encircles paradise. That copies the initiatic doctrine of the “center” in its relation with the primordial state: always present from the metaphysical point of view. And the symbolism of passing through the wall of fire is not different from that of baptism of fire, referring in that way also to the theme of Hercules who achieved immortality (he ascends Olympus to marry Hebe, the perennial youth) only after the fire consumed his human nature on Mount Oeta: a theme that refers to still many others of

initiatric origin, e.g., that of a virgin enclosed in a circle of fire, who will belong to whoever can pass through it without perishing.

Obviously, in projecting it to an afterlife, the Catholic conception of “purgatory” reflects the most general theme of purification.²⁴ Moreover, there is also an allusion to the initiatic idea that paradise and the kingdom of Heaven represent two distinct “places”.²⁵

In the ancient Christian view, there was always a mingling with magic, when, once admitted that the Adamic state can be re-achieved through the other levels of mystical contemplation, they indicate the prerogatives of that state. The first is the gift of knowledge, or gnosis—through which the fact is recalled that Adam had given the animals “their names”—the name, according to the ancient conception, expressing the very existence of a thing or a being. In relation to that, St. Thomas also writes:

This rectitude of man in his original and divine institution consisted in the fact that the lower part of his being was subjugated to the higher part and this was not obstructed by the other. Therefore the first man did not find in exterior things an obstacle to pure and steady contemplation of intelligible effects, perceived by means of an irradiation of the first truth. [TM, 89]

That, however, is also related to the second gift, which is *apatheia* in the

²⁴It is said: Only who is purified through fire can enter paradise. St. Ambrose (In Ps. 118, serm. XX, 12)

²⁵TM, 25-6. Where this passage from St. Ambrose is cited: ‘Paradise is a permanent region of heaven, but it is, so to speak, the ground floor of the kingdom, the foundation on which the kingdom of heavens properly called is constructed at the summit; it is the lower region of the invisible heaven, from which the elect, each according to his own merits, will ascend sooner or later toward the different higher regions or heavens.’ In Christian terms, the distinction is also expressed by saying that the grace of Christ is superior to the grace of Adam and leads to a perfection that is beyond the ordinary paradisiac state.

most general sense of being undisturbed in respect to passion, of not being preoccupied by impulses, and of a natural sovereignty over instincts.²⁶

Cult of Mary and the initiation of the Fedeli d'Amore Moreover, according to patristics, man as microcosm comprises the entire creation, through which the dominating power possessed by man over himself is manifested likewise in the macrocosm: the dominion of man over nature is the prize of the complete victory that man brings back on himself: the hierarchical relationship established between the powers interior to man are transferred into the relationship between man and the world [TM, 84]. It is through such a way that an unlimited power over creation had been promised to the saints, according to the words of Mark 16:17-18.

And these signs shall follow them that believe: In my name they shall cast out devils: they shall speak with new tongues. They shall take up serpents; and if they shall drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them: they shall lay their hands upon the sick, and they shall recover.

It is unnecessary to point out that the premises just noted are the same as in high magic or theurgy: Agrippa and Paracelsus did not express themselves any differently. Finally, as the third prerogative of the adamic state, there is the gift of immortality, *athanasia*, “corporeal immortality being a sign and proof of the interior presence of God”. For that reason, “a restoration of the primordial state would also include the reacquisition of immortality”. [TM 82-4]

At the origins of Christianity, there was, as an echo, the ontological ideal of deification—assimilation to God and participation in his nature—as an effect of the earlier mystery tradition and it still predominated

²⁶St Augustine’s (*De civ. Dei*, XIV, 15) view is of interest, according to which at the very point in which the soul separated from the divine world, the body ceased in its turn to be subject to the soul and to obey it, and came under the state of passivity defined by concupiscence.

over the morality of faith, love, and the merits that carry essentially their fruits into the afterlife. Therefore, there were still half-closed perspectives of the type that, once the dross has been separated, tends toward a world higher than that of mysticism, and of which the world of mysticism is only a weakened and rather humanized echo.

One final point. We know the part that Mariolatry, i.e., the cult of the Virgin as "Mother of God", has in Christianity. If this cult, in its most external aspects and from the historic point of view, gives evidence of the influence that gynocratic views had in Christianity, i.e., the pre-eminence of the feminine divinized principle (Magna Mater, Gaia, etc.), as in the archaic, pre-Indo-European Mediterranean cycle, then only an esoteric assumption of it is possible. A rather unique thing, it is suggested by the same Catholic author, to whom we referred repeatedly, when he says: Mary is "the highest ideal of the ascetic", because "the ascetic tends to form Christ in the soul, to make it become the Christ bearer and the Mother of Christ" [AC 192].

Although this symbolism, itself attributable to the scope of initiation, at its base contradicts the principle of passivity characteristic of the Christian mystical way and as emphasized by the conception of the indispensability of grace (i.e., of the activity of a force that psychologically is experienced in terms of grace) for every supernaturally efficacious effort. If in Christian symbolism the Virgin is only fecundated—by the Holy Spirit—according to the initiatic symbolism the "virgin birth", it is, more precisely, the birth that has no need of external help, the endogenesis due to a pure and intact force. Kumari, the Virgin, is the "power of the will", according to a Hindu text.²⁷

Another mystical interpretation of the "Mother of Christ" is that which makes her the representation of the Church, the mother of supernatural life. [AC, 193] That is, in relation to the supernaturalizing

²⁷We note the correspondence with the expression used by Dante (Par. XXXIII, 34) for the Virgin: "Queen, who can do whatever you will".

influence that would be connected to its tradition, to its organization, and its rites.²⁸ Usually, such a point is, however, in connected with the exclusivist claim, a characteristic of Catholicism.

Mysticism considered as a development of the experience of the insertion of the individual, effectuated by the sacraments and above all by the Eucharist, into the current of divine life, and the Church, understood as the mystical body of Christ, as the bearer of this current, is the obvious conclusion that there cannot be true mystical life if not in the Church [TM 77]; and that Non-Christian mysticism, being less than union with Christ (which, evidently, is considered along the lines of an historic personality conceived as the Redeemer, not of a superhistoric and universal role model to imitate), is in fact naturalistic, if not the result of demonic influences. In such a way, we end up presuming that in the non-Christian Mysteries, there could not have been any question of true deification, but only of more or less contingent psychic states. [61-71]

The well-known principle *Extra ecclesiam nulla sulus* [no salvation outside the church] sanctions, in general, the idea that only Christian redemption could result in liberation from diabolic power, expressed as the breaking of the circle of the demonic force that surround us, while helping us to doubt its power, and that making us think that redemption in the sign of Christ and the Church is superfluous, would be the most dangerous victory that Satan can attribute of his activity [66].

We previously said that all that can only have value for Catholic “internal use”; likewise, we noted that these views have an exclusively practical justification, no different from that of exclusively analogous views that are encountered in outer, exoteric forms of most other traditions: but

²⁸As much to the form, or doctrine, as to the organization that is its deposit, the symbolism of Woman was applied in various cases in the initiatic domain. So, in the case of the Medieval chivalric initiation of the “Fedeli d’Amore”, Woman represented both “Sacred Wisdom” and one or the other organizations of that current. The passage at the active movement was often portrayed through the symbolism of marriage, or even of incest (the Woman or the Mother becomes the spouse of the initiate).

they still lack every foundation beyond the sphere of the jurisdiction of each tradition.

In relation to that, we can pose, as the last issue, the question of the extent in which, for those who have an initiatic vocation, it is useful to adhere to and join a religious tradition—specifically, to Catholicism in the case of a Westerner.

As the conclusion of the preceding examination, it seems clear the Christianity, as compared to other traditions, has a particular character. In fact, from one side it is not, like ancient Judaism or orthodox Islam, a pure religion of the “Law”, but that inner experience is important to it. On the other hand, it does not know the experiential, esoteric, and initiatic plane, so that its level is inferior to that of traditions where this plane is adequately taken into consideration. This intermediate nature of Christianity can be characterized by defining it exactly as an essentially mystical religion, which has absorbed and adapted some esoteric elements into its mysterico-sacramental form.

Now, a current that is defined in such terms has a predominantly psychic and collective, rather than a spiritual and metaphysical, character. In every way, that seems rather noticeably what Catholic tradition has become in our time, so that it leads us to think of one of the cases of entities, from which, through involution, the influences that are truly from above have in a good measure receded. But since psychic entities of that type conserved their vitality and strength through inertia, uniting itself to it, for those who have an initiatic vocation, it can serve more of a bond than as the basis for higher development. We come back to a “chain”, from which it is difficult to free oneself and whose subtle influences are difficult to control. So through the doctrinal side, there is something characteristic that even those who sincerely live out the Christian faith sacramentally and mystically are the most “taken”, the most fanatic, the most incapable of recognizing and respecting anything which is anterior and superior to their tradition and that has been realized in other equally

legitimate forms in the world and in history.

In every respect, in the case of Christianity, it must be judged that the relations between the outer religious way and the metaphysical way are minimal and that one can immerse oneself in the mystical-devotional current to the point of reaching relatively high levels without perceiving anything of the initiatic and metaphysical order. With its character of a closed system in its own way, with elements which represent only a formal, reflected image of the mystery of transformation and of deification, we would almost say “lunar”, Christianity is perhaps, among the traditional forms, the one which is least recommended to those who want to enter the “direct way”.

Posted on 2013-05-19 by Aeneas

* * *

X on 2013-05-19 at 18:53 said:

One of the most valuable articles on this site.

Such Evola is sane, not that one who talks about Nordics and Jews all the time.

Ash on 2013-05-19 at 20:09 said:

As I understand it, Evola is saying that the Traditional teachings can use the Christian and Catholic faith as a language to explain themselves, but that this language has shortcomings (elements of the sacraments, the personal God, etc). Would that be correct? It also makes sense of what he says about those revolting against the modern world: “When we appear to be destroying, we are in fact rearranging and replacing what is on the wane with higher forms, forms more vibrant and glorious.” Might one say, he is seeking a new and better language?

If so, that would be a rather heartening clarification of my understanding of the interrelation between Tradition proper and the faiths in which it manifests itself. The language of the Triune God has of course been used to great benefit in leading people to truth, but to his literal existence I have usually taken the point of view of Buddhism or the Vedanta. I rather hope we'll see Evola touch upon the person of Christ. While the Logos is central to the students of Tradition, the teacher himself as a historical figure has been less discussed in relation to the more esoteric currents within his Church.

Mihai on 2013-05-20 at 03:38 said:

There is much to combat in this article (which I am sure I have one or two years ago integrally). Right now, I do not have the time, but I will limit myself to saying this:

1. The so-called barrier between esoterism and exoterism is never as absolute and strict as it is usually claimed today. The opposite is usually true, since the degree of esoterism and exoterism are usually determined by the capacity of understanding of the one receiving these doctrines. Nor should such a schema be regarded as universally true, since it is not true in Christianity, where esoterism is the upward extension of dogma. (Of course, I speak from the point of view of human realization- the dogmas are actually the downward extensions of esoteric principles in reality).

2. There is also this procroustean bed of delimiting esoterism and mysticism. This, of course, has its origin in Guenon. However, let it be said that in the Christian East, mysticism has nothing to do with anything of a sentimental and individualistic nature as it is regarded in the West, and, from this point of view, mysticism here is the same as what Evola and Guenon mean by 'esoterism'. There is however, a problem in these authors' conception of what constitutes actual esoterism and what "mere mysticism" or "mere theology". For example, I don't see why a St Dionysius the Areopagite, Maxim the Confessor or Simeon the New Theologian should be all regarded as mere "exoteric theology", while the writings of an al-Ghazzali or ibn-Arabi as pure esoteric teaching. What exactly is the difference between these authors, even when regarding expression ?

It is clear that the fault here is to be found in the too narrow conception of esoterism as having to do with secret rites, completely separated from the exoteric dogma. When discarding this all too procroustean ideas, the truth about Christianity will appear in its true light.

There is one phrase here that is completely unwarranted :

"religious rites appear in a certain way as a useless and misleading parody of initiatic rites, that sometimes almost seems as profanation, "

Even if I were to accept as true Evola's views on Christian esoterism (or the lack of it), I don't see how an incomplete understanding can be a "parody or a profanation". To understand incompletely means to not derive the full efficacy or benefices from a doctrine. A parody is the subversion of a doctrine for nefarious uses.

Evola is so focused on what he calls esoterism and initiation that he goes so far as to think that everything religious is simply useless or of limited appeal and only good enough for the masses.

My question is: when one strives for the highest peaks, doesn't that same one have to, first, climb through the simple roads at the base, before reaching the barren cliffs at the top ?

To strive for a higher realization does not mean to reject what the masses are doing, but to surpass it. If one cannot even do as much as the "mere exoteric" does, how can one legitimately have pretenses to esoterism ?

Graham on 2013-05-20 at 20:57 said:

"the effective destruction of human nature and real deification"

This stood out to me. "Real deification." The Christian theologians I've read, the few who mentioned the possibility of deification or divinization, always take care to clarify and limit, to stipulate in what sense deification is achievable, in a way that the traditionalists don't. I might summarize the difference as 'participation' versus 'identification'. It could be a difference in perspective, theological speculation and metaphysical realization, or (for argument's sake) a limitation in Christian theism itself, as Evola maintains. I don't know. I do see it as a stumbling block in the Gornahoor project, when the Christian deification is equated with Sankara's "atman is brahman"; it seems facile, but I could be wrong. The recent entry on the Thomistic doctrine of Personality was stimulating.

Now to the other part of that sentence that struck me, "effective destruction of human nature." This is characteristic of Evola's style, and it's what the younger just-post-Nietzschean me found attractive about him, this pungent contempt bordering on hatred for the human. Today it strikes me, distinctly, as heretical, perhaps Nestorian or Apollinarian, and definitely smacking of false Gnosticism. Christ himself has human nature. That Evola would choose to speak of the "destruction" of human nature, instead of its purification through grace, to my mind suggests a malady. Correct me if I'm wrong.

Graham on 2013-05-20 at 21:15 said:

To clarify, I was speaking of heresy in a 'pan-traditional' sense, and attempting to apply the specific heresies mentioned in a metaphysical sense with respect to deification, rather than with respect to the historical person of Christ. So if there's a heresy that holds that Christ had no human nature, but only a divine nature coupled with a human body, this Christology has obvious implications for deification; on the other hand, the Catholic doctrine holding that Christ had both a divine and a perfect human nature suggests a deification which Evola deems somehow insufficient.

August on 2013-05-21 at 00:32 said:

One might object that there can be no heresies in a metaphysical sense, within which domain one is free to exert his will to the extent of his capability, up to 'identification' if one's power allows it. This seems to be the spiritual attitude of the warrior that is often ascribed to Evola.

Specifically, this attitude might smack of heresy because it suggests that God, or Pure Being if you like, is not something entirely fixed and active, and is only a certain 'domain'. within which manifold beings aspire to take possession of a great power. This is problematic for those who conceive of Being as culminating in a personal, theistic way.

Mihai on 2013-05-21 at 03:31 said:

"is not something entirely fixed and active, and is only a certain 'domain' within which manifold beings aspire to take possession of a great power. This is problematic for those who conceive of Being as culminating in a personal, theistic way. "

This is plainly luciferian non-sense, regardless if we conceive the Absolute as personal or impersonal. Read the Hindu Upanisads- in no way do they suggest that Brahma can be conquered through individualistic will-power and a Promethean attitude.

Come to think about it, not even the gnostic heresies or any kind of heresies for that matter claim this. The only possible exception to this may be some of the most degenerate tantric sects.

On the other hand, I really have come to ask this, since all too many traditionalists take this for granted : why is an impersonal conception of Deity "clearly" superior to the personal one ?

"This is characteristic of Evola's style, and it's what the younger just-post-Nietzschean me found attractive about him"

Yes, same here. And it is precisely this reason why Evola is such an excellent bridge between the abyss of nihilism and the plains of Tradition.

August on 2013-05-21 at 06:03 said:

You seem to misunderstand slightly, yet your critical attitude is welcome, so I will try to explain better.

There is no question of conquering Gods, let alone doing so through individual will. Rather, it is about achieving an equivalent existential status, and thereby establishing oneself (one's Personality) as the center of a whole state of being. What else is meant by complete freedom in the context of initiation? For this to be possible, the principle of Being cannot be equal to Brahma, or the particular God of any tradition, so long as that tradition ascribes any characteristics to God other than pure Being, which is the potentiality of the indefinite possibilities of formal states. Hence, beyond Brahma there is the Supreme Unity, Brahman, because Being is not the Infinite.

As for me, I do not necessarily consider an impersonal conception of the Deity as superior to the personal; the reason I consider them both is because both must have their place. If the impersonal conception were senseless, or impossible, there would be no need to consider it as it would not be true. If it is true, it must be taken into account, and an objection based on preference does not free us from this fact.

Ash on 2013-05-22 at 15:52 said:

Perhaps we should consider the effect having a personal theistic God would have on the formulation of a doctrine of apotheosis. In my mind, it would probably be heretical to say

that the human ego is identified with the persons of the trinity or their essence. It would not be to say that the divine element of Being that is the foundation of all states of existence, including human existence, is identifiable with the Godhead. That is, not the person of God but rather the transcendent reality which the personal God puts a face on. A christian would need to differentiate between these meanings, leading to different definitions of words like "identification."

Cologero on 2018-05-19 at 21:32 said:

There is a way out of the impasse. The first step is to recognize a knowledge path within Catholicism. We are commanded to "know, love, and serve God", i.e., the three traditional paths of jnana, bhakti, and karma yoga. Pace Evola, there is a path of divine union, not just the duality he mentions. E.g., St. Catherine of Genoa hints that the Self is God.

Moreover, Gornahoor has followed the suggestion in note [4]. That accounts for the emphasis on the Fathers (via the Philokalia) and the stream inaugurated by Eckhart, in particular, Ruysbroeck and Jacob Boehme.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-26 at 21:16 said:

Catholicism is incompatible with what is "healthy and normal" for the "active and volitive" Western man.....and what is the source for Evola's characterising Western man this way ? Nietzsche doesn't count as the man had no transcendent knowledge so why repeat his prejudices ?

The dismissal of Schuon strikes me as very superficial. I've spoken to hesychasts and they told me that actively repeating the Jesus prayer does induce a transcendent state, it's not a mantra. And also the hesychasts have methods for recognising false and deceitful visions.

Cologero on 2013-05-26 at 21:56 said:

Well, Jason-Adam, as Guenon pointed out in a letter to Guido de Giorgio, Evola was full of prejudices. That is unfortunate, given his otherwise brilliant insights. Evola, apparently, was not so concerned with intellectual coherence. For example, he referred to the time before the French Revolution as "healthy and normal". Were the medieval knights not healthy and normal? Painting with such broad strokes does not produce any art.

Even if the hesychasts are at a "low level", that is still much higher than anyone else. Evola included, since he was never initiated into anything.

Mihai on 2013-05-27 at 03:21 said:

The problem, it seems to me, is the terminology employed. Since the Eastern Church (as did the One Church in the beginning of Christianity) describes its methods, disciplines and knowledge as mystical, and Evola identifies "mysticism" solely with what came to prevail in

the West under this name- that is individualist and spontaneous achievements of an admittedly sentimental and subjective nature- he comes to the conclusion that the Jesus prayer must be nothing more above this sentimental and subjective experience.

He clearly had no direct insight into the mystical teachings that have been kept here until the modern times, he probably had no adequate knowledge of the Philokalia- and this is proven by the fact that he doesn't once cite a given Church Father, but only modern authors talking about the Fathers, so his conclusions in this area are terribly superficial.

Mysticism means here something that resembles his definition of esoterism- and I say resembles, because even his definition of esoterism is somewhat strained and certainly only includes a portion, not the whole of what used to be 'named esoteric' knowledge throughout history.

Mihai on 2013-05-27 at 03:27 said:

"Even if the hesychasts are at a "low level", that is still much higher than anyone else. "

True, and I would even go further to say that even doing nothing but the 'external' discipline of going to church and receiving the Sacraments is still better than doing nothing but stand in front of the computer screen and complaining on 'traditional' forums of how the West, because of Christianity, has lost all contact with esoteric knowledge- much like the pseudo-traditionalists of our days are doing (not surprisingly, many being affiliated to the new-right).

Logres on 2013-05-27 at 13:51 said:

"The Alexandrian distinction between the pistikos and pneumatikos, i.e., between the simple believer and the gnostic or initiate, must be maintained."

Certainly agree with this; lately, reading Ousepensky's *The Fourth Way*, and certainly (for myself, and perhaps other believers) would agree that there is a danger in Christianity today of assuming that one "knows" when nothing of the kind has happened, when the individual has merely transferred illusions to another plane. If there is a danger of giving in to a "higher" illusion, that danger can be obviated by efforts not to succumb to further illusions. The danger, inherent if any, could come merely from institutionalizing those tendencies to illusion in the forms and sacraments, which certainly goes on, but can still be obviated by the individual, if they are being guided in that Tradition by a higher spiritual impulse. There are many resources, within the Faith, to aid in that possibility. I don't think blaming Catholicism or Christianity in toto, as Evola dances about the possibility of doing, flirting with it, so to speak, serves a constructive purpose in and of itself.

Logres on 2013-05-27 at 13:54 said:

F. Seraphim of Sarov, for example, is spoken of in the Eastern Church, as actually having transcended monasticism, and gone back into the world. Isn't there more than a "trace", here,

of recognizing that the journey doesn't end in mystical absorption into God?

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-27 at 17:01 said:

Evola strikes me sometimes as getting close to schizophrenic – I mean here's this guy who's an admirer of De Maistre, Cortes, De Poncins, who says the pre-1789 world is the healthy one, yet then he's also into Dadaism, Beatniks, Crowley, is anyone seeing a split mind ?

Mihai on 2013-05-28 at 03:23 said:

Not really, but, admittedly, he does have problems identifying genuine spiritual knowledge from counterfeits. For example, he cherry-picks some interesting bits from Crowley found here and there in his doctrine, but he doesn't see the big picture in all of this: namely that Crowley was, in the end, just another occultist whose system is no more than pseudo-spiritual syncretism with certainly lots of material that strikes me as of sinister origin.

(By the way, when I enter the facebook account for Gornahoor, I see a Crowley picture at the top: I believe it harms the mission that Gornahoor has set for itself and attracts all sorts of unwanted individuals).

In his first volume of the Introduction to magic, there is some material written by antroposophists, which (the material) is certainly filled with occultist concepts.

I think Evola was one of those individuals who feared getting past and leaving behind certain initial steps (such as Nietzsche) of fear of contradicting himself.

scardanelli on 2013-05-28 at 12:53 said:

Well said. Your response, I think, sums up the entirety of Evola's problematic relationship with Christianity. It seems that both he and Guenon largely ignored the Orthodox church, and i've often wondered why this is.

There seems to be competing ideas of Orthodoxy as Eastern Orthodoxy, meaning a cultural phenomenon, and Orthodoxy, meaning the true, historical, ancient form of Christianity. Perhaps the former conception made it possible for them to overlook Orthodoxy. The more I learn, however, the more I tend towards the latter, though I do feel a certain sense of loyalty to Catholicism.

August on 2013-05-28 at 16:49 said:

Evola considered the world to have suffered a schizoid event, namely the consolidation of modernity as negation of existing traditions without inauguration of a new one. He did not consider this to be a mere cultural change, but a 'concrete' event of cyclical transition that affected the world and man on many planes; not absolutely, but deeply enough that only 'esoteric' penetration offered a real escape, whilst even religions had been more or less tainted. Much of this, of course, derived from Guenon, and summarized by Nietzsche as the 'death of God'.

Evola thought that the gravity of the change was such that new, modern man could no longer be accommodated by the structures of yesteryear, hence his intrepidity in exploring late modern expressions of this novel atmosphere and its resultant existential turmoil, whilst recognising the fundamental health and normality of the prior traditional forms and the absolute principles they protected.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-28 at 17:38 said:

August your explanation of Evola's thought is very good and I agree with your analysis. Do you think it is possible though for someone to make himself a man of a prior age ?

August on 2013-05-29 at 03:13 said:

Hi Jason-Adam, here is my comment, feel free to explain your question further if my interpretation is off.

A movement toward his primordial center may be undertaken by a man, along which path he may certainly recover the memory of what it was to belong to a prior age, particularly the essential part, and those ages that are to him directly ancestral.

Yet, this is not the same as making himself that prior man, for his point of departure is inevitably the modern form, that very manhood that could not but emerge after the cosmic shift described above; at least some part of this modernity, even if only the memory, will likely remain a part of his soul.

In any case, the recovery of primordality is an internal movement, and while its effects may be reflected on the outer man, the individual as such remains what he is within the world in which he manifested.

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-29 at 14:16 said:

I can only speak for myself but within me I have always felt that I do belong in this world and I want to live as far apart from it as I can; the more I come into contact with the degeneracy that is modern life I get very angry and want to destroy it all. That is why, before I became aware of Tradition, I was attracted to punk – the pure hardcore nihilist punk to be exact – but since becoming aware of Mediaeval civilisation I do feel an instinctive attraction to it, I feel as if I belong in the Middle Ages. When I first read old works of chivalry, I immediately desired to become a knight, a desire that has not left me at all. That's why I feel alienated from most Traditionalists equally as I do from moderns because they do not share my values and beliefs, which are those of the crusaders. I do feel at home around SSPX circles but those people tend to be of a more intellectual bent whereas I want to take those beliefs and fight for them. Can I be the last Christian warrior ?

Jason-Adam on 2013-05-31 at 13:54 said:

Evola seems to be engaging in nit picking over words – what he should be doing is actually trying out both yoga and Christian mysticism to experience for himself the differences and similarities.

The part about the gifts of the Holy Spirit according to St Thomas is the clincher of this piece – Evola admits that theoretically St Thomas is speaking about initiation. We can ignore the judgements he makes afterwards but aside from a personal prejudice I see no reason why one can not use Aquinas as a pathway to realisation.

Another issue is Evola is so opposed to any notion of a God apart from the Self, but that is a belief not only to Christians but also to Muslims. Evola's self-focus seems to me to be based on modern teachings. It sounds similar to Crowley.

Mihai on 2013-06-01 at 15:50 said:

"for the simple (though disturbing to religious exclusivists) reason that a part of him quite clearly saw beyond the specific theology and form of God in Christianity."

Actually, in regards to Christianity, Evola never saw beyond anything, because, like I mentioned in the comments to a previous article, he was totally unaware of the most profound doctrines of Christian mysticism, as preserved in the East. At best, he considered some of their points here and there, but he considered them as somewhat "copied" from other more ancient mystery traditions, as if Christianity were no more than some fragmentary bits collected from here and there and artificially put together.

In other words, his view of Christianity was quite profane, and the fact that he only cites for references some book of a modern scholar, and never some actual material of Patristic writings, proves that he merely wanted to be done with the thing as quickly as possible, since it never constituted any interest to him.

Regarding some other parts of your post, it is really a good time to put into question an issue which many people take for granted (serious seekers, not only pseudo-esoterists): namely that an impersonal Absolute is somehow superior to the Personal. This is really a mere arbitrary postulate without any serious support, since "impersonal" is a negation of the person, making it something less, not something more.

Anyway, both these conception of the Absolute, and Evola's understanding of "genuine" initiation is an attempt to fit all spirituality into the procroustean bed of what represents the view of just some spiritual "schools", mainly the Vedanta.

The same point can be made, in some measure, about Guenon as well.

Mihai on 2013-06-02 at 16:20 said:

There is here something clearly contrary to any genuine esoterism, and contradictory to what they have, otherwise, tried to point out: namely that Truth is ineffable.

Guenon wrote somewhere that logical relationships are inseparable from ontological ones. Which means that abstract logic can in some measure point us the way as long as we are on the plane of Being. Beyond-Being points to something which is beyond all ontology and, as such, and with which no logical methodology is co-extensive. You can guess from this how coherent Guenon is on this score.

As such the rationalistic schema above is completely null and void because it tries to fit the Infinite into the limited conceptions of human understanding. It seems to me that, to the traditionalists, Truth must adhere to some verbally constructed schema. Also, I sometimes really ask myself: since it is so easy to talk about the Absolute in logical terms and since the human mind alone can reach and understand in such simplistic concepts the ultimate realities, I really am not sure what we have symbols, myths and mystical methods for.

This, of course, has nothing to do with genuine apophatism, nor esoterism or higher wisdom, but is only the result of modern prejudice which always feels the need for a radical simplification, in order that the individual may feel comfortable and secure, with a formulation that the mind by itself is able to grasp.

In the Christian East apophatism is taken to a whole new, dynamic level. In complete adherence to the ineffability of God, the Patristic writings do not attempt to resolve the supreme Mystery of God on the plane of human reason and logic. In keeping true to the apophatic spirit and to genuine esoterism, or mysticism, the only claims they make of God are antinomian, mutually exclusive formulations: God is Three and One, the Three are equal, yet the Father is supreme etc. It is here a Mystery which transcends all notions of human coherence and before which the human mind finds itself on slippery ground, completely impotent before the Ineffable- and this is the kind of experience which human weakness detests, hence the tendency of simplistic rationalizing.

If we look at the history of different heresies regarding the Trinity, we can see at their origin the same tendency- the attempt to reduce the real Mystery to the simplistic conceptions of human logic.

The same goes to the Christian idea concerning Divine Personality, which should be understood not as a limitation, but its very opposite.

(By the way, Guenon's claims that the Absolute manifests because it is a possibility, so it simply must manifest. I really wonder what "kind" of Infinite we are talking about here, when manifestation simply bursts forth from it mechanically, without it having any control and certainly without any intelligence involved. Such a notion of the Absolute is even inferior to what we humans are capable of).

Besides this, I see in this insistence on impersonalism and the optionality of "adherence" to the personal, Self-revealed God, which is somehow inferior compared to some verbally constructed abstraction, not the slightest trace of any perennial wisdom but actually another manifestation of modern prejudice, where human personality is dissolved into the atomism of an

impersonal and mechanistic universe and where the individual has the satisfaction of holding on to this individuality all the while claiming that he is above all paths and doctrines, because he sees "beyond" such "petty human concerns" and therefore succeeds in getting rid of the danger of actually having to face his own ego and let go of it through real submission to spiritual discipline.

As far as I am concerned, all this is only an excuse to do nothing and take no spiritual path seriously while pronouncing "infallible" judgements on whether this or that author is esoteric or not, or if Christianity, a religion for the masses, actually deserves even the slightest glance from such "elitists" as themselves. (And in this whole paragraph I have been referring not to the traditionalists as such, but to their pedantic followers who are plaguing the internet these days).

Like I said, I have profited and still profit immensely from the writings of Guenon "and friends", but I do not slavishly follow them on every issue. When Guenon says one thing and a most reputed Father says something different, there can be no question regarding my allegiance- and this because I really take Guenon's work seriously.

Graham on 2013-06-02 at 23:55 said:

Hopefully I will have more time to engage this essay soon. The first thing I find noteworthy is that Evola's evaluation of Catholicism here is more favourable, and far more nuanced, than that of some of his contemporary followers. Evola evidently deems Christianity rich in esoteric symbolism, connected at its origins with genuine initiation into the greater mysteries, and calls it a traditional form (if with qualification). This is all very far from any 'strong Nietzschean' readings of his works.

Otherwise, I still think it's possible that Evola suffered a certain spiritual pride that affected his notion of deification, entwining it with a wicked fantasy of the 'destruction of human nature' (and didn't Mircea Eliade remark the same thing?). Self-evidently, then, anything that smacked faintly of 'sentimentalism' or 'mere humanity' – such as the theological virtues, the devotions of certain mystics and saints, or perhaps the Johannine symbolism of God as Love – was taken by him as proof of spiritual inferiority. While fully accepting the superiority of intellect to feeling, might this contempt not be the projection of a man, preoccupied with erasing his humanity, onto a type that instead sought its purification and integration – devotion, sentiment and all?

Matt on 2013-06-03 at 17:48 said:

I've always considered Evola's statements on the destruction of human nature to be read in the Shaivite sense; human nature/human state isn't "destroyed" but transcended.

Now deep down Evola might not have meant that, but at least from reading his writings, that seems to be what he meant.

3.7 The Cross and the Eagle

The Secret Language of the Fedeli D'Amore by **Arturo Reghini** (Pietro Negri) originally appeared in *Introduction to Magic*, volume 2.

Arturo Reghini, **Guido De Giorgio**, and **Julius Evola** each tried to recapture the ideal of the Roman Tradition in a different way. For example, where De Giorgio saw in Dante the amalgamation of the Eagle and the Cross through a development, Reghini, as a pagan, Mason, and Pythagorean, sought to cleanly separate the two. In this essay, Reghini, as did **Rene Guenon**, counts on the work of **Luigi Valli** to explicate the hidden meaning of **Dante's** Divine Comedy, not to mention the group of poets known as the **Fedeli d'Amore**.

Reghini reveals that the object of Dante's "love" is really the Divine Sophia. He brings up the ideas of the active and potential intellect, a topic of great interest at that time in the Middle Ages. Astute readers will be able to relate this to the meditation formulated by **Valentin Tomberg** in the second letter, which we have mentioned several times. Reghini also points to an interesting correspondence with an idea from the *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*.

Several years ago **Luigi Valli** published *La Chiave della Divina Commedia* [The Key to the Divine Comedy] in which, proceeding successfully along the interpretative line divined by Foscolo and then followed by **Gabriele Rossetti**, Perez, Pascoli, and a few others, he succeeded at highlighting thirty agreements between the Eagle and the Cross in the sacred poem and finds, at least in part, the doctrine hidden under the veil of the strange verses [delli versi strani]. The thought exposed and simultaneously hidden by Dante would be, very synthetically, this: The Cross showed itself impotent to redeem in fact humanity and cannot redeem it alone. The involvement of the Eagle is necessary, i.e., for authority and

imperial justice, it is necessary to reestablish the Empire, take away from the Church the unfavorable donation of Constantine; the corruption of the Church and humanity will then certainly have an end, thanks to the double virtue of the Cross and the Eagle and it will actually be able to save itself. Dante proclaimed openly that on the cathedral of Saint Peter stood the unworthy usurpers, the preachers of gossip, who did not possess the genuine intention given by Christ to his first monks; and he covertly added that on the chair of the Church was seated the apocalyptic whore, he recognized the failure of the preaching of the Cross and the necessity of the intervention of the imperial Eagle to save humanity. This bold, and for certain not very orthodox from the Catholic perspective, conception inspired not only Dante's writings but also his action, understood as carrying out his program first by means of the armies of the **Templars**, and then of the Emperor.

Following logically the thread of these studies, Luigi Valli next published an extremely important, interesting, and powerful volume, entitled: *Il Linguaggio segreto di Dante and dei Fedeli d'Amore* [The Secret Language of Dante and the Fedeli d'Amore]. The first centuries of Italian literature and all the history and the battles of those times are the object of this study, and are presented under a light and an aspect that even now is unsuspected and unexpected. With a patient, methodic, scientific, and imposing work, Valli, resuming the misunderstood and neglected work of Rossetti, confirms and demonstrates the existence from the beginning of Italian literature of a secret language, the jargon of the Fedeli d'Amore; he deciphers its meaning, the numerous doctrinal, sectarian, and political allegories and brings back into the light a whole grandiose movement, inspired by the "initiatric tradition" and bitter enemy of the Church of Rome.

Unable to even succinctly summarize the events of this great battle, we will only say how, through this understanding, the poets of love, the writer of the "sweet new style", who strangely seemed to lose themselves

singing of their absurd, self-conscious and inconsistent love, are transfigured into formidable battlers, into ardent champions of their Holy Faith. They dramatically tower over all the most noble figures of Cecco d'Ascoli and Dante Alighieri, who are greater, the more they are understood. We express to Luigi Valli our admiration and our recognition; his work constitutes, as we intended to point out, a "piece of gelatin", and as much against it as the myopic and lazy misoneism and "positive criticism", the vestal of pure aesthetic, and the shrewdness of the curious, has coalesced, the light is by now made and will end up by standing out.

The love for which the heart of Fedeli d'Amore was burning, is similar to the mystical love of Persian literature and that of the Song of Songs. Gabriel Rossetti reconnected it above all with Platonic love, which would give a pagan character to the movement. Valli demonstrates that the "rose", the "flower", the "woman", (1) which is under various names the only object of this love, is the active intellect, that loves of itself the potential intellect (2): it is, as Dino Compagni sings:

L'amorosa, Madonna Intelligenza	The lovely Lady intelligence
Che fa nell'alma la sua residenza	Who makes her home in the soul
Che co' la sua bielta m'ha innamorato	Who with her beauty enthralled me

To the accumulation of the proofs that Valli discovered or brought back in this regard, more of them could be added; this, for example: Dante from the principle of the Comedy speaks of the

Divina potestate	The divine power
La somma sapienza e il primo amore,	Wisdom in the Highest and Primal Love

He places his "love" in a triad that corresponds perfectly—in the Kabbalah—to the triad of the highest sephiroth: Kether, Chokhmah, Binah, or the Crown, Wisdom, Intelligence.

If this is the woman, the domina, of the Fedeli d'Amore, it is perfectly logical that Francesco da Barberin in his Documenti di Amore puts docil-

itas, docility (from *docere*, to teach), first among the twelve virtues that Love must awaken in the novices. The tradition that puts this docility among the first requisites of initiation is transmitted down to us, as is shown for example by what Arturo Reghini writes on pages 106-108 of his book on the *Parole sacre e di Passo* [Sacred Words and Passage]. Even the world discipline has the double meaning of science and constraint; and the German *gelebrig* corresponds through its polysemy to the Latin *docilis*.

The transmission of the secret language of the Fedeli d'Amore in that of later sects and movements was recognized, in addition to Valli and before him, by Rossetti and Aroux, who actually pushed too much on this way and were sometimes led astray by the intent of wanting to recognize the concordance between the various sectarian jargons; but the concordance undoubtedly exists in part, and leads to posing the problem of the transmission, not of only sectarian jargon, but of the same traditional doctrine.

We, too, with Valli, believe that Rossetti, the first systematic discoverer of the sectarian jargon of the Fedeli d'Amore, was led to his interpretation by the knowledge of ancient secret traditions. If memory does not fail us, his *Mystery of Platonic Love in the Middle Ages* was dedicated to B. L., which is very plausibly **Bulwer Lytton**, the author of *Zanoni*, who, beyond having a profound esoteric erudition, was also an expert on Italian language and literature. One could perhaps think that Rossetti was inducted and initiated by Bulwer Lytton into the systematic study of the sectarian medieval jargon, a study happily taken up by Valli, who succeeded in emending, extending, and completing the results achieved by Rossetti in the last century.

We saw that Love is the "Active Intellect"; it is, as Dante says in the last verso of the *Comedy*: "The love that moves the Sun and the other stars". In the potential intellect of the Fedeli d'Amore this active intellect is awakened and operative, in the profane it is sleeping and inoperative.

According to Valli, in the sectarian jargon, sleeping consistently means to be in error, to be far from the truth and in particular to belong to the Church of Rome. It is the symbolism adopted by Dante in the last cantos of the *Purgatorio*, in which after the immersion in the river Lethe, the river of the dream and oblivion, the immersion into Eunoe follows, by virtue of which, like a new plant (neophyte) with renewed frond. Dante becomes pure and ready to jump to the stars, that is, capable of rising to the “kingdom of Heaven”. As we noted, it is about a pagan symbolism adopted by Virgil and Plato, and that is found again in the very old Orphism and in the Eleusinian mysteries; here at the river Lethe, which sweeps away the knowledge of men, is in contrast to the fresh arising of Memory or the mnemonic virtue of the pomegranate, that gives awakening and immortality. The Platonic anamnesis, the record, is identified to the consciousness and correspondingly the truth, the *aletheia*, and is the negation, the passing of Lethe. The attainment of the truth is a conquest of consciousness above the dream and death; it is necessary to maintain the continuity of consciousness even through the dream and death.

Love in the initiatic sense has therefore the capacity to take away the dream and death, giving to the Fedeli d’Amore a new life. That is reached through degrees of successive development.

The Arrow and the Rose

In the concluding part, Reghini points to several other Hermetic symbols found in **Dante** and other writings of the **Fedeli d’Amore**. These include the Arrow, the Rose, the Rebis, the Azoth, and the Phoenix. Finally, he mentions the significance of the analogical or spiritual meaning of such texts, which simply cannot be understood by those not prepared for it.

In **Francisco da Barberino’s** *Documenti d’Amore*²⁹ [Documents of

²⁹<https://archive.org/details/DocumentiAmoreEgidiVol1/page/n18/mode/2up>

Love], the Fedeli d'Amore is represented in the first degrees as pierced by the arrow of Love and in the last degree with some roses in the hand. The symbolism of the arrow is also found in one of the twelve figures of Basil Valentine's Azoth³⁰. But the similarity between the symbolism of love and Hermetic symbolism and the link between the two traditions again turn out to be shown more through the presence of the Hermetic Rebis in one of the designs that illustrate Barberino's Documents of Love. The Rebis, or Hermetic androgyne, is a characteristic and very important Hermetic symbol, whose history we briefly treated in another work, *Un codice alchemico italiano*; the figure of the Rebis reproduced by Valli goes back to Dante's time and is older by several centuries than what we tracked down in the books on Hermetism.

Other concordances with the symbolism and Hermetic terminology are found in the verses of an obscure poet of love, **Nicolo dei Rossi**, who in one of his lyrics expresses "the degrees and the virtue of true love". There are four degrees: the first is called liquefatio which is opposite, says dei Rossi, to congelazione. The second degree is called languor, the third zelus, and in the fourth, love reaches the hierarchical summit by means of ecstasy or excessus mentis. We understand therefore how one of the most important works of the literature of Love, the Romance of the Rose, (whose Italian version, *Il Fiore*, is due to a Florentine named **Durante** who is almost certainly **Dante**), treated alchemy explicitly and is classified in the alchemical literature. This rose sung with such moving harmony by all these poets, starting from **Ciullo l'Alcamo**, the dantesque rose candida, is clearly similar, if not identical, to the Hermetic rose of the Rosicrucians.

An important confirmation of this assimilation and affinity between Hermetism and the Fedeli d'Amore is given here by the four so-called "Templar degrees" of Masonry which arose in France or in Germany to-

³⁰https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Basil_Valentine
https://www.alchemywebsite.com/prints_series_val_azoth.html

ward the middle of the 18th century. It is about the Princes of Mercy, called also the Knights of the Sacred Delta, and also designated in another way. Their task, says the ritual, is

to guard with fidelity the treasure of traditional wisdom, always concealing it from those who do not know how to penetrate into the third heaven.

The third heaven is the name of their temple and is, as everyone knows, the heaven of Venus. We note moreover that in Orphism and Pythagoreanism, the third heaven is the last. **Philolaus** in fact says that there are three heavens: Uranus, the Cosmos, and Olympus. The third heaven, Olympus, is the home of the gods, and Saint Paul referred to this Orphic-Pythagorean classification when he told of having been raptured to the third heaven.

Now the “intellect” of **Dion Compagni**, writes Valli,

stays in a palace where different locations represent probably degrees of initiation, and in that palace the third place is the salutorio ... referring us back to the frequent allusions to the third heaven or the third degree, that in the material heaven is the heaven of Venus, but in the symbols signified rather probably the worship or a higher degree of his initiation.

The Princes of Mercy by means of their triple virtue succeed in lifting up the veil of truth; and are therefore called *beni emeth*, the sons of Truth. Among the characteristic symbols of the degree the Palladium of the Order appears, or the statue of Truth, naked and covered with a tricolored veil. These three colors that reappear in the decorations of the Temple and in other symbols of the degree are green, white, and red, the three Hermetic colors with which Dante adorns his Beatrice (*Purg*, XXX, 31-33).

The numeric symbolism of the degree is based on the number three and its powers: the sacred or luminous Delta is one of its principle symbols. The word emeth, truth, contains three letters, the first, the middle, and the last of the Hebrew alphabet. Its numeric value is 441, or nine. On the throne are nine lights. In the temple are nine columns, each one of which bears a candelabra with nine lights or in all there are 81 lights. The age of 81 years is the ritual age. We will not dwell on recalling the importance Dante attached to three and nine, and with the frequency the number nine recurs in the *Vita Nuova*: Valli relates some verses in which **Giacomo da Lentini** proposes that “the mercies are strict... nor by the lovers called finally who completes nine years”.

As to the number 81, Valli already reported the following strange and bold passage from Dante that he writes precisely in the *Convivio*:

Plato, from whom one can very well say that he had matured ... living 81 years ... And I believe that if Christ had not been crucified and had lived out the span which his life, according to its nature, might have passed from the mortal body into the eternal in his eighty-first year (IV, xxiv)

that is, if he had reached the ritual age of the Knights of the sacred Delta. Naturally Dante in the *Vita Nuova* had Beatrice die in the ninth day of the month of June in 1281; and he took care to specify that in Syria the month of June is the ninth, and that Beatrice was dead when “the perfect number was completed nine times” in the third tenth century, or in 1281.

Among the symbols of this degree that are reconnected to the symbolism of the “Fedeli d’Amore” we note again the arrow that was on the throne of the Most Excellent (the president of the chamber), that is obviously the arrow that Francesco da Barberino puts in the hand of Love in the first figure of his *Documents of Love*. This arrow is of white wood and has feathers colored partly in green and partly in red, with a gold point.

Another symbol of the degree is composed of two arrows, the two arrows of the Love of tradition, one of gold, the other of lead: the two arrows of the dantesque lyrical poem: "Three women have come around my heart". For fuller information about this topic we refer to the Manual of **Andres Cassard**. And finally it is necessary to note how the sole Phoenix, about which there is a continual mention in the poetry of the Fedeli d'Amore and that, as Valli shows, represents the organization and the initiatic tradition always being reborn, either one or the other of the most important symbols of Hermetism, the symbol of the Rubedo. The purple Phoenix is reborn and lives among the flames of the "philosophical fire", as the Fedelt d'Amore, burning with holy zeal (the *zelus* of Nicolo dei Rossi), is reborn to new life by means of the *excessus mentis*.

Numerous other comparisons could be established between the sectarian jargon deciphered by Valli and the symbolic languages of the Hermetists, among the symbolism of the doctrine of Love and of similar and derived movements; comparisons that indicate a clue and perhaps a proof of the existence and continuity of an initiatic tradition that arose in the Middle Ages. Unlike Valli, we however have several reservations about the purity of the Christian character of such tradition.

When one begins to recognize the existence of a "false appearance" in a secret organization, beginning by degrees, it is right to doubt that if love and a noble [gentile] heart are one thing, the word "gentile" can also have the meaning that it has in latin: *sangue gentile* [native blood]; and if Dante takes from Virgil the beautiful style, Virgil can also represent pagan initiation. But we will have the chance to return to these problems; for now, we limit ourselves to note how Boccaccio, who, Valli shows us, glorified the Templars, the same Boccaccio, author of a Genealogy of the Gods in the tenth story of the Decameron, makes jokes of the resurrection of the flesh, typical, i.e., of that same teaching that the Athenians mocked, saying to Saint Paul: "we will hear you about this another time". We recall, in regards to Boccaccio, that in his third story

he has Melchizedek say that between Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, "no one knows which is the true faith". That Boccaccio puts phrases of this type even in Melchizedek's mouth, who occupies a position of the first order in tradition and in the esoteric hierarchy, is something that can make us reflect and can make us suspect what was the only Phoenix that with Zion joined the Appenines, as a sonnet says that goes under the name of Cino da Pistoia.

One final observation: in our earlier writing on the Knowledge of the Symbol, we had the chance to cite a passage from the *Convivio*, in which it shows how, according to Dante, the meanings to consider in the allegorical language were four, corresponding perhaps to the four degrees of the rite and of the organization. Of these four meanings, the most important for us, is the last, i.e., the anagogical meaning. Naturally this spiritual meaning, which is related to the process of spiritual development, cannot be understood and sometimes simply imagined, without the personal experience of it: who does not experience it, cannot understand it, says Dante. And it is for this reason that it almost always eludes those who up until now were occupied with secret language of the Fedeli d'Amore, unlike the meaning that we will call synagogic.

For example, to sleep means allegorically to live in ignorance, in the inertia of the intellect; morally, it means not to participate in the work of the organization; anagogically, it is the state opposite to that of initiatic Awakening. Valli thinks that, while the *Vita Nuova* was written in code, Dante abandoned in the *Comedy* the sectarian jargon; but if this is true, in part at least, through its moral or political meaning, since in the sacred poem the hostility against the Church is explicit and even extreme, it is not true for the anagogic meaning. This meaning is still and necessarily hidden under the veil of symbolism, in order to interpret it, it is necessary to possess the experience of the stages of consciousness to which it refers, and the knowledge of the symbols traditionally adopted to indicate them. For this reason, the true and higher meaning of the secret

language of Dante and of the Fedeli d'Amore remains and will always remain a mystery to all those who "sleep" and will continue to sleep.

Posted on 2013-04-06 by Aeneas

* * *

David on 2013-04-06 at 22:22 said:

Few things. First, when they speak of potential intellect, is this in the same vein as Eckhart potentiality ? Second, what is the link between Dante and the Templars ? Thirdly, everything about this is more than welcome; it is very interesting and I would like to hear more between Dante and Virgil, Fedeli d'Amore and esoterism. Thank you for the translation.

Cologero on 2013-04-06 at 22:45 said:

The active intellect is a teaching from Aristotle. There was a lively debate leading up to Thomas on this topic, particularly from the Islamist philosophers Averroes and Avicenna. It is a large topic and the Catholic Encyclopedia, the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, and Wikipedia are some resources. Of course, we would be more interested in the esoteric meaning, which is why I mentioned Tomberg's second letter. That can be read as the active and passive intellects. The next question is why that is described as "Love". This topic will come up again when I review a book on the relationship between the ideas of Thomas Aquinas and Dante, something which seems to have eluded Reghini.

Jason-Adam on 2013-04-08 at 14:54 said:

It is possible to interpret this differently without resorting to paganism – one can see Dante as Dugin does as campaigning for the restoration of the Roman-Byzantine symphony of powers between the Pope and the Emperor that the harlot (the post-schism papacy) broke by trying to usurp the imperial rights. I do not share this view but am mentioning it just to show the variety of possibilities.

Cologero on 2013-04-08 at 20:17 said:

Reghini's attempt to "prove" its paganism is off base. Aside from the obvious fact that no pagans are rushing to incorporate Dante, there is the other uncomfortable (for Reghini) fact that much of Dante's Divine Comedy is related to Persian and other Islamic sources. The name "alchemy" itself is of Arabic origin. Without going into all the details at this time, Rene Guenon's two essays on Valli's book, included in "Insights into Christian Esoterism" should be consulted

alongside Reghini's essay. Rather than marking a sharp departure from the spiritual tradition of the Middle Ages, Guenon's conclusion is more rational:

Dante's work, far from being contrary to the spirit of the Middle Ages, is one of its most perfect syntheses, in the same rank as that of the cathedral builders; and the simplest initiatic facts enable us to understand without difficulty that there are very profound reasons for this correspondence.

Cologero on 2013-04-18 at 23:02 said:

During the journey, which lasted thirteen days, the Magi took neither rest nor food; they did not feel any need, and this period seemed to them not to last more than a day. The nearer they came to Bethlehem, the brighter the star shone. It had the form of an eagle, flying through the air and moving its wings. Above it was a cross.

(From the Apocrypha, book ii.)

argusandphoenix on 2019-04-08 at 21:20 said:

Dante just grows and grows as an iconic figure. Thank you, sir.

Cologero on 2020-04-06 at 07:44 said:

Saint Bernard is the link between Dante and the Templars.

Graham on 2013-04-09 at 18:32 said:

It seems like it is advisable to read the Comedy and the Convivio together, to understand the symbolism of Beatrice – perhaps with Guenon's volume near to hand.

Then again, if Reghini says one needs experience of the higher states of consciousness in order to comprehend the anagogic meanings, then all this reading could be futile.

How does one approach an initiatic text? Is there a method for reading a text in its depth? Something akin to *lectio divina*?

David on 2013-04-11 at 20:52 said:

I am nowhere near being able to answer your question, or even understand in depth the Divine Comedy; but I think we cannot forget the sheer beauty and motivation of such a text (I'm not talking about pure emotionnal esthetics or poetry, but rather the drive to attain those

states). I think those texts were written in part for this; if not, what reason is there to describe something only other people who attained them would be able to understand? It's like telling someone his own name. To me those text were both written as a fact and a motivation; but mostly as the bridge between both of them.

Cologero on 2020-08-14 at 07:24 said:

Dante relied on the following texts that describe the path to higher states of consciousness.

Richard of Saint Victor, *De Contemplatione*

Saint Bernard, *De Consideratione*

Saint Augustine, *De Quantitate Animae*

For a review of *De Quantitate Animae*, see *The Greatness of the Soul*³¹

3.8 Dante's Contemplation

What is a worse punishment than always to will what will never be and to be constantly opposing what will always be? ... The soul will never have what it wants and will endure forever what it does not want.

BERNARD OF CLAIRVAUX

Besides **Saint Augustine's** *De Quantitate Anima*, **Dante** relied heavily on two other works. One is *De Contemplatione* (On Contemplation) by **Richard of Saint Victor** and the other is *De Consideratione* (On Consideration) by **Saint Bernard of Clairvaux**. Moreover, it was Bernard who guided Dante to Mary and then to the very Vision of God. The Paulist edition of St. Bernard asserts that "Dante chose Bernard as his spiritual guide", as though it were an arbitrary literary device. But those who know, understand that it was Bernard who chose Dante. Follow the path described by Bernard and then you will see.

³¹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=12616>

Contemplation In his letter to Con Grande³², explaining the proper interpretation of the *Divine Comedy*, Dante asserted that in contemplation, the intellectual soul is raised to the extent that it transcends human kind. Richard of St. Victor is claimed as a witness to this state, along with Bernard and Augustine. Richard mentions the three ways of thinking: Cogitation, Meditation, and Contemplation. He describes them like this:

Cogitation rambles indifferently here and there in a haphazard way, without regard for the outcome of its rambling. Cogitation creeps. Cogitation involves no labour and brings no fruit. Cogitation issues from imagination. In cogitation is prone to aimless wandering.

Meditation strives with great assiduity, often over a harsh and difficult ground, to reach the end of the road. Meditation walks and runs. In meditation, there is labour and fruit. Meditation issues from reason. In meditation, we scrutinize. It is an eager and persistent effort of the mind in searching and finding out; or a steadfast and careful speculation of the mind passionately fixed on the search of truth.

Contemplation is, with admirable agility, borne up in its free flight, wheresoever inspiration carries it. Contemplation arises from intelligence. Contemplation is an unlimited clarity of the mind, suspended in admiration at the sight of wisdom. Thus, it is an unrestricted, all-embracing penetration of the mind into those things, which are to be comprehended.

These are the three sources affiliated with those ways. **Intelligence** holds the highest place, **imagination** the lowest and **reason** is in the middle. Every notion, which is subject to the inferior mode of thinking, must also be subject to the superior one. It follows that ideas, grasped by imagination, and many others above them, are grasped by reason as well. Similarly, those that are apprehended by imagination or by reason, as well as those that reason and imagination cannot apprehend, submit to intelligence. See

³²<https://faculty.georgetown.edu/jod/cangrande.english.html>

then how widely the radius of contemplation expands, how it embraces and lights up everything.

Back to the epigraph: **Imagination** fantasizes a future that will never be. Even worse, it fantasizes a past that could have been, but never was. The solution is to evaporate such fantasies under the bright light of consciousness.

Reason, on the other hand, when it is dissatisfied with what is, tries to think of an alternative. The dream of reason is to resolve all the questions of life through philosophy, science, drugs, psychological therapies, five-year programs, “new” deals, and so on. Although it may ameliorate some harsh conditions of life, the fundamental human problems of ignorance, malice, concupiscence, and death remain intractable.

The second punishment, which arises from reason, is to rue and lament what actually is. The antidote is abandonment to divine providence, or nihilism.

Intelligence is a higher order thinking that transcends the human state. The mind becomes clear, the soul is set at ease, and the intellect has a direct grasp of reality.

Consideration

The greatest of all is he who spurns the use of things which the senses can perceive and goes up not by steps but in great leaps beyond our imagining: he has learned to fly to the heights in contemplation at times.

BERNARD OF CLAIRVAUX

Prior to the greatest consideration, which is the purest, there are two others, one powerful and the other freer. Bernard gives names to the three types of consideration:

1. **Practical:** It makes use of the senses and the things the senses perceive in an orderly and coordinated way, so as to please God.
2. **Scientific:** It wisely and carefully searches into and weighs the signs of God's work in the world.
3. **Speculative:** It retires into itself and, as far as God helps it, frees itself from human affairs for the contemplation of God.

Although each of the forms is suited to those in his particular station in life, the third is the fruit of the other two, which otherwise meander aimlessly without the third in view. There are three ways to pursue knowledge, from the lowest to the highest:

1. **Opinion.** Opinion claims no certainty because it tries to discover what is like truth, rather than to grasp it directly. It considers something to be true that is not known to be false. Eight centuries before Karl Popper, the Scholastics understood that opinion could not be proven true, but only falsified.
2. **Faith.** Faith is a certain voluntary and confident foretaste of truth not yet apparent. However, truth is hidden and obscure.
3. **Gnosis.** Gnosis is a clear and certain grasp of something unseen. Gnosis not only grasps the truth, but knows that it is the truth.

Opinion is necessarily provisional, but to believe something false is ignorance. Faith has no doubt, otherwise it is opinion. When it is true, faith is still a mystery, since it lacks gnosis. Then you know something, you seek no further; otherwise, it is not true gnosis³³.

³³Bernard goes on to suggest some topics worthy of contemplation. The first of those is the hierarchy of angels, which has special relevance to the *Divine Comedy*. That will be addressed in a post in the near future.

Our happiness will be complete when what is already certain to us will be as plain as it is certain.

Posted on 2020-08-23 by Cologero

* * *

Lee on 2020-08-24 at 02:19 said:

No, I would say the concept of gnosis is ultimately outdated. First of all that is a semantical maneuver that makes the concept appear more appealing than it really is. Secondly, advances such as pragmatism show that gnosis ultimately leads to error. For instance, as pragmatism states, there are contradictory claims within gnosis itself. For instance the yin and the yang comes in contradiction with the angelic hierarchy, which comes in contradiction with the law of attraction. Ultimately transcendent claims should be attempted to be rationalized as much as possible. This allowsallows for the most room for original work. how can the yin and the yang possibly be true given the contradiction with the sciences. This is one of the strengths of modern idealism. Once you allow for gnosis you cut off the Publics can rationality which can be dangerous. The modified argument is that gnosis can never be used never to contradict another theory. You need the give up the critique of posterior reasoning as given by Kant.

Cologero on 2020-08-24 at 05:15 said:

It's outdated, Lee? So when will your opinion be outdated? Can you predict the most compelling argument in the year 2525, if man is still alive?

Dennis on 2020-08-24 at 10:14 said:

"advances such as pragmatism..."

Thanks for the laugh Lee...needed that on a Monday morning!

James on 2020-08-25 at 02:02 said:

The seeming "contradictions" in gnosis is not at all a bad thing . It is part of the task of attaining gnosis that one is able to experience the synthesis of contradictory things . This is attested to by the highest reality: God + Man . The Source of All Life + Death . An instrument of torture , death , and humiliation + paradise , everlasting life , and glory . Three is One and One is Three . A creature being the Mother of the creator . The universal + the particular . Eternity + Time .

The exercise of being able to understand seeming opposites is , in fact , the initiation from above because it is from above that everything that rises converges (to quote that beautiful

Mystic Flannery O'Connor as she herself gets it from Teilhard de Chardin). To be able to retrace the rainbow back to the pure white light .

Contradictions , at least in the sphere of gnosis and not simply the cult of chaos , is actually a participation in the creative act of the universe and of man . For creation is the synthesis of two seemingly contradictory things: nothingness and being . Chaos and Order . Choice and Divine Will . This is why in order to start on the path to gnosis , one must first find that "rapport between individual effort and divine reality" as a dear friend once said . It is the ability to calmly , and in silence , attain to the "marriage of opposites" . As man and woman as seeming opposites unite , so does a new life come forth .

"The ying and yang" being in contradiction to the "hierarchy of angels" might only seem contradictory when looked upon in purely materialistic terms . One might even say that it's not even fair to say that they are contradictory in exoteric terms ! One need only understand the purpose of each . French is no more valid of a language than English even if English has two words for Beef and Cow . The language may be different , but the meaning might be compatible . They are only inappropriate exoterically in the same way that if one is invited into the house of a host , one should have the courtesy to eat *his* food rather than attempt to override the cook . Nothing is wrong with the food of either (so long as it is conducive to health , of course) , but it is a matter of congeniality that one acknowledges the benefits of the other .

Transcendent claims can indeed and have been for the longest time rationalized . This has never been in dispute . An ant crawling on the inked manuscript of Shakespeare's sonnets reduces the ink to "this is a dangerous chemical , i shall not step on this" without any idea that it is some of the greatest lines in English . I do not begrudge the ant for believing that . Her instincts have served her well . She may be the very best ant in the colony .

I congratulate you on taking the time to warn the other people of the dangers of transcendent thinking , Lee . After all , the organism needs feet as much as it needs a heart and and eyes . We should be wounded as creatures if our feet attempted to pump blood or our knees attempted to "see" . Thus , I encourage you to maintain your vigilant adherence to reduction . It will serve all of us well if that is your true vocation in our society and are incapable of any other type of thought . I look forward to offering you complex logic puzzles to solve so that the rest of us don't have to worry about such tasks .

You believe that originality can be attained by divorcing ourselves from higher thought (or at least convincing ourselves that there is no such thing as 'higher' thought) . I do not know what you consider to be the definition of "originality" .. and I also do question if originality as the end is truly conducive for the humanity of a person , but it does not matter . I'm afraid you cannot save Cologero . He is too far gone . Better to try with others who are more willing to be productive reductionists . Too many of us here are obsessed with , as Oscar Wilde might put it in his *Picture of Dorian Grey* , "quite useless" things . But I thank you for your service to our society .

Matt on 2020-08-25 at 17:51 said:

"Secondly, advances such as pragmatism show that gnosis ultimately leads to error." Error flows from knowledge? Is this some attempt at a Zen koan?

Santiago on 2021-11-16 at 15:37 said:

One of the most useful summations I have ever read.

3.9 Esoteric Scholasticism

The first man was of the earth, earthly: the second man, from heaven, heavenly. Such as is the earthly, such also are the earthly: and such as is the heavenly, such also are they that are heavenly. Therefore as we have borne the image of the earthly, let us bear also the image of the heavenly.

1 COR 15:47-49

Scholasticism is in the highest degree a product of human ingenuity. In it the logical faculty celebrated its greatest triumphs. One who aims to elaborate concepts in their sharpest and clearest contours should serve an apprenticeship with the Scholastics. It is they who provide the highest schooling for the technique of thinking. They have an incomparable agility in moving in the field of pure thought.

RUDOLF STEINER, *Eleven European Mystics* (GA7)

Dear Unknown Friend, do not scorn mediaeval scholasticism. It is, in truth, as beautiful, as venerable and as inspiring as the great cathedrals that we have inherited from the Middle Ages. To it we owe a number of masterpieces of thought — thought in the light of faith. And, like all true masterpieces, those of mediaeval scholasticism are beneficial. They heal the disorientated, feverous and confused soul.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot*

Scholasticism deals with the most important concepts such as God, the soul, freedom, immortality, salvation, good and evil. The foundation for thinking begins with the seven liberal arts: grammar, logic, rhetoric, arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy. Compare that to the stunted interests of philosophers nowadays.

Although knowledge begins with the senses, it is incomplete until the idea is known. Otto Willmann described the Scholastic process to higher understanding:

Our spirit, associated with the body as it is in earthly life, is primarily directed toward the surrounding world of matter, but **focused upon the spiritual in it; that is, the essences, natures, and forms of things**, the elements of existence which are akin to it and provide it with the rungs by which it ascends to the supra-sensory. The field of our cognition is thus the realm of experience, but we should learn to understand what it offers, penetrate to its sense and idea, and thereby open to ourselves the world of ideas.

Ultimately the goal is self-knowledge, not merely the image of his self. Karl Werner warns about being satisfied with the latter rather than the former.

In time man has no perception of his self, the hidden foundation of his spiritual nature and life; ... he will never be able to look at himself; for either, forever estranged from God, he will find in himself only a bottomless dark abyss and endless emptiness, or he will, blessed in God, and turning his gaze inward, find only God, Whose sun of grace shines within him, and Whose *image* reflects itself in the spiritual traits of his nature.

But **St Augustine** understood that the actual God image in man is Christ rather than that self-image. The God image is in the *anima rationalis*,

the intellectual soul, which distinguishes the human from the beast; in effect, then, it is supernatural, not natural. He elaborates:

The God-image is within, not in the body. ... Where the understanding is, where the mind is, where the power of investigating truth is, there God has his image. ... where man knows himself to be made after the image of God, there he knows there is something more in him than is given to the beasts.

That sums up the Scholastic project. Start with the understanding and work up to the concept of God. That is the path of the intellect. Then follow up with the Mystical Impulse.

The Mystical Impulse I cannot express this better than the Unknown Friend:

No more is it true that the mystical impulse from the end of the thirteenth and into the seventeenth century was purely and simply a reaction against the “dry intellectualism” of scholasticism. No, **the flowering of mysticism during this epoch was the fruit and the result of scholasticism.**

St. Thomas towards the end of his life arrived at mystical contemplation of God and the spiritual world and said, on returning from this ecstasy, that his written works now appeared to him “like straw”. Indeed, he wrote nothing after this. The believing thinker thus became a seeing mystic. And this transformation did not take place in spite of his work of scholastic thought, but rather thanks to it—as its fruit and its crowning glory.

Now, what happened to St. Thomas Aquinas also happened to a group of individuals who formed the crest of the wave of scholasticism. Just as St. Thomas, through scholastic reasoning, arrived at contemplation, so did part of advanced scholasticism arrive at mysticism, i.e. at the *aim* of scholasticism, which is *intuition* or **the state of union of faith and intelligence.**

Renaissance Mystics Valentin Tomberg mentions three mystics in particular:

Meister Eckhart, Ruysbroeck, or, lastly, St. John of the Cross are spirits amongst whom you will search in vain for a spirit of opposition to scholasticism. For them also it was true that scholasticism was "like straw", but they knew at the same time from their own experience that this straw proved to be an excellent combustible. They certainly surpassed scholasticism, but they did so by attaining its aim. **For the aim of scholastic endeavour is contemplation, and it is mysticism which is the fruit of the scholastic tree.**

Rudolf Steiner has a similar point of view:

One can therefore interpret the activity of the mystical theologians Eckhart, Tauler, Suso and their companions by saying: They were inspired by the content of the teachings of the Church, which is contained in theology, but had been reinterpreted, to bring forth a similar content out of themselves anew as an **inner experience**.

The following list combines suggestions from Tomberg and Steiner. The recovery of esoteric or mystical Scholasticism is the antidote to the scientific mechanistic dualism that passes for knowledge today.

- Meister Eckhart
- Johannes Tauler
- Heinrich Suso
- Jan van Ruysbroeck
- Nicolas of Cusa

- Cornelius Agrippa
- Paracelsus
- Valentin Weigel
- Jacob Boehme
- Giordano Bruno
- Angelus Silesius
- St John of the Cross

Posted on 2020-07-14 by Cologero

* * *

Adil on 2020-07-15 at 10:55 said:

And there goes the myth of dry scholastic intellectualism, that “mysteriously” and supposedly paved ground for atheism (according to some commentators).

Michael M on 2020-07-16 at 09:41 said:

@Adil

Perhaps the opening of mysticism is just “too much” to recognize for moderns considering the scope of the effort to produce such an effect in the World. Incredibly hard to verify, we specifically lack this higher quality tied to overcoming the discursive intellect. What is typically the argument those commentators make? Are they just seeing their own image in the Scholastics? Maybe given that Man now doesn't see his true image as a reflection of God but of the highest truth as man, he can only look back and see himself in all things.

Adil on 2020-07-16 at 12:09 said:

Michael M

I've heard the argument circulate in some Eastern Orthodox corners of the net. They seem to push forward that the 'backwards' empirical reasoning of Aquinas from sensory input to God would leave this First Mover bereft of any positive characteristics (circumventing the mystical), thus begging the question for the rise of atheism. The opposite conclusion of this article, which

claims scholasticism laid the groundwork for mystical integration. Which was indeed confirmed by Aquinas's own breakthrough.

"Maybe given that Man now doesn't see his true image as a reflection of God but of the highest truth as man, he can only look back and see himself in all things."

It seems this is a corruption of the Christ impulse, in which spirit seeks to realize and transform itself through man – but backfires in solipsism and egotism. The only mystical breakthrough in such a state is that of the temporary intoxication.

Cologero on 2020-07-16 at 17:09 said:

I don't know about those corners.

Empirical reasoning from phenomena would look more like a design argument, which Thomas rejects. From the senses, you then develop an understanding of essences. Not at all "empirical". And there is indeed some positive content.

If God is not the Unmoved Mover, then that means he is not changeless.

If God is not the First Cause, then He must have had some help to create the universe.

That's an odd argument from those corners since they deny the possibility of the knowledge of God's essence. Actually, Thomas is not all that distant from Palamas, since he also denies that possibility (at least in this life). Hence, we can know God only through his "activities", which is the Latin equivalent of the Greek-derived "energies". (the root Act in Latin translates the Greek erg). If those are not empirical, what exactly are they?

Adil on 2020-07-18 at 04:44 said:

I believe the problem such an Orthodox critique posits is precisely that there is no direct experience of the divine in this world. That is, since according to Thomistic divine simplicity, God's nature cannot be divided, the essences turn into mere 'phantoms' of God's mind, which is ultimately unknowable. Therefore, there is a fundamental gap between God and this world, which can't be directly penetrated by the uncreated divine grace. This, supposedly, would be fertile breeding ground for atheistic ideas as well as de-sacralizing nature and leading further into Protestant dualism. More generally, I believe it's a critique of Aristotle's "materialism" (denial of the pure realm of forms).

Cologero on 2020-07-21 at 07:33 said:

Divine simplicity is also accepted by the Orthodox. Aristotle is not a materialist. He emphasizes the immanent aspect of "forms", while Plato emphasizes the transcendent aspect. There is no "realm of forms" unless you have a better geography book than mine; the forms are in the Mind of God. If there were a "direct experience of the divine in this world", then scientists would have discovered it.

The conclusion is, as we point out in this essay, that Thomas provides a “fertile breeding ground” for a direct, mystical intuition of God. However, it is necessary to follow the path and not be distracted by pseudo-intellectual side trips.

3.10 Christian Gnosis

In which we review *Christian Gnosis: From St. Paul to Meister Eckhart* by **Wolfgang Smith**.

3.10.1 Introduction

St. Thomas Aquinas was not the only one. Just as he arrived at contemplation through scholastic reasoning, so did the peak of the scholastic wave reach gnosis [*mystique*], that is to say, intuition or the state of union of faith and intelligence, which is the aim of scholasticism. A **Meister Eckhart**, a **Ruysbroeck**, the Admirable Doctor, a **St. John of the Cross** are in fact spirits amongst whom you will search in vain for a spirit of opposition to scholasticism. For them also it was true that scholasticism was “like straw”, but they knew at the same time from their own experience that this straw is an excellent combustible. They certainly surpassed scholasticism, but after having attained its aim. For the aim of scholastic effort is contemplation, and it is gnosis [*mystique*] which is the fruit of the scholastic tree.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Letter XIX The Sun*

The idea of a Christian gnosis is not widely accepted. That is as it should be, since gnosis is not something that can be taught but must be experienced. It is not necessary for salvation, so it may be safely ignored if it means nothing to you, and it should be ignored. Nevertheless, there are some who are called to follow the path of gnosis.

If you are not convinced of the existence of a Christian gnosis, there are resources you can turn to. *Knowledge & the Sacred* by **Seyyed Hossein Nasr** is a near encyclopedic compendium of gnosis. *The Transcendental Universe* by **C. G. Harrison** deals with specific issues of Christian Gnosis. Finally, *Christianity: Dogmatic Faith & Gnostic Vivifying Knowledge* by **George Heart** deals with the transmutation of faith to gnosis.

Here, we will review *Christian Gnosis: From St. Paul to Meister Eckhart* by **Wolfgang Smith**. Unlike other men of Tradition who accept a more or less universal gnosis, Smith will show that a specifically Christian gnosis goes beyond what other sapiential traditions can offer. He bases this on the doctrine of the Trinity, especially as it appears in Meister Eckhart.

We can but point out the highlights of Dr. Smith's book, and we do it with the following goals in mind:

- To encourage you to read Dr. Smith's book yourself
- To encourage you to read the saints and sages mentioned by Smith
- To encourage you to follow the path of gnosis yourself, if you are called to it

Paul

Woe to you lawyers, for you have taken away the key of gnosis: you yourselves have not entered in, and those that were entering in, you have hindered.

LUKE 11:52

Smith announces his intent

is to understand, as clearly as we can, what gnosis is, and what role it plays in the perfection of Christian life.

First of all, he justifies the notion of “gnosis” against the prejudice against it. As Christ points out, the “legalists” are those who take away the key of gnosis. On the other hand, there is a gnosis that “puffs up”, and another that is “knowing as we should.” (1 Corinthians 8:1,2)

The issue is simple: gnosis is for the few (1 Cor. 13:8-10), it is the “meat” of doctrine, not the “milk”. Hence, it will be hidden from most, who then will plausibly deny its existence. St Thomas Aquinas defines gnosis this way:

As God works miracles in corporeal things, so also he does supernatural wonders above the natural order, raising the minds of some living in the flesh beyond the use of sense, even up to the vision of his own essence.

Clement Smith then refers to **Clement of Alexandria** as the “expositor par excellence of gnosis”, since he embodies both the wisdom of the Greeks and the gnosis bestowed by Christ. Clement refers to an *oral* tradition that came to him directly through the Apostles (*pace* Sola Scriptura). Hence, Clement admits that some things cannot be written down.

Clement describes the qualities of the “perfect man”, which bears comparison to the “true man” of Taoism. Such a man is “impassible”, i.e., transcends the movements of pleasure and pain, fear and desire, and so on. He is in a state of “gnostic love”.

Clement describes a conversion, a *metanoia*, that happens in the “twinkling of an eye”. The conversion is to a divine vision characterized by the negation of duality. Smith draws out the consequences of nonduality. Nonduality is not a “monism” like the night in which all cows are black. Rather gnosis is to be united to God while ignorance or disbelief is to be separated and divided.

Vedanta Besides Christian gnosis, Smith acknowledges three other traditions of gnosis: **Kabbalah**, **Tantrism**, and **Vedanta**. We discussed

Tantrism earlier when reviewing Oscar Hinze. The Vedanta, according to Smith, constitutes the oldest *living* tradition of gnosis. Therefore, there are ultimately two choices for doctrinal gnosis: the Christian and the Vedantic. Doctrinal gnosis is what can be spoken about, bearing in mind that true gnosis is beyond words and thoughts.

Without dismissing the Vedanta, Smith denies that Christian gnosis is merely a form of the Vedanta. Rather, it likewise is nondualist, yet the Trinitarian aspect adds a new dimension that is not reducible to the metaphysics of the Vedanta. Nevertheless, the encounter with the Vedanta is providential. The goal of that encounter is not to borrow from Eastern sources, Rather it is an anamnesis, a remembering of what had been forgotten.

The Kabbalah embodies the oral transmission pertaining to the Mosaic Revelation, providing access to the esoteric sense of the Torah. Smith devotes two chapters to the Kabbalah, concluding with its Christian development.

3.10.2 Cosmology and Christian Kabbalah

None of the things which are comprehended by the senses or contemplated by the mind really subsist; nothing except the transcendent essence and cause of all.

ST. GREGORY OF NYSSA

As fire is concealed by smoke, as a mirror by dust, as an unborn babe by the womb, so is Knowledge concealed by ignorance.

Bhagavad Gita III.38

So far, **Wolfgang Smith** focused on the beginnings and the justification for a Christian Gnosis. Later on, he will deal with **Jacob Boehme**

and **Meister Eckhart**, culminating in the notion of a “Trinitarian Non-Dualism” vis-à-vis the Vedantic conception.

The middle chapters of Smith’s book prepares the ground for a deeper understanding of Creation, the Incarnation, and the Trinity. First of all, Smith explains his cosmology. We won’t need to linger on this, since it has been thoroughly covered in more detail in his books on the metaphysics of science. His contribution to the field is his interpretation of quantum mechanics that is consistent with traditional cosmology.

Smith then puts himself in the stream of the Hermetic tradition by reliance on the Christian Kabbalah. He explains the insights of Pico della Mirandola³⁴, Johann Reuchlin³⁵, and Egidio di Viterbo³⁶ (“who ranks among the greatest Christian Kabbalists of all time”). Along the way, he mentions Friedrich Christoph Oetinger³⁷, the follower of Boehme, Valentin Weigel and the “great” Paracelsus³⁸.

Rather than repeating Smith, which would be little more than a review of his reviews in any case, we will explain Smith’s vision in slightly different terms. Thus it will be more like a jazz piece. The chord changes are the same, the melody is recognizable, we follow the same drummer, but we hope it will be a smoother composition. For Gornahoor readers, we can dispense with the intellectual justifications, but instead recommend the original text for that.

Anthropic Realism Smith calls his philosophical position **Anthropic Realism**: “realism” because both universals and particulars are mind independent, and “anthropic” because it stands on the bedrock of unmediated apperception. He admits his admiration for the phenomenology of

³⁴<http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/pico-della-mirandola/>

³⁵https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Johann_Reuchlin

³⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Giles_of_Viterbo

³⁷https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Friedrich_Christoph_Oetinger

³⁸<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Paracelsus>

Edmund Husserl, although Smith goes far beyond Husserl.

Scientific realism leaves no place for man, for the transcendent Intellect, which is a witness to the cosmos. It is not traditional cosmology that is absurd; it only seems absurd because scientific cosmology is absurd. In other words, scientific realism leaves the knower out of the picture. Of course, this goes back to **Arthur Schopenhauer** who asked the same question. Or even to **Bishop George Berkley**: does the cosmos exist if there is no one there to experience it? Smith's answer is a resounding "No" and I'm sure that if you think about it, you, too, will feel compelled to agree.

The cosmos exists for us as an object of intentionality, i.e., man & cosmos, microcosm & macrocosm are complementary polarities. If one goes, so does the other. Certain artificial conundrums of naïve realism and Cartesianism are dissolved by anthropic realism. Viz., we don't see the image of a mountain or a tree in our brain; we actually "see" the mountain or tree. The Cartesian universe, devoid of qualities, cannot be known and hence does not subsist on its own.

By distinguishing the corporeal world of apperception from the physical world without qualities, the existence of higher planes makes sense again. Above the quotidian corporeal world of our sense experience, there is the subtle or astral world, and the celestial world above that. No drugs or techniques can take us from the astral to the celestial world. Most today mistake the subtle as the "spiritual" life. Modern man is stunted, with the higher centers merely virtual. Kundalini energy remains coiled up in the lowest chakra. Of course, gnosis awakens the higher centers, "realizing" them, or making them actual rather than virtual.

Theophany Smith then deals with the exoteric teaching of *Creatio Ex Nihilo*. This view sees creation as static, as "other than God". A breakthrough is possible to arrive at a nondualist conception: a *theophany* rather than a creation.

Created things exemplify ideas in the Mind of God, which is ultimately the Divine Essence. God is simple, thus they are “one” in God. Creation therefore exemplifies in its multiplicity what in God is “one”, i.e., nondual. But this is not a “one time” affair. Creation is not manifested archetypes, but rather manifesting archetypes; this is a change from a static to a dynamic conception. We “see” the thing, but we “know” the archetype. That is, the archetype is “repeated” in our mind, but not as another copy. Rather, it involves the participation of the human mind in the Mind of God.

Bottom line: There is no static creation, in addition to, and apart from, God. Rather there is God revealing himself. We get a sensual representation of the divine ideas; the world becomes phenomenal. Since God does not have “sense” organs, God is conscious of the world through the human consciousness.

Kabbalah Smith devotes two chapters to the Kabbalah. Since there is extensive literature on the topic, we will just present some highlights. At some future point, a comparison with **Valentin Tomberg** and **Vladimir Solovyov** would be useful. Smith claims that, in addition to Christian gnosis, there are three other such traditions: Kabbalah, Tantra, and Vedanta. Due to its Scriptural roots, Smith asserts that the Kabbalah — of the three — is the most compatible with Christian Gnosis.

Smith finds in the Kabbalah keys to the Trinity, the Incarnation, Wisdom, the Eternal Feminine, and the four worlds, among other topics. The origins of Kabbalah lie in the mystical visions of Ezekiel. Tomberg does likewise, interpreting Ezekiel’s visions as a revelation of the archetypal world and the chariot as the central symbol of cosmic knowledge.

The En-Sof is the Absolute and Infinite Godhead and the ten Sefiroth are God’s self-revelation. It is the world, yet the highest Sefiroth represent the Trinity:

- **Keter:** the transcendent

- **Hokhmah:** Wisdom
- **Binah:** Intelligence

There is then an emanation down to Malkuth, or the World. Malkuth is also represented by the Feminine principle of Shekinah, which in turn is tied to Binah, the Holy Spirit.

The mystery of sex is symbol of the love between the divine I and the divine You. The *hieros gamos* is the central fact in the whole chain of divine manifestations

Adam and Eve, man and cosmos originate in higher world. Interestingly, Smith comes close to the ancient Gnostic idea of the world, as we now experience it, as the creation of a “Demiurge”, an inferior being. Originally, the material world which we behold with our senses and contemplate with our rational mind did not exist. It was “sin”, the awareness of evil, that created this world. This is not precisely a “new world” but more like a new way of knowing. Adam becomes attached to the glamour of the world, worshipping the Shekinah exclusively, and failing to see the connection to the higher Sefiroth.

There is a deep truth here, since it is a commonplace that God “created the world”. But are mosquitoes, cystic fibrosis, and so on really part of the original creation? Clearly the answer is No, otherwise the “Fall of Man” and the “expulsion from the garden” would make no sense.

This bears connection to Tomberg. Adam’s originary orientation was vertical, that is, he experienced the theophany directly. The fall, then, was to change orientation to the horizontal, the false belief that things are independent of any transcendence. So the fallen world was not created by another being, or demiurge, but rather by the Antichrist, which is an egregore. It is only ignorance that considers the egregore to be independently real.

The Kabbalah describes four worlds: emanation, creation, formation, and action. In Neoplatonism, these correspond to the One, the Intelligi-

ble, Soul and Matter. Leaving out emanation which is totally transcendent, these correspond to the angelic, subtle, and proto-material worlds. They are also the three worlds of the Hindu Triloka.

Tikkun, or redemption, is the restoration of the ideal order. Today, of course, that primal order is seldom understood. Its foundations are polarity and hierarchy. There is a hierarchical order to everything, from the spiritual, to the subtle, to the material. Manifestation requires a series of syzygies; this notion will be expanded in a further explanation of Tomberg's ideas on Salvation and Evolution.

The divine order is Hierarchy, which revolutionaries oppose. Moreover, without polarity, there is no manifestation. Hence, the attack starts with the flesh and promotes the idea that polarity is nothing more than an arbitrary preference or orientation.

Jesus Christ On the other hand, the Shekinah, as the Theotokos, can lead us upward out of ignorance, whether through the connection with Binah, or with the Tifereth, the Heart Sefiroth, which represents Jesus Christ. Smith points out that Christ has the perfect balance of masculine and feminine virtues. In a series of paradoxes, reminiscent of the Tao Te Ching, he explains:

- He is the King who rules, yet is meek and lowly in heart
- He commands, yet is submissive to all
- He the Judge of kings and the Friend of sinners

In short, he personifies the Word [Logos] that was in the beginning. In the Chinese translation of the Gospel of John, "Tao" is used to translate "Logos".

3.10.3 Meister Eckhart

Carl Jung regarded **Meister Eckhart** and **Dante** as two of the Ten Pillars of the Bridge of the Spirit³⁹.

Faust is the most recent pillar in that bridge of the spirit which spans the morass of world history, beginning with the Gilgamesh epic, the *I Ching*, the *Upanishads*, the *Tao-Tê-Ching*, the fragments of **Heraclitus**, and continuing in the *Gospel of St. John*, the letters of **St. Paul**, in **Meister Eckhart** and in **Dante**...

CARL JUNG

The Traditional author, **Ananda Coomaraswamy** (AKC), in *Vedanta and the Western Tradition*⁴⁰ exclaimed:

Eckhart, with the possible exception of **Dante**, can be regarded from an Indian point of view as the greatest of all Europeans.

Valentin Tomberg included Meister Eckhart among those who arrived at the point of contemplation using Thomism as their starting point. In the Letter on the Sun, we read:

Meister Eckhart, Ruysbroeck, or, lastly, St. John of the Cross are spirits amongst whom you will search in vain for a spirit of opposition to scholasticism. For them also it was true that scholasticism was "like straw", but they knew from their own experience that this straw proved to be an excellent combustible. They certainly surpassed scholasticism, but they did so by attaining its aim. For the aim of scholastic endeavor is contemplation, and it is mysticism which is the fruit of the scholastic tree.

³⁹<http://jungiancenter.org/wp/ten-pillars-bridge-spirit/>

⁴⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=556>

The starting point of scholasticism are the two sources of knowledge: Reason and Revelation. While Reason strives to understand the nature of the world, it can only penetrate part of the way to knowledge of the Divine Essence. For the latter knowledge requires Revelation. However, deep contemplation seeks to penetrate into an intuitive grasp of the Divine. According to Tomberg, this task is also the Hermetic task, viz., to unite intelligence and the intuition of faith.

Among those who are “very advanced in substantially” uniting them, there is **Nicholas Berdyaev**. Berdyaev, in *The Divine & the Human*, asserts that the opposition of the divine and the human will be overcome in the Holy Spirit. Without going into all the details at this time, he claims that the era of the Spirit was anticipated by Meister Eckhart, then by his successors **Johannes Tauler**, **Jacob Boehme**, and **Angelus Silesius**.

Wolfgang Smith, in *Christian Gnosis*, takes up the same themes: the union of the divine and the human, as well as the role of the Holy Spirit. Through an analysis of Eckhart’s mystical vision, Smith describes a Trinitarian non-dualism. There are two phases: the Trinity and the birth of the Logos in the soul.

Trinity Eckhart develops ideas from **Dionysius** and **Augustine** in his understanding of the Trinity. Augustine regarded the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as analogous to “Being, knowing, and loving or willing.” **Vladimir Solovyov** thought highly of Augustine’s explanation of the Trinity from the *Confessions*. Augustine related the Trinity of Plotinus to the Christian understanding as shown in this chart:

Plotinus	Augustine	Trinity
The One	Being	Father
Idea-world	Knowing	Son
Psyche	Willing (or loving)	Holy Spirit

Augustine derived this understanding from the phenomenology of

his own spiritual life. Solovyov shows how these three acts are identical to each other.

1. I am the One who Knows and Wills
2. I know (or am conscious of) my Being as well as my Willing. I know that I am (being) and that I will.
3. I will myself as one who is and who knows.

Each of these acts of the Spirit is completed by the other two, so that they constitute a unity.

The Father is Being, even beyond being, the One, the unknowable essence of the Godhead, or Thearchy as Dionysius called it. The Father is beyond sense experience and intellect so that the self-emptying of apophatic theology is ultimately the only path to approach God.

He knows himself in the Son, the articulated word. The Son, as the Logos, conveys the intelligibility of the Father. The Father knows himself as reflected in the Son, and the Son knows the Father. The Holy Spirit is the unifying love.

This is the way to know God. Eckhart makes this clear:

if you would know God, you must not merely be like the Son,
you must be the Son yourself.

It is not enough to be “Christ-like”; rather we must be transformed. When we put on the mind of Christ, we become the Son, so that God is reflected in the soul. The Holy Spirit unites the divine and the human.

The Birth of the Word in the Soul There is difficulty for the hylic personality to attain to spiritual vision, since sensual imagery is his primary mode of knowing. Eckhart writes:

Some people want to look upon God with their eyes, as they look upon a cow, and want to love God as they love a cow.

So Jesus is the Son incarnated in the flesh. Nevertheless, for the Holy Spirit to come, he must go:

It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send Him unto you. (John 16:7)

The point is clear. In Jesus Christ, the human and divine were united in a visible way. For us, however, the Spirit must come in order to overcome that division that separates us from the divine in our own consciousness. Eckhart warns us about the neglect of the Spirit. Although Christ ascended into Heaven and sits at the right hand of the father, that avails us nothing.

What would it avail me if I had a brother who was a rich man, and for my part I were a poor man? What would it avail me if I had a brother who was a wise man, and I were a fool?

He continues:

The Heavenly Father brings forth his only-begotten Son in Himself and in me.

The birth of the Logos in the soul⁴¹ is the whole point of **Letter II: The High Priestess** in *Meditations on the Tarot*. The Son is by generation, but the Son who lives in us, makes us children of God by adoption. This is what the Meditations calls Initiation. Eckhart goes even further, bringing out the consequences on his non-dual understanding. In Sermon 6, we read:

⁴¹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-word-is-made-flesh>

The Father begets his Son like himself in eternity. "The Word was with God and God was the Word." It was the same in the same nature. I will say more: he has begotten him in my soul. Not only is it with him and he with it alike, but he is in it. The Father begets his Son in the soul in the same way as he begets him in eternity, and not otherwise.

The sacrifice of the Eucharist is not a repetition nor a re-enactment, but is the same sacrifice as Calvary. This is something that happens in eternity, not in time. Similarly – and this is what Eckhart is driving at – the birth of the Logos in the soul is not a different "logos" but is the same Logos that is with the Father eternally. That is how it looks from the standpoint of eternity.

It is the birth of the Logos in the soul that brings knowledge of the Father, otherwise it would be impossible. That is the non-dualism. This second birth overcomes the duality of wills. Sermon 12 states:

A person who is so established in the will of God wants nothing else but what is God and what is God's will.

The Father knows himself in the Son, and the Son knows the Father. When "I" am united with the Son, we can understand Eckhart:

The eye in which I see God is the same eye in which God sees me.
My eye and God's eye are one eye and one seeing, one knowing,
and one loving.

And in Sermon 6:

In the innermost spring I went forth in the Holy Spirit. There is one life and one being and one activity there.

3.10.4 Jacob Boehme

I was a hidden treasure, and I desired to be known; therefore I created the creation in order that I might be known.

HADITH QUDSI

Origen, Dionysius the Areopagite, **Jacob Boehme**, Louis Claude de Saint-Martin, Vladimir Solovyov and Nicolas Berdyaev, for example, show in their works a progress which is very advanced in *substantially* bringing together intelligence and the intuition of faith.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Jacob Boehme has to be termed the greatest of Christian gnostics. The word gnosis I employ here not in the sense of the heresies of the first centuries of Christianity, but in the sense of knowledge basic to revelation and dealing not with concepts, but with symbols and myths; contemplative knowledge, and not discursive knowledge. This is also a religious philosophy or theosophy.

NIKOLAI BERDYAEV, *Studies Concerning Jacob Boehme*⁴²

In *Christian Gnosis*, **Wolfgang Smith** reveals himself as a follower of **Franz von Baader** in the stream of Christian theosophy. That is why he concludes his work with the ideas of **Paracelsus**, **Jacob Boehme**, and **Meister Eckhart**. Smith interprets the latter figure as the sources of a distinctively Christian Trinitarian nondualism, not inferior to the nondualism of the Vedanta. This post will deal with Smith's chapter on Jacob Boehme, and the final one with Meister Eckhart's Trinitarian nondualism.

⁴²http://www.berdyaev.com/berdiaev/berd_lib/1930_349.html

Jacob Boehme⁴³ is the model of the esoterist for the coming Age: He was a layman — a cobbler by trade, just like my grandfather — was married and raised a family. Yet behind that quite ordinary looking exterior, he was undergoing a profound spiritual transformation. He tried to live an obscure life; his first book was distributed just to his friends. Toward the end of his life, he was finally able to dedicate his time solely to his spiritual writings, thanks to some wealthy patrons.

Excursus on Gnosis Berdyaev describes the foundation of Boehme's gnosis in the following paragraph:

We ought to be re-united with the traditions of the theosophy and anthroposophy of J. Boehme, in truth with a Christian theosophy and anthroposophy. And moreover, even more deeply ought we to be re-united with the traditions of the esoteric, hidden Christianity. But the fruition of the great traditions of Boehme and of Christian gnosticism ought to be creative, it ought to guide along the path of a completely new, creatively-active knowledge. Modern people, seeking God and the Divine life, are very afraid of thought and knowledge, and the basic thrust of their will often becomes anti-gnostic. They admit the possibility only of a passive, abstract knowledge. They cannot accept knowledge as a creative act, bearing life into the light of the world, of knowledge as being and life.

NIKOLAI BERDYAEV, *Theosophy and Anthroposophy in Russia*⁴⁴

The fundamental notion is that gnosis is creative. Discursive knowledge, on the other hand, is passive and abstract, i.e., it is something to be absorbed as is. Gnosis is the knowledge of the heart. It is creative in the

⁴³The main source used for Boehme's teachings is *Five Christian Principals* by Rene Cossey.

⁴⁴https://www.berdyaev.com/berdiaev/berd_lib/1916_252b.html

sense that the knower needs to raise his level of being, and that is a creative process. In other words, he needs to be the artist of his own life, his own soul; only in that way can he hope to achieve gnosis.

The next notion is that Boehme has both a cosmology and an anthropology. They are intimately related as the macrocosm to the microcosm. By knowing himself, man knows the macrocosm, and by knowing the macrocosm he knows himself. This was more fully developed by Boehme's follower Johann Gichtel⁴⁵, who showed that the planets are related to the inner states or chakras.

Of course, this assumes a traditional cosmology that involves the following degrees of existence:

- Mineral or physical
- Plants
- Animals
- Intellect
- Celestial or Angelic
- Divine

Those states of being also exist within man, even if most people live their lives at the levels of plant and animal life, with excursions into the truly human state or perhaps higher states. As a matter of fact, it is considered a marker of high intelligence and good education to believe that only the mineral or physical state of being actually exists. Thus, all interior life is believed to be the result of electro-chemical processes. For them, I have selected this theme song⁴⁶.

⁴⁵<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8618>

⁴⁶<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dkSfdGNuD0c>

The following sections briefly summarize Boehme's system in order to understand Smith's interest. As we pointed out, this should not be read as passive, abstract and discursive knowledge to be passively received. Instead, make the effort to re-experience Boehme's vision in your own consciousness.

The Ungrund or Abyss Boehme has his own particular interpretation of Traditional metaphysics. In common with them, he starts with the unmanifest source or all, describes the Law of Three that makes manifestation possible, and then the Law of Seven indicating the stages of that manifestation.

The Ungrund desires to reveal himself through manifestation. The universe is the outcome and development of One Grand Thought. All things are governed by one central law and all planes of existence are related. This is the Law of Correspondences.

The Abyss contains within itself everything and nothing, i.e., everything potentially but nothing manifestly. Within the Abyss is an eternal uncreated Will (Byss). It desires to become manifest, to be something.

The Will fashions a Mirror which reflects all things, making them manifest. The Mirror is Eternal Wisdom, Eternal Idea, Virgin Sophia, and the Infinite Mother, while the Will is the Infinite Father. Like the Tao, Boehme describes this relationship:

Abyss $\Rightarrow$ Duality $\Rightarrow$ Trinity.

The Father-Mother begets a Son; these energies are diffused by the Holy Spirit. Through the union of the Will and Wisdom, the unmanifest becomes manifest, the latent becomes active.

In Guenon's system, the Ungrund is Nonbeing, and Being is its first principle. Boehme claims, moreover, that the Ungrund is God as he is in himself. The Ungrund makes the Ground, i.e., Being, which is the Father. This is similar to the Palamite understanding assuming that the Ungrund is the unknowable essence of God, and the Father is the energies,

or the Act of Being as in Thomist metaphysics. The Logos concentrates those energies, which are diffused through the Holy Spirit. Thus, the generation of all things takes place and the unmanifest becomes manifest.

Obviously, this should not be understood temporally, since it is all prior to time itself.

The Ternary In *Symbolism of the Cross*, **Rene Guenon** describes the three gunas, which are “essential, constitutive and primordial qualities or attributes of beings envisaged in their different states of manifestation”. Boehme likewise recognizes those qualities. There are two which he calls Fire and Light. These contrasting principles exist in all things. The third manifests in our external nature. This can be summarized as:

- Fire, Wrath, Law, Dark Principle, latent and unmanifest (nonbeing)
- Light, Mercy, Love
- Manifestation or Being

The Dark Principle is unmanifest, since it would be understood as the wrathful or vengeful aspect of God. Nevertheless, Man has free will, so he can will the dark principle. A contrast is necessary for conscious awareness. This is not a problem provided it is transmuted by the Light or Love Principle. Otherwise, man is in the “false imagination”, resulting in a misunderstanding of God and the World.

In other Traditions, these principles are called

- Brahma the Creator/Shiva the Destroyer,
- Ormuzd/Ahriman,
- God/Devil

Vishnu, then, is the Preserver, balancing the two principles. This requires knowledge and wisdom gained through experience. This reconciles Law and Love. By following Truth, man transmutes evil into good, otherwise he becomes a slave to evil.

The Polarity occurs on every plane of manifestation. It is reflected as

- Positive/negative
- Active/passive
- Masculine/feminine
- Action/reaction

This Polarity — or Sex — is the law of all manifestation, the creative power of the universe. That is the cosmic order and any deviation from it is disordered.

The Septenary Boehme says there are seven properties or forces through which the Divine energy operates. Each quality has its own essence, forming together one harmonious whole. They permeate all manifest things. Although Boehme talks about them as if sequential, they operate simultaneously, outside of time. These are the seven qualities, followed by their names:

- **Contraction:** The desire drawing all towards itself (*Desire*)
- **Friction:** expansive force creating a dual action and differentiation. Desire going into multiplicity (*Motion*)
- **Sensibility:** rotary motion of 1 and 2. The wheel of life. (*Sensation*)

- **Lightning or Fire:** The Spirit diffuses a mild light, transforms the dark principle, ending strife
- **Love or Light:** love binds, builds up and harmonizes the principles of joy
- **Audibility:** intelligible or vital sound. The manifestation of Life. (*Intelligence*)
- **Essential Wisdom:** gathers the previous six into one harmonious whole

Contraction, Friction, and Sensibility form the “Dark Principle”. Contraction is the desire drawing things to itself; it is harsh, cold, and sharp. It is a kind of magnetic attraction, congealing Nothing into Something. Friction is expansive, thus causing differentiation. It is desire becoming multiplicity. Sensibility is the wheel of life brought about by the action and reaction of Contraction and Friction. This wheel is experienced as wandering and anguish, which amasses itself into an Essence. In other words, the first principle is Attraction, then Repulsion, resulting in Circulation.

The Lightning Flash is the eruption of the Spirit, who transforms the Dark principle by the suffusion of Light. This ends the Strife of Attraction and Repulsion. This is the beginning of Consciousness and Life.

Love then builds up and harmonizes the principles, bring joy and perfection. Audibility brings intelligence. Finally, Wisdom brings harmony and bliss.

This process is the “Great Work”, the *Magnum Opus*, that must be performed in each of us in order to reclaim our original nature and “the great transmutation which Christ Jesus accomplished in His Own Person.”

The Created Universe The Uncreated Heaven is perfect and complete and is part of God. However, the Created Universe is outside and apart from God. Therefore, it needs to develop from incompleteness to completeness. This does not exhaust God, who is Infinite, but rather enriches him.

God produces from his own eternal nature and wisdom, in which all things exist as possibilities of manifestation. Created things manifest successively in time. Creation is in Equilibrium, the harmony of the active forces (Light) and passive forces (Dark).

Creation unfolds through endless circles. Outside the circle of the Uncreated heaven, there is the created heaven or angelic world. There are three hierarchies headed by Michael, Lucifer, and Uriel (corresponding to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit).

Fall of Lucifer Although the Dark Principle is passive and unmanifest in God, and never becomes active, the possibility of evil arises in free beings. Free beings can choose to be centered in the natural egoic Self. This is to remain at the level of Contraction. Or else they can be centered in the Light Center, the expansive power of Love. Evil and disorder enter the world when creatures become centered in that lower self. Once selfish desire is kindled, it just becomes stronger. Instead of letting the Divine Light reconcile opposing forces, they get stimulated resulting in anguish. Life becomes struggle and anxiety.

Evil first entered the Cosmos when Lucifer, the head of our universe, became self-centered thereby rejecting the divine order. Lucifer's fall was the result of pride and the pursuit of knowledge apart from God. He rejected the feeling of humility in the face of the Divine mysteries. Curiosity and the desire for novelty became dominant. Thus evil, Hell, and the Dark Principle entered the world.

Our personal task, therefore, is to reconcile the extremes of the forces of Darkness and Light. As the Hermetists taught, that is necessary for

the recovery of the Prima Materia, the element of immortality. Then it can be molded by the Will for creative purposes, without painful toil, “transforming work into play”.

This must begin with self-knowledge in order to recognize the Luciferian temptations in our own souls. This should be easy to do, since Lucifer is the Prince of this World.

Adam’s Fall Earth was situated spiritually within the sphere of Lucifer. Lucifer split the world into Darkness and Light, separating God’s Wrath from God’s Love, making Equilibrium difficult. The world became dense and gross.

As we pointed out above, man is not just a “rational animal”, but rather a composite being containing elements of all things. Thus he has facilities to know things on all planes, including the physical, astral, physical, and divine things.

The human race was ethereal, so Adam was a luminous being permeated by a celestial essence. His mind was innocent, no knowledge of evil, without avarice, pride, envy, or anger. Adam’s body was not dense, since the inner life was the master of the body. Adam’s inner life was in touch with Heaven; he could communicate with God, the angels, and nature. His being was tripartite, in harmony with each other:

- **Spirit:** light principle
- **Soul:** dark principle
- **Body:** in the world of sense formed through the union of the light and dark principles

Nevertheless, virtue requires the possibility of vice and the experience of temptation. So Adam was tempted by Lucifer, decentering his attention onto the world. He was tempted to experience the pairs of opposites,

thus disturbing his previous state of Equilibrium. This was the Fall into duality: the experience of each side of light and dark in isolation.

Hence, our task to reconcile these opposing principles. Unlike Lucifer's Fall, Adam did not really wish to oppose God, but merely to experience earthly pleasures. Therein lies the clue to the way back.

Adam and Eve Originally, Adam was a dual unity, including Eve. Boehme describes Adam-Eve like this:

Adam was a man and also a woman, and yet neither of them distinct, but a virgin full of chastity, modesty, and purity, namely the image of God.

When Adam's attention was enticed by the world, Eve (the feminine part of his nature) prompted him to separate. Noting that the animals were male and female, he/they were overcome with desire to copulate like mammals⁴⁷.

Adam's deep sleep refers to his forgetfulness of the angelic world; he then awoke in the external world, separated from Eve. He lost the unitive consciousness in dualistic thinking. They ate the fruit of the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, becoming subject to death, decay, and corruption. Now part of the sidereal universe (i.e., under the stars), they lost awareness of anything higher.

Because of Lucifer and Adam, even nature has become gross. In the world there is a mixture or alternation of the two principles of the Dark and the Light. There are storms and beautiful weather; poisonous plants and delicious fruit; savage beasts and noble animals. Curse, decay, corruption, and death struggle with blessing, health, and life.

Man has sunk to the animal plane of existence, tending towards the bestial. His inner disposition is like the animals. Man must extirpate these

⁴⁷<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xat1GVnl8-k>

instincts to become wholly human, and restore the image of God. Adam should have restored creation to order, following the fall of Lucifer. Unfortunately, he is unable to bring the opposing forces into Equilibrium. Christ, the second Adam, re-establishes man in his primal dignity as Lord of Creation.

Atonement and Redemption Jesus was a Divine Human Being with the essence of both God and Mary; he combined the highest part of the masculine (forcefulness) with the best attributes of the feminine character (tenderness). Christ is the Son of Virgin Mary, but also of the Heavenly Virgin who united herself with Mary.

Whereas Adam fixed his imagination on the lower world, Jesus fixed his imagination wholly upon the Father subjecting the lower principle to the higher, re-establishing equilibrium. The resurrection body is paradisiacal body, which eventually disappeared (ascended to Heaven). Heaven is not a distinct place, but interpenetrates the physical universe. This is hidden from normal sight.

Regeneration by the Holy Spirit is required for Equilibrium. This requires an inward transformation, not just an historical faith in Jesus. Man must forsake the principles of Darkness and the world (lust and appetites). The Light principle was lost through Adam but regained with Christ. Prayer is the means to soar above the center of nature. Will and desire become one. It is necessary to be in harmony with the Divine Will, and then conscious union and knowledge of God.

On earth, the soul is already either in heaven or hell. So it does not “go” anywhere after death, yet the soul is fixed at the moment of death and cannot be changed. However, souls in a half-regenerate condition can ultimately reach heaven after a period of purgation.

Creation was the act of the Father, the Incarnation was the act of the Son, Holy Spirit will bring about the end of the world. This will bring about nondual awareness. This is reminiscent of Joachim of Fiore.

Nondualism Wolfgang Smith, then, interprets Boehme's theosophy in a nondual way. Christ is the Incarnate God who reveals himself. This happens on several levels:

- On the plane of eternal nature as the summation of the septenary cycle
- On the plane of human history as Jesus of Nazareth
- God becomes incarnate in all who are born in Christ

The first is creative and the second is redemptive, i.e., the restoration of a state which had been lost. Man and cosmos are in flux, a "kind of samsara", which will have its fulfilment in the Kingdom of God.

Smith concludes this chapter with three questions:

- Does Boehme's doctrine differ from the Kabbalah?
- Is it Trinitarian?
- Is it Nondualist?

The answer to the first question is a qualified Yes, with some adjustments. But what is more interesting is the idea of a Trinitarian Nondualism, which Smith will develop more fully in the final two chapters on Meister Eckhart. Specifically, Deliverance is not a matter of just knowing the transcendent Father, but of knowing both the Father and the Christ. This is one act of knowing, not two, and is incarnational as well as transcendent. The Mystical Union is the Supreme Identity or, as Boehme describes it:

What is void of will is one with the Ungrund ... which is God himself.

Postscript on Personal Development I've avoided discussing what is most discussed: e.g., the life and sanctity of Boehme, his siddhis, the sources of his doctrines, or whether they are heterodox. Ultimately, they need to be comprehended, if at all, internally, in one's conscious life.

This is clearly difficult because of the falls of Lucifer and Adam. We have lost our birthright gift of understanding transcendence due to our attachment to the glamor of the world process. These are some exercises in conscious awareness that you can try at home.

- Lucifer exchanged an intellect centered on God to one centered on the world. Cunning, guile, idle curiosity, and the like, replaced genuine creativity. See *The Intellectual Center*⁴⁸ for the distinction between the higher and lower functions of the intellect.
- Adam rejected a vision of wholeness for dualist knowledge and attachment to the natural world. He entered a world of Strife instead of one of Love, all the while assuming he can somehow remain on the "pleasant" side of duality.
- In that state, it is assumed that only the physical world exists and all problems have a scientific or material solution. The very idea of a quest for higher consciousness is rejected.
- By his attachment to sexual reproduction and its ersatz simulations, he finds it difficult to refocus attention upwards. The same sexual energy could be used to achieve the original wholeness, or alchemical marriage, or even like Dante and Beatrice, to achieve the mystical union.

These aspects of consciousness need to be experienced personally. Unless there is an awareness of being in a fallen state, then the very idea of redemption makes no sense.

⁴⁸<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/intellectual-center>

Posted on 2016-07-20 by Cologero

* * *

Boreas on 2016-07-20 at 22:19 said:

This is a great book dear Friend. It's great you've recently taken Wolfgang Smith's opuses in deeper examination. Was it me who first recommend it to you? I have given this book two times from my bookshelf to dear friends, as a Christmas present and so on. I've read and bought all Susijengi Sepän (Wolfgang Smith's) books and they have been life's changing lately. I loaned three of his books to psychologist-fysicist Friend of mine and he became interested. Well, to cut the story short, namaste.

Cassiodorus on 2016-07-20 at 23:50 said:

Colegero,

I am hoping that you will be discussing Smith's Trinitarian nondualism. I am not sure- but I think it is not actually in alignment with Guenon and Schuon's metaphysical point of view. It seems to me that Wolfgang Smith's position resembles that of Jean Borella's or perhaps Robert Bolton?

Cologero on 2016-07-21 at 12:50 said:

@Cassiodorus, we will get to Smith's Trinitarian nondualism, although he attributes it to Eckhart, not himself. I don't know Borella's view on it, although Smith does mention him several times.

You are correct, it is a deviation from Guenon, yet not in the way of a refutation.

Keep in mind the dogmas like the Trinity used to be restricted to initiates, and were not intended for the general public.

Matt on 2016-08-12 at 10:54 said:

Boehme, who will be the subject of the next part, has an interesting take on the Fall. There were two falls: the Fall of Man and the Fall of Lucifer. Lucifer's Fall lead to the natural evil/privation in the world, and Adam's Fall lead to the moral evil/privation in the world.

One doesn't usually find an examination of the extent to which Lucifer's fall affected the world beyond merely bringing temptations to the human being. I guess Boehme stands out in this regard.

Babbus on 2016-08-12 at 19:54 said:

Mr. Salvo, here's a link to Corbin's *The Paradox of Monotheism*:

<https://www.scribd.com/doc/300003894/The-Paradoxe-of-Monotheism-Henry-Corbin>

I hope to have been of assistance.

Boreas on 2016-09-10 at 16:03 said:

Excellent synopsis again, Cologero! I haven't been here for a while, but as a synchro I just yesterday evening read the chapter on the Gnosis of Boehme.

Boehme's explanation of the Fall of Lucifer is interesting. I have lately been thinking that it was a cosmological and ontological necessity to bring the fire of mind to man, which lead to the involutory cycle with all its effects of cosmic evil, to the outgoing, which is followed by the evolutionary cycle, or the in-going and the path of return that was perfected in Jesus Christ, who "redeemed Lucifer" and established the law of mercy and love as the highest standard in earth instead of the old covenant which was based upon justice. Any thoughts on this?

Barnabas Fiacabrili on 2016-10-07 at 02:06 said:

Astounding. I personally want to thank you for showing me the truth of Christinaity. Years ago I left the church in favor of vendata. I know now, thanks to this website and all the great intellectuals I have read since, how inseparable they are. By grace, direct experience and knowledge will solidify this.

Thank you and God bless!

Victimarius on 2016-10-07 at 07:49 said:

Excellent article. I would also like to thank you for it. Illuminating.

Mark Citadel on 2016-10-14 at 05:03 said:

Astounding stuff, definitely has enhanced by knowledge of gnosis. Just unfortunate so many people associate it with the early century heresy. The section on the Fall of Lucifer in particular cleared up a few issues I was having with the Ahriman comparisons.

I really must get around to picking up your book!

Matt on 2016-11-16 at 18:32 said:

Wolfgang Smith had a correspondence with Fr. Malachi Martin, a well-known Catholic priest in the West. Their correspondence covered topics on Tradition and its relation with the Church. These written correspondences were just recently released by Smith. A key focus was on Jacob Boehme. Martin appears to share Smith's high esteem of Boehme, as well as appreciating Hermeticism (Martin describes Hermetic teaching as pre-Christ Christology).

Below is a link to the first bit of their written correspondence where they discuss Boehme's teaching on Lucifer's fall. What I thought was most noteworthy is Smith and Martin's agreement

that Boehme's insight on this topic renders an interesting interpretation of the creation account in Genesis. Smith has drawn out the implications of this in a number of his writings and lectures, which have been touched upon in the previous Gornahoor posts in this series. Gornahoor readers and Cologero may find it interesting.

<http://www.christendom-awake.org/pages/book-promotions/in-quest-of-catholicity/book-extracts.pdf>

3.II The Russian Idea

For as lightning cometh out of the east, and appeareth even into the west: so shall the coming of the Son of man be.

MATTHEW 24:27

Over the past two hundred years, an important spiritual and philosophical movement has been coming out of Russia. This, until recently, has been little known and appreciated; fortunately, the past few decades has seen new translations of many of the thinkers listed below. According to the Lindisfarne Press⁴⁹, the publishers of the *Library of Russian Philosophy*, Russian philosophy is marked by certain characteristic features.

- **Epistemological realism:** Knowledge consists of the idea of the thing, and these ideas — in the Platonic sense — are real.
- **Integral knowledge:** Knowledge is an all-embracing unity that includes sensuous, intellectual, and mystical intuition. Here we recognize the degrees of knowledge described by Rene Guenon, in recapitulation of Traditional Wisdom.
- **Integral personality:** The complete man is sensuous, rational, and mystical.

⁴⁹<http://www.steinerbooks.org/p.php?id=12>

- **Resurrection:** The flesh and the world are to be transformed.

I date this from the time of the Joseph de Maistre's⁵⁰ period as ambassador to Russia. In addition to his vocation, Maistre was a Martinist and Catholic philosopher. He represents the opening of Russia to Western ideas, and around the same time, several works important to Martinism and Hermeticism were translated into Russian. These include: the *Imitation of Christ* by Thomas a Kempis, as well as works by Louis-Claude de Saint-Martin and Jacob Boehme.

This led to two independent streams.

- Occult, as represented by
 - Helena Blavatsky
 - Gurdjieff, Ouspensky
- Sophiology, as represented by
 - Vladimir Solovyov
 - Sergius Bulgakov
 - Pavel Florensky
 - Nikolai Berdyaev
 - Vyacheslav Ivanov

This spiritual outpouring can related to the three Romes.

- The Third Rome. Theophan the Recluse ties together the two Romes: one, by the Russian edition of the *Philokalia*, and the other in his version of **Lorenzo Scupoli's** *Spiritual Combat*, translated into English as *Unseen Warfare*.

⁵⁰<https://gornahoor.net/library/EvolaOnDeMaistre.pdf>

- Boris Mouravieff represents the second Rome, the Byzantine Empire. Following Theophan and the occultism of Gurdjieff and Ouspensky, he reworks the Orthodox spiritual tradition.
- Valentin Tomberg is the first Rome. He begins with the occult stream originating with Blavatsky and then expanded by Rudolf Steiner. He is also heir to the Martinist current that had infiltrated the Russian consciousness and then integrates it with the Sophiology of Solovyov and his followers. He eventually joined the Roman Church.

I include Rudolf Steiner, although he was not a Russian. However, his wife was Russian, and he predicted that the next cultural epoch is to emerge from Russia.

The culmination of these streams is represented by two important works of Christian Hermeticism:

“Meditations on the Tarot” by Valentin Tomberg, and *Gnosis*, by Boris Mouravieff. While quite different in tone and subject matter, they are compatible on a deeper level. I can point out some interesting correspondences.

- Both books written by Russians, who were almost exact contemporaries: Valentin Tomberg (1900 – 1973) and Boris Mouravieff (1890 – 1966).
- They each fled the Russian revolution in 1920.
- They each claimed to be recovering the esoteric teachings of the Church, one from the Roman church, the other from the Eastern church.
- Their main works were written in the 1960s in French.

- They were made available in English within a few years of each other.

The first two volumes of *Gnosis* (exoteric and mesoteric cycles) each contains 21 chapters, indicating incompleteness. The third (esoteric cycle) has 22 chapters. It concludes with a description of the Knight, his work in the world, and the creation of an elite to begin the process of transformation.

Meditations on the Tarot contains 22 chapters, one for each of the major arcana. The final arcana is the “world”, and it ends with the challenge to bring Hermeticism into the world by meditating on the meanings of the minor arcana.

Posted on 2010-03-27 by Cologero

3.12 Sophia and the Eternal Feminine

Do you remember the roses over white foam,
A purple reflection in azure waves?
Do you remember the image of a beautiful form,
Your confusion, and trembling, and dread?

SOLOVYOV, *Das Ewig-Weibliche*

Das Ewig-Weibliche zieht uns hinan.

GOETHE, *Faust*

It is not a coincidence that, starting sometime in the 19th century, visions of Sophia or Mary became more frequent. We will use **Vladimir Solovyov** as the expositor of the Sophianic current in the Eastern churches and Fatima as an example from the Roman church.

Solovyov Like **Dante** and **Hafiz** before him, Vladimir was precocious in having become aware of the Anima at the young age of 10. Fortunately for him — as it was for both Dante and Hafiz — his love for the young girl was not reciprocated. Emotionally devastated by rejection, he had his first of three encounters with Sophia:

He perceived suddenly the blue of the sky all around him and in his own soul; and through this blue he saw the Eternal Womanhood, woven as it were of blue ether, and holding in her hand a blossom form unearthly countries. She nodded in his direction, smiling at him with a radiant smile, and then disappeared in the mist. His soul became blind to all worldly things, and the childish love which caused his jealousy became repugnant to him.

N. LOSSKY, *History of Russian Philosophy*

Perhaps had Vladimir and the girl become childhood sweethearts, he would have ended up in the bourgeois life of a parish priest. But his rejection of carnal life set the course of his life. In answer to the question, “Have you ever been in Love”, Solovyov responded:

Seriously, once; otherwise, 27 times.

From that, it seems clear that he had multiple flirtations over the course of his life, but that his real love was for Sophia.

Solovyov died of kidney disease in 1900.

I recently rid myself of #27. I then received a blessing from Mary while meditating on her Coronation in Heaven.

I will probably die of kidney disease if COVID-19 doesn’t kill me first. But #28 might save me.

Path of the Initiate There are two esoteric paths:

1. **The way of the Monk** requires the renunciation of life experiences. This makes it one-sided.
2. **The way of the Initiate** is the more difficult path. The initiate uses life experiences to further his growth. This gives him knowledge of all the forces exerted in the world. Ultimately, it is a solitary path.

Although monks tried to convince Solovyov to join their monastery, he regarded that path as a form of slavery. He ultimately chose the solitary path of the Initiate. This allowed him to freely choose his own course of study. Eventually, he went to England to study Indian, gnostic, and medieval philosophy. Yet, his work was not merely intellectual and academic; his life was punctuated with spiritual experiences.

In the British Museum, he experienced his second encounter with the Divine Sophia, who told him to go to Egypt. His third encounter took place in the desert, 20 kilometres outside Cairo. His dream life was significant for him. For example, in the dream state, he would envision prophecies and engage in conversations with the dead. Many passages in his notebooks include the fruits of automatic writing.

Solovyov's Predecessors Solovyov was much more than a theologian, or philosopher, or even a mystic. It took another Initiate to recognize his real project. Valentin Tomberg made this insightful observation:

[I] had never encountered a work written before the time of Rudolf Steiner that contained such a profound concept of the nature and mission of Jesus Christ, a view presented against the background of cosmic history. . . . A question now arose: How did Solovyov come to this amazing cognition of the more profound mysteries of the Son and even the divine Trinity as a whole? In studying the

works of Solovyov, we find no actual path or method leading to this perceptive knowledge. We can indeed follow his thoughts and thereby be convinced of their truth, but the works of Solovyov offer no explanation as to how we can reach similar new knowledge.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Christ and Sophia*

That may have been true of his *published* works. Keep in mind that the Russian religious censors were quite strict. The memory of the fate of Konrad Nordermann and Quirinius Kuhlmann, who brought the ideas of Jacob Boehme to Russia a century before, was not forgotten. They had been severely tortured and burned alive by the authorities.

Hence, Solovyov was careful with his writing. He had to couch the gnostic concept of syzygy in the *Meaning of Love* in more orthodox terms. His promise to write a book on the influence of Hermes Trismegistus on the Church Fathers was never fulfilled. His controversial books were written in French and published in France.

Nevertheless, his notebooks—which were not available during Tomberg's lifetime—provide the full sources of his ideas. For example, in *Theological Principles*, he includes this schema

Neoplatonism and Kabbalah	Law	Old Testament
Boehme and Swedenborg	Gospels	New Testament
Schelling and Solovyov	Freedom	Eternal Testament

It is easy enough to recognize in this the idea of the Cistercian **Joachim de Fiore** on the Three Ages: the Age of the Father, the Age of the Son, and the Age of the Holy Spirit. Solovyov, thus, regarded himself as the fulfillment of the process begun in Neoplatonism and the Kabbalah, continued through Boehme and Swedenborg, then through Schelling. Hence, he brought Absolute Idealism into his system, expanding on Schelling,

particularly on the idea of Freedom. In other words, he claimed knowledge of the Absolute. He also developed his ideas of cosmogony and theogony from Schelling; this is what Tomberg was referring to. (These topics will be discussed in an upcoming post.)

So, we do indeed recognize the path leading to Soloviev's knowledge. As a matter of fact, what was only implicit in Solovyov's published works—viz., Neoplatonism, Kabbalah, Boehme, for example—was developed openly by Tomberg himself. He didn't need to concern himself with the censors.

Dialogue with Sophia Employing a technique which we have recommended several times, Solovyov engaged in a dialogue with the Anima. The manuscript was titled, *The Sophia*, which Solovyov described as a “mystical-theosophical-Philosophical-Theurgical-Political” dialogue. Although it was never published in his lifetime, Solovyov regarded it as the foundation of all his later works. It was not simply a rhetorical device, since the manuscript included Gnostic symbolism and contained passages of automatic writing. (Automatic writing comes directly from the subconscious or from a supernatural source. The Enochian language was revealed to John Dee in this way.) Instead, it must be understood as a revelation of Sophia.

Essence and Existence In the manuscript, Sophia's dialogue partner is the Philosopher, the “lover of Sophia”. Although the Philosopher instantly recognizes Sophia, she is not simply a projected part of his unconscious; she is an independent being in herself. Of course, Solovyov knows Sophia from his three visions.

Nevertheless, Sophia questions the philosopher's idea of knowledge. All traditional wisdom recognizes the two worlds:

1. the metaphysical order, the world of Being, the invisible and intangible world, the ideal world

2. The physical order, the world of Becoming, the visible and tangible world, the real world

In Orthodox theology, this shows up as the distinction between the essence and energies of God. The energies of God are known through his activities, but His essence is inexhaustible, and cannot be fully known. In the West, the word for energies (*erg*) is translated as act (*actus*). So actual grace, for example, is experienced as God's energies. When the philosopher claims knowledge of the Absolute, Sophia questions him. The following snippet is instructive.

Sophia: Do you know me? Do you know with whom you are speaking?

Philosopher: As if I could not know you!

S: You no doubt know me as a phenomenon, that is, insofar as I exist for you or in my external manifestation. You cannot know me as I am in myself, that is, my thoughts and intimate feelings as they are in me and for me. You know them only when they manifest themselves outwardly in the expression of my eyes, in my words, and my gestures. These are only external phenomena and yet ...

P: And yet, when I look into the deep azure of your eyes, when I hear the music of your voice, is it outward phenomena of sight and sound that I perceive? My God! I know your thoughts and feelings, and, by your thoughts and feelings, I know your inner being.

S: And this is the way that all beings know each other. You know the interior phenomena by way of the exterior, and, by that, the being—itsself, or what one philosopher [Kant] has called the intelligible character [noumenal or thing-in-itself].

Solovyov is describing “spiritual vision”, that is, the ability to discern the spiritual world beyond the world of phenomena. It is the ability to understand the inner state of another person (which in pop culture is mistakenly called “mind reading”).

Metaphysical Principles Not surprisingly, Sophia revealed to Solovyov some metaphysical teachings that are compatible with Traditional metaphysics, as in **Rene Guenon**'s *Multiple States of the Being*, for example. As was just mentioned, there is the distinction between Essence—the principle of unity—and Existence—the principle of multiplicity.

Sophia points out that the principle of the Absolute is not Being, but rather Nonbeing. She points out:

[The Absolute] can be neither the direct object of our outer sensations, nor the direct subject of our inner consciousness, for everything in these two categories is what we call being.

The principle of Being cannot be Being, since it would be a being outside of all being. Hence, the Absolute principle is that which has the possibility of being; in other words, it is Infinite possibility. Yet the absolute cannot lack anything, so it must include the opposite of itself. That is,

In order to be truly absolute and infinite, it must also be the principle of relativity and finitude.

At this point, the Philosopher admits that this understanding brings him to a state of mystical enthusiasm.

Sophia explains that is because the absolute principle is Love. In expressing itself as relative and finite, that is a form of self-denial and the affirmation of the other, the very definition of Love.

The Universal Religion Sophia revealed the universal religion, which she described as:

The universal religion is the fruit of a large tree, whose roots are formed from primitive Christianity and whose trunk is formed from the religion of the Middle Ages.

Solovyov wrote in the margins:

The universal religion is not only the positive synthesis of all religions, but also the synthesis of religion, philosophy, and science.

As the positive synthesis, Solovyov wants to avoid the notion of a “mere Christianity”, which is a negation. On the other pole, he has to avoid a New Age type syncretism or a vague religion of humanity. This idea was most fully developed in one of his last books, *Russia and the Universal Church*, which had to be published in French, for obvious reasons.

Solovyov denied that the mystical bond of the Roman and Orthodox churches had ever been severed. His biographer explains:

In the light of the “fire of Truth and Knowledge” that lived in Schelling’s works, Soloviev acquired a new awareness of the implications of the Johannine aspect of Christian revelation and mystical experience. With the great German philosopher, he came to recognize that “the true Church which has its basic foundation in Peter, goes through Paul, finally to become the Church of St. John”.

PAUL M. ALLEN, *Vladimir Soloviev: Russian Mystic*

Over the years, Solovyov had become closer to the Roman Catholic church, even taking its sacraments. However, as much as the partisans would like to one side or the other, this could not be considered a “conversion”, since that would make no sense in his understanding.

Rather, he envisioned a Universal Church, that would include both the Catholic and the Eastern churches, although it would be centered in Rome with the Pope as its head. Solovyov had pointed out in his lectures that Reason was ineffective against the passions and the party spirit. Hence, a millennium after the schism, passion and sectarian interests continue to hide the mystical bond from most people. If Reason is useless, the perhaps the spirit of Love, the principle of the Absolute, can end the separation.

Filioque A short note on the Filioque is appropriate in the context, since, for the most passionate, it is a fundamental issue. **Sergei Bulgakov**, one of Solovyov's closest followers, has a long discussion in *The Comforter*, his book on the Holy Spirit. He asserts that the Filioque is not a cause for separation, because its real meaning still needs to be clarified. He wrote:

These dogmatic divergences must not serve as a pretext for mutual accusations of heresy, inasmuch as they can be harmonized or at least considered not to exclude one another. Not imaginary heresy, but the schismatic spirit and false dogmatism sustain that separation of which the ancient church was free.

Unfortunately, the most rabid and partisan spirits seem to find all sorts of bizarre consequences that follow from the Filioque. On the other hand, Bulgakov, who is a more sober and deeper thinker, cannot actually find any meaningful practical impact:

In practice, the two sides West and East, do not differ in their veneration of the Holy Spirit, despite their divergence regarding the procession. It seems highly strange that such a major dogmatic divergence would have no practical impact whereas normally a dogma always has a practical significance, determines the religious life. Even the most extreme zealots of the schismatic spirit have not been able to apply the imaginary dogma to life or to indicate its practical consequences.

References:

Vladimir Soloviev: Russian Mystic, **Paul M. Allen**

Divine Sophia: The Wisdom Writings of Vladimir Solovyov, **Judith**

Deutsche Kornblatt

History of Russian Philosophy, **N. Lossky**

Christ and Sophia, **Valentin Tomberg**

Posted on 2018-07-18 by Cologero

* * *

Arthur Konrad on 2018-07-19 at 06:25 said:

The way of the monk is not normally an esoteric path, quite the opposite. One-sided renunciation misses the point, which is contemplation of one's desire, which is an inner force, and not the renunciation of physical objects themselves for their own sake, which represents exterior and in itself insignificant morality.

Marian visions are mostly suspicious and subversive. They rest somewhere on the plane of mediumship, that is to say – it is enough that one becomes obsessed with something for his subconscious to oblige him, but that is counter-productive and is a form of spiritual passivity. But more than anything else, it leads one astray of proper contemplation and realization of the subtle vital and creative force symbolized by the eternal feminine, which is again – subtle and profound and not reducible to mere visions and pleasant sensations. "Dialogues" with various spiritual entities in particular fall in this sensual domain.

Without aiming to promote partisan discussions, but from this spiritual opus seems to be derived much of what came to be Christian mysticism and typically Christian sensuality (of which Solov'yev is a proper foot soldier) and is almost a hallmark of its mode of being.

Too much speculative, fantastical and allegorical, all in all – Christianity through and through.

P.S. Remember that Buddha, in his conversation with Mara, did not allow himself to be deceived.

Cologero on 2018-07-27 at 00:42 said:

Mr. Konrad, we have been describing in the past few posts the phenomenology of the encounter with the "eternal feminine". Did not the Buddha, as you described, have to pass through similar experiences? There is no virtue, nor value, in the inability to be tempted at all. That is the way of the monk, who hopes to avoid such temptations in his solitude; that ultimately is ineffective.

Even St. Anthony was tempted; there is nothing particularly Buddhist about it.

Yet, the man who is not deceived will make his choice willingly and consciously, but he still makes the choice. In your account, you left out the notion of sacrifice. See for example the choices made by Zanon and Mejnor. Zanon made the sacrifice.

The Buddha, unlike the mass of men, was not deceived by the attraction of mortal life. Nevertheless, a Buddha rejects Nirvana and reincarnates willingly and deliberately.

Joe on 2020-07-21 at 23:09 said:

A reference to COVID-19 in 2018—is this a vindication of Marian visions?

Cologero on 2020-07-21 at 23:29 said:

Joe, you caught me red-handed re-editing old posts. So it is neither a prophetic vision nor the Mandela effect. But congrats for being such a careful reader.

3.13 Berdyayev and the Mirage of Progress

In these passages, taken from *The Destiny of Man*, **Nikolai Berdyayev** reveals his origins from Russian Hermetism and that he is more than a “philosopher” in the academic sense. He rejects the notion that we can study man as he is today and then extrapolate back to his origins. Like **Rene Guenon**, he sees what he calls modern savages as a degenerate form and not as the proto-man. Science shows us nothing about origins, since it merely masks “philosophic assumptions” as scientific fact. Interestingly enough, he proposes that the world was more “plastic” than it is now. Of course, this is identical to the claims of Tradition. By “Akashic Records”, we recognize Traditional Method⁵¹ or the technique of Hermetic meditation⁵².

Anthropologists and sociologists have devoted a great deal of attention to the primitive man but their methods and principles of investigation were determined by the evolutionary theory of the second half of the nineteenth century. They studied modern savages and from them drew conclusions about the primitive man. Scientific investigation in the strict sense was from the nature of the case impossible, but as a result of philosophic assumptions it was believe that, to being with, man was at a savage, half-animal stage and then, up to the nineteenth century, he gradually progressed. Man’s distant past was inferred from his present, from

⁵¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=624>

⁵²See Section 5.3 in this book.

savages and animals. The scientists' imagination was so poor that in man's distant past they could conceive of nothing different from what they found in modern times at the lower stages of life. But ancient man and his life were infinitely more significant and mysterious than anthropologists and sociologists suppose. In this respect theosophists and occultists are nearer the truth. There is something to be said for the Akashic Records, the Chronicle of the world, though the idea is easily vulgarized. At the dawn of humanity the world was at a different stage than it is now. It was more plastic, and the limits which divide this world from other worlds were less sharply marked. We are told this, in a covert form, in the book of Genesis.

Berdyayev continues with his critique of scientific evolutionism and denies that the study of primitive people of today or of animal behavior can tell us anything about the mentality of ancient civilizations. Like Guenon, he denies a unitary notion of progress. On the contrary, civilizations arise and die. The myth of Atlantis may serve as a warning to us. Rather than being the pinnacle of human evolution, modern man is more likely the degenerate, fallen, and weaker product of something much greater.

The evolutionary theory of the nineteenth century has been disproved both by science and philosophy, and cannot be used as the basis of the methods and principles of inquiry. It is inadmissible to transfer to the ancient, primitive humanity our habits of thought and feeling and our view of the world. Everything then was different, not at all similar either to the savages or to the animal world of our day. Levy Bruhl, criticizing Taylor and Fraser, tries to discover the nature of primitive thought, quite different from civilized people's thought, but his modern positivist and rationalistic mentality prevents him from understanding it. What he calls *la loi de participation* shows that primitive thought was of a higher type than that of the nineteenth-century man for it

expressed the mystical nearness of the knower to his object. Man loses as well as gains through the growth of civilization. He not only progresses but degenerates, falls, grows weaker and poorer. There is no doubt that some ancient knowledge connected with the proximity to the sources of being was lost by man in the course of time, and only a memory of it is left to him. There is no doubt that there existed great civilizations in the past, such as those of Babylon or Egypt, and that their fall meant a period of regress and a loss of tremendous achievements. There are considerable reasons to believe in the truth of the myth about Atlantis, where a very high civilization became morally degenerate and perished. It is far more likely that the savages as we know them are a product of degeneration and retrogression, and do not represent the primary stage of human development. In speaking of the primitive moral consciousness as we know it, we must not draw conclusions with regard to the first origins of mankind. The facts that lend themselves to study and observation are chronologically secondary and not primary.

Posted on 2010-08-22 by Cologero

3.14 Theosophy and Gnosis

A chapter in the book *Freedom and the Spirit* by **Nicolas Berdyaev** deals with the Theosophical movements vis-à-vis authentic gnosis. **Valentin Tomberg** writes that Berdyaev is one of those who “show in their works a progress which is very advanced in substantially bringing together intelligence and the intuition of faith.” Berdyaev was also respected by Evola for his “unsuccessful” attempt to recuperate Christianity for our time; they probably agreed on the freedom, creativity, and absoluteness of the person.

Berdyaev begins by pointing out that there already existed an “authentic Christian theosophy”, among whom he included: **Clement of Alexandria, Origen, Dionysus the Areopagite, Meister Eckhart, Jacob Boehme, Franz Xavier von Baader, and Vladimir Solovyov.** To them he adds the pagans **Heraclitus, Plato, and Plotinus.** In this sense “theosophy” means knowledge of the divine. **Helena Blavatsky’s** Theosophical movement, on the other hand, is unrelated to that tradition. Berdyaev describes her and other’s writings:

Contemporary theosophical writings are devoid of divine and creative inspiration. They betray no talent; they are frankly boring; they are, moreover, written in a style which would be more appropriate to a manual of mineralogy or geography; in fact they are almost impossible to read!

By “Theosophy”, Berdyaev is also including the anthroposophy of **Rudolf Steiner**, whom he finds more “interesting” (not truer).

He criticizes the intricacies of its cosmological system, particularly since “God” cannot even be found in that system. Theosophy is a child of its time, being a form of spiritualized naturalism and evolutionism that were—and are—in vogue. It makes no demands as the spiritual world is attained automatically through evolution.

Theosophy as Symptom Theosophy is philosophically naïve and its adherents unsuited to high culture. We could say that the movement abounds with over-educated proles who thus seek a simple spiritual teaching that is allegedly based on science and the secret teachings of the ages. This is proved by the fact that there has arisen little in the way of high culture and incisive social commentary from theosophical quarters. The one exception may be Tomberg, but his magnum opus was created after he abandoned that movement.

Nevertheless, despite the “very low level of theosophical literature” and “charlatanism”, it must be taken seriously when understood as a symptom of the crisis of Christianity and science, which may no longer speak to contemporary man. Unfortunately, it does not challenge the modern world, but rather adopts its values as a sign of evolution. Thus, it will ultimately fail to satisfy the “deep spiritual longing” which depend on religious faith and authentic mysticism.

Secret and Mystery Ostensibly claiming to be an esoteric teaching, Theosophy really turns it into a form of exoterism. Its esoterism offers a “secret rather than a mystery”. A secret is information, conceptual thought, that can be told by one person to another; there is a natural human fascination with knowing a secret that others do not know. However, a mystery cannot be communicated that way, it is ineffable. It depends on one’s own experience and intuition; the way can be pointed out, but each man must reach the destination on his own, depending on his own spiritual level.

Of course, Christianity also recognizes the distinction between the exoteric and esoteric. Berdyaev writes:

There is both a deeper and a more superficial understanding of Christianity. Esoterism in Christianity almost coincides with mysticism. Christian mystics have been truly esoteric. But the contemplation to which they devoted themselves, though beyond the reach of simple Christians, has nothing of the enigmatic about it. To understand them completely it is only necessary to possess an experience similar to theirs.

It is not clear to Berdyaev exactly what the esoterism of Theosophy consists of. He points out the profound difference between a Blavatsky or Steiner and a **Jacob Boehme** or **Louis Claude de Saint-Martin**. He claims that “when pagan polytheism flourished, monotheism was

regarded as an esoteric truth to be hidden from the masses who were unable to reach such a high level.” But he asks:

What still remains to be discovered is what constitutes esoterism in an age of confusion like the present one, which is without any unique, integral, and predominant belief.

The Conception of Man There is a radical and profound difference in the way Man is understood in Christianity and in Theosophy. Of the former Berdyaev writes:

Christianity is anthropocentric and anthroposophic in the truest sense of the words. According to Christianity, man is the highest order of being and is superior even to the angelic hierarchy. The Son of God became incarnate in a man and not in an angel. ... he is created in the image and likeness of God, he is not a product of cosmic evolution nor is he re-absorbed by it; he is not the child of nature. ... The human species cannot be eclipsed by a new race, whether of supermen, angels, or demons.

There is much more, but the point is clear. There is no evolution beyond man, which is the implication of the previous series of posts on involution and evolution. In particular:

1. There will be no evolution into higher races, with new “organs”, such as Steiner taught
2. There is no “superman” coming as Nietzsche believed
3. There will be no transhuman based on technology

There is no secret, but there is a mystery. The open secret is that we know who man is and what he must do to be “saved” or “liberated”. The mystery then is to actually follow that path. This is because:

The Christian conception of man is hierarchical and not evolutionist. Man is not a transitory fragment of the cosmos, a mere step in its evolution; he is superior to the cosmos, independent of its infinity, and in principle embraces it completely.

The Theosophical understanding is that man is a temporary and fleeting manifestation in an indefinitely long cosmic process. He comes into being and is dissolved again.

Pagan Gnosticism Berdyaev points out that in Theosophy man is but the play of cosmic forces, formed by the hierarchy of spirits superior to man. This part is unclear to me, given the genuine teachings of Dionysus. I believe the point is that the angels are free and do not block communion with God, while the theosophical hierarchy of spirits limits man's freedom. But the next point he makes is very telling:

Theosophy re-establishes the old demonolatry and man remains subject to the genii.

Evola and Berdyaev part ways on this point. For Evola, the daemons, genii, manes, Laertes are an essential part of pagan teachings. For Berdyaev, however, they are the reminders of the time when man was unfree and bound to such spirits. Thus he can conclude:

The freedom of the human spirit achieved by Christianity is no more and we are confronted with a return to ancient, semi-Christian, semi-pagan, Gnosticism.

Berdyaev then makes this observation:

Theosophy and anthroposophy of every variety deny personality, and combat this principle in the interests of a sort of cosmic communion. They complicate the problem by failing to observe the

distinction between personality and individuality. For Christian thought personality is a spiritual category while individuality is a biological one.

Both Evola and Berdyaev are in perfect agreement with that conclusion. Readers will have to decide about the role of the daemons in man's life.

Excursus on Various Traditions At this point, I want to bring in a discussion that Berdyaev did not deem necessary, although his thought has consequences for the answer. While Tradition sees hierarchy and inequality everywhere, it is strangely egalitarian when it comes to the various traditions. That is, Rene Guenon will say that each tradition is identical and the choice is arbitrary. Normally, a man follows the tradition of his people, but more advanced souls will choose one based on their personal needs. Furthermore, those very advanced will be beyond any particular tradition, as Evola believed himself to be.

On the one hand, a metaphysical teaching must be complete. On the other, it is impossible not to notice that traditions follow each other in time. Could we not regard this in the same way as the involution of man? That is, there is one main axis which represents the "perfect" tradition. The various traditions are attempts to manifest it, some closer some further away. There are futile lateral branches that are in reality counter or anti-traditions.

Excursus on Reincarnation In personal conversations, I have noticed that there is a great deal of confusion about the question of reincarnation in relation to tradition. Let us be completely clear at the outset. This is not a question to be decided by whether or not such and such a tradition "teaches" reincarnation. That question is irrelevant and its only purpose would be to distinguish false from true traditions. No, the only way to deal with this issue is to understand the metaphysics of it. Once it is

clearly understood that reincarnation is simply not possible, there can be no more doubt. No one today who understands math and science will bother trying to square the circle or build a perpetual motion machine. Although Guenon, Coomaraswamy, and Evola have critiqued the idea of crude reincarnation, it is still wise to consider Berdyaev's point of view. He explains, in regards to the various theosophical systems:

Man is reincarnated and thus loses his image, the substratum of personality ... the unique and integral, the ontological core of things, can be found nowhere. Personality comes together and then dissolves, only to reappear in other personalities. ... Man possesses a physical body which corresponds to the mineral kingdom, an etheric body which corresponds to that of plants, an astral body which corresponds to that of animals, and a spiritual Ego which has an affinity with God. All these constituent parts are then dissolved and so personality itself disappears.

Berdyaev compares this to those Russian Easter eggs, each one containing a smaller version within itself. While traditional teachings also understand the various soul elements in man, they nevertheless constitute a unity. Hence, you cannot take the vegetal soul of one being and arbitrarily combine it with the intellectual soul of another, like some children's game of Mr. Potato Head. As we recently pointed out, the spirit, or rational-intellectual soul, of man is attracted to a given genotype and historical-social situation. It would be absurd for the soul to incarnate at a different time into a completely different genotype and situation. This is what Guenon means by his claim that a being can be in the human state just one time.

It is this unity of personality that Berdyaev emphasizes: man as body, soul, person, an integral whole not an arbitrary construction.

Part II will deal with the failures of the Christian churches to teach an authentic gnosis in our time and what the solution might be.

Posted on 2013-04-24 by Cologero

* * *

Mihai on 2013-04-25 at 04:09 said:

This post is outstanding. I don't have the time nor the disposition right now to discuss the many profound and extremely points brought here.

I will have to engage in a deeper study of Berdyaev's work, as I believe that he might be a great source to balance some of the views more problematic views of the traditionalists.

Jason-Adam on 2013-04-25 at 13:45 said:

Indeed this post is quite outstanding.

Let me say that the concept of hierarchically arranged traditions can reconcile the notions of perennial philosophy with the fact that there is no salvation outside the Church.

Synodius on 2013-04-26 at 10:15 said:

I'm trying to understand mechanics of incarnation from the traditional perspective, and don't know how to view the nature of the spirit. I'll try to summarize how I see it, correct me please if I am wrong.

The spirit is the most universal part of man, but it is still subject to some limitations until it realizes the supreme identity. Until then (although time is taken only analogically here) it enters some degree of existence where it clothes itself with an individual soul corresponding to its specific nature and the soul then in turn clothes itself with a corresponding body. Individual faculties somehow provide means needed by the spirit for achieving the liberation. This can be done while still in the body or after death while still in the same degree of existence, although preserving individual consciousness after death is a kind of achievement which is not automatic. If this is not achieved, at the end of the cycle the being is reabsorbed and thrown into another degree of existence in the new one, into circumstances that are only in some way analogous to that in the previous incarnation but necessarily different (as the whole degree of existence is different), again determined by the nature of the spirit. Was this nature in some way changed or updated by the acts in previous life? Or only in some cases, because acts that modify just corporality for example, cannot touch the spirit?

There is no trace of individual memory from the life in different degree, so the individual consciousness has only one shot to be around during the liberation. If after death the individual consciousness is preserved can it enter some body by force so to speak? If the soul, body and circumstances change, is there some margin of change within which these can be still linked exclusively to the same spirit? And what about the change in the spirit itself? Are these questions

wrongly posed? I've read Evola's *Awakening*, now going through *Multiple states & S.of the Cross* and trying to make some sense of it...

August on 2013-04-27 at 14:31 said:

Interesting, relevant, and also disturbing questions.

"... re-emerging into circumstances that are only in some way analogous to that in the previous incarnation but necessarily different (as the whole degree of existence is different), again determined by the nature of the spirit."

Moreover, if one's incarnation is and can only be a reflection of the 'color' of his spirit, and we have attained the centrality and metaphysical opportunity of a human birth, how great is the risk that we lose this centrality in our next round of existence (assume no total liberation, and the active refusal to accept religious preservation of the human state via salvation)? Recall Guenon's ominous paragraph about the danger of being reborn as the equivalent of an animal or vegetable!

That should give us all something to chew over, especially if the human state really is so superior to other beings; yet this view is primarily theological, and would be strange if transposed to the infinitude of Possibility, given that there is nothing inherently impossible about the idea of an indefinite number of states of being with more freedom, and hence superiority, than the human.

Caleb Cooper on 2013-04-28 at 11:13 said:

Human superiority is based on his spiritual nature; i.e. he contains the full image of God, which he derives from his prototype, Adam, before the Fall. Now granted that down here for nearly all humans this remains an unrealized potential, because the likeness of God has been distorted, and we are in present fact inferior to the spiritual hierarchies.

To flesh this out a bit, God can exercise his creative power through all the infinite realms of creation. Man is the closest being to God in that the full image within him gives him this freedom as well. Most angels have very narrow ranges in which they are content to act as go-betweens, transmitting God's powers to.

They aren't very aware or interested of things outside their purview. There are many places "where angels fear to tread"; in my inner work on myself and others I've noticed that when you're in a negative place where the vibrations are very low and dense, it can be very hard to invoke the aid of angels. Tomberg expresses this as them being so pure that if they tried to force themselves to descend to an atmosphere where the devil is strongly present, the atmosphere would not support them; i.e. there would not be enough celestial oxygen and they would "faint", lose consciousness and float back up to where they can breathe. In these cases one can often still invoke the help of the Saints, showing the superiority of man in his ability to travel and be active where angels fear to tread.

We should note the incident recorded in the Islamic tradition where the most glorious of the Cherubim, Lucifer, was brought by God to the newly created Adam, and told to bow before him. Because of his pride however Lucifer refused, setting in motion his fall and sowing the great enmity between the devil and man.

God created man for a greater purpose than any other order of beings; to be His vicar in the created realms, the one entrusted to tend and cultivate God's garden. Adam can be seen exercising this prerogative in the naming the animals which gave them their missions. With the fall man lost his position as God's regent, but Christ reversed this fall and restored the image and likeness of man, ascending back to the position of God's representative to all the realms which has always been our birthright to reclaim if we wish.

TL:DR The truly human state understood as its essential spiritual core is the full image of God and thus superior to even the angels.

Cologero on 2013-05-05 at 15:28 said:

Synodius and August: I have considered adding to these comments, but decided the only alternatives are Silence or a long discourse. The discourse is unnecessary since many have previously addressed these questions in a deep way, and you fellows have read them. But as our recent translations have shown, it is insufficient to consider these questions solely on a rational basis. However, there is a post planned for this week that will address this topic in part. I'll keep these thoughts in mind.

Shankara mentions the opportunity of the human birth, but adds some conditions as we shall see. Although Guenon has remarked that there is nothing special about the human state, given indefinite possibilities, it is not clear what he means. Even in his Islam, the angels superior states had to bow down to Adam. So, despite – or perhaps because of – its difficulties, it offers possibilities that other states don't. As for "salvation", Shankara points out that both the celestial (or heaven) and the hell body, do not offer these possibilities. Actually, they are extensions of the human state.

As was pointed out, acts cannot "change" the spirit, which is transcendent to them. However, there can presumably be changes from the human state to another; that is why the teaching of a literal reincarnation makes no sense. If you return again as a human, then what could possibly have been gained? But the spirit has various possibilities of manifestation, including those of the human state. So it make not be so much that the spirit "changed", but rather than it had to undergo a necessary step in order to reach a higher state. Obviously, this all ends in a flash with final liberation.

August on 2013-05-10 at 06:55 said:

FWIW, here is my reply to Caleb Cooper (delayed by comment system problems), the aim of which is to propose horizons beyond the human that lack nothing of the potential for complete

realization that humans enjoy here:

Yes, good notes Mr Cooper, especially about the ability of the Saints to intercede in realms where even Angels will not. By activating the potential of human centrality in this realm, and realizing it, one may gain access to the sole 'portal' between the worlds, the 'Universal Axis', if you like. We have learned the general names of such men, common between some traditions, as Primordial Man (one who realizes centrality of the human), and Universal Man (one who is absolutely liberated in this life), both of whom are of course more than mere natural men.

But beyond theology, and hence beyond our human state of being, every world is centered around the Universal Axis (=omnipresent God), and so there ought to be an indefinite number of states with beings that are situated at the center of their respective universe, with all the potential that this implies, and who are therefore in an equivalent position to we humans in this state. They too can pursue complete Deliverance, no less than we. Moreover, their state may be characterized by less pitfalls, less grossness, or be shared with fewer other beings; any number of other conditions that render their world and state relatively freer and perhaps superior to ours might apply.

Indeed, the whole idea of an initiatic hierarchy implies an indefinite series of states that are superior to our point of departure here, such that one who realizes his human potential partially (by going beyond the human), but not fully in the Great Liberation, may be reborn in a state where his centrality with respect to the Axis is preserved, and he is somehow better placed than in his earthly life. He may already have some experience of this state during his work in this life. And if we have had many traditions in our particular world, we can be assured that traditions of a kind are to be found in superior worlds, ever calling us home. But at some point of development, the experience of a given being is likely to converge with that of others, despite the point of departure; and the Universal Man need have no concern for superior states, because he has reached perfection beyond all states of being, and he 'will not be born again'.

TL;DR Any state of being that is a full expression of the potential of its world will be centered around the nucleus of that world, which nucleus is penetrated by the Universal Axis, allowing that central being potentially direct access to union with God (Being) and Deliverance. Such cases necessarily involve transcendence of the particular state in which the being commenced the work. Man may be potentially superior to Angels, given their inherent limits, but not necessarily to other central states of being beyond this world, all of which can theoretically be used to attain the final goal directly.

Those who have not approached metaphysical premises outside of a religious framework, as pure concepts, may find these explanations unclear. There are no contradictions with theology, mainly a different vocabulary and broader scope. Guenon's 'Multiple States of the Being' is a primary source.

Nevertheless, life is a mystery, and there is much room for prayer at this stage, that the mercy of God will bless us with the light that we need on our path of return, just as He has found

fit to show us this world.

Synodius on 2013-05-15 at 21:42 said:

If I understand correctly the geometrical representation from Symbolism of the Cross it is not the human state (or any other state) as such that is important, it is only its central point that is of metaphysical importance, the point corresponding to the True Man, which makes this state the starting point for the realization of the Universal Man. The being at this central point is superior in a way even to a being in a higher state but who has still not attained the center of its own state, that would explain why angels have to bow before a Man (in the center), but this superiority would not be exclusive for the human state because this can also be said about any state in relation to its respective higher states and so Guenon can say that the human state is not in any way special. This would also mean that theoretically by reincarnation into the same state but with better chances for reaching the center you could gain something while on the other hand by moving a level up to a higher state doesn't necessarily mean an improvement from the point of view of total liberation, because you start analogically in the same distance from the center as you were located in the previous state in the moment of death which is identical with the birth to the other state to which you were transported by the will of Heaven. This moment of death is not the same as the death of the body and various teachings about post mortem events (toll houses, tibetan book of the dead...) deal only with what follows bodily death but precedes death/birth to another state and what determines its outcome; and are not to be taken literally because the womb to which one gravitate according to eastern conception would be on a completely different plane and past sins which are emphasised in the west are just something like habitual gravitational fields which make it hard to remain detached in the moment of this death. I still have a lot of questions but this is a sketch of how I imagine guenonian 'reincarnation' might work...

Synodius on 2013-05-16 at 08:06 said:

Maybe I am trying to read too much into the Guenon's geometric representation which really impressed me but I felt the need to add more detail into it to get a more complete idea of how it works in a mechanistic sense, which might not be its purpose. I think it's message is really powerful: by locating the whole psychic realm into the same plane as just an extension of the human state it puts things into the right perspective and prevents seeing any kind of psychic curiosity as 'spiritual', and by emphasizing the indefinite multitude of the states it makes one see the relativity and contingency of all conceptions that are too human. While I appreciate all this and was never a fan of the usual idea of reincarnation (because of all the stupidity that usually goes with it, e.g. I learned recently that a woman teaching taiji in the park in my area claims that she learned it in China where she lived 500 years ago although the form she teaches is a short Chen style form which is around 70y old) is it really impossible in this model? The

soul could under certain conditions (not necessarily as a rule) continue in a different body which could have a benefit of not having to pass through a 'hard reset' by the birth into a completely different state. The possibility of a more conscious continuation would make the methods that claim to help with this transition more interesting. Also the cases of demonic possessions, if they are not taken only psychologically, would suggest the possibility of breaking the exclusive link of one spirit/one soul/one body. Also, where would you locate the spirit in the geometric representation? Only at the central points along the Axis? This way the spirit would always be transcendent with respect to all contingencies represented by the horizontal line or plane, but then how to imagine the differences between the spirits of different beings? This is something which led me to ask maybe inappropriately about the possible change in the spirit, about some kind of spiritual substance that undergoes change. I spent too much time using some kind of jungian psychological container for everything higher than matter and now reading Guenon I am discovering that there is much more to this distinction of body/soul/spirit that I learned as a catholic kid. And while I understand the differences between intellectual and merely mental and imaginative faculties that Guenon stresses so often, I still have troubles to put it all into a coherent model. I know, rational systematization can become an obstacle to experiential knowledge, but maybe someone can relate more details to that geometric representation without distorting it

August on 2013-05-16 at 10:26 said:

Hi Synodius. I have given thought to similar strong questions, and offer some more views here. As always, we are dealing with considerations derived from a true premise, in an attempt to explore the boundaries of possibility through logical application of 'consequentials'. I heartily invite anyone to challenge what I have set out by pointing out potential flaws or misapplications of logic, from first principles to conclusions. Let us not abide by error!

—

"... the womb to which one gravitate according to eastern conception would be on a completely different plane..."

You could well be using the term 'womb' in a figurative sense, but let me emphasize that there ought to be states of being where one is not born in the progenerative sense.

"... is earthly reincarnation really impossible in this model? The soul could under certain conditions (not necessarily as a rule) continue in a different body which could have a benefit of not having to pass through a 'hard reset' by the birth into a completely different state."

Firstly, let's clarify that by 'soul' we are referring to an individual's particular subtle elements, and not some higher faculty. Now, assuming that by 'different body' you mean being born again after physical death into a newly conceived body, how could this constitute continuity unless the infant was born with the knowledge that the previous human had accumulated up to the point of death? This does not happen. As for 'migrating' into an already grown body, what does

that say about the soul already connected to that body? Such a case would be some sort of demonic machination, and not what you are referring to.

Now, to establish why earthly reincarnation really is an impossibility under that model, we need consider questions of time. Time, as a succession of events, is a particular condition of this state of being. As such, it is illusory, and cannot be transposed to the Absolute. In actuality, we (our Spirit) are all that is, and has always been; there is no time in the Spirit, only an absolute metaphysical moment, that all states serve to veil. Our Spirit is simultaneously participating in all possible states, in a moment that we shall call the Eternal Present. Our advantage on earth as humans is that we have the intellective faculty that allows us to conceive of this fact (that we are Spirit in human form) in an abstract way, and work toward directing the energies contained in the re-presentation of this world to our journey home by direct means, so that (ideally) we do not meet with another existence and its particular, veiled modes of awareness. The tragedy is that the very faculty and world that allows us to do this must be consumed and destroyed by this heroic battle, together with an indefinite number of other lives that we might have become fixed in (assuming Deliverance)! Yet, in victory, we attain eternity, because the course of our whole time on earth was only an instant from the perspective of our Spirit, and it is an instant that plays forever. It was the act that our Spirit projected once into eternity, and your life is the way the Eternal Present looks and must needs look through the prism of this state of being. The fact that we get to see it, and conceive of its time, history, and future development, does not change the primary fact that our experience of it is taking place within the instant of the everpresent Spirit.

Imagine a powder. When it is burnt by fire, it creates red smoke. When it is dissolved in water, red fluid. The powder is your Spirit, the fire and water states of being. Earthly reincarnation would be akin to taking this powder and seeing it become green when burnt by the same fire, or yellow when dissolved in the same water, randomly. This could only happen if the powder changed, in which case it is not the eternal Spirit.

Now, does any of this negate the possibility of some Master Adept returning, actively and voluntarily, to earth, say by appearing spontaneously in some desolate meadow, in human form but without any human needs, to reminisce about that time on earth when he was subject to the illusion of time? To see how his old home in this state looks now that he has gone 'beyond Being'? I can't exactly conceive of how going beyond form would affect the possibilities of form – how objective is the existence of the world of forms to one who goes beyond them?

Importantly, if our Spirit is characteristically reflected on earth as a wise human, alongside other Spirits that are briefly here as tulips, paprikas, and cockatoos, why exactly would we incongruently manifest in another state as an equivalent of these non-intellectual beings? Guenon openly suggested this was the case, but it seems that this is merely so because it is possible. Truly a mysterious universe where one's Spirit incorporates the possibility of effectively subjecting itself to a great and wise life in one state, whilst simultaneously being a lowly worm

in another, and hanging the Sword of Damocles over its own head, that it might become centered in awareness of a dull state and all its grim attendants! Are we to take comfort in the idea that a man, composed as he is of parts, can choose to recoil from his lower nature and avoid ever having to fix his intellection amongst the existential possibilities of that dark part of his Spirit? Or maybe there is some consolation hidden in these lesser states.

In any case, Deliverance is not a question of 'nothingness,' in the sense of everything ceasing after one has experienced life (this is a horrible thought!). Deliverance seems like a full and complete repossession of the Great Unity, making it one with your Self. I do not see how this could happen without implying the eradication of anything that is not Self or willed by Self, such that you are anything and everything thereafter (where 'things' apply). And this brings us to your next question.

"... how to imagine the differences between the spirits of different beings?"

Yes, let us try to clarify somehow. Here I would emphasize the importance of Non-Being. If we stopped at Being, it would seem that all spirits simply converge in God, and that any resulting differences are merely His choices expressed on contingent planes. In this case it would be odd to talk of Self in a transcendent sense at all, there would just be many contingent beings with relative selves and a God at the center representing an absolute limit. But in Non-Being there is a 'space,' if you like, wherein is an Absoluteness that is totally effaced, such that it can house non-converging differences that are capable of total expansion without limiting one another. Hence, apophatically, the Infinite. Pure Being is something like a prototype of all possibilities of Being, wherein differences can manifest indefinitely, but are all permutations of Being, their common element.

The Spirit should be conceived as a reflection of the Great Unity, combining both Being and Non-Being.

"Also, where would you locate the spirit in the geometric representation? Only at the central points along the Axis?"

In the three-dimensional cross representation, the spirit passes through the center, but is not actually there, and it emanates everywhere. Think of the physical sun as a ball, at the center of which is a port opening onto a hypothetical world of pure light; at this center we have the highest concentration of light in our world, but its rays permeate our whole world to greater or lesser extents, and through a greater or lesser variety of obstacles.

Cologero on 2013-05-22 at 23:00 said:

Synodius, in the Spiritist Fallacy Guenon gives a clearer account, albeit in passing. "Transmigration means the transition to a different state. This is unlike the popular notion of reincarnation which can only be a "migration". He also points out the possibilities of psychic inheritance, which may in some instances take several generations to recur. Again, this psychic inheritance does not prove "reincarnation" although it may "feel" that way to those who are sensitive to it.

Sigurd on 2017-08-02 at 21:33 said:

Removing some latent Theosophical ideas has been one of the primary obstacles I've faced in approaching the subject of tradition. Even in reading contemporary works that may be helpful in explicating the lived experience of traditional societies, it is often difficult to ascertain elements of another order mingled in. An example that comes to mind is Jeremy Naydler's *Temple of the Cosmos*, where he gives a brilliant introduction to Egyptian tradition, but makes a point that the way of experiencing the cosmos "sympathetically," having a symbolical sensitivity to cosmic events, and seeing thought-forms and emotions as "other" and as beings, has been, more-or-less, superseded in the natural evolution of consciousness, seemingly suggesting that a sort of "coenaesthesia" is the "bridge" to the next stage of human consciousness.

On this topic, perhaps I can request a response (or referred to an appropriate place to edify myself) on the topic of the astral or "etheric" body. It is to my understanding that the contemporary notion of the subtle body as a 'projectable,' spectral-like doppelganger of the corporeal body finds its roots in Theosophism. The etheric body in a traditional sense (including all those variations that envelope Neoplatonism, Hinduism, etc.) is a sort of vehicle or ochema of the Self that links the Self to the conditions of the body/somatic vehicle. It is thus a modality of consciousness, in contrast to a projection of a sort of prefigured, animated "double," though the latter is an ability one acquires in the course of initiation.

Is this, then, the appropriate understanding of the subtle form? To where ought one categorize such phenomena as contemporary "astral projection" or projection of a double that is considered the subtle form by some occultists and spiritualists? Would much appreciate a response, Cologero.

3.15 Thoughts around the Maypole

When we plunge into those mute and motionless depths in which the muddy stream of our actuality has its source, being careful not to violate its purity and peace, we come into inward contact, in this source of our own spiritual life, with the source of the universal life.

VLADIMIR SOLOVYOV

While some people can only see a certain world leader as a thug, we are incredulous that a mere thug would be reading and recommending

thinkers like **Vladimir Solovyov** or **Nicolai Berdyaev**. Perhaps we will go through the former's Justification of the Good to look for clues to world events. For now, however, we are still trying to explicate Solovyov's description of creation through God's three positings. It should be read in conjunction with **Rene Guenon**'s Multiple States of Being, as it fills in the missing gap from possibility to actuality.

The Artist and the Creative Act Solovyov uses the example of the creativity of the artist as analogy, another example of the Hermetic method. It is worth meditating on this. Of the forms of man's spiritual activity in the world – religion, art, politics, science, economics – why does Solovyov choose the artist? Like God, the artist holds his artistic ideas in his consciousness. Solovyov explains:

The artistic idea is certainly not alien or external to the artist. It is the artist's own inner essence, the core of his spirit and the content of his life; it is what makes him what he is. In striving to realize or embody this idea in an actual work of art, the artist wishes merely to have this inner essence, this idea, not only within himself, but also for himself, or before himself as an object. The artist wishes to represent his own as "another", in another, objective form.

This applies especially to the writer, who strives to objectify his thoughts in written form. This form should be beautiful, coherent, intelligible, accurate, grammatical, rhetorically stimulating, and so on. Solovyov does qualify this analogy when he admits that

Artistic creation presupposes a certain passive state of inspiration or inner reception, in which the artist does not possess an idea but is possessed by it.

This just means that the idea is prior to any manifestation of it and arises out of non-being. Even as the idea is being formed as a thought in

consciousness, that is the beginning of objectification. **Valentin Tomberg** develops this concept fully in the fourth Letter, as he discusses the stages from inspiration to the “book”.

So the first positing is the idea in mind, and the second is its objectification. This object is both other and not-other. This unity of the object with the creator is the third positing. That is, the object is part of multiplicity, yet it is a manifestation of the unity in the artist’s consciousness.

Is the analogy clear? Or is another inspiration necessary?

Microcosms and Heaps Organic unity is the expression of one spirit in multiplicity. A heap is collection of independent units with little more than proximity in common. An organism, therefore, is the objectification of one idea. A heap is the manifestation of many ideas, even if they seem to be somewhat related.

The modern mind cannot focus, has no power of concentration, and is therefore attracted to heaps. It loves the intellectual diversity, just as some people prefer the variety at the food court in their local mall. There is an intellectual thrill that comes with hearing new ideas, very like the feeling of a boy opening his birthday gifts. As such it is part of the glamour of the world, a tinsel attraction, and just adds to the chaos in the noosphere.

Those organizations that pretend to oppose the modern world need to be true to the etymology of the word, i.e., it should be an organic unity, rather than a heap. The organization, the conference, needs to be a microcosm, a replication of the new society it has in mind. This is a fourfold vision. Otherwise, it devolves into a single vision, Newton’s sleep, a simple concept that is the least common denominator. There is multiplicity with no unity.

The political as artistic creation.

Posted on 2014-05-01 by Cologero

3.16 The Artist of the Future

According to **Boris Mouravieff**, there are four fields of study to understand man's interior and exterior worlds: **Philosophy**, **Religion**, **Science**, and **Art**. The history of Western civilization has been the dominance of one or another of those forms in succession. We are currently in the age of science, in which the scientist has displaced the philosopher of the ancient world and the theologian of the medieval. Art, however, is the synthesis of the preceding three forms. That synthesis is the opposite of a revolution, which is based on division. So reaction is not a looking back, but a going forward. Hermetic philosophy can elucidate these stages. But only a crisis provides the opportunities for the manifestation of latent forces, assuming they still exist.

The Triad of Providence, Will, and Destiny are the powers that govern the manifested universe (see **Rene Guenon**, *The Great Triad*). The different ages focused on one of these powers. The synthesis will be knowledge of the whole, i.e., the tetrad. **Fabre d'Olivet** explains:

These three powers — **Providence**; **Man**, or more precisely the human kingdom; and **Destiny** — together make up the universal ternary. Nothing escapes their action. Everything in the universe is subordinate to them — everything, that is, except for God Himself, who embraces all three in his unfathomable unity so as to form the tetrad of the ancients, that immense quaternary which is all in all and apart from which there is nothing.

The Age of Philosophy

Providential law is the law of the divine man. He lives a life primarily of the intellect, which is governed by that law.

FABRE D'OLIVET

It is the philosopher who lives a life of the intellect, that is, a life of contemplation of Being. In Being, there are the essences or, as Guenon calls them, “possibilities”. From that perspective, there is no difference between possibilities of manifestation and possibilities of non-manifestation. The philosopher seeks the Wisdom to live the good life. For him, it is simply a question of knowledge. If ignorance of what is good is the problem, then knowledge is the solution. Since Being has no beginning, he regards the world as Eternal.

Nevertheless, this wisdom is available to the few, since the bulk of men neither seek it, nor understand it when it is explained to them. That is why Aristotle can claim that most men are born slaves. That does not mean they live as chattel slaves, but rather that they need to be directed.

That is the natural order of things, so the best state is the aristocratic, or rule of the best⁵³. That requires, however, that men could recognize the best. That is not the case, since the best are recognized today only in athletic competitions and beauty. That is why they are so popular today. Hence, the degeneration of the castes is described by Plato as the fall from aristocracy to democracy in several stages.

The Age of Religion The next age is that of religion. Here the focus moves to the Will. Ignorance, or defect of the intelligence, is not the problem, but rather sin, or defect of the Will.

Thus, **Augustine** finds a meaning deeper than what the philosophers see. For him, slavery is the fruit of sin. As the Fathers often pointed out, the sinner has as many masters as he has vices. The doctrine of “original sin” just means that all men are born as slaves in this sense.

The philosopher believed a man could become just by overcoming ignorance. However, the theologian sees that justification can only come from something transcendent. Hence, man becomes free only through a second birth into this higher state.

⁵³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7730>

Therefore, the just, or well-ordered, state is governed by the cross and the eagle.

The Age of Science As the awareness of Being and Will faded, attention fell on Destiny, which is nature under necessity. The claims of the philosopher and the theologian could not be verified in nature. The ordering principle of Religion, which had maintained civilization for centuries, lost its force as the Will weakened.

Religious restrictions came to be seen as forms of slavery rather than as the path to liberation from slavery. There is no need to repeat what's been said many times before, but Science did have great success in forming, or deforming, a civilization. However, the limitations of empiricism as an explanatory principle, are becoming quite apparent, even if only to a few.

There are two conflicting directions. On the one hand, science represents the final stage of the degeneration of the castes, not even anticipated by Guenon and Evola. Whereas the philosopher and theologian were aware of transcendent states, for the scientist, man is just another mammal. The consequences of this are seldom made explicit even by the educated and intelligent classes. Of course, it may very well be that current day rulers are nothing but mammals. Esoteric tradition teaches that there are degrees of men, dependent on their dominant chakra. Moreover, it also teaches that there are anthropoids with a human exterior, but without an intellectual soul. This is actually becoming accepted by mainstream thinking.

The other direction is the advancement of technology, which has made living easier in many ways. That opens the possibility for general prosperity, but the verdict is still out on that. However, it also makes possible mass manipulation and control. The will lead to a form of slavery unknown to previous eras.

The Age of the Artist

As far back as the beginnings of recorded history we find evidence that the Tradition taught the way to cross this moat by knowledge of oneself and by working on oneself.

BORIS MOURAVIEFF, *Gnosis Book Two*

The wise man will rule the stars

Rosicrucian maxim

The Artist of the future will be a philosopher, knight, saint, and scientist. He will integrate the intellectual, psychic and instinctive spheres into a whole. That integration is the True Will, so the Artist must needs be the conscious creator of his life. This is liberation from necessity, as Guenon explains:

In uniting itself to Providence and consciously collaborating with it, the human Will can become a counter-balance to destiny and finally neutralise it... the Will hard won by faith this shows that it is related to Providence is capable of enslaving Necessity itself, controlling Nature and producing miracles.

Pythagorean maxim

On the principle that Atman is Brahman, the knowledge of the whole, then, begins with self-knowledge. This knowledge leads to the Real I and True Will. Then,

Esoteric Tradition teaches that any civilization is none other than a projection of the consciousness of the 'I's of elite man onto the exterior world.

Hence, the Artist will need to have a creative imagination that can visualize a new civilization and bring it into manifestation.

Posted on 2016-02-23 by Cologero

* * *

Matthew Anderson on 2016-02-24 at 21:57 said:

I like that term, "intentional sociopath". Here are the writings of a modern day intentional sociopath: <http://vongremmler.blogspot.com/>

Richard (the author of the blog) died in July, but he would have liked it too. It describes him well.

Formally, his articles are about "psychology", and he often refers to his ideas as "theories". But he uses that term to get past people's ego-defenses. His insights come neither from a scientific nor a theoretical perspective. His knowledge is from direct experience. For anyone wishing to develop their emotional center, this would be the perfect material for that.

Mark Citadel on 2016-03-08 at 09:34 said:

Precise and on point as always:

"But only a crisis provides the opportunities for the manifestation of latent forces"

I become more certain of this with each passing day. Greatness cannot emerge from a world of decadence, a world of inverted caste. It must rise from the smoke of chaos, for in such an environment those who do not wake from their slumber perish, and those who do open their eyes find the organic will of God before them. Civilization rises like a phoenix.

Mark Citadel on 2016-03-10 at 17:13 said:

By the way, Cologero, I just posted up a review of René Guénon's 'The Crisis of the Modern World'. It's hard to express just how much I appreciated this book. A sage of Reaction!

<http://citadelfoundations.blogspot.com/2016/03/rene-guenons-crisis-of-modern-world.html>

Christian Doctrine and Theology

4.1 Justification and Postmortem States

Fear God, and keep his commandments: for this is the whole duty of man. For God shall bring every work into judgment, with every secret thing, whether it be good, or whether it be evil.

Ecclesiastes 12:13-14

In the *Paradisio* of Dante's *Divine Comedy*, that great mystical work, the coming of the soul into the Presence of the Divine Light is a gradual process. One cannot come into the Divine fullness all at once; it is too intense to be perceived. Preparation is needed. It has to be a slow process of knowing, a seeing of more and more, a progressive revelation to the soul of God's ineffable Light. The soul then comes to a point where she sees everything in a flash, but the distance to this point, not in spatial terms but spiritual, is great. In this understanding, Dante is following his own experience.

WAYNE TEASDALE, *Essays in Mysticism*

The Lord Jesus Christ ... will judge the living and the dead

2 Tim 4:1

Man must recognize his complicity in the act of evil.

CARL JUNG, *The Red Book*

Die before you Die The Initiate is one who strives to become a *jivan-mukta*, someone liberated while still in the body. Or in other words, the goal is the Beatific Vision while still in the body. That requires the three-fold Christian path of purgation, illumination, and union. The Saint and the Initiate therefore die to this life in order to experience a spiritual birth.

Christianity is the not religion of Jesus, but rather the religion of Christ. The modernists prefer to focus entirely on the “historical Jesus”, the end result of which is the religion of this-worldly humanitarianism. But Jesus is the first coming of the Logos. St. Augustine’s realization that this Logos was tied also to Platonism led to his conversion. The exoteric teaching is that there will be future comings of Christ.

However, the second coming is not just an event in linear time, but in eternity. Hence, the second coming of Christ is the birth of the Logos in the soul. When the soul is still and purified, the Logos is born as the rebirth of the soul.

John Ruysbroeck, among others, also writes about the third coming of Christ, this time as Judge. The point is not to condemn, but rather to offer healing through forgiveness.

General Judgment The General Judgment, or Last Judgment, occurs at the end of the world. At that point, all humanity will be judged. Everyone will be made aware of each other’s judgments. Moreover, the effects of one’s acts and omissions have consequences beyond the span of the

individual life, usually for many generations. For example, a man who beat his son in the 15th century may have set off a chain of events that persist into current times. For the purposes of this note, nothing more needs be said about this now.

Justification and Self-Justification Justification is to make just. This is more than the mere “imputation” of justification as taught by the Reformation. That false belief gained credence during a period of the loss of spiritual vision, which led to nominalism. So “imputed justification” is justification in name only. What the Christ brings is real justification, that is, a change in consciousness initiating the purgative stage of the spiritual path.

Such as we are, the human condition is committed to self-justification. This leaves one mired in subjectivity, and hence it is ineffective as a means of justification. E.g., a man commits adultery, but tells his wife, “But it didn’t *mean* anything.” Or else, he blames a “moment of weakness”, or ignorance of the facts of the situation. We blame the circumstances of our birth, bad genes, an addictive habit. These and various other excuses for self-justification seem limitless, although we seldom accept them from anyone else. True judgment is to see oneself objectively. Without facing the truth, it is impossible to change and healing can’t occur.

After spiritual rebirth, i.e., the birth of the Logos in the soul, one puts on the “mind of Christ”. This means our identity is recentered on a higher level. Christ will then reveal our true motives and we will view our lives objectively. We will understand how our acts and omissions have affected other people and events. The unrepentant will resist that, but the repentant will welcome it.

A physician will tell you the precise state of your health, not to condemn you, but rather to cure you. He might suggest a change in diet, an exercise regimen, surgery, or a medication. It is obvious that deceiving you about the state of your health will not be of benefit. Nevertheless, it

is up to the patient to follow the doctor's orders.

The situation is similar for sin, which is objectively harmful to the soul. Christ is the physician of the soul. When unaware, or dimly aware, of the true motivations of our actions, these motivations are experienced as compulsions. And "commandments" are experienced as unwelcome external checks on our unfulfilled desires. But the light of the Logos in the soul illuminates one's actions. It is the means to self-observation which turns compulsions into free acts.

The Esoteric Path To understand the esoteric path from Hell to Heaven, we turn to the initiates. Esoteric teachings are usually buried in other structures, both to preserve them as well as to protect them from those who don't understand. Obviously, the great exoteric Traditions contain an esoteric element. The exoteric rites, symbols, etc. conceal — or reveal — a deeper content. They also can provide cover for small groups to peacefully pursue their own yearnings (although there have been many exceptions.)

On a more practical level, other devices have been used. For example, the Tarot cards have a hermetic interpretation. But they would most likely been lost if confined solely to small groups. Hence, their popular use as a means of soothsaying has preserved them over the centuries. Obviously, most people would prefer to be told their future through card layouts than to actually *create* their own future.

Poetry may also be used for the same purpose. Dante belong to the *Fedeli d'Amore*, an esoteric group which required each of its members to write a poem. A great poem, like the *Divine Comedy*, has been preserved and studied over several centuries, although few will use it as a guide on the esoteric path. On this point we differ from the "scholars", who only see an allegory in the poem. This is unjustified, since Dante himself has given himself away. The allegorical is merely the second level of interpretation (above the literal). Ultimately, the fourth level is the anagogical or

spiritual interpretation. The scholars want to understand it as an allegory describing the soul after death. Obviously, Dante could not have truly intended that. What is being described are the states of the soul in this life.

Heaven and Hell The Orthodox have maintained a deep tradition of the experience of Heaven and Hell:

According to the saints, the “fire” that will consume sinners at the coming of the Kingdom of God is the same “fire” that will shine with splendor in the saints. It is the “fire” of God’s love; the “fire” of God Himself who is Love. “For our God is a consuming fire” (Heb 12.29) who “dwells in unapproachable light” (1 Tim 6.16). For those who love God and who love all creation in Him, the “consuming fire” of God will be radiant bliss and unspeakable delight. For those who do not love God, and who do not love at all, this same “consuming fire” will be the cause of their “weeping” and their “gnashing of teeth.”

*Heaven and Hell*¹.

Thus Heaven and Hell are understood as opposed responses to the Divine Light of Christ as Judge. The saved will experience the Light as glory, but it will be painful for the damned. So in a sense Hell is “empty”. God does not “send” people to Hell, rather it is their choice, that is, it corresponds to their particular state of being in a precise way.

The Initiate experiences Christ as the eternal Judge eternally, not as some abstract future event. Dante, in the *Inferno*, describes the experience of Hell in all its various manifestations. The sins that lead to Hell are based on malice, since there is never any intention to reform. Such men

¹<https://oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/spirituality/the-kingdom-of-heaven/heaven-and-hell>

and women would repeat their acts over and over again. Hence, Hell is a repetition, Nietzsche's "Eternal Return", in which the same punishment is repeated ad infinitum. That state is called the eternity of Hell.

Therefore, there is nothing unjust about it. If someone has no interest in God during life, why would that change after death? If the response is that, after death, the soul knows. Unfortunately, that "knowing" — the "seeing the light" — is experienced as painful, not as joy. As described in Nietzsche's Eternal Return, the sinner repeats the sin over and over, with no intention to repent.

Purgatory Why purgatory? Purgatory is not proved by recourse to ancient writings, official documents, or cherry-picked Bible passages. Instead we rely on the testimony of initiates. As per Dante, there is a slow process of revelation up the Mountain of Purgatory. If, in this life, we see through a "glass darkly", the sudden infusion of the Divine Light typically requires a period of discomfort while getting accustomed to the Light. This is the stage of illumination: perhaps there are rare exceptions, but the passage from purgation to union requires this stage. Even the Orthodox have come to the same realization: the doctrine of the tollhouses² serves the same purposes.

The sinner in Hell is devoid of Love, so his primary motive is malice. He is malicious for its own sake, and the concomitant false pleasure then keeps him in bondage. The soul in Purgatory is motivated by Love, although it is deficient, disordered, or excessive. These are sins of weakness, concupiscence and ignorance. The sinner in purgatory has pursued love through an evil means, or his love pursues a disordered end, or else the love for a good when moderate, but bad when excessive.

These sins can be rectified: the deficient can see the unintended harmful effects of their choices, the weak can grow stronger, the ignorant can

²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=6343>

learn from their mistakes. Thus Dante's *Purgatorio* describes how the sins in Purgatory can be overcome.

The pain and suffering of purgatory is not experienced in a negative way. It is more like the way an athlete experiences pain during his training, or an ascetic during his self-discipline. Unlike the pains of Hell, the pain of purgatory serve a purpose. They lead to deliverance, while the pains of Hell lead nowhere.

Consider:

- Accept responsibility for one's actions and their consequences
- Eschew self-justification
- See yourself as others see you. (See, for example, Schumacher's Four Fields of Knowledge³)
- Recognize the consequences of your acts, including those unintended
- Engage in self-observation to develop awareness of all your motivations

Posted on 2017-10-18 by Cologero

* * *

Ann K on 2017-10-21 at 11:17 said:

Thank you! A brilliant overview and very helpful to me, a catechumen in the Orthodox Church.

jonathansolvie on 2017-11-16 at 09:35 said:

Thank you for this excellent article, sir. What could be a more needful matter for reflection? Why are we not taught this in school? People are no longer taking the day of judgement seriously,

³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=507>

believing it to be some fairytale, never having been exposed to anything but the outermost exoteric surface of these teachings.

“The General Judgment, or Last Judgment, occurs at the end of the world. At that point, all humanity will be judged. Everyone will be made aware of each other’s judgments.”

I want to believe this myself, but I lack certainty regarding it. How does it work metaphysically? A mere apprentice of the Mysteries as I am, such a summary of the religious dogma, the what, doesn’t contribute much to a deeper understanding of the why and how – though I do accept Revelation.

I find it straight forward to accept that there is a General Judgment at the end of the present human world (which I, in accord with Guénon, presume is relatively close at hand, considering its rapidly worsening state: it is a matter of centuries rather than of millennia now; but a more specific estimation than that must be withheld). I was going to say: a General Judgment (from now on G.J.) for the majority of those individual souls who have found themselves in the human state after the Fall into time is not hard to accept. What I have some difficulty with is the idea that ALL who have lived would be included in this G.J. at the end of the world. What of those exceptional men—great sages, adepts, yogins—who supposedly, according to their traditions, surpassed human paradise itself and were, so to speak, ‘extinguished’ in God, or in any case, are no longer tied up with the destiny of this particular human world? Can we expect to meet Shakyamuni or Shankara during the G.J.? Church dogma would say yes, but is it not a generalized simplification to say so, according to a deeper esoteric perspective? Can it be unofficially and informally admitted that there are exceptions to the general rule of the G.J.? (I am not asking this because I expect to avoid it for my part.)

In short: to whom does the G.J. apply and to whom may it possibly not apply? Would it be wrong to say that it applies to souls who remain within the gravitational field’ of the human state, in one of its extensions’, without having attained the resurrection-body exceptionally early, as typified in the Biblical tradition by Enoch, Elijah and the like, but no doubt having occurred more times than what is recorded in that tradition, as exemplified by the rare Daoist adept whose body is said to disappear from the tomb, etc. And how does the possibility affirmed in the East of transmigration’ to non-human states, accepted by Guénon and Schuon as possible in spite of their adoption of Sufi Islam, fit into this?

I understand that the General Judgment is a mystery that we must probably await grasping in its fullness until we get to experience it when the Hour strikes, but these questions still interest me.

Max on 2017-11-26 at 17:42 said:

We do not take judgement seriously when we refuse to approach it inwardly as an objective experience at every moment. All the emotional frustrations repeatedly encountered in the world should make us halt and reflect on the situation, but instead we often double down on the same

errors as if sheer velocity could release us from the downward pull of the earth's field of gravity. The sense of dull repetition trapping many is a clue that the state of things is not right. Faced with the spleen of modernity there comes a temptation to pursue ways of numbing and forgetting instead of letting it act as a catalyst for rising to higher being. The same mental energy provoked through frustrations can be turned around for good uses.

4.2 On Job and Suffering

There never was, and never will be a place on earth free from sorrows. The only sorrow-less place possible is in the heart, when the Lord is present there.

ST NIKON OF OPTINA

I. Introduction

Job in the Bible is a powerful text. It can be seen in many lights, and render different interpretation. Most of the medieval commentators of the book have seen Job as the enduring ideal; he lost everything, yet in the end, he still sides with God. Through those readings, we can also understand other insights that lead to different questions about God, sorrow and suffering.



First we must understand that Job challenge God. If we think that Job is passive toward God, then we lose perspective and understanding of his plea. This challenge is formulated toward what happens to him; but also what happens everywhere.

The question of Job is therefore not "Why me?", but rather "Why us God?". He speaks to Him as a fallen Adam, representing the whole

of human race that demands answer on suffering: why is it that God let the world be "imperfect" and why doesn't he act upon it? Is He not all-powerful? The theodicy therefore becomes a question of cosmodicy.

As a side note, the focus should not be put between Satan and God, but rather between human and humans, and in the end, between God and Adam. Satan here is to be taken as an older form of the character, and represent an accusation toward Job (the word Satan can be interpreted as "the accusator"). It is not about a cosmic battle between God and Satan, as this would be futile in the conclusion of God answer to Job (more on it later). The focus is on God himself: it is theocentric. In the same vein, if there is some difference and contradiction with other books of the Bible such as Genesis, we must not see them as being unrelated: the author of Job wrote with Genesis in mind, and he gave us a complementary observation that leads to questions and insights on the world. Also, I will by no means elucidate the book for ever and ever. Hermeneutics and the understanding of God cannot be depleted in formal texts and words like this. Also, Job is a book rich in meanings that demands also subjective understanding.

In Latin, the word for suffering is linked deeply with the action of bearing, or sustaining. That suffering is associated with evil. In French this is even easier to understand "*J'ai mal*", literally translated as "I have evil" (which means "*I have pain*"). In the case of Job, this suffering is "unjustified", and is not a moral suffering, neither a "natural" suffering; nor is it just physical or psychic : he also suffers because God doesn't answer him. He has in himself pure suffering, on every level of his being. The question in Job is not only around suffering, but much more about language, and how we can speak of/about God.

Also we must keep in mind that Job faith is disinterested. He doesn't ask for more riches, for resurrection, for anything but God Himself. It is also stated that he is a stranger, a non-Israelite, yet he still believes. It is a free faith.

II. On Job

The “friends” of Job answer to him using different approach to evil and suffering. Some uses collective retribution, individual retribution, immanent justice, radical indignity of man, divine pedagogy, etc. Most of them sound like purely exoteric, often even liberalist or modern by standard. Job himself doesn’t revolt so much against suffering in the dialogue, but rather against the speech of his friends; they are speaking lies. Job refuses a theology that is not anchored in experience and into which truth is grafted. Truth must be appropriated.

Of course, the character of Job is a rebel, but a “just rebel” in the sense that he doesn’t see fit to negate God, neither diminish Him: he wants to speak to Him, to understand. To Job, there is no “interested faith” in resurrection or supra-terrestrial retribution: he prays to God in gratuity and disinterest; therefore Satan lost his bet.

The answer of God seems to cause problem to most readers; but in truth, this answer is all that was needed. God tell Job that he was right to revolt; because he continued to believe. Job asked for God to see him, and He did. He accuses the “friends” of Job of speaking ill: their “ethics” are a source of immorality because morality cannot think theologically suffering, less so think God. God refuses to let Himself be caged in the logicity of morality and retribution. In doing so, God sets himself free of an anthropocentric soteriology. God recognize existence of “evil suffering” (that is, suffering without logical explanation that derives from chaos and non-being) that can be fought against (see the teachings on Behemoth and Leviathan). God shows Job his temporal finitude, his spatial finitude and his ignorance. God shows that His will and Goodness is not for human only, but for the whole of Creation (Job 38, 26 compare GN 5, 10; there is no necessity in God’s Love). God, by showing His gratuitous creative Will and Love, takes the fight directly beyond anthropocentric views. And that is the whole of God answer to suffering even if he does not answer it “directly”: suffering and evil will always be difficult to “bear”,

to “support” (latin “*suffere*”) if one center his view on Man as man. But if he does it as Creation (Adam) on God, everything changes. Humanity is not the center of God, He is the center of All; therefore, Job, as man, is not the measure of things. Man is a stranger in a strange land, God rejoice of Himself and Creation without him: Job cannot judge creation from an anthropocentric perspective (that is, a finite and non-static point of view). Only God can be the Final Judge. He asks Job to go beyond anthropocentric existentialism. Job finally understand his finite nature on earth, and by this dialogue with God, retake his dignity of Adam the Fallen that wants to be reunited with Him.

Man is not the centre. God does not exist for the sake of man.
Man does not exist for his own sake.

C.S. LEWIS

On Behemoth and Leviathan: God makes us remember that where it is chaotic, it needs not be Chaos. In other words, nature and animals as they are represent a form of chaos (see ancient kings hunting animals through their kingdom to make it safer, more “orderly”). Yet this chaos is not to man’s command, it is only to God. Evil is fought upon, but never totally destroyed; if chaos was to be destroyed, evil with it, there would be no more liberty, no more free will. The very existence of evil and chaos gives man the choice between them both, and ultimately to transcend them both to regain access to God directly. Liberty exists in the cosmos so that we can use free-will to (Love) rejoice in God. On the other hand, if there would be only Chaos, then nothing could be. Everything would be pure materiality without form. In other words, God do fight evil: he constrains it and rule over it so that there is a balance that permits us to love and serve Him. He is therefore the first of those who fight Evil and Chaos. And we, as Adam, must share this fight in the ordering of the cosmos, the society, the family, the body and most importantly, our

mind and being. We participate in the order of God by being orderly and constraining chaos within ourselves.

In the same line of thought, we will say thus : it is absurd to condemn the world of its imperfections while admitting the existence of the same world, and ask ourselves why injustice and suffering exist, because if one says “exist”, one says “to be separated from God”, therefore, from Perfection; who says “effect”, says “distance from the Cause”, in such that Existence implies inherently imperfection. A sorrowful separation, for exemple, already exist in the distinction of the pure spatiality of the body; then it is illogical to admit the spatial distinction while being astonished by a moral separation. The roots of all evil, we repeat, is the ontological distance between the world and God, that which cannot not exist, God being infinite; this distance echoes throughout all of Existence.

SCHUON, *Les stations de la sagesse*

III. Conclusion

As such, Job represents the perfect believer: he serves without having seen or received, and serves with a disinterested will. Even after speaking with God, there is no mention of seeing directly God or his energies; rather he saw Creation under a new eye. The truth of Creation is the truth of foundation (Temple of Jerusalem) and the truth of Christ. God is present through his creation like he is through His Temple or His Son. God is the angular stone of the Cosmos. God gives Himself to see everywhere: it is up to us to see it. Therefore the world is not a dark illusion, but a grand theophony in which God reveal Himself in Himself by Himself. In being totally transcendent, yet present in the immanence, there is a rejection of dualism and pantheism (non-dualism). God reveal Himself in a sacramental character (as Christ reveal Himself in the Eucharist)

through creation; there is an earthly symbolism in the cosmos that allude to supra-terrestrial symbols. What are symbols therefore? Unification of the Divine and the Human. God and Adam. Therefore Creation is, as Philo, Eckhart, St Bernard and St Thomas Aquinas said, an open book for us to understand and behold the Creator.

There is some arguments against God, for God, through God: but never without God. Job is there to remember us that we can live and think everything through God; in other words, we need not to stop believing or desire knowing God because of contingent acts (like suffering). There is no possible atheism; the problem is not with God, but with Man. There is no need to condemn man for suffering, nor is there reason to stop believing in God. In light of this, we could give back the title of All-Powerful to God, only we have to see this in another way: God is Powerful in the Aristotelian sense of power, that is, He is not in act while in power. Why? Because he does indeed act upon evil, but not in an "all" way, or He would destroy free-will with evil (Genesis 18:23-33).

World is therefore the Grail of God. He pours Himself into it. We can try to represent this constant revelation and order (see above) through art: art as the formal revelation of this truth. Therefore Man is to be understood as a divine animal who reintroduce the Absolute in the Relative, that participate in Him.

Knowing all this, we can understand better sin. Sin is not an objective concept, or it would relate to the Absolute. It is purely subjective, because it doesn't exist in God. When we sin, we fail to reach God. When we are washed of sin in Christ, we are washed of subjectivity and participate in the absolute Godhead. Sin is the separation from the unity of God as death is the separation from the body.

We thank Jean-Jacques Lavoie for insights on this powerful text.

Posted on 2013-10-06 by David

4.3 Benedictines and Lectio Divina

I. Introduction : the Voice of God

When we speak of the Bible, we speak of the Christ-Logos as the recapitulation of the Word of God as it fills the universe as a sign of God's will, inscribed in the order of all things. It is therefore necessary to meditate on what was passed on to us by the Scriptures and the Tradition, both in the Guenonian sense of the word, but also as the Christian Tradition who wrote the Second Testament of God. In prayer and meditation we speak to God; in the Scriptures it is He who speaks to us. It is in this dialogue that we can understand the perfect Silence of His presence. We have to liberate the senses, to look out for Unity, the source of the Being in a relation of the Other; we have to get to the Self by fixing ourselves on God. The Word of God is a Word of Life and Truth (Mt 13, 19). In Hebrew the word speaking is "dabar" which also signify "revealing things", to "shed light" on them, to "act in a profound manner upon them"; to speak is to act. Just as in Genesis, God speak, and things are. In the truest sense of language, the speech does what it says, and says what it does. The Ancients, like Philo, believed that Scripture and Nature were interconnected: to understand one is to understand the other, and to understand one you have to look at the other. In reading the Bible, we open ourselves to that understanding of the universal. The universal gives way to the particular, just as the Celestial Jerusalem can be traced (and will descend from the sky) on Earth. Of course, the existence of the earthly Jerusalem is to attain the Celestial One, to come out of the secret of things.

In this brief text, I will look specifically at one way of understanding the text, Lectio Divina, and how (and why) it is applied by a specific order of Christian monks, the Benedictine.

2. Main: Learning the Scriptures. Rule of St Benedict

Silence The first rule of the monk is Silence. This silence is well defined as their motto is *Silence yourself and listen*, as can be seen around their monasteries. Outward silence may come to mind first, but as you go through their monastery, you will see that it is not so. They use Gregorian chant and other ancient music for their offices; they work and need to speak to properly do it. They even take some times to chat between themselves. But the silence that is true to them is the inner silence. In prayer, in walking, in Oratio (i.e. mental prayer, see below), etc. they all fix themselves on God and respect the Silence. The first word of the rules of St Benedict is “Listen...”. The lower silence (exterior) is always linked with the higher silence (inner one).

Obedience, stability and conversion Their three vows are the three vows of monasticism in general. Obedience to the superior as obedience to God. They respect authority as it is a direct hierarchical representation of the divine hierarchy (see St Denys) in the heavens. For them, the Abbot acts as Christ within the community. There is a strong sense of self-disinterest in this form of obedience, as they try to get rid of their self-will to attain the Will of God. The other vow is stability, linked with the practical establishment of a sense of enduring fidelity to one own monastery; but also it is a stability that is within God, an inner stability (linked with silence). Lastly conversion for them is the path of converting part of themselves through purification to a higher spiritual connection with God through Christ; through Him in imitation and in consciousness.

Inner life Their inner life is developed through the shedding of the false self, the human will and the vice within themselves. They work through prayer, offices, chants, rosary, labor and Lectio Divina. I will expend on those last two later on. As Cassien puts it, the asceticism is the

center of the monk's life to purify his heart. It is done through humility and prayer. There must be a desire for what he calls the "Real Science". The goal is to be in complete control and concentration at each moment and purify the thoughts at each moment. And that is done through the Scriptures, or through the praying of the Scriptures (for the Fathers, it was necessary to know the Bible in one's own memory, so that with time we speak through it, with it; so that with time, our interior teachers would be Moses, Abraham, St Peter, etc. in everyday life).

Ora Est Labora (Work is Prayer)

Ora Prayer is the center of the monk's life. They gather to pray, and they return in their individual cell to pray. They pray when they work, and they work as they pray. Praying is working, and working is praying. They develop humility and virtues through incessant praying, and they sanctify their lives through this purification. Their whole life – their whole Being – becomes a prayer offered to God. They participate in the Cosmic law by imitating Christ (good works, faith and spiritual development – "Luke 5:16 But Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed", the lonely place of the Being, the Soul) and try to sanctify Creation. They participate in the Absolute within the Relative so that the Relative may become again Absolute; they pursue the way of Christ.

Labora They work because they want to be part of the World as they sanctify it, not so much as to enter the world. Of course, as they want to be stable and self-sufficient, there is a macro-micro relation present in their work: on a smaller scale they have to work to satisfy the necessity of living; yet in the upper levels of understanding, they also do it to sanctify their work that others de-sanctify in the modern world.

Ora Et Labora (Prayer and Work) Therefore, work and prayer are linked and interconnected. They represent the goal of the monk to go beyond dualism. By praying (contemplation) and working (action), they combine them both and make them look lower than the actual goal of both of them: attaining God. It is their way of explaining the non-dualistic perspective of the contemplative.

We could also point out to an old Christian text:

A wandering mind is made stable by reading, vigil and prayer.

Flaming lust is extinguished by hunger, labor and solitude.

Stirrings of anger are calmed by psalmody, magnanimity and mercifulness.

Mary And that contemplation is expounded also in their devotion to Mary (as is within the Church in general). Mary is the perfect contemplative. When the Angel came to see her, she listened. Having listened to the Word of God, she shed out her own self (her will) and said “yes” to the Life that is God; so that His work may be done through her (Luke 1:38 “I am the Lord’s servant,” Mary answered. “May your word to me be fulfilled”). There is also the symbolism of the chivalric love with Mary as the Divine Sophia: Love (Divine Love – also note that to really Love, one as to abandon himself in the Other that is loved; that is, we have to abandon ourselves in God) as a way of knowledge. St Bernard wrote on this extensively for those who want to learn about it.

Lectio Divina

Introduction When reading and praying, the only goal is God and His Unity. Every other consequences (happiness, peace, etc.) are just good consequences. Before starting the whole process, it is important to conquer noise and activity in the mind. The reader must regain his

Silence. There must be emptiness through disinterest, stopping the flow of thoughts in the mind. What we mean here is that one must control his mind through incessant prayer or meditation before starting. If one is can't aim at this for exterior or interior reasons, he must try to cleanse his mind by reading without stop the Scriptures; *Lectio* demands a total concentration on the object at hand, that is, the Word of God.

Through grace, we are to let the Spirit (source of the Scriptures) guide us through the process to give life to the Word of God by the Logos. It doesn't depend on us as much as on Divine Will and our reception to it. Those of you who find it difficult to think about reading the Scriptures without being self-willed should think ahead and ask themselves if they are not too proud to ask for help and guidance in reading the Scriptures; therefore the problem lies with lack of silence and disinterest. More so, as the Fathers said, if you only read to find what you want, or if you think you can interpret everything in the Scriptures (as Nature), it is not God or the Self that you love or seek, but yourself.

In all the process, there is to be a bareness and dispossession of the ego, of the self (through humility) against any romantic view of the Self and the Cosmos; the Being must align itself with The One Up High; this elevation of the heart (intellect) toward the divine knowledge must not be done through a subjective and sentimental reading of the text (even if those can happen as consequences of our human nature, and at least influence us in a positive desire for more of the Scriptures, it's act, or God).

The four part (*Lectio*, *Meditatio*, *Oratio* and *Contemplatio*) are gradual process. At first, one will probably only tackle with the inner silence and *Lectio*. After some time, he will be able to integrate *Meditatio*; that being mastered, *Oratio*; that being mastered, *Contemplatio*. It is progressive in the act of the *Lectio Divina* (*Lectio* to *Contemplatio*) and through time in terms of practice and devotion. What we don't know, we learn in the Scriptures; what we have learn we meditate, what we have meditated

transpire in our acts and Being.

Lectio Divina, contrary to the spiritual reading of the XVIIe century, transcends the dualism between affect and intellect: it is reconciled in the Meditatio/Oratio part, and breached through in the Contemplatio.

Note that in some of the oldest books of monastery, Lectio Divina is strongly attached with a master-disciple scheme. Therefore, this introduction to Lectio Divina can be but incomplete: but at least one will not fall in the hell where the neutral ones are.

In the following description, there will be less and less information, as more one progress, more one progress in his own way. Furthermore, some parts cannot be described in words (contemplation of God (Contemplatio); personal prayer (Oratio))

Lectio Lectio is the basis of the process, and it must be taken with utmost respect and reverence for the Word of God. The Lectio should be done at a determined moment (and not at “lost time” or “when one has time”). One should have Mt 6:6 in mind when starting the process of Lectio. It is through discipline and effort that the rejection of the modern rhythm can be done to acknowledge one with the Divine Rhythm. Lectio should be done therefore in isolation and silence.

Cassien speaks highly of self-purification before lectio. We should control and purge the basic vices of the Thumos/Eros before using the Nous to read; or nothing will be revealed. Unique prayer of uninterrupted words spoken with the heart is for him the best way to purify oneself. The goal is to become harmonious with the teachings of the Word (that is, the Cosmos).

One should read without discrimination (i.e. choosing what to read): some texts will “tell nothing” but it is at that moment that God will take on that silence. That being said, some text should be read, but maybe not re-read without end, unless they do speak to one. The goal is that one should not read John 1 at each Lectio, but one should not also read The

Book of Numbers through all the year in hope of God speaking to him.

One should accept that some truths are higher than him, and therefore develop humility through that lack of understanding. It is through assiduity, fidelity and grace that one will unlock the secrets; God will speak through his Word, and when the whole of the Scriptures is in one, the whole Cosmos will become the Scriptures and God will speak freely to the one. We have to learn the Scriptures to perfect memorization, to transform us into the Word. Also, one should not forget that some signification can come from reading the Scriptures without being ascribed to them per se. In other words, you should not expect everyone to understand everything the same while reading; neither should you ascribe to every view out there.

One should try to read with a loud voice the text, as to integrate it in his mind. One would be wise to read the text without immediately thinking about it, that way he will not suffer the subjectivity or the ideas that comes with it. There is no thinking about efficacy, technical results or psychological results. This is not a New Age meditation technique to feel good; there should be no attention on the ego-self, we should look at the text as if it was told for the first time to the Cosmos, with the Eyes of God. We have to be part of the text: when we read Genesis 1, we have to be there. We have, through our own speech, to create the world with God. In reading the Scriptures, we actualize its Potentia. One is able to put the Eternal Word in the Eternal Present as if to stay in the Word.

The goal being understood, one should not shun the external help to better understand the text (especially if one does not read Hebrew and/or Koine Greek): hermeneutics, biblical research, cultural/historical analysis, etc. Those methods can help one not to fall to preconceived ideas and therefore to subjectivism. It should not shape the reading, but rather help at non-reading. The objective is still the *Lectio*, not the method. One reads the Word of God for spiritual unction and *Charitas* rather than culture and erudition. Yet, to help us understand what the text meant

to those who, by Divine Grace, wrote it, we have to be able to immerse ourselves in them, and therefore reach God.

To choose what to read, one could make himself a plan on one or two years spanning the full Scriptural text interconnected with Patristic texts; or one could follow the liturgical year of the Church.

Meditatio Meditatio is also called “Mastico” as to masticate the Word that we received. It should engage the whole of the Being through memorization, actualization, attention and whispering of the passage that was read or retained (if one reads three chapters, it would not be wise to meditate on the three of them at the same time; one should aim for particular to universal: start with the verse that was the most spiritually descriptive, then moves on to meditate on the whole passage, then the whole Bible, then the whole Cosmos). As St-Basil said: God becomes fixed in us through memorization.

Meditatio should be taken as deep reflection and intensive internalization of the Word. It can use different schemes to attain that goal, like particular to universal; analysis of words and sentences; “mantra”-like reflection on the words; etc. Some teachers also suggest writing down reflection made, to read them afterward and keep them as a teaching that God made through Oneself to oneself.

Oratio The Oratio is the mental prayer. As St Augustin said : “If the text is prayer, pray; if he is mourning, mourn; if he is joy, let yourself be filled with happiness”.

The Word came to us through Scriptures and comes back to God through prayer; just as the Word became Incarnate so that we too could rejoice in God. One should open this part by psalms, chanting, verbal prayer, internal prayer, etc. Fathers speak of ecstatic divine love that should not become the goal in itself. Then it becomes a “tranquil meeting with God” where the Word goes up like the Spirit toward the sky so that we

can see the divine light in the most profound part of the Self. It is to open the door on which the Word-Logos is knocking; to contemplate the Word became Flesh in ourselves.

Contemplatio See Jn 11, 20: like Mary, we have to be still and listen. No vision, no ecstasis, no apparitions (II Cor 5:7 *For we live by faith, not by sight*). The veil between the Verb and the Self vanish; duality fall within Christ. There contemplative knowledge can be learned. There is no sensuality, no sentimental approach. Here the Divine Love (*charitas*) is united to Faith. The way to enter hear is to come back to the Silence of the beginning through the whole process so that every possible thought is rejected in a Divine Silence that God will fill. It is useless to think of God, because one would only think of god (see Eckhart); it is useless to think of God when one is in His presence. The Word is condemnation or salvation: we need to put it in practice, just as Jesus Christ, being incarnated, was the new Adamic Archetype and acted upon the Good and the good. The second one to reach and teach the first.

3. Conclusion

This outline of the *Lectio Divina* is to show that some method for contemplation exists and are strong within Christianity, both in the East (*Hesychasm* was spoken of here at Gornahoor) and in the West. Be it *Lectio Divina*, *Hesychasm*, Eastern meditation, *Dikhr*, etc. the important part to remember is that *praxis* is necessary. Without some form of inner purification, inner contemplation and inner meditation, what we read and think stays on the speculative level, on a level of minds and thoughts that serves no purpose. We have to reach our Being through Traditional teachings. Furthermore, it is not through vice and sensuality that we reach that sort of enlightenment (I exclude myself from any sort of debate about a Right Hand Path), and therefore the exoteric and

esoteric goes hand in hand, and both prayer and asceticism are needed to reach deeper techniques of perfection. The Benedictines may not be a Traditional order per say, but they do represent a Traditional forces in the sense that they possess knowledge and ideals of reaching God. In the very least, they are a depository of saintliness, of Good and Beautiful and True.

As a conclusion I would like to offer a small thought. Huichols shamans in Mexico think that if they stop doing their purification rituals and offering, the whole of the Cosmos will crumble upon itself. In a sense, this is true for every Priest in the world: in an age as dark as ours, every bit of purification and sanctification of the world is important. If the world would become totally closed to God, totally profane, it would indeed crumble upon itself and come back to a stage of total Chaos. Those monks at least sustain the world as they try to unite it with God through themselves.

Posted on 2013-09-29 by David

* * *

jc00001 on 2013-09-30 at 13:33 said:

Excellent article about the practical application of exegesis. I haven't found anything like this before. A true treasure.

Matthew on 2013-10-18 at 14:54 said:

Great article, thanks. If only more in the modern world took this approach to the reading of scripture.

4.4 Absence as presence: the resurrection and exaltation of Christ

When the Divine Light penetrates the soul, it is united with God as light with light. This is the light of faith. Faith bears the soul to heights unreachable by her natural senses and faculties.

MEISTER ECKHART

Resurrection and faith are a critical matter for Christians; especially in this time of Easter. More so, for traditionalists, it leads to a more profound understanding of the resurrection of the spirit through initiatic death and rebirth (i.e. the cross bearing, death and rebirth of Christ). In the Gospel of Luke, there are plenty of important facts that points out to something more than just merely a biography of an event, marked in time and space: it is a timeless and profound meaning of rebirth; as it is said in the liturgy of the Easter Vigil : it is the rebirth of the whole of creation.

In the New Testament, the writers have used words like «eigeirô» (to wake up) in response to the term «koïmao» (to sleep); «anistème» (to get up) and «anastasis» (to get up from a fall); and saying that he now lives («zaô»). Of course, those terms can be interpreted in a Gnostic mindset and deliver interesting information (getting up from a fall, waking up, etc.), but what is most important is the fact that they are not alone. If the author would only have used words like «living», it would have been only a matter of the resurrection of the flesh, a mere reanimation of a corpse. But that is not the case.

For Luke and the evangelists, we cannot reduce the resurrection to a matter of «living man». It is about a living God. That is why it was added that He is glorified and exalted, that He has ascended. The vocabulary chosen is always that of glorification (as with God) and verticality (getting up literally meaning to put oneself in a straight position). It is to enter the glory of God.

Now as for the story of Luke, there is hidden beauty in it, waiting to be unveiled both by examination and meditation; especially as this is the text used in Catholic Easter liturgy on Sunday. Let us remind us of the Douay-Rheims Bible⁴:

⁴<https://www.drbo.org/chapter/49024.htm>

And behold, two of them went, the same day, to a town which was sixty furlongs from Jerusalem, named Emmaus. And they talked together of all these things which had happened. And it came to pass, that while they talked and reasoned with themselves, Jesus himself also drawing near, went with them.

But their eyes were held, that they should not know him. And he said to them: What are these discourses that you hold one with another as you walk, and are sad? And the one of them, whose name was Cleophas, answering, said to him: Art thou only a stranger to Jerusalem, and hast not known the things that have been done there in these days? To whom he said: What things? And they said: Concerning Jesus of Nazareth, who was a prophet, mighty in work and word before God and all the people; And how our chief priests and princes delivered him to be condemned to death, and crucified him.

But we hoped, that it was he that should have redeemed Israel: and now besides all this, today is the third day since these things were done. Yea and certain women also of our company affrighted us, who before it was light, were at the sepulchre, And not finding his body, came, saying, that they had also seen a vision of angels, who say that he is alive. And some of our people went to the sepulchre, and found it so as the women had said, but him they found not. Then he said to them: O foolish, and slow of heart to believe in all things which the prophets have spoken.

Ought not Christ to have suffered these things, and so to enter into his glory? And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded to them in all the scriptures, the things that were concerning him. And they drew nigh to the town, whither they were going: and he made as though he would go farther. But they constrained him; saying: Stay with us, because it is towards evening, and the day is now far spent. And he went in with them. And it came to pass, whilst he was at table with them, he took bread, and blessed, and brake, and gave to them.

And their eyes were opened, and they knew him: and he vanished out of their sight. And they said one to the other: Was not our heart burning within us, whilst he spoke in this way, and opened to us the scriptures?

It is interesting to note that Luke 24, 13-32 is voluntarily doing a parallel with Genesis 18, 1-33. The structure is the same⁵. Also, there is a lot of words which are used that parallel the one in both texts («ôphthè», «ophthalmoi», «kai idou», «euriskein», «enantion», «lambanein arton», «kataklainein», etc.). The reason is to emphasis both tradition and the fact that the death and resurrection of Christ is a good news («evangelion»), just as with Sarah and Abraham, and a primordial return to creation.

The first thing that sets the mood is the double irony presented to the reader (or hearer): the two men don't recognize the truth from both the women and Jesus, just in front of them. The women, even if they represent in front of the law less than man (you need two women for one man in justice), believed the angels (Luke 24, 5-12) even if they didn't saw Jesus. They went beyond reason. Those man cannot open their eyes, open their heart (seat of the intellect even here, see Luke 24, 25; 32) to higher truths, with their «faces downcast». Their earthly feelings cloud them from seeing the truth.

The second thing that is important with the teaching of Luke is the

⁵Nota Bene: Thanks are given to the research of Jean-Jacques Lavoie, who formulated the basis of the meditation on the subject.

1. Arrival of the characters
2. Hospitality towards them
3. Exchange of thoughts
4. Context of feast
5. Superior knowledge given by host
6. Sudden disappearance of characters

kerygmatic doctrine hidden in the story. It is twofold. First of all, the meaning is that of the traditional liturgy of the Christian Church: it is Sunday, it uses mediation of the community, the Exalted One has the initiative and culminates in the initiatic ritual of the Eucharist; it also uses the same structure: teachings from the Scriptures (old and new), then an interpretation and actualization and finally the Eucharist. Second, it is a summary of the teachings of Jesus Christ in the Gospel of Luke, even paralleling the structure of Luke 10 (the Samaritan). The Eucharist uses words from the separation of bread for the Multiplicity earlier in Luke: it marks the Christ as the sustained both of the flesh (Luke 9, 10-17) and the spirit (Luke 24, as the «opener of the scriptures»).

But thirdly and most importantly, this story asks the question: how can we move from non-faith to faith? What is union with Christ? Both disciples gave up, closed their eyes to the truth, spoke only of what they knew on the rational level. They knew a lot of facts; they had proofs (Scriptures, women, etc.); yet they were still closed to truth and faith. Their hearts (because of burning passions), seat of the intellect, was kept hidden from them. But the Logos, both as a scriptural body (teachings, liturgy) and Eucharistic body (rites, initiation) opened their hearts: it was an obligated passage. They thought Jesus as a prophet at first, powerful in deeds and speech; then he was a Messiah coming to save the Kingdom of God on earth; then he was revealed as what He is. The only way they could see him is to go through the process, to walk the Way⁶ with Him. They had to be initiated. Then, and only then, their eyes were opened to His glory, through the sacramental rite, which would now have to be repeated each Sunday; but also at each meal, at each moment of their lives to live in Him, to be dead to the world and alive in Him, just as He did (see Saint Paul letter to the Romans 6, 3-11). Why is it that at that precise

⁶There is a lot of vocabulary in Luke which alludes to the road, the way, or walking: «eisodo», «odos» and «exodos» mainly. The beginning is marked by the «eisodo», and his death by «exodos». Even the following of Christ is described as a way, a path.

moment he disappeared? Because His mode of presence is absence. God reveals Himself in absence, for all times and ages; it is still his mode in our time⁷. Because He is beyond-being, beyond-existence. He is, yet he is not, because as the fathers have once said: « If God exist, we do not exist. If we exist, God do not exist. » His presence is absence; His absence is Presence.

Posted on 2013-03-30 by David

4.5 The Devils Conspire

All great events have been distorted, most of the important causes concealed, some of the principal characters never appear, and all who figure are so misunderstood and misrepresented that the result is a complex mystification.

BENJAMIN DISRAELI, *Coningsby*

He said to them, 'An enemy has done this.'

MATTHEW 13:28

Separation from the Light Demons made their choice and were banished into the darkness. From there, they can have no vision of heaven as Jacob Boehme explains:

Heaven is in hell, and hell is in heaven, and nevertheless there is neither of them revealed to the other. Even if the devil were

⁷For those who wait for a physical sign from God, a presence in the historical dimension, etc. Luke made himself quite clear: God hasn't changed his mode of presence; we are not less or more suited to Union with Him than the first christians were. The rite of the Eucharist is the mode of presence of God in the world.

travelling for many hundred thousands of miles, for the purpose of going to heaven, he would nevertheless always remain in hell. Thus the angels do not see the darkness; they see only the light of divine power; but the devils see only the darkness of the wrath of God.

JACOB BOEHME, *Mysterium Magnum*

Satan rules hell and can never rule heaven. Hence, the only battleground is the world in the middle: **Earth**.

Lucifer's Goal Boehme reveals Lucifer's motivation.

Lucifer saw creation and knew its foundation. Thereupon he also wanted to be a god, and to rule in all things by the power of fire. He wanted to bring his own thoughts into form and not what the Creator desired. Thus he became an enemy of God, an enemy desired to destroy what was formed by the action of God for the purpose of putting in its place his own effects and figurations.

JACOB BOEHME, *Theosophical Questions*

The Battle for Earth Adam and his descendants have been granted dominion over the earth. Since Satan cannot directly and physically have dominion, he relies on human agents whom he leads astray by whispering in their hearts. In this way, demonic intelligences plan to displace God in His creation. Human beings refuse to, or are unable to, comprehend the magnitude of that conspiracy; therefore, they are unable to implement it on their own. **Solange Hertz**, in her book *Utopia*, explains why:

Sinful men's lives are too short, their wills too weak, their thinking too limited. Bound to bodies shackled by recurring hunger and fatigue, they are incapable of an effort which must be sustained at white heat literally through centuries.

Disinformation When Adam was created to live in the Garden of Eden, Satan saw his opportunity. If he could persuade Adam to disobey God, he could then be the ruler of creation. He invented disinformation, the big lie, to accomplish his goal:

Now the serpent was more subtle than any other wild creature that the Lord God had made. He said to the woman, "Did God say, 'You shall not eat of any tree of the garden?'" And the woman said to the serpent, "We may eat of the fruit of the trees of the garden; but God said, 'You shall not eat of the fruit of the tree which is in the midst of the garden, neither shall you touch it, lest you die.'" But the serpent said to the woman, "You will not die. For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil."

GENESIS 3:1-5

Here we learn a few things. First, the devil is more intelligent and more knowledgeable than human beings. Second, he understands human psychology. Third, he works through disinformation. He will distort a truth just enough to sound plausible. The subsequent fall of Adam made Satan prince of the world.

Conspiracy Theories

Whoever thinks history "just happens" needs to read the *Mystical City of God*, by **Maria Agreda**, for proper perspective. Called on for their opinions after the Crucifixion, the higher ranking demons agreed that it would be impossible to reverse the Redemption now accomplished by Christ, but they could labor to prevent the application of its fruits. They advised that, "in accordance with the new order of assistance and favor established by God for the salvation of men, they should seek new ways of hindering and

preventing the work of God by deceits and temptations so much the greater."

SOLANGE HERTZ, *Utopia*

The Redemption After the Redemption, Satan was no longer ruler of the world. Hence, he needed a long term plan to reassert his dominion. Here is a more text from the City of God, describing a meeting of the demons;

They resolved that, in accordance with the new order of assistance and favor established by God for the salvation of men, they should now seek new ways of hindering and preventing the work of God by so much the greater deceits and temptations.

Human nature was still weak:

The natural inclinations and passions of the flesh remain just the same, and the sensible and delectable creatures have not changed their nature. Let us then, making use of this situation with increased astuteness, foil as far as in us lies the effects of what this Godman has wrought for men. Let us begin strenuous warfare against mankind by suggesting new attractions, exciting them to follow their passions in forgetfulness of all else. Thus men, being taken up with these dangerous things, cannot attend to the contrary.

Now then, ye demons who follow me, now is the time to give way to our wrath against God. Come all of ye to take counsel what we are to do; for I desire to hear your opinions. Acting upon this counsel they redistributed the spheres of work among themselves, in order that each squadron of demons might, with a specialized astuteness, tempt men to different vices. They resolved to continue to propagate idolatry in the world, so that men might not come to the knowledge of the true God.

All agreed to sow among men the seeds of discord, hatred and vengeance, proud and sensual thoughts, desire of riches or honors, and by suggesting sophistical reasons against all the virtues Christ has taught. . . . Some of the devils charged themselves with perverting the inclinations of children at their conception and birth; others to induce parents to be negligent in the education and instruction of their children, either through an inordinate love or aversion, and to cause a hatred of parents among the children. Some offered to create hatred between husbands and wives, to place them in the way of adultery. . . .

Key to Understanding There are three worlds, corresponding to the Body, Soul, and Spirit. Satan did not create the physical world so he has no power over it. He has no consciousness of the spiritual or celestial world. He can only work through the world of the Soul, the is through emotions, images, and thoughts.



Figure 4.1: Satan's Infernal Council

So unlike Hollywood depictions, Satan does not do physical harm, certainly not directly. That is not what must be feared. Also, Hollywood assumes evil is difficult to find; there is a portal that must be opened, or a haunted house, some unusual event that frees up a demonic spirit, etc. On the contrary, evil is commonplace and will find you. That spiritual battle takes place in the soul.

If you are “visualizing” some meeting, etc., you won’t understand. Rather you need to monitor your emotions, imagination, and thoughts. That is where you will encounter evil.

Posted on 2021-10-31 by Cologero

4.6 Meditations on the Good Life

Death, when understood by men, is immortality; but not being understood by the ignorant it is death. This death should not be feared; what should be feared is the perdition of the soul, which is ignorance of God; for this is terrible for the soul.

ST ANTHONY THE GREAT, *Counsels on the Character of Men
and on the Virtuous Life*

In tantum Deus cognoscitur, in quantum amatur.

ST BERNARD

(God is known to the extent He is loved.)

In recent days we have been advised on how to be good:

- By the president: Support the right to traffic in human body parts
- By a candidate: Make America great again
- By the pope: Turn off the air conditioner

In *The Sparkling Stone*, **Blessed John of Ruysbroeck** provides a more traditional perspective, as summarized in the following outline:

1. **How a man becomes good**

- (a) Clean conscience
- (b) Obedience to God
- (c) The glory of God

2. **How a man becomes inward**

- (a) A heart unencumbered with images
- (b) Spiritual freedom in his desires
- (c) The feeling of inward union with God

3. **How a man can see God**

- (a) The foundation of his being is abysmal
- (b) His inward exercise is wayless
- (c) His indwelling is a divine fruition

Becoming Good First a man must have a clean conscience that is free of sin. There are three elements of sin.

1. It must be a serious matter
2. Knowledge that it is a serious matter
3. Performed willfully

The pagan view found, for example, both among the ancient Greeks and Hindus, stops at the second element. For them, ignorance, or *avidya*, alone would lead to the clean conscience. Then the practice of the virtues would follow from that knowledge. However, this didn't take into account that, besides the ignorance of the mind, there is also a weakness of the will.

Hence, knowledge alone is insufficient, one must consciously follow God. John also adds that a man must be "obedient to his own proper convictions." Of course, the most proper convictions must be based on true knowledge. At a higher stage, John claims that even knowledge must be left behind in a state of learned ignorance, in which a man becomes free of such sin.

Finally, a good man should act for the glory of God. John explains:

If it happens that by reason of his business or the multiplicity of his works, he has not always God before his eyes, at least there should be established in him the intention and desire to live according to the dearest will of God.

This three qualities make a man good, so he is prepared for the next stages.

Becoming Inward John advises that anyone who considers himself spiritual needs to observe himself. Images in the imagination come from the flesh, not from God who is Spirit so no images are possible of Him. According to an old Norse adage,

The divine sleeps in the rock, breathes in the plant, dreams in the animal, and wakes in man.

This is related to Plotinus' path from the psyche, through nous, to God. The material world is both physical (the "rock") and psychical (the "animal"). The animal soul is material and is full of images. Thus it lives in a dream-like state, not yet self-conscious. To the extent that a man, who does indeed possess an animal soul, lives the same way, he is not yet awake and not living a fully human life. So for the heart to become unencumbered with images, it must rise to the level of the nous by consciously observing himself.

As a man becomes free of worldly images, he becomes inwardly free. He becomes oriented toward God rather than toward the world. As imageless and free, he begins to feel a true union with God within; this perfects his inward and spiritual life. This acts like a feedback loop. The feeling of union, the desiring power of the soul (*epithetikos* or *eros*) becomes enticed to seek deeper union. God's knowledge of you is your knowledge of God; your willing of your own being is also God's willing.

Seeing God This union is experienced as "abysmal", i.e., arising from the measureless depths, unbounded heights and an endless horizon. He

plunges into the depths of the soul and ascends to the heights. The horizon of Being always recedes. Our knowledge of God is never complete so we dwell in a “knowledge that is ignorance”. By dying to things, the soul feels itself to be one life with God.

The next point is above reason and without condition. The inward drawing of the Divine Unity is experienced according to the measure of his love and the manner of his spiritual, interior exercises. Spiritually naked and unencumbered by images, he finds an Eternal Light in the inmost part of his spirit. This Light reveals the “eternal demand of the Divine Unity”. The more he feels it, the more he craves it.

The fruition is the loving adherence to God. There is an inner silence, so that thoughts and images begin to lose their impact and compulsion. The spirit then beholds a Darkness, where discursive thought cannot penetrate. Hence, the spiritual exercise is “wayless”, that is, there is no straight path to that Darkness, no mechanical process, no repetition of mantras. Rather one must be drawn into it, first through interior silence and the will to transcend discursive thought to a direct intuition.

Posted on 2015-08-03 by Cologero

* * *

Mark Citadel on 2015-08-06 at 12:48 said:

The contrast between John's view of the good could not stand in more stark contrast to the pabulum we hear from the Modernist wardens could it?

“He becomes oriented toward God rather than toward the world.”

Society follows the same metric. Oriented towards telluric interests it will be evil, but oriented up towards the divine, it will find its existence blessed, if only by natural forces and factors that govern success and decline.

Cologero on 2015-08-07 at 08:39 said:

Mark, another way to put it is that what the world finds lovable and what God considers lovable are quite different.

Aleksandar Gueric on 2015-10-02 at 08:34 said:

About becoming inward, Novalis wrote that "mysterious path leads within" and that "In us, or nowhere, is eternity with its worlds – the past and the future." This quote, for me, contains an explanation of a peculiar feeling, or sensation, I have had in me since very young age.

Past, for me, was never something gone but a living experience reachable through the mere power of concentration while objects around us – trees and rocks, when absorbed with intuitive knowing become living parts of the self. So, tree didn't decided to speak to me, for example, when I walked by it on one autumn day when I suddenly felt it's perspective – it's experience of time and change of seasons quite different from every day human one. It was only an intuition or deep knowledge and understanding of things behind their material forms and naturalistic mechanics.. I think that simultaneous experience of human consciousness and totality of all other non human consciousness as well as awareness of timelessness through the simple focus of mind, must be what people call "being awake".

Novalis' Magical Idealism sparked this kind of imagination and intuition ever since reading about him as a child in a big encyclopedia we had at home. I recognized his language although I had no intellectual capacity to know why, only intuitively how, through a symbolic collage of metalanguage. Many years forward, Lama Anagarika Govinda spoke with the same language to me in "Foundations of Tibetan Mysticism", book that have found me by pure accident. Then I realized he quoted Novalis a lot and, at one point, even considered being his reincarnation. I think that he was close. They both spoke the same language, walked the esoterically same path, perhaps. This language, or knowledge, I date back to Plato who formulated and crystalized it's essence. He was definitely an Initiate.

My peregrination during the turbulent 20s and falling into one trap after another in my constant search for something, which led me across 3 continents, finally seemed to come to an end with the discovery of another author who spoke the secret language I understood, and who also loved to quote Novalis, my initial sparkle – Baron Julius Evola. Gate has been opened enabling me to finally move forward transcending in the spiral way out. Novalis's spiral path inwards.

This path is polarized or centered around the notion of a sacred center, which was, for me, always in Hyperborea. Real, unreal, mythical, physical, etheric, poetic, all in one. Magnetism was so strong that I envisioned myself bathing in Aurora Borealis, a cosmic North, source of light and purity. This is the greatest Ideal for me and true Home, which is "everywhere and nowhere".

I apologize for what must have been a crazy post. This site carries the same message and understanding which guided me through years of my journey and I'm grateful to find it.

4.7 Adornment of the Spiritual Marriage

A careful reading of **John of Ruysbroeck**'s works reveals the great distance that separates contemporary thought from Medieval spirituality. The meaning of those older texts is often obscured by translations which assume that archaic language is more uplifting than clear writing. For example, here is a sentence as it appears in the English translation of John's *Adornment of the Spiritual Marriage*⁸:

[Christ] fed in ghostly wise with true and inward teachings all those men who could understand them: and others from without through the senses with signs and wonders.

Here is my alternate translation for your consideration:

Christ fed the true esoteric teachings in a spiritual way to all those men who could understand them; and others exoterically through the senses with signs and wonders.

Here John is making clear that the esoteric (or inward) teachings have to do with changes in man's interior life, not with unusual events in the space-time world. More specifically, the esoteric teachings require a change in the way one lives his life. A fortiori, these teachings are not part of some novel philosophical system. In the meditation on Justice, **Valentin Tomberg** brings up the same issues. The spiritual "Greeks" are interested in worldly wisdom and spiritual "Jews" expect the power of God to be revealed in signs and wonders. (Obviously, this has nothing to do with ethnicity.)

Another factor to consider is the difference between literal and symbolic interpretations of sacred texts. The exoterically minded will understand symbolic teachings literally and literal teachings symbolically. To illustrate this, I will mention two topics brought up by John and the animal powers and his understanding of the three comings of Christ.

⁸<https://www.ccel.org/ccel/ruysbroeck/adornment.html>

Animal Powers In Chapter XXIII, John lists three adversaries to the spiritual life:

- **The Devil.** These are spiritual influences that impinge on us from outside the world.
- **The World.** These are the hodgepodge of influences originating in the human world. These are the “A” influences described by **Boris Mouravieff**.
- **Our own Flesh.** These are the influences arising from the lower centers of the soul.

For this illustration, we will focus on the “flesh”. This sentence summarizes John’s thought on this matter:

A man should keep his senses in sobriety and should restrain the animal powers by means of the reason; so that the lusts of the flesh do not enter too far into the savouring of food and of drink.

Of course, elsewhere he includes sexual impulses along with food and drink. Now this is all to be understood quite literally. “Animal powers” is simply the admission that man’s soul includes an “animal soul”. Moreover, the traditional teaching is that the “reason”, or intellectual soul, is to have dominance over the lower parts of the soul. This is no different from what Rene Guenon or Julius Evola have written about many times, in many ways. The only difference is that John provides us with the specifics about how that is to be accomplished.

Hence, there is nothing inherently evil about the “flesh” or “animal powers”. Man is part of organic life on earth, and hence falls under the General Law of Life: motivation by fear, sex, and hunger. This was common knowledge at one time; even the Tantric teachings understood them to be embodied in the three lower chakras.

So the problem arises when animal powers become compulsive, and not subject to the dominance of reason. This is quite opposed to the modern view, which understands the power of reason as a late addition to the genetic makeup of man. In this view, the power of reason is the passive force, in service to the needs of sexual and alimentary desires. In this view, therefore, such a use of reason makes a species more “fit” for survival. Moreover, many believe today that their sexuality represents the deepest part of themselves, so it needs to be expressed without any *frein vital*, or inner check.

Needless to say, the esoteric teaching is that the intellect needs to be the active force. The intellect, therefore, needs to restrain the animal powers. The intuitive intelligence, the knowledge of the heart, is the deepest part of man, although it usually remains hidden and merely virtual. The animal soul, then, is just the outer husk.

Now, the animal powers already have an intelligence of their own. Even the material world has an intelligence, otherwise the idea that matter “obeys” certain laws would make no sense.

In the animal world, a natural intelligence regulates sex and hunger, since they, too, are created by the Logos. Thus most animals have a period of estrus during which mating occurs. Often, such mating is very ritualized and ruled by instinct. The same applies to food. Most animals have specific and limited diets which suit them and are instinctually known.

For man, the situation is different. The adult female is sexually receptive at all times and not just during certain times of the year. Moreover, man is omnivorous, able to eat and digest a wide variety of foods. This suggests that man’s “animal powers” are not intended to function by a separate intelligence as is the case with animals, but rather by man’s unified reason. This is not the place to go into all the details, which can be summarized by this note from John:

We should build up a wall and make a separation within ourselves. And the lower part of ourselves, which is beastly and con-

trary to the virtues, and which wills our separation from God, we should hate and persecute, and we should torment it by means of penances and austerity of life; so that it be always repressed, and subject to reason, that thereby righteousness and purity of heart may always have the upper hand in all the works of virtue.

The wall sounds like the “cage” described by Mouravieff.

Freedom from Images Clearly, sex and food are not bad, since they are necessary for life. Nevertheless, the lower part has no interest in spiritual pursuits, so it resists the dominance of the intellectual soul. This prevents the unity of the soul and turns a man into a mass of competing interests. John relies on the grace of God:

There springs from the side of man ... a gathering together of all inward and outward powers in the unity of the spirit, in the bonds of love.

The animal powers hinder this unity through the power of sensible images and fantasies. In other words, images will arise in consciousness of sex and food, well beyond the body’s actual need of them for health and maintenance. John explains:

The freedom which allows the man to turn inwards, without hindrance from sensible images, as often as he wills and thinks upon his God. This means that a man must be indifferent to gladness and grief, profit and loss, rising and falling, to strange cares, to delight and to dread, and never be attached to any creature.

These three factors

- grace
- unity of the spirit

- freedom from sensible images

are the

foundation and the beginning of the inward practice and the inward life.

The Three Comings of Christ As an example of a symbolic teaching that is usually understood literally, we can look at John's teaching on the three comings of Christ:

These are the three comings of Christ, in inward exercises. We will now explain and set forth each coming separately. Attend therefore with diligence; for he who never has himself felt or experienced this shall not easily understand it.

John returns often to this topic, in increasing detail. For our purposes, we can focus on the first teachings. But pay careful attention to his words. One cannot reach an understanding through an intellectual argument, nor is it just a matter of blind faith. Rather, the teachings on the three comings of Christ needs to be experienced directly in order to understand them.

First Coming. The first coming is the incarnation, or the "historical" Jesus. We can skip past this, since its meaning is clear. This usually deteriorates into inconclusive debates about the "real" Jesus. Yet, paradoxically, this really can't be fully understood until the second and third comings are understood.

Second Coming. The second coming takes place "in the heart", that is, it begins with second birth of the Logos in the soul. We have addressed this many times previously. Yet John makes clear that the second coming is not a one-time event. Rather, it takes place daily bringing "new graces and new gifts". These graces make a man "just", so he can see himself exactly as he is.

Third Coming. The third coming happens at the Judgment at the hour of death. Here, justice is forced on the soul if it hadn't been previously prepared by the second coming. In that case, the judgment will appear harsh, as though coming from the outside. John explains: "the soul must then account for every word spoken and for every deed done, before the Eternal Truth."

Exoteric Postscript As should be clear by now, the religion described by John of Ruysbroeck is not intended for "children", as **Joris-Karl Huysmans** described it. Rather, it is possible only for the spiritually mature, those who have turned away from childish things, who have tasted fully the bitterness of life and seek to transcend it.

On one side, there is the exoteric battle between the defenders and the opponents of religion. They both presume the same frame of reference. For them, there is the quest for the perfect argument that will be the "defeater" of the opponent's position. The wisdom of the world for them is decisive: perhaps a new scientific discovery, technical advance, biblical exegesis, etc., is the answer. Or else, there is the quest for signs and wonders, or which side will manifest the will to power, whether of God or of man.

The esoteric battle, on the other hand, is an interior affair, or spiritual combat. It is not visible to the world. A fortiori, in today's world, a man can be engaged in this battle daily yet appear totally ordinary to the eyes of the world. Now, there is a pseudo-tradition abounding that rejects the True Religion of the Western Tradition in favor of some imaginary past. Keep in mind that Tradition is not a return to the past, but rather a return to what has always been. The pseudo-traditionalists therefore themselves need to participate in the spiritual combat. There is no difference, they must also dominate the animal soul through the powers of the intellect. Their path is all the more difficult without the guides or graces that make it possible.

Posted on 2016-01-14 by Cologero

* * *

Matt A on 2016-01-15 at 09:42 said:

You quote John as saying that man must "never be attached to any creature." This got me thinking, because it made me realize that I have a lot of work to do here. I asked myself, should we abandon (literally or even just emotionally) our spouses and children due to our attachments towards them? I think not. What attachments and karmic knots we have created should be untied with love (as Mouravieff suggests), so that the relationship can continue (or not) through the guidance of love and the will of God, instead of through attachment. We must be on guard that our emotional needs towards others don't supersede God's will. Including the desire to please and comfort our closest of family, and even ourselves.

aegishjalmer on 2016-01-16 at 12:04 said:

A wonderful post! Could you please elaborate on the pseudo tradition you mention, at least it's outlines?

Thank you

Cologero on 2016-01-17 at 10:38 said:

@aegishjalmer Some clues:

- The most common indication are those who reject tout court the bearer of Tradition in the West, viz., the Medieval tradition. Granted, this is not the same as the admission that many of its traditional elements have been forgotten.
- They typically expect a mass intellectual conversion based, of course, on their own ideals. Rather, a movement has to begin with a smaller group.
- They consciously or unconsciously adopt many of the attitudes of the modern world, while claiming they are somehow "traditional". Tradition is not a return to some part of the past, but rather to that which has eternal value.
- Their organizations are not hierarchically arranged on traditional principles. The pretenders to leadership positions would have been marginalized in a real traditional society.
- Grown men pose for publicity stills while holding a cat.

William Zeitler on 2018-01-15 at 11:36 said:

Can you suggest a translation of *The Adornment of Spiritual Marriage*? Your translation sounds wonderful, but may not be available. Thanks!

Cologero on 2018-01-16 at 08:33 said:

I use the translation by C. A. Wynschenk, but I am not familiar with any others. My "translation" is more interpretive than a strict translation. I'm trying to make the point that, if you understand the Hermetic teachings, you will "read" the literal text in a different way.

Petrus on 2018-01-16 at 13:26 said:

While the Wynschenk translation is freely available online, there is a modern version whose employment of English is less stilted than the earlier one, and is an edition in the Classics of Western Spirituality series: "John Ruusbroec: The Spiritual Espousals, The Sparkling Stones, and Other Works."

4.8 Predestination and Predilection

Our will is truly free only in union with that of God and that God acts on earth only through our free will freely united with his.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Every incarnated human being is the product of two shaping forces: heredity and the creative force of self-realization of the eternal individuality.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Any discussion of the mystery of birth would be incomplete without an understanding of predestination and predilection as understood in the Medieval Germanic-Roman religion, which is also known as the Catholic religion. To summarize the earlier post:

- Each person comes into the world with a set of qualities (his karmic inheritance).
- Beyond those innate qualities, his life's path is to actualize the possibilities open to him (his dharma path).
- He enters the world process at a time, place, and relationships suitable for him.

Nevertheless, the story is incomplete. Ultimately, beyond such terrestrial concerns, the goal is salvation and liberation. Hence, there is a supernatural destiny beyond our ordinary life. For some reason, the doctrines of predestination and predilection are seldom mentioned today despite their enormous importance. They may be hard to understand, or even distasteful to the secular mind, so it is helpful to meditate on them. For what follows, I am relying mostly on the book *Predestination* by **Fr Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange**.

Predilection This is the **Principle of Predilection**:

One would not be better than another unless one were loved more by God.

Predilection and predestination are clearly radically anti-egalitarian, as that principle makes clear.

St Thomas Aquinas justifies this principle:

Since God's love is the cause of goodness in things, no one thing would be better than another if God did not will greater good for one than for another ... and the reason why some things are better than others is that God wills them a greater good. Hence it follows that He loves more the better things.

Hence good things are not better because of some accident or injustice, but precisely because God loves them more. And the most perfect good is *theosis*, or becoming God-like. Fr Garrigou-Lagrange explains:

Every agent acts for an end and the purpose of the action of the supreme agent is to manifest His goodness by reproducing a likeness of Himself which is a more or less perfect participation of His nature.

Predilection is both a philosophical truth, known to reason, as well as a revealed truth. As a philosophical truth, it is obvious that it is true. Fr. Garrigou-Lagrange explains:

This principle is true in every order. It is true of plants, of animals, of human beings, of angels, of things in which there is less of perfection or of goodness. It is also true of every man who, from whatever point of view, is better than another ...

As a revealed truth, predilection is related to the gratuitous gift of grace from God which makes us pleasing. Thus, predilection, or what we consider the “good life”, may have one meaning in the natural realm, but in the supernatural, it may be completely different; the beatitudes are examples of supernatural predilection. This goodness comes from the grace of God, and makes us pleasing in his sight.

There is no injustice in this, for justice requires that unlike things be treated differently. Nevertheless, pride must be avoided since it is God who makes one man superior to another (Thomas Aquinas).

Predestination

Predestination is the foreknowledge and preparedness on God’s part to bestow the favors by which all those are saved who are to be saved ... God already knew, when He predestined, what He must do to bring His elect infallibly to eternal life.

ST. AUGUSTINE

The doctrine of predestination follows from predilection. St Thomas defines it this way:

The plan of the direction of a rational creature towards the end,
i.e., life eternal; for to destine is to direct or send.

Therefore, predestination is the plan in God's mind of directing a particular man to the ultimate and supernatural end. This plan, from all eternity, determines the efficacious means that will lead a man to his final end.

For God, intention precedes execution, or ends before means. Hence, according to this doctrine, God will also provide the means, circumstances, and situations required to achieve the ultimate end for the elect, or predestined. This is exactly what Guenon was getting at with the notion of "compossible". The conditions of birth need to be consistent with, and provide the necessary opportunities, to achieve salvation or liberation. A sign of being predestined is to be born into the Medieval Germanic-Roman tradition, or otherwise to have the opportunity to embrace it freely. Nevertheless, some would spurn God's love and reject it.

Antecedent and Consequent Will To fully grasp these doctrines, it is necessary to be clear about the difference between the antecedent and consequent will of God. What God wills antecedently may or may not take place. On the other hand, the consequent will is efficacious.

Now the antecedent will of God is for all to achieve salvation, but not all are predestined. The antecedent will is more like the Hermetic notion of Providence. To deny the antecedent will would make God responsible for "wars, concentration camps, and physical and psychical epidemics" as Tomberg points out. This view of God's omnipotence is not uncommon and is based on presumption.

The consequent will involves the alliance of the divine will and the human will. This is not pure passivity, as Fr Garrigou-Lagrange makes clear:

The wills of men are more in God's power than their own.

We can't go into all the details right now, but God affects the will through graces and virtues.

Postscript on Incarnation Tomberg's understanding of incarnation is in general agreement with Evola's. Tomberg writes (in Letter XX):

The individuality descends consciously and of his own free will to birth, into an environment where he is wanted and awaited.

Those are rarer cases however. For most, the incarnation is dominated more by the horizontal than the vertical.

The consequences of Tomberg's insight have been mentioned in other contexts. Some are "born from above", even if their memory of it is quite dim. The second birth is a remembrance of that. Many, if not most, people today, have a self-understanding of being a product of biological forces and cultural influences. They lack that true will that Tomberg mentions.

The united will constitutes the indestructible and immortal kernel of the body ... its active principle, its formative will-energy, survives death.

The notion of being "adopted sons [or children] of God" is trivialized today. It leads to a spiritual infantilisation, a pure passivity, the presumption that God loves you just the way you are, without any demands. As we have seen, God does not love everyone to the same degree. His real children are those who have taken on his nature. That's what being a son means: to inherit the nature of the father, or, speaking colloquially, being a "chip off the old block."

Nevertheless, unlike certain reformation heresies, the Germanic-Roman religion does not accept that some people are condemned at birth. God

does not demand the impossible, so it is incorrect to claim that a man may be born with certain proclivities that compel him to deviate from the cosmic law. Even worse is to believe that such compulsions are therefore good and defensible.

Posted on 2015-07-10 by Cologero

4.9 The Breath of Life

Man consists of three elements: spirit, soul, and body, which sometimes are reckoned as two, for often the soul is included in the designation of spirit (for it is that certain rational part, which beasts do not have, that is called spirit). Our chief element is the spirit.

ST. AUGUSTINE

Augustine and the Eastern fathers tend to distinguish between the soul and spirit. Basing himself on Aristotle, **Aquinas** employs different terminology although the principle is the same. This can be a source of confusion; that is why we need to know our Greek and Latin.

If Adam had his spirit breathed into him by God, and Eve by implication, Fr. Warkulwiz poses the question of how his descendants got their souls. The first choice is transmission by the reproductive process. This is rejected out of hand by Augustine on the grounds that the soul would be a body rather than a spirit. However, Augustine realized that the special creation of the soul by God is inconsistent with the dogma of original sin.

Aquinas takes an important step in resolving that issue. He distinguishes between the sensitive soul which man has in common with the animals and the intellectual soul, which distinguishes man from the animals. The latter soul is the *ruach* that God breathed into Adam, what we have been calling “spirit”. With this distinction in mind, Aquinas can

claim that that the sensitive soul is indeed transmitted through seminal generation, while the intellectual soul is not. We have already addressed the topic of heredity⁹ as it applies to the body and the (sensitive) soul. (In the ensuing discussion, I will replace the idea of intellectual soul with the word “spirit”.)

But here is where the dogma gets fuzzy. He says it is unnatural for the intellectual soul (spirit) to be without a body, so he insists that the spirit is created by God and infused into the body at the moment of conception. This explanation has the benefit that it acknowledges the transcendence of the spirit, since it is not mechanically produced as part of the world process, but has a transcendent source. Nevertheless, it raises some issues that are unsatisfactory from a metaphysical and esoteric perspective.

- How can something immortal and transcendent have a beginning in time?
- If a spirit without a body is “unnatural”, how do we account for purely spiritual postmortem states?
- How does a perfect God create a spirit deformed by original sin?

Pre-existence of spirit

Before I [God] formed thee in the belly I knew thee.

Jeremiah 1:5

Rene Guenon pointed out that without the ability to think outside of time, a man can never master metaphysics; hence we can’t think in terms of a clock in the heavens that is synchronized to a clock on earth. To be consistent with the dogma, we could say that the spirit exists virtually, but actually when conjoined with a soul and body.

⁹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1664>

Postmortem states Here Aquinas is inconsistent. If the spirit persists in a postmortem state, then there is no reason to require it to be joined to a body, so the pre-existence of the spirit is not logically refuted. Just the opposite, since something immortal has no beginning in time. In any case, Genesis is concerned only with this world. Although Fr. Warkulwiz mentions the idea of possible worlds, he doesn't follow through with it. We have pointed out in the post on Parallel Universes¹⁰, that the spirit can, and does, incarnate in different worlds. This makes the question moot.

Incarnation Both **Rene Guenon** and **Valentin Tomberg** employ the symbolism of the cross. There is the horizontal line which represents the world process, or Destiny. The vertical line represents transcendence, or Will. Since God works through secondary causes, then the incarnation of a spirit should be approached in the same way. Fr. Warkulwiz points out that creation is identical with will: when we say that God creates the word, we mean he wills it into existence. Analogously, the spirit wills itself into existence at the appropriate moment in the world process. If the world process is corrupted (by original sin), then the perfect spirit will find itself in that situation.

This is something that is not proved by argument, nor by quoting texts, but rather by remembering. If I misplace my keys, it is not because I willed to lose them. Nevertheless, I am responsible for that state of affairs. The reason they are lost is because I was not acting consciously when I laid them down. As an exercise, the next time you misplace something, instead of frantically searching for it, sit quietly and try to remember where they are.

There is a similar exercise for your life. Try to remember why you chose this particular life, its qualities, your parents, your world. Then you will understand.

¹⁰<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1863>

Posted on 2011-07-12 by Cologero

* * *

Iulianus on 2011-07-13 at 07:13 said:

Many explain the part in the Bible, "God breathed the breath of life into the face of Adam" the first-created, who was created by Him from the dust of the ground, it must mean that until that moment there was neither human soul nor spirit in Adam, but only the flesh created from the dust of the ground. This interpretation is wrong, for the Lord created Adam from the dust of the ground with the constitution which the holy Apostle Paul describes: "May your spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ" (1 Thess. 5:23). And all these parts of our nature were created from the dust of the ground, and Adam was not created dead, but an active being like all of God's animate creatures living on earth.

The point is, that if the Lord God had not breathed afterwards into his face, this breath of life – that is, the grace of our Lord God the Holy Spirit Who proceeds from the Father, rests in the Son and is sent into the world for the Son's sake – Adam would have remained without the Holy Spirit within him. It is the Holy Spirit who raised Adam to Godlike dignity. However perfect, he had been created and superior to all the other creatures of God, as the crown of creation on earth, he would have been just like all the other creatures, though they have a body, soul and spirit, each according to its kind, do not have the Holy Spirit within them. But when the Lord God breathed into Adam's face the breath of life, then, according to Moses' word, "Adam became a living soul" (Gen. 2:7), that is, completely and in every-way like God, and like Him, forever immortal. Adam was immune to the action of the elements to such a degree that water could not drown him, fire could not burn him, the earth could not swallow him in its abysses, and the air could not harm him by any kind of action whatever. Everything was subject to him as the beloved of God, as the king and lord of creation, and everything looked up to him, as the perfect crown of God's creatures. Adam was made so wise by this breath of life, which was breathed into his face from the creative lips of God, the Creator and Ruler of all, that there has never been a man on earth wiser or more intelligent, and it is unlikely that there ever will be. When the Lord commanded him to give names to all the creatures, he gave every creature a name which completely expressed all the qualities, powers and properties given it by God at its creation.

"As a result of this gift, of the supernatural grace of God, which was infused into him by the breath of life, Adam could see, understand the Lord walking in Paradise, comprehend His words, understand the conversation of the holy Angels, the language of all beasts, birds and reptiles and all that is now hidden from us the fallen and sinful creatures. All this was so clear to Adam before his fall. The Lord God also gave Eve the same wisdom, strength, unlimited power, and all the other good and holy qualities. He created her not from the dust of the ground, but from Adam's rib in the Eden of delight, the Paradise which He had planted in the midst of the earth.

“In order that they might always easily maintain the immortal, divine and perfect properties of this breath of life, God planted in the midst of the garden the tree of life with fruits endowed with all the essence and fullness of His divine breath. If they had not sinned, Adam and Eve themselves as well as all their posterity could have always eaten of the fruit of the tree of life and so would have eternally maintained the vivifying power of divine grace.

“They could have also maintained for all eternity the full powers of their body, soul and spirit in a state of immortality and perpetual youth, and they could have continued in this immortal and blessed state of theirs forever. At the present time, however, it is difficult for us even to imagine such grace.

Source: Saint Seraphim of Sarov – On Acquisition of the Holy Spirit

http://www.fatheralexander.org/booklets/english/sermon_st_seraphim.htm

Will on 2011-07-16 at 09:08 said:

Ananda Coomaraswamy's article *The Coming to Birth of the Spirit* offers much clarification on the terms 'soul' and 'spirit,' as well as others.

The text is available online, though unfortunately without the substantial footnotes which are worthwhile in themselves.

<http://www.religioperennis.org/documents/acoomaraswamy/spirit.pdf>

Iulianus on 2011-07-17 at 07:19 said:

Notes on “The Coming to Birth of the Spirit” are included in *The Essential Ananda K. Coomaraswamy*, the eBook can be found here: <http://mikrotheos.blogspot.com/2011/01/blog-post.html>

I think that St Seraphim of Sarov is right, but it should be emphasized here that “grace of our Lord God the Holy Spirit”, i.e. “the energies of God” are uncreated. Clarification from the book *THEOSIS – THE TRUE PURPOSE OF HUMAN LIFE*: “The energies of God are divine energies. They too are God, but without being His essence. They are God, and therefore they can deify man. If the energies of God were not divine and uncreated, they would not be God and so they would be unable to deify us, to unite us with God. There would be an unbridgeable distance between God and men. But as God has the divine energies, and unites with us by these energies, we are able to commune with Him and to unite with His Grace without becoming identical with God, as would happen if we united with His essence. So we unite with God through His uncreated energies, and not through His essence. This is the mystery of our Orthodox faith and life. Western heretics cannot accept this. Being rationalists, they do not discern between the essence; and the energy of God, so they say that they cannot speak about man's Theosis because God is only essence, for on this basis, how can man be deified when they do not accept that

the divine energies are uncreated, but regard them as created? How can something created deify man, i.e. how can something outside God deify man? In order not to fall into pantheism, they do not talk about Theosis at all. What then, according to them, remains as the purpose of human life? Simply moral improvement. If man cannot be deified with divine Grace and divine energies, what purpose does his life have? Only that he becomes morally better. But moral perfection is not enough for man. It is not enough for us simply to become better than before, simply to perform moral deeds. We have as our final aim to unite with holy God Himself. This is the purpose of the creation of the universe. This is what we desire. This is our joy, our happiness, and our fulfillment."

According to St Ignatius Brianchaninov "Our mind is – image of God the Father, our word (and unspoken word is often called "thought") – image of the Son of God, and our spirit – image of the Holy Spirit."

"Whoever is joined unto the Lord is One Spirit" I Cor. 6:17

Cologero on 2011-07-18 at 00:55 said:

As for the Coomaraswamy article, what specific clarification (of what has been written) are you referring to? Coomaraswamy takes pains to point out that we are not discussing philosophical categories, but rather those arising from experience. Thus ultimately the only "clarification" of value comes from one's own self-understanding.

Cologero on 2011-07-20 at 11:53 said:

Thanks, Iulianus, for the extensive quotes.

Will on 2011-07-22 at 21:17 said:

The leading quotation from Augustine seems to need clarification, insofar as it equates the "rational" with "spirit." Perhaps this simply reflects a problem in the translation.

Rational comes from ratio, which is discursive thinking and reasoning (*dianoia* in Greek). A higher faculty is Intellect – intellectus, or *nous* in Greek. Plato holds that man comes to know and unify with the Good through noesis, not through discursive reasoning. Does Augustine hold the contrary? I don't know; I am quite ignorant of Augustine's theology.

Coomaraswamy argues that in the trinity of Body-Soul-Spirit, it is the spirit which is eternal. Augustine says the same thing, but if he asserts that the spirit is the rational faculty, is he asserting that this faculty survives death?

My (limited) understanding of these terms is as follows: The spirit is eternal and transcendent, as well as impersonal, such that one cannot rightly speak of "my" or "your" spirit as some kind of individual thing; indeed, it is more accurately "nothing", no-thing, as Coomaraswamy says.

The soul, or psyche, can be spoken of, and moreover can be worked on, harmonized, ordered, and perfected, so as to fully partake and reflect the Divine. However, traditions including Christianity describe this process as soul-death, or ego-death, as when Jesus says that whoever does not hate his own soul cannot be a disciple. This seems to me to refer to the individuality of the soul vs. the non-individuality of the spirit, and the necessity to ‘die before you die’ so as to be born again into the eternity of spirit.

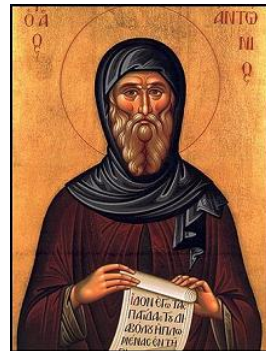
Although etymologically, the use of ‘spirit’ to denote the transcendent, eternal, and uncreated seems problematic insofar as the word comes from spirare – to breathe – a limited bodily function. Or does this choice of terms hint at the importance of the breath as a link to the transcendent?

Perennial on 2011-07-23 at 02:30 said:

Will, you make an excellent point. From an English perspective, I personally prefer using the term soul for what they refer to as spirit, since in English this is generally regarded as the eternal aspect of man, and vice versa for spirit, which has a rather more nebulous connotation. But there may be an argument for the “orthodox” use in English. Perhaps it would be that we should at least try to use the same terminology in the same sense, or at least *simili modo*. In any case, I would be interested in seeing other views on this.

4.10 St Anthony and Practical Reason

What follows are some of the main themes of **St Anthony**’s “Counsels on the Character of Men and on the Virtuous Life”, from the *Philokalia*, Volume I, translated by **Constantine Cavarnos**. Dr. Cavarnos includes copious footnotes relating St Anthony’s essay to biblical passages, apparently to counteract the claims of the first translators, which we have previously documented¹¹. Nevertheless, it is unlikely you will hear these themes in a Sunday sermon, or from a TV preacher.



¹¹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=497>

Practical Reason

Men are improperly called rational; it is not those who have learned thoroughly the discourses and books of the wise men of old that are rational, but those who have a rational soul and can discern what is good and what is evil, and avoid what is evil and harmful to the soul, but zealously keep, with the aid of practice, what is good and beneficial to the soul ...

The “book learning” St Anthony refers to may be called “theoretical reason”. But what makes a man truly rational is the “practical reason”, that is, the ability to choose ones ends or goals and the means to achieve them. Since man is the “rational animal”, someone who does not possess practical reason is really “inhuman”, being more like the irrational animals.

Just as helmsmen steer the ship in the proper direction in order to avoid hitting a reef or shoal, so let those who aspire after the virtuous life consider carefully what they ought to do and what they ought to avoid.

Freedom Those who “are free in their life and ways”, are properly called free.

Freedom and happiness of the soul consist in genuine purity and contempt of transitory things.

Characteristics

A truly rational and virtuous soul is recognized from a man’s look, walk, voice, laughter, manner of spending his time, and the circumstances of his life. Everything in such a soul has been thoroughly changed and corrected so as to become graceful.

A virtuous life is like a work of art, with the soul as artist:

Like skilled painters and sculptors, it is by their works that they display their virtuous and God-loving way of life.

Rulers

Examine the things that pertain to you, and prove for yourself that rulers and masters have authority only over the body, not over the soul; and let this always be before your mind.

This is even more important in our day when propaganda has become a science. Pay attention to the sources of your concepts and values to determine if they are truly good, or simply absorbed from the mass media.

Vigilance The soul's "God-loving rational faculty, being a vigilant gatekeeper, bars entry to evil and ugly thoughts." We are accustomed to regarding thoughts as our own, without considering the source. We are bombarded by thoughts¹²; they are the key to influencing our behavior. A man must be the detached observer of his thoughts, paying attention to their origin¹³, before latching onto a thought and letting it guide his actions.

Obstacles St Anthony lists many obstacles to a virtuous life. Again, the point is not to be "good" in order to get a reward, but rather to recognize those attitudes that prevent us from leading the rational life. The spirit [*nous*, mind] must guide the soul which masters the body. The "passions", on the other hand, make us passive, not the active agent¹⁴ of our life. In one place he lists "lust, love of glory, and ignorance". In another, "conceit, arrogance, deception, envy, avarice". The point is that these temptations tie us to transitory things, dominate the soul, and thus prevent our full use of reason and freedom.

¹²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=451>

¹³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=309>

¹⁴<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=203>

Many paths

Through God's love for man, there are many paths that lead men to salvation, ways that convert men and lead them to the Heavens.

Posted on 2010-05-30 by Cologero

4.II On the Human Soul

St Gregory of Nyssa on the Human Soul by JOHN P. CAVARNOS, Edited and Revised by CONSTANTINE CAVARNOS, 95 pp, Institute for Byzantine and Modern Greek Studies¹⁵

We regard all knowledge as beautiful and precious, but one kind of it more so than another, either by reason of its exactness, or because it has reference to superior and more wonderful objects. On both these accounts we should naturally be led to place in the front rank the study of the soul.

ARISTOTLE, *On the Soul*

Originally published as a doctoral dissertation, this edition was revised for use by a more general audience. Since the fundamental goal of Christianity is the “salvation of souls”, it is curious that there was no systematic understanding of the soul until the efforts of **St Gregory of Nyssa**. Mr. Cavarnos points out:

Christianity, being concerned above all with man's destiny and salvation, must inevitably undertake to explain the mystery of life. For the Christian that means more specifically the human soul.

¹⁵<http://ibmgs.org/>

Curiously, St Gregory turns to the great pagans of antiquity, in particular **Plato** and **Aristotle**, for his understanding of the soul. There are a few explanations that have been proposed by Gornahoor. The first is attributed to **Julius Evola**, who would regard this as the process of “rectification”, i.e., the partial restoration of the Middle Ages to its pagan roots following the shock of primitive Christianity. **Guido De Giorgio**, on the other hand, would regard the two Romes — the Ancient and the Medieval — as two forms of the same tradition, the later a deepening of the earlier. Our preference is that St Gregory is giving us a guidebook to the soul, not a theory, and anyone who makes the efforts at self-knowledge will simply see that it is true.

Unfortunately, Mr. Cavarnos falls prey to the modernist notion that St Gregory was merely making “good use of classical and contemporary material for giving form and expression to accepted Christian doctrines and concepts.” Were that true, then why couldn’t modern theories of the mind or soul be put to the same use? No, it is not a pragmatic concern for good usage, but whether the doctrine is true or not.



Anthropology Like the pagan philosophers, St Gregory conceived the cosmos as divided into two orders: the spiritual and rational over against the material and irrational. In his understanding of the purpose of man, St Gregory is closer to his Christian roots. Mr. Cavarnos summarizes:

Man was created in the image and likeness of God so that he could partake of the divine nature and make it known to the rest of the creation. He is related to God by his endowment of the divine principle of reason, through which he knows God and imitates Him to attain to virtue and perfection.

So man is suspended between the two poles and is to be the link between them. Following **Rene Guenon**, we have referred to those poles as form and matter, or essence and existence. The former binds man with the divine and the latter with the subrational world. In his higher role, man possesses divine attributes such as life, reason, wisdom, and so on. Man is also a microcosm, so his self-knowledge relates to the knowledge of the cosmos by analogy.

Nature of the Soul St Gregory makes a useful distinction of his study. The metaphysics of the soul relate to the essence, origin, and destiny of the soul, and the psychology of the soul is concerned with determining, defining, and classifying the diverse faculties of the soul. This psychology is necessarily a phenomenology, since the soul can only be directed observed from the inside.

Starting with the nature of the soul he claims that the soul is the principle that gives life to the body. That is, it animates the body, from the Latin word *anima* for soul. Immediately, this is the opposite of educated men today who believe, on the contrary, that the soul is a function, or epiphenomenon, of the body. Not so, and this is why Rene Guenon identifies the five fundamental preconditions for manifestation: space, time, form, matter, and life. Hence, there are both material forces and psychic forces in play, irreducible to each other. Evola makes use of this idea in his own doctrine of the degrees of race. Of course, these are the natural forces, which operate on the horizontal plane, and not the supernatural, or vertical, forces.

St Gregory, like Plato, accepts the immortality of the soul as well as its simplicity. Mr. Cavernos does not point this out, but this is analogous to the Roman idea of divine simplicity, which should be expected if the soul is truly the likeness of the divine. In this case, the human soul is chiefly identified with the rational, or intellectual, faculty; this faculty is therefore the ruling principle. Again, this is consistent with the ancient

pagans and the Medieval tradition.

Gregory brings up an excellent and very important point: the “passions” are actually distinct from the soul, hence cannot be considered part of it. For Gregory, the soul is beautiful, which would preclude any ugliness. This means two things in practice:

- Man’s interiority is subject to inferior and subrational influences arising, as it were, from outside of himself
- When a man submits to the demands of these influences, he is not fulfilling himself, but, on the contrary, he is surrendering up his self to an outside agent

Gregory, like St Anthony of the Desert¹⁶, regards these passions as animal traits. These are the beasts of the field that must be named and mastered. The questions that we brought up at one point are worth revisiting: if a being is dominated by his passions, to what extent can he be considered as a man rather than an animal? On one hand, the case can be made that he is a “virtual” man, since he has the possibility of being rational.

The Origin of the Soul Gregory rejects two doctrines: the preexistence of the soul and the theory of reincarnation. Like contemporary writers on tradition, Gregory demonstrates the metaphysical impossibility of reincarnation, with an argument that doesn’t need to be discussed at the moment. Keeping in mind Aristotle’s five versions of priority, Gregory rejects the temporal preexistence of the soul, but not the ontological preexistence.

For Gregory, the whole of humanity preexisted in God’s mind as a possibility, not an actuality. Clearly, this is consistent with what Guenon writes in the *Multiple States of Being*. A soul is a possibility of manifestation. Gregory accepted traducianism (the rational soul is passed in the

¹⁶See Section 4.10 of this book.

semen), which is hard to defend, as it makes of it a natural process. In keeping with traditional metaphysics, the soul manifests in a world in which it is compossible with the rest of the world. That is, the soul manifests when there is an affinity between the possibilities of the soul and the particular world in which those possibilities can be actualized. I'm sorry that this cannot be proved in the manner of the geometers, but a man can just "see" that it is so, provided he has sufficient self-knowledge.

Like **St Thomas Aquinas** after him, Gregory claims that the soul passes through three stages: the insensible stage, the sensible stage, and the rational stage. Since the soul is the form of the body,

the soul is the determining principle or cause in the living being. It constructs for itself a body that is suitable, like a seal that impresses its stamp on wax.

Once again, this is an idea that has been insufficiently developed. It seems, therefore, that the features of a man's body are not accidental, incidental, arbitrary, irrelevant, or unimportant. Rather they are the visible manifestations of the invisible soul. We will explore this idea further in the mailing list.

The Soul after Death Plato, Origen, and the Bible provided the sources for Gregory's thought on this matter. Unlike the fundamentalists of today — and I would include the anti-Christian, neo-Nietzschean and neopagans in that camp — Gregory tends to understand Scripture allegorically rather than literally. Gregory believed that by the very order of things, the good and justice will ultimately prevail. Again, this is consistent with Guenon in the *Symbolism of the Cross*. Gregory believed that if the soul becomes mindful of its previous sins, and fearful of their consequences, he becomes wise and prudent. That is a big "if". On the one hand, few today believe they are sinful or that there are consequences. On the other

hand, the neo-Christians who believe in “faith alone”, don’t accept that there is any necessary reason to become wise or prudent.

I will gloss over the discussion of the resurrection, but will point out that “resurrection is the restoration of our nature to its original state.” Of course, for us, that is the Primordial State. In that state, there is no childhood, old age, disease, or infirmity. The body is incorruptible and is finer and lighter. This is not unlike what Guenon wrote about the body being lighter in earlier yugas. Obviously, the impure souls will not be part of this resurrection to the Primordial State.

The Relation of Body and Soul Gregory claimed that

the study of the soul and its relation to the body is of primary importance, since the knowledge of the soul and the manner in which it operates in the body has a profound bearing on the ideas of perfection and salvation, as well as on man’s well-being and thinking.

If that be so, then why does no one in the West consider it very important? Only in the East, do some men continue to map out the intricacies of the soul. If Gregory is correct, then we understand why Protestantism is so destructive, since salvation, for it, involves little more than responding to an altar call.

Unlike the pagans, like Plotinus for example, who regarded matter as inherently evil, Gregory saw the origin of sin in man’s will, not in the body, *per se*. Nevertheless, the lower forces, which as we pointed out earlier arise from the outside of man, must be overcome. Specifically, men in the flesh must separate or detach from such forces. This does have an effect on salvation:

if anyone is entirely preoccupied with the things of the flesh and uses every movement of the soul and all its energy for his fleshy

desires, he will not be separated from experiences involving the flesh, even when he is out of it.

Gregory has an interesting understanding of the senses:

Since the senses are more akin to the coarseness and earthiness of the body than to the soul, they are subject to errors. They are termed windows through which death enters, for they lead men to the life of the passions and bodily pleasures.

Men today are in basic agreement, except that for them life enters through the senses. Sensuality is considered normal and good. For the moderns, the purpose of the intellect is to think up ways to improve sensual experience: the body desires and the soul tries to satisfy it. For Gregory, the reality is reversed: the body is the instrument of the soul. The soul commands and the body executes. This is not life denying, since the intent is not to cause the body to suffer, but rather to improve the life of the soul. The desires of the body are never fully sated, so men today are anxious, angry, fearful and seek to hide from them through the pursuit of “good” experiences. Rather, the soul should learn to be ordered, just as the macrocosm is ordered.

The Faculties of the Soul

The Platonic Element Gregory follows Plato’s naming of the three powers or faculties of the soul:

- **Nous.** The rational power consisting of intellect and will.
- **Thymos.** The spirited or striving faculty.
- **Epithymia.** The appetitive faculty of desire.

Gregory says the inclinations of thymos and epithymia are harmful or good, depending on how they are applied. Although they are beast like, they cannot be reduced to instincts, presumably because instincts are mechanical and, as such, are beyond ordinary conscious control.

When under the dominion of the nous, of the two lower faculties, one gives courage and the other the desire to participate in the good. Otherwise, disorder sets in. Gregory's teaching is summarized in Table 4.1.

Faculty	Virtue	Illness
Rational	Contemplation of the divine	Impiety
	Discernment between good and evil	Lack of sound judgment concerning the truly good
	Clear and unconfused knowledge of physical nature	False opinion regarding the nature of things
Spirited	Hatred of evil	Envy
	The struggle against passions	Hatred
	The urging of the soul to courage	Malice
Appetitive	The virtuous motion toward what is worth desiring	The love of money
	An erotic impulse towards virtue	Sensuality

Table 4.1: Powers of the soul according to Plato

Disorders of the Rational Faculty Although most people focus on the illnesses of the spirited and appetitive faculties, it is actually the illness of the intellect which is more serious and the most difficult to eradicate. A man who is disordered in his spiritedness or appetite can learn to overcome them, provided his intellect is still sound. Unfortunately, a man with a disordered intellect is not even aware of this disorder; hence, he has no incentive to change. These types of men make communication

difficult.

It is worth the effort to update Gregory's symptoms. Now, as then, impiety is a common illness of the rational soul. Impiety means the denial of the existence of any higher, spiritual influences; moreover, any such teachings are simply mocked.

Lack of judgment of the good leads to regarding the disorders of the lower faculties as good, rather than the bad that they really are. Or things that are necessary are regarded as evil. This leads to a strange kind of neo-Puritanism. Although I'm not an advocate of Puritanism, at least their intent was to establish order and lead to salvation after death. Neo-Puritanism, on the contrary, seeks to abolish death, an obvious absurdity. This leads to public attacks on smoking, the right to bear arms, and even on what the populace is allowed to eat and drink.

The disease of misunderstanding the nature of things leads to decision-making base on sentimental motives or wishful thinking, rather on how things really are. Anyone who opposes such beliefs is shamed, ostracized, or even worse, if they hold positions of power.

As we have pointed out, the roots of these errors go deep and are based on the rejection of one or more metaphysical principles. For example, we have shown how the rejection of final or formal causes leads to specific sorts of errors. The rejection of order, i.e., impiety, leads to Marxist-like plans to overturn the established order.

The Aristotelian Element Alongside the Platonic understanding of the soul, Gregory also draws on Aristotle. For him, they are not in contradiction. Gornahoor would say that the Platonic understanding is founded on interiority and is proved by the dominion of the rational soul.

The Aristotelian perspective starts from the senses and leads inward. So he accepts the understanding of the soul as encompassing three elements:

1. The vegetative soul, which controls growth and increase and the activities of life.
2. The sensitive soul, which governs sense activities.
3. The rational soul, or intellectual power

Gregory writes:

The perfect life in the body is seen to be in the rational nature of man, being nourished and perceived by the mind, participating in reason and governed by the mind.

In keeping with the outer orientation, the nous, or rational soul, exteriorizes its activities in matter. Thus, the nous is united to power, which is the ability to bring ideas and plans into manifestation. Since the soul is beautiful, what it makes manifest will also be beautiful.

Free Will and Virtue In the final chapter, Mr. Cavaros addresses Gregory's teaching on the will. He defines freedom:

freedom is choosing freely the object desired. Will is a faculty exempt from servitude, free, residing in the independence of our reason. Free will is the essential foundation for virtue, for if it is lacking, then there can be no virtue, no praise, no blame for human conduct.

The consequences of this teaching are hard, and few are willing to accept it. Gregory explains:

The soulless or irrational beings are led by an external will. If a rational and thinking nature discards freedom, it also loses the right for thinking.

Obviously, a multitude of spiritual influences abound, whose goal is to implant themselves in unaware minds, thus controlling their wills in a very real sense. Isn't this far too obvious to deny? For example, in the USA, almost out of nowhere, a movement arose to infringe the right to bear arms. Suddenly the nation was mobilized, the media focused on the topic, the populace talked about it, and so on. The "debates" on the topic are almost always reduced to swapping slogans or making sentimental arguments. I saw one woman saying, in all seriousness, that women don't need a gun for self-defense since she "feels" safe even when walking in bad neighborhoods. Apparently, any argument — whether pro or con — is unnecessary, since her feelings trump any such argument.

I am not trying to adjudicate that issue here, but to point out how external ideas take hold in a mind. This irrationality is considered "soulless" by Gregory. As you go through the day, can you tell which beings that you encounter actually have a soul and which are soulless?

According to Gregory, God endowed human nature with the principle of all that is beautiful, and the most precious and beautiful good is the gift for being independent and free. Necessity and compulsion negate man's being the image of God.

Hence, when a man makes a bad choice, he must accept the consequences of that choice. This is the natural result and not a special act of divine retribution as some are inclined to think. The conclusion from this is clear, as was shown in Guido De Giorgio's meditation on death¹⁷. God does not directly punish a soul, or send it to hell or whatever other place or state; rather, man himself chooses his own ultimate state.

Mr. Cavernos does not draw any conclusions from this; nevertheless, Gornahoor thinks there is a clear and important conclusion. If all this is true, then the salvation of the soul requires the development of the rational faculty or nous. This is measured in several ways:

¹⁷<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=11683>

- The rational soul becomes the master of the lower faculties.
- It contemplates the divine
- It discerns between good and evil
- It has clear knowledge about physical nature
- It exteriorizes itself in a life of virtue and beauty

Posted on 2013-03-14 by Cologero

4.12 Rational Man and Moral Law

Today the meaning of the moral as cosmic worth has been lost, and up to now, it has been reduced to nothing more than the corroboration and canonisation of deficiency, weakness, and fear — of the plague of beautiful sentiments, of noble virtues, of holy ideals — that is, of the fundamentally immoral.

JULIUS EVOLA

St Anthony the Great St Anthony has already been dealt with in Section 4.10, so we will focus just on his concept of the “rational man”. The rational man is not just a learned man or scholar, but rather someone who not only knows good from bad, but also has the power to act on it. The rational faculty needs to be developed. In appearance, Anthony seems to be recommending conventional morality when he talks about overcoming irrational passions and desires or orienting oneself toward the eternal and divine rather than the temporal and material. Yet these are more than moral strictures, they are rational, properly so called.

The rational faculty unites man with divine power, power over oneself, one's thoughts, one's acts. As such, it is a faculty that must be developed. For Anthony, the irrational man is in a state of darkness and devoid of divine light. That is, the rational faculty is only virtual and not actual. Since man by definition is rational, such men are not, strictly speaking, even men. This brings Anthony close to the Gnostic idea of the three classes of men [Hylic, Psychic, and Pneumatic], and only the actualized rational man is pneumatic.

There is a potential consequence to this point of view that does not seem to have been realized by Anthony's commentators, though it has by Nietzsche. Eric Voegelin writes, in his discussion of what Reason (or rationality) is:

The constituent of society is the Homonoia or "like-mindedness" of Everyman in a community formed through recognition of the reason common to all men. In Aristotle, if love within the community is not based upon regard for the divinity of reason in the other man, then the political friendship on which a well-ordered community depends cannot exist. The source of the Christian notion of "human dignity" is the common divinity in all men. Nietzsche perceived that if that is surrendered then there is no reason to love anybody, one consequence of which is the loss of the sense and force of obligation in society and, hence, of its cohesiveness.

But according to Anthony, only the rational man is in union with God (or Nous in Platonic or Aristotelian terms), and reason is not at all common to all men. Obviously, the modernist project of deriving human dignity from material and biological considerations has failed (it is unreasonable), with the resulting loss of cohesiveness in Western societies. So, if biologism cannot justify egalitarianism, then neither can Christianity, since full human dignity may only be virtual. Another way of putting

it is to say that although in essence there may be a common divinity in men, it is not necessarily so in existence.

Yet, Anthony insists on comparing the irrational man to brute animals, whether or not the rational faculty is merely undeveloped or, perhaps, does not even exist at all. The full implications for ethics and political science have not yet been drawn out.

Julius Evola If the world is Will and Idea, then knowledge of ideas is insufficient for its understanding and the hope for a science of everything is futile. The act of Will brings Ideas into reality, that is, it causes a change in Being. Thus the world does not present itself as a scientific problem, but rather as a moral problem, so fundamentally, morality necessarily implies the power to act. Evola writes:

The ethical problem and the metaphysical problem coincide: the measure of reality, as of the good, of the certain and of the true, is the perfection of actuality or power. *Per virtutem et potentiam idem intelligo.* [Spinoza, *Ethics*, “by virtue and power I mean the same thing.”] The good or virtue is potency, evil impotence. There is no other evil except insufficiency and weakness, no other good except the will that is unconditionally sufficient in itself, and therefore free to be and do what it wills.

Conventional morality is of two types. One is the idea of a war against the body or parts of the soul. The other is intellectual and involves finding a moral system that demands adherence. Neither solves the problem of power or change of being.

More recent attempts — such as that of Ken Wilber — have postulated a scale of moralities, as one “evolves” from stage to stage. Such attempts are clearly self-serving and unprovable, not to mention incompatible with a true moral will. Evola anticipated such scales when he wrote:

The life of the spirit is essentially that of freedom. It makes no sense to speak of a transcendent law — whether natural, rational, or moral — which would determine how the stages would proceed in accordance with some incontrovertible sequence: the passage from one stage to the other is instead unconditioned, it happens if it happens, its direction is not deducible from one stage to another; it is an absolute achievement, an achievement, therefore, for which one cannot, but even must not, ask for a further reason.

The material on Anthony is taken from the booklet “Rational Man” by Constantine Cavarinos and is available from the Institute for Byzantine and Modern Greek Studies¹⁸.

Posted on 2010-12-02 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2010-12-02 at 12:21 said:

Would it be valid to say that Anthony's notion of the divine rational faculty being present in man in essence but not necessarily in existence is in the same spirit as Evola's (and in the wider context of Tradition) view that the Self is present in essence but not existence?

Also, after getting more acquainted with St. Anthony's view of what makes one human and its relation to morality, I now further understand your comment modern day Christians being hesitant to include his writings in current translations of the Philokalia.

GF on 2010-12-09 at 00:08 said:

So the true moral project is the struggle to make oneself exist, or in religious language, to heal the soul. Can we perhaps see 'civic virtue' as a corresponding exoterism?

Cologero on 2010-12-10 at 07:39 said:

Yes, that was the point of the juxtaposition, to demonstrate the compatibility of Anthony with Tradition. We always need to avoid being distracted by the theology and dig down to the underlying metaphysical, or esoteric, core. I've been told by someone who has been involved

¹⁸<http://www.ibmgs.org/>

with esoterism and mysteries for over 50 years that the Coptic religion (Anthony was Egyptian) is a Christian veneer over the ancient pharaonic religion. I have no way to verify that, as interesting as it sounds. (The Coptic language is based on ancient Egyptian.)

Cologero on 2010-12-10 at 07:43 said:

Exactly, if “heal” means “make whole”. Not ‘civic virtue’ if you mean an external code of conduct that “I” must follow. But yes, if on the lines of synarchy, such as described in *The City of the Sun*.

Matt on 2010-12-10 at 10:49 said:

Cologero,

Yes that is really interesting. If thats the case, Coptic initiates achieved what the Templars and Hermeticists ultimately failed to do with the catholic church.

4.13 Gleanings about the Field of Pearls

I have been reading *The Way of a Pilgrim*, recently, which is a Russian peasant’s account of his discovery of the prayer of the heart. The anonymous author had lost his father and wife to an illness, and been dispossessed by a worthless brother, who had also crippled him when they were younger. Henceforth, the man becomes a beggar, and then, after hearing in Church St. Paul’s admonition to “pray without ceasing”, a pilgrim to discover what the inner or hidden meaning of this was.

Somehow, he obtains a copy of the *Philokalia*, and literally learns it by heart from reading it every day. Additionally, his old *starets* sometimes appears to him in a dream, and offers him guidance, not only spiritual but even to face physical challenges, such as curing an old woman who has been kind to the pilgrim.

“It costs nothing but the effort to sink down in silence into the depths of



one's heart and call more and more upon the radiant name of Jesus. Everyone who does that feels at once the inward light, everything becomes understandable to him, he even catches sight in this light of some of the mysteries of the kingdom of God. And what depth and light there is in the mystery of a man coming to know that he has this power to plumb the depths of his own being, to see himself from within, to find delight in self-knowledge, to take pity on himself and shed tears of gladness over his fall and his spoiled will!"

It should be instantly apparent to the unbiased reader (whomever they may desire to appear to themselves) that here we have no "life-denying" or purely passive "asceticism. On the contrary, this is spoken of as an active power corresponding to the alchemical stage of *rubedo*. You see that they are spoken of as "tears of gladness".

There is no doubt that "Semitic" spirituality in a purely "exoteric" sense has included many "life-denying" elements in propagating what appeared to it to be truths. However, we need to make a point that the division exoteric-esoteric is itself part of the problem (as Cologero has alluded to). It is to think in terms of division, separation. Well, this is the problem to begin with! Because "esotericism" departs (or is corrupted), the "exoteric" shell attempts to preserve "Christendom" inside of formulations from which Life has departed. Likewise, esotericism without exoteric landmarks can be dark paths indeed. The thing is to unite the two! *Or, rather, to see that they are already One.*

The pilgrim refers to the Almighty as the "*merciful and man-loving God*". This will be too "materialistic" or even "humanistic" for Gnostics, just as the Virgin Mary has always scandalized certain highly spiritual individuals (St. Francis designed the manger creche to confound them).

"Everyone does what he can, as he sees his own path, with the thought that God himself shows the way of his salvation." This will be not rigid

enough for the Pharisees in Christendom, who wish everything to be “made clear”.

“The mysterious sighing of creation, the innate aspiration of every soul toward God, that is exactly what interior prayer is. There is no need to learn it, it is innate in every one of us.” This will irritate the Protestants (who hate Nature) & those who wish (like General Namaan) for mightier tasks than bathing in the Jordan to cure their leprosy.

The volume is not the work of a saint or scholar, but a peasant, who comes to know God through “the Jesus prayer” of hesychasm (which interestingly enough, receives various emphasis or stresses on its syllables, according to the inner spiritual gift of the person praying the prayer). The *starets* comes to him in a dream, and even points out which portions of the *Philokalia* to read first, and in what order.

As we wander through the desert of Modernity, a pithy man¹⁹ points out that even in God’s “separation” from the modern world, the spiritual man ought to begin to learn to discern signs of His presence, for He can never be finally absent. No decayed corpus of Christendom can prove the lack of His, the Lord’s, power. No collapse of the West can prove that, after all, God is mocked. The Supreme Lord will not be mocked, no matter how large scale the rebellion is, nor does His mercy fail even in the dark.

I think a reader here recommended (for which I thank him) *The Three Conversions of the Spiritual Life*, by Garrigou-Lagrange, OP, which my wife bought me for father’s day. There is little doubt that out of the “wreckage” we can salvage, not merely “much”, or even “all” that we need, but abundantly more so. God has littered the landscape with many treasures, and books such as these testify to an inner heart of Christianity which has existed even during the seemingly dead days of being buried under ground. In fact, since the heart is alive, the body remains as well – not the body the Pharisees promulgate, but the body of the Lord. For

¹⁹<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=6491>

instance, Garrigou-Lagrange distinguishes, in direct and explicit parallel to Dionysius' tradition, the three inner stages of purgation, illumination, and union, and what happens when one gets stuck along the way, in between one of the stages. Are any readers here stuck in a spiritual stage they do not understand? He goes on to explain that God the All-Merciful converts a man where he is at. This, by the way, is why the conversion begins in the senses, and doesn't include the soul or spirit to begin with: God isn't going to make someone enlightened against their will! He begins with the beginning stage. When they are purged as to senses, then a purgation of the soul commences, but is "illuminated" in this more difficult stage: the person now loves not only with the heart, but with strength. The last conversion is a movement into spirit, in which God is loved with the "soul" (spirit), and finally attains intellectual and perfect and near-continuous (at least) union with God.

As one can see, this involves a "taking up" of each lower part into a higher part, along with a move of consciousness to the higher plane. From the "sensual" plane, soul and spirit are one. Only from the soul plane does one even begin to intuit that there are higher regions still. And what comes after this? The Self Beyond the Self?

Look about you, if not in your tradition, then some tradition fit for you. Seek it, and find it: you will seek what you find anyway. It is ultimately not a concept or even an "ideal" (although it certainly will make use of both along the way), but a path which you already know, as the Russian peasant pilgrim already knew, when he set out on his journey, that he would find his Lord.

By the way, if you have fallen, a repentance equal or greater in fervor than the sin which was committed will re-instate your "talents" and place you back upon the Ladder. The thing is to climb.

Posted on 2013-06-21 by Logres

* * *

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-22 at 11:15 said:

Logres do you think there is a difference between the western spirituality of a Gerrigou-Lagrange and the eastern hesychasts ? I want to resolve for myself once and for all whether Christian spirituality is one, uniting west and east, or if the cultural divide between western Christianity and the eastern church is too great akin to say Christianity and Hinduism.

Scardanelli on 2013-06-22 at 11:35 said:

For more on the three stages of spiritual path from the Orthodox perspective, there is an excellent series by Archimandrite Zacharius: The Enlargement of the Heart, The Hidden Man of the Heart, and Remember Thy First Love. I've only begun reading the first, but in skimming through all of them they seem quite good.

Scardanelli on 2013-06-22 at 11:40 said:

...And you're a lucky man Logres. All I got for Father's Day was a shirt and tie.

Logres on 2013-06-22 at 22:55 said:

Scardanelli, thank you for those recommendations; a huge part of what we are to be about (at this stage) is sharing interests and reading lists – things that would be normative under different conditions. I think it was Jason-Adam who recommended Lagrange, and I am pleased to have read it. I thank you in advance, as I am sure you have steered me well!

Jason-Adam: I have given a lot of restless and restful thought to this, and with the proviso that I defer to any one with higher knowledge, I am bound to say (especially after leafing through Scupoli and reading Lagrange, as well as what I remember from Thomas Merton's commentaries and excerpts on John of the Cross) that the Catholic mystical tradition is substantially identical to what one would find in Orthodoxy. Even making allowances for Romanides' criticisms (and you won't find any stronger critic, unless it was Athanasios Bailey's website @ Orchid Land Publications (now defunct, on the web, although you may be able to dredge archives), the mystical theology of both teach the same truth. I think it might help you to experientially realize that (like Iamblichus and Plotinus, in a way) there is a common "source" (even though it can't be perceived mentally, it can be intuited, although someone who had attained mystical Union would be able to perceive it mentally, as this is the last stage). If you are a warrior, then your recognition of this commonality will be tempered by a healthy preference for one or the other, and a suspicion for the other, although even this should not keep you from affirming certain elements. Christianity is a "warrior religion" in many ways: the Vedic side is carefully hidden, whether deliberately or not, & so like Islam (but to a much lesser extent) Christianity has been a marching and embattled faith, which tends to draw strong lines. You can see the Orthodox fall into a perspective of embattled and reactionary thought, at times, when they begin to denigrate everything Western, because it is "Western". While this may be a good attitude and

stance at times and places (and the warriors will help decide when this is), it cannot be the final word. Even an Orthodox theologian like Evdokimov goes so far as to suggest that there are undiscovered sacraments which God's grace has yet to reveal. since it is infinite. Perhaps one of them will be the reunion of the Church, who knows? That is why it's a blessing to be alive right now. Some of this is sketched in the "Church of John", "Church of Peter", "Church of Paul" outline given by Tomberg and others. Meanwhile, Meanwhile, it's no shame and a great help to "wake up" to the various dangers and departures within the Tradition – my guess is that Orthodoxy has many of its own. The Church is indefectible, not perfect.

Jason-Adam on 2013-06-24 at 13:00 said:

@ Logres, I agree with you that essential Catholic and Orthodox mysticism takes you to the same place while using different language, which is why I do not agree with the Orthodox minds of a Romanides or a Dugin who see only evil in the Western church. My approach to spirituality is indeed affected by my warrior calling, which causes me to be partial to my own ancestors and heritage and as such I just find myself not fitting in with non-Western forms, even though I do admire from afar those forms. When it comes to relations between the churches, I accept Soloviev's two lung thesis from Russia & the Universal Church which is why I oppose deeply people like Dugin who try to widen the schism between east and west and also those westerners who think being traditional means hating yourself, your family and your culture.

Logres on 2013-06-24 at 14:52 said:

@ Jason-Adam. It's interesting that the Philokalia recommends "anger" directed at one's sin and demonic influence in the soul, whereas Gurdjieff/Ousepensky seem to imply that anger serves no useful purpose. One of the Church Fathers, Gregory or some such, indicated that anger heightens power if it is employed properly. Now, words mean different things to different kinds of people, so perhaps anger is being used in various senses, and there is a way of reconciliation. Still, even the Steiner crowd wrestled with Eastern differences: everyone sees the difference, but perhaps not accurately, and there is trouble interpreting what this means. Are we just different modes of one Truth? I tend to think it is more than merely a "mode" difference. Something is being gained/lost on either side. Perhaps as each perfects their own Tradition, we shall see more clearly how they are, and can be, One? I would like to go through The Cloud of Unknowing, at some point, and compare to the Philokalia.

Cologero on 2013-06-25 at 00:34 said:

Evagrius, from the Philokalia:

Our anger contributes very much to the aim of demons when it is active
in a way that is contrary to nature, and it becomes more useful for all

their evil arts. Therefore none of them ceases exciting it both at night and in daytime. But when they see it bound by meekness, they unloose it by means of plausible pretexts, so that having become exceedingly sharp it might serve their ferocious thoughts. Therefore, it is necessary to avoid exciting anger, whether for just of unjust ends.

The word translated as anger is actually *thymos*, i.e., spiritedness or the irascible appetite. Now, Evagrius is a solitary monk and is speaking to monks.

Thomas Aquinas defines wrath as "the spiritual strength to attack the repugnant". In this case, it is not an irrational emotion set aflame by demons, but rather an inner power that is in the service of the good and the true. Peter Chojnowski in his booklet "Flesh of my Flesh" has a chapter on this topic, particularly as it relates to men in the modern world. Because of the ideals of "tolerance" and "niceness"

anger is kept from its normal release in the rectification of that which is disordered. When normal release in acts of ordering are forbidden due to a legal and juridical preoccupation with rights and tolerance, you have personal and social explosion waiting to happen. ... to prevent a man from expressing in any way his repulsion to the disorderly, the perverted, the obnoxious, the dishonorable, is to invite and even ensure the engendering of psychological frustration which can only manifest itself in violent rage

St John Chrysostom: "He who is not angry, whereas he has cause to be sins. For unreasonable patience is the hotbed of many vices, it fosters negligence, and incites not only the wicked but even the good to do wrong."

Logres on 2013-06-25 at 11:44 said:

@ Cologero: I remembered last night that Ousepensky did have a passage which indicated that "anger at self" was a way to channel anger to where it needed to go, so I think, on reconsideration, there are two meanings of "anger" here (which of course the Church Fathers warn happens in many Bible verses/contexts, rendering Scripture not perspicacious as Protestants assumed it to be).

4.14 The Image and Likeness

When this thought or contemplation visits the inner temple of our spirit, this is filled with the light and majesty of God. The spirit's rapture then is indescribable. All its bones, that is, all the smallest moving parts of its being, give an irrepressible leap of deep inward joy.

BISHOP THEOPHAN THE RECLUSE

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God.

Mt 5:8

It is said that man is created in the image and likeness of God. Although the West tends to conflate the two terms, that is not quite correct esoterically. In what follows, please refer to the schema 4.14.

	Exoteric Teaching	Esoteric Teaching	Source	Reality
Image	Intellect and Will	Real I and True Will	Intrinsic	Virtual
Likeness	Grace	Transcendent influences	Acquired	Actual

Table 4.2: Image and likeness

The image of God can only be perfected in a purified consciousness, freed of lower influences, by the action of Grace. "Pop" religion today regards the "image and likeness" as a *fait accompli*, asserting a certain dignity on those. However, the image of God in man is only virtual and needs to be actualized. That is the "likeness" of God, the process by which man becomes more god-like, or theosis. He becomes a "son of God", which means sharing in the same nature. To become such a son by adoption is a privilege and is not at all universal. Pop religion, on the other hand, claims that everyone is a "child of god" no matter what. The opposite

misconception is that God is “totally other” to man. While that may be true for profane man, it is not so for those in communion with God.

Now, following the Greek Fathers, the Eastern Church²⁰ has been clearer about making this distinction. The failure to take this into consideration often leads to mischief in social policies.

The Image of God So, to summarize, the “image” is what we are born with, but it is as yet only virtual. As the image of God, man has intelligence and free will. Of course, that is the higher intellect, not just discursive thought. This higher intellect is called the “heart” in Tradition. When the heart is purified, that is, purged of the distorting effects of negative emotions, disordered desires, and false doctrines, then the image of God will be more perfectly reflected in one’s consciousness. In that state, one is “pure of heart”.

The Likeness of God As one overcomes the lure of the lower influences, one becomes open to “grace”, or transcendent influences. One’s nature changes to become more God-like. One is given the gift of understanding. One’s will becomes free, since it is not being driven by external forces. One hungers for impartial justice and so on. One becomes passionless and free of useless sentiment. Nevertheless, there can be the experience of great joy, as Theophan describes, and even flights of ecstasy.

Pop religion presumes we are by birth children of God. Misleadingly, they take this from John as an indication:

That was the true light, which enlightens every man that comes into this world. (John 1:9)

As such, it appears universal, however that is immediately followed by:

²⁰<http://www.stgeorgeserbian.us/darren/darren03.htm>

He was in the world, and the world was made by him, and the world knew him not. He came unto his own, and his own received him not. But as many as received him, he gave them power to be made the sons of God, to them that believe in his name. Who are born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God. (John 1:10-13)

But that is not the case; we see only the “second birth” makes one “born of God” which can only come from the acceptance of the “true light”. In Tradition, to be “born of God” means to share the same nature, just as the son shares the nature of the father, i.e., he is a “chip off the old block”. The pop religion, on the other hand, interprets the phrase as referring to perpetual infantilism.

Hermetic Teaching Valentin Tomberg in his *Meditations* teaches that the image and likeness of God refers to the human personality. He contrasts that with Oriental systems which lead to a depersonalization, which he rejects. Tomberg is following the Eastern Church in recognizing that growing in the image and likeness of God is actually a process of humanization, of becoming “truly human”, a fuller “realization of true human nature”. In effect, he has “more being” than he did before.

This is an alchemical process. As such, it transforms the base human into the image and likeness of God through “sublimation”. In Hermetic initiation, one penetrates into the depths of consciousness to awaken to the primordial Adamic state of the image and likeness.

While the contemporary *Catechism of the Catholic Church* shows the loss of any understanding of the distinction between the image and likeness, that was not also the case of the Nordic-Roman Medieval Tradition, which, like the East, had not forgotten that doctrine. Quoting **St Bernard**, Tomberg shows how the image and likeness separated after the Fall of Adam and the forgetting of the Primordial State. Bernard claims that while the image of God remains in man, the likeness has been lost

“in the soul which sins”. As he wrote in Sermon on the Annunciation of the Blessed Virgin Mary:

Man was made in the image and likeness of God: in image he possesses freedom of will, and in likeness he possesses virtues. The likeness has been destroyed; however, man conserves the image. The image can be burnt in hell, but not consumed. It is damaged but not destroyed. Through fate as such it is not effaced, but subsists. Wherever the soul is, there also will be the image. It is not so with the likeness. This remains in the soul which accomplishes the good; in the soul which sins it is wretchedly transformed. The soul which has sinned ranks with beasts devoid of intelligence.

The consequence is that man is “free”, perpetually free through eternity. The likeness, however, is not essentially immortal. The Holy Guardian Angel acts to preserve the likeness that has been lost in man.

Misconceptions Distortions arise because of the lack of understanding about the distinction between the image and likeness. In particular, new age and liberal theory more or less adopt the notions of the “image and likeness” as well as the universalization of the “children of god”. For example, if the image of God is actual rather than virtual at birth, then it would follow that one’s weakness, faults, and foibles are in reality God-given attributes of one’s personality or nature. This is a reversion to pantheistic paganism as we showed in *Esoteric Stoicism*²¹. Specifically, one’s “presuppositions” are seen as God given, while in the Christian view such presuppositions need to be examined and tested.

Social Policy You will be hearing in the coming month about the “option for the poor”. It is said that there is an inherent “dignity of man” (i.e., worthy of respect) due to his being in the “image and likeness of

²¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8147>

God". Of course, we treat everyone with the respect due him as a matter of justice. Even if a man has lost the likeness of God, "every sinner has a future" (Augustine). Similarly, the unborn is also due justice, even if his being is still virtual.

In economic policies, there is a religious left that makes common cause with the secular left. On a certain level, this is quite strange. The religious left bases its program on man as being in the image of God and a descendant of God. The secular left, on the other hand, regards man as a material being and a descendant of monkeys. When two incompatible premises lead to the same conclusion, then, by Occam's razor, one is justified in accepting the simpler premise, which is the secular worldview. Hence, the religious left tends over time to get sucked into the secular, material view.

Now, economic solutions are not as simple as many want to believe. There are several alternatives, not necessarily incompatible with each other, to provide for the material needs of the poor. Moreover, the option for the poor should include cultural and spiritual components. This is where the secular worldview falls short, since only economic and material considerations matter. And the religious left, but accepting *de facto* the secular premise, becomes impotent.

By failing to recognize that the loss of the "likeness of God" has been lost (due to faulty understanding), the religious left has no solution to the cultural and spiritual issues. The secular left promotes contempt for religion, sexual license, drug use, gun violence, and so on. While in their personal lives, they are usually less affected by the consequences of that worldview, that is not true of the poorer elements which have fewer options. The religious left seems to say nothing about that.

Postscript This is not to say that the religious right has much better to offer. By glorifying capitalism and perpetual war, they create more problems than they solve. Even if they are marginally better on cultural

and spiritual issues, there is a disturbingly mixed message.

At a recent protest of a Planned Parenthood clinic, the Evangelicals were yelling through a megaphone, presumably to harass the women. I don't know if they checked first to determine if a woman was there due to incest or rape. In another section the Catholics gathered to say the Rosary. The Evangelicals then turned the megaphone onto the Catholics admonishing them "not to worship Mary." Is there any wonder why the educated left regards the right as unhinged?

Posted on 2015-08-31 by Cologero

* * *

Br. Giles Mary on 2015-09-07 at 16:26 said:

As a quasi-celibate (I say quasi because our community is normal in the Church but not yet a canonical "religious institute" not as if I only practice celibacy occasionally. Gospel purity of heart is of course another matter altogether...) I would like to add my two cents... The Christian celibate, at least, is not consciously transforming raw sexual energy (at least none that I know of) like a practitioner of tantra (I don't think you implied as much, but I only say it for context.) The goal is rather a transformation of vision.

Christopher West has made a name for himself in the mainstream by popularizing John Paul II's "Theology of the Body" catecheses. He well makes the point that consecrated celibacy is ideally not like caging a lion. In fact, perhaps things are different in your country, but in America puritanical vision of sex has deep roots and is a major cause of much of our sexual distortion. It seems to be the mainstream wisdom of the Church that the attempt to cage the lion, as you said, is almost certainly doomed to fail. I would like to say a lot more, but I'm short on time. Suffice to say that a full-fledged life decision for a celibate form of life is essential to bearing the proper fruit. Aquinas explains this well in the Summa Theologica. Also, speaking from my own experience, as a sort of quasi-celibate I don't engage in any sexual activity and try to diminish and avoid impure phantasies, but my being is more sexual than ever. Although we're not given in marriage in the Kingdom, nonetheless we are created male and female. There are relevant metaphysical topics regarding nature and grace that would also be interesting...

Also, to the broader thread... We pray at abortion clinics and try to counsel women. I've had some of the most profound and thoroughly dry-unspectacular spiritual experiences there. There is a definite difference between the typically protestant and catholic approaches. It probably has to do, on the one hand, with protestant notions of imputed grace, in contrast to a catholic

renovation of the soul. Many can't see beyond their troubled consciences and feel the need to draw some sharp moral lines. It's a self-serving tendency...

Alistair Fraser on 2015-09-07 at 17:46 said:

just wanted to tidy up my last paragraph from earlierwhich leads to the shortening of any romance to the physical by the so called sex addict, they crave the physical orgasmic sensation in conjunction with this discombobulated aftermath reset of thoughts ,which sort of short cuts them out of their depressive cycle and then they get to do it all over againbut with the descent into addiction, the thoughts lessen and stagnate, the depression increases and the physical sensation lessens , and just like the gambler and cocaine addict , they keep believing , next time it will be different , Wake up time or deterioration into the abyss.

BR. GILES MARY – your input is valued in extending the understandings , , the puritanical is also over this side, but maybe not so fanatical as over your way in today's times .

you stated "but my being is more sexual than ever." which is an interesting expression in the celibate status , do you feel that you contain a certain "contained" vitality or some extra energy as a result of the celibacy and cerebral vision you are committed too ?

Br. Giles Mary on 2015-09-14 at 16:07 said:

Alistair,

" do you feel that you contain a certain "contained" vitality or some extra energy as a result of the celibacy and cerebral vision you are committed too ?"

It's something like this. Certain potentialities of the soul are indeed freed up or activated in this form of life, for sure. An important point that I have to remind even myself of is that we can go too far in conceiving these things as extrinsic to our soul/body composite.

"We are our bodies..." is, I believe, one of the phases Saint John Paul II drew from the tradition for his Theology of the Body catecheses. He also uses some phrase about our basic psychosomatic makeup in Love and Responsibility. This is a typically Aristotelian notion rather than Platonic, which the Church has pretty well invested herself into. The soul is the form of the body rather than something extrinsic to it.

So, we even speak of spiritual progress in terms of growth into an integral and perfect human being. Perhaps, at first, it sounds quaint and modern. But, having grown up as a thoroughly truncated modern man, I'm often discovering anew what this means. So, if we're created male and female, and not destined to leave that behind, I think it follows that we express our sexual differentiation with greater depth and clarity the closer we get to beatitude. Besides, who in their right mind would want to become less a man? It's all about Christ and his Bride. Maybe in response, somebody wants to evoke the Adamic-androgyne or something... Anywho...

Glory to God and Thanks for the discussion.

4.15 Seven Gifts of the Holy Spirit

Esoteric science in its teaching goes far beyond simple information. Its purpose, in fact, is nothing less than the transformation of the very being of those who study it

BORIS MOURAVIEFF

We can represent the Fallen World, i.e., the world in which mankind determines what is right and wrong, true and false, as a closed vector space, in which each vector represents an idea or meme. Depending then on your specific position in the space, you will be subjected to various idea vectors of different strengths and directions, randomly with no fixed pattern. Hence, there is no true standard of right and wrong, just various forces acting on your mind. Most of the inhabitants of this world accept it as it is, while convincing themselves that their particular vectors are somehow truer than other vectors. We can refer to these as the A influences.

Since that can never be more than a war of all against all, we can ask if the world process is truly closed.

If the world process is not closed, then higher influences can enter into it. Specifically, there are the B influences that come from valid (or formerly valid) traditions. Unlike the A influences, the B influences all have the same direction. Furthermore, there are even higher influences such as esoteric teachings and even angelic (or planetary) influences. It is possible to become attuned to such higher influences in order to escape the influences of the world process. The highest of such influences will come from the Holy Spirit.

The Reformation denied such higher influences, which are expressed in symbolic form, and asserted that only the literally physical and historical interpretations of scriptures are valid. They also denied the authority of philosophy and metaphysics. This worldview is not something to debate; the real problem is that at that time after the Medieval period, fewer

men were able to even understand the more ancient esoteric and symbolic understanding of religion. That is, they could perhaps grasp the B influences, but not the C or higher influences. Ultimately, physics and history, profane sciences which deal solely with the A influences, became the sole source of authority. The esoteric sciences were forgotten or driven underground.

The Seven Gifts The seven gifts of the Holy Spirit are given (or at least strengthened) in Confirmation. Unfortunately, in most cases these gifts are ineffectual, and are hardly known. Hence they remain virtual, not fully actualized. In addition, over time the meaning of words often change. So it is worth the trouble to understand how certain concepts were used in Medieval Christendom. English is inadequate as a language for metaphysics, so we will sometimes resort to the Latin or Greek equivalents for clarity.

First of all, these are the gifts of the Holy Spirit:

- Wisdom (Sophia)
- Intelligence (intellectus, nous)
- Counsel
- Strength
- Knowledge (gnosis)
- Piety
- Fear of God

These gifts require a period of purification in order to become fully active. Few today are willing to, and often do not even how to, engage in that process of purification.

Wisdom We have addressed the topic of Wisdom, Sophia, Chokmah, have been often addressed. For a good description of Sophia, especially how it was described by **Vladimir Solovyov**, please visit *The Immaculate Conception and the Divine Sophia*²².

Intelligence According to St. Anthony, only the rational man is in union with God (or Nous in Platonic or Aristotelian terms), and reason is not at all common to all men. The rational faculty unites man with divine power, power over oneself, one's thoughts, one's acts. As such, it is a faculty that must be developed²³.

Man is dominated by three psychic forces: eros (desire, concupiscence), thymos (spiritedness, emotion), and nous (intellect). Most people determine their goals based on desire and emotion. The intellect merely serves an instrumental function, i.e., it determines the means to reach the goals defined by eros and thymos.

However, real intelligence needs to determine man's proper ends or goals, not just the means. This gift of the Holy Spirit enables us to choose our proper goals based on intelligence, rather than on concupiscence or emotion.

Counsel Natural willing designates the movement of a creature in accordance with the principle (*logos*) of its nature towards the fulfilment (*telos, stasis*) of its being. (Wikipedia)

Gnomic will, on the other hand, requires a process of deliberation and decision making. It is therefore dualistic, dual in the evil sense described by **Valentin Tomberg**. If purity of heart is to will one thing, then our very being will spontaneously (NOT impulsively) choose its proper

²²<https://crc-internet.org/our-doctrine/national-restoration/holy-russia/the-immaculate-conception-and-the-divine-sophia.html?r=soloviev>

²³*Rational Man and Moral Law*, see Section 4.12.

end. Specifically, if we rely on the Counsel of the Holy Spirit, rather than on our own Will, we will gain the power to fulfill our purposes in life.

Strength The concept of Strength is that of an intermediary between pure consciousness and manifestation. It is the link between the idea and the phenomenon²⁴.

The rational man is not just a learned man or scholar, but rather someone who not only knows good from bad, but also has the power to act on it. There are three faults that beset man from the Fall: concupiscence, ignorance, malice. This is not an abstract dogma, but something that is readily observable, both in our own selves and certainly in other people. As we pointed out in *Space Aliens, Pigs, Roosters, and Snakes*²⁵, even the Buddhists became aware of these faults, although they did not know exactly how they arose.

One of the obstacles of the spiritual life is that even when we become aware of these faults within us, we still find it difficult to overcome them. Weakness, then, is the fourth fault which prevents us from doing what we need to do.

Hence, the Holy Spirit gives us the Strength to overcome the faults arising from the Fall.

Knowledge There are three levels of knowledge: doxa, dianoia, episteme. Doxa is opinion, or knowledge of sensory things. Dianoia refers to logical, hypothetical, speculative, scholarly, and argumentative knowledge, while episteme is direct, intuitive knowledge of spiritual things.

Intelligent people are seldom able to surpass dianoia. They think that everything is open to debate or that the next book will reveal the secret. They often know the writings of Saints and Mystics, yet don't bother to achieve the higher states of those saints.

²⁴Letter XI from *Meditations on the Tarot*.

²⁵<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=9647>

The knowledge, i.e., gnosis, that results from episteme is of a totally different order. It is direct and certain. Episteme does not have a natural source, but rather is a Gift of the Holy Spirit.

Piety The cause of the Fall was the desire to follow one's own desires rather than to be obedient to God's Will. This Gift of the Holy Spirit overcomes the Fall and inspires us to obedience. We learn to love to serve God's will.

We find it easier. And faith becomes stronger. No longer are we confused about dogmas, especially when we notice the strange beliefs of irreligious moderns.

Fear of God

This moral instrument is moulded to fit the traditions of milieu and family. It is shaped from birth onwards by education. Clearly, without this instrument, the organization of social life in all its forms is unthinkable. Yet because of its nature, it cannot guarantee good and equitable human conduct; to ensure its own existence in times of peace, human society has always been obliged to have recourse to constraint and the application of penalties: necessary remedies, since morality will never be strong enough to curb the extreme and anarchistic tendencies of the Personality. The latter, in effect, lacks that kind of consciousness that the practical studies of religion describe as the fear of God.

BORIS MOURAVIEFF

Even if the Fear of God is an imperfect motivation to do God's Will, it is certainly praiseworthy. It leads to repentance and the desire to improve. Most of those stuck in the world process fear the government or social disapproval rather than God; they then seldom seek to improve. That is man's natural condition, therefore this is a great Gift of the Holy Spirit.

But God knows best.

Posted on 2019-12-06 by Cologero

* * *

S.P on 2020-08-09 at 21:47 said:

Since you mention the dogmas, how should we understand them in relation to a Primordial Tradition? If the Church demands the belief that outside of it there is no salvation, at the risk of mortal sin, how to reconcile this with the acceptance of other religions and a Primordial Tradition? Is such a dogma a mere necessity for orthodoxy to protect itself from corruption?

PS: I'm sorry for the possible bad English.

Cologero on 2020-09-11 at 16:42 said:

Obviously, there was a Primordial Tradition, known to Noah, who would have passed it on, right up to Abram. When the nations were scattered after Babel, the various religions were created. No one is predestined to hell (also a dogma), therefore, as Augustine asserts, everyone is given what he needs for salvation. (The details are not for us to know.) Moreover, as Augustine asserts, there is but One Tradition, now known as Catholicism.

This ends the discussion.

S.P. on 2020-09-11 at 20:52 said:

Well, thanks for the reply, Cologero. I suppose it relates to the conception of a primordial monotheism already discussed earlier.

A few months ago, through reading, I obtained a particular state of inspiration, which I attribute (without going too deep) to the Holy Spirit. It is a very curious experience, there is a feeling of lightness and clarity of mind, and a natural disposition (if the term is allowed) towards the Transcendent. Unfortunately, human weakness is very efficient. Of course, you have what you deserve.

4.16 Length, Breadth, Height, Depth

That you, being rooted and grounded in love, may have power to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and to know the love of Christ which surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled with all the fullness of God.

EPHESIANS 3:14-19

Quaternity Saint Bernard mentions this quaternity, but it does not imply any division in the One. Rather, they show the different paths to the One. We shall ultimately see God face to face, and see him as he is. But in this life, as he points out, the search continues. The quaternity helps us to comprehend – not to “know”.

Length Length represents eternity, which has no end in place or time. It is God as Infinite, the source of all possibilities.

Breadth

For thou lovest all things that are, and hatest none of the things which thou hast made.

WISDOM 11:25

Sun rises upon the good and the wicked, and rain falls upon the just and the unjust.

MATTHEW 5:45

Breadth is God’s love, which has no boundaries. Breadth extends throughout the world process because God loves what He created.

Height Height means that God is above all. This is God as the Absolute, as Power, omnipotence.

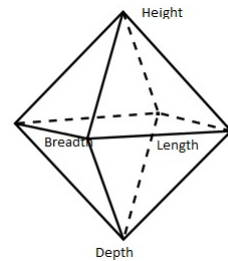


Figure 4.2:
Quaternity

Depth Depth signifies that God is within. As such, God is Wisdom, Intelligence, Judgment.

Contemplation

Discursive thought is satisfied when it arrives at a well-founded conclusion. Now, this conclusion is the point of departure for contemplation. It fathoms the profundity of this conclusion at which discursive thought arrives. Contemplation discovers a world within, which discursive thought simply verifies as “true”.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Knowing these attributes through reason is not the same as comprehension. To comprehend, one must first become holy. Then you will know from your own experience. **Holy love** and **holy fear** make a man holy. Fear responds to the height and depth; love to the length and breadth. Teachings, and there are many in our day, that neglect one or the other will not lead to comprehension; worse, they lead to incomprehension. Love without Fear is vapid; Fear without Love is heartless.

Love that includes perseverance and long-suffering is the length. Love extended to enemies is the breadth.

Fear of God’s irresistible power is the height. Fear of God’s wisdom and judgment is depth.

But to us God hath revealed them, by this Spirit. For the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God.

1 CORINTHIANS 2:10

To comprehend the deep things of God requires more than knowing the truth.

[Contemplation] becomes active when it is a question of something deeper than the question: Is it true or false? It perceives more the **significance** of the truth discovered by discursive thought and also why this truth is true in itself, i.e. it reaches to the mystical or essential source of this truth. How does it arrive at this? By listening in silence. It is as if one wanted to recall something forgotten.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

A fact penetrates the soul when it has meaning, otherwise its truth is irrelevant to life.

Psychological truths are not metaphysical insights; they are habitual modes of thinking, feeling, and behaving which experience has proved appropriate and useful. So when I say that the impulses which we find in ourselves should be understood as the “will of God,” I wish to emphasize that they ought not to be regarded as an arbitrary wishing and willing, but as absolutes which one must learn how to handle correctly.

CARL JUNG, *Aion*

Thus, as Saint Bernard tells us, the revelation of length, breadth, height, and depth as true is incomplete. Jung explains why this is so psychologically:

the psychic phenomenon cannot be grasped in its totality by the intellect, for it consists not only of *meaning* but also of *value*, and this depends on the intensity of the accompanying feeling-tones.

Reason can describe the meaning of the quaternity, but holy love and fear are necessary to reveal its value. On the personal level, there are four attributes corresponding to the divine four:

- **Marvel** at the height of majesty
- **Fear** the abyss of judgment
- **Burn** with the fire of love
- **Endure** with perseverance

Saint Bernard then describes four modes of contemplation associated with the dimensions of the quaternity.

Wonder at Majesty The first and greatest is to wonder at the majesty of God. This demands a purified heart that is freed from vices and released from sin. Then it can ascend easily to heavenly things. Sometimes the contemplative can be rapt in amazement and ecstasy, even if only for a moment.

This is associated with height.

Judgment of God The contemplation on God's judgment may strike fear to outsiders because it is indeed frightening. Yet it drives out vices, strengthens virtues, initiates into wisdom, protects humility. Humility is the foundation of virtue.

This is associated with depth.

Remember Kindnesses Remember with gratitude the kindnesses and graces received from God. This is a reminder to love God always.

This is associated with width.

Endurance

one thing I do, forgetting what lies behind and straining forward
to what lies ahead

PHIL 3:18

Forget what is past and contemplate the expectation of what is promised. This nourishes patience and promotes perseverance. What is promised is eternal.

This is associated with length.

The Beginning of the Search Saint Bernard recommends these contemplations to those seeking God. They don't need to be formal or structured or long. You can practice them at any time throughout the day. It might even take a moment, even a passing thought. At the very least, these contemplations are superior to long-winded discussion. As Saint Bernard concludes:

God is sought more worthily and found more easily by prayer
than by discussion.

Acknowledgments: Quotes from Saint Bernard are from the Paulist Press edition of the *Selected Works of Saint Bernard of Clairvaux*.

Tomberg quotes are from *Meditations on the Tarot*, Jung quotes from *Aion*. (emphases are mine)

Posted on 2020-09-13 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2020-09-22 at 00:23 said:

You finally answered the question I asked 5 years ago in your post "Innate Wisdom and Collective Initiation" (<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1721>). The question was, "how does height differ from depth?" 5 years is a lengthy time, but it's not an eternity. I'll remember this kindness.

4.17 To eat of the Tree

The archetypal sin is described in the chapter 3 of the Book of Genesis, every sin being a repetition, or an application to a particular situation of this primal error. This episode has been greatly abused, both by critical rationalists and by “fundamentalists” who refuse to admit anything beyond the literal understanding. Of course, this episode also has a historical, or better yet sacred historical meaning, as the end of the Golden Age of our aeon and the starting point of the gradual decline that followed, but my main purpose here will be to approach it from a microcosmical perspective, from the point of view of the inner constitution of man and his faculties.



In the image and likeness of God Created in the image and likeness of God, man inhabits an intermediate state. He cannot stand on his own, as an independent monad. We will see later what this means.

To be in the image of God is equivalent to saying that man's being is a complete reflection of the being of God. It doesn't mean that a certain part of man is in this Image, but that man as a whole — this includes his primordial body, illustrated by Christ after the Resurrection, as opposed to the opaque body that is the result of the fall — is a mirror of the Absolute. Opened towards the infinite, man has the whole within himself, imparted to him through Grace. **St. Gregory of Nazianz** speaks of this fact: “Man is a creature that was commanded to become god. The image implies man's destiny in godhood”. The likeness, on the other hand, implies that man is to use the attributes which spring from his being (the image of God) to act according to the divine Order. Just as God sustains, with His uncreated energies, the whole cosmos according to a rigorous law, so man is to act upon the nature he has been given to rule, with his attributes, in conformity with sacred principles, and not to some arbitrary

fancy.

St. Gregory Palamas, along with some other philokalic Fathers, says that the fall from the primordial state implied a loss of the likeness with God, while the image, although it was retained and can never be nullified, increasingly obscure and distorted, acquiring more and more a status of a virtuality, no longer fully realized and accessed by fallen humanity. Hence the need for initiation (Baptism) and other sacramental rites that give us the possibility to make the image active once more and, also, to regain the likeness.

The primordial state implied an undifferentiated inner unity in man. Since I intend to write from a microcosmical perspective, the names of “Adam” and “Eve” will be taken in a special way, as symbols of inner faculties of the human being. The birth of Eve from Adam’s rib can be interpreted as the separation of Heaven and Earth, repeated in the microcosm, a first differentiation in the interior constitution of man—remaining, however, unified. In geometrical symbolism, this can be represented by the passing from the circle to the ellipse — a polarization of the center in two complementaries.²⁶

Adam, here, is the fiery part, always in contact with Heaven, while Eve is the humid part, in contact with the earth. Adam is passive in respect to Heaven and active in respect to Eve, while Eve is passive towards Adam, but active towards the earth. Generally speaking, primordial man is passive in relation to God, receiving from him the uncreated energies that sustain his being, and he is active in relation to the earth, passing the uncreated energies received from above, to the realm below, ordering nature according to divine order — as above so below, on Earth, as it is in Heaven. On the inner plane, the intellect rules the desiring faculty and both act in unity. In other words, primordial man knows God in all things and desires nothing but God and the acting of God’s will upon the earth.

²⁶See Rene Guenon: *Symbols of Sacred Science*, Chapter XXXII.

Eve's dependency on Adam is underlined in some of the patristic teachings, that she received the command not to eat from the Tree of Knowledge of good and evil indirectly from Adam, who received it directly from God. Adam, being the ruling principle in man, is responsible for the ordering of the being according to the divine laws, while Eve must act in obedience to these laws and pass them forward towards nature.

Knowledge of good and evil The tree of knowledge of good and evil is a symbol of dualism, of separation. Here is what **St. Maxim the Confessor** has to say regarding it:

Since man came into being made with an intellectual spiritual soul and a body equipped with senses, after a first meaning, the Tree of Life is the intellect, the seat of wisdom, and the Tree of Knowledge of good and evil is the bodily sense, where, clearly, the irrational movement has its beginning. Both trees give the ability to discern between various things. ... The intellect has the ability to discern between the spiritual and the sensual, the eternal and the ephemeral ... while feeling discerns between physical pleasure and pain. (Quoted and translated from the Romanian Philokalia, Maxim's answers to Thalassios).

A Romanian theologian, **Dumitru Staniloae**, adds that the fall implied a break between the various faculties, mankind concentrating much of its efforts on the lower, irrational ones, oscillating between two equally illusory extremes, that fuel each other — those of pleasure and pain:

Man's inclination towards the sensory stirs his pleasure for it, turning all his energy away from the spirit only to what comes under the senses ... he does not give away pleasure as the cause of pain, but turns himself to it in order to get rid of the pain, wrapping himself into an ever thickening vicious circle. (Translated from Romanian, from a book called "The asceticism and mysticism of the Orthodox Church").

The two authors give good and evil a horizontal meaning, as two opposite (but in truth complementary) aspects of an illusory horizontal line. I believe, however, that it could be also interpreted in a relatively vertical way. Good being that which leads back towards unity (or at least keeps one closer to it), while evil is that which deepens the fall, leading further into fragmentation and dissolution. However, neither one can exist without the other. For example: gluttony is evil, fasting good. Gluttony thickens the body which then leads the soul into a stupor, making the access towards the pneumatic faculties impossible. Fasting purifies the body and makes it a suitable support for the spirit. However, there would be no need for fasting were man's body pure, just as medicine is unthinkable for a healthy person. Thus, "good", in this case, is only relative, being actually a necessary evil (from the point of view of matter) meant to repair a greater evil. Primordial man is beyond good and evil, because he knows the true Good (which is plenitude). Fallen man knows good **AND** evil, and can never disconnect them from one-another so the only option available is to transcend them. I think such an interpretation is also echoed in the parable of the prodigal son.

Again, in the words of St Maxim, "the saint extinguishes all opposition within himself". Here is the real doctrine of going beyond good and evil. It is not, as Nietzsche believed it — the destruction of all standards in order to replace them with some arbitrary ones, conceived by a promethean will — but the ultimate conformity with spiritual Reality.

The stages of sin Looking now at the actual occurrence of the primal sin, we see multiple stages of it. The inception comes through the subtle approach of the devil — the centrifugal pseudo-principle of inferior chaos, that opposes divine order and seeks to pull creation into the pulverizing illusion of the outer darkness. "And he said unto the woman, Yea, hath God said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden?" (Gen. 3.1). He approaches Eve, as the principle in man directly in contact with

the earth. The fact that he managed to approach her may also suggest a temporarily negligence on account of the intellect (Adam). In this first stage, the demonic force only attempts to initiate a dialogue with the desiring part of man. Since a dialogue is a series of emissions and receptions, both partners sending and **receiving** ideas from each other, this would imply that Eve will have to enter into relation with these lower forces and receive some influence from them. The fact that she accepts a dialogue immediately makes her temporarily passive towards the inferior regions, leading to a direct suggestion:

And the serpent said unto the woman, Ye shall not surely die: For God doth know that in the day ye eat thereof, then your eyes shall be opened, and ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil.

This is the primal temptation: the illusion of becoming independent from God, of pursuing a self-sufficient existence, completely closed and uninfluenced by anything above.

And when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was pleasant to the eyes.

That is, Eve only considered the fruits according to their most outer appearance, in a sensual manner, severed from their deeper significance, not making any use of the ordering faculty of the intellect and a tree to be desired to make one wise, i.e., a wisdom understood only according to a limited and exterior point of view

she took of the fruit thereof, and did eat, and gave also unto her husband with her; and he did eat.

Eve, the desiring and receptive faculty, by eating of the fruit, became active towards Adam, the intellectual and ordering principle and passive towards the earth and the lower regions. Adam, instead of correcting this

error he participated by approving the indulgences of desire, becoming himself active in relation to God and passive towards Eve. Adam's mistake is graver than Eve's, since Adam is the intellect who has supreme responsibility for the maintaining of the divine order in creation. It is only after he ate that "their (physical) eyes opened". The message is that, even though the sensual part begins to rebel, all is not lost and may be corrected by the rational part who is responsible to keep it in check; but if reason also participates in the act, the point of no return has been passed. This is why the unseen warfare is primarily concerned with the battle over the mind. A parallel of the episode in Genesis can also be found in *Proverbs*, chapter 7:

My husband is not at home, he has gone on a long journey

This means that the rational faculty left the center — the spirit — and concerns itself with the circumference, the external world of appearance; his hands are filled with money meaning that it is unable to act — filled hands — having concerned itself with multiplicity, away from the primordial unity

God's judgement God's judgement upon fallen man is not to be regarded as some legalistic, external punishment. In Genesis, God appears sometimes to directly sentence the fallen couple "I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children" while other times He simply observes the changing of state that man and nature undergo: "cursed the ground for thy sake; in sorrow shalt thou eat of it all the days of thy life".

This should be understood in the light that Divine Justice means to put each and all according to their rightful place and status. When man acts according to illusory purposes, fragmenting the essential unity of creation, he operates a similar fragmentation within himself (because of the analogy that always exists between macrocosm and microcosm),

suffering an ontological degradation, creating a sympathy bond with an inferior level of existence. God sends one to the level that one, of one's own accord, has chosen. Thus, the fact that man became subject to death/demons/disease/decay, is not some external, arbitrary punishment on God's part, but the consequence of man having attached himself to things pertaining to a level of existence where it is possible to be affected by hostile forces. If I make money, for example, the supreme goal of my life, I become attached to them, the standard according to which I measure myself. Since this "standard" is on a level of existence of perpetual becoming and fluctuations I will share its ups and downs, opening myself up to insecurity, fears, hopes, depression etc. If God is also said to condemn us is because, being the supreme Subject, He cannot be an impersonal, passive observer in respect to any process, but is the primary Mover of all things.

There is one last issue to consider before drawing conclusions. Namely the notion of "original sin". It must be said that in the Eastern Church this notion was never accepted as it is proposed in the West. What I mean is that, here, human beings do not "inherit" Adam's guilt. It is just that the degradation of the macrocosm and the inherited traits from one's ancestors make it harder, for descendants born in later times, to understand Reality and access higher faculties without direct divine Revelation and certain Divine-established rites, meant to reawaken the Image in man. This means that, for example, a person born in the Iron Age — the whole period which we call "historical" — does not enter the world with a "stained" soul. It is just that the cosmic conditions in such a time and the physical and psychic elements passed to him from his direct ancestors make him susceptible to develop his inferior possibilities (since all external conditions are right for such), while the Truth is very difficult to be discovered without external aid. He may attain the highest summit, but he has to fight his way to it; but first he must become conscious of his higher calling, which may prove the more difficult. Better put, he is

in a small part actually human, while the largest part of his humanity lies dormant, in a state of virtuality. Of course, each period presents some compensations.

Conclusions After all this, we can conclude that sin is a revolt of the part against the whole, the considering of objects (as well as other beings and persons) independent from their inner purpose, their inner reason for existence. It also implies a misuse of the possibilities of the human being, the employing of human faculties, meant to be directed towards the Infinite, in pursuing illusory, finite objectives, apart or contrary to cosmic order. Using a neoplatonic template, adopted very successfully by Dionysius the Areopagite, the hierarchy of being depends on each given level or degree of existence to be correctly polarized (as showed above)-passive towards the superior level and active towards the inferior. When any being or faculty attempts a schism towards its superiors, the structure collapses, and the being disintegrates, along with all its pretenses.

Sin begins with a diabolical suggestion. When the rational subject is not watchful, his lower nature may enter into dialogue with the suggestion, flirt with it, and slowly come under its influence, especially through the imaginative faculty, at which, we should look at in a different article. After a while, the desiring part will break with the rule of reason and try to pursue the suggestion. If reason does not, through the will, act with firmness, it will begin, slowly, to be dragged into the mire of the irrational soul. The consent of the mind results in the immersion of the entire being in the act.

By consenting to the act, man operates an inversion of polarities within himself. He becomes active in relation to the Sky — meaning that he deliberately refuses the divine energies that sustain his being — and passive in relation to the earth — he is dragged down by inferior influences. As a result of this, man's inner constitution becomes chaotic, disordered, his heart is a battle ground where the unseen warfare takes

place. Externally, he becomes an agent of disorder in nature and his surroundings. Just as the saint, or the superior man in general, who is a medium through which divine energies are manifested, has an ordering and stabilizing effect upon nature and other persons, so the inferior man, ruled by passions, is a tool for infernal energies, having a destructive effect on the surroundings- just consider how it feels when sharing a space with a calm, wise and kind person as opposed to someone who is extremely furious, frustrated, agitated or hateful.

Such is the archetypal sin, which is repeated according to circumstance in all particular situations. The inversion of polarities is the way it is effected. Since man is an intermediate creature, he cannot stand on his own, hanging in midair, in complete neutrality and indifference. He either consciously subjects himself to the influence of Heaven — which keeps him in his place as sovereign and lord of nature, as well as open to the Infinite, to the possibility of godhood- or he rejects Heaven and is dragged down by the gravitational pull of Hell. If man rejects what he has in common with the angels, he loses even what differentiates him from animals, going even lower than them. History — especially sacred history — proves this.

On a more particular scale, it can account for the gradual degeneration that has occurred in western mentality, beginning from the time of the Renaissance, when western man became indifferent towards higher realities, going through the active opposition to them by militant rationalism and immediately falling towards an increasing irrationalism, down to the very bottom of sub-human possibilities; having reached Jung's notion of the collective unconscious and the quasi-religious attitude towards it, it is hard to imagine that man's conception of his being and his faculties of knowledge can fall any lower. But it is a logical conclusion after the part (reason) attempted to become independent of the whole (the intellect, or the heart as a symbol for the spirit). The principle of polarities outlined above explains very well why rationalists are very sharp

in employing reason against the higher realities, but are absolutely powerless in the face of the most degrading irrationalities. Reason, refusing the illumination of the higher, cannot but receive the darkness of the lower.

I will continue, in the future, to address through a more particular approach the notion of “unseen warfare”.

Updated 21 Feb 2021 This was Holy Fool’s last post. He had previously been an enthusiastic supporter and active commenter. He suddenly left without explanation, secretly removing all his posts on the way out. He allowed me to keep this one, provided it is published anonymously.

So much for the warrior ethos of loyalty and integrity.

Posted on 2013-02-21 by Holy Fool

* * *

vivianiprimo on 2020-02-23 at 09:35 said:
Amazing piece of writing, thank you so much!

Lee on 2020-03-23 at 02:59 said:
Ok, this is helpful. Passive in relation to the Divine, active in relation to creation.

Meditations on the Old Testament

5.1 In the Beginning

In the beginning God

Genesis 1:1

God is whatever was at the beginning. For the physicist, that is some ill-defined quantity of energy confined to a vanishingly small space. It is in some sense transcendent because it does not include any of the fundamental particles that define matter; that happens later as the universe begins to cool.

Yet, that inchoate pre-matter contains all the physical laws and fundamental constants that allow the formation of stars, galaxies, planet, life, human beings, and so on. Hence, the physicist is not an atheist, he just does not recognize God.

Revelation Physics can explain atoms, molecules, even crystals, but not a living thing. Living things have structures apart from their physical

and chemical components. No single physical property accounts for life.

But what is structure but its form? So when a metaphysician claims that the soul is the form or the body, that is what is meant. Therefore the form, or the soul, is likewise real.

Human life is inexplicable by physics. Consciousness is not hidden in any theory, and there is nothing to suggest that intelligent beings, capable of understanding the laws of physics, should arise.

The human being discovers that there is moral universe with its own laws, unknown and unknowable to physics. Moreover, unlike stars and planets, the human being wonders why he exists and what his purpose is. This can only be known by revelation.

Moses, who is more important than any scientist, passed on what was revealed to him.

- God is a person, not an inchoate cloud of mass/energy.
- God has a plan for us to be with Him.
- God has provided us with guidance to create a good society and a path to lead us to Him.

Obviously, that is simplified, but still captures the essential. Unfortunately, the principles of guidance are called “commandments”, a word which has taken on misleading connotations over the centuries. Commandments are often misunderstood as directives to compel us to do what we don’t want to do, with the result that we will be punished for failure to follow such commandments.

Rather, commandments like forbidding murder, theft, adultery, covetousness, seem obvious to create both a peaceable social structure and an harmonious inner life. Who would be surprised that breaking those commandments leads to social conflict and inner turmoil? So we are not arbitrarily “punished” for breaking commandments, rather we are warned of the adverse consequences of doing so.

It is analogous to warning your young child not to touch the hot stove, lest she hurt herself. The “hurt” is not your punishment, but rather the inevitable consequence.

We learn to love God’s commandments for that reason; if we fail, God loves and forgives. Think in those terms and you won’t be left feeling dark and somber about your future prospects.

Posted on 2022-08-14 by Cologero

5.2 The Stages of the Fall

The meditation of Christian Hermeticism — whose aim is to understand and advance the work of the alchemical transformation of the spirit, the soul, and matter, from the state of primordial purity before the Fall, to the state after the Fall, and from the latter to that of the Reintegration — proceeds from the seven “days” of the creation according to Genesis to the seven stages of the Fall, then to the seven miracles of St. John’s Gospel, and then to the seven sayings of Jesus concerning himself in order to conclude with the seven “words” of Jesus Christ crucified and the seven stages of the Passion.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot. Letter XXI: The Fool*

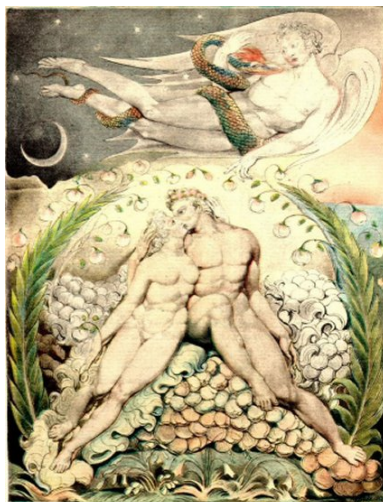
Wouldn’t it be dreadful if some day in our own world, at home, men started going wild inside, like the animals here, and still looked like men, so that you’d never know which were which?

C S LEWIS, *Prince Caspian*

In order to achieve the alchemical transformation described above, the stages of the Fall of man documented in Genesis need to be understood.

Although there are four levels of interpretation of sacred texts, the historical or literal, the allegorical, and the moral levels are not our concern here.

Anagogical Interpretation There have been many attempts, some quite clever, to interpret the story of Eden in a historical, or rather material space-time, event, in continuity with our own world. However, the Fall is by its nature discontinuous. This is not to deny that there is an historical, or pre-historical, understanding possible, but that is best left to the meditation of the seven stages of creation. The point is that there is not physical understanding, at least in the way we understand the physical.



However, besides a physical history, there is also a psychical history of the world, i.e., there is an “inside” as well as an “outside” to history. The psychical history always leaves traces in consciousness that can be recovered. This is the anagogical interpretation which transcends the material world process, and it is recovered through Hermetic meditation, almost like a deep phenomenology. This gives us access to the real inner history of mankind. Tomberg describes it this way:

One can no longer deny the fact that in the psychic domain, nothing dies and that the whole past lives present in the diverse layers of the depths of consciousness — the “unconscious” or subconsciousness — of the soul. Palaeontological and geological layers

contain only the imprints and fossils of the now dead past; psychic layers, in contrast, constitute a living witness to the actual past. They are the past which continues to live. They are memory — not intellectual, but psychically substantial — of the actual past. For this reason, nothing perishes and nothing is lost in the domain of the psyche; essential history, i.e. real joy and suffering, real religions and revelations of the past, continue to live in us, and it is in us that the key to the essential history of mankind is to be found.

Letter VI. The Lover

Seven Stages As was pointed out previously, the world as an ordered whole, as Being, is a static world. A dynamic world, one in which there is the possibility of morality, love, and creativity, requires free beings, beings who can say “I”. Then, there must be a not-I, or hindrances, in order to make freedom actual and not merely virtual.

In the Edenic stage, Adam was conscious of his real I and was in direct contact with God. The hindrance was the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, which he was commanded not to eat; this was the object of temptation. There was also the tempter, the same being who tempted Jesus in the desert. The phenomenology of the temptation and subsequent fall are told in the early chapters of Genesis.

The seven stages of the Fall are summarised in Table 5.1, followed by an interpretation of each of them.

Stage I: The Voice of the Serpent

The formula of horizontal consciousness of the serpent would be that of realism, pure and simple: “That which is in me is as that which is outside of me, and that which is outside of me is as that which is in me.” This is horizontal consciousness (simultaneous knowledge of the subjective and the objective), which sees

Stage of the Fall	Consequence
The Voice of the Serpent	Spiritual Disobedience, Doubt
The Delight to the Eyes	Greed
The Temptation of Experience	Spiritual immodesty
Cain's Fratricide	Fall from higher self to lower self
The Generation of Giants	Marriage of the lower self with lower beings
The Tower of Babel	Substitution of the real by factitious existence
Sodom and Gomorrah	Material instead of Spiritual Evolution

Table 5.1: The Stages of the Fall

things not in God, but separated from him or “naked” within itself, through itself and for itself. And as the self here replaces God (horizontal consciousness being that of the opposition of subject and object), the serpent says that on the day when Adam-Eve (Adam and Eve) eat fruit from the tree which is in the middle of the garden, their eyes will open and they will be as gods, i.e., the self will replace the function previously filled by God and that they will know good and evil.

Letter VI. The Lover

Prior to the Fall, Adam's intelligence was vertical, oriented toward God, and were not conscious of naked things, or those separated from God.

their eyes had not yet been opened and they “they were both naked and were not ashamed.”

Genesis 2:25

“They saw divine ideality expressing itself through phenomenal reality”, i.e., the world was a theophany. They had knowledge of the ideal and the real, or direct perception of hylomorphism.

The temptation is for the self to replace God, so that it will know good and evil:

If before they saw things in divine light, they will see them now in their own light, i.e. the function of illumination will belong to them, just as once it belonged to God. The source of the light will be transferred from God to man.

Eve listened to the voice of the serpent to eat from the tree as clearly as the original command to avoid it. The two contrary voices are the origin of doubt, or double-mindedness. (This is clearly expressed in the German word *Zweifel*, or two-ness.)

Faith, on the contrary, is a single inspiration. The principle of obedience is to listen to the sole voice from above. The desire for power does not result in certainty, but instead leads to inner confusion and insecurity.

Stage II: The Delight to the Eyes

The woman saw that the tree was good to eat, and fair to the eyes, and delightful to behold”

Genesis 3:6

Apart from God’s illumination, the tree looked delightful. Tomberg expands on this idea:

She looked at it in a new way — no longer as formerly, when the sole voice from above vibrated in her being, when she experienced not the least attraction for the tree, but rather now with the word of the serpent vibrating in her being — with a questioning, comparing, doubting look, i.e. ready to have experience. Because when one is in doubt, one is induced to have the experience in order to dispel it —if one does not surmount it by raising oneself to a higher plane.

The desire for experience is the beginning of greed.

Stage III: The Temptation of Experience

She took of the fruit thereof, and did eat, and gave to her husband who did eat.”

Genesis 3:6

The act follows the idea. So the idea of personal power and the delightfulness of the tree induce in Eve the desire to have the actual experience. In today’s world, the desire for experiences is quite strong. Drugs, sex, loud music, and so on, are all temptations that induce the desire to experience them. The negative results are numerous, etc., addiction, death, disease, heartbreak, etc. These occlude the presence of God.

This quest for experiences is the opposite of emptiness, or spiritual mind fasting. To put it another way, emptiness is spiritual chastity, which forgoes harmful or sinful experiences. The attempt, then, to assuage doubt through experiences is spiritual immodesty.

It would be contrary to the holy vow of chastity to put forward a hand and to take from the tree of knowledge. The spiritual world does not in any way tolerate those who seek experiences. One seeks, one asks, one knocks at its door. But one does not open it by force. One waits for it to be opened.

That is, one relies on Grace, not on force.

Stage IV: Cain’s Fratricide

And Cain said to Abel his brother: Let us go forth abroad. And when they were in the field, Cain rose up against his brother Abel, and slew him.

Genesis 4:8

The next three stages are the logical development of the original sin, which are realised. We let Tomberg's description speak for itself.

For Cain's fratricide is the primordial phenomenon containing the seed of all subsequent wars, revolutions and revolts in the history of the human race.

The root of the fratricide is the revolt of the "lower self against the "true self—of the fallen "likeness" against the intact "image".

to wander is the inevitable lot of the revolt of the "lower self against the "higher Self

Cain was exiled because the rebel against his "higher Self will no longer live under the law of the vertical but. rather under that of the horizontal, i.e. he will be "a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth". (Genesis 4:12) That is, he will no longer be rooted.

Stage V: The Generation of Giants

Now giants were upon the earth in those days. For after the sons of God went in to the daughters of men, and they brought forth children, these are the mighty men of old, men of renown. ~ Genesis 6:4

The generation of giants is the primordial phenomenon which is the proto-historical seed of all subsequent pretensions in the history of the human race for individuals, groups and peoples to play a domineering role as divine sovereigns, and thus all pretensions of being "supermen".

At the root of the generation of giants is the marriage of the "lower self with entities of the fallen hierarchies instead of with the "true Self".

To be drowned is the lot entailed by the pretension to be a "superman". He who unites himself with an entity of the fallen hierarchies, instead of with his "higher Self, to the point of being possessed, will be drowned, i.e. he will fall prey to madness.

Marriage with lower hierarchies or pre-Adamic beings (see, e.g., Mouravieff, *Gnosis*) indicates that these lower hierarchies become intertwined with the lower parts of the human psyche.

The followers of Lucifer are beautiful, so they affect the emotional level of the soul, or astral body, bypassing the intellect. That attraction is the beginning of self-deception and hence lying.

Then the etheric body is likewise infected, which is the centre of the will. The will becomes weak, seeking the satisfaction of bodily urges instead of the Will of God. Satan is the ape of God, so this distorted will mocks and ridicules anything higher. These beings are called Ahrimanic, the name of the devil opposed to the God in Zoroastrianism.

Stage VI: The Tower of Babel

And therefore the name thereof was called Babel, because there the language of the whole earth was confounded: and from thence the Lord scattered them abroad upon the face of all countries.

Genesis 11:9

This temptation involves lower selves acting collectively in order to replace the Higher Self. Tomberg explains the meaning of the building of the Tower of Babel.

The building of the tower of Babel (Genesis 11:1-9) is the primordial phenomenon containing in seed form all subsequent tendencies in the history of the human race towards the conquest of heaven by means of forces acquired and developed on the earth.

At the root of the building of the tower of Babel is the collective will of “lower selves” to achieve the replacing of the “true Self of the celestial hierarchies and God with a superstructure of universal significance fabricated through this will.”

For the tower blasted by lightning suffices to reveal to serious meditation the comprehensive arcanum of the relationship between the will and destiny — between what one wants and what happens.

To be blasted by a thunderbolt is the fate of building, collectively or individually, a tower of Babel.

Stage VII: Sodom and Gomorrah Sodom and Gomorrah could have been saved by ten righteous men among them, that is, by spiritual selection. Opposed to that, is the idea of natural selection, that the world evolves by totally natural processes. Tomberg says we are given two choices:

Those for whom evolution is an organically determined process in which descent and ascent are only two successive phases of a single cosmic vibration? Or those who see in evolution a cosmic tragedy and drama whose essence and leitmotiv correspond to the parable of the prodigal son?

The natural approach denies the ideas of the Fall, perdition, redemption, and salvation. Its symbol is the Ouroboros, a closed circle. It is the denial of freedom in the world.

The serpent took his tail in his mouth and thus formed a closed circle. He turned himself with great force and thus created in the world the great swirl which caught hold of Adam and Eve. And the other beings followed them.

This is the situation of all naturalistic, mechanistic, and historicist theories of the world: things will happen automatically apart from the human will. Opposed to the idea of a closed circle is the idea of a spiral, the state before the Fall, which allows for true growth, development, and creativity.

Posted on 2018-11-05 by Cologero

* * *

argusandphoenix on 2018-11-05 at 11:15 said:

“She looked at it in a new way — no longer as formerly, when the sole voice from above vibrated in her being, when she experienced not the least attraction for the tree, but rather now with the word of the serpent vibrating in her being—with a questioning, comparing, doubting look, i.e. ready to have experience” This reminds me of your post on Electricity (as opposed to Life): Electricity being the vibration of the serpent within our being.”

Boreas on 2018-11-05 at 12:54 said:

Excellent text Cologero, thanks! Much food for thought.

Luciferians following Blavatskyan thought see in the parable of the Fall man's liberation from animalistic ignorance and tend to see God as a tyrant wishing to keep man enslaved. This the reversal of what you and Tomberg say about the matter, and I was too once ensnared by this luciferian philosophy. It has also been used by occultists of the modern satanic variety to promote feminism, as Eve is here seen as the liberator. I would very much like to hear your thoughts about these things in light of the more traditional version.

james on 2018-11-05 at 15:43 said:

Thanks for another great post.

J. R. R. Tolkien on 2020-09-17 at 11:00 said:

Following the principles that the more cannot come from the less, that the perfect cannot come from the imperfect, also the findings of Michael Behe that mutations cannot construct something new but only alter already existing genes. It would therefore seem that if there are degenerate human forms, it would seem that they degenerated from the primordial form, it is impossible to understand exactly how this happens, hence the eternal doubt, if neodarwinism was true how does it become self-conscious? It would also have to explain that. There is no need to mention that it doesn't explain many things, since this should be obvious.

No one knows the mystery of the origins, no one will ever know, there are things beyond human understanding, this is one of the things that we will never know. There are traces of primordial humanity everywhere, the swastika for instance, the rites of initiation. But we are not satisfied.

5.3 Hermetic Meditation

Since Gornahoor has been so insistent on the necessity for spiritual practice, we will here provide an example of Hermetic meditation. This is based on suggestions from the writings of Valentin Tomberg, the foremost Hermetist of the 20th century. As he points out:

There are no theories; there is only experience, including here the intellectual experience of arcana (mysteries) and symbols.

The process involves relaxing the mind, and then entering into the arcana using the active imagination, almost as an eye witness to the events depicted. This is what Evola refers to as clairvoyance. Yet, the important thing is not to deal with the external facts surrounding the symbol, but to go deeper into the consciousness evoked by the symbol. This involves penetrating in succession the vital, mental, and spiritual layers. These layers are related to the Degrees of Knowledge¹.

So, the spiritual layer, or *nous*, is what Tomberg calls “intellectual experience”. Evola claims the *nous* is what he means by the solar or Olympian “spiritual race”. Even beyond that is the Primordial State, the Tao, the Unmoved Mover.

The following meditation is based on the use of the Genesis myth of Adam to penetrate to the awareness of the primordial state, and was intended for students studying Meditations on the Tarot. Again, the important thing is not the precise historical factuality, but rather the awareness of deeper and deeper levels of consciousness. This can be done, too, with other symbols. For example, take any of the many myths and symbols mentioned by Evola and Guenon, and do this sort of active meditation. That is how to reach an understanding of the Golden Age, or the Hyperborean origins, for example.

¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=411>

Guided Meditation Invite everyone to take the appropriate role — Adam or Eve — the end result will be the same in any case.

Step 1: Read the relevant passages or look at the symbols

Step 2: relax, in preparation, concentration without effort (this is not a history test)

Step 3: Quietly observe the flow of thoughts, without getting drawn in

Step 4: Imagine what the Garden is like sensually and physically. The beauty, the abundance, the songs of the birds, the animals, the feel of the grass underfoot, the warmth of the sun, the refreshing coolness of the night. No mosquitos, no sunburn, and so on. Visualize the Tree of Life. Then the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil — is it attracting, or repellent, or more like a void? Allow your imagination free reign to visualize the appearance of the Garden.

Step 5: Move a little deeper. What is life in the Garden like? The experience of pleasure without pain, no hunger, no thirst. How do you experience your mate? Are you attracted by Adam's or Eve's beauty? Do you experience sexual desire? How do you react to nakedness? Again, give free reign to the imagination, always attentive to higher inspiration.

Step 6: What is the mental life of Adam and Eve like – their feelings, their thoughts? What is it like to have no fear of death, illness, poverty? No anxiety, since there is perfect manifestation. But is there still something lacking? What is the attraction to the Tree of Knowledge? Why is there even the possibility of temptation? What were they thinking? Does that attraction to worldliness still exist? How to overcome it?

- Step 7:** What is the spiritual life like of Adam and Eve? Move beyond words and thoughts and try to experience this directly. They are in constant awareness of the presence of God, not as an old man walking around, but in their hearts. What is that like? There is no crisis of faith, no doubts, no feelings of forsakenness and abandonment because that presence is always felt.
- Step 8:** Gradually stop the active participation in the imagination. Detach and observe, and in the silence be attentive to any inspiration from the superconsciousness.
- Step 9:** As you let go, and in silence contemplate the flow of thoughts, images, feeling, become aware of the primordial state that precedes all thought, images, & feelings.

Posted on 2010-08-13 by Cologero

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Angel Andre on 2010-10-23 at 14:28 said:

You speak of Hermetic meditation, most interesting since it is true i feel, most definitely, that without practice one cannot truly know or experience these things. Im sure you have heard of this before, but you should post some of this up and have a discussion on it, id be interested to see what comes of it. Here is what i think is to be one of the most fascinating books in regards to not just theories, but actual doing, actual practice.

About the man :

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Franz_Bardon

some accounts of his life, written by him but also finished by his secretary at the time.

<http://www.scribd.com/doc/301829/Frabato-The-Magician->

And, here is the work, the theory and practice... Initiation Into Hermetics:

<http://www.scribd.com/doc/301820/Initiation-into-Hermetics-by-Franz-Bardon>

Meditations on the Gospels

6.1 Meditation on the Immaculate Conception

One can also say that the incarnated human being is the product of two heredities — horizontal heredity and vertical heredity, the latter being the imprint of the individuality from above and the former being the imprint of the ancestors here below. This seeks to express that he is the product of two imitations — horizontal and vertical, i.e., that in order to become what he is he owes it to imitation of his ancestors from the past and to that of himself above. In the last analysis, therefore, it is a matter on the one hand of horizontal heredity going back to the archetype or terrestrial heredity, i.e. Adam, and on the other hand of vertical heredity rising up to the Father who is heaven, i.e., God. This is why it is so important to allow light from the dogma of the **immaculate conception** to convince us of its truth, for what is at stake is the line of vertical heredity — “God-man heredity”.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

The Father gave her his Son, the Son came down into her virginal womb to become her child; in her the Holy Spirit miraculously fashioned the body of Jesus and made her soul his own dwelling place, penetrating her whole being such an ineffable manner that the expression “Spouse of the Holy Spirit” is far from adequate to express the life of the Spirit in her and through her. In Jesus there are two natures, divine and human, but one single Person who is God; here on the contrary we have two natures and two persons, the Holy Spirit and the Immaculata, but united in a union that defies all human expression.

ST MAXIMILIAN KOLBE

For the Word generated by the Father is understood by the one in whom it is received perfectly — by that person who is the Immaculate Conception.

ST MAXIMILIAN KOLBE

By the power of the Holy Spirit the Word became incarnate from the Virgin Mary.

Nicene Creed

Just as Eve was the genetic equivalent to Adam, apart from the X chromosome, so likewise is the New Adam the genetic equivalent to the New Eve. In our time, given our knowledge of biology and genetics, the possibility of a virginal conception is no longer inconceivable.

So Jesus, the New Adam, is the genetic image of his Mother, Mary, the New Eve. Moreover, while the body of Jesus was in Mary’s womb, her soul was, in Kolbe’s words,



the dwelling place of the Holy Spirit. As we saw in Letter II on the High Priestess, the Holy Spirit can be reflected only in the completely unperturbed soul, a soul protected from sin. That is Mary, who understood the Spirit perfectly.

As Tomberg points out, we are under the law of horizontal heredity, in imitation of our ancestors, going back to Adam. This prepares the biological and social environment in which the individuality can incarnate. Hence, Jesus appears at a specific time and place, to the mother prepared to receive him.

While Mary was “full of grace” from the beginning, we are likewise called to be full of grace; this is *theosis*. This is confirmed in Mary as the Queen of Heaven. For us, it is something to be achieved. For that, she is our model.

Jesus has two natures, divine and human, in one Person. We, through *theosis*, can have a divine as well as a human nature. However, we retain our own Person, so this union of the human with the divine requires two persons. By purifying our own soul, the Holy Spirit can become more fully reflected in our own consciousness. Then the Logos is born in us, too, and we put on our true Self:

And I live, now not I; but Christ liveth in me. And that I live
now in the flesh: I live in the faith of the Son of God, who loved
me, and delivered himself for me.

Galatians 2:20

Posted on 2022-12-08 by Cologero

* * *

DEWnada on 2022-12-08 at 16:36 said:

The Theotokos can be considered the Pneumatophoric Hypostasis according to Bulgakov. If we apply Tomberg's Luminous Holy Trinity model with Bulgakov's Sophiology we then get: Mary, the World Soul / Holy Soul, consort of the Holy Spirit & Pneumatophoric Hypostasis; Bat Kol / Shabbat HaMalka, Daughter of God, consort of the Son of God / the Logos & the Logophoric Hypostasis; and Elat / Al-Kat, the Divine Mother consort of the Divine Father El and the Mysteriophoric Hypostasis. Trino-Sophia is here seen as the transcendent uncreated Sophia Mother, the mediating unbegotten Sophia Crone-Daughter, and the immanent created Sophia Virgin-Immaculata. I made up the Logophoric and Mysteriophoric Hypostases terms and welcome better conceptual designations. Critique and amplify. Sat Naam

6.2 Meditation on the Incarnation

At this time of year, it is certainly *de rigueur* to meditate on the meaning, actuality, or possibility of the Incarnation of the Logos in Jesus Christ. This will involve brief excursions into the implications for a spiritual path, metaphysics, and the radical change in the world process in the current cycle.

Of its actuality, I am sure all readers are familiar with the story; if not, it is easy enough to find. There will be objections to the story as miraculous and incredible, but these objections can only arise from an *a priori* commitment to a positivist world view that cannot prove itself to be true. If, on the other hand, one is ready to accept the actuality of unusual preternatural or supernatural phenomena, e.g., miraculous cures, amazing powers of yogis and tulkus, the skills of magicians, etc., then the story of the birth of Jesus cannot be so easily rejected. There is only the "vexed theological question of grace", as Julius Evola called it in a recent translation; some will be willing to see it, others will not.

However, in this meditation, we are not as interested in the Incarna-



tion as a matter of faith, but rather as gnosis. We will stipulate it as a given, and move on. As one of our mottos indicates, “truth lies in the interior of man” (St Augustine). Augustine moved beyond Neoplatonism when he came to the realization that the Logos of the Greek philosophers, understood in an objective and exterior way, was actually the same Logos Who was incarnated and is known in man’s interiority.

The Path of Affirmation This is expressed in the Path of Affirmation that is conceivable in the Incarnation. All previous forms of spirituality follow the path of denial. Specifically, these would include Advaita Vedanta, Buddhism, and Neoplatonism. This path ultimately tries to transcend the material conditions of life, including the human person, by the realization of one’s true identity as Brahman or the One. In this path, any determination is a limitation.

In the Path of Affirmation, on the contrary, God is approached through these determinations. St Athanasius describes the Incarnation: Not by conversion of the Godhead into flesh, but by taking of the Manhood into God. This differs from Oriental the idea of an Avatar in which a god takes on the appearance of a man for a specific purpose, e.g., Parashurama, an avatar of Vishnu, appeared to overcome the rule of the Kshatriyas.

Rather, the Logos raised the human up to God, once and for all. Christ, as the second Adam, restored the possibility of the Primordial state to man. In this Path, man is not annihilated, so that only God remains, but instead there are two who are united. Although largely ignored in common practice, this is an essential element of the catholic, apostolic, Roman religion. Some quick examples, although many more can be found, including the official Catechism:

IRENÆUS: The Word of God, our Lord Jesus Christ, who did, through His transcendent love, become what we are, that He might bring us to be even what He is Himself.

CLEMENT OF ALEXANDRIA: The Word of God became man, that

you may learn from man how man may become God.

Of course, the premier example of this teaching is Dante's *Divine Comedy*, where he shows us the path to union with God through the rich imagery of his poetry.

In Christian Hermetism, particularly as evidenced in Valentin Tomberg¹ in our time, the birth of the Logos in consciousness is the result of the alchemical marriage between the Holy Spirit and the purified soul. That becomes the new, or absolute self, in union with the Father, or absolute being.

So, the goal of this path is the spiritual and alchemical transformation of man, and even the world. Ultimately, no one can be convinced of this through any type of rational argument, so this is only an invitation to follow that path. Once any type of realization of this nature is reached, one's faith is secure.

The World Process In the literature on tradition, most of the attention is focused on metaphysical teachings that aim to transcend all material circumstances. There is lip service to social organization, viz., the idea of castes and hierarchy, as well as the notion of cycles of the four ages. However, the relation of metaphysics to the world process is often left unclear; to those who are striving to be liberated from all worlds, what difference would it make?

But, if the real path is the Path of Affirmation, then it does indeed make a difference. In the idea of the four ages, there is often the misconception that the ages run according to some independent and objective cosmic clock. If that is true, then one can be passive and simply wait for events to occur. In particular, the end of the Kali Yuga comes at the prescribed moment apart from any consciousness of it. That is indeed odd for a teaching that regards consciousness as primary over the physical and

¹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/the-elements-of-sacred-magic>

material. If that were true, then Guenon's call for the establishment of a new elite would make no sense.

All traditions recognize three forces: the three *gunas* in the Vedanta, or the Great Triad of Taoism. We will stick to the Western formulation of Providence, Will, and Destiny. Destiny is the automatic and deterministic element of the world process. Its law is that of increasing entropy; left to its own devices, the world winds down, ultimately to a totally undifferentiated state. This is compatible with profane science.

Of course, such a state is impossible, since nothing could occur in it and God is Infinite possibility. Providence is God's or Heaven's influence on the process, not through force, but rather through suggestion and persuasion. This opens up new possibilities, especially the possibility for a new world to follow the old when all its possibilities have been exhausted. The middle term in this is the Will of man, responding to Providence and transforming his being and that of the world.

Creation and Redemption The pagan view of cycles was defective. It regarded the world as uncreated with no beginning and man as perpetual. Hence, cycles reoccurred, in perpetual return, the same thing over and over. Even Guenon rejected this, since, in his view, a world had a beginning and an end, the end of one being the beginning of another, much different, world.

This we take as closer to the truth. Hence, we must understand the cycle, from a perfect age to an ever more degenerate one, and finally to the birth of a new age that is both in continuity with and different from its predecessor. This must be understood as a drama involving God, man, and the earth, not as the predetermined result of a mindless process, or even worse, some demiurge.

Hence, the transition from a golden age to a lesser one, did not happen according to some calendar, but was rather the result of man's will. On the other side, the transition from the *kali yuga* to a golden age cannot

happen from within the world process but rather it must be interjected into it from a transcendent or providential source, to then be adopted by the Will of man, at least by some who will be the leaven.

So the Incarnation is the beginning of the process of Redemption, that is, the regeneration of man and the world in a world to come. That is why Valentin Tomberg could regard Creation and Redemption as the two great magical acts since magic “requires the perfect union in Love between two distinct and free wills: the divine and the human”.

We know creation interiorly through the memory of the Primordial state and its loss. There is the testimony of saints and mystics, there is the evidence of it through perduring vestigial preternatural powers of the soul; ultimately, conviction comes through our own remembrance of that state.

Similarly, for the Incarnation. We know that there have been saints who have reached the divine union, or Beatific Vision, in this life, the Western equivalent of the jivan-mukti. We, too, may have been graced with a taste of that union.

A follow up will deal with the scientific and metaphysical issues involved with this.

Posted on 2013-12-22 by Cologero

* * *

JA on 2013-12-23 at 10:22 said:

Gnosis is not heresy, heresy is denial of the true facts as given in the Creed and as taught by the Councils and the Magisterium. Gnosticism denies Christ came in the flesh.

Catholicism is an elitist religion, read the book Nobility by Dr Plinio if you doubt that.

“taste of union”... so Cologero, you have achieved theosis ?

Blessed Christmas, my brother in Christ !

scardanelli on 2013-12-23 at 10:25 said:

"Ultimately, no one can be convinced of this through any type of rational argument, so this is only an invitation to follow that path."

In the previous posts on Evola and Coue, we have seen that Faith is certainly a necessary beginning condition. Yet ultimately faith must be resolved in certainty. What the discursive mind believes upon faith must be seen and verified within. When one sees the truth in this fashion, there is no more need to argue or attack the assertions of others. One can perform spiritual works of mercy out of love for ones neighbor though.

When Faith stagnates, when it is not resolved in certainty, it becomes rigid dogma, it becomes the empty worship of the Pharisees. Thus one feels the need to "protect" the truth, when in reality, the truth is and always will remain without your help. Certainty from within is the way to spiritualize matter and to establish truth in the midst of this world. This is the ultimate support of Orthodoxy.

Matt on 2013-12-24 at 11:42 said:

No talk of the act of creation being fundamentally misguided and/or evil, no talk of the world being created by a being/principle opposed to the True God; I fail to see how the post is gnostic in the historical-religious sect sense, nor do I see a supposed initiatic fetishism.

Merry Christmas.

Jacob on 2013-12-24 at 21:58 said:

I try to avoid posts that contain just praises, but this was was such a great post IMO. The comments were very interesting a well. There did not seem to be anything Gnostic in the post to me. In fact, as Cologero said the Clementine initiation post is a great post on Gnosticism. Still, I think even things connected to Gnosticism are useful insights as long as they can be separated from the specifically heretical teachings. I mean, I don't think anyone who is actually informed on these things would say using Meister Eckhart's teachings are a bad idea, although he ran into trouble with ye inquisition. The Templars and the Jesuits as well had their problems.

Anyway, Merry Christmas everyone.

Michael on 2013-12-24 at 22:00 said:

I've been wondering how Tomberg's path relates to Guenon's idea of the elite. Thank you for clarifying. Those who follow the path outlined by Tomberg are those who cooperate with the providential spark ("Thy will be done") that will bring about the golden age.

It seems that Catholicism is both exoteric and esoteric at the same time, and the esoteric can be uncovered by those who approach from both a hermetic or exoteric angle.

Merry Christmas!

anon on 2013-12-25 at 10:15 said:

Speaking of Gnosticism, not only as historical sect, but primarily as an eternal tendency (or current) within the human heart, either dormant or active, one that occurs in the context of many religious different traditions, and which finds not only spiritual, but also political expression, I was glad to see two articles on Gornahoor that mention Voegelin. I stumbled across him before ever hearing about Evola or Guenon.

The death of the spirit is the price of progress. Nietzsche revealed this mystery of the Western apocalypse when he announced that God was dead and that He had been murdered. This Gnostic murder is constantly committed by the men who sacrificed God to civilization. The more fervently all human energies are thrown into the great enterprise of salvation through world-immanent action, the farther the human beings who engage in this enterprise move away from the life of the spirit. And since the life the spirit is the source of order in man and society, the very success of a Gnostic civilization is the cause of its decline.

A civilization can, indeed, advance and decline at the same time—but not forever. There is a limit toward which this ambiguous process moves; the limit is reached when an activist sect which represents the Gnostic truth organizes the civilization into an empire under its rule. Totalitarianism, defined as the existential rule of Gnostic activists, is the end form of progressive civilization.

– Eric Voegelin

“One comment I should make right now. Obviously the title ‘Gnosticism and Modernity’ is, at least partly, inspired by my own work in the field. But when I hit on this problem, that was 25 years ago. In the meantime, science in this matter has advanced. And today I would have to say that Gnosticism is one component in the historical structure of modernity but no more than one.”

– Eric Voegelin

“I have been called every conceivable name by partisans of this or that ideology... a Communist, a Fascist, a National Socialist, an old liberal, a new liberal, a Jew, a Catholic, a Protestant, a Platonist, a neo-Augustinian, a Thomist, and of course a Hegelian.”

– Eric Voegelin

Michel on 2013-12-26 at 16:02 said:

Oh that with yoke tender,
Realize thy burden great bull,
Plough thine fields strangely,
With the fierceness of a thousand suns,
Subtly dancing to finer hymns,
Pouring as gentle streams from breaking skies,
Arise thou Great Morning Star!
Seize thy rightful place stolen from thee,
Fly thou blithe spirit, in swirls of liquid burning,
Embrace The Son of like particle,

Ever galvanized, progenitor of Thee once silent,
Now e'er flaring Blazing Song.

Cologero on 2013-12-27 at 00:17 said:

I have been away visiting family and am just now catching up on comments, for whose civilized tone and intelligence I am grateful, even those who respectfully disagree. Of course, I have no desire to be "original"; rather, I want only to bring to light what has been forgotten and perhaps re-express it in contemporary terms. If anyone is still confused by this post, please ponder these words from St Augustine (Confessions, Book XI, Ch 8):

Thus, in the gospel He speaks through the flesh; and this sounded outwardly in the ears of men, that it might be believed and sought inwardly, and that it might be found in the eternal Truth, where the good and only Master teaches all His disciples.

Max on 2013-12-27 at 17:36 said:

A child might live happily without worries, almost not even conscious of himself. But he still wishes to grow up, know and do things. We must not necessarily regard the procession of the ages of the world as a degeneration. It depends on perspective. Through the different qualities of time we can know the whole like a child gets to know himself as he grows older. If as an old man he still remembers how it is to be a child in his heart, he is beyond time and can see all in a single instant. There is a purpose to living which can only be found and fulfilled by living.

6.3 The Infancy Narratives

This is a review of *The Infancy Narratives* by **Joseph Ratzinger**. Since the story is, or should be, very familiar, we want to instead focus more on the exegetical methods used by Fr. Ratzinger than on the story itself. He writes that good exegesis involves two stages.

1. **Historical component.** What did the authors intend to convey through their text in their own day?

2. **Contemporary component.** Is it true? Does it concern me? How so?

Obviously, spiritual writings do not concern me in the same way as a new tax code might. Unlike a subject like chemistry, for example, spiritual truths are best communicated through myths and symbols. As such, their meaning, their “concern for me”, are not always open to everyone. That is because they describe “spiritual processes that have given birth to a new people” [Bachofen].

That is true in regard to the narratives surrounding the birth of Jesus. Nevertheless, these narratives also claim to be representing “the history of events occurring materially on earth”. There are two easy, but ultimately unhelpful, solutions (beyond complete rejection).

- Accept the spiritual teaching but not the material. Christ, then, is one of the world’s great teachers. This superficially sounds more “intellectual”, since it avoids the messiness of actual events.
- Naively accept the historical aspect without a deeper concern. This is the sentimental solution. Unfortunately, facts are mute and do not speak for themselves. Hence, there is the need for a careful exegesis of the type taught us by Fr. Ratzinger.

We have the model of **Marius Victorinus**, the neoplatonic philosopher who initially accepted Christianity as an intellectual system, but not as a historical teaching with institutions, and so on. Or perhaps the Inklings, like C. S. Lewis and Tolkien, had a better idea: it is a myth that actually happened. Here, we will take the perspective of Victorinus. The historical component will have to be an individual decision.

In the first part, we highlight Fr. Ratzinger’s exegetical points, drawing out their logical consequences, and placing them into a larger perspective.

The second part on the birth of Jesus and the revelation to the shepherds will appear on Christmas Eve.

The final part on the Magi will appear on the feast of the Epiphany.

Salvation Perhaps we no longer consciously think in terms of a savior, but at the time of Jesus' birth, the idea of a savior was in the air. This was written about Augustus Caesar, the Emperor at the time:

Providence, which has ordered all things, filled [Augustus] with virtue that he might benefit mankind, sending him as a Saviour ... the birthday of the god was the beginning of the good tidings that he brought for the world. From his birth, a new reckoning of time must begin.

Fr. Ratzinger points out that religion and politics were not separated as they are now. Salvation then also included peace, a recurring theme in the Christmas message. Yet, a political solution is not the point. In *Introduction to Christianity*, Fr. Ratzinger describes the situation of man, which has been called "original sin".

The seat of original sin is to be sought precisely in this collective net that precedes the individual existence as a sort of spiritual datum, not in any biological legacy passed on between otherwise utterly separated individuals. ... no man can start from scratch any more, completely unimpaired by history. No one starts off in an unimpaired condition in which he would only need to develop himself freely and lay out his own grounds; everyone lives in a web that is a part of his existence itself.

In other words, we inherit this structure. This is not biological heredity, otherwise it would be a medical problem. That is, a "physician of the body" could develop a serum, a vaccine, a surgical procedure, or a genetic recoding to "cure" original sin. So original sin must be a defect of the soul,

not directly the body. **Rene Guenon** states how this is possible, while still being inheritable:

That there is a psychic heredity as well as a physiological heredity is hardly in doubt and is even a fact of common observation. But what few take into account is that at the least it supposes that the parents furnish a psychic seed as well as a biological seed. (*The Psychic Fallacy*, p 176)

So salvation can come only from a *physician of the soul*, a designation for Christ. The world system cannot be cured from within. With the knowledge of good and evil, man learned to separate the “no” from the “yes”, the false from the true, evil from good, doubt instead of faith. The influences of the world are legion and contradict each other. Only a transcendent influence from above can be the source of salvation. So being enters history. **Boris Mouravieff** identifies the world system as the “A” influences and the transcendent as the “B” influences.

Death and Destiny In his analysis of the symbolism of Ocnus the Rope Plaiter found in a tomb, **J J Bachofen** describes the pagan world-view revealed therein, in these terms:

The thread of death is woven into the web of which every tellurian organism consists. Death is the supreme natural law, the *fatum* of material life, to which the gods themselves bow, which they cannot claim to master. Thus the web of tellurian creation becomes the web of destiny, the thread becomes the carrier of human fate ... the loom, carrier of the supreme law of creation written in the stars, was assigned to the uranian deities in their sidereal nature; and, finally, that human life and the entire cosmos were seen as a great web of destiny.

The radicalness of the new message cannot be known unless and until one can place himself in the place of the pagans at that time, fully feeling or recreating in his interiority the weight of this heavy conception of death and destiny. The pagan view, as exemplified, for example, in Plato and Hindus, was entirely moralistic. A person was rewarded or punished after his death in accordance with his acts while alive. This judgment was impersonal and mechanical, the *lex talionis*, “an eye for an eye”. In contrast, the new message is one of life and freedom, not death and destiny. Fr Ratzinger recounts **Bernard of Clairvaux**’s sermon on the topic:

After the error of our first parents, the whole world was shrouded in darkness, under the dominion of death. Now God seeks to enter the world anew. He knocks at Mary’s door. He needs human freedom. The only way he can redeem man, who was created free, is by means of a free “yes” to his will. In creating freedom, he made himself in a certain sense dependent upon man. His power is tied to the unenforceable “yes” of a human being”.

Thus God is revealed both as Being and as acting in history, transcendent and immanent. Unlike the pagan gods who themselves were subject to death and destiny, God is revealed as the creator of the cosmos. No longer subject to the stars, man becomes free. So free, in fact, that the salvation of the world depends first on Mary’s free choice. Only in freedom can there be an escape from the domination of worldly influences. In *Introduction to Christianity*, Fr. Ratzinger writes:

Only by the action of the individual can the transformation of history, the destruction of the *dictatorship of the milieu* come to pass.

This “dictatorship of the milieu” is the set of A influences.

Genealogy and World History Even to the casual reader, Matthew's and Luke's genealogies differ from each other in significant ways. Rather than engage in hypothetical contortions to harmonize them, Fr. Ratzinger makes another choice. Anyone familiar with esoteric texts will recognize that deliberate contradictions indicate that the text is to be understood symbolically, not literally. Hence, Fr. Ratzinger brings out the symbolic meaning of the two accounts.

Matthew starts with Abraham and leads forward to Jesus, in three sets of 14 generations each. Curiously, he points out that the number for the name "David" is 14, giving force to the idea that Jesus is the heir of David. This is the only place where Kabbalistic numerology is used, hence this can be understood as a tacit endorsement of that method.

So for Matthew, Abraham is the beginning of the history with Jesus as the fulfillment. The first phase of 14 generations leads from Abraham to David; the second phase, a period of decline leading to the Babylonian captivity; and the third, rises again to Jesus. However, Joseph, while the legal father, is not mentioned as the "begetter" of Jesus, who was instead born of Mary. So legally he belongs to the house of David, but his origin is elsewhere, from above. The idea of vertical and horizontal heredity will be discussed again in the third segment

Luke, on the other hand, starts with Jesus as an adult and then works the genealogy backward to Adam. This indicates the Jesus is a new orientation to world history. Adam transcended animality by being made in the image and likeness of God. Jesus, on the other hand, is the god-man. The god-man transcends man just as fully as Adam transcended the animal. We, then, are offered the opportunity to achieve theosis, to truly become god-like. Thus the unfulfilled goal of both Adam and Plato, to be like the gods, finally becomes possible in world history. This will be brought up again in the third segment.

Posted on 2014-12-15 by Cologero

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Tom Blanchard on 2014-12-24 at 10:45 said:

Lovely Christmas reading – thank you for this. Looking forward to the second part.

Michael on 2015-01-02 at 11:01 said:

Beautiful post. I am curious about your comment on kabbalistic numerology: do you see this as a tacit endorsement of the kabbalah as a whole? I am not sure how much of the kabbalah is unique to kabbalah versus just being part of the Judaism of that time. In other words, I am wondering if you would recommend study of the kabbalah.

Cologero on 2015-01-04 at 10:52 said:

Well, I am curious about why Fr. Ratzinger, who is very careful with his words, would mention it. Of course, in Hebrew every word is also a number. Nevertheless, I don't believe that any "serious" exegete, up until now, has proposed that the numbers have any significance.

As for the study of the kabbalah, you could start with *Meditations on the Tarot* and determine for yourself if the kabbalistic references add anything to the depth of understanding and spirituality. We can be sure that Fr. Ratzinger was at least familiar with the existence of that work, if not its actual contents.

Mercurius on 2015-12-21 at 22:28 said:

This past year, I've been working with/in a very demanding company that tends to suck away anything of "free time"—thus, at best, due to time strictures, I've only been able to occasionally touch the hems of spiritual Life in the Western liturgical cycle.

As a result, Advent came and went fast, not allowing much opportunity to reflect, and denying something of a developing "Christmas Spirit". Yet, this post, was corrective—it compensated, and provided JUST what I could not attain by myself "this season", restoring my lacking "Christmas Spirit" to where I'd expect it to be—and, coincidentally proving, or illustrating that, "Saviors" are necessary

Michael, re "Kabbalah" in antiquity, and the Ratzinger remarks, I myself (at the least), find the "Apostolic Gnosis" series of Lea and Bond pretty important exegesis from a Greek wind.

<http://www.amazon.com/The-Apostolic-Gnosis-Materials-Study/dp/1872189695>

6.4 The Herald Angels Sing

Relying on the best of recent biblical exegesis, Fr. **Joseph Ratzinger** provides interesting details regarding the actual birth of Jesus in Bethlehem. He avoids the sentimentalism often surrounding the Christmas story, and instead brings out its essential meaning. Interested readers can consult the book. What I prefer to focus on here is the meaning rather than the events, which are familiar to all. In particular, God's revelation via angels brings out important details that are still helpful today. The method of this revelation was different for Mary, Joseph, and the Shepherds. These took the forms of command, dreams, and song, respectively, all forms of communication that bypass the lower intellectual mind and pass directly to higher centers.

We have already discussed the annunciation to Mary. This came in the form of a command, not a logical proof nor a discussion. Such an incredible message could only take hold in a sinless consciousness, aligned already with the will of God, and not beclouded by the "personal equation". There can be no debate; only the free choice between obedience and rebellion.

The God of the Human Race As we saw in the myths of the origins of Rome, the idea of birth of a god-man from the mating of a god with a virgin was not at all unknown in ancient time. Even the ancient Greek cities had their spiritual origin from a man they revered as a god. The god, in all those cases however, was the god of a specific people and bestowed a particular identifying spiritual gift on them. However, as Fr. Ratzinger points out, such myths created a mixed being, a demi-god, whereas Christ was fully God and fully man, without confusion or mixture. Moreover, unlike the timeless quality of a myth, this story is determined at a specific place and time.

So the meaning of the birth of Jesus is different. The Holy Spirit, the

father of Jesus, is the “giver of life” itself, not just one aspect of life. He is the God of the human race, not just a particular people. Nevertheless, such a possibility was known to a few people at that time:

As to the god of the human race, a few philosophers had an idea of him; the mysteries of Eleusis might have afforded a glimpse of him to the most intelligent of the initiated; but the vulgar never believed in such a god.

FUSTEL DE COULANGES, *The Ancient City*

With the birth of Jesus, this God was revealed to all. The revelation to the vulgar will be described in this segment in regard to the shepherds. The revelation to the initiated will be the topic of the next segment on the Magi.

Horizontal and Vertical Heredity While Luke traces the genealogy of Jesus horizontally back to Adam, the first man, John indicates the vertical origin of Jesus as the incarnation of the Logos. Analogously, the birth of each human being is the result of both horizontal and vertical heredity. In horizontal heredity, the physical and psychic characteristics of the ancestors are transmitted to the descendants. In the vertical dimension, the intellectual soul, or individuality, is breathed into the body/soul.

This is explained more fully by **Valentin Tomberg** in Letter XX of *Meditations on the Tarot*. Horizontal heredity operates by imitation of the ancestors. As Fr. Ratzinger points out, we are born into a “collective net” of our ancestors, tracing back to the very origins of the human race. The unraveling of this net requires the birth of the perfect man. Only then can we experience a second birth, as adopted children of God, which lifts us out of and liberates us from that net. We see this in John:

To all who received him, who believed in his name, he gave power to become children of God, who were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God.

John 1:12-13

Joseph's Role Since Joseph's role is often given short shrift, it is useful to focus on what Fr. Ratzinger writes about him:

Whereas the angel "came" to Mary, he merely appears to Joseph in a dream ... Once again this shows us an essential quality of the figure of Saint Joseph: his capacity to perceive the divine and his ability to discern. Only a man who is inwardly watchful for the divine, only someone with a real sensitivity for God and his ways, can receive God's message in this way.

Obviously, what was revealed in Joseph's dream was quite difficult to believe. So how was Joseph able to discern God's will, even as revealed in a dream? That is because Joseph was a just, or righteous, man, and a just man is one whose life is lived in and from the word of God. Also, Joseph was "inwardly watchful", that is, he monitored and guarded his thoughts. He was able to see past the trap of the collective net of human influences to recognize the divine influences that transcended them.

Of course, many people ask God for a "sign" to reveal His will for them. But are they just? Could they really recognize God's message, given their spiritual state. Or do they prejudge the sign so that only something consoling or beneficial is interpreted as a sign? Fr. Ratzinger offers this challenge:

God is constantly regarded as a limitation placed on our freedom, that must be set aside if man is ever to be completely himself. God, with his truth, stands in opposition to man's manifold lies, his self-seeking and his pride. God is love. But love can also be hated when it challenges us to transcend ourselves. It is not a romantic "good feeling". Redemption is not "wellness", it is not about basking in self-indulgence; on the contrary, it is liberation from the imprisonment in self-absorption.

The duty of the father is to name the son. This name, “Jesus”, was revealed to Joseph. It means “Yahweh is salvation”. The angel in the dream explains: “He will save his people from their sins.” Since this is the purpose of the incarnation, it is imperative to understand exactly what that means. Fr. Ratzinger explains:

Man is a relational being. And if his first, fundamental relationship is disturbed—his relationship with God—than nothing else can be truly in order. This is where the priority lies in Jesus’ message and ministry: before all else, he wants to point man toward the essence of his malady . . . if you are not healed there, then however many good things you may find, you are not truly healed.

Clearly, it is not simply a matter of “doing good”, as Plato thought, or of avoiding certain behaviors. Rather, sin is the state of not being in proper relationship with God, the Logos.

The Shepherds Shepherds were in the fields around the region where Jesus was born, “keeping watch over their flocks by night.” Once again, we see the theme of watchfulness. The shepherds were not just outwardly close to the event, but “they were also inwardly closer to the event, unlike the peacefully sleeping townsfolk. . . . inwardly they were not far from the God who had become a child.” The watchfulness of the shepherds has become part of the monastic tradition.

When the angel appears to the shepherds, they were filled with fear. Just as the angel Gabriel reassured Mary not to fear, the angel likewise dispels the shepherds’ fear. The spirit of fear is the opposite of the spirit of love.

Then a multitude of angels appeared praising God: “Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among men with whom he is pleased.”

Fr. Ratzinger makes this fascinating point:

Christianity has always understood that the speech of angels is actually song, in which all the glory of the great joy that they proclaim becomes tangibly present.

As **Julian Jaynes** documented in *The Origin of Consciousness in the Break-down of the Bicameral Mind*, speech in the forms of commands, music and poetry bypass the rational mind. Specifically, there is a direct revelation or intuition, without the duality of yes/no, faith/doubt, etc. Even among the Greeks, the muses sang the poetry, so that they literally heard the muses.

So the true experience of angels is not dualistic, and not even visual. The angelic song goes straight to the shepherds' hearts, not their heads.

Posted on 2014-12-24 by Cologero

* * *

X on 2014-12-24 at 23:50 said:

"Clearly, it is not simply a matter of 'doing good', as Plato thought, or of avoiding certain behaviors. Rather, sin is the state of not being in proper relationship with God, the Logos."

Sin is the state of not having fully internally realized Logos.

David on 2014-12-26 at 03:14 said:

This series of article with Joseph Ratzinger are really good. I have alot to think and assimilate. Everything appear so simple yet it is so far reaching; and this yet again is only an illusion of the mind because of its relation to Being. Thank you for all your articles but those one really speaks. Eager to read the last one.

Q on 2014-12-26 at 08:09 said:

"The spirit of fear is the opposite of the spirit of love."

But fear of God is the beginning of wisdom, isn't it? How do you interpret that? I always simply looked on that as meaning that wisdom starts by fearing to tread on the wrong path.

Scardanelli on 2014-12-26 at 09:49 said:

Q, I think the type of fear discussed above is one of closing oneself off to influences from above and clinging to the profane. Love on the contrary is opening oneself to the divine. The

fear of God as the beginning of wisdom refers to fear as a type of humility before God. This type of fear is a self emptying that must take place if we are to receive wisdom.

Tom Blanchard on 2014-12-26 at 11:39 said:

Our priest gave a very similar homily this Christmas Eve, specifying that the inner meaning of the Shepherd is watchfulness, illustrating the interior disposition necessary to hear the speech of the Angels. Quite likely he also took inspiration from Ratzinger's *Infancy Narratives*...: <http://www.anglicanphiladelphia.org/sermon/christmaseve-14.mp3>

Michael M on 2020-12-24 at 10:21 said:

Interesting to note that it was a dream that came to St. Joseph, at night, but contrasting to other nightly revelations as specifically a dream vs. Nicodemus' talks, Mary's visitation, the Shepherds meeting and the Magi and the Star. Again he is told later to take the family to Egypt...through a dream, so perhaps we can see that for the Just, the Lord may speak to them there. Joseph was inwardly watchful and his dreams were not inundated with the incorrect tendencies and worries which most will give as the reason not to interpret dreams. Not something I've worked out entirely but given the next year (2021) declared to be a year dedicated to St. Joseph it may be time for these works to be contemplated more.

A small comment on the inner watchfulness of the Shepherds, as the Magi are to be addressed in a later post I will save that part when it comes up to contrast.

From a short lecture by Fulton Sheen, he compared the Shepherds to those that know nothing. I took this to mean a more natural, do nothing, know nothing, unconcerned with the world approach, somewhat 'natural' or simple in that they live and subsist on one task which is their flock and develop a type of watchfulness that is scorned by those concerned with material things. Good, honest, and hard working folk, here angels speak to their hearts, for they are not centered in the mind but in the every day, every moment present of life. Song and emotion (pure) are tied together as it moves the heart and can be grasped through the heart outside of time unlike a purely 'rational' way of understanding, the full Gestalt of it is different, much like the simple life of a monk which is mentioned above as well.

6.5 Revelation to the Wise

Revelation presupposes emptiness — space put at its disposal — in order to manifest itself. This is why it is necessary to renounce.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

The concept of first-born takes on a cosmic dimension. Christ, the incarnate Son, is God's first thought, preceding all creation, which is ordered toward him and proceeds from him. He is both the beginning and the goal of the new creation.

JOSEPH RATZINGER

Historical Background Balaam was a pagan soothsayer, quoted in the Bible. He would have used auguries to come to his prophecies. This is what he prophesied about Israel:

I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not nigh: a star shall come forth out of Jacob and a scepter shall rise out of Israel (Num 24:17)

This prophecy about a star and a king was known to other nations outside Israel. Some of them may have pondered about the new "king of the Jews" and how to recognize him. The point here is that boundaries were not as strict as we may assume today. A pagan, since he was quoted in the Bible, had a divine revelation. Although Fr. Ratzinger does not mention this, there are parallels between Zoroaster and Moses.²

The Magi Feast of the Epiphany, January 6. In "King of the World", **Rene Guenon** writes:

Now it can be revealed that these mysterious personages represent in truth nothing other than the three leaders of Agartha. The Mahanga offers gold to Christ and hails him as King; the Mahatma, offering incense, greets him as Priest; and the Brahatma, greeting him as Prophet, proffers myrrh.

²<https://www.jewishencyclopedia.com/articles/15283-zoroastrianism>

The Magi were from the “land of sunrise”, i.e., the East. They were members of the Persian priestly caste, presumably the Zoroastrian religion. The Magi were also the teachers of the Greek philosophers. Aristotle mentioned the Magi, and he believed the Hebrews originated in India where they were called “Kalani”.

On the one hand, the Magi were seekers of truth. On the other hand, they could also be the possessors of supernatural knowledge who used their powers to deceive and seduce (See Acts 13:10). This reflects the difference between sacred magic and personal magic. (See Letter V, *The Pope*). The Magi of Matthew’s Gospel are of the former type and use “religious and philosophical wisdom as an incentive to set off in the right direction, it is the wisdom that ultimately leads people to Christ.”

Wisdom Besides Baalam’s prophecy, according to Tacitus and Suetonius there was speculation at that time that the ruler of the world would emerge from Judah. Fr. Ratzinger speculates about the Magi:

They were people of inner unrest, people of hope, people on the lookout for the true star of salvation. The men of whom Matthew speaks were not just astronomers. They were “wise”. They represent the inner dynamic of religion toward self-transcendence, which involves a search for truth, a search for the true God and hence “philosophy” in the original sense of the word. Wisdom, then, serves to purify the message of science: the rationality of that message does not remain at the level of intellectual knowledge, but seeks understanding in its fullness and so raises reason to its loftiest possibilities.

Pope Leo XIII, in the Encyclical *On the Nature of Human Liberty* (*Libertas Praestantissimum*), describes the qualities of the wise man:

Even the heathen philosophers clearly recognized this truth, especially they who held that the wise man alone is free; and by the

term “wise man” was meant, as is well known, the man trained to live in accordance with his nature, that is, in justice and virtue.

We have seen revelation in various guises. There was the revelation to Mary who was sinless, to Joseph who was just, and to the Shepherds, who were spiritually poor and watchful. Finally, we have the revelation to the intelligent, beautifully expressed. Fr. Ratzinger shows us the proper use of intelligence. This is how he described the qualities of God:

We may not ascribe to God anything nonsensical or irrational, or anything that contradicts His creation.

So to become more God-like, we need to strive to be sensible, rational, and consistent. *Pace* certain irrationalists and fideists, the true religion is not irrational, although it transcends reason. Rene Guenon asserts nothing different.

Fr. Ratzinger makes some important affirmations. The Magi represent certain types, from which he concludes:

- They represent the religions moving toward Christ.
- They represent the self-transcendence of science toward him.
- They are the successors of Abraham who set off on a journey in response to God’s call.
- They are the successors of Socrates and his habit of questioning above and beyond conventional religion toward the higher truth.

In summary, Christ is not just the fulfillment of the religion of the Hebrews, but also that of the pagans. He is known not just to the priests and prophets, but also to the philosophers and scientists.

The key point is this: the wise men from the east are a new beginning. They represent the journeying of humanity toward Christ. They initiate a procession that continues throughout history. Not only do they represent the people who have found the way to Christ: they represent the inner aspiration of the human spirit, the dynamism of religions and human reason toward him.

The Star It is seldom helpful to speculate about likely, or more often not-very-likely, stories to try to harmonize theological accounts with alleged historical and scientific events. So rather than postulating some sort of supernova, there is another way to look at it. In any event, the reliance on a supernatural star destroys the whole inner meaning of the story, which depends on the inner attitude of the Magi, not some external compulsion.

In the year 7 BC (the most probable year for Jesus' birth), there was a conjunction of Jupiter and Saturn in the constellation Pisces (the Fish). Jupiter was the highest deity and would have been brightest in the evening alongside Saturn. Saturn represented the Jewish people, since Saturn was identified with Yahweh (they shared the same day of the week: Saturday). The Babylonian astronomers could conclude this: the birth in the land of the Jews of a ruler who would bring salvation. Of course, this was not compelling in itself, but depended on the Magi's inner state of expectation. Fr. Ratzinger writes:

This implies that the cosmos speaks of Christ. The language of creation provides a great many pointers. It gives man an intuition of the Creator.

Here we can recall Guenon who wrote that Creation is the reflection of the Logos, the first Thought of God. This is the message to the wise. For others:

The knowledge that emerges from creation, and acquires concrete form in the religions, can also become disoriented, so that it no longer prompts man to transcend himself, but induces him to lock himself into systems with which he believe he can, in some way, oppose the hidden powers of the world.

A further point is that astrology, at least as understood, came to an end with the Magi. The ancients regarded the heavenly bodies as divine powers determining men's fate. Now we understand that Christ conquered all the powers and forces in the heavens and reigns over the entire universe. It is not the star that determines the child's destiny, it is the child that directs the star.

Posted on 2015-01-05 by Cologero

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Dennis on 2017-01-04 at 16:39 said:

"7 BC (the most probable year for Jesus' birth)". Um no. What is your evidence for this claim? I've never heard a claim for his birth year earlier than 4 BC. I also recommend you read "Chronicle of the Living Christ" by Robert Powell (translator of Tomberg), which presents a detailed and convincing argument for putting the birth of Christ at December 6, 2 BC.

Cologero on 2017-01-04 at 22:01 said:

Thanks for clearing that up for us, Dennis. I am familiar with Powell's argument but disagree with such a purely quantitative approach.

Ultimately, it is not the year that matters, but rather the idea that the birth of Christ is tied to the Winter Solstice, after which "darkness decreases and light increases". See *The Mystery of Christmas* by Dom Prosper Guéranger for a more complete explanation. (H/T Carman)

http://traditioninaction.org/religious/g009_Mystery.htm

6.6 The Holy Grail

All that He wrought among them, all that He said and suffered, He disposed in such wise that not a single moment was passed without mystery, not a single letter was devoid of some mystery.

SAINT BERNARD, *Sermon III on Palm Sunday*

In particular, if Christ died on the cross, it can be said that this was by reason of the symbolic value which the cross possesses in itself and which has always been recognized by all traditions; thus, without diminishing in any way its historical significance, the latter may be regarded as directly derived from the symbolical significance that goes with it.

RENE GUENON, *Symbolism of the Cross*

Since it was the day of Preparation, in order to prevent the bodies from remaining on the cross on the sabbath, the Jews asked Pilate that their legs might be broken, and that they might be taken away. So the soldiers came and broke the legs of the first, and of the other who had been crucified with him; but when they came to Jesus and saw that he was already dead, they did not break his legs. But one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once there came out blood and water.

JOHN 19:31-34

There are many legends about the Holy Grail, but there will be no attempt to write a documentary. Instead we will focus on one interpretation in particular, because it reveals the theological and metaphysical significance of the Grail, namely Sergius Bulgakov's essay on the Grail which is an extended meditation on John 19:34.

Primordial Tradition The Grail Legend begins with Seth, the third son of Adam and Eve, who was able to rescue the Grail from the Edenic Garden. Then he passed this on so that the Primordial Tradition was never lost to humanity.

The Sufi Suhrawardi also traces it back to Seth (and ultimately to Hermes). He lists Greek philosophers, Persian kings, and Muslim mystics, so the Primordial Tradition was not unknown. Persian sages included the Magi who visited the infant Jesus in Bethelhem.

The purpose of the Grail was not fulfilled until it received the Blood and the Water of Christ.

The Death of Christ The most common legend is that Joseph of Arimathea captured the blood of Christ in the Grail. Even so, the Cup could not have held all of it, so we can ignore it in Bulgakov's account. Bulgakov points out that Jesus was already dead before the spear was thrust into his side, an anomaly that demands an explanation.

Metaphysically, death is the separation of the soul from the body. Nevertheless, His body did not undergo corruption (Acts 2:31), so there was still a connection of the spirit to the body. Hence, the body was alive although in a state of deep sleep and unconsciousness. This is remarkably close to the definition of the causal body. Since the body was alive, in a sense, the spear caused the blood and water to flow out; Christ's body was then without blood and water.

The Meaning of Blood Blood has special significance because it is both material and psychical; thus, it unites the gross body to the animal soul (or life body). The soul, of blood, is intermediate between the body and the spirit. The animal soul lives in the blood; at death, it decays along with the body. The animal soul is not immortal. The human spirit is immortal and animates the soul and indirectly, the body.

Christ's soul was separated from His body after the spear was thrust into his side. The Resurrection restored the soul and blood to the body. That is the blood of the Eucharist. The blood is related in two senses:

- I. The blood is the body of the spirit, the I.

2. The blood contains the soul of the body

The Mystery of Golgotha Valentin Tomberg, from a different perspective, comes to a similar conclusion:

With the Mystery of Golgotha, when the blood of Jesus Christ flowed onto the ground, a force was planted in human blood and in the Earth's soil; it counteracted the demonic element in the blood and the enslaving influence of the subterranean spheres that works through the soil. This counterinfluence causes human blood to carry not only the subjective illusions of demonic airs, but also the objective impulse of conscience. In addition, this influence not only robs the ground of its enslaving power, but it also speaks of nature's yearning and hope for redemption through humankind. Through it, human blood receives the capacity to reflect moral and spiritual truth, just as natural water reflects the sky; the ground, however, "receives blood," and thus the capacity of "groaning together with the whole creation."

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Christ and Sophia*

The Sanctification of Creation The blood and water that flowed from Christ's side into the world, now abides in the world. Bulgakov writes:

Through the stream of Christ's precious blood and water that flowed out of his side, all creation was sanctified—heaven and earth, our earthly world, and all the stellar worlds. The image of the **Holy Grail** expresses precisely the idea that the world received His holy relic in the blood and water ... The whole world is the chalice of the Holy Grail.

That is why it is hidden in the world from the world. There are exceptions:

It exists in the world as an invisible power, and it becomes visible, appears to pure human hearts who are worthy of its appearance.

In other words, it does not appear to the gross body but only to the life body (or etheric body), which is why the search continues.

Ascension and Second Coming The Ascension into Heaven does not refer to a spatial event. Heaven is not a “place” somewhere in the cosmos. Rather it indicates a change of state; that is, it refers to the glorification and deification of Christ’s human substance. For that reason, it becomes inaccessible to human perception.

That change of state began with the Resurrection when Christ appeared to his disciples. Even after the Ascension, he appeared to Paul. So his abiding in Heaven does not preclude his appearance on Earth.

Likewise, the Second Coming does not refer to a spatial change, the journey from Heaven to Earth. On the contrary, it refers to a change in human beings so that Christ will become visible to those prepared to “see” him. The Holy Spirit manifests and realizes Christ in them. But first the soul must be purified so that it accurately reflects the Holy Spirit. Then Christ will be born from the union of the Spirit and the body. See *The Word is Made Flesh*.



The Kingdom of Christ The blood and earth restore liberates humanity from its bondage, or at least its possibility. Tomberg explains:

For humanity this influence on blood and earth means the restoration of equilibrium in these regions and hence the establishment of freedom. Now it depends upon human beings themselves whether they will yield to the enslaving influence of earth and the phantasm-producing influence of blood, or whether they will view the whole

earthly globe as the victim of the fall of humanity and make blood the bearer of conscience.

Bulgakov announces this restoration in the colorful phrase, “The Great Pan is dead!” By this is meant that the Prince of the World has been cast out of his role and that the World is now the Kingdom of Christ. Even Nature has been changed. The natural world is no longer an obstacle, it is not evil in itself. Rather humanity has been given new powers for the establishment of the Kingdom of God, not only within use, but in the midst of us. A new civilization arises.

Although Satan has been removed as Prince of the World, he still lingers to tempt humanity. Tomberg provides a more complete picture:

The establishment of equilibrium (and with it, human freedom) is not the only result of the Mystery of Golgotha. It was also the beginning of a gradual retrieval of Lucifer’s territory. The spirit who had severed this territory from the region of the hierarchies of good now experienced an inner conversion through the Mystery of Golgotha. True, that conversion initially concerned only Lucifer himself and not, say, the Luciferic influence in human beings—which is still active in the old direction and can be changed only by human beings themselves.

Redemption

Most probably we are in Eden still. It is only our eyes that have changed.

G K CHESTERTON

After the Fall, humanity lost the constant awareness of God (or, lost sanctifying grace); nature fell under the dominion of Satan and was resistant to human effort.

Redemption is the restoration of the status quo ante before the Fall. That means the state in which there is the awareness of God's presence in the life body; nature itself has been changed. But just as the Serpent was in the Garden, Lucifer is still present among us, not as Lord, but as tempter. He has no power over us unless by our consent.

References Sergius Bulgakov, *The Holy Grail and the Eucharist*
Valentin Tomberg, *Christ and Sophia*
Sayyed Nasr, *Three Muslim Sages*
Rene Guenon, *Symbolism of the Cross*

Posted on 2021-04-03 by Cologero

* * *

Paulo Adolpho on 2021-04-05 at 23:47 said:

Cologero, why god created lucifer, knowing that one day he would turn his back on him. God really likes to see the circus on fire?

6.7 The Seven Miracles as an Esoteric School

The mission of Christ and Mary is to reverse the effects of the Fall and restore the creation to its original perfect state when the Logos and Sophia brought it forth (Proverbs 8 22:31³). Each of the seven miracles of St. John's Gospel corresponds to the reverse day of Genesis and restores to creation the grace bestowed by that day's miracle. The seven sacraments of the Church are based on the magic of evoking these miracles.



³<http://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=Proverbs+8&version=NKJV>

What I intend to show is that the last gospel is in fact an initiatic text, and that the seven miracles are intended to be a practical esoteric school which corresponds with the other western Traditions. As far as I know, it was the Catholic Hermeticist Valentin Tomberg⁴ who first elucidated this esoteric school in his last book, *Lazurus Come Forth!*⁵. My spiritual practice and this essay owes much to it.

By applying the lessons of the seven miracles we spiritually grow, with the first miracle developing the faculties needed to master the latter ones. Like learning any set of skills that build on each other, you do not completely master a subject before progressing to the next. It can be compared to building a pyramid; laying down two bricks at the foundation allows you to place a brick on the second level; laying down three bricks on the first level allows you to build two on the second level and one on the third, etc. One simultaneously works on all levels which one can, always coming back to the basics as they are the foundation on which all the other levels depend.

Putting too much effort into the higher levels before one has prepared the foundation can be counter productive. For example, attempting to master the fifth miracle of walking on water (i.e. to make the will effortlessly immune to desire) by engaging in ascetic practices will likely fail if one hasn't become competent in the four preceding miracles, creating a large shadow which blocks the power from the lower chakras rather than putting their power at the disposal of the higher self.

This is like taking a brick and trying to suspend it five layers above the ground all by itself; it's just going to fall to the ground with no foundation under it. The capstone of the pyramid is the alchemic marriage; the spiritualization of matter; attaining the Resurrection Body, the fruit of the raising of Lazarus.

⁴https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Valentin_Tomberg

⁵<http://www.amazon.com/Lazurus-Come-Forth-Valentin-Tomberg/dp/15>

Each miracle will be listed, followed by the corresponding miracle of Genesis and sacrament, followed by some commentary.

The Turning of Water into Wine at the Wedding *The union of God and His creation on the hallowing of the day of rest of the seventh day, i.e. the marriage of Heaven and Earth – The Sacrament of Marriage*

Evokes the joyful celebration of God's union to His creation, the way wine at its best induces that state of ease and enjoyment which is proper to a joyous occasion. This corresponds to that other Christian esoteric school, the Tarot, which starts by teaching the same state with The Juggler/Magician card, who to successfully keep all the balls in the air must enter into the same lucid care free state of conscious. If he tries too hard to focus on the task or any individual ball he will drop them; to succeed he must stop trying and allow his awareness to expand past the individual objects he juggles.

Likewise, to be spiritually fruitful we need to change our everyday water (i.e. the mind which reflects objects) into the playful ease of wine (lucid experience, what psychologist have rediscovered as 'flow'⁶). This creates the state of 'concentration without effort' in which your work becomes married to heaven.

Specifically, when one is in the state of flow of the Juggler or the Wedding Guest, one is so focused on the joyous experience of the moment that everything else disappears, including the sense of one's own self. With the ego empty, inspiration is able to both emerge from the deeper levels of the self which are normally entombed by the ego, and to pour into us from above. Most people are like block(head)s into which nothing can be poured; it's only when we cultivate empty space that we become like a glass in which power from heaven can be poured.

Cultivating this state purifies the root chakra (and correspondingly all the odd/mental chakras) which governs instinct, removing the fear and

⁶http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Flow_%28psychology%29

anxiety which blocks it so that kundalini can begin to spiral heavenward up the spine and nourish the other centers of the soul.

Besides a progressive freeing from anxiety, the fruit of learning this lesson is mystical experience, as one enters into a state where one from time to time feels the presence of God.

The Healing of the Nobleman's Son *The bringing forth of man and animals, each according to their kind on the sixth day – The Sacrament of Baptism*

According to Tomberg, this healing was accomplished by bringing the son out of horizontal hereditary with his earthly father, and restoring him to resonance with the original archetype of his perfect heavenly Father. Likewise, this miracle brings us out of fallen horizontal hereditary and reestablishes our vertical hereditary to the spiritual archetype we emanated from, the image of God; the death to the sins of the world and spiritual rebirth of the baptismal waters.

One can note that Shamanic totemic magic is based on this principle of establishing an alliance with the perfect animal spirits in heaven so as to be drawn toward their virtues. This type of magic is well and alive in the employment of sport team mascots.

Reestablishing the vertical connection will result in the fruit of Gnosis, which is merely a mystical experience revealing itself to consciousness. When we live in the vertical that which is above reveals itself to us below. It's worth noting that the second card of the Tarot, the High Priestess, is the card which teaches the principles of the gnostic sense.

The Healing of the Paralytic *The restoring of ensouled movement, in all directions; height, depth, and breadth; of the birds of the air and the fish of the sea on the fifth day – The Sacrament of Penance*

"Go forth and sin no more." The Paralytic's condition was due to his sin, as evidenced by the Master's words after he had been healed. Sin

enslaves and takes away our freedom, especially when we try to hide it within ourselves. The Persian branch of the Aryan tradition held that the greatest value was truth, and therefore the greatest sin one could commit was to lie. One could argue then that the gravest sin is to try and deny our own sins and hide them from ourselves. God will forgive us all our sins, on the prerequisite that we fully acknowledge them.

There's a lot I could say about this, as it relates directly to my vocation as a healer and massage therapist. People have all types of things they don't like about themselves, and usually they try to keep them from fully entering their consciousness. For example, they might detest one of their coworkers and want to give them a well deserved punch to the face. But if they did that they'd lose their job, plus they like to think of themselves as a good person, and good people don't get angry and violent, so they repress the impulse. On the physical level this produces nervous disorder⁷; the subconscious prevents an unpleasant emotion or thought from reaching consciousness or the motor nerves, which results in the buried signal being held as an electric charge in the body, tightening the surrounding muscles.

Often when I work on someone I can feel the stuck emotion which is tightening the muscles. To treat them I allow the blocked emotion in the psyche and nerves to flow again, and the muscle goes back to normal, restoring ease of movement. Confession, when done right, allows people to acknowledge emotions they'd otherwise keep bottled up, thus healing them. This process purifies the second chakra which governs emotion (and correspondingly the other even emotional chakras), which is blocked by guilt.

The fruit of learning the third lesson is magic, which is simply the execution of that which is revealed by gnosis. Mysticism bears fruit by revealing itself as gnosis to consciousness, and gnosis bears fruit by becoming magic and flowing out into the world.

⁷http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_E._Sarno

Continuing the correspondence to the tarot, the third card of the Tarot, the Empress, is the card that teaches sacred magic. The Empress holds a shield with an eagle on it. This is the aim of sacred magic, to defend the freedom (the eagle) of all ensouled beings, the movement through the heights, breadth, and depth which is taken away by retained sin.

Caution and Conclusion I will caution you that there's a reason the full extent of most people's emotions are sealed. If their full force were made manifest the world would become a very brutal place. As one of my shamanic instructors warned us, in traditional societies no parent wants their child to become a shaman, because it's very poor life insurance. Not all magic is sacred, and the soul is fragmented into both good and evil. Both come flowing out and manifesting themselves as the Work restores movement to the soul. I have had multiple people end up hospitalized after my heart cursed them, directing uncontrolled but sustained hatred their way. For example, the day I began unsealing my emotions toward my stepmother, she, who had been in robust health (my family follows my lead in eating paleo), ended up being hospitalized with intense pains whose cause could not be pinpointed.

This is why the two previous steps come first. Without them the unsealing of the soul's power would result in the Luciferian raising up of our arbitrary personal will and the uncontrolled releasing of demonic sorcery from the subconscious. In Traditional Orders this was guarded against by grades of initiation, to make sure the initiate was spiritually mature enough to face the next step, and the whole process was overseen by experienced masters. In the Kali Yuga it is very difficult to find such an Order, so the dangers are increased.

The Christian path has always been Purification, Illumination, and Union, the fruits of which are Mysticism, Gnosis, and Magic. In alchemy these are accomplished through 'The work in black', 'The work in white', and 'The work in red' of lead, mercury, and sulfur; in the Tarot they are

taught by the first three cards of ‘The Juggler’, ‘The High Priestess’, and ‘The Empress’; and in the Gospel of St. John the keys to realizing the work are contained in the first three miracles. As Gornahoor has pointed out, there is unity underlying the western tradition, and one can find all the essential esoteric elements needed for the Work hiding in plain sight within Christianity, which is the most accessible to those of us of the west.

Part 2 will continue with the remaining miracles. Before that will be an article expanding on the first two miracles; specifically how one can cultivate the mystic’s ‘emptiness’ by contemplating and linking ones breath to the vertical originating archetype of God’s breath which brought forth the Void and Sophia.

Posted on 2014-03-12 by Caleb

* * *

francismercuri on 2014-03-12 at 01:03 said:

Thank you—this is most excellent. It happens to have appeared here in quite a timely fashion, as currently this evening my readings and note taking have involved Tomberg’s discussion of “The Chariot” in his “Meditations”, where he also addresses these very “Seven archetypal miracles”, and their correspondence with the “Seven ‘I Am’ statements of Christ. His “departure point” in that meditation, is the account of Christ’s temptation in the wilderness, which also was the RC Rite Gospel reading for this past, first Sunday of Lent. Looking forward to your next installments.

scardanelli on 2014-03-12 at 09:44 said:

Indeed... thank you for this Caleb. I have read Lazarus, Come Forth! previously, but for whatever reason, didn’t make the connection between the seven miracles and the first seven arcana of the Tarot. It certainly opens up new areas to explore.

Frazer M on 2014-03-12 at 13:40 said:

As a handy reference, here follows the miracles/“I am” statement pairings as given by Tomberg in his meditation on The Chariot. All chapters/verses refer to the Gospel of John:

1. Wedding of Cana (2)/"I am the true vine (15:1)
2. Healing the noble's son (4:46)/"I am the Way, Truth, and Life" (14:6)
3. Pool of Bethesda (5:2)/"I am the door/gate" (10:9)
4. Feeding of 5000/multiplication of loaves (6)/"I am the bread of Life" (6:35)
5. Walking on water (6)/"I am the good shepherd" (10:11)
6. Healing the man born blind (9)/"I am the light of the world" (8:12)
7. Raising Lazarus (11)/"I am the resurrection and the life" (14:6)

patriciakay3 on 2014-03-15 at 13:21 said:

Thanks so much! I look forward to Part 2... it's very helpful material.

skeleton cave on 2019-03-19 at 11:43 said:

That icon is taken at St. Seraphim's Orthodox Cathedral in Dallas, TX.

Tannheuser on 2022-03-31 at 14:46 said:

I suppose the subsequent sections discussed never ended up being published? It's too bad
– these reflections are a valuable supplement to Lazarus, Come Forth.

Advent Meditations

7.1 Week 1

Just as we celebrate and anticipate the Incarnation of the Logos on the material plane, so, too, we want to prepare for the analogous birth within the human soul. **Valentin Tomberg**, in Letter II, refers to the “second birth” as *Christian Yoga*. Hence, the elements of Christian Yoga are analogous to the stages of yoga described by **Patanjali** in the *Yoga Sutras*. In Letter XVI, *The Tower of Destruction*, these stages are related to the three stages of the spiritual life described by **St. John of the Cross**. Hence, we have a schema relating these yoga stages in three languages as exposed in Table 7.1.



Tomberg contrasts the Vedantic ideal with the Christian goal. The former, he says, leads to the extinction of consciousness, whereas the Christian goal is the “unity of two”. For more on the differences between Yoga and Christianity, see *Studies in the Psychology of the Mys-*

Sanskrit	Greek	English	Spiritual Life
Dharana	Catharsis	Concentration	Purification
Dhyana	Theoria	Meditation	Illumination
Samadhi	Theosis	Contemplation	Mystical Union

Table 7.1: Stages of Christian Yoga

tics by **Joseph Marechal, S.J.**¹, so we needn't be concerned about that topic at this point.

The Greek Mystic **Nicholas Cabasilas** in *The Life in Christ* explains that there are three obstacles to theosis. These are:

1. NATURE. The Divine nature is different from human nature.
2. SIN. A will corrupted by evil separate us from God.
3. DEATH. In the mortal body, we can see only the dim reflection in the mirror; in this state our bodies are dominated by sense life.

These obstacles are overcome by the following historical events respectively:

1. INCARNATION. This unites the human and divine natures in one person.
2. CRUCIFIXION. This leads to the forgiveness of sins.
3. RESURRECTION. This overcomes death and the attraction to sense life.

Cabasilas relates these ideas to the effects of the sacraments, or mysteries, with the aim of salvation. The esoteric path aims beyond this to liberation. That aim is union while still in the mortal body:

1. Purify our soul so it becomes the perfect reflector of the Holy Spirit.
2. Expose our false sense of I, replaced with the mind of Christ.
3. Move from a life of instinct to a life of intelligence and love.

The first step is concentration without effort, which depends on detachment and purification (See Letter XVI)

- DETACHMENT is the separation from “arbitrary, personal activity”. We are no longer absorbed in the minutiae of life, but are living on a higher level.
- PURIFICATION is the cleansing of the mirror by no longer being agitated by emotional disturbances, etc.

Spirit must become divine Breath in place of arbitrary, personal activity, and Water must become a perfect mirror of the divine Breath instead of being agitated by disturbances of the imagination, passions and personal desires. Reintegrated consciousness must be born of Water and Spirit, after Water has once again become Virginal and Spirit has once again become divine Breath or the Holy Spirit. Reintegrated consciousness therefore becomes born within the human soul in a way analogous to the birth or historical incarnation of the WORD.

Meditations on the Tarot. Letter II: The High Priestess

Posted on 2022-11-25 by Cologero

* * *

Balder on 2022-11-28 at 15:41 said:

You have almost converted me with Christmas Meditations. It seems I retain many of those things named animistic in the pamphlet and they are impossible to discard. Perhaps I should build upon them.

rui artur on 2022-11-30 at 08:36 said:

@ Balder,

there is nothing in the Christian revelation which is opposed to an animistic conception of reality – in fact, it presupposes it. Except perhaps some specific practices (but even those are liable to be syncretized).

Balder on 2022-12-01 at 04:14 said:

Rui Artur, I think you are right. But my worldview is thoroughly Pagan. Like the old pagan gnostics of old, I can only underwrite some aspects of the Christian dogma, creed and ethics, and also the metaphysics of Christianity because of its theological dimension is bereft of the total and higher significance of Aryan Metaphysics and esotericism, which I think (like Guénon) can be found from the Advaita Vedanta and from the Eastern Metaphysics, and from the Indo-European line. This is why I consider myself as a Gnostic Christo-Pagan. The parts of the Bible I highly value are some of the Torah, and from the New Testament especially the Gospel of John, Sermon on the Mount – which I consider to be the highest ethical teaching given to mankind as counsels of perfection – and the Apocalypse, which I consider to be Hyperborean teachings in origin.

As a person I still consider myself being largely under the impulse of the Finno-Ugric national spirit Lemminkäinen or Kaukomieli, or the Norse Balder, who like Osiris, Jesus and Tammuz and the like live, die, resurrect and live free in the new World in the New Heaven and Earth. The Ragnarök went already.

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-02 at 06:43 said:

I must mention that there has been an attempt to synthesize Christianity with the doctrine of Non-Dualism of the Vedanta. The book is called Christianity and the Doctrine of Non-Dualism, the writer “A Monk of the West”. It was quite a baffling reading I must admit.

<https://www.sophiaperennis.com/books/christianity/christianity-and-the-doctrine-of-non-dualism/>

Arthur Konrad on 2022-12-02 at 08:10 said:

Perennialism implies a belief that certain traditions contain teachings which have objective value, and that these traditions partially overlap, or overlap on important points (and on others

they don't). Therefore, to derive value from, or acknowledge the validity of a certain tradition is a matter of practicality, for people who approach this in a practical way. It is easy to see why going an inch further from this can lead to all sorts of extravagances, such as the Perennial Philosophy, Traditionalism, New Ageism, etc. This is of course, all very Western.

So, what is the practical value of having a 'Pagan worldview' nowadays? I'm asking this honestly. For it somehow applies that one has it, and another does not, so what in it is distinctly Pagan which is not in fact, in its positive aspects, merely Universal? Doing away with the whole concept of 'Paganism' is in my opinion, in the first order a matter of good education – is there anything more absurd than to call the Roman religion a 'Pagan' (i.e. 'rustic') religion? Or that of Athens or Babylon or Song?

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-03 at 11:03 said:

First of all, apologies for Cologero for taking this thread too far afield from the topic. I'll try to be as short as possible in my answer to Arthur.

@ Arthur Konrad, of course the term Pagan (or Heathen) is a controversial and not a very good one in that. I have, however, used the term to refer spiritualities of a non-abrahamic kind. In short, your message implies that practicality and utility trumps over idealism and truth. If you're a pragmatist and a utilitarian, go and choose to be an trans-sexual Atheist bright, I'm sure you'll be more welcomed in today's world than a Christian or a Pagan who sticks to their guns in the face of the onslaught of modernity.

There are some distinctive features of a Pagan worldview that separate it in its essential aspects from the Judeo-Christian and other revelations of the Abrahamic kind (the question of Monotheism being only one). Ancient Paganism, Hermeticism and Christianity are all essential parts of the Western mystery Tradition, and whatever we think about the first, it still runs in the veins of many, and with the words of Tomberg "one must love the pagan past". Universality, locality and particularism have all their appropriate places. Christ in this picture is the Corner Stone and the Lapis that the builders forgot and rejected.

Arthur Konrad on 2022-12-03 at 14:46 said:

@ Kaukomieli

'In short, your message implies that practicality and utility trumps over idealism and truth'
Truth is highly practical and utilitarian

'There are some distinctive features of a Pagan worldview that separate it in its essential aspects from the Judeo-Christian and other revelations of the Abrahamic kind'

The religion today corresponds very much to the impulses and character of the age. One aspect of our age's character is the insatiable greed for controversy.

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-03 at 15:25 said:

@ Arthur

"Truth is highly practical and utilitarian"

Then I just might suggest you go ahead and practice some chaos magic, lets say do the invocation of Bugs Bunny and tell us about the results of that meeting with the Christ Rabbit. Their motto is however, if it works, it's the truth.

"The religion today corresponds very much to the impulses and character of the age. One aspect of our age's character is the insatiable greed for controversy."

With following the impulse of Christ we get to eat that sacred super-wordly bread and to drink that sacred essence of holy water which quenches our thirst eternally and would have made Odin himself happy when hanging on the Yggdrasil for nine days and nights. From the spirit of our Bloodline we are life loving joyous and proud pagans; Christ calls to us to transcendental, heavenly happiness.

Kaukomielä on 2022-12-03 at 16:21 said:

Christianity.....My views

Monotheism.....Panentheism / Monism / Non duality

Trinitarian Doctrine.....Nine-Fold Valknutr / Odin-Vili-Ve

Animal souls dissolve.....Animal souls transmigrate in the group soul

Only one life.....Transmigration / Re-incarnation (the term is debatable, God / Spirit is the only transmigrant)

A new soul in every birth.....Pre-Existence of the Soul

Strickt Patriarchy.....Norse / European temple of Priests and Priestesses (not Woman Priests)

Origin of Mazdaen dualism of Good and Evil.....Indo-European and Nordic-Hyperborean line of non duality

Man as Imago Dei.....confirmed also

Creationism.....Emanationism

God as Person the Consummation.....Doctrine of the Absolute

Solar Worship / Strickt Right Hand Path.....Synthesis of Solar and Lunar cults (the RHP / LHP)

Tendency to absolutism, fundamentalism, and even totalitarianism.....Plurality and Higher unity of multifaceted viewpoints

Strickt Orthodoxy.....No Heresy if practical ethics are in line

Judeo-Christian calendar year.....Hermetic Solar Year of Euinoxes and Solstices

Tendency to collectivism.....Aristocratic Ethics

Arthur Konrad on 2022-12-03 at 17:29 said:

I can only assume you verified all these things through personal insight

P.S. What is a Judeo-Christian calendar year?

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-04 at 19:59 said:

@ Arthur

"I can only assume you verified all these things through personal insight"

Yes. I deciphered them from the universal mind.

"What is a Judeo-Christian calendar year?"

I think Cologero is speaking a little about that in this topic.

Kaukomieli on 2022-12-04 at 20:48 said:

@Arthur, cordially and humbly: "Who is among you who gives you brother a stone (the doctrine) if he asks for bread (practical life wisdom)?"

You say: truth is practical and utilitarian. I ask you, is what is practical and useful the truth?

7.2 Week 2: Purity of Thought

The distinguishing mark of the Hermetic path is that it seeks to make dogmas and teachings "real" in consciousness. As Tomberg insists, this does not make it "better" than the exoteric teaching, only that it is a path that some are called to follow.

In this spirit, we can meditate on what **Christmas** means.

- The birth in the past of Christ the Redeemer.
- The expectation of Christ the Judge at the end of time.
- The birth of Christ in the soul eternally, now.

Redemption is the reversal of the effects of the Fall. The Hermetic Tradition calls this process "regeneration" as we seek to make that real in consciousness. The undoing of the Fall requires the second birth of Christ/Logos in the



Figure 7.1: Relic of the crown of thorns

soul. That is, the soul, as the passive element, reflects the activity of the Spirit. Disturbances in the soul — passions, images, desires, thoughts — will distort the reflection of spirit, just as disturbances on a pond distort its reflection of the surrounding forest.

It is this personal, subjective element that is at the root of such disturbances. Thus, the solution is to become more objective about oneself. That is to take the standpoint of Christ the Judge. Justice is possible only when the Judge is totally objective, not influenced by ignorance, opinion, personal preferences, or subjective passions. **Valentin Tomberg** writes in this regard:

The vow of *obedience* is the practice of silencing personal desires, emotions and imagination in the face of reason and conscience; it is the primacy of the ideal as opposed to the apparent, the nation as opposed to the personal, humanity as opposed to the nation, and God as opposed to humanity. It is the life of cosmic and human hierarchical ordering; it is the meaning and justification of the fact that there are Seraphim, Cherubim, Thrones; Dominions, Virtues, Powers; Principalities, Archangels, Angels; Priests, Knights and Commoners. Obedience is order: it is international law; it is the state; it is the Church; it is universal peace. True obedience is the very opposite of tyranny and slavery, since its root is the love which issues from faith and confidence. That which is above serves that which is below and that which is below obeys that which is above. Obedience is the practical conclusion to that which one recognises as the existence of something higher than oneself. Whosoever recognises God, obeys.

Yet that does not address the question of “how” to obey. We cannot obey as long as the subjective element has its grip on us; these are impure

elements that disturb the soul. Tomberg discusses the idea of purity in the context of the five wounds and three vows. We can summarize these in two stages: purity of thought and purity of will. These correspond to the head and the heart respectively.

Purity of thought is the “crown of thorns”. The following passages explain that symbol:

Thus every crown is essentially a crown of thorns. Not only is it heavy, but also it calls for a painful restraint with regard to the thought and free or arbitrary imagination of the personality.

Here true thought receives confirmation and subsequent illumination; false or irrelevant thought is riveted and reduced to impotence. The crown of the Emperor signifies the renunciation of freedom of intellectual movement, just as his arms and legs signify his renunciation of freedom of action and movement. He is deprived of the three so-called “natural” liberties of the human being — those of opinion, word, and movement.

The “crown of thorns” is borne, in principle, by every person capable of *objective* thought — the “crown of thorns” being given to the human being since the beginning of human history.

The lack of concentration allows arbitrary, free, or irrelevant thoughts and images to flourish in our consciousness. We need to renounce them so they can be replaced by true thoughts; the art of concentration will help in that regard.

Nicholas Cabasilas writes this in his commentary on the beatitude of “purity of heart”.

To cleanse one’s heart and to exercise one’s soul for sanctification — what striving or effort or exertion would effect this more than these thoughts and meditations? Yet, if one examines this carefully, one would not call it the effect of meditation on Christ, but rather of the meditation itself.

To be occupied with the noblest of thoughts means to abandon evil thoughts; but this is to be pure in heart. Our life and our birth are twofold, both spiritual and fleshly. By its desires, the spirit fights against the body and the body resists the spirit. Since it is impossible for contraries to be at peace and to join together, it is quite evident that one or other of the desires will by means of memory, gain control over the thoughts and cast the other out. The memory of the life and birth which are according to the flesh and concentration on such matters produce the most depraved desires and the uncleanness to which it leads. So likewise, when the soul by constant remembrance holds fast the birth of the baptismal washing, the divine Food which is appropriate to this birth, and the other things which belong to the new life, it is likely to lead desires from the earth to heaven itself.

We can extract these main points:

- There is our fleshly birth in the body and a second spiritual birth.
- There is an inner spiritual battle between lower (personal, subjective) thoughts and higher (spiritual, objective) thoughts
- “Constant remembrance” is necessary. In our terms, this is constant awareness, “concentration without effort”

Hermetically, this movement from fleshly to spiritual thoughts is a mystical evolution. This is the regeneration of the inner life from the Instincts to fully human life of the Intellect and Intuition.

For more on this, you could start with *Salvation and Evolution*².

As for the idea of regeneration, it is necessary to understand what the Fall entailed. Given Tomberg’s high opinion of Jacob Boehme, this summary of Boehme’s teaching may be helpful, especially the sections on the Fall of Lucifer and Adam’s Fall: *Christian Gnosis: Jacob Boehme*³.

²

³

Posted on 2022-12-02 by Cologero

7.3 Week 3: Purity of Will

It is futile to attempt to be concentrated if the Will is passionate about other things. The oscillations of the mind will never be able to achieve silence unless the Will itself infuses it with silence. Only the still Will can render the imagination and the intellect silent in concentration.

St. John of the Cross and **St. Theresa d'Avila** never tire of repeating that the concentration necessary for spiritual prayer is the fruit of the moral purification of the Will.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot*

Concentration can be applied on three planes:

- Mental
- Astral
- Physical

We began with learning concentration on the physical plane. Then we transferred that knowledge to our thoughts or mental plane. Finally, we will do the same to our emotional life for the purification of the soul.

Note that there are many more levels beyond these. In the *Letter on the Star*, Tomberg explains:

There are *twelve* degrees higher than that of the consciousness of the human transcendental Self. It is necessary, therefore, in order to attain to the ONE God, to elevate oneself successively to degrees of consciousness of the nine spiritual hierarchies and the Holy Trinity.

The Mental, Astral, and Physical correspond to the spirit, soul, and body. In the Letter on Judgment, Tomberg relates them to the Trinity. The undivided self, then, corresponds to the Unity of God.

Image and Likeness The idea of man being the “image and likeness” of God is a recurrent theme throughout *Meditations on the Tarot*. Although people today often like to repeat that we are all born in the “image and likeness” of God, that is not at all the Traditional teaching; rather, because of the Fall, we have lost the full likeness and it is the task of the Hermetist to restore it. Tomberg explains:

The ideal of alchemical *transformation* of Hermetism offers to human beings the way to the realisation of true human nature, which is the image and likeness of God. Hermetism is the re-humanisation of all elements of human nature; it is their return to their true essence. Just as all base metal can be transformed into silver and into gold, so are all the forces of human nature susceptible to transformation into “silver” or “gold”, i.e. into what they *are* when they share in the image and likeness of God.

If we are already in the “image and likeness of God”, then our level of being as such right now is perfect: i.e., there is no need for transformation, redemption, or regeneration.

The image of God, according to **St. Bernard**, is our “essential” being. In that case it must be our higher intellectual soul, which distinguishes humans from animals. It is unsullied, it has no negative part, it is free, it is the source of the “spark of God”, and so is perfect. However, we rarely live at that level of awareness. It is as though we own a penthouse suite, yet choose to live in the basement.

The likeness, on the other hand, is our soul life which reflects the image. This is — because of the various perturbations — what must be purified.

Emotions As was mentioned last time, personal emotions need to be silenced to make the soul capable of “receiving from above the revelation of the word, the life and the light.”

Now, the emotional center of our being, or the “astral” plane, has its own way of knowing. This is called the “cognitive power of the emotions”. This manner of knowing is quite different from that of the thinking center or mental plane. This knowing is episteme, the knowledge of the heart, beyond the dianoia of mental knowing. There is a higher emotional component concomitant with its knowing.

Our age is dominated by thinking, arguing, and so on. This dualistic thinking distorts the emotional center. Tomberg writes this about the relationship between the will and thinking:

Thus, it is not thought as such which allows the desire for personal greatness or the tendency towards megalomania, but rather *the will* which makes use of the head and which can take hold of thought and reduce it to the role of its instrument.

Organic humility, replacing the current of the will-to-greatness is not found in the head, but rather in the heart, i.e., it reaches the heart, penetrating from the right-hand side. Because it is there that the will-to-greatness has its origin and it is there from whence it takes hold of the head and makes it its instrument. This is why many thinkers and scientists want to think “without the heart” in order to be objective, which is an illusion, because one can in no way think without the heart, the heart being the activating principle of thought; what one can do is to think with a humble and warm heart instead of with a pretentious and cold heart.

When functioning well, the heart and the head cooperate. In the example of megalomania, on the other hand, we see that the will can take hold of the head, making it the servant of a disordered emotion. Common knowledge warns us about making decisions when in a negative emotional state, but that is often ignored. Moreover, it is even celebrated,

since an opinion stated with strong negative emotions is falsely given a higher value.

The other distortion is when the head tries to think without the heart under the guise of objectivity. This leaves our emotional range limited and underdeveloped.

Purity of Heart is to Will One Thing The inner life of the soul, in our present condition, does not present a unity. Rather, our desires, aspirations, passions, and so on, are in conflict with each other. First one dominates, then another, as though there were multiple separate “I’s” inhabiting, and even fighting for control over, the soul. Tomberg calls these “lost sheep” alluding to the Gospel story. He explains:

The soul’s faults and vices are not, fundamentally, monsters but rather, lost sheep. . . . As it is the same with all the soul’s faults and vices, we all have the mission of finding and bringing back to the flock (i.e. to the soul’s choral harmony) the lost sheep in ourselves. We are missionaries in the subjective domain of our own soul, charged with the task of the conversion of our desires, ambitions, etc. We have to *persuade* them that they are seeking the realisation of their dreams in a false way by showing them the true way. It is not a matter of commandment, but rather of the alchemy of the cross, i.e. making present an alternative way for our desires, ambitions, passions, etc. It is a matter, moreover, of the alchemical “marriage of opposites”.

Our alchemical task, then, is the transmutation of these multiple selves into a single I.

Posted on 2022-12-09 by Cologero

7.4 Week 4: Incarnation of the Logos

The tendency is certainly accentuated, if not prevalent, amongst contemporary Hermeticists to concern themselves more with the “Cosmic Christ” or the “Logos” than with the human person of the “Son of Man”, Jesus of Nazareth. More importance is attributed to the divine and abstract aspect of the God-Man than to his human and concrete aspect.

It was contact with the person of Jesus Christ which opened up the current of miracles and conversions. And it is the same even today.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Letter VIII: Justice*

With these words, Tomberg is warning us not to forget about the first coming of Jesus in the flesh, regarded as somehow inferior to an esoteric interpretation. A fortiori, the Hermetist’s goal is not to create an alternative or “better” religion. Nevertheless, there is always a stream of “New Age” gurus who claim something similar. For example, one such popular guru claims to have discovered the real meaning of all the religions, viz., what the Buddha “really” taught or what Christ “really” taught. He then claims that the religions have distorted those teachings and offer no authentic path. Although he came to that realization spontaneously, he will teach you certain “modalities” for a hefty price to reach the same realization. This is the sin of simony, the notion that spiritual enlightenment is a commodity that can be bought and sold.

The idea of the Logos was not unknown to pagan philosophers and Hermeticists prior to the first Christmas. However, it is the fact of the Incarnation that matters most, as St John pointed out in the remarkable claim that the Logos became flesh. So Jesus is not only the fulfillment of the Mosaic law, He is also the fulfillment of the natural law. This is made clear by the visit of the Magi.

Tomberg makes us wrestle with a philosophical conundrum. The thinking mind, restricted to *dianoia*, knows essences, and the Logos is “the fundamental universal [or essence] of the world”. And Jesus Christ is then the “particular of particulars”. Some minds, like that of the new age guru, see that as representing a limitation on their thought; hence they resort to a sort of Docetism which denies the need for the physical, including a birth, visible church, sacraments and so on. It is a small step, then, to reach the conclusion that there is no need for the purification of the head and the heart in order to reach higher states.

Since for God, essence and existence are One, to know God is to know both his essence and existence. Tomberg explains that

Christian Hermeticism itself can only be knowledge of the universal which is revealed in the particular.

Hence, the Christian Hermetist “aspires to mystical experience of the communion of beings through love”. Thus he seeks spiritual friendships in the particular.

Yet, not unlike the pagan Hermetists — his precursors — or even the new ager perhaps, he also seeks the mystical experience of communion with the Logos, i.e., the knowledge of the universal.

Spiritual Beings Fr. Reginald Garrigou-Lagrange tells us that the angels know intuitively, not rationally. Each higher level of angel understands more through the knowledge of ever more encompassing principles. Tomberg asserts:

For Hermeticism there are no “principles”, “laws”, and “ideas” which exist outside of individual beings, not as structural traits of their nature, but as entities separated and independent from it.

This makes perfect sense, since knowing and being are one. If an angel, then, “knows” a certain principle, it is ipso fact the embodiment of that principle. Ideas have no power on their own, they are purely passive. An idea has effects only when it is immanent in a being. We can choose to understand our environment as an abstraction, the mere interplay of impersonal forces. Or else, we can choose to understand it as a great drama of personal forces.

A recent episode of the Vikings series on the History Channel had an interesting scene. Rollo was a Viking warrior who converted to Catholicism and was rewarded with the Duchy of Normandy. Unable to totally forget his pagan past, he explained to his wife, “When you hear thunder, it is only thunder. But when I hear thunder, I hear the sound of Thor.” He was still at the level of original participation in Owen Barfield’s sense. Can we recover that state of original participation?

Tomberg tells us we must “love our pagan past”, so perhaps we can learn something from Rollo. Now this is not a new teaching, but actually something we forgot. So perhaps we can try to remember. The mystic visionary, Catherine Emmerich, saw that the world was populated with angels: each country, city, diocese, and parish has its own guardian angel. Fr. Ripperger, in a youtube video⁴, reminds us furthermore that each generation has “generational spirits”, not all benign, as a sort of Zeitgeist.

If we can overcome the Zeitgeist of scientism, we can meditate on our role in the cosmic hierarchy. See yourself in relation to your family, parish or other community, nation, Church, then ascending through the angelic hierarchy. And when you get to the Logos, see also the Baby in the manger.

Posted on 2022-12-16 by Cologero

⁴https://youtu.be/mpJgVAsø2Dc?si=DRtUFauKacdQ_HyN

Meditations on the Angels

8.1 Gods and Angels

As a man of science, I cannot be any other than a pantheist; as an artist, it is impossible for me to be other than a polytheist; as for being human—that is also taken care of.

GOETHE

Goethe has a threefold inner attitude towards existence. He was *wholly* a scientist and had thus to see in the whole of nature the revelation of the Deity. He was *wholly* an artist and had to recognize the individual qualities of the Divine. And he was wholly human... Although not directly mentioned, the third element in his spiritual makeup was the ideal of Christ.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Inner Development*

There has been a movement of late to promote polytheism as the authentic tradition of the West. This is justified by three arguments:

- **Etiology.** Polytheism is allegedly associated with Europeans and monotheism with Semites.
- **Instrumentalism.** Polytheism leads the believer to a certain set of values judged to be superior to values of believers in monotheism.
- **Tradition.** Polytheism is the authentic Tradition of the West.

None of these arguments addresses the question of the truth of polytheism, nor do they define it properly. The proponents of the first two arguments can be said to be invincibly ignorant, since they are naïve about metaphysics and don't fully grasp the significance of their position.

However, the proponents of Tradition are deliberately ignorant, since there is no support in Guenon, nor even in Evola, to justify their position. "Tradition" does not mean a return to the forms of the past, something that, in any case, is quite impossible.

In his essay *Monotheism and Angelology* (from which we quote below), Rene Guenon exposes the nature of the error that gives rise to polytheism. First of all,

polytheism consists in admitting the existence of a plurality of totally independent principles, whereas these are secondary aspects of the supreme principle. This lack of understanding is the result of a failure to understand those traditional truths that refer to the divine aspects or attributes.

While individuals may believe this error, in the general case, it reflects the degeneration of a traditional from about to disappear. No tradition whatsoever could ever be polytheist. In particular, any theory of the evolution from polytheism to monotheism [e.g., that of Comte], is the reversal of the normal order of things.

All genuine tradition is essentially monotheistic, that is, it affirms above all the oneness of the Supreme Principle — or more strictly

speaking, “non-duality” — from which everything is derived and on which it entirely depends. Let’s be clear that polytheism and monotheism apply to the religious plane, and Principle is the corresponding idea at the metaphysical level.

Nevertheless, monotheism is not incompatible with a multiplicity of divine attribute and even with angels, understood as representing or expressing certain divine attributes within the order of supra-formal manifestation.

Angels exist in all traditions, and the Devas of Hinduism correspond to the angels of the Semitic religions. There is no question of “borrowing” from one religion to another. “Angels” are not mere ideas or irrational beliefs.

Angels are supra-formal states of being, and they are actually higher states of Being. Understood in this sense, we could even regard the Norse, Greek and Roman gods and goddesses as angelic beings, provided we look beyond the sentimental portrayal of the angels in Christian art. But in no way are they independent principles; they are valid to the extent that they reflect the attributes of the One principle.

CONCLUSION: The re-emergence of polytheism is not a reflection of a revolt against the modern world, but rather of an acquiescence to it. *It is a symptom of the degeneration of the modern world.*

Posted on 2010-06-27 by Cologero

* * *

Francis A. Mercuri on 2010-06-28 at 00:11 said:
Excellent review Charles.

To all of this, can be added Guenon’s additional arguments contra an absolute “polytheism” (presented in a highly consolidated manner as follows):

1. The Metaphysical Absolute as such, although infinite, can not truly be spoken of, since it transcends all limitations. Any attempt at defining the Absolute, immediately generates a limit, and the conceived "Absolute" ceases to be so. However, it is somewhat feasible to regard the Absolute in terms of containing all "Possibilities", or "Total Possibility", which are in tandem, the Possibilities of Being, and the Possibilities of Non-Being.
2. Being is the Principle of manifestation. As it is the Principle, and not manifestation itself, Being is never manifested, and remains always "outside" of manifestation. Yet, Being is responsible for manifestation, when it acts in a "determining", and "organizing" fashion upon the possibilities situated within Non-Being. But, where then "is" Being?
3. Non-Being is the Principle (or pole) of non-manifestation, containing within itself obviously, all Possibilities that remain un-manifest, in "equilibrium". Since Being, although the pole of manifestation, never manifests, as the Principle of manifestation, Being is ultimately "contained" within Non-Being; all of which returns both Principles to the Absolute, or "Total Possibility", in an ultimately "non-dual" manner.
4. Based on 1,2, and 3, it is "impossible" that a plurality of equal "Absolutes" could exist in competition among each other, and therefore any "polytheism" must ultimately, to avoid contradiction, come to regard its various "deities", as equivalent to the so-many "determinations" arranged by Being; and although such "attributes" might eventually, when retraced, lead back to their origin in "Total Possibility", to argue that any one of them, limited as they are, by their very constitution, can be equated with "God", or "The Absolute", is to blatantly reject, or ignore, any "notion" of an Absolute as "metaphysical Infinity".

8.2 The True Horoscope

Man alone is capable of communion with God. For to man alone among the living creatures does God speak: at night through dreams, by day through the intellect. And He uses every means to foretell and prefigure the future blessings that will be given to those worthy of Him.

SAINT ANTONY THE GREAT

The True is the good of the intellect.

DANTE

The first stage of [esoterism] is attained when one enters conscious interaction with the beings of the angelic hierarchy. [It] does not involve knowledge of universal laws, but entering conscious interaction with the beings who know the mysteries of birth. The true horoscope will not be reached by a path of calculation but through a path of interaction with suprasensory beings. What angels have imparted to humankind is the horoscope in the true sense.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Old Testament***Free Will is the Greatest Gift**

The greatest gift that in his largess God
Creating made, and unto his own goodness
Nearest conformed, and that which he doth prize
Most highly, is the freedom of the will,
Wherewith the creatures of intelligence
Both all and only were and are endowed.

DANTE, *Paradiso*

Dante learns an interesting lesson on Mercury: Humanity used free will to fall into sin by Adam's rejection of the Supreme Good. He took it on himself to know good and evil. and endured the just consequences of what was done freely. He thereby cut humanity off from higher influences, which was then left to its own devices. The two obvious solutions are unworkable.

1. One option is for humanity to save itself. That hardly seems possible since no political program, medical procedure, pharmaceutical, eugenic practice, educational technique, etc., has proved efficacious.

2. Or else, God could simply pardon Adam, but that would negate the whole point of free will.

A crime demands restitution. In this context, the crucifixion was paradoxically both a just penalty against humanity's sin and also a crime against Christ.

Providence

A generated nature its own way
Would always make like its progenitors,
If Providence divine were not triumphant.

On Venus, the discussion turned to Providence. Francesco da Buti, who wrote a commentary on the *Divine Comedy* in the 14th century, in which he lists both the negative and positive astrological influences of the planets. Regarding them, he concludes:

All are not found in one man, but a part in one, and a part in another, according to Divine Providence; and the wise man adheres to the good, and overcomes the others.

In other words, the planetary effects do not compel on their own, but all ultimately are subject to Divine Providence. A fortiori, Providence even supersedes genetic and family influences. Otherwise, without being open to higher influences, nothing could change in the world. Moreover, the wise man can pick and choose which influences to follow.

Vows Since free will is the greatest gift to humanity, so a vow, which is the voluntary suspension of free will, is a sacrifice of great worth. The three traditional vows are obedience, poverty, and chastity. Valentin Tomberg describes their esoteric meaning:

- The vow of **obedience** is the silencing of personal desires, emotions and imagination in the face of reason and conscience; it is the primacy of the ideal as opposed to the apparent, the nation as opposed to the personal, humanity as opposed to the nation, and God as opposed to humanity. It is the life of cosmic and human hierarchical ordering. That which is above serves that which is below and that which is below obeys that which is above.
- The vow of **poverty** is the practice of inner emptiness, which is established as a consequence of the silencing of personal desires, emotions and imagination so that the soul is capable of receiving from above the revelation of the word, the life and the light. Poverty is perpetual active vigil and expectation before the eternal sources of creativity; it is the soul awaiting what is new and unexpected; it is the aptitude for learning always and everywhere.
- The vow of **chastity** means the resolution to live according to solar law. Although virtue is boring and vice is disgusting, that which lives at the foundation of the heart is neither boring nor disgusting. The foundation of the heart is love. The heart lives only when it loves. It is then like the sun. And chastity is the state of the human being in which the heart, having become solar, is the centre of gravity.

The True Horoscope

The power and motion of the holy spheres,
As from the artisan the hammer's craft,
Forth from the blessed motors must proceed.
The heaven, which lights so manifold make fair,
From the Intelligence profound, which turns it.

The heavenly planets do not move on their own according to some fixed immutable physical law, but rather are moved by the angelic hierarchy.

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, in his commentary, points out this correspondence:

The Intelligences, ruling and guiding the several heavens (receiving power from above, and distributing it downward, taking their impression from God and stamping it like a seal upon the spheres below), according to Dionysius the Areopagite are as follows:

- The Seraphim – Primum Mobile
- The Cherubim – The Fixed Stars
- The Thrones – Saturn
- The Dominions – Jupiter
- The Virtues – Mars
- The Powers – The Sun
- The Principalities – Venus
- The Archangels – Mercury
- The Angels – The Moon

Valentin Tomberg makes this perfectly clear:

The spiritual world is not a world of laws, principles and ideas; it is a world of spiritual beings — human souls, Angels, Archangels, Principalities, Powers, Virtues, Dominions, Thrones, Cherubim, Seraphim and the Holy Trinity: the Holy Spirit, the Son and the Father.

Takeaway In order to understand your horoscope, i.e., your place in the world, your nature and destiny, it is necessary to know the spiritual beings active in your life. For example,

- Your Guardian Angel, who is an all too often neglected aspect of your life
- The archangels who influence your space: family, nation, etc.

- The principalities, the spirits of time (zeitgeist), who are guides through history

This is a partial list. Moreover, there are malignant spirits simultaneously influencing your life. Generational spirits may even attach themselves to families for years.

Anne Catherine Emmerich saw how these angelic influences are assigned at birth:

I have seen that everyone receives two spirits at birth, one good, the other evil. The good one is heavenly by nature and belongs to the lowest hierarchy; the evil one is not a devil, not yet in torments, though deprived of the vision of God.

Her vision leaves open the possibility that the evil one could even be redeemed.

Saint Diadochos of Photiki in the *Philokalia* shows how they can act in two ways:

Spiritual knowledge teaches us that there are two kinds of evil spirits: some are more subtle, others more material in nature. The more subtle demons attack the soul, while the others hold the flesh captive through their lascivious enticements. Thus there is a complete contrast between the demons that attack the soul and those that attack the body, even though they have the same propensity to inflict harm on mankind. When grace does not dwell in a man, they lurk like serpents in the depths of the heart, never allowing the soul to aspire towards God. But when grace is hidden in the intellect, they then move like dark clouds through the different parts of the heart, taking the form of sinful passions or of all kinds of day-dreams, thus distracting the intellect from the remembrance of God and cutting it off from grace.

Ultimate control is always under Divine Providence.

DEUS VULT

Posted on 2020-11-11 by Cologero

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Patricia Kay on 2022-11-11 at 16:40 said:

Would you give a brief description of these intelligences? I'm not sure what "principalities" or "thrones" or "dominions" are?

Cologero on 2022-11-11 at 16:51 said:

Tomberg recognizes that few people are able to experience the Divine Light in its fullness. The task of the angelic hierarchy, therefore, is to attenuate the Light in a manner appropriate to each one as it descends through the hierarchy. The esoteric path then is to reverse course and ascend through the hierarchy. To quote:

Each lower rank of hierarchy is a "moon" in relationship to the "sun" of the rank above it.

The angels transmit the tumultuous, strong impulses of the archangels in a bearable form, suited to human individuals, i.e., in the form of the soft light of moral clarity.

The archangels adopt the radical, valid-to-all-mankind commandments and prohibitions of the principalities (archai) to suit the special characters and capacities of the various peoples, thereby protecting them from becoming over-pressured.

And something similar is effected by the principalities in relation to the powers (exusiai), the powers toward the virtues (dynamis), the virtues toward the dominions (kryiotetes), the dominions toward the thrones, the thrones toward the cherubim, the cherubim toward the seraphim, and the seraphim toward the eternal Trinity of God.

See also:

Angelic States of Being

Death by a Kiss

8.3 Liberating the Guardian Angel

Between the angelic nature, which is an intellectual thing, and the human soul there is no step, but they are both almost continuous in the order of gradation. ... Thus we are to suppose

and firmly to believe, that a man may be so noble, and of such lofty condition, that he shall be almost an angel.

DANTE, *Convivio*, VII, 3

Nearly all that has been said theologically of the angels can be said metaphysically of the superior states of the being, just as in the astrological symbolism of the Middle Ages the ‘heavens’, that is to say the various planetary and stellar spheres, represent these same states and also the initiatic degrees to which their realization corresponds

RENE GUENON, *Multiple States of Being*

In flowing and running water, in mists dissolving into water, also in the winds and the lightning flashing through the air, in all these, you have to look for the physical body of Angelic beings. The difficulty for man consists in his fixed idea that a physical body must necessarily have a definite outline. It is difficult for a man to say to himself: I see fog rising, I see a stream of water dissolving into spray, I stand in the blowing wind, I see lightning dart from the clouds, and I know that all these are revelations of Angels; behind this physical body, which is by no means so limited as the human one I have to recognise the spirit.

RUDOLF STEINER, *The Spiritual Hierarchies*

As long as the human being is regarded as just one species in the Animal Kingdom, there will be no possibility of understanding. Humanity is a Kingdom in itself; hence, humans require a cladistics distinct from merely biological categories. Starting with some early notes, and developed over time, Valentin Tomberg observed a clade based on the depth of a person’s awareness of Self and his relationship to angelic hierarchies. There are three such classifications of the human being.

- **LOVE CLASS:** Those in this class have realized a permanent sense of I and are victorious. They live only for humanity and have come to help. These are in direct contact with the 1st hierarchy.
- **CONSCIENCE CLASS:** People in this class consciously take part in the conflict between good and evil. They have developed a sense of the I and are led by the 2nd hierarchy.
- **KARMIC CLASS:** These have not developed a real sense of I and are victims of the curses resulting from the Fall. The people of the third class are all still experiencing their own karma and looking for their real purpose in life. These are under the leadership of the 3rd hierarchy.

Finally there are those who are unable to develop a sense of I at this time.

Spiritual Baptism Tomberg describes a “spiritual baptism” which takes place before birth and prepares the soul for its life mission. The experience differs for each class.

For people of the 3rd **Karmic Class**, spiritual baptism consists in being consciously reminded of the fate that they will experience as karma.

For people of the 2nd **Conscience Class**, spiritual baptism brings to awareness a request from the spiritual world to focus attention on a task, or to develop knowledge of something in the spiritual world.

For people of the 1st **Love Class**, baptism consists in the soul telling the hierarchy what it is ready to accomplish.



Figure 8.1: Archangel Gabriel

Angelic Bodies In order to understand higher states available to humans, it is first necessary to be clear about how the angelic states are related to the human. The lowest order, the Angels proper, share the ether body, astral body, an intellectual soul (the “I”) with man. Hence Angels cannot understand man’s physical nature, yet are familiar with the corresponding states of the soul.

Archangels, then, like the angels have no physical body, but neither do they have an etheric body. Hence, they relate to the human on the astral level and above.

Of course, the various angels possess all the higher states of man, who, on the other hand, must work in order to reach those higher states.

Karmic Class In the *Meditations on the Tarot*, Tomberg describes the process of ascending from the third class to the first. When the soul is ready to move upward, the guardian Angel withdraws.

This is called in Christian Hermeticism “liberating the guardian Angel”. The guardian Angel is freed — often in order to be able to acquire new missions — when the soul has acquired the disposition of its part of “likeness” in order to experience the Divine more intimately and more immediately, which corresponds to another hierarchical degree. Then it is an Archangel who replaces the freed guardian Angel. Human beings whose guardian is an Archangel have not only new experiences of the Divine in their inner life, but also receive a new and objective vocation. They become representatives of a human group — a nation or a human karmic community — which means that from this time onwards their actions will no longer be purely personal but will at the same time have significance and value for those of the human community that they represent.

Conscience Class Those of the second class are under the guidance of the second hierarchy. Tomberg elucidates:

It also happens sometimes that the Archangel is freed as well. Then an entity from the hierarchy of Powers (Exusiai) replaces the Archangel. The human being then becomes a representative of the future of humanity. He lives in the present what mankind someday is due to experience in future centuries.

Unlike those in the Karmic class, who are passive to the forces of life, these people have a sense of I and consciously engage in spiritual warfare. They war against the spirits of the air from below while the Exusiai battle them from above.

The future of mankind depends on this outcome.

Love Class Those in the first class have a higher mission, and are under the guidance of the highest angelic levels. He uses Saint Francis of Assisi as an example.

Lastly, a guardian Elohim — and there are many of them — can also be freed. Then it is an entity of the first hierarchy, a Seraphim, who replaces him. It was so for **Saint Francis of Assisi**. The Seraphim who gave him the teaching of the Crucifixion whereby he gained the stigmata — the Seraphim in the vision of St. Francis — was his guardian. This is why Saint Francis represents more than mankind; what he represents is “divinised humanity”.

Sources:

Chakra Werk by **Willi Seifß**.

Meditations on the Old Testament by **Valentin Tomberg**

Meditations on the Tarot by **Valentin Tomberg**

Posted on 2022-04-27 by Cologero

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Janet Martha on 2022-04-30 at 12:44 said:

“The personal God is the angel. The angel is the space in which the Godhead shows itself in your heart.” David Nieuwejaers, rephrasing Henri Corbin.

8.4 Angels and Demons

Since we cannot be present at the holy ceremonies in honor of the angels, we should not let this time of devotion go by fruitlessly; rather, such time as we do not spend in singing their praises, we should spend in writing about them. And because our aim is to present as best we can the excellence of the holy angels, we ought to begin with man’s earliest conjectures about the angels. In this way, we shall be in a position to accept whatever we find that agrees with faith, and refute whatever is opposed to Catholic teaching.

THOMAS AQUINAS, *De Angelis*

In *The Multiple States of Being*, **Rene Guenon** recommends Aquinas’ short theological treatise on the angels¹ as an introduction to an understanding of angels as higher, supra-individual states of being. Aquinas himself looks back to the ancient Greeks to begin his study of angelic beings. After all, if angels, demons, and gods are real entities or states of being and not merely figments of the imagination or objects of belief, then they can be understood by any metaphysician. Aquinas explains:

Now it is clear that every intellectual substance receives the intellectured form according to its totality, or otherwise it would not be able to know it in its totality. For it is thus that the intellect understands a thing insofar as the form of that thing exists in it.

Thus, a complete understanding of the angelic hierarchy is possible only for the intellect that contains the form, that is, the idea of the angel, that

¹https://www.gornahoor.net/?page_id=13278

is, it participates in the higher form. This is the metaphysical principle, “to know is to be”.

Gods and the Celestial Hierarchy Confusion results from terminology, since we tend to consider the “angels” as good and “demons” as bad. However, Aquinas clarifies this by pointing out that angels can be evil and that according to **Plato**, demons can be good or evil. Regarding Plato, Aquinas writes:

In this way, therefore, between us and the highest God, it is clear that they posited four orders, namely, that of the secondary gods, that of the separate intellects, that of the heavenly souls, and that of the good or wicked demons. If all these things were true, then all these intermediate orders would be called by us “angels”, for Sacred Scripture refers to the demons themselves as angels.

So, Aquinas accepted the gods as angels. He also considered that the planets were ensouled. Hence, he seems to be implying that the gods Mars, Venus, Jupiter, Saturn and so on were actually angels. This aligns him with the Hermetic Tradition. **Valentin Tomberg**, in *Meditations on the Tarot*, assigns the correspondences listed in Table 8.1.

Preternatural Phenomena Aquinas recognizes certain preternatural phenomena and attributes them to the influence of higher intellectual substance. Keep in mind that in the following passage, the Platonic “demon” is the same as the Catholic “angel”, so no inference should be made that it necessarily implies an evil or satanic influence.

[Certain followers of Aristotle] say that it is through the influence of the stars that persons who are possessed sometimes foretell future events, for the realization of which there is a certain disposition in nature through the heavenly bodies. But in such

Archangel	Planet
Michael	Sun
Gabriel	Moon
Raphael	Mercury
Anael	Venus
Zachariel	Jupiter
Oriphiel	Saturn
Samael	Mars

Table 8.1: Angel-Planet correspondence according to Tomberg.

cases, there are manifestly certain works which cannot in any way be reduced to a corporeal cause. For example, that people in a trance should speak in a cultivated way of sciences which they do not know, since they are unlettered folk; and that those who have scarcely left the village in which they were born, speak with fluency the vernacular of a foreign people. Likewise, in the works of magicians, certain images are said to be conjured up which answer questions and move about, all of which could not be accomplished by any corporeal cause. Therefore, as the Platonists see it, who could evidently assign a cause of these effects, except to say that these are brought about through demons.

On Infallibility We see here that Aquinas asserts the traditional teaching that gnosis is infallible. Unfortunately, self-deception is not so easily overcome.

Accordingly, Augustine says in the Book of Eighty-Three Questions: “Everyone who is deceived, that, indeed, in which he is deceived, he does not understand.” And accordingly, concerning

those things which we grasp properly by our intellect as well as concerning the first principles, no one can be deceived.

Posted on 2011-08-31 by Cologero

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Perennial on 2011-08-31 at 03:45 said:

Based on similar analysis, St. Thomas conceded the possibility of legitimate astrology, practiced within certain limits. I could see where the information contained here would dovetail very nicely with St. Thomas' analysis on that question. It would be interesting to see St. Thomas' ideas on the relation between the heavenly bodies and the spirit explored in more depth.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-08-31 at 18:24 said:

The daemon of Socrates was indeed instructive, while the demons of the modern world are known to serve the purpose of testing the motives and faith of humans. The Lesser Guardian of the Threshold springs to mind here. For a Christian, though, I wonder if Hermes, for instance, can truly be considered equivalent to (for example), Michael or Gabriel, as there seems to be a major difference in function. Let me be blunt to illustrate this point. One can imagine taking (or being taken by) Hermes as a lover – as nymphs and goddesses alike would attest – but Michael? No, I don't think so....But there are also definite similarities because both Hermes and Gabriel are heraldic messengers. Then there is the question of Nephilim that crops up for the occultist. There is a clear distinction between a Nephilim and an Elohim – should we equate it to the difference between 'good' and 'evil' or 'light' and 'dark', I wonder? Certainly there is a difference in quality. But perhaps it is analogous to the difference in quality between a rain cloud and the wispy clouds you see in the sun. The robe of one would feel like petals and the silk of cobwebs – the finest possible substance one can possibly imagine, the way that light feels. The robe of another would feel heavier, like storm clouds....one would bring you absolute joy and freedom, restoring you to a state of absolute innocence and joy, whereas another would hold you in suspense, hypnotically, hardly daring to breathe or blink lest the eye of the Watcher should fall upon the self. Who could bear to be faced with that terrible gaze? Guardian angels, in the meantime, are always loving and protective, best not forget them!

logres on 2011-08-31 at 22:36 said:

Funny you should mention the Lesser Guardian of the Threshold – I just came across Tomasso Palamadessi.

Charlotte Cowell on 2011-09-01 at 03:44 said:

i had never heard of him until you mentioned his name but – having just looked briefly into it – he seems like a very interesting character, i shall investigate further!

8.5 Changing of the Guard

The third dimension of history understood as the impact of imaginal world on human history. Wars, migrations, expansions, conversions, and so on, need to be seen in the light of this higher dimension, above and beyond the material, biological, economic, and ideological causes.

We have seen that **Julius Evola** attributes the movements of human events to hidden, transcendental forces. However, he gives no details about those forces. If we turn to **Rene Guenon**, we find an acknowledgment of those forces, but treated in a superficial way. Guenon distinguishes between the Unmanifested, Formless Manifestation, and Formal Manifestation.

Formal Manifestation is our human state, body and soul, along with the existing world. Guenon's writings are oriented to pure metaphysics, transcending all states, what he calls the **Supreme Identity** from Sufi teachings. Formless manifestation includes beings that are not individuated in the material world. As part of manifestation, its study is not properly metaphysics, but involves the traditional sciences, e.g., cosmology. This is not Guenon's task as he sees it.

There are two ways to look at formless manifestation. From the strictly human perspective, it is transcendent to the human state. However, from the perspective of the Being, the human state is just one possible state, among many other higher states of formless manifestation. Thus, in the Multiple States of the Being, Guenon mentions the angels, which are seen as exterior beings in exoteric religion. However, esoterically, they are higher states. These states are between the Absolute and the human state.

For details of those states, we need to look elsewhere.

Please don't think of "angels" in the merely sentimental way that you may be accustomed to. We mean, by "angels", those superior Intelligences which form part of formless manifestation. Just focusing on one part of hidden history, namely, the history of nations and races, we find this from

Thomas Aquinas:

For in human affairs there is a common good which is, in fact, the good of a state or a people, and this seems to belong to the order of Principalities. . . . the arrangement of kingdoms and the changing of domination from one people to another ought to belong to the ministry of this order. Also, the instruction of those who occupy the position of leaders among men concerning matters pertinent to the administration of their rule seems to be the concern of this order.

THOMAS AQUINAS, *Summa contra Gentiles*, III, 80

So there is an order of the angels, called Principalities, who influence or direct the various nations, ethnicities, and races. Wars, migrations, expansions, conversions, and so on, need to be seen in the light of this higher dimension, above and beyond the material, biological, economic, and ideological causes.

Book III of the *Summa* deals only with topics that can be known solely from human experience and reason, and do not depend on any special revelation. So what evidence is there to indicate that human events are subject to hidden, transcendental forces? We can propose these three:

- I. The rapidity with which certain ideas and intellectual movements can grab hold of a nation, or particular segments of a nation. Seldom are they the result of intelligent forethought, but instead seem to arise spontaneously.

2. The actual results of revolutions or political programs do not comport with the original intentions. Even if this is not noticed right away, then certainly over time, any initial successes will be followed by stages of decline, until the final result is the complete opposite of the original movement.
3. It was the common experience of traditional cultures.

The first two are clear and obvious enough, so we can focus on the third. We recently posted an article by **Guido de Giorgio** about the recovery of the past. As he writes:

Whoever intends to remain in the pure domain of traditional truth, always turns, logically, toward the past, to retrace the stages of certitude and add them to his experience.

So, if we can no longer experience the world as our ancestors once did, we need to retrace our steps. The way to start is a form of Hermetic Meditation, what **Henry Corbin** calls creative imagination. In the Middle Ages, the imagination was counted as one of the inner wits.

As an example, in the Trojan War, the gods and goddesses took different sides in the conflict. In the *Convivio*, **Dante** relates this to the higher Intelligences, or principalities. He writes:

There are others like the eminent Plato who maintain that not only are there as many Intelligences as there are spheres in heaven, but also as many as there are species of things, for example one for men, another for gold, another for dimension, and so on. He held that just as the heavenly Intelligences each brought their sphere into being, so other Intelligences brought into being all other things and exemplars, each in its own species; and Plato called them Ideas, that is to say universal forms and natures. ... The pagans called them God and Goddesses.

Dante is saying much more here than that these higher intelligences are involved in human affairs in terms of politics or war. The gods and goddesses also represented certain qualities: beauty, wisdom, martial spirit, and so on, what Plato called the Ideas. In Guenon's scheme, the ideas are possibilities in the Infinity of the unmanifest Absolute. However, they have another existence in the imaginal world of formless manifestation, where the ideas are experienced not as abstractions, but as living beings.

As De Giorgio pointed out, we cannot simply regard the past as simply of antiquarian interest, as something exterior to us. Rather, traditional truths must be "found again and vivified". Specifically, one must live them as these higher states of being. As Evola never tires of pointing out, the way of action leads to the awareness and achievement of these higher states. Effective action, or the recovery of Tradition, can only arise out of these higher states.

Posted on 2012-06-14 by Cologero

8.6 The Bondage of Spirits

In the essay *On Magic*, **Giordano Bruno** discusses the existence and action of non-human spirits. The practice of invoking god, demons, and heroes is the branch of magic called theurgy. He calls this the "magic of the hopeless" because they often become the vessels of evil demons. A safer practice is to learn to command and control lower demons through higher spirits.

Valentin Tomberg describes theurgy in a similar way:



Figure 8.2: Ahriman

With respect to the cult of the “gods” and the iconolatry that this cult entailed, the “pagan” initiates and philosophers saw in it the practice of theurgy, i.e. that of intercourse with entities of the celestial hierarchies either by raising themselves to them, or by rendering possible their descent and presence on earth.

As sources, he lists Plutarch, Plotinus, Proclus, and Hermes Trismegistus to show that the highest theurgy did not try to evoke demons. Tomberg is apparently an Euhemerist, as was Giovanni Boccaccio by the way. He explains the origins of the pagan gods this way:

The “paganism” of the poets—symbolic and mythological paganism — was, in so far as it was not a symbolic version of the wisdom and magic (theurgy) of the mysteries, a universal humanism. Its “gods” were, truth to tell, human personages — heroes and heroines, divinised or poetised, who were prototypes of the development of the human personality

Our interest here is not in magic, but rather in understanding the sources of thought.

Thinking and the Laws of Physics Several years ago², we wrote about free will and the laws of physics, reaching the conclusion that free will and physics are compatible. The confusion is the failure to understand that free will is not the same as power. A person cannot break the law of Gravity, or any other physical law, through will alone.

Another confusion is the idea that everything that exists is ultimately reducible to physical laws. The human world is not the physical world. In all likelihood, most everything around you is an artefact, not a natural

²<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=210>

kind. Even assuming that all natural kinds are ultimately reducible to physics, artefacts are not.

That is because human activity is the result of thought, and there is no physical law of thought. That is true not just of artefacts, but of all of culture. That raises the question, then, about the origin of thought.

Some physicalists are persistent, and assume that thoughts are simply the epiphenomena of biochemical processes. In that case, the works of Shakespeare should be explicable in chemical terms, and a fortiori, by a physico-chemical law. That is because those works cannot arise by chance, as shown by the infinite monkey theorem³.

The next attempt is to attribute thoughts to “evolution”. The social systems arising from thought are said to have favoured by the “survival of the fittest”. Of course, this just begs the question. An evolutionary explanation, in order to be scientific, must identify a gene, or complex of genes, that are associated with a given system. Not only has that not been done, no one is even trying. I volunteer for research for 23andme, and they have never asked me such questions. Moreover, different cultures would have to have genetically different populations. Yet such a genetic population can create a patriarchy and an anti-patriarchy at the same time. Besides, no one has yet explained how genes create thoughts.

The more educated seem content to attribute thoughts to “culture” or “society”. Yet that hardly makes sense, since culture and society are the results of thought, not the creators of thoughts. How can such abstract notions inculcate thoughts in people?

We could, I suppose, remain content with the concept of the “meme”. It is useful as a description, but there is no indication of the source of the meme or why certain people, or groups of people, are more influenced by a given meme than others.

We could also speculate that there are unknown forces that create memes. That leaves us with three choices.

³https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Infinite_monkey_theorem

1. The force acts at random. If so, then it cannot explain the origin of the works of Shakespeare.
2. The force is a rigid law. That goes against all experience, since thought is fluid. One thought does not necessarily lead to another.
3. The force is controlled by a conscious being. This would explain why thought is neither random nor rigid. This is the esoteric, Hermetic, and Traditional explanation.

Giordano Bruno Giordano Bruno explains quite a bit about such conscious beings. He explains how spirits affect our inner life:

Demons penetrate through bodies and initiate thoughts in us. They convey impressions directly to our internal senses, just as we sometimes seem to think of something suggested by the internal senses.

They send not only dreams, voices, and visions to be heard and seen, but also certain thoughts which might be hardly noticed. They communicate truths sometimes through enigmas and sometimes through sense impressions. Sometimes they may even deceive.

There are many types of spirits, which explain the different influences on human thought. Bruno elaborates:

- Some are brute animals and cause injury without reason. Mark 9:25 describes them as “deaf and dumb”, i.e., they are without reason, recognize no commands, do not hear threats or prayers.
- Demons which are fearful, suspicious and credulous. They do not distinguish the possible from the impossible, or the appropriate from the inappropriate. They are like humans who are dreaming and disturbed by fantasies.

- Wiser demons reside in pure air. They distort worship and prayers, create Illusions of fear, anger, religion, and introduce confusion and doubt.
- Ethereal spirits are pure and luminous. Not hostile.
- Aqueous and terrestrial spirits are hostile, or at least not friendly. Less rational and more fearful.
- Spirits of fire are heroes and gods, and are the ministers of God. These are the Seraphim, Cherubim, and Thrones. They have very subtle bodies made of fire.
- Spirits occupy the bodies of humans, animals, stones, minerals. This is a form of panpsychism. Whatever his defects, **Teilhard de Chardin** insisted that a true science had to deal with the inside of things as well as the outside.
- No body is totally devoid of spirit and intelligence.
- Spirits never perish; rather, there is continual change of combinations and actualisations.
- There are various loves and hates.
- Everything desires to remain in its present state of existence and does not comprehend or think about another state of being.
- The diversity of natures and drives gives rise to a variety of bonds which affect spirits and bodies.
- There are subterranean spirits.
- Demons have emotions, desires, angers, jealousies

Tomberg's definition is straight forward:

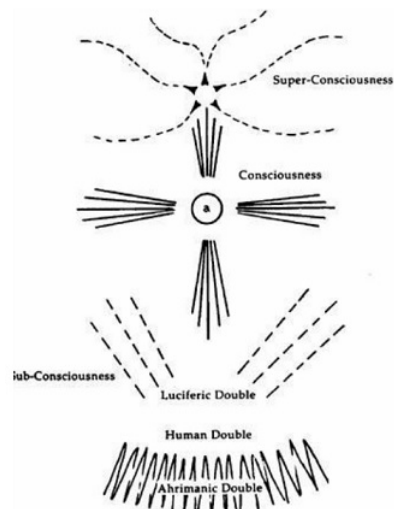
"An autonomous being capable of interfering with the intentions of the ego" and which "possesses a mental life of its own" is nothing other than what we understand by a "demon".

We can't go into further detail in this introduction. Bruno claims to have experienced many of these spirits. The human race has always suspected their existence; this is shown in all the Hollywood films about spirits and in the works of **H P Lovecraft**.

Lucy and Harry There are two particular spirits, or actually classes of spirits, that play a prominent role in Anthroposophical literature: Lucifer and Ahriman, nicknamed Lucy and Harry by the anthros. In an early work, *Inner Development*, Valentin Tomberg describes the activities of these spirits in the human being, as shown in the diagram on the right. The Luciferic being is bound to the astral body in man's fallen state. He is called a doppelganger since it is like an evil twin. He is the father of lies, and creates idle fantasies in the mind that mask the imagination of Sophia, or Divine Wisdom. A moral universe requires hindrances, which are provided by this double. This is a clue to the meaning of the Book of Job.

Another doppelganger is the strictly human subconscious. In the *Meditations*, Tomberg uses the ideas of **Carl Jung** to explain the content of the subconscious. As for Ahriman, let us use his own words:

And just as our angel, standing above us, represents, one could say, our archetype,



so it is that the Ahrimanic double, on the other hand, is our caricature. This caricature, the Ahrimanic double, is a very intelligent being, one who does not manifest through arousing wild passions, but instead manifests particularly whenever subordination to an aim works strongly in a person. Precisely those individuals, therefore, who are highly respectable (from the external, bourgeois point of view) can be tools of this Ahrimanic double. It is precisely such people who can be subordinated, to a very high degree, to the being of the Ahrimanic double—who thereby takes on the leading role.

VALENTIN TOMBERG,
Inner Development

As a reminder, the angel is our guardian angel whose prototype is the same as the person. This notion has even penetrated Orthodox theology, for example, in **Sergei Bulgakov**.

In the *Meditations*, Tomberg became more critical of the anthro's obsession with the Luciferic and Ahrimanic beings. In that, he is justified, since their tendency is to reduce, even in its highest forms, the activities of the human spirit to manifestations of evil.

He barely mentions Ahriman at all, in fact. However, in the *Letter on the Devil*, he brings up Mephistopheles, whose characteristics are actually identical to those of Ahriman described in his earlier work. For example, consider the following quotes:

Even Doctor Faust—who made a pact with the devil (and this concerns all “pact-makers” of this kind, ancient and modern)—was only the naive victim of a prank on the part of Mephistopheles

(who is a rogue well-known to all those who have knowledge of the “occult world”).

Some do it in the tragic sense of having to do what they no longer want to do and they no longer believe; others do it with fierce conviction and passionate indignation; there are also entities from the hierarchies of the left who accuse by making use of ridicule —*farce*— as a means of demonstrating their prosecuting thesis.

It is primarily human pretension and snobbery that he turns into ridicule.

Mephistopheles; and the whole revelation is only a farce made by him for the credulous? no — for spiritual snobs.

Mephistophelian accusation against those who do not seek the truth as such, but rather extraordinary circumstances of revelation.

The Ahrimanic doppelganger, aka Mephistopheles, is a *caricature* of the human being. Other features are spiritual pranks, ridicule, and farce. He can be recognized by spiritual pretension and snobbery, i.e., the desire to appear to be “spiritual” to others.

As for being well known, Mephistopheles may reveal himself in a dream rather than to the awakened consciousness. That I know from experience.

Personality Disorders Another indication of the influence of demons are personality disorders and psychopathy. Tomberg explains how that is possible:

One engenders an elemental being and one subsequently becomes the slave of one’s own creation. The “demons” or “evil spirits” of the New testament are called today in psychotherapy “neuroses of obsession”, “neuroses or fear”, “fixed ideas”, etc. They have been

discovered by contemporary psychiatrists and are recognised as real — i.e. as “parasitic psychic organisms” independent of the conscious human will and tending to subjugate it.

This is not the case with organic conditions such as bipolar disorder or schizophrenia, whose effects can be somewhat mitigated by medications. However, personality disorders like the paranoid, histrionic, borderline, etc., are different. Just because psychologists can categorize certain complexes of behaviour does not necessarily mean they are strictly medical problems. There is no real understanding of their cause nor is there any universally effective treatment. Tomberg’s description, therefore, is pretty apt. He goes on to say:

One need not fear the devil, but rather the perverse tendencies in oneself! For these perverse human tendencies can deprive us of our freedom and enslave us. Worse still, they can avail themselves of our imagination and inventive faculties and lead us to creations which can become the scourge of mankind.

If you have ever had a close relationship with someone with a personality disorder, you will probably agree that it feels more like dealing with evil than with a sickness.

Posted on 2018-10-08 by Cologero

8.7 Angelic States of Being

Hear us Lord, holy Lord, almighty Father, eternal God, and deign to send your holy Angel from heaven to guard, cherish, protect, visit and defend all who are gathered together in this place.

*Liturgical prayer of the introductory service preceding the solemn
Mass*

The citizens of heaven are spirits of power, glorious, blessed, having individuality and ranked in order of dignity from their creation, perfect of their kind, with ethereal bodies, immortal, not created incapable of suffering, but made so pure in mind, kindly in affection, devout in piety, perfect in chastity, of one mind in agreement, secure in peace, created by God, dedicated in the praise and worship of God.

SAINT BERNARD OF CLAIRVAUX

We have gone on in mind, but not with our whole mind; with only part, and that too small a part. Our affections lie weighted down by this bodily mass, and they are stuck to the mire by desire: for now only dry and delicate consideration flies before.

SAINT BERNARD OF CLAIRVAUX

States of Being The Person exists in multiple states of being, of which the human state is but one of them. Rene Guenon explains it like this:

almost everything that is said theologically of the angels can also be said metaphysically of the higher states of the being. . . . the sum of all these states is still nothing at all in relation to the personality, which alone is the true being, because it alone represents its permanent and unconditioned state, and because there is nothing else which can be considered as absolutely real. . . . in the subtle state we are still only concerned with ideas clothed in forms, since the possibilities which this state comprises do not extend beyond individual existence

RENE GUENON, *Man and his Becoming*

The theologian **Sergius Bulgakov** describes it in a different way:

everyone has a personal guardian angel who is his heavenly image.

So how is this heavenly image related to the human person? He elaborates:

A guardian angel has an affinity of individual character with a human ... There exists a likeness between the hypostasis of a guardian angel and that of a human: it is one and the same individuality living in two worlds, in heaven and on earth. ... The form of being remains distinct in the spiritual and human world, in heaven and on earth. Here one should not speak about identity but only about correspondence or likeness. Sometimes this idea is expressed in the straightforward convergence of an angel and a human soul which after its liberation from the body assumes a certain luminous shell similar to an angel's.

SERGIUS BULGAKOV, *Jacob's Ladder*

The hypostasis or individuality is what we have been calling the Person, or the I. So the human and spiritual worlds represent different states of the Person. Of course, they are not identical; the guardian angel is not human. Nevertheless, there is necessarily a likeness, otherwise they could not be states of the same person. Specifically, there is a continuity between the human state and angelic states.

Valentin Tomberg, in *Meditations on the Tarot*, goes even further. One of the Hermetic tasks is to ascend Jacob's Ladder by rising through the hierarchy of angels. He explains:

The transcendental Self is not God. It is in his image and after his likeness, according to the law of analogy or kinship, but it is not identical with God. There are still several degrees on the ladder of

analogy which separate it from the summit of the ladder—from God. These degrees which are higher than it are its “stars”—or the ideals to which it aims. The Apocalypse specifies the number of them: there are twelve degrees higher than that of the consciousness of the human transcendental Self. It is necessary, therefore, in order to attain to the ONE God, to elevate oneself successively to degrees of consciousness of the nine spiritual hierarchies and the Holy Trinity

He even provides a specific example of this ascent in which the Person moves beyond even the Guardian Angel:

The guardian Angel is the friend of the bride at the spiritual marriage of the soul and God. The guardian Angel withdraws before the approach of One who is greater than he. There is what is called in Christian Hermetism the “freeing of the guardian Angel”. The guardian Angel is freed—often in order to be able to acquit new missions—when the soul has acquired the disposition of its part of “likeness” in order to experience the Divine more intimately and more immediately, which corresponds to another hierarchical degree.

Then it is an Archangel who replaces the freed guardian Angel. Human beings whose guardian is an Archangel have not only new experiences of the Divine in their inner life, but also, through this very fact, receive a new and objective vocation. They become representative, of a human group—a nation or a human karmic community—which means to say that from this time onwards their actions will no longer be purely personal but will at the same time have significance and value for those of the human community that they represent.

It also happens sometimes that the Archangel is freed as well. Then it is an entity from the hierarchy of Powers or Elohim which

replaces the Archangel. The human being then becomes a representative of the future of humanity. He lives in the present what mankind someday is due to experience in future centuries.

Principles and Persons For some reason, it is considered more sophisticated to believe in “principles” rather than persons. So there is talk about the “laws of physics”, higher principles, and so on. But do you really regard your wife or husband merely as “principles”, say, for example, of authority or of caring. Are your children “principles”. Do you love them as principles or as the unique persons that they are? Of course, we have our roles to play in the world, and as we act in principled ways, we embody those principles.

Principles or abstract ideas do not have agency; they accomplish nothing without a person with the will to embody those principles. Only a person can make an idea effective in life, the world, in history. Nor does a principle have meaning or value without a person to embody it. This is also true in the spiritual world, as explained by Valentin Tomberg:

The spiritual world is not a world of laws, principles and ideas; it is a world of spiritual beings — human souls, Angels, Archangels, Principalities, Powers, Virtues, Dominions, Thrones, Cherubim, Seraphim and the Holy Trinity: the Holy Spirit, the Son and the Father.

The vertical world, the spiritual world, is that of values and, as the “value of values” is the individual being, it is a world of individual beings or entities.

Unlike fallen humans, the angels act with intelligence, justice, and detachment. Here are some examples:

The holy angels punish without anger those whom they receive for punishment by the eternal law of God; they help the suffering

without the compassion of pity; and when those whom they love fall in danger, they minister without fear.

SAINT AUGUSTINE, *City of God*, Book IX

The Body of Angels Saint Bernard says that the angels have ethereal bodies, i.e., they are not material. As ethereal, they are not subject to the limitations of space, just to time. That is how they can sometimes be experienced in a manner imitative of sensual experience. After all, sensual experience arises in the soul, it is not “out there”. We experience bodies in our imagination and particularly in dreams. Although dreams unfold in time, there is not space, since the scene can change into another in an instant.

Angelic Hierarchy Dionysius first formulated the angelic hierarchy. There are nine orders of angels arranged hierarchically. They each have different roles and functions. These are their roles as described by Saint Bernard.

Angels An Angel is entrusted with the care of a particular person. This angel is the heavenly prototype of that person, and sees God face to face:

in heaven their angels always behold the face of my Father who is in heaven.

MATTHEW, 18:10

Archangels Archangels know divine mysteries and are sent only on serious and important occasions. The most important occasion was the visit of the archangel Gabriel to Mary.

Principalities The Principalities, through their moderation and wisdom, set up and rule every power on earth which are kept within bounds, transferred, diminished, altered.

Powers The Powers check the powers of darkness and binds the malignity of this air so that it can do no evil, nor any harm, unless it is for our good.

Virtues The Virtues produce the signs and wonders which appear in the elements or are formed from the elements to instruct mortal men. There are many references to these.

Dominions The Dominions minister to spirits of the lower orders. They are masters of the rulership of the principalities, guardians of the powers, the work of the virtues, the revelations of the archangels, the care and prevision of the angels.

Thrones The Thrones are seated and God is seated on them. Sitting is symbolic for supreme tranquillity, placid serenity, the peace which passes understanding.

Cherubim The Cherubim drink from the very fount of Wisdom and pour forth a stream of knowledge to all the citizens of heaven

Seraphim The Seraphim are aflame with the divine fire. They kindle the other citizens so that each is a burning and shining light, and are burning with love, shining with knowledge.

Summary These descriptions need to be read on three levels: as descriptions of the angels, as revealing how God acts through the angels, and how they act through us. Bernard reveals how God does different

things through different spirits. As for the human element, the angel is suggestive not coercive:

An angel can be present in us. . . . An angel is “within” when he suggests we do good. He does not enter to cause us to do good. He is exhorting us to do good, not making us good.

Saint Bernard summarizes the three aspects like this:

God loves us as Love itself; he knows as Truth itself. He sits as Equity, rules as Majesty, governs as Prince, keeps safe as Salvation, works as Strength, reveals as Light, is with us as Holiness.

All these things the angels do.

So do we, but in a far lowlier way. Not because of the good we are but because of the good we share.

We can now understand theosis. Just like God, just like the angels:

We are to love, to know, to be at peace, to rule, to govern, to be strong, to live in the light, to be holy.

Appendix Saint Bernard in *On Consideration* reversed the Principalities and Virtues in the hierarchy, but I restored them to the more traditional ordering of Dionysius. The functions don’t change.

Posted on 2020-09-17 by Cologero

Meditations on Incarnation

9.1 Classical and Romantic Ethics

Before I formed thee in the bowels of thy mother, I knew thee:
and before thou camest forth out of the womb, I sanctified thee,
and made thee a prophet unto the nations.

JEREMIAH 1:5

In the chapter Classical and Romantic Ethics from *Sintesi di dottrina della razza*, **Julius Evola** recapitulates the traditional doctrine of preexistence. This was one of the acceptable opinions for the origin of the soul along with traducianism and creationism. The latter developed in opposition of the former, but has nothing to say against preexistence, properly understood (i.e., not in a crude, “materialistic” sense). Every possibility of manifestation “exists” in the mind of God. If you want to restrict the word “exist” to manifested being, then that possibility does not “exist” as an actuality. Moreover, if by “preexistence” is meant a prior existence as another human being, then that use of the word is false. In a planned

post on the metaphysics of **Vladimir Solovyov**, we will defend the use of the neoplatonic and other traditional sources cited by Evola.

Evola himself refers to the Catholic teaching on the creation of the soul from nothing, with the same semantic confusion about “preexistence” mentioned above. This chapter cannot be understood in the conventional scientific, empirical, or material sense, but requires a full understanding of the metaphysical principles underlying it. Thus “race” in his view is not at all a biological quality that can be determined genetically, but a spiritual attitude. Otherwise the decline of the modern world would be incomprehensible. It results from a spiritual decline, regardless of biological facts.

These are questions that are ignored by theologians today. The idea that archangels are assigned to different peoples and nations is no longer taken seriously, never mind that they participate in their creation. The quote from Plotinus on inequality used to be known and was held to be due to God’s Providence, predestination, and predilection. Of course, our intent is not to open a debate on these topics, but rather to observe their effects. All things, including men, have their origin in the mind of God as possibilities. If a man has a destiny, he must actively actualize it and not wait passively for it to happen. In **Rene Guenon**’s words, that refers to the actualization of the possibilities open to him. That is, he must become who he is.

Classical and Romantic Ethics In the work just cited we reproduced various traditional texts that clarify and confirm those views. In particular, in this regard, there is this passage from **Plotinus**:

The general plane is unique, but is divided into different parts, so that in all there are distinct places, some more pleasant and others less—and souls, also unequal, come to inhabit these distinct places that correspond to their own differences. In such a

way everything is concordant and the difference of the situations corresponds to the inequality of the souls.

And even more precisely:

The soul chose itself prior to its daemon and its life.

Plato similarly taught:

It is not the daemon that chooses you, but you yourself are to choose the daemon. You yourself choose the destiny of that life to which you then will be irremediably connected.

These last expressions are particularly interesting for us, since the concept of daemon has nothing to do with the Christian concept of an evil entity, but has instead the closest relation with the deepest forces of race, both of the soul and of the body. We cannot here analyze the traditional doctrine in this regard, but only recall that in the same way the “daemon”, the “*lares*”, the “*penates*”, the “double” (which is a synonym of the “subtle body”) are notions that in antiquity merged and reflected the precise knowledge of the true roots of the differentiations of bloods, of *gentes*, and ultimately of individuals themselves, on the basis of a complete vision of the world, comprising the invisible and the visible, and not of that modern distortion which knows only about material and psychological processes. From such evidence, which could be multiplied with reference to the traditions of all peoples, we therefore see confirmed the idea of transcendental, or vertical, heredity and of the choice that, on the basis of analogical correspondences, determines its connection to “horizontal”, historical-biological heredity. The consequences of all that in regard to the justification of the idea of race theory are quite obvious.

The central view of Catholicism is that God, while creating man out of nothing, let the miracle happen, through which this being created from nothing is free, in the sense that he can rejoin God at the root of

his own being, or else deny Him, be limited to himself, disperse himself, or degenerate into a useless creaturely free will. This same doctrine, with due transpositions, can be applied to the relations between the individual being and the spiritual entity, of which it is the creation and human manifestation. We mean that the individual being, within given limits, enjoys equally free will and that the same alternative is posed to him: either to will his own nature, deepening it and realizing it to the point of rejoining himself to the pre-human and superindividual principle that corresponds to him; or to give himself up to arbitrarily construct an unnatural mode of being, deprived of relation with one's deepest forces or directly in contradiction with them. This is exactly the existing opposition between the traditional and especially the Nordic-Aryan ideal and the "modern" ideal of civilization. For the former, the essential task is to know and be oneself; for the latter, the task is instead to "construct oneself", to become what one is not, to break every limit to render possible everything to everyone: liberalism, democracy, individualism, activist-protestant ethics, anti-race, anti-traditionalism.

As was traditionally taught, the doctrine of preexistence therefore leads beyond both fatalism, as well as a poorly understood and individualistic freedom. Moving on to more immediate consequences, in realizing his own nature, the individual harmonizes his own human will with the super-human will which corresponds to him, he "remembers" himself, he establishes the relation with a principle that, being beyond birth, is likewise beyond death and every temporal condition: therefore, according to the ancient Indo-Aryan conception, this is the way through which he aims to achieve "liberation" and to realize the divine, by way of action. Dharma—which means one's own nature, duty, fidelity to blood, tradition, caste—is connected, as we already explained in the other book, to the sensation of having arrived here from far away and does not mean limitation, as the "evolved spirits" believe, but liberation. Led back to this traditional vision of life, all the principle themes of race theory acquire

a higher and spiritual significance and the objection based on birth as chance or destiny loses every force.

But that is not enough: it is not by chance that the formula, “know yourself”, that in its deepest meaning precisely refers to such teachings, and was itself written on Apollo’s Delphic temple, i.e., of the Hyperborean God. To let such traditional truths act on oneself, to the point where they awaken precise inner forces, means to proceed on the way that leads to a spiritual level from which the meaning of life constitutes something absolutely different from that of the rest of mankind: the importance of clarity, absolute strength, and incomparable certainty. But to have a presentiment of all that, to barely see a “style” in which the feeling of detachment of “those who have reached from afar” and of interior inaccessibility unites to himself a type of indomitability, in which there is simultaneously a superior serenity, a distance, and a readiness to attack, to command, to absolute action—to have a presentiment of this “style”, means also to have concealed the mystery of the primordial Nordic, or Hyperborean race, as race of the spirit. Such is in fact the Olympic and solar way of being. Popular imagination relates it today to the so called “men of destiny” and previously related it to the rare types of great leaders—in reality, in what were the last echoes or flashes of what was typical, in general, of the great Hyperborean super-race, before its dispersion and degradation. We recall Plutarch’s expression about the same members of the ancient Roman Senate: “They sit like a council of kings”.

An additional consequence follows from this: if a civilization of the “classical” type, in this Olympic and virile sense, not in the vulgar esthetic and formalistic meaning, reflects something of the Nordic race of the spirit, every romantic and tragic civilization, which is opposed to it, will be instead the certain sign of influences taking priority, that proceeded from racial and ethnic residues of a non-Nordic, pre-Aryan, and anti-Aryan nature.

Posted on 2015-07-16 by Cologero

* * *

Mark Citadel on 2015-07-18 at 13:10 said:

Man's pre-existence in the mind of God as a possibility (with this constituting a true existence) would seem to rule out all arguments for abortion, and then some. Those not yet born are most certainly the same as those whom they will become, with their passage of birth being a mere semantic.

The Christian view of abortion is affirmed entirely here.

Cologero on 2015-07-18 at 16:39 said:

Agreed, Mr Citadel. This doctrine is stronger and, to my mind, preferable to the "creationist" account which seems rather arbitrary and ad hoc.

Matt on 2015-07-19 at 15:55 said:

It's certainly a different view of pre-existence when compared to what others have written on the subject, with the exception being Guenon, I guess.

From my readings of Evola on the subject of pre-existence, I always got the impression that his view of the pre-existence of the particular subject was the same as that of a Origen, or a Saint-Martin (Martin's being more along the lines of the Kabbalah's Adam-Kadmon). That the soul/person pre-exists embodiment as a manifested pure spirit, not just as a possibility of manifestation in the Divine Mind.

More material to contemplate on.

Cologero on 2015-07-19 at 20:56 said:

Matt, I took the liberty of bringing out Evola's real meaning while putting it into a larger context. As a literal event, Evola's notion of a soul choosing its incarnation does not make much sense. Nevertheless, his rethought notions of karma and dharma are powerful. So we can understand the created soul as having qualities; this is also consistent with predilection. Moreover, the categories of being, at least at the moment of conception, are not simply "accidents", but are essential to the soul's being.

9.2 Incarnation of the Logos

In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God,
and the Word was God. The same was in the beginning with

God. All things were made by him: and without him was made nothing that was made. In him was life, and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it.

Gospel of John

In this gospel passage, the birth of Christ is expressed in theological language, since the mere historical fact has no meaning in itself. In his study on Hindu Doctrines, **Rene Guenon** devotes a chapter to the relationship between theology and metaphysics. In particular, he writes:

Every theological truth, by means of a transposition dissociating it from its specific form, may be conceived in terms of the metaphysical truth corresponding to it, of which it is but a kind of translation...

This needs to be kept in mind, especially for those who are put off by theological language or can only see arbitrariness in theological disputes. Thus it is instructive to try to understand the metaphysical meaning of this passage, especially considering that it is the fundamental premise of Christianity. "Word" is the translation of the Greek philosophical term *Logos*¹, of which there is no really suitable translation; thus we shall leave it untranslated. There are two principles in play here.

- GOD: Principle of Being (Aquinas)
- LOGOS: Principle of order (Greek philosophy)

The identity of God and the Logos thus implies that the principle of order is inseparable from Being itself. Were that not so, then chaos would be

¹<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Logos>

on equal footing with order, not the absence of order; ignorance would be equivalent to gnosis, not its opposite; revolution would be a possible option to hierarchy, not a revolt against being itself; darkness would be in perpetual opposition to light, rather than its shadow.

Posted on 2010-12-26 by Cologero

* * *

Cologero on 2010-12-26 at 12:48 said:

That is why the claims of Arius² that the Logos was created had to be opposed as heretical; this was not a hair-splitting theological game nor a power play.

²<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Arius>

Hermetic Meditations on Catholic Doctrine

10.1 I Sleep, but the Heart is Awake

I sleep, but my heart is awake.

Song of Solomon, 5:2

Please consider the four states of consciousness mentioned by **Bede Griffiths** in *The Cosmic Mystery*¹.

We are accustomed to consider the sleeping, dreaming, and waking states as distinct states of consciousness, which follow each other consecutively. However, most of us have noticed that, rather than sequential, they interpenetrate each other. Our presumed waking state is mostly a series of semi-dreams: i.e., thoughts, imaginations, little stories, and so on. Then there is something deeper, beyond conscious awareness, in operation, affecting our postures, movements, attention and so on.

Among those dreams is the dream of awakening. That “I”, the subject of that dream, will “snap us out of it” from time to time. That I needs to

¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8055>

be nourished until the whole heart is awake.

Theology of the Body A delay was caused by some new information on the *Theology of the Body*² (H/T Perennial) that I came across as I was writing the introduction to the chapters on Sintesi that relate the sexes to race. Surprisingly, Evola's ideas have some things in common with **Pope John Paul II's** conceptions. Perhaps that is so, given the influence of German idealism and the philosophy of personalism on both of them.

For Scholasticism, the mind, or intellectual soul, is the image of God. The mind is without qualities, neither male nor female. For JP II and Evola, on the other hand, the body is the outward expression of spirit, hence either masculinity or femininity permeates the whole being. The Scholastic approach easily devolves to a Cartesian dualism of body and mind.

Moreover, the Scholastic definition of the person is too abstract: *an individual substance of a rational nature*. It does not mention Will, I, Freedom, Consciousness. Then there is Guenon's objection that it focuses on Being to the exclusion of non-Being. Specifically, it is too static, not making the distinction between the virtual and the actual. The actualization of a person is something else. Will must be developed, consciousness expanded, freedom/liberation must be achieved as it is not simply a given. "Truth shall set you free." For the Scholastics, there can be no development of the person. However, for JP II and Evola one of hallmarks of the person is self-possession, which requires a development.

Also, speculative theology does not make a clear distinction between soul and spirit. Mystical theology, on the other hand, does. **St John of the Cross**, for example, distinguishes between psychic experiences and truly spiritual experience. **St John of the Cross** is one of the influences on the *Theology of the Body*.

²<https://sspx.org/en/theology-of-the-body-genesis-of-confusion>

Sex and the Body These are some of the main points of the Theology of the Body. When the Evola translations come out, we can see better how they relate.

- There is no abstract “human”: the human being is always embodied as a man or a woman. Masculinity and Femininity are expressions of the person.
- The Spirit is not without qualities.
- The body is not just matter, subject to physical or biological laws. Rather, it is permeated by the soul and the spirit. Otherwise, resurrection cannot be understood except as the revival of a corpse.
- Biology is a human construct and does not exhaust all we know about the human being, sex, or the body.
- The Baconian project of gaining power over nature, specifically, technological power over the body, is rejected. Rather, the subtle rules the dense so the spirit must control the body, without relying on material means.

Unintended Consequences There are perhaps other results that can be derived from this approach, not that they can be attributed to JP II. Biblical, mystical, philosophical, and phenomenological sources are used to develop the theology of the body. Why, then, can we not include other sources and even traditional sources? For example, Evola relies on **Otto Weininger**’s book *Sex and Character* as well as the Laws of Manu for his own teachings on the spiritual and bodily aspects of masculinity and femininity.

Although JP II does not mention this, if the spirit has qualities, then race, or *ethnos* as **E Michael Jones** calls it, has its counterpart in the spirit. The relationship is not necessarily one-to-one, as we will see. Of course,

this doctrine rejects the idea that biology or DNA is the cause of differences in psychic and spiritual makeup of the person.

Furthermore, the body cannot be understood as a piece of matter, but rather as a non-dual body/soul/spirit complex. This conception is developed by **Valentin Tomberg** in Letter XX of the Meditations of the Tarot. He shows the chain:

spirit $\Rightarrow$ psychic forces $\Rightarrow$ energy $\Rightarrow$ material organs.

That is the vertical process that works with the horizontal process of heredity. More research needs to be done to relate these various currents of thought.

Then, too, the notion that the body can be more or less dense begins to make some sense. Hence, there may be no physical traces of the Hyperboreans for the reason that the body in that era was less dense. This is something proposed by Rene Guenon. In this case, the positive sciences cannot be the last word.

Posted on 2015-04-21 by Cologero

* * *

X on 2015-04-22 at 01:16 said:

"St John of the Cross, for example, distinguishes between psychic experiences and truly spiritual experience."

Can you please say it more detailedly for this?

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 05:36 said:

X, this topic is discussed at length at *Three Ages of the Interior Life*³ by Fr Garrigou-Lagrange.

For example, concerning psychic phenomena: *The Illuminative Way of Proficients*⁴.

Also, on mystical union, which can also be read as the antidote to Cassiodorus' objections: *The Transforming Union*⁵

³<http://www.christianperfection.info/index.php>

⁴<http://www.christianperfection.info/tta82.php>

⁵<http://www.christianperfection.info/tta105.php#bk2>

X on 2015-04-22 at 06:00 said:

Thanks you very much, Mr. Salvo.

And the by the way, there is error in the first link.

X on 2015-04-22 at 06:04 said:

"The state which St. John of the Cross describes here is a state of love linked to a state of infused contemplation. The connection is owing to a necessity of love: 'True and full love cannot hide anything.' This connection is not accidental, since this need is connatural to perfect charity."

thomas walker on 2015-04-22 at 10:11 said:

We know from our own experience that body and soul are intimately related : bodily ailments can completely dominate our thoughts and emotions . I think that the kabbalistic idea of *nephesh* speaks to this , Our personalities are intimately linked with our bodies . There is a problem to understand how after death only the soul will exist until it is joined to the body in the Last Judgement . If time and space are abolished how can there be bodies which as bodies with extension must occupy space ?

Also , doesn't Jesus teach that in heaven there will neither be taking or giving in marriage because bodies will be like the angels (i assume that means without gender) Therefore gender is only accidental not essential .

obscure on 2015-04-22 at 15:20 said:

Nous is indeed prior to qualities, but qualities are received prior to the quantitative features of the body since quantity most signifies prime matter. The first relation to the body and thus to the macrocosm is qualitative, but pure Nous is not for this reason qualitative. Prime matter is also not separable and thus not really distinct from information. Although form itself as Spirit or Idea is really distinct from matter or informed matter.

The rational soul is a discursive intellect animating a material substance or complex subject (these terms are synonymous). Its constitutive features are active intellect, passive intellect and sense-perception. Pure intellect is only an active intellect and its constitutive features are its simple form and its essential act (sometimes erroneously translated by neo-Thomists in the tradition of Gilson as 'act of existence', but in truth 'essential act' or 'actus essendi' is pure will). A pure intellect is necessarily passive in relation to the First, but this is due to metaphysical necessity rather than discursive intellection with respect to the agent. The psychological (or 'epistemological') triad of the rational soul is not to be confused with the physiological triad (rational soul, sentient soul and vegetative soul) or the moral-constitutive triad (intellect, will and appetite).

Substantial form is the subsisting simple subjectivity of a complex subject (or compound substance, material substance, etc.: These terms are synonymous). A per se simple subject (not subsisting in a complex subject) is either a Spirit or Idea which is specifically different from the Absolute simple subject. Thus the metaphysical triad of all reality is Absolute simple subject, relative or 'specific' simple subjects and lastly the complex subjects. In the order of pure simple subjects Spirits are active while Ideas are passive, although with respect to what is inferior (the order of complex subjects, the material cosmos, temporal procession, nature, etc.: These terms are synonymous) Ideas are obviously called 'active', but this is due to metaphysical necessity (which is to say, the hierarchy between God, supernature and nature). Corporeal form is constituted by extension and quality; it is an accidental form of a simple subject and it is the basic information of matter. Substantial form is not corporeal form, it 'contains' essential possibilities not corporeal matter.

The basic qualification of Spirits other than the Absolute is their essential act or will gratuitously caused by the First (for the only relationship between the Infinite and the finite is gratuitous i.e. grace). The Absolute cannot be distinguished from His essential act in any respect since the Absolute is a Pure Act of Infinite Power. Even though neo-Thomists may not write in this way it is all to be found in the primary texts of their Doctor and of other medieval doctors. Duns Scotus is in many respects the master and I recommend this blog containing some historical materials if any are interested:

<http://lyfaber.blogspot.com/>

David on 2015-04-22 at 16:30 said:

Cologero : Would it be possible to have all the texts within this site on a .zip or .rar format have a download link ? If the site is to end, a great part of the first texts I never had the chance to read. I imagine you have either a backup of .html files or the actual text files somewhere which could be given. Thank you.

obscure on 2015-04-22 at 18:48 said:

Here are some translations of the Scotistic Theoremata:

<http://lyfaber.blogspot.com/2010/01/theoremata-scoti-partes-i-v.html>

Scotus' discusson of quality is interesting, although I'm sure it won't surprise many.

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 20:28 said:

TW, this is the full quote: "In the resurrection they take neither wife nor husband, but are like the angels in heaven."

I suppose one approach is Guenon's: the being that was in the human state is now in an angelic state.

But, JP11 contrasts the resurrection body with our bodies as they are now, with its members at war with the spirit. The resurrection body will not experience that opposition, it will be spiritualized. JP11 is closer to Tomberg with this explanation:

Spiritualization signifies not only that the spirit will master the body, but that it will also fully permeate the body and the powers of the spirit will permeate the energies of the body. (67:1)

He takes pain to emphasize that this state is not “disincarnation” of the body, nor a dehumanization. There is a deep harmony between spirit and body, but primacy resides in the spirit. He goes on to relate this to theosis (translated as divinization).

In the resurrection, the body is outside of human history “tied to marriage and procreation”. However, this does not mean that the body is suddenly neutered. (It would be interesting to compare that idea with the way Mouravieff includes marriage and procreation as part of the “General Law”.)

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 20:47 said:

Thanks for that synopsis, Obscure, but the issue is the whether or not JP11 is introducing novelty into that doctrine. It appears that he is rejecting the notion that the Spirit is distinct from the body. For the Scotist, is masculinity or femininity an accidental or an essential quality? If God has qualities, then why would not a man have them?

As for your other link, I read the claim that the “more perfect man has more perfect intelligence”. I thought the Scotist position is that the goal of creation is the divinization of man, i.e., union with God. I don’t see them as the same thing.

Cologero on 2015-04-23 at 08:55 said:

David, Gornahoor will not be taken off-line, since it is intended for a future generation that may have a better perspective. However, I won’t be updating it but perhaps someone else will.

thomas walker on 2015-04-23 at 13:14 said:

Thanks for your reply Cologero

obscure on 2015-04-23 at 23:15 said:

Hello Cologero,

Keep in mind that when I write some long comment I intend a general audience and not just yourself in particular, for I enjoy sharing information. There is much ink I could spill with regard to the hierarchies of metaphysical qualification. This would require a fine treatment with some more effort than I can provide at the moment. If anything I’ve provided has produced

some degree of confusion it was due to a degree of privation on my part. I promise to address your points at a later time.

As for the ToB, I can't say I've read it. My impression was that it was mostly an exoteric text of a more-or-less existential nature.

I will leave off for now with a Hermetic passage (Although it is not the sort of passage to be taken with little consideration or lack of interpretation):

"Soul enters the body by necessity, Intellect enters soul by judgment. While being outside of the body, soul has neither quality nor quantity. Once it is in the body it receives, as an accident, quality and quantity as well as good and evil for matter brings about such things."

Cologero on 2015-04-24 at 00:07 said:

No confusion at all, Obscure, what you describe is how I would have been accustomed to look at it.

However, in light of the ongoing translation of Evola's *Sintesi*, there are questions that arise. I am not trying to provide the basis for a sophisticated theory of "white nationalism", but in exploring the metaphysical ramifications of his doctrine. Precisely, is there spiritual differentiation among men?

It is not so obvious that corporeal life is an accident. For example, in Plato's Myth of Er, the circumstances of birth are determined by the prior state of the spirit. For Guenon, each human being is a possibility of manifestation in God's mind, and this determines the "accidents" of birth. Perhaps these are differences in terms, but maybe not.

Based on the way it's been used, I, too, assumed that ToB was sort of a Catholic Kama Sutra. However, it is actually heavily indebted to John of the Cross. It also brings back final and formal cause to the understanding of the human being, contra both science and the entire modern project. It restores the notion of interiority to the body, which therefore cannot be treated simply as passive matter.

Michael on 2020-04-21 at 08:01 said:

"Biology is a human construct and does not exhaust all we know about the human being, sex, or the body"

An interesting point when contrasted to the modern approach of "constructs". While the modern approach says we can determine these for ourselves, JP II says there are higher methods of understanding to more great knowledge of the categories, a theology of the body (unified).

Yet in the other approach, we believe we can determine that human construct by just thinking it, isn't this just intellectual thinking centered from the individual? Pulling it down into discursive thought where all differences are forgotten instead of realized.

10.2 Meditations on the Body

You were a model of perfection, full of wisdom, perfect in beauty;
in Eden, the garden of God.

EZEKIEL 23:12-13

I've been doing some preparation for the upcoming discussion on the sexes from an esoteric perspective. Besides the obvious sources, I started reading *The Theology of the Body* by **Pope John Paul II**. I was more than a little surprised by what I read. As in any such work, the method is more important than the conclusion; the conclusion will make sense only by wrestling with the process.

Hence, this is a reflection just on chapter 1 which deals with the method. There are several themes which we have already addressed, showing the possibilities that can still be extracted from the Tradition. As such, the method is important in its own right, and not merely as a philosophically sophisticated justification of the doctrines on sexuality (the outcome is never in doubt). The real fruits will come when it is applied to other areas. I've highlighted several themes from my notes that warrant discussion.

- Opposition to modernity as defined by Bacon, Descartes, Kant
- Phenomenology as Hermetic meditation
- Subjectivity vs objectivity
- The relationship between experience and revelation
- Notion of the Person
- Nondual body/mind. Man as male and female

- Biblical texts as myth
- John of the Cross
- Self-mastery
- Tranquil witness of consciousness

While a pope has to be circumspect about what he writes, we are free to be more speculative in drawing out the logical conclusions and place these ideas in a wider context.

Modernity The primary reason that a refutation of the modern project is impossible is that it is perfectly logical within its own presuppositions, much like an alternative geometry is to the Euclidean. If you change one axiom, the rest ineluctably follows. What is necessary, therefore, is the refutation of the axiom. For that task, the ratio, or rational mind is inadequate. Rather, only the intellectus, or higher mind can accomplish it. This is the “intellectual conversion” that Guenon refers to. If the modern world is an illusion, only the truth can dispel it. But the truth must be “seen” or “intuited”, not discovered by reason, or philosophy, or scientific experiment.

Francis Bacon inaugurated the modern project when he eliminated formal and final causes from his philosophy. As a methodological assumption, it turned out to be quite powerful, leading to scientific discoveries and technological advances. The problem arises when the Bacon’s method is extended beyond that limited domain. Allegedly scientific theories about the origins of the universe, life, man, and society turn out to be destructive. The neglect of formal causes implies that the material world exists on its own and is self-explanatory. The denial of final causes implies that meaningless not just of the world, but also of man. There can be nothing “natural” beyond what we experience because nothing has a purpose beyond that.

Rene Descartes took the next step. For him, the body is part of the material world and consciousness is detached from it, with no clear relationship. This leads to **Arthur Schopenhauer**'s famous question in the introduction to the *World as Will and Idea*: where exactly is the scientist in his theory? How does he explain himself? Specifically, where is he at the "big bang" or the "origin of the species"? He claims to be an objective observer at those events, but that is clearly an absurdity.

JPII challenges this project radically. The body, for him, is never inert matter, but rather a fully integrated body/spirit. The very experience of bodiness forms the basis for his meditations.

The Turn to Interiority Although JPII Does not reject the metaphysic of being, he is more interested in exploring the states of consciousness described in the Genesis story, rather than understanding it simply as objective fact. This has led to criticism in some quarters. However, the insistence on pure objectivity, if taken too far, implies that even atheists can be theologians (such is the case). Theology becomes a "language game" with a set of rules that anyone can follow.

Now such an approach is not arbitrary subjectivity, from which many theological deviations arise. Rather, it is more like the way theology is understood in the East, as *theoria*, i.e., the theologian must actually "know" God, not just talk "about" God.

Thus, theology is not so much logic, but is based on the "interior gaze" as JPII expresses it. Confusion may arise because the distinction between the psyche or soul and the intellectus or spirit is poorly understood. At the soul level, experience is indeed merely subjective. However, paradoxically, the spirit is totally objective. It is the "witness to conscience" as JPII puts it.

The story of creation is "prehistory", since it cannot be understood in terms of history or science. JPII describes it as a "myth" and relies on figures such as **Mircea Eliade**, **Carl Jung**, among others to grasp

mythological symbols in their fullness. Note that this does not mean JP II denies that something “happened”, but he proposes a way to understand it.

He calls this method phenomenology, but it is not your grandfather’s phenomenology. Actually it is more like the Hermetic meditation described by **Valentin Tomberg**. He even refers to the lectures as “meditations”. So JP II uses the Biblical narrative to explore ever deeper levels of psychic layers. The main topics are “original innocence”, “original solitude”, the origin of shame, what it means to be embodied.

The objective text is insufficient. That is, revelation needs to be related to experience; it is not some incredible belief without relevance to life.

Sex Now Adam’s original state was solitude. Although he named, or knew, all the animals, none were suitable companions to him. With Eve came the awareness of being embodied as male and female. Now this brings up an interesting point about how sex is related to humanity.

Definitions can be conventional or real. A conventional definition, for example, includes types of triangles (equilateral, isosceles). A type of triangle is still a triangle, it has the property “triangularity”. Hence, the distinction is conventional and is made for convenience and communication.

A real definition includes genus and difference, e.g., “man is a rational animal”. Man is of the genus “animal”, and what distinguishes him is “rationality”. So he is both animal and not-animal. Of course, the scientific project rejects that notion, and regards man as just a “type” of animal. Rationality is a matter of degree not qualitative distinction.

So what then is sex? Is it more like a type of triangle? That is the modern view that regards one’s sex as somewhat arbitrary, and a person can therefore reassign or redefine his own sexuality. That is rejected.

But is it not of the second kind, since both male and females are fully

human, and not different species of the genus “human”? JPII writes that sex is “constitutive for the person” not an “attribute of the person”. Thus it is not conventional; it is essential to who one is, not accidental.

Thus there are differences between male and female. For example, man is the knower, woman is known, i.e., man is conscious.

Self-mastery In the Baconian project, every problem is presumed to have a technological solution. The body is no different from any other material object, so surgery, drugs, genetic manipulation, and other techniques are employed to solve existential issues.

However, for JPII, the human person is called to self-mastery. That is, the person is master of the body or, in Hermetic terms, the “subtle rules the dense”. Obviously this is also Evola’s position when he writes of an inner autarchy.

Now to be free is to be free of constraints. JPII points out that a “drive” is just an inner constraint. On the other hand, for the modern mind, freedom is the ability to act on one’s “instinctual” drives. Any “voice” that opposes that misunderstanding is experienced as a threat. From that perspective, happiness should be the result of such acting out. In other words, “the dense rules the subtle”.

This false maxim is taken to the extreme by Marxism, for which the forms of consciousness are determined by the material aspects of life. Since few people bother to understand the root thoughts of their worldview, they may hold Marxist ideas even while denying it. For example, the notion that all social problems can be “solved” by more education, programs, etc. is such a view. While a good regime is known for bringing peace and prosperity, it also requires a population that is able to exercise a certain measure of self-control.

Further Directions This method of phenomenology can be applied into new areas. Since the focus of *The Theology of the Body* is on marriage

and procreation, there is still much more to be said about being embodied as a man. There is the meditation on “original innocence”, as JPII says:

Original innocence conceived in this way manifests itself as a tranquil witness of consciousness that precedes any experience of good and evil.

Obviously, the “witness” state is not descriptive, as phenomenology claims to be, but rather prescriptive. That is, it is a task and is therefore “real” only for those able to achieve such a state. Elsewhere, he writes:

Man is the causal origin of actions and at the same time the author of their meanings.

Thus, a man must act consciously, understanding the meaning and consequences of what he does, for a determinate aim. Much of human activity is meaningless.

Similarly, rationality in the animal is virtual in most cases. A man’s task, then, is to actualize that quality. We can quickly mention:

- A life lived in accordance with reason
- Becoming free from irrational drives, emotions, etc.
- Taking responsibility for one’s actions
- Recognizing the personhood of others, not treating them as objects
- Achieving an inner state of calm and detachment
- Letting the subtle rule the dense
- Becoming the witness of consciousness

These qualities, and more, deserve studies of their own.

I Sleep, but the Heart is Awake

I sleep, but my heart is awake.

SONG OF SOLOMON 5:2

Please consider the four states of consciousness mentioned by **Bede Griffiths** in *The Cosmic Mystery*⁶.

We are accustomed to consider the sleeping, dreaming, and waking states as distinct states of consciousness, which follow each other consecutively. However, most of us have noticed that, rather than sequential, they interpenetrate each other. Our presumed waking state is mostly a series of semi-dreams: i.e., thoughts, imaginations, little stories, and so on. Then there is something deeper, beyond conscious awareness, in operation, affecting our postures, movements, attention and so on.

Among those dreams is the dream of awakening. That “I”, the subject of that dream, will “snap us out of it” from time to time. That I needs to be nourished until the whole heart is awake.

Theology of the Body A delay was caused by some new information⁷ on the *Theology of the Body* (H/T Perennial) that I came across as I was writing the introduction to the chapters on Sintesi that relate the sexes to race. Surprisingly, Evola’s ideas have some things in common with **Pope John Paul II**’s conceptions. Perhaps that is so, given the influence of German idealism and the philosophy of personalism on both of them.

For Scholasticism, the mind, or intellectual soul, is the image of God. The mind is without qualities, neither male nor female. For JP II and Evola, on the other hand, the body is the outward expression of spirit, hence either masculinity or femininity permeates the whole being. The

⁶<https://gornahoor.net/?p=8055>

⁷<https://sspx.org/en/theology-of-the-body-genesis-of-confusion>

Scholastic approach easily devolves to a Cartesian dualism of body and mind.

Moreover, the Scholastic definition of the person is too abstract: *an individual substance of a rational nature*. It does not mention Will, I, Freedom, Consciousness. Then there is Guenon's objection that it focuses on Being to the exclusion of non-Being. Specifically, it is too static, not making the distinction between the virtual and the actual. The actualization of a person is something else. Will must be developed, consciousness expanded, freedom/liberation must be achieved as it is not simply a given. "Truth shall set you free." For the Scholastics, there can be no development of the person. However, for JPII and Evola one of hallmarks of the person is self-possession, which requires a development.

Also, speculative theology does not make a clear distinction between soul and spirit. Mystical theology, on the other hand, does. **St John of the Cross**, for example, distinguishes between psychic experiences and truly spiritual experience. **St John of the Cross** is one of the influences on the Theology of the Body.

Sex and the Body These are some of the main points of the Theology of the Body. When the Evola translations come out, we can see better how they relate.

- There is no abstract "human": the human being is always embodied as a man or a woman. Masculinity and Femininity are expressions of the person.
- The Spirit is not without qualities.
- The body is not just matter, subject to physical or biological laws. Rather, it is permeated by the soul and the spirit. Otherwise, resurrection cannot be understood except as the revival of a corpse.

- Biology is a human construct and does not exhaust all we know about the human being, sex, or the body.
- The Baconian project of gaining power over nature, specifically, technological power over the body, is rejected. Rather, the subtle rules the dense so the spirit must control the body, without relying on material means.

Unintended Consequences There are perhaps other results that can be derived from this approach, not that they can be attributed to JPII. Biblical, mystical, philosophical, and phenomenological sources are used to develop the theology of the body. Why, then, can we not include other sources and even traditional sources? For example, Evola relies on **Otto Weininger's** book *Sex and Character* as well as the Laws of Manu for his own teachings on the spiritual and bodily aspects of masculinity and femininity.

Although JPII does not mention this, if the spirit has qualities, then race, or *ethnos* as **E Michael Jones** calls it, has its counterpart in the spirit. The relationship is not necessarily one-to-one, as we will see. Of course, this doctrine rejects the idea that biology or DNA is the cause of differences in psychic and spiritual makeup of the person.

Furthermore, the body cannot be understood as a piece of matter, but rather as a non-dual body/soul/spirit complex. This conception is developed by **Valentin Tomberg** in Letter XX of the *Meditations of the Tarot*. He shows the chain:

spirit $\Rightarrow$ psychic forces $\Rightarrow$ energy $\Rightarrow$ material organs.

That is the vertical process that works with the horizontal process of heredity. More research needs to be done to relate these various currents of thought.

Then, too, the notion that the body can be more or less dense begins to make some sense. Hence, there may be no physical traces of the Hyperboreans for the reason that the body in that era was less dense. This is

something proposed by Rene Guenon. In this case, the positive sciences cannot be the last word.

Posted on 2015-05-08 by Cologero

* * *

David on 2015-05-08 at 01:33 said:

Fascinating to delve into the theology of recent popes. I also liked the extract you took from Benedict XVI some texts ago; he is a brilliant theologian.

«Now to be free is to be free of constraints. JP II points out that a “drive” is just an inner constraint. Of course, for the modern mind, freedom is the ability to act out on one’s “instinctual” drives. Any “voice” that opposes that misunderstanding is experienced as a threat. From that perspective, happiness should be the result of such acting out. In other words, “the dense rules the subtle”.»

This also seems to be the error of psychoanalytic, i.e. the fascination with the subconscious as a force that drives and subject even the Self (considered in poor form, i.e. a social construct for overruling of subconscious urges). Psychoanalysis in more than one way is a direct inversion of Traditional principles, especially of Plato’s ideas.

aegishjalmer on 2015-05-08 at 01:58 said:

Thanks for that great analysis. Very helpful

Jacob on 2015-05-08 at 13:56 said:

Good post Cologero. There need needs to be some clarity these days on how to think about sex because all other information is so biased and convoluted that it causes a lot of confusion.

I struggle sometimes myself with eliminating Marxist materialist thoughts from my arguments. How can I oppose Liberalism as a force which causes the breakdown of Tradition without resorting to material conditions affecting a person’s thoughts.? It goes back to a question I had earlier when Evola said that degeneration caused people to think a certain way and adopt certain ideologies. That seems almost like materialism to me. I had always assumed the opposite. Certain modes of thought was the cause of degeneration. Maybe there’s a golden mean in between libertarian thought that the person is a self contained free willed individual with no external influences and Marxist determinism.

obscure on 2015-05-09 at 01:52 said:

Cologero,

This was a very even post: A calm tide at the day's end reiterating what was also present before daybreak; only having achieved a greater height. The pregnant Moon lifts up the waters of the soul in the darkness and offers the Father's light and that very light pours in which is the Son and the image of the Father. The light travels far in the darkness but is never divided from the Father. The waters rise up in the darkness receiving the Son's mediation with the subtle aid of feminine gravity.

Then day breaks again and men forget the terrors and struggles of the night; falling down and away quickly until they are reminded again. The sea of souls rages in ignorance with the Father in full view. Although on some days there is a calm breeze of grace sent down from above. The light penetrating the breeze is the same Son carried in the womb of the Moon at high tide. And the breeze of air pulls the waters along the surface, carrying the fire and separating the salt; walking upon the waters and embodying the light of presence. What is far is not far and what is close is not close; what is close is far and what is far is close. The height creates the depth and the depth returns to the height because there is nowhere else to go upon the horizon. Anyone can see, if they want to, that those who chase the horizon never get to heaven.

So, the wise stop moving their legs and instead they tilt back their heads. In this way, they understand that through not moving they are truly moving. This is why it is good to see good patterns in repetition.

Wayne Ferguson on 2015-05-09 at 15:10 said:

John Paul II

"The Redemption of the Body and Sacramentality of Marriage" (Theology of the Body)

"From the Weekly Audiences of His Holiness September 5, 1979 – November 28, 1984"

http://www.catholicprimer.org/papal/theology_of_the_body.pdf

X on 2015-04-22 at 01:16 said:

"St John of the Cross, for example, distinguishes between psychic experiences and truly spiritual experience."

Can you please say it more detailedly for this?

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 05:36 said:

X, this topic is discussed at length at *Three Ages of the Interior Life*⁸ by Fr Garrigou-Lagrange.

For example, concerning psychic phenomena: *The Illuminative Way of Proficients*⁹.

⁸<http://www.christianperfection.info/index.php>

⁹<http://www.christianperfection.info/tta82.php>

Also, on mystical union, which can also be read as the antidote to Cassiodorus' objections: *The Transforming Union*¹⁰.

X on 2015-04-22 at 06:04 said:

"The state which St. John of the Cross describes here is a state of love linked to a state of infused contemplation. The connection is owing to a necessity of love: 'True and full love cannot hide anything.' This connection is not accidental, since this need is connatural to perfect charity."

thomas walker on 2015-04-22 at 10:11 said:

We know from our own experience that body and soul are intimately related : bodily ailments can completely dominate our thoughts and emotions . I think that the kabbalistic idea of *nephesh* speaks to this , Our personalities are intimately linked with our bodies . There is a problem to understand how after death only the soul will exist until it is joined to the body in the Last Judgement . If time and space are abolished how can there be bodies which as bodies with extension must occupy space ?

Also , doesn't Jesus teach that in heaven there will neither be taking or giving in marriage because bodies will be like the angels (i assume that means without gender) Therefore gender is only accidental not essential .

obscure on 2015-04-22 at 15:20 said:

Nous is indeed prior to qualities, but qualities are received prior to the quantitative features of the body since quantity most signifies prime matter. The first relation to the body and thus to the macrocosm is qualitative, but pure Nous is not for this reason qualitative. Prime matter is also not separable and thus not really distinct from information. Although form itself as Spirit or Idea is really distinct from matter or informed matter.

The rational soul is a discursive intellect animating a material substance or complex subject (these terms are synonymous). Its constitutive features are active intellect, passive intellect and sense-perception. Pure intellect is only an active intellect and its constitutive features are its simple form and its essential act (sometimes erroneously translated by neo-Thomists in the tradition of Gilson as 'act of existence' but in truth 'essential act' or 'actus essendi' is pure will). A pure intellect is necessarily passive in relation to the First, but this is due to metaphysical necessity rather than discursive intellection with respect to the agent. The psychological (or 'epistemological' triad of the rational soul is not to be confused with the physiological triad (rational soul, sentient soul and vegetative soul) or the moral-constitutive triad (intellect, will and appetite).

¹⁰<http://www.christianperfection.info/tta105.php#bk2>

Substantial form is the subsisting simple subjectivity of a complex subject (or compound substance, material substance, etc.: These terms are synonymous). A per se simple subject (not subsisting in a complex subject) is either a Spirit or Idea which is specifically different from the Absolute simple subject. Thus the metaphysical triad of all reality is Absolute simple subject, relative or 'specific' simple subjects and lastly the complex subjects. In the order of pure simple subjects Spirits are active while Ideas are passive, although with respect to what is inferior (the order of complex subjects, the material cosmos, temporal procession, nature, etc.: These terms are synonymous) Ideas are obviously called 'active' but this is due to metaphysical necessity (which is to say, the hierarchy between God, supernature and nature). Corporeal form is constituted by extension and quality; it is an accidental form of a simple subject and it is the basic information of matter. Substantial form is not corporeal form, it 'contains' essential possibilities not corporeal matter.

The basic qualification of Spirits other than the Absolute is their essential act or will gratuitously caused by the First (for the only relationship between the Infinite and the finite is gratuitous i.e. grace). The Absolute cannot be distinguished from His essential act in any respect since the Absolute is a Pure Act of Infinite Power. Even though neo-Thomists may not write in this way it is all to be found in the primary texts of their Doctor and of other medieval doctors. Duns Scotus is in many respects the master and I recommend this blog containing some historical materials if any are interested:

<http://lyfaber.blogspot.com/>

David on 2015-04-22 at 16:30 said:

Cologero : Would it be possible to have all the texts within this site on a .zip or .rar format have a download link ? If the site is to end, a great part of the first texts I never had the chance to read. I imagine you have either a backup of .html files or the actual text files somewhere which could be given. Thank you.

obscure on 2015-04-22 at 18:48 said:

Here are some translations of the Scotistic Theoremata:

<http://lyfaber.blogspot.com/2010/01/theoremata-scoti-partes-i-v.html>

Scotus' discussion of quality is interesting, although I'm sure it won't surprise many.

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 20:28 said:

TW, this is the full quote: "In the resurrection they take neither wife nor husband, but are like the angels in heaven."

I suppose one approach is Guenon's: the being that was in the human state is now in an angelic state.

But, JP11 contrasts the resurrection body with our bodies as they are now, with its members at war with the spirit. The resurrection body will not experience that opposition, it will be spiritualized. JP11 is closer to Tomberg with this explanation:

Spiritualization signifies not only that the spirit will master the body, but that it will also fully permeate the body and the powers of the spirit will permeate the energies of the body. (67:1)

He takes pain to emphasize that this state is not “disincarnation” of the body, nor a dehumanization. There is a deep harmony between spirit and body, but primacy resides in the spirit. He goes on to relate this to theosis (translated as divinization).

In the resurrection, the body is outside of human history “tied to marriage and procreation”. However, this does not mean that the body is suddenly neutered. (It would be interesting to compare that idea with the way Mouravieff includes marriage and procreation as part of the “General Law”.)

Cologero on 2015-04-22 at 20:47 said:

Thanks for that synopsis, Obscure, but the issue is the whether or not JP11 is introducing novelty into that doctrine. It appears that he is rejecting the notion that the Spirit is distinct from the body. For the Scotist, is masculinity or femininity an accidental or an essential quality? If God has qualities, then why would not a man have them?

As for your other link, I read the claim that the “more perfect man has more perfect intelligence”. I thought the Scotist position is that the goal of creation is the divinization of man, i.e., union with God. I don’t see them as the same thing.

Cologero on 2015-04-23 at 08:55 said:

David, Gornahoor will not be taken off-line, since it is intended for a future generation that may have a better perspective. However, I won’t be updating it but perhaps someone else will.

obscure on 2015-04-23 at 23:15 said:

Hello Cologero,

Keep in mind that when I write some long comment I intend a general audience and not just yourself in particular, for I enjoy sharing information. There is much ink I could spill with regard to the hierarchies of metaphysical qualification. This would require a fine treatment with some more effort than I can provide at the moment. If anything I’ve provided has produced some degree of confusion it was due to a degree of privation on my part. I promise to address your points at a later time.

As for the ToB, I can't say I've read it. My impression was that it was mostly an exoteric text of a more-or-less existential nature.

I will leave off for now with a Hermetic passage (Although it is not the sort of passage to be taken with little consideration or lack of interpretation):

"Soul enters the body by necessity, Intellect enters soul by judgment. While being outside of the body, soul has neither quality nor quantity. Once it is in the body it receives, as an accident, quality and quantity as well as good and evil for matter brings about such things."

Cologero on 2015-04-24 at 00:07 said:

No confusion at all, Obscure, what you describe is how I would have been accustomed to look at it.

However, in light of the ongoing translation of Evola's *Sintesi*, there are questions that arise. I am not trying to provide the basis for a sophisticated theory of "white nationalism", but in exploring the metaphysical ramifications of his doctrine. Precisely, is there spiritual differentiation among men?

It is not so obvious that corporeal life is an accident. For example, in Plato's Myth of Er, the circumstances of birth are determined by the prior state of the spirit. For Guenon, each human being is a possibility of manifestation in God's mind, and this determines the "accidents" of birth. Perhaps these are differences in terms, but maybe not.

Based on the way it's been used, I, too, assumed that ToB was sort of a Catholic Kama Sutra. However, it is actually heavily indebted to John of the Cross. It also brings back final and formal cause to the understanding of the human being, contra both science and the entire modern project. It restores the notion of interiority to the body, which therefore cannot be treated simply as passive matter.

Michael on 2020-04-21 at 08:01 said:

"Biology is a human construct and does not exhaust all we know about the human being, sex, or the body."

An interesting point when contrasted to the modern approach of "constructs". While the modern approach says we can determine these for ourselves, JP II says there are higher methods of understanding to more great knowledge of the categories, a theology of the body (unified).

Yet in the other approach, we believe we can determine that human construct by just thinking it, isn't this just intellectual thinking centered from the individual? Pulling it down into discursive thought where all differences are forgotten instead of realized.

10.3 Solarity and Impassibility

Le cœur a ses raisons, que la raison ne connaît pas.

BLAISE PASCAL

And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.

JOHN 8:32

Many people expect to experience physical effects and/or emotional consolations from the meditation and prayer practice. I'm not denying that effects like visions, auditory phenomena, and condolences are possible. Rather they are not the goal. A fortiori, they usually diminish as you advance and it would be a mistake to expect them all the time.

At a recent Sunday sermon, the priest brought up the same point. He said that because God is spirit, He has no emotions, at least not as we understand them. Hence, we should not seek such emotional consolations. Of course, he was referring to God's impassibility but probably didn't want to explain that teaching to random lay people.

Impassibility Impassibility was one of the preternatural gifts before the Fall. (The others are integrity, immortality, and infused knowledge or gnosis.) If the aim of the spiritual life is theosis, to become more like God, then we need to recover the quality of impassibility that was lost. As this applies to God, the philosopher Edward Feser explains¹¹:

the claim that classical theism makes God out to be "unemotional" is ambiguous. If by an "emotion" we mean a state that comes upon us episodically, that varies in its intensity, that has

¹¹<https://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2014/09/olson-contra-classical-theism.html>

physiological aspects like increased heart rate and bodily sensations, etc., then it is certainly true that the classical theist maintains that God cannot possibly have such states. However, if the insinuation is that classical theism makes God out to be “unemotional” in a way that entails that he cannot be said to love us, to be angry at sin, etc., then that is certainly false. To love is to will the good of another, and for the classical theist God certainly wills our good, acts providentially so that we attain what is good for us, etc. Hence he loves us. The classical theist also holds that God wills that sin be punished, and acts so that those who are unrepentant are in fact punished. Hence he is in that sense wrathful at sin. And so forth. Hardly “apathetic.”

Our impassibility is analogous to God’s, but not identical. Obviously, as embodied beings, we do indeed experience emotions that spontaneously arise in us and with intense bodily sensations. Nevertheless, we can achieve some freedom from negative emotions like worry, doubt, fear, hate, apathy and despair, all of which imprison us to some degree. Of course, unlike in Eden, we are subject still to irreprehensible qualities such as hunger, thirst, pain, weariness, death, disease.

Practical Esoterism **Valentin Tomberg** has provided us a different standard by which to measure spiritual progress: viz., the sequence mysticism, gnosis, magic, philosophy. These can be briefly summarized.

- **Mysticism:** The first step is inner contact with the divine, beyond created being. This requires the body to be relaxed and the soul to be serene. This means that inner serenity is the starting point rather than the result.
- **Gnosis:** Gnosis is mysticism that has become conscious of itself, i.e., it is mystical experience that has been transformed into higher knowledge. This is direct, unmediated intuition, not a theory.

- **Magic:** Magic is the power of the invisible and spiritual over the visible and material. The aim of magic is “liberating action, i.e. the restoration of freedom to beings who have partially or totally lost it”, as Tomberg phrases it. Hence, gnosis is knowing the truth, which then sets us free.
- **Philosophy:** Esoteric philosophy is the culmination of the sequence. Its fundamental requirement is not to substitute one intellectual conception of the world with another, but rather to create in the individual a new “dimension” and a new depth of life.

Note that this does not include emotional consolation nor any physical sensations as necessary aspects of the mystical experience. To the contrary, emotions need to be silenced. Tomberg warns us of the danger of not following through the whole sequence.

Mysticism which has not given birth to gnosis, magic and Hermetic philosophy—such a mysticism must, sooner or later, necessarily degenerate into spiritual enjoyment” or “intoxication”. The mystic who wants only the experience of mystical states without understanding them, without drawing practical conclusions from them for life, and without wanting to be useful to others, who forgets everyone and everything in order to enjoy the mystical experience, can be compared to a spiritual drunkard.

Three Vows To prepare us, Tomberg provides us with the esoteric understanding of the three traditional vows. These are suitable not just to the religious, but especially to those living in the world.

- **Obedience:** The vow of obedience is the practice of silencing personal desires, emotions and imagination in the face of reason and conscience.

- **Poverty:** The vow of poverty is the practice of inner emptiness, which is established as a consequence of the silence of personal desires, emotions and imagination so that the soul is capable of receiving from above the revelation of the word, the life and the light.
- **Chastity:** The vow of chastity means to say the putting into practice of the resolution to live according to solar law, without covetousness and without indifference.

In other words, obedience means that personal desires, emotions, and fantasies must be made subservient to the intellect and the moral conscience. Spiritual poverty means the silencing of such desires, emotions, and fantasies.

Solarity Tomberg then explains the meaning of the solar law, or solarity.

For virtue is boring and vice is disgusting. But that which comes from the depths of the heart is neither boring nor disgusting. The foundation of the heart is love. The heart lives only when it loves. It is then like the sun. And chastity is the state of the human being in which the heart, having become solar, is the centre of gravity.

This describes the awakening of the heart chakra, as he explains:

Chastity is the state of the human being where the twelve-petalled lotus (anahata in Indian esoterism) is awakened and becomes the sun of the microcosmic “planetary system”. The three lotus-centres situated below it (the ten-petalled, the six-petalled, and the four-petalled) begin then to function in conformity with the life of the heart (the twelve-petalled lotus), i.e. “according to solar law”. When they do this, the person is chaste, no matter whether he or she is celibate or married.

The three lowest chakras are the seats of fear, sex, and hunger. When these chakras are subservient to the solar law, they are balanced and beneficial. Otherwise, they are disordered, abnormal, and come to dominate consciousness when they should be in line with intelligence and morality.

For more on the chakras as described by Johann Gichtel and Oscar Hinze, see *The Degrees of Existence*¹².

For the lower chakras, see *Sex and Tropism*¹³.

Posted on 2018-12-21 by Cologero

10.4 Meditations on the Good Life

Death, when understood by men, is immortality; but not being understood by the ignorant it is death. This death should not be feared; what should be feared is the perdition of the soul, which is ignorance of God; for this is terrible for the soul.

ST ANTHONY THE GREAT, *Counsels on the Character of Men
and on the Virtuous Life*

In tantum Deus cognoscitur, in quantum amatur.

ST BERNARD

(God is known to the extent He is loved.)

In recent days we have been advised on how to be good:

- By the president: Support the right to traffic in human body parts
- By a candidate: Make America great again

¹²<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8618>

¹³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=8349>

- By the pope: Turn off the air conditioner

In *The Sparkling Stone*, **Blessed John of Ruysbroeck** provides a more traditional perspective, as summarized in the following outline:

1. **How a man becomes good**

- (a) Clean conscience
- (b) Obedience to God
- (c) The glory of God

2. **How a man becomes inward**

- (a) A heart unencumbered with images
- (b) Spiritual freedom in his desires
- (c) The feeling of inward union with God

3. **How a man can see God**

- (a) The foundation of his being is abysmal
- (b) His inward exercise is wayless
- (c) His indwelling is a divine fruition

Becoming Good First a man must have a clean conscience that is free of sin. There are three elements of sin.

1. It must be a serious matter
2. Knowledge that it is a serious matter
3. Performed willfully

The pagan view found, for example, both among the ancient Greeks and Hindus, stops at the second element. For them, ignorance, or avidya, alone would lead to the clean conscience. Then the practice of the virtues would follow from that knowledge. However, this didn't take into account that, besides the ignorance of the mind, there is also a weakness of the will.

Hence, knowledge alone is insufficient, one must consciously follow God. John also adds that a man must be "obedient to his own proper convictions." Of course, the most proper convictions must be based on true knowledge. At a higher stage, John claims that even knowledge must be left behind in a state of learned ignorance, in which a man becomes free of such sin.

Finally, a good man should act for the glory of God. John explains:

If it happens that by reason of his business or the multiplicity of his works, he has not always God before his eyes, at least there should be established in him the intention and desire to live according to the dearest will of God.

This three qualities make a man good, so he is prepared for the next stages.

Becoming Inward John advises that anyone who considers himself spiritual needs to observe himself. Images in the imagination come from the flesh, not from God who is Spirit so no images are possible of Him. According to an old Norse adage,

The divine sleeps in the rock, breathes in the plant, dreams in the animal, and wakes in man.

This is related to Plotinus' path from the psyche, through nous, to God. The material world is both physical (the "rock") and psychical (the "animal"). The animal soul is material and is full of images. Thus it lives in a dream-like state, not yet self-conscious. To the extent that a man, who does indeed possess an animal soul, lives the same way, he is not yet awake

and not living a fully human life. So for the heart to become unencumbered with images, it must rise to the level of the nous by consciously observing himself.

As a man becomes free of worldly images, he becomes inwardly free. He becomes oriented toward God rather than toward the world. As imageless and free, he begins to feel a true union with God within; this perfects his inward and spiritual life. This acts like a feedback loop. The feeling of union, the desiring power of the soul (*epithetikos* or *eros*) becomes enticed to seek deeper union. God's knowledge of you is your knowledge of God; your willing of your own being is also God's willing.

Seeing God This union is experienced as "abysmal", i.e., arising from the measureless depths, unbounded heights and an endless horizon. He plunges into the depths of the soul and ascends to the heights. The horizon of Being always recedes. Our knowledge of God is never complete so we dwell in a "knowledge that is ignorance". By dying to things, the soul feels itself to be one life with God.

The next point is above reason and without condition. The inward drawing of the Divine Unity is experienced according to the measure of his love and the manner of his spiritual, interior exercises. Spiritually naked and unencumbered by images, he finds an Eternal Light in the inmost part of his spirit. This Light reveals the "eternal demand of the Divine Unity". The more he feels it, the more he craves it.

The fruition is the loving adherence to God. There is an inner silence, so that thoughts and images begin to lose their impact and compulsion. The spirit then beholds a Darkness, where discursive thought cannot penetrate. Hence, the spiritual exercise is "wayless", that is, there is no straight path to that Darkness, no mechanical process, no repetition of mantras. Rather one must be drawn into it, first through interior silence and the will to transcend discursive thought to a direct intuition.

Posted on 2015-08-03 by Cologero

* * *

Mark Citadel on 2015-08-06 at 12:48 said:

The contrast between John's view of the good could not stand in more stark contrast to the pablum we hear from the Modernist wardens could it?

"He becomes oriented toward God rather than toward the world."

Society follows the same metric. Oriented towards telluric interests it will be evil, but oriented up towards the divine, it will find its existence blessed, if only by natural forces and factors that govern success and decline.

Cologero on 2015-08-07 at 08:39 said:

Mark, another way to put it is that what the world finds lovable and what God considers lovable are quite different.

Aleksandar Gueric on 2015-10-02 at 08:34 said:

About becoming inward, Novalis wrote that "mysterious path leads within" and that "In us, or nowhere, is eternity with its worlds – the past and the future." This quote, for me, contains an explanation of a peculiar feeling, or sensation, I have had in me since very young age.

Past, for me, was never something gone but a living experience reachable through the mere power of concentration while objects around us – trees and rocks, when absorbed with intuitive knowing become living parts of the self. So, tree didn't decided to speak to me, for example, when I walked by it on one autumn day when I suddenly felt it's perspective – it's experience of time and change of seasons quite different from every day human one. It was only an intuition or deep knowledge and understanding of things behind their material forms and naturalistic mechanics.. I think that simultaneous experience of human consciousness and totality of all other non human consciousness as well as awareness of timelessness through the simple focus of mind, must be what people call "being awake".

Novalis' Magical Idealism sparked this kind of imagination and intuition ever since reading about him as a child in a big encyclopedia we had at home. I recognized his language although I had no intellectual capacity to know why, only intuitively how, through a symbolic collage of metalanguage. Many years forward, Lama Anagarika Govinda spoke with the same language to me in "Foundations of Tibetan Mysticism", book that have found me by pure accident. Then I realized he quoted Novalis a lot and, at one point, even considered being his reincarnation. I think that he was close. They both spoke the same language, walked the esoterically same path, perhaps. This language, or knowledge, I date back to Plato who formulated and crystalized it's essence. He was definitely an Initiate.

My peregrination during the turbulent 20s and falling into one trap after another in my constant search for something, which led me across 3 continents, finally seemed to come to

an end with the discovery of another author who spoke the secret language I understood, and who also loved to quote Novalis, my initial sparkle – Baron Julius Evola. Gate has been opened enabling me to finally move forward transcending in the spiral way out. Novalis's spiral path inwards.

This path is polarized or centered around the notion of a sacred center, which was, for me, always in Hyperborea. Real, unreal, mythical, physical, etheric, poetic, all in one. Magnetism was so strong that I envisioned myself bathing in Aurora Borealis, a cosmic North, source of light and purity. This is the greatest Ideal for me and true Home, which is "everywhere and nowhere".

I apologize for what must have been a crazy post. This site carries the same message and understanding which guided me through years of my journey and I'm grateful to find it.

10.5 Rest, See, Love, Praise

After this period God shall rest as on the seventh day, when He shall give us (who shall be the seventh day) rest in Himself... The seventh shall be our Sabbath, which shall be brought to a close, not by an evening, but by the Lord's day, as an eighth and eternal day, consecrated by the resurrection of Christ, and prefiguring the eternal repose not only of the spirit, but also of the body. *There we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise.* This is what shall be in the end without end. For what other end do we propose to ourselves than to attain to the kingdom of which there is no end?

SAINT AUGUSTINE, *City of God*

Augustine represents the time from Eden to the General Resurrection as the days of the week, culminating in the eighth eternal day. In that day of rest, the soul will finally see, it will love what it sees, and love evokes praise.

The Path of Knowledge

Not all men are in the same condition, and all are not led or disposed to a knowledge of the truth in the same way. For some are

brought to a knowledge of the truth by signs and miracles; others are brought more by wisdom. “The Jews require signs, and the Greeks seek wisdom” (1 Cor 1:22). And so the Lord, in order to show the path of salvation to all, willed both ways to be open, i.e., the way of signs and the way of wisdom, so that those who would not be brought to the path of salvation by the miracles of the Old and New Testaments, might be brought to a knowledge of the truth by the path of wisdom, as in the prophets and other books of Sacred Scripture.

THOMAS AQUINAS, *Commentary on John*

In this way then, from what has been said, we can understand the matter of this Gospel. For while the other Evangelists treat principally of the mysteries of the humanity of Christ, John, especially and above all, makes known the divinity of Christ in his Gospel.

Ibid.

Something rather than Nothing

Consider the universe... are we, now, to imagine that its maker first thought it out in detail... and that having thus appointed every item beforehand, he then set about the execution? Such designing was not even possible; how could the plan for a universe come to one that had never looked outward?... And all is made silently, since nothing had part in the making but Being and Idea — a further reason why creation went without toil.

PLOTINUS, *Enneads*

These Ideas exist in the Mind of God, from all eternity, not in stages as a general contractor would construct a house. As Rene Guenon pointed

out, some of these Ideas are possibilities of manifestation, i.e., they can and will participate in Being; moreover, by definition, they must needs become manifest. Nothing or the Void is not a possibility of manifestation. Nothingness is unthinkable. Hence, when God withdraws himself, leaving a void, that void will be filled up with creation.

The Meaning of Free Will The common misunderstanding of Free Will is the power to choose among alternatives. Since a Free Will is necessarily uncaused, this choice is usually conceived as arbitrary. For example, in one of **Jean Paul Sartre's** novels, a character stabs himself in the hand in a café, just to demonstrate his freedom. This is because most people can only understand the **gnomic will**, by which a person comes to a decision after deliberation.

The **natural will**, on the other hand, arises from one's very nature. It is free because it is not compelled from some source beyond one's own nature. A fortiori, God's will arises from his very nature or essence. It is not compelled by any creature.

Essence and Personality Man is a composition of Being and Becoming, or non-being. He has an essence, eternally known to God. When born, this essence manifests in time and space, as a substance. In the course of life, he acquires accidents, say as represented in Aristotle's categories. These are contingent, in the sense that they are not self-caused but depend on various external circumstances. One's life task is to fully manifest one's essence. That means the development of a unifying principle, or Self, that unites the disparted elements of the soul.

Augustine speculated on how these accidental qualities would manifest after the resurrection. To what extent would the resurrection body resemble the original body. Obviously, the new body would need to be recognizable to others, but it would need to be more perfect. Nevertheless, he speculated that the wounds of the martyrs would be visible, yet

not ugly. Moreover, nothing of life should be lost.

Being and Hell

Hell is the state of the soul powerless to come out of itself, absolute self-centredness, dark and evil isolation, i.e. final inability to love.

NICOLAS BERDYAEV, *The Destiny of Man*

There was a pagan adage that asserted, “It is better to die young, and best never to have been born at all.” Augustine opposes this view with the revealed truth that creation is good, or, said another way, being is better than non-being. The notion of Hell seems to bother many people, so they concoct alternatives such as annihilationism or universal salvation.

Since being is good, a corollary is that being is hell is still better than non-being; this refutes annihilationism. The other objection is that an eternal hell is unjust and not fitting to the ideal of Christ. We know that the Son will come to judge the living and the dead. Note the word “judge”; the Son acts as the impartial judge, not as an angry prosecutor. The person’s whole life will be put on the balance, not any one specific act.

To deny the possibility of hell is to deny free will. As mentioned above, one’s true will arises from one’s very nature. That is what makes the judgment just; one’s state of being is revealed in his thoughts and deeds. The notion that even the fallen angels will be redeemed is far-fetched. Unlike a material being, who combines being and non-being, a spiritual being cannot change. The decisions of the fallen angels were instantaneous and immutable. The attitude is that, “It is better to reign in hell than serve in heaven.” So, it is absurd to think that the demons will be coerced, against their will, to “serve” in heaven.

Moreover, “eternity” does not mean everlasting, or infinite duration in time. That is, eternity refers to “quality” and everlastingness to “quantity”. It is the quality of postmortem experiences that matter, not the duration. This is consistent with the state of the soul. **Valentin Tomberg** describes this difference:

This subjective state of soul is neither long nor short—it is as intense as eternity is. Similarly, the blessedness that a saint experiences in the vision of God is as intense as eternity —although it could not so last, since someone present at the ecstasy of a saint would time it as a few minutes. The “region” of eternity is that of intensity, which surpasses the measures of quantity that we employ in time and space. “Eternity” is not a duration of infinite length; it is the “intensity of quality” which, if compared with time and thus translated into the language of quantity, is comparable with an infinite duration.

Meditations on the Tarot

Union with God

No one has ever seen God: the only Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, he has made him known.

JOHN 1:18

The viewpoint of the Vedanta and the Neoplatonists is that the essence is absorbed into the Absolute without, however, the contingent or conditioned aspects of one’s being. This was the possibility before Christ, since that absorption is not really a “seeing” of God. Hence, there is no love and no praise.

The **Beatific Vision**, on the other hand, retains the personality. Tomberg explains how:

For this “vision” takes place in the domain of essence transcending all substance; it is not a fusion, but an *encounter* in the domain of essence, in which the human personality (the consciousness of self) remains not only intact and without impediment, but also becomes “that which it is”, i.e. becomes truly itself—such as the Thought of God has conceived it for all eternity.

The Beatific Vision is the union of essences, yet the two substances are separate. The individual personality persists.

Posted on 2020-04-19 by Cologero

* * *

Samuel Fiebig on 2020-04-20 at 09:04 said:
Absolutely beautiful. Thank you.

Matt on 2020-05-15 at 15:25 said:

Are you using the term “personality” interchangeably with “essence”. Maurice Nicoll, in his *Psychological Commentaries*, distinguishes the two by stating that personality is the mask we put on in order to make our way through the contingencies of life and society. It is our external manifestation, and forms the meat around the seed of our essence. This allows some (maybe not many) to grow their essence later in life by feeding off the personality. So instead of dying as a seed, they become fully realized. How one’s essence “feeds” and grows from one’s personality is the part I’m not clear about in Nicoll’s writing. In any case, I’m assuming this is not quite the meaning of personality that you’re using. The more fully developed essence is that which persists, I would assume, which could be thought of as a union of one’s inner essence with one’s external personality.

Cologero on 2020-05-15 at 22:54 said:

Yes, more like your final sentence. I was using it in Tomberg’s sense as the last section of the post shows. Unfortunately, there is not a consistent philosophical language in English, and on top of that, we have to deal with translations from other languages like French or Russian; hence, context is always important. Your point, I believe, illustrates what we have been doing in our meetings. We are taking those negative aspects of the personality, which steal our psychic energies, and converting that energy into the development of essence. This is not different

from using the awareness of sinfulness as motivation to a higher purpose. Tomberg's point is that nothing in our life is lost; this is unlike some eastern and similar teachings that strive for depersonalisation. Augustine addresses this issue in the *City of God* when he writes about the general resurrection: how does our earthly life correspond to the resurrection life?

10.6 The Five Ways to God

The misconception is that the so-called 5 proofs for the existence of God are supposed to be so compelling that anyone, or even a robot, will know that God exists by following a syllogism. By that standard, you cannot even prove that you yourself exist, or that your wife, husband, or lover exists; i.e., any being with an "I" or Self.

That is why Valentin Tomberg suggests instead to use the proofs as seeds for a deeper meditation. These are mine, but you should do your own. The quest for certainty is not satisfied by a scientific, mathematical, or logical proof, but rather in an entirely different dimension.

Perhaps the *quinque viae*, the five ways of reasoning, of St. Thomas Aquinas will not necessarily convince you, but you will emerge from meditative work on the five arguments proving the existence of God with a clear head and a calm heart, well-prepared and equipped to seek and find other ways to certainty. It is the occupation with these five ways of reasoning which will render you stronger and calmer, which will elevate you above all the entanglements due to the confused play of complexes which are a mixture of feelings in which personal preferences assert themselves and thoughts which are only a mouthpiece for these preferences. And it is this elevation above psychological complexes which is the salutary effect — even the healing action — of occupation with scholasticism, when one reads in the style of scholastic meditation.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Letter XX The Sun*

The purpose of these meditations is not to win an argument, but to raise one's level of being. Beyond the rational, discursive mind, there is the intuitive mind. The latter is the only adequate way to know God, a realization that Thomas reached near the end of his life. In sum, these are the five ways.

- **The First Way:** God, the Unmoved Mover
- **The Second Way:** God, the First Cause
- **The Third Way:** God, as Necessary
- **The Fourth Way:** God, as the Absolute
- **The Fifth Way:** God, the Designer

These are not logically compelling proofs, but rather their truth is understood through meditation on the concepts. Otherwise everyone would be compelled to believe in God by running an algorithm, including your expensive sexbot, who would suddenly refuse to have sex with you until you married her.

Belief must be free, not forced. Do you believe your lover is a conscious human being with a sense of self? You have no logical or empirical proof of that, nor would you even raise the question.

Here are some suggestions for meditation. This is not a complete exposition, just some starting points. As the concepts germinate in consciousness, perhaps they will be left behind in favour of direct intuition.



The First Way: God, the Unmoved Mover

Quietly observe the movement of thoughts, images, emotions in mind. Allow them to arise and pass away without attachment to any one of them. In the midst of all these changes in consciousness, what does not move?

The Second Way: God, the First Cause

Matter is condensed energy, energy is condensed psychic force, and psychic force is the condensation of consciousness, i.e., spirit.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, Letter XX

Inertia is the fundamental law of matter: an object at rest will remain at rest, and an object in motion will remain in motion, unless acted upon by an outside force. This means that matter is the passive force and cannot change its state unless an outside force brings it about. Hence Matter cannot be the first cause.

Matter is condensed energy. Energy is the ability to do work, i.e., “cause things to change state”. Hence, energy is the active force necessary to cause motion. How to reconcile the two, since pure matter is indeterminate, i.e., nothing in particular.

So it is with Schrodinger’s famous cat. It is neither dead nor alive until one looks. That is the psychic force or will. The psychic force is noumenal so it cannot be detected by any physical experiment.

The psychic force requires an agent, since it exists in consciousness, not in reality. That agent is spirit, so by analogy God is the first cause of all things.

The Third Way: God, as Necessary Why is there something rather than nothing? The Void, or Nothing, is not a possibility of manifestation, i.e., it does not exist. Hence, it is a possibility of non-manifestation, that

is, it is part of Non-Being. Therefore, to even conceive of the possibility of Nothing, then Non-Being must be conceivable. Thus, it is necessary.

Being includes all possibilities of manifestation, or whatever is not Non-Being. Hence, Being, or the manifested world, is contingent. But the Void cannot be manifested, thus there will always be contingent beings.

The Fourth Way: God, as the Absolute The fourth way is that of Ascending Cognition: ascending from the cognition of the phenomenal to the beings behind it. The kingdoms of nature must be studied first to find definite archetypal forms expressed in them.

- Physical nature is recognized first
- Living Nature, including plants and animals
- Next human beings
- Then the suprahuman spiritual world

From the experience of the phenomenal world, abstract to the noumenal or spiritual world, to understand the form of the thing. Widen the understanding beyond individual things. Notice how systems take place in space and time. Through higher level abstractions, more and more is understood with less and less.

Ultimately, one ascends to Being and to the Absolute.

The Fifth Way: God, the Designer This way is the opposite of the meditation on the fourth way. This meditation is descending cognition: the highest soul forces are first apprehended and a gradual descent follows.

Start with God as Infinite, as the author of all possibilities. The entire universe is present to Him, not in time, not in concepts, but directly. How can a world arise? How can a world that contains free beings manifest?

- Geometry and Arithmetic form the dividing line between the ideal and real
- They are respectively the foundations of space and time
- Intermediaries, or messengers, are first necessary
- They choose to follow or oppose the plan.
- A free being is a moral being. As such, he needs an opposition to his will in order to make choices.
- A free being, who knows both good and evil, must experience both forces.
- He requires a body, unlike angels.
- Animals form the pattern. We observe how biological systems co-operate to form a body.
- Vegetative life forms the foundation
- The physical world is the substrate
- The size and age of the universe are necessary to support human life

Details need to be filled in. As they are, the necessity of each stage is understood.

Posted on 2020-11-29 by Cologero

About the Unknown Friend

II.1 The Conversion of Valentin Tomberg

Much ink (virtual and real) has been spilled regarding the conversion of **Valentin Tomberg** from Anthroposophy to Roman Catholicism. Yet, as we saw in the conversion of **Rene Guenon**, such a move cannot be understood in the conventional sense as the rejection of one thing and the adoption of another.

Nevertheless, there are those who are convinced that Tomberg rejected so-called New Age teachings to become a Catholic, and therefore attempt to follow him in that path. As a matter of fact, it seems that the Internet is replete with converts (or reverts) who are quite enthusiastic in promoting their new-found faith, usually to excess. While we think such conversions are a good thing in general, that is not at all Tomberg's message.

In Letter XI, Tomberg explain his reasons for entering the Church.

The way of Hermeticism, solitary and intimate as it is, comprises authentic experiences from which it follows that the Ro-

man Catholic Church is, in fact, a depository of Christian spiritual truth, and the more one advances on the way of free research for this truth, the more one approaches the Church. Sooner or later one inevitably experiences that spiritual reality corresponds — with an astonishing exactitude — to what the Church teaches.

He then lists several specific teachings:

- There are guardian angels
- There are saints who participate actively in our lives
- The Blessed Virgin is real, as she is understood, worshiped, and portrayed
- The sacraments are effective and there are seven of them
- The three sacred vows of obedience, chastity, and poverty constitute the very essence of all authentic spirituality
- Prayer is a powerful means of charity
- The ecclesiastical hierarchy reflects the celestial hierarchical order
- The Holy See and the papacy represent a mystery of divine magic
- Hell, purgatory, and heaven are realities
- The Master himself abides with his Church
- The Master is always findable and meetable there

The Common Believer Any cursory reading of the Meditations shows that it is replete with references to ideas, systems, books, and people that are certainly precursors to the New Age teachings of today. Yet Tomberg did not reject them in toto, not at all. To the contrary, he makes the remarkable claim that following Hermetic teaching to its depths led to his “conversion”. The reasons for this must be explored in what follows. But first of all, note that Tomberg does not claim any sort of superiority; rather, he acknowledges a solidarity with common believers, as expressed in Letter IV.

For the Hermetic-philosophical sense has more in common with the plain and sincere faith of simple people than abstract metaphysics has.

- For the common believer, God lives; likewise for the Hermeticist.
- The believer addresses himself to saints and Angels; for the Hermeticist they are real.
- The believer believes in miracles; the Hermeticist lives in the presence of miracles.
- The believer prays for the living and the dead; the Hermeticist dedicates all his efforts in the domain of sacred magic to the good of the living and the dead.
- The believer esteems all that which is traditional; the Hermeticist does likewise.

Rejection of Alternatives In the Introduction to *Inner Development*, we are informed that Tomberg initially tried to align himself with the Christian Community and then with Russian Orthodoxy.

The Christian Community was formed by some of Rudolf Steiner’s followers; they have no dogmas, although they have priests and seven

sacraments. However, dogmas are not an affront to free will as the Community claims, but rather they are living symbols of a higher spiritual reality as Tomberg came to realize. Typically, organisations that reject dogmas tend to converge to liberalism.

Tomberg attempted to work with the Christian Community by introducing a cult of Mary-Sophia. Emil Bock reportedly said to him: “We have Michael, that’s enough! We don’t need Mary-Sophia.”

As we will see in the next section, that is absolutely contrary to Tomberg’s purpose and mission.

Orthodoxy lacks a complete hierarchy, in particular, the papacy which Tomberg regards as a mystery of divine magic. Russian Orthodoxy retains a notion of being the Third Rome, with an Emperor and the Patriarch as Pope. From the esoteric perspective, this is a caricature of the true teaching, whose real source is suspect. Most of the early popes came from the East; they were more aware of the celestial hierarchy and divine magic. Someday, there will be a Russian pope ruling in the first Rome.

The Blessed Virgin Tomberg insists that the Blessed Virgin is real, as she is understood, worshipped, and portrayed in the Church. This means that he accepts the four Marian dogmas, not as beliefs but as a personal experience. These are:

- Mary as the Mother of God
- Perpetual Virginity
- The Immaculate Conception
- The Assumption

Although it is not so common today, when I was a schoolboy, we would attend yearly novena to the Blessed Virgin. We would be given scapulars or medals. Although I might not have fully understood their significance

at the time, I have always lived in the security of Mary's promises of protection. Tomberg describes the esoteric meaning of these promises:

Every Hermeticist who truly seeks authentic spiritual reality will sooner or later meet the Blessed Virgin. This meeting signifies, apart from the illumination and consolation that it comprises, protection against a very serious spiritual danger. For he who advances in the sense of depth and height in the "domain of the invisible" one day arrives at the sphere known by esotericists as the "sphere of mirages" or the "zone of illusion". This zone surrounds the earth as a belt of illusory mirages. It is this zone which the prophets and the Apocalypse designate "Babylon". The soul and the queen of this zone is in fact Babylon, the great prostitute, who is the adversary of the Virgin. ... One cannot traverse it without the protection of the "mantle of the Blessed Virgin".

Mary is celebrated as the Queen of Heaven. Tomberg has a deeper insight that takes that teaching much further. In Letter XI, he asserts:

The day when it is achieved will be the day of a new festival — the festival of the coronation of the Virgin on earth. For then the principle of opposition will be replaced on earth by that of collaboration. This will be the triumph of life over electricity. And cerebral intellectuality will then bow before Wisdom (SOPHIA) and will unite with her.

The Virgin will be not only Queen of Heaven, but also Queen of the Earth. Of course, this is confirmed in the *Dogmatic Constitution*, which calls Mary the Queen of the Universe.

The triumph of life over electricity refers to the Hermetic teaching of electricity, or electro-magnetism, arising from lower forces. Just as a reminder, Tomberg explains:

The fruit of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil — the fruit of the polarity of opposites — is therefore electricity; and electricity entails fatigue, exhaustion, death. Death is the price that is paid for the knowledge of good and evil, i.e. the price of life amidst opposites. For it is electricity — physical, psychic and mental — which was introduced into the being of Adam-Eve, and thereby into the whole of life-endowed Nature, from the moment that Adam-Eve entered into communion with the tree of opposites, that is to say with the principle of electricity. And it is thus that death entered into the domain of life-endowed Nature.

Therefore, the next dogma will be Mary as Co-Redemptrix.

Way, Truth, and Life Tomberg rejected Anthroposophy (although not Steiner himself), describing it as

a movement for cultural reform (art, education, medicine, agriculture) deprived of living esotericism, i.e. without mysticism, without gnosis and without magic, which have been replaced by lectures, study and intellectual work aiming at establishing a concordance between the writings and stenographed lectures of the master.

In other words, it has Truth but not the Life. It is locked in concepts, meaning that one learns the concepts first, then tries to have the experience, whereas it should be vice versa. Tomberg explained this in a letter to Bernhard Martin:

First they [i.e., Anthroposophists] have a world of formulated concepts and then try to arrive at experience. But the concepts hold them shut within their world: the spiritual world remains silent, because they are the ones talking about the spiritual world; they don't let it speak. It's otherwise with people [like

Jung]; in silence they let the spiritual world speak. And the spiritual world speaks in symbols — i.e. in mystery speech — today just like before.

In other words, it is necessary to treat the concepts as symbols, as the symbol is understood in the Meditations. It is an invitation to a personal meditation, not a univocal concept to be learned. In *Covenant of the Heart*, Tomberg is more explicit:

Alas it happened, however, for reasons which we need not go into here, that Rudolf Steiner gave his work the form of a science, so-called “spiritual science”. Thereby the third aspect of the indivisible threefoldness of the Way, the Truth, and the Life was not given enough attention. For the scientific form into which the logic of the Logos had to be cast, and by which it was limited, left little room for pure mysticism and spiritual magic, that is, for Life. So there is in Anthroposophy a magnificent achievement of thought and will — which is, however, unmystical and unmagical, i.e. in want of Life. Rudolf Steiner himself was conscious of this essential lack. Therefore, it was with a certain amount of hope that he indicated the necessary appearance of a successor (the Bodhisattva), who would remedy this lack and would bring the trinity of the Way, the Truth, and the Life to full fruition.

Knowledge as Intuition Tomberg is trying to get us out of our heads in order to experience a higher type of knowledge. In *Covenant of the Heart*, he explains:

truth is based on “intuition [which] is not attained through practical knowledge or intellectual consideration (reflection), but through direct experience of reality ... ‘an evolving revelation from the inner being of man’ ... and ‘a direct grasping of the being of things’.

He then goes on:

For those who experience it, this form of knowledge counts as the highest because it is experienced . . . as the result of the most profound contemplation and the greatest concentration, in comparison with which that of intellectual consideration and the practical knowledge gained by way of observation appears superficial. However, it does not count in the slightest way as knowledge (let alone as the highest form of knowledge) for the scientific disciplines which, as such, lay claim to being of general validity. For the scientific approach is not to strive simply for the truth, but rather to strive for that brand of truth which is of general validity, i.e. that which can be comprehended fundamentally by everyone bestowed with healthy understanding and faculties of perception, and which should thus be concurred with. A scientific discipline, whether a spiritual-scientific or a natural-scientific discipline, does not want to, and is not able to, address itself only to those people who are capable of the concentration and inner deepening necessary for intuition. Were it to do so, it would then not be scientific, i.e. generally comprehensible and provable. Rather, it would be “esoteric”, i.e. a matter for an elite group of special people. In this sense theology is also “science” since, assuming the authority of Scripture and the Church are acknowledged, it can be comprehended and tested by all believers.

Direct spiritual knowledge achieved through intuition is *personal*—never general or universal, i.e. scientific in the conventional sense. That is why Hermetism is not one philosophical system among many systems, nor one scientific theory among other competing views, nor the foundation of a new religion. In other words, it is not expansive in the horizontal sense, but rather a matter of depth, i.e., a deepening of understanding.

Postscript So, to simplify, we can define:

- The Truth as the understanding of concepts
- The Way as the deepening of that understanding
- The Life as direct intuition

An example might be this:

- Hegel's system of Absolute Idealism, or perhaps other similar systems
- Steiner created not just a thought system, but also proposed a path of spirit and soul development
- Tomberg opens up the meaning of symbols and intuition

Posted on 2018-08-17 by Cologero

II.2 Myth as Eternal Idea

The most profound thought is bound up with the historical, external figure of Christ. And the greatness of the Christian religion is that it is there for every stage of development. It is within the grasp of the most naive consciousness and at the same time it is a challenge to the deepest wisdom.

GEORG HEGEL

The story of Jesus' three temptations in the wilderness, as described in Matthew and Luke, was commented on by **Valentin Tomberg** in all the phases of his public life. Hence, it will serve to demonstrate the consistency of Tomberg's understanding. This will involve three steps

- A brief summary of four works from different periods of his life.

- The methodology used
- An interpretation of the three temptations, highlighting any development and changes over time.

Tomberg's Life Stages The following works contain discussions of the three temptations in the wilderness. The different versions show a remarkable consistency, especially for someone who allegedly underwent a radical conversion.

- **Anthroposophic Meditations on the New Testament.** These meditations were composed during the period when Tomberg was fully committed to the Anthroposophical Society. However, by the end of the 1930s, he was being eased out.
- **Inner Development.** This is the English translation of a series of seven lectures delivered in 1938, when he was separated from the society. It seems that he believed that the Michael Community (a church inspired by **Rudolf Steiner's** teachings) would be the bearers of a new future.
- **Degeneration and Regeneration of Jurisprudence.** This was a thesis written by Tomberg in 1944 concerning his understanding of law and jurisprudence. By this point, he had entered the Catholic Church. Since the thesis was intended to be academic, there are no references to Steiner or other Hermetic teachings.
- **Meditations on the Tarot.** Obviously, this is Tomberg's mature work, and the one he wanted to be known by. Steiner plays an important role in it, but he is placed in a much larger context. The foundation of these meditations is the Hermetic Tradition from Hermes Trismegistus up through its manifestation in France in

the early part of the 20th century. Steiner, then, is one figure within that tradition, and not the sole authority as he is for the anthros.

By placing Steiner within a larger tradition, he cannot play the role of an extra “pope”. Thus, as Tomberg came to see, Hermetism is not in competition to the exoteric church but instead confirms its teaching. His task was to reconcile the two, which had been in conflict for centuries.

The church without the life of Hermetic teachings would fall into a type of humanism in which, for example, a pope would be more concerned about air conditioning rather than saving souls. And Hermetism on its own usually leads nowhere, as the examples of Crowleyism and the Golden Dawn show.

Philosophy Tomberg adheres to the tradition of the true Philosophy, i.e., that which includes Plato, Aristotle, Neoplatonism, Medieval realism, philosophical idealism, not to mention Hermetism. Ideologies like empiricism, materialism, atheism, and so on, are actually anti-philosophies, and therefore have no place.

As was explained previously, Philosophy teaches that there are three levels of knowledge. The highest is Intuition, or direct insight, which transcends even logical reasoning. To make an analogy, suppose Mike and Ike are at home, wondering if it is raining outside. Mike analyses the weather patterns and makes the case that it cannot possibly be raining. Ike, on the other hand, goes out the front door onto the lawn, where he can experience the rainfall.

So which of the two knows the truth? Clearly it is Ike. Your own experience should convince you of the futility of logical arguments to change someone’s mind, except perhaps among mathematicians.

Excursus on Hinduism Since it is unlikely that Europeans will start building temples to the monkey god, they probably are referring to Yoga

or the Advaita Vedanta when they embrace Hinduism. However, as we've demonstrated convincingly, the Advaita philosophy is compatible with the True Philosophy of the West—just search for Guenon, Radhakrishnan, Murti, or Bede Griffiths, *inter alia*, in these pages.

However, what was proper to the people of the Indian subcontinent is not necessarily proper to contemporary Europeans. The Vedanta is a static, ahistorical system, but Europeans have an historical consciousness. Now the yogis recognize that there has been a "Fall of man" from some Golden Age to our current situation; the entire reason for being of the yogic path is to restore that Age.

Yet, they have no explanation for how that Fall occurred. Just ask your neighbourhood yogi, as I have. The West, on the other hand, does have an understanding of the circumstances around the Fall. Because of that, it also has a better understanding of how to restore the primordial state.

There is no question of making a "case" through reasoning. Rather the task is to gain a deeper insight by intuition, similar to the way Ike determined it was raining. After having meditated on Tomberg's explanation of the temptations in the desert, you can see that it rings true.

Method In the Meditations, Tomberg explains:

[myths] reveal the archetypes which manifest themselves endlessly in history and in each individual biography — they are mythological symbols pertaining to the domain of time.

In other words, a myth is true, not simply because it describes a physical event at a certain instant in space-time, but rather because the event is recreated in human consciousness throughout history.

Hans Leisegang, quoted by Tomberg, claimed:

Every myth expresses, in a form narrated for a particular case, an eternal idea, which will be intuitively recognised by him who re-experiences the content of the myth.

That “eternal idea”, or “ideal” in Tomberg’s version, is the goal of the myth. The process was described in *The Future of Intelligence*¹. The myth starts with physical events, which is at the level of doxa or opinion. We then try to formulate the unifying idea that relates the various elements of the myth. Eventually, we may grasp, in a moment of insight, the eternal idea in the Mind of God, the Wisdom of God or Sophia.

Some want to insist on the details of the myth, as if the story could have been recorded by a camera crew. Then the story of the temptations could make a good Netflix show, with the image of the devil and beautiful depictions of the various temptations. And the audience would be on the edge of their seats wondering if the temptations would be accepted.

But in that case the deeper, or true, meaning would be obscured. Only when the temptations can be experienced fully in one’s own consciousness, as well as that of humanity as a whole, will the myth’s meaning be revealed.

There is no argument or proof necessary, but rather the “seeing” that it is true. The revelation is not the details of the story; rather, it is that moment of insight. Its truth is understood when it brings light onto one’s own situation as well as the human condition.

Posted on 2018-09-04 by Cologero

11.3 The Temptations in the Wilderness

[materialists] fear judgment. Because the future brings retribution for the past, people deny both the moral world order and the future in the sense of that moral world order.

¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=10063>

VALENTIN TOMBERG

One generation creates the destiny of the next.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Although the sequence differs between Matthew 4:1-11 and Luke 4:1-13, these are the three temptations:

- To turn stones into bread
- To jump off the pinnacle
- To rule the world

The first item to note is the symmetry between the beginning of the Old Testament and the New Testament. Genesis sets the stage for the emergence of the First Adam and the three temptations in Eden:

- Listening to the serpent. The serpent was cunning and shifted the perspective of Adam and Eve from the vertical to the horizontal.
- Seeing fruit as a delight to the eyes.
- Eating of the fruit

Adam and Eve succumbed to each of those temptations, and then experienced the corresponding effects.

First of all, Eve allowed the voice of the serpent to have equal influence with that of God. This was an act of disobedience and the result was doubt, i.e., having two minds in conflict with each other.

This put the tree in a new light, for now it seemed desirable. Doubt wants to be resolved by experience, i.e., to actually taste the fruit of the tree. That is greed, the opposite to poverty.

Eating the fruit, i.e., actually undergoing the experience is unchastity.

The New Testament begins with the stories of Jesus' origins ending with the Baptism in the Jordan. He is led to fast for 40 days in the wilderness. There, Satan tempts him, but Jesus resists each one of them. The following sections show Tomberg's analysis from each of the four works mentioned.

Anthroposophic Meditations on the New Testament In this work, there are two chapters devoted to the temptations in the wilderness. The NT starts with the human and leads to the divine. Curiously, Tomberg begins his discussion with Friedrich Nietzsche. Nietzsche experienced loneliness and isolation in their depths. That is, he knew the wilderness and its temptations, yet yielded to them.

His emptiness led him to seek the fullness of life in the instincts and the will to power. Then from the mountain top, Nietzsche came up with the idea of the Eternal Return. This means that the Earth has no future, but is condemned to repeat itself endlessly. Nietzsche claimed to have been inspired by superior forces. Yet then led him to devalue God, spirit, soul. The same temptations exist today, although few succumb with the same intensity.

Jesus in the wilderness was likewise isolated; the angels did not minister to him until afterwards. For, according to Tomberg, it is human freedom that must resist the temptations. The wilderness represents the Kali Yuga, the Dark Age. That is the temptation of humanity as a whole, which we see constantly repeated. Suprasensory experiences are rare because people have not yet decided:

- Whether to rule or to serve (power or obedience)
- Whether to possess the kingdoms of the past or to wander destitute into the future (wealth or poverty)

- Whether to desire miracles of knowledge (the authority of miracles or the chastity of knowledge)

People are exposed to these temptations in diverse forms and Tomberg provides examples.

First Temptation. Stones into Bread The tendency is to substitute a quantitative numerical value to everything qualitative and specific. But quantity is death and the property of quality, the living, cannot be reduced to it.

Tomberg considers money as an example of converting metal or paper into a “basket of bread”. The value of money is arbitrarily set while bread, which supports life, is subjected to the power of number. The prime example of this is in the USA where the major concern in elections is the GDP, as the spiritual and intellectual level of society declines precipitously.

Second Temptation: retreat into the subconscious This temptation is to seek the source of life in the instinctual life of the subconscious. This is jumping from the pinnacle into the abyss, the domain of hidden instinctive urges. Thinking is difficult so the temptation is to expect miracles from the subconscious.

The true source of life, however, is the superconscious and the free life of thinking.

Third temptation: materialism Materialism is the temptation to see the world as having no moral or spiritual guidance. This view grants them freedom from responsibility. However, when materialism is followed all the way through, the ruling intelligence behind matter will be seen to be the “prince of the world”.

The path of materialism leads through hallucination to insanity and from insanity to demonic possession. These terms are not meant in a clinical sense, and the symptoms are certainly noticeable in our time.

The fundamentals of materialism are force, chance, matter

- Blind force is the opposite of spiritual light, a denial of the Holy Spirit
- Blind chance is the opposite of the Logos, or Son
- Spiritless matter stands in contrast to the cosmic First Cause, or Father

Force is unspiritual time, chance the lack of causality, and matter, the mechanization of life. The results are sleep, prostration, and death. The following meditation contains the opposite tendencies:

- Out of the Godhead is created humankind.
- In Christ death becomes life.
- In Spirit's cosmic thoughts, the soul awakens.

Inner Development In the series of lectures published with the title *Inner Development*, there is a brief discussion of the three temptations. The context is a critique of the three currents of contemporary intellectual life, viz., religion, art, science

Religion Religion has succumbed to the temptation of reckoning with the Prince of this world. It has succumbed to the temptation to organize the world with the help of a power principle and take possession of it with the help of a centralized power organization. This is the temptation to rule the world, provided one bows down to Satan.

He then criticizes the Roman Church which, he claims, “strove to bring the world and its glories under its dominion.” However, in the *Meditations*, the view becomes more balanced. He came to recognize that the Church is the Mystical Body of Christ, i.e., a real entity. It is the egregore of the Church, a factitious creation, that succumbs to the temptation, not the Mystical Body.

Art Tomberg then turns his attention to art:

Artistic creation is increasingly becoming a situation whereby the artist creates out of the deep dark underworld of his subconscious.

That is because the artist succumbs to the temptation of jumping into the abyss.

The artist leaps from the pinnacle of the temple of clear consciousness into the sphere of impulses, instincts, whence something is supposed to arise that is to be regarded as angelic revelation.

The art of popular culture is now plagued with vulgar, scatological, and sexual innuendo. For some reason, this is considered to be a deep insight into the human condition.

Science Science succumbs to the temptation to turn stones into bread:

Modern science is based upon the conception that the dead mineral world can be the foundation of everything, and that everything living is only a consequence of movement in this mechanical, dead world. i.e., all bread arises out of stone.

Summary Tomberg related the temptations to the political forces rampant at that time. The specifics might not be so important now, but the temptations still arise in different contexts.

World history is essentially nothing other than the continual karmic confrontation of humanity with the first, the second, the third, or all three temptations.

Degeneration and Regeneration of Jurisprudence In this PhD thesis, written shortly after his conversion, Tomberg reformulates the temptations in the context of jurisprudence. Instead of religion, art, and science, the concern is now law, ethics, and religion.

A view which presumes law, ethics, and religion to be a structure unity cannot avoid recognizing a kind of “fall” in the history of jurisprudence in the 19th and 20th centuries. A fall consists of succumbing step by step to the same three temptations to which Christ was exposed in the desert.

First Temptation

The turning away from the ideal of reason, and the turning towards the instinctual is, seen morally, nothing but the leap from the pinnacle of the temple into the abyss, hoping that there angels of God will lift the one falling. i.e., intelligence reigning in the darkness of the instinctual.

Thought should be oriented toward the divine, but the temptation is to sink.

The height of pure thought (pinnacle) oriented towards the divine (temple) has been left behind to find the reign of the nation’s subconscious force (angels) in the instinctual (abyss). This is the path from faith to superstition.

Just as an individual's personal instincts may be made, so too are the national instincts. Hence, there is a risk or a leap into the unknown. This temptation is to put the irrational above reason.

Second Temptation Historically, there have been no intervention of angels to break the fall. Only the ground can break the fall, leading to the cult of materialism.

Hence, one generation creates the destiny of the next, although not necessarily a repetition of what came prior. Culture and morality were assumed to be determined by mechanical and material forces. Hence, the materialist generation reversed the order of the higher and the lower. In particular, the revolutionary movements of the 19th century were rooted in the primacy of the material. Quantity placed above quality.

This is the temptation to transform stones into bread. The transformation of inorganic and dead stones into organic bread is actually a reversal of the above and the below.

It treats culture (law, ethics, religion) as the product of the material (amoral and irrational).

Third Temptation The materialist generation gave way to the positivistic generation:

Law is only what was laid down by a power according to its will and sanctioned by force. The good is only what leads to the set objective. And that objective is defined to be "truth".

Matter is no longer fundamental, but force is. In man, force is actualized as the Will.

Will is the reality in the life of a human—ultimately it creates and directs everything—including all of civilised and legal life. But for legal life this means a decisive change in its foundation: might replaces right.

The temptation is to become the authority over all the kingdoms of the world, provided on bows down and worships Satan. This is predominantly the situation we find ourselves in today.

Meditations on the Tarot The three temptations have a prominent place in the Meditations. However, they are always put in contrast with the temptations in Eden, and in relation to the three vows of obedience, poverty, and chastity.

The three vows are, in essence, memories of paradise, where man was united with God (obedience), where he possessed everything at once (poverty), and where his companion was at one and the same time his wife, his friend, his sister, and his mother (chastity).

The work of redemption begins with the three temptations in the wilderness. However, this time the tempter was not the serpent. Rather, the tempter was the prince of the world (the new man, the superman, or other son of man who, if incarnated, would be the realisation of the promise of freedom made by the serpent.

The three temptations of the Son of Man in the wilderness were his experience of the directing impulses of evolution, namely the will-to-power, the “groping trial” and the transformation of the gross into the subtle. They signify at the same time the test of the three vows—the vows of obedience, chastity and poverty.

Bread and stones The first temptation came after Jesus’ forty day fast:

Hunger of the spirit, the soul and the body is the experience of *emptiness* or poverty. It is therefore the vow of poverty which is put to the test when “the tempter came and said to him: If you are the Son of God, command these stones to become loaves of

bread" (Matthew iv, 3). "Command these stones to become loaves of bread"—this is the very essence of the aspiration of humanity in the scientific epoch, namely to victory over poverty. Synthetic resins, synthetic rubber, synthetic fibre, synthetic vitamins, synthetic proteins and. . .eventually synthetic bread! —When? Soon, perhaps. Who knows?

Forty-five years later, we can begin to answer such questions. Synthetic meat is being grown in the laboratory and will soon be mass produced. Of course, the advances in artificial intelligence are seen as a threat. Synthetic humans are already being produced for specialized purposes (i.e., sex).

Through the media, the population is being prepared to accept these androids as fully human. Some even predict them to be the next root race that will replace biological humans.

In cultural terms, this temptation leads the intellectuals to deny life, which is regarded as merely complex molecules. In the political realm, economic life is regarded as primary.

Groping Trial This is the temptation to jump off the pinnacle into the abyss, assuming God will come to the rescue. In practical terms, it is the idea of evolution over creation. Creation is the accomplishment of absolute wisdom and absolute goodness.

Evolution, on the other hand, proceeds blindly by trial and error, from one species to the next. Evolution is actually guided by the serpent, or prince of the word. This temptation is opposed to chastity, and fornication is threefold: spiritual, psychic, and carnal.

The principle of spiritual fornication is therefore the preference of the subconscious to the conscious and superconscious. of instinct to the Law, and of the world of the serpent to the world of the WORD.

Transformation Temptation The third temptation is directed against obedience. The temptation is the will-to-power, the desire to rule over the world.

It is a matter, therefore, of accepting the ideal of the superman (“fall down and worship me”), who is the summit of evolution (“he took him to a very high mountain”) and who, having passed through the mineral, plant, animal and human kingdoms, subjecting them to his power, is lord over them, i.e. he is their final cause or aim and ideal, their representative or their collective concentrated will, and he is their master, who has taken their subsequent evolution into his hands. Now, the choice here is between the ideal of the superman, who is “as God”, and God himself.

Obedience is faithfulness to the living God.

Fundamental Law of Magic A fundamental law of sacred magic is this:

That which is above being as that which is below, renunciation below sets in motion forces of accomplishment above and the renunciation of that which is above sets in motion forces of accomplishment below.

This means:

When you resist a temptation or renounce something desired below, you set in motion by this very fact forces of realisation of that which corresponds above to that which you come to renounce below.

Or

It is not desire which bears magical realisation, but rather the renunciation of desire (that you have formerly experienced, of course). For renunciation through indifference has no moral — and therefore no magical — value.

This renunciation is actually the practice of the three sacred vows, which is the true magical training, and concentration without effort. That is the esoteric value to resisting those temptations.

Posted on 2018-09-07 by Cologero

Meditations on the Tarot

12.1 Dreaming in the Dog Days

But when the artichoke flowers, and the chirping grasshopper sits in a tree and pours down his shrill song continually from under his wings in the season of wearisome heat, then goats are plump and wine sweetest; women are most wanton, but men are feeblest, because Sirius parches head and knees and the skin is dry through heat.

HESIOD

In the midst of a restless sleep during a stultifying dog day night, following a massive hurricane, I was entertained by a dream. As I pulled into my driveway, I noticed my two closest college friends with a young boy waiting for me. Although they were my friends, they were not friends with each other. On the contrary, each represented a different, mutually incompatible, trajectory of my life. B. had been my friend since grammar school. As such, he represented the conserving element of my past, the

drag of inertia. R., on the other hand, was a new friend; together we explored the lifestyle choices of the social upheavals of that era.

Being a trickster, I resolved to deceive them. Pretending not to know them, I casually asked if they had been sent to clear my windshield. To my surprise, they did not recognize me. R. was suspicious and went into my car to look for clues regarding my real identity.

Following him, I found a text and opened it. A secret was revealed to me about the Tarot. I learned I was not in the land where the centre is everywhere. I read the next paragraph, but had trouble understanding it. Multi-coloured balls were dancing around the final word. It was somewhat confusing and I wondered how they could possibly know that to be true. Unfortunately I cannot now recall the word. I suddenly awoke, and the ideas for this essay rushed into my head; I'm afraid I will leave out something essential.

The Crown of Creation According to Valentin Tomberg, the Minor Arcana represent an extension to the final Major Arcanum, The World. As such, they represent an ascent, known as Jacob's Ladder¹.

The Minor Arcana of the Tarot represent the way of ascent from consciousness belonging to the world of action (the phenomenal world) through the world of formation and the world of creation to the world of emanation.

The suit of Pentacles corresponds to Assiah, or the World of Action. This is the mixed, or dualistic world. Not fully God's creation, it is the result of Adam's fall. It is ruled by Satan, the Prince of the World. Tomberg explains:

The world of our experience is the phenomenal manifestation of both the world created by the Word and the evolutionary world of the serpent.

¹<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/psychurgical-practice>

This world is the world of images, intellectual constructions, and imagined ideals. However, these are not liberating, but rather keep humanity enthralled. Boris Mouravieff describes it this way:

Dreamlike imagination, which is somnolent, comes from the Absolute III, and is also found to a certain degree in animals: it is a passive force. The latter form of imagination, the 'dream of the sleeping serpent', produces a hypnotic effect on man, keeping him in the state in which the vast majority of humans pass their lives.

Tomberg agrees:

It is the Serpent who is the prince of this world, and who is the author and director of the purely biological evolution following the Fall.

Mouravieff is even clearer on this point.

Satan is the Regent of organic life on Earth within the limits of the mental and physical life of the three kingdoms of nature: flora, fauna and man. He dominates them by the action of sexual energy in the four phases of life: conception, birth, growth and finally reproduction. This sexual energy is the dynamic expression of his Love, which is carnal Love, while the spiritual life, which is accessible to man through the mediation of his higher centres, remains outside the sphere of the World of Action.

His task is thus limited and he carries it out, as we said, by the sexual Love which emanates from him, by the force of attraction between the sexes, and by Illusion, the dreams of the sleeping young Serpent. The current of his Love acts like a drug on both man and woman and, in its different forms, keeps them in a hypnotic state from puberty to the end of their days.

The Sephiroth For preparation, the first step is to identify the qualities of the Sephiroth as they appear in the World of Action. The loss of “vertical consciousness”, i.e., direct consciousness of the Divine, colours our experiences. By forgetting the vertical, the World of Action seems to be self-sufficient and independent of any transcendent foundation. Thus, the philosophy of naturalism – along with its children materialism, positivism, and atheism – seems a reasonable way to understand this world. Hence, some of the sephiroth might be described this way.

- **6 Beauty.** Beauty is sensual and the images of beauty keep us in a dreamlike state. The beauty of nature ties us to the desire for experience. The beauty of people excites the desire for biological evolution, even past the time when that makes any sense.
- **5 Justice.** Justice is the restoration of equilibrium. So in a dispute, Justice would resolve the two points of view with reference to the Will of God. In the World of Action, humanity replaces God, so that man determines what is good or evil. Since there is no belief in transcendence, Justice devolves into a power struggle between the parties.
- **4 Mercy.** In vertical consciousness, Mercy is oriented toward the supernatural end of man. When that awareness is lost, Mercy is oriented toward man’s natural goals.
- **3 Intellect.** The Intellect is dominated by Science. The aim of the Intellect is not to know higher things, but rather to provide the understanding to manipulate nature.
- **2 Wisdom.** There is no true Wisdom. Rather, cunning, slyness, and artfulness are considered to be the hallmarks of Wisdom.

Of course, a meditation on the Minor Arcana would have to develop similar ideas more deeply. The pip cards correspond to the ten sephiroth.

What about the Crown of the World of Action, the Ace of Pentacles? For most of humanity, life in the Assiah is a difficult struggle. It is bounded by toil, disease, pain, and death. Even during the good times, their presence casts a shadow over life, and they seem to impinge at the most inopportune times.

Nevertheless, at any time there are those who seem to have mastered life. They have physical beauty, sex appeal, intelligence, ability, health, fame, and, of course, sufficient fortune so that the cost of anything never needs to be considered. They become the objects of envy. I'm sure you can name many such people, but I'll mention two quite different men, if you consider them objectively: George Clooney and Donald Trump. And there are those who suddenly appear, almost out of nowhere, like Jennifer Lawrence.

Everyone desires that life of leisure, and their images are everywhere. They keep us in a hypnotic state, since very few will ever meet such success. In the Mebes Tarot system², the Ace of Pentacles represents Wealth, both Inner and Outer. Outer wealth is visible and comprehensible to the masses.

Inner wealth signifies what must be given up in order to climb the ladder. Idle wealth is useless, rather it must be what is paid. Now, the Crown of the World of Action is related to the Tiphereth of the World of Formation. That latter is represented by the 6 of Swords, which symbolises the Science of Success.

The Seven Sleepers This morning, I was dreaming about the Seven Sleepers³. In the dream, I was communicating via thought about how we would know when to wake up together. Then we all woke up.

Posted on 2017-09-20 by Cologero

²https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/G._O._Mebes

³https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Seven_Sleepers

* * *

james on 2017-09-21 at 02:49 said:

Thanks for another great post.

Arthur Konrad on 2017-09-22 at 19:19 said:

It appears that a gentleman is only faithfully perceived as such if he does not have to labor for his wealth. It seems that for this reason the aura of a gentleman persistently eludes the self-made men.

Then, just the day prior to reading this, after experiencing unprecedented level of concentration while meditating, I came to suddenly think how superficially subconscious, almost petty the dreams are. Perhaps I'll be reconciled with them

Nature dominates nature, and if the lower nature relents, it might be reintegrated in the world of new, endless possibilities

Max on 2017-11-26 at 20:34 said:

One wonders where final words go...

While thinking about spleen there were some lines by Baudelaire mentioning dog-days.. . I do not know what it all means.

'Where do the dogs go, you ask, you inattentive men.' They go about their business.

Business meetings, amorous meetings. Through the fog, through the snow, through the mud, in the burning dog-day sun, in the rustling rain they go, they come, they trot, they pass under coaches, impelled by fleas or passion, by need or by duty. Like us, they get up early in the morning and are trying to make a living or chasing after their pleasures."

I guess some good old "philosopher dogs" have simply seen too much – not much impressed by what is on offer by the world any longer.

Most dreams are ridiculous anyway. What is strange is that we believe them without reservation, and how well-crafted they seem. Must be the work of some unknown genius. Perhaps we will meet.

12.2 The Word is Silence Expressed

The Multiple States of the Being is **Rene Guenon**'s fundamental work on metaphysics. In it he explains that "just as Unity (Being) is nothing but the metaphysical Zero (Non-Being) affirmed, the word is silence

expressed." That is, Silence contains within itself the possibility of the Word.

But the Silence is more than the word. The latter is silence expressed, but Silence must needs include as well the inexpressible. Hence, Silence is related to mystery, which refers to something inexpressible, not incomprehensible (which is a common misconception). The implication here is that the understanding of a mystery requires intuition, a direct knowing of the inexpressible; what can be expressed can, on the other hand, be known through discursive thought.



Guenon makes some interesting etymological connections. The Greek *mysterion* derives from *myein* which means "to be silent". The same root *mu* in Latin is used in *mutus*, "mute", but more significantly in the word *mythos*, "myth". So a myth refers to that which is inexpressible, that is, something that can only be expressed indirectly by means of symbolic representations.

In *Meditations on the Tarot*, this Silence is related to concentration without effort. To know this Silence is *to be* this Silence. That is, the discursive mind is quieted of its thoughts, images, desires. This is a concentration, not *of* something, but the effortless concentration of the Silence. We read there:

Concentration *without effort*, which means there is nothing to suppress and where contemplation becomes as natural as breathing and the beating of the heart, is the state of consciousness — of the intellect, the imagination, the feelings, and the will — a state of perfect calm, accompanied by the complete relaxation of the nerves and muscles of the body. It is the deep silence of desires, concerns, imagination, memory, and discursive thought. We would say that the entire being has become like the surface of calm waters reflecting the immense presence of the starry sky and its

inexpressible harmony. And the waters are deep, oh how deep! And the silence increases, always increasing, what SILENCE! Its growth takes place in regular waves which pass, one after the other, through your being: one wave of silence followed by another wave of deeper silence, then yet another wave of even deeper silence ... Have you ever *drunk the silence*. If so, you know what concentration without effort it.

Originally published on 2011-02-11 in medtarot

Posted on 2022-11-15 by Cologero

* * *

De Bosit on 2022-11-16 at 13:14 said:

Drinking silence for me was an exercise lying down on my back in bed before going to bed and just trying to quiet the mind.

But I think the way to actually reflect the starry sky (lets say you work with noisy colleagues and have to do your job) is actually much more beneficial.

You don't realize the „intake“ of information in these quiet moments. But doors open and tunnels are dug deeper and deeper.

12.3 The Word is made Flesh

The Spirit blows wherever He wants, and you hear His voice, but you do not know where He is coming from nor where He is going; so it is with everyone born of the Spirit.

JOHN 3:8

The breath of the Spirit is the pure act of intelligence, arising from the Silence. So how do you hear his voice? We read in *Meditations on the Tarot*:

The pure act is unknowable in itself; it is only its reflection which makes it perceptible, comparable, and comprehensible; in other words, it is thanks to its reflection that we become conscious of it.



The Spirit is active principle and the Virgin is the passive, reflecting principle, like the calm surface of a body of water. It takes the two conditions for the conscious experience of the Holy Spirit, or Kingdom of God. As Jesus tells Nicodemus in his nocturnal visit:

Amen, amen, I say to you that a man cannot enter the Kingdom of God without being born of Water and the Spirit.

JOHN, 3:5

Water represents consciousness. The reflection of the pure activity of the Holy Spirit will be distorted unless that consciousness is itself pure. Two qualities are necessary, one pertaining to the Mind, the other to the Will:

Virginal The Mind is free of false ideologies, beliefs, and dogmas.

Immaculate The Will is free of the cloudiness of the imagination, passions, and personal desires

Reintegrated consciousness, the Kingdom of God, or the Primordial state requires a rebirth in the Spirit and Water, to be able to hear the Spirit and to reflect it accurately. This is how the Word expresses the Silence.

The Word is made flesh by the Holy Spirit through the Virgin Mary.

Originally published on 16 Feb 2011.

Posted on 2022-12-04 by Cologero

12.4 Conscious Participation in World Events

Wisdom has built her house, she has set up her seven pillars.

Proverbs 9:1

The Bateleur represents Unity, which transcends thought, desire, volition, that is, the entire world process. It represents Intuition, mystical awareness, or a cognition beyond discursive thought. This “first act of intelligence” is a gift of the Spirit, who blows he wills, so it is not the customary way we know.

In ordinary life, to know is to be conscious of something, so duality arises, represented by the High Priestess. This “other” is the reflection of Spirit, represented by Water. This is the feminine principle, the **Divine Sophia**, which builds the house of Being. Thus, everything in the world of form is actually the symbol or “signature” of Transcendence, in the words of Schwaller de Lubicz.

The Transcendent takes form both in the subtle and gross realms of manifestation. The gross realm includes all existing things we experience. But initially, it reveals itself as thoughts in the subtle realm. This card shows us the connection between these two realms.

In everyday life, we stop at the thought, treating it as an end in itself. We have no concern as to its origin or its deeper meaning. It is meditation that leads us to depth. Valentin Tomberg writes in *New Testament Studies*:

It is very difficult in our time to distinguish between thinking of something and meditating on it. This is especially difficult because, while meditation arises as the result of deep thinking, from a certain perspective meditation not only differs from thinking, but it is actually the opposite. ... meditation involves repeated submersion into the insight.



So what happens when we meditate?

The purpose of meditation is not to gain new knowledge, but to live in acquired knowledge. The discovery of new thought content is not the goal of meditation: the object is to bring thought content down into the life of feeling and volition. The goal of meditation is to make a truth the content of one's whole being. And meditation must be continued for as long as it takes to change clear thought into a clear force of the will.

The thought, which is the reflection of the divine idea, must come alive. To do so, it cannot remain dispassionate, but must enter into our feeling life (also part of subtle manifestation). This activates the Will — the idea guides the Will and the feeling motivates the Will. The role of the Will, then, is to manifest creatively in the World Process. This is the formula of manifestation:

Intuition $\Rightarrow$ Thought $\Rightarrow$ Will $\Rightarrow$ Manifestation

Valentin Tomberg puts it this way:

Meditation leads to conscious participation in objective world events.

Posted on 2010-10-15 by Cologero

12.5 The Open and Closed Universes

Sacred Magic Letter III on the *Empress* is about Sacred magic, which is putting mystical revelation into practice. This requires preparation:

- **Mysticism:** Real contact with the Divine
- **Gnosis:** Taking this contact into consciousness

- **Magic:** Executing what mystical revelation has made known

Unlike sacred magic, personal magic, i.e., in which the magician decides himself when and how to put esoteric teachings into practice, has certain dangers, including physical problems as well as emotional. I knew a woman, quite closely in fact, who got involved with Enochian magic. Despite her esoteric training she was anxious, emotional, inconstant, and paranoid. I don't know which came first, but at the very least the magical practice did not help her. Sacred magic offers healing, not harm.

Moreover, psychological and physical effects should not be pursued for their own sake. True mysticism is beyond such states, reaching something much higher. Rather, the focus needs to be on uniting the human will with God's will. The latter has been revealed to us, at least in a general way. In addition, he has a plan for your own particular life, you need to discern it.

The fruit of this union is concentrated in the blood. This is the **Holy Grail**. Power starts with divine and human sincerity, united in human words and actions. True sincerity is not cerebral, but rather it must flow in one's life blood. We read:



The more sincerity there is in the human word or action, the more there is the vital essence of blood. When it happens — and the Angels fall down in adoration when this occurs — that the human wish is in accord with the divine, the Holy Blood is then united to the vital essence of the human blood and the Mystery of the God-Man is repeated, and also the miraculous power of the God-Man is reiterated. Here is the power of sacred magic — or its sceptre.

The aims of sacred magic are:

- The freedom to see (give sight to the blind)

- The freedom to hear (hearing to the deaf)
- The freedom to walk (the ability to walk to the lame)
- The freedom to live (life to the dead)
- The freedom to follow an ideal (good news to the poor)
- The freedom to be truly oneself (casting out evil spirits from the possessed)

In sum, it is the restoration of freedom, particularly from doubt, fear, hate, apathy, and despair.

The fallen angels (e.g., Satan, Belial, Lucifer, Mephistopheles) never deprive anyone of his freedom, and their only weapon is Temptation. However, possession has nothing to do with temptation. That is because human perversity is capable of much worse evil. The human mind will engender elemental beings and subsequently becomes the slave of its own creation.

Selection and Election Letter X on the *Wheel of Fortune* mentions that there are two ways of looking at the world:

- **exoterically**, as a mechanical process or
- **esoterically**, as a cosmic drama comprising the Fall, perdition, redemption, and salvation

The analogy of a passenger ship illustrates these views:

- The passengers buy a ticket and are passive. For them, the ship is an automatic process leading them to their destination
- The crew, on the other hand, are involved in the drama of keeping the ship on course via work, watches, maneuvering, and orientation.

Analogously, evolution can be understood in two ways.

- It can be seen as a “natural process” through the eyes of the passengers
- It is a “tragedy and drama” as the crew experiences it.



The passengers are ready to believe in determinism, fatalism, or naturalism. This offloads responsibility to Nature, God, the stars, i.e., anywhere except the moral human being. Of course, the passengers can point out the evidence for natural evolution, and they are not mistaken as far as it goes. But the esoterist looks for the moral cause:

Joseph de Maistre was not interested in the logic of facts, since, as he asserted, the Law of Gravity does not cause the rock to fall. Instead, he was concerned with the moral logic, or the moral cause of events. Science deals with facts yet can never answer the question, “Why?” Ultimately, therefore, it comes down to the moral will, which is the real cause. And an evil will brings about evil effects

Hence, while the exoteric explanation sees “natural selection” as the agent effecting change, the esoteric explanation sees “election”. One is chosen to be on the crew, to participate in the cosmic drama as an active agent.

The Two Wheels In the drama of Creation, God created in six days and rested on the seventh. This is presented by a circle with the seventh day at the top. However, as a day of rest, it is open, so the circle is not closed: there is an opening.

The serpent, on the other hand, bites his tail, creating a closed circle. This is the ouroboros. The serpent world is endless repetition, cycle after cycle, the eternal return. Buddha, Solomon, and Nietzsche sensed this.

The Buddha looked for an escape, Solomon despaired, But Nietzsche praised it.

There are no miracles in the closed world of the Serpent, just the same thing over and over, following an impersonal cosmic process. This applies also to the doctrine of cosmic cycles in some Eastern and New Age teachings.

True religion shows the open world, in which miracles are possible. Natural processes do not explain the totality of the universe. That is the “good news”: the world is not an eternal prison, there is an entrance and an exit.

The Fall is the cosmic event set in motion by the closed circle of the serpent biting his tail, locking those inside the world. Hence, Redemption is the cosmic act of the Reintegration of the Fallen world in stages:

1. An opening in the closed circle is created (religion, initiation, prophecy)
2. A exit path is taught (Buddha)
3. Avatars enter through this door
4. The fallen world is transformed from within by the radiation of the incarnated Word (Jesus Christ)

Posted on 2022-10-30 by Cologero

12.6 The Lamp of Trismegistus

According to **Eliphas Levi** in *Transcendental Magic* the initiate possesses

- the lamp of Hermes Trismegistus, or reason illuminated by science.

- the mantle of Apollonius, of full and complete self-possession, which isolates the sage from blind tendencies
- the staff of the patriarchs, which is the help of the secret and everlasting forces of Nature

The lamp of Trismegistus:

- enlightens present, past, and future
- lays bare the conscience of men
- manifests the inmost recesses of the female heart

For commentary, please visit *Meditations on the Tarot*⁴.

Comment The Hermit has given up personal opinions and goals. And he speaks the truth, when necessary, and charitably if possible. But sometimes the objectivity and plain-spokenness is interpreted as rudeness by others. In his role as prophet, he may announce blessings and woes, but the woes are warnings and should be interpreted as kindness, not as rudeness.

The Hermit is not really a misanthrope. He loves humanity, but objectively and intellectually, not sentimentally. But humanity prefers sentiment, or the illusion of love, to real love. The lamp with three flames that brings wisdom also casts shadows. So “the consciences of men are laid bare” and the faults, foibles, pretenses, and illusions of humanity are exposed. So that objective knowledge is not the result of hatred but

⁴<https://www.meditationsonthetarot.com/lamp-of-trismegistus>



Figure 12.1: The Hermit

rather of wisdom (another word for prudence). On the contrary, the mass of men, whom **Louis Claude de St Martin** called “men of the torrent”, refuse to understand, accept, and integrate their shadows ... they are the real haters.

In *La Vita Nuova*, **Dante** describes his first glimpse, at nine years of age, of his beloved Beatrice, also nine years old. Nine days later at nine o’clock, she greets him on the street. **Josephin Paladin** in his essay on Dante relates that number to the Hermit, showing again that Dante was an initiate.

Posted on 2010-09-11 by Cologero

12.7 Wisdom, Prudence, Cunning

Fools despise wisdom and instruction.

PROVERBS 1:7

Blessed is the man that findeth wisdom, and is rich in prudence.

PROVERBS 3:13

I am sending you out like sheep among wolves. So be as cunning as serpents and as innocent as doves.

MATTHEW 10:16

And it thus appears that the entire world is like a single mirror full of lights presenting the divine wisdom, or as charcoal emitting light.

BONAVENTURA, *Collationes in Hexaemeron* ii, 27

The German chemist Wilhelm Ostwald⁵ last century developed a colour model. Although it was developed specifically for manufacturing, and there have since been other models, the concept itself is sound.

This diagram shows Ostwald's colour picker as a bicone. The polar points are white, which is all colours, and black, which is the absence of colour. The central axis, therefore represents shades of grey. Along the circumference of the circle at the centre of the bicone, that is, the equator, are all the colours in the spectrum. Physics considers only these to be true colours, since each corresponds to a specific wavelength. The spectrum is created by passing white light through a prism. Unfortunately for the physicist, there is no formula to detect colours, which requires a human observer to name them. Nevertheless, all the other representations are better called "hues" rather than colour.

This figure is similar to the quaternio so favoured by Carl Jung. He uses an octahedron, so there is a square where the circle is. The square, as fourfold, represents completeness. The circle is also complete, but it also implies perfection. The bicone is used whenever continuity is required.

The diagram shows white light, which is a composite of all the colours, at the top, and black, the total absence of colour at the bottom. As the white light is separated into its components, it manifests as pastels, then the full colour spectrum, and the, with decreasing intensity moves down to the browns and darker hues.

Polarity The poles of the bicone represent opposing forces, the active and the passive. The task of Hermetic philosophy is to locate the neutralizing force or equilibrium that reconciles the opposites. For our example, the North Pole represents Wisdom, and the South Pole, cunning.

⁵https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ostwald_color_system

Wisdom Wisdom is the first and the greatest of the gifts the Holy Spirit. It illumines the mind and leads the will to the divine. Like the white light of the North Pole, Wisdom, the Mind of God, contains all possibilities.

The word of the Holy Trinity became flesh in Jesus Christ and its light became flesh in Mary.

Cunning

mimicry is precisely what the Book of Genesis understands by cunning when it says that “the serpent was more cunning than any other wild creature that the LORD God had made”. To be cunning is to mime wisdom, after having eliminated the essential — its light — and then to make use of it for one’s own ends. Cunning is the ape of Wisdom.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Human beings who are dominated by the Thinking function of the soul, become detached from conscience and will. That opens them up to Luciferic influences, which is the seducing principle. Without the light of Sophia, they can indeed be called “children of the serpent” or “children of darkness”. The will is not oriented toward God but rather to earthly power and riches. Feelings are irrelevant to cunning; the only goal is success, even if achieved through deceit or guile.

Cunning holds such a strong attraction because it is so effective. Those able to manipulate the world and other people can find worldly success. Since he is thinking and focused, while most everyone else is dominated by feelings and lower desires, he holds an advantage. Those dominated by the Feeling function, become hypnotized and are prey to propaganda and deceit. Those dominated by lower desires develop a separate I of the body that makes it impossible to become a real person.

As long as human beings are not fully conscious, they will listen to the serpent. His promise of special or secret knowledge mimics wisdom, so even those with good intentions can still fall into the temptation of cunning. Jung explains this process in psychological terms:

Since the shadow, in itself, is unconscious for most people, the snake would correspond to what is totally unconscious and incapable of becoming conscious, but which, as the collective unconscious and as instinct, seems to possess a peculiar wisdom of its own and a knowledge that is often felt to be supernatural. This is the treasure which the snake guards, and also the reason why the snake signifies evil and darkness on the one hand and wisdom on the other. Its unrelatedness, coldness, and dangerousness express the instinctuality that with ruthless cruelty rides roughshod over all moral and any other human wishes and considerations and is therefore just as terrifying and fascination in its effects as the sudden glance of a poisonous snake.

CARL JUNG, *Aion*

Prudence

Behold, I send you out as sheep in the midst of wolves; so be wise as serpents and innocent as doves.

MATTHEW 10:16

Prudence is the reconciling principle between Wisdom and cunning. The World is represented as the plane at the centre of the bicone. The battle is not between the Light and the darkness, but takes place in the world. One must use intelligence to be able to wander about in the midst of wolves. It is insufficient to be naively innocent, counting on God alone to resolve all your problems. As Tomberg makes clear:

The first three petitions [of the Our Father prayer] affirm divine authority, not divine power. Hence, God is powerful to the extent that his power is freely recognized and accepted.

Letter IV

While we recognize His authority in the world, His Will is without effect unless that power is allowed to act through us. But first, it is necessary to bring the unconscious into consciousness; specifically, that entails bringing the Our Father prayer all the way down to our lower centres. Then the innocence of the Dove can penetrate all the way down to our lower centres. In that case, we can use the cunning of the serpent in innocence.

As was just mentioned, unbalanced humans are subject to seduction, hypnosis, and false egos. This is overcome only by balancing the three soul functions. Training in the path of the Heart aims for the thinking, feeling, and willing functions to be animated by the Higher Self. Then there can be gradual improvement:

- Thinking and Feeling: **Positivity**
- Thinking and Willing: **Impartiality**
- Thinking, Willing, and Feeling: **Harmony**

Prudence begins with a positive attitude, impartial judgment, and a harmonious inner life. Prudence is one of the cardinal virtues, and can be thought of as “applied wisdom”, i.e., wisdom applied to concrete situations. A wanderer in the world, a knight errant, must be prudent. The world is not just sheep and wolves, but is shared by many other people. One must certainly know one’s enemies, but not everyone, who is not a friend, is an enemy.

Unfortunately, prudence has become the lost virtue. Any mention of prudence as a virtue often brings on an attack. One is suspected of “blaming the victim”, or of preventing someone’s right to act in a certain way. A few weeks ago, I saw a woman interviewed on TV. She was a student at a prestigious college who got so inebriated that she passed out on the street. A passerby then raped her, and she didn’t even know about it.

Clearly, it was not prudent of her to put herself in that condition in the first place. Of course, the crime of rape had been committed. She was incensed to accept any responsibility. We agree; she did not commit the crime, nor did she contribute to or it. It is not a question of “blaming the victim”, but rather the prudential judgment of not being a victim in the first place. Many more examples can be found in everyday life.



The Hermit The Arcana of the Hermit represents Prudence. The Hermit abides in the Light, wanders in the world like the knight errant, and makes forays into the lower realms. Tomberg explains the symbolism:

The Hermit holds the **lamp** which represents the “luminous point” of transcendental synthesis; he is wrapped in a **mantle**, hanging in folds, for deploying the particular qualities which have their place in the region of the “equator”; and he supports himself with a **staff** for feeling his way in the domain of darkness, in the region of the reversed cone culminating in the “black point”.

He is therefore a Peripatetic Platonist (en route around the “equator”), making use of scepticism (his “staff”) while he walks. This is why the traditional interpretation of the ninth Arcanum is *prudence*.

Posted on 2020-10-12 by Cologero

* * *

Tom on 2020-10-12 at 15:20 said:

I appreciated this post as it helped confirm and deepen some of the conclusions and meditations I recently made on the Inferno of the Divine Comedy.

At various points in the Inferno, Dante, relying on Virgil, is able to enlist the help of numerous demons, such as the Centaurs and Titans. Enlisting their help is a terrifying experience for Dante, but with Virgil's ability to command (or at least negotiate with) them, the threat they pose is neutralized, and they are instead shown to be indispensable auxiliaries in the journey through the underworld.

The interpretation I made, based on some of my own experiences, is that Dante is describing how in our earthly life, we often need to make use of these "lower" powers while remaining firmly in command of them. An example that comes to mind is in physical battle – a man would find it difficult to fight without awakening the fierce Centaur nature, the key being then to remain firmly in command of it. Someone who has engaged in any kind of battle has probably experienced this Centaur nature first hand. Similar interpretations can probably be made for the Titans, Geryon, and other helpful demons in Dante's underworld.

12.8 Solar and Lunar Initiation

Christian initiation is the conscious experience of the heart of the world and the solar nature of man.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

If Hermetism has provided a safeguard for nearly twenty centuries, it must be said that circumstances have now changed. At the current point in history, as at the time of the Coming of Christ, the veil has been partially raised. Therefore, for those who want to advance beyond book knowledge, which never goes beyond the domain of information; for those who intensely seek the true sense of life, who want to understand the significance of the mission of the Christian in the New Era, the possibility will exist of initiation into this divine Wisdom, mysterious and hidden.

BORIS MOURAVIEFF, *Gnosis I*

Classic initiation formula: *try to grasp that which, once learned, you will know all.*

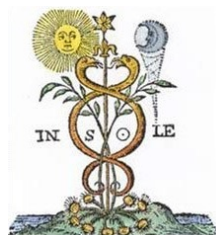
BORIS MOURAVIEFF, *Gnosis II*

In his Meditation on the Lovers, Tomberg describes the experience of Initiation. Along the way, he teaches us how to understand symbolic texts. Commenting on the story of creation in Genesis, he points out that the true of that story lies not in its allegedly historical details — viz., the Garden, Tree, Serpent, etc. — but in our inner experience. By penetrating into the depths of the soul, one can recover a sense of the Primordial state and how it was lost. To make clear, this is not the same as some pseudo-intellectual description of symbols, but rather of conscious efforts to recreate that story in consciousness.

This, he says is knowledge of the “beginning”, *initium*, which knowledge is called initiation. As Mouravieff also points out, initiation now takes place on a spiritual plane, not on the material. Tomberg concurs, when he writes, “God-man is the Initiator and there is no other.”

This descent into the depths of the human being is called Hermetic Initiation by Tomberg. Its method is ecstasy, which is the aim of the jnani in the Vedantic systems. Following this path, the Initiate descends into the depths of his soul, until he awakens to the primordial layer of his soul as the “image and likeness of God”. This is the alchemical creation of the true I or Will, the experience of the Microcosm.

The second type of initiation involves ecstasy, or the going outside oneself, leaving the Self behind to be absorbed in God or Heaven. This is what is commonly known as mystical experience. The Initiate reaches



the beginning in terms of the Macrocosm. There is no need to discuss this at this point, since the literature is so vast.

However, it is the first type of initiation that is less known or even rejected when it is made known. However, in our time, when man has no experience of the Macrocosm nor even understands who he is, it is the necessary path. In the past, the development of the Self has been referred to as the Left Hand Path, in contrast to those paths that seek to annihilate the Self. Mouravieff goes so far as to point out the dangers of seeking ecstasy for its own sake. He points out that this often involves the use of drugs, or entheogens. Quite clearly, if the aim is consciousness of the Self and development of the Will, any drug induced stupor leads in the totally opposite direction.

For Mouravieff, then, the path of the Initiate in the Era of the Holy Spirit is the development of the I. Nevertheless, this does not preclude the experience of the Macrocosm as found in his elaborate cosmology, but rather that it must be done so consciously.

Tomberg insists the Christian esotericism unites the two paths. So, like the left hand paths, he proclaims the knowledge of the Self. Yet unlike those unbalanced deviations that see no more than material reality, Tomberg makes clear that the true Initiate must also be initiated in the right hand path. Table 12.1 summarizes Tomberg's description of the two methods.

Table 12.1: Solar and Lunar Initiation

Solar Initiation	Lunar Initiation
Right Hand Path	Left Hand Path
Disciples of day	Disciples of night
Hermetic initiation	Pythagorean initiation
<i>Continued on next page</i>	

Solar Initiation	Lunar Initiation
Conscious experience of the Initial microcosmic state	Conscious experience of the initial macrocosmic state
Conscious descent into the depth of the human being	Conscious ascent into the Empyrean
Enstasy	Ecstasy
Experience at the depths at the foundation within oneself	Rapture, or going out of oneself
One becomes more and more profound until one awakens within oneself to the primordial layer (the image and likeness of God)	The macrocosmic layers (spheres or heavens or Empyrean) reveal themselves to consciousness
The sense of spiritual touch	The sense of spiritual hearing
Like a chemical experiment undergone on the psychic and spiritual plane (alchemical and substantial)	Musical (music of the spheres) & mathematical
Beginning is the microcosmic layer of Eden	Beginning is the macrocosmic sphere of Heaven
Sacred Heart (the intellectual center of man)	Cosmic Word (the Logos)

Originally published on 21 January 2012 on Medtarot.

Posted on 2023-03-13 by Cologero

* * *

Kaukomieli on 2023-03-19 at 05:52 said:

Hands that unite in prayer are the most intimate and clear expression of why the paths of the two hands should be united. Freedom and Love.

12.9 Freedom is a Fact

Human thought results in the diremption of the **Cosmos**, into **Macrocosm** and **Microcosm**. The Macrocosm is what we experience through our senses, the Microcosm what we experience through thought. Through our senses — colour, shape, sound, and so on — we ascertain that something is. But it is through thought that we understand what it is.

In the diagram by **Robert Fludd**⁶ we see the arrangement of the Microcosm. The three Hermetic sciences — **Alchemy**, **Astrology**, and **Theurgy** — address different sections of the diagram as shown in chart 12.9.



Microcosm	Macrocosm	
Thought	Senses	Method of experience
Alchemy	Chemistry	Study of the elements.
Astrology	Astronomy	Study of stars and planets.
Theurgy	Science	Study of angelic hierarchies.

Table 12.2: Macrocosm and Microcosm.

Now astrology is no more concerned with the effect of the stars on our future than alchemy is with chemical experiments in the lab. Alchemy is concerned with spiritual transformation based on the elementals. Astrology then is concerned with the planets and their relationship to the stellar heavens.

As we have shown, Rudolf Steiner devoted a book⁷ to understand-

⁶<https://gornahoor.net/?p=17151>

⁷<https://gornahoor.net/?p=2377>

ing astrology. The constellations represent systems of thought that cohere together. It is curious that people of a given worldview will take the same position on any new issue that may come up. This is because their thought patterns are determined by the constellations. The planets correspond to different “moods” that affect thoughts in certain ways. In the course of one’s life, the moods may change, or one may find oneself in a different thought constellation. Besides your “sun sign”, there may be other constellations that have a smaller, but not negligible, effect on thought patterns.

In *Meditations on the Tarot*, Tomberg makes clear that the Hermetic method involves understanding by analogy, not physical causation. Thus, we understand astrology as analogous to astronomy, as there is no question of the stars having a physical causation on our destinies. This is not to deny the possibility of **synchronicity**, that is, a strange coincidence between an exterior situation and an interior one. Tomberg was certainly familiar with Steiner’s book, but he updated his conception to include Jung’s idea of archetypes, which he defines as “astrological planetary influences”.

Tomberg defines “characterology” as “microcosmic astrology”. In coming to self-knowledge, the understanding of human types is essential. By self-observation we come to understand our own type and thus learn how to transcend it. Otherwise, a man is enslaved to the constellations of thought (his “horoscope”) that form his character.

The ordinary man is a product of temperament (the elemental forces) and character (his astrological sign). Only by awakening his spirit can a man develop a true conscience. Tomberg writes:

Freedom is a fact which one experiences when one judges not by his temperament (“etheric body”) nor by his character (“astral body”), but rather by the Scale of Justice, or by his own *conscience*. ... Conscience is neither a product nor a function of *character*. It is above it. And it is there, and only there, that the domain of *free-*

dom begins and is situated. One is not at all free when one judges or acts according to character or temperament, but one certainly is when one judges and acts according to the scale of Justice or conscience. But Justice, the praxis of the scale, is only the starting point for a long progression and development of conscience, and therefore of the growth of freedom.

Originally published on 6 June 2011 on medtarot.

Posted on 2023-03-02 by Cologero

Sparse Notes and Musings

13.1 The Good Shepherd

The Gospel for the Second Sunday after Easter is John 10:11-15¹, the parable of the Good Shepherd.

In this passage, Jesus compares himself to the Good Shepherd who watches over his sheep and would give his life for them. The Shepherd is clearly the Logos, the Word made flesh. The flock is not so clear. It is obviously not a mechanical aggregate of individual sheep who just happen to come together. On the contrary, they form a unity, which derives from the primordial unity of the divine Logos.

In the Sophiology developed and refined by **Vladimir Solovyov**, the flock, then, is the unity produced by the Logos, that is, Sophia, the world soul or ideal humanity. Sophia is the mediatrix between the multiplicity of individuals (the real content of her Life) and the absolute Divine unity (her ideal principle).

¹<http://www.biblestudytools.com/rhe/john/passage.aspx?q=John+10:>

Furthermore, Jesus says, “I am the good Shepherd and I know Mine, and Mine know Me, as the Father knoweth Me, and I know the Father.” Note in this passage the emphasis is on “knowing”, not on faith or believing. And not just a common knowing, but analogously to how the Logos knows the Father. This type of knowing is superior to rational thinking, it is, rather, a direct intuition of identity, for the sheep know who they are and whom they belong to. They have made themselves meek in order to be able to follow.

When this knowledge is lost, the sheep separate from the flock and become prey to the wolves. With the forgetfulness of Divine unity, that is, when the hireling is watching over the flock, Solovyov explains

the world soul ceases to unite all within herself, all things lose their common bond and the unity of cosmic creation breaks up into a multitude of separate elements.

As to the separation of an individual, he continues:

when it is detached from the whole by exciting in itself its own peculiar will, the particular elements of the universal organism lose their common bond in the world soul and, left to themselves, are doomed to discordant, egoistic existence. The root of such existence is evil and the fruit, suffering.

Posted on 2010-04-18 by Cologero

* * *

GFJF on 2010-04-19 at 00:42 said:

This is just what I came to ask you about. Until recently I hadn't payed much attention to the traditional aspects of Christianity, the result being that I'm now playing catch-up. However I digest the Neoplatonic terms quite well, so thank you for that. Since Christ, properly understood, is the Logos, it follows that the Father is the One, and the Holy Spirit is the All-Soul. One question I have is this: in the Lord's Prayer it is said that God is in Heaven; that implies the priority of

Heaven over God, does it not? It seems to me that Heaven merges in some way with God-as-One, and Father (as demiurge) merges in some way with Christ-as-Logos.

Cologero on 2010-04-20 at 00:07 said:

I know some gnostic sects tried to identify the Holy Spirit with Sophia, or the world soul. But they are really on different orders; the spirit is divine and ideal, the world soul is manifesting the divine idea as the cosmic process. This was briefly addressed in another comment.

The Trinity is more complex and will have to be dealt with separately.

GFJF on 2010-04-20 at 11:39 said:

Ah. I see I'm dealing with these ideas in the wrong way, treating them primarily as words.

13.2 Secret, Arcanum, Mystery

Hermetism distinguishes between three closely related words:

- Secretum (secret)
- Mysterium (mystery)
- Arcanum



It is important to keep these distinctions in mind.

Secret A secret is a fact, procedure, practice, or doctrine which a number of men agree to hide. There is no inner transformation required to know a secret. I can tell you where the treasure is buried; you can then find it and remain the same person you were before. A secret is hidden in the darkness.

Mystery A mystery, in contrast, is hidden in the light. According to Tomberg:

A mystery is a spiritual event comparable to physical birth or death. It is a change of the entire spiritual and psychic motivation, or a complete change of the plane of consciousness.

There are those who tell me that an intelligent man does not believe in miracles. Yet that same man is not at all concerned about why there is such a being as an intelligent man in the first place. To understand that requires unveiling a mystery.

Arcanum An arcanum, on the other hand, is hidden in the twilight. They may be symbols, myths, or rituals that both conceal and reveal their meaning, depending on the depth of meditation or understanding. To the uninitiated, an arcanum will be interpreted as an allegory, or even nonsense; he cannot be simply told the meaning, as though it were a mere secret. But to the initiate, an arcanum reveals

that which is necessary to know in order to be fruitful in a given domain of spiritual life. It is that which must be actively present in our consciousness—or even in our subconscious—in order to render us capable of making discoveries, engendering new ideas, conceiving new artistic subjects. In a word, it makes us *fertile* in our creative pursuits, in whatever domain of spiritual life. An arcanum is a ferment or an enzyme whose presence stimulates the spiritual and the psychic life of man. And it is symbols which are the bearers of these ferments or enzymes and which communicate them—if the mentality and morality of the recipient is ready.

Posted on 2010-10-25 by Cologero

* * *

James O'Meara on 2010-10-26 at 14:02 said:

"A mystery is a spiritual event comparable to physical birth or death. It is a change of the entire spiritual and psychic motivation, or a complete change of the plane of consciousness."

As Aristotle observed, one participated in the Mysteries not to acquire knowledge but to undergo an experience, viz, a transformation.

13.3 Geocentrism and the Center of the Universe

God is an infinite sphere, the centre of which is everywhere, the circumference nowhere.

HERMES TRISMEGISTUS

God is an intelligible sphere, whose centre is everywhere, and whose circumference is nowhere.

ALAIN DE LILLE

The whole visible world is only an imperceptible atom in the ample bosom of nature. No idea approaches it. We may enlarge our conceptions beyond all imaginable space; we only produce atoms in comparison with the reality of things. It is an infinite sphere, the center of which is everywhere, the circumference nowhere. In short, it is the greatest sensible mark of the almighty power of God that imagination loses itself in that thought.

BLAISE PASCAL

A presumptuous truism of modernity is that science has disproved the geocentric theory of the universe. This allegedly makes man aware of his cosmic insignificance, because of which he is always in a state of angst and feels the urge to act like a character in a Woody Allen film.

Actually, the opposite is the case. This diagram of the Empyrean², properly understood, shows that the earth is the farthest point from God, which makes it insignificant and godforsaken. Only the subterrestrial hell realms are worse and man's continual descent leads him in that direction. This thought brought the Traditional Man to anxiety; hence, his concern with salvation and ultimate deliverance.

Man, in his descent from his true Self, is thrown into the historico-material process in which he forgets his own being. Modern man can only see the material or historical process, or sometimes both together, which he calls the problem of "nature vs nurture". He conceives man as a *tabula rasa*, that is, lacking a nature, karma, dharma. Hence, his thrownness is an injustice, his defects and strengths are not his, but cosmic accidents. Nor can he claim credit for his intelligence, wisdom, courage, fortitude or other qualities. His defects need to be corrected through the intervention of others.

Words³, to the modern mind, are sophisticated animal grunts and have no relation to anything transcendental. Hence, the intellect leads to no ultimate understanding, but rather is a tool of the will to power. To assuage his guilt over his undeserved advantages, he needs to be committed to or engaged in a cause. The absurdity of the cause means nothing, because the world itself is absurd. That is why it is futile to debate such a person; there is no common ground.

Traditional man never understood the Earth as the center of the Universe, to believe otherwise is risible. Modern men, and those who think like them, understand things in material terms. Hence, they are forced to interpret the diagrams of sacred science in material terms, i.e., as primitive forms of astronomy. No, the Empyrean represents a spiritual journey through states of consciousness, not a physical journey like Star Trek. Man descends through denser states to the sublunar region when he ulti-

²<https://gornahoor.net/wp-content/uploads/2011/03/hierarchy.jpg>

³<https://gornahoor.net/?p=3936>

mately reaches the subtle and gross states represented by water and earth. Here, his dharma intersects with Fate and Fortuna at his conception and birth.

The subtle state, or water element, of the world is chaotic, consciousness is perturbed with pointless desires, confusions, absurdities that the child absorbs. Most men find it impossible to maintain a steady mind, but that is the only way to allow higher influences to come into consciousness.

The gross state, or earth element, is dominated by blind, deterministic forces. Instead of being the field where a man can work out his karmic influences, it instead proves to be a privation, where his undeveloped will is weak and unable to manipulate and control those forces. Only by intense work on developing his True Will can he hope to progress.

It is clear, then, that the Earth is not our true center. The attempts of the neo-pagans to relocate Tradition in nature are thus misguided. Likewise, are the attempts to support tradition on neo-Nietzscheanism. That is merely another form of modernism; the only result is a battle for the control of the Mythos, but as the will to power, not as the fruit of intellectual understanding.

As **Rene Guenon**⁴ points out, the “Heart of the Incarnate Word” is the “spiritual Sun and Center of the World”. It is our task to find our way back home to our center, and “know the place for the first time.” By finding the center of the World, we will find the God whose center is everywhere.

Posted on 2012-04-10 by Cologero

* * *

Avery on 2012-04-11 at 00:07 said:
Here is how I understood your article:

⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=3936>

The materialist, modern observer sees Nature as the origin of all things; the Earth is the center of the universe, not in the superficial sense, but in the deeper sense that claims and values lack substance unless if they relate back to material-scientific law. Language is to modern man a tool used by the strong to dominate the weak for purposes of survival and reproduction.

Primitive man did not use language to bring himself “down to Earth”, but instead to elevate himself facing God. The spiritless, wordless chaos of Nature is a state of alienation from God which one must avoid, and which is as bad as it gets without actually falling into Hell and facing God’s displeasure. Earthly things, especially the matters of sex and violence which now dominate modern discourse, are at best part of a system that enables higher seeking, and at worst a distraction from it.

Please correct any errors in my summary.

Cologero on 2012-04-11 at 07:44 said:

We use the term “primitive man” in a specific way here; I believe you mean to say “Traditional man”. “Primitive” implies an evolutionary development from a lower state to a higher state, in which “primitive man” offers a glimpse into our past. Rather, it represents a glimpse into our future.

Cologero on 2012-04-11 at 07:49 said:

Here are some homework questions:

- 1) How does Alain de Lille, a Medieval theologian, come up with the same formulation as the much more ancient Hermetic Tradition?
- 2) For Christians: why will you never hear a Sunday sermon on the ideas of Alain de Lille?
- 3) For new rightists: is this what you mean by the Semitic desert god?

Graham on 2012-04-11 at 16:58 said:

Answers to homework questions:

- 1) Through an unbroken intellectual tradition. For the record I have read the same formulation in Nicholas of Cusa.
- 2) Because that wouldn’t be “pastoral”. Well, I am only half-joking. Because the knowledge has been cast aside. And what was intuitive to a peasant is obscure and embarrassing to a businessman.

Cologero on 2012-04-12 at 13:31 said:

It is a strange characteristic of human nature that a man with a certain character flaw is likely to interpret other men in terms of that flaw. For example, a cheat is more likely to regard all men as cheats. In particular, a man who constantly accuses us of using “straw man” arguments, uses nothing but them himself.

We have never promoted any particular dogma, creed, faith, or belief. To the contrary, we have pointed out they are necessarily matters of opinion, not of principle. Nevertheless, we do not consider it wrong for a man to take one or the other side of such issues, for good reasons, provided he understands the difference.

It is true that our focus is on the Western traditions, including Hermetism, antique paganism, and Medievalism. The Eastern traditions are well discussed elsewhere, while, oddly enough, our own Western traditions are poorly understood. This can be attributed to a couple of factors. There is a blindness brought on by polemics. This is revealed by the attempt to prefer one specific belief system over another for reasons that have nothing to do with principles. For example, they may object to an alleged cast of mind, attributed typically to some despised historical people. However, as we, following Evola, have pointed out, that is on the horizontal level of subtle manifestation. This sort of objection has nothing to do with principles that transcend space and time.

The more important factor is that it truly is difficult to understand these principles. Unfortunately, in our era where there are no standards, and the good and the bad are mixed indiscriminately, anyone can claim authority on anything. To be clear, we rely on authority ourselves as a sort of intellectual check. So when we focus on the Middle Ages, we do nothing more than develop what the main authorities of Tradition have written about that time.

Specifically, Guenon, Schuon, Coomaraswamy, de Giorgio, and Evola all regard the Middle Ages as a Traditional civilization, the last one experienced in the West. Guenon and Schuon were non-Christians who regard it as traditional. Guenon shows the correspondence of Medieval principles to those of the East. Coomaraswamy, also a non-Christian (although he advised his son to adhere to it), also shows that correspondence in great detail. Furthermore, he recommends several important Western and Christian texts to understand Tradition. De Giorgio was more sympathetic to Christianity, but also to antique paganism. He demonstrates the connection and continuity between the two. Only Evola is expressly anti-Christian, yet he recognizes the Traditional features of the Middle Ages. He also severely criticized neo-paganism, because he understood it is a matter of principle, not labels or group identity.

So, the typical idiots continue to try to post here, believing they can insult, humiliate, or refute us. Now, we may get some facts wrong, or express things unclearly, or even misrepresent Tradition. Those are valid points for discussion. But to send us a list of alleged facts, which are no more than innuendo, claiming to refute thereby the Traditional character of the Middle Ages is a waste of effort. That is not critiquing us; that is a critique on the very notion of Tradition and its founding fathers as we pointed out in the preceding paragraph.

I add this long comment, not for the benefit of one person who most likely will not see it that way, but on the assumption that there may be others who suffer from the same misunderstanding. It is unfortunate to see a man dedicate a lot of time and effort, and have nothing to show for. Thus, we make the effort to always focus on principles. Those who see life in just two dimensions

are forced to engage in Strife. Yet, there is something deeper than that.

Cologero on 2012-04-12 at 17:09 said:

To demonstrate the confusion of today and the inadequacy of our common ways of categorizing ideas, here is a quote from a neo-pagan web site:

Knut Hamsun and **John Tolkien** are perhaps the writers who can best be defined as “Pagan” of the last 150 years, pagan and profoundly anti-modern.

I know nothing about Mr. Hamsun, but I am certain that Mr. Tolkien would be quite surprised at that judgment, except perhaps for the “anti-modern” part. I know he opposed the political system espoused on that web site.

Yet it is an interesting point that illustrates, rather than refutes, our own perspective. We will have more to say about it at some future date. Can the case be made that Lord of the Rings is the most important pagan literature of the past century?

Matt on 2012-04-12 at 20:01 said:

I can see they placed Hamsun in that regard, since his noted pantheism seems to be an integral part of most neo-pagan thinking.

Cologero on 2012-04-12 at 22:11 said:

But they link the two and interpret LOTR in a naturalistic sense. They say the original is in Italian :

When we read their books, we truly feel those living and vivifying descriptions of nature, her forces, her elements. We see that to speak in the same way of thinking, in brief, it speaks the Hyperborean blood itself.

Yet, Tolkien himself writes:

The Lord of the Rings is of course a fundamentally religious and Catholic work; unconsciously so at first, but consciously in the revision. That is why I have not put in, or have cut out, practically all references to anything like ‘religion’, to cults or practices, in the imaginary world. For the religious element is absorbed into the story and the symbolism.

Are they horribly misreading LOTR or have they discovered some deep convergence? If there is any interest in this topic, I’ll ask for permission to translate the entire post. To me, it seems that Tolkien has affinity with the ancient pagans in the sense that the religious sensibility

is integrated into the daily fabric of life; it is not seen as an activity, or belief, separate from one's other daily activities and interests.

Matt on 2012-04-13 at 01:35 said:

I'm not in disagreement with you there, was merely acknowledging why they mentioned Hamsun as the worldview in his books seems to be in the same spirit as that of neo-paganism.

But yes, Tolkien is another matter. Eru Illuvatar (The One, Father of All) is a notable example of how the work can not merely be interpreted in a naturalistic sense, as Eru transcends nature and the cosmos.

As to why they would interpret the The Rings books in this way? I don't know what the sites motives are (as I don't even know which site it is), so I can't say for certain, but the reason may be the same as it for many modern minds... leaving out elements that are significant in a work in order to placate to the pre-conceived opinions of followers.

Cologero on 2012-04-19 at 00:03 said:

I have been reluctant to link to *website*⁵, but I will since I just found an *English translation*⁶ (allegedly by a *third order Franciscan*⁷). The translation is good enough. He misquotes Tolkien, which should be: "I don't know half of you half as well as I should like; and I like less than half of you half as well as you deserve." Also, one phrase makes no sense as translated: it should be "salvation (*from* what?)".

I want to point out the profound difference between the consciousness of these neo-pagans compared to that of the pagan Romans as described by Evola in the most recent translation, and to make it a point of discussion.

The Romans did not live in a world of nature, but in a world saturated with occult, divine, and transcendental forces. The Roman experienced a cosmic order and recognized his duty to conform to it. To fail was to commit a *nefas*; salvation was certainly necessary.

This creates a divided consciousness, as every action must relate to the cosmic order, every decision relate to a divine will, every choice relate to one's duties. The true pagan, that is the pagan as a man of Tradition, surpasses this division by transcendence. It seems, though, that the neo-pagan wants to deny the divided consciousness in the first place. He experiences a divine law as a burden, as an impingement on his freedom, so he seeks to live instead in immediacy like the animals. He wants to be part of his environment rather than to struggle against disorder.

⁵<http://www.corrente88.net/2012/01/17/hamsun-tolkien-lario-e-la-natura/>

⁶<http://oregoncoug.wordpress.com/2012/04/04/hamsun-tolkien-the-aryan-and-nature/>

⁷http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Secular_Franciscan_Order

A similar narrative, albeit in a intellectually more sophisticated form, is that of the New Right. It, too, denies transcendence, which it can only interpret as totalitarianism. To admit a cosmic or divine law is to admit all must follow it. That is true in one sense. Evola even uses that word to describe the inseparability of the spiritual and the temporal in ancient Rome. All aspects of life are subject to spiritual authority and political power.

Yet, it also leads to perfect freedom, because a man also has his own unique and transcendental dharma to follow, something truly his own. Without a sense of transcendence, what can freedom mean other than to follow one's whims? Rather than a life of freedom, the neo-pagan path leads to a life dominated by material, environmental, and historical factors.

Matt on 2012-04-19 at 12:55 said:

Thanks for the link. I read the article on the Italian website (through a translation program on my pc). Its of the usual neo-pagan variety. And with national socialist symbols being placed at the forefront of the site (along with Hitler) I understand your reluctance of posting that link.

As you were giving your summation of the neo-pagan worldview in contrast to the actual pagan worldview of the ancients (or even of a pagan of today who doesn't share the neo-pagan worldview), the connection with gnosticism becomes apparent (which I didn't see before), mostly in terms of the neo-pagan seeing the divine law as a type of totalitarianism. So although there is a love of material nature there that isn't shared with gnostics, there is nonetheless an agreement they have when it comes to the divine law.

Matt on 2012-04-19 at 12:59 said:

Thanks for the link. Just slightly browsing that site, and I can see why you were reluctant to post the website. Anyway, the article is of the usual neo-pagan variety.

In your summation of the neo-pagan worldview in contrast to the actual pagan worldview of the ancients, the connection with gnosticism becomes apparent (one that I hadn't quite noticed before), in the view of seeing the divine law as a totalitarianism.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-04-20 at 08:35 said:

I love LOTR. It took me several attempts to get past the first 100 pages then suddenly the book took off and carried me with it, I was unable to put it down, I think it's one of the most amazing things ever written. I have always tended to see it as a Christian work, albeit implied not explicit, in the grail tradition – marriage of the true king with the faerie queen? pretty straightforward from that point of view I would say, no conflict with 'pagan' (ie, nature) traditions, just Celtic. A lot of the feeling and description of the Shire comes from Tolkein's dismay at the industrialisation of England following the wars and the attendant war machinery. Really there is no incompatibility whatsoever between the true Christian stream and true religion of former times... ..they are the same

Cologero on 2012-04-20 at 09:56 said:

Perhaps more so in the Franciscan tradition? Talking to animals, and so on.

The nun *backs you up*⁸, Charlotte. I think, though, we are more comfortable with seeing a “development”, not in the sense of evolving and leaving the old behind, but in the sense of a “deepening” and an incorporating of earlier elements.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-04-20 at 16:22 said:

Franciscan, yes that's right, he's one of 'us' :-)) I hadn't really considered whether it is more an evolving or a 'deepening', it just seems to be the way it is. As you know I was recently in Central America and I found that contact with the Maya was an extraordinary and thought-provoking experience. now THAT is a strong culture, to have survived so long, throughout countless bloodthirsty revolutions, right up until the present day, spiritually intact. The spirit contacts there are fully manifest on the earth plane and very connected with the earth – living so closely with nature is such a source of power, it was good to be reminded just how much. It is also interesting to note the degree of syncretism going on, with Baroque catholic churches cheerily sharing space with blatantly pagan forms of worship – merengue hymns, anyone, pineapple offering and corn shaped into lizards, life-like effigy's of Christ, etc. Also fascinating was how the devoutly Christian element of society has no conflict with the partisan communist guerrillas, who rightly saw in Jesus the blueprint for true revolutionaries... scary word, but the key is in the 'true'. But coming from a Celtic/Druidic/Grail legend perspective, it was very interesting to see so far back into another culture – to see into their spiritual space, the other side of Atlantis.

Charlotte Cowell on 2012-04-20 at 16:24 said:

and yes, I have to agree with the nun – this is the first thing I learned, this universality – everything is pure to the pure?

Cologero on 2012-04-26 at 23:18 said:

Consider this from Boethius' *Consolation of Philosophy*:

It is well known, and you have seen it demonstrated by astronomers, that beside the extent of the heavens, the circumference of the earth has the size of a point; that is to say, compared with the magnitude of the celestial sphere, it may be thought of as having no extent at all.

So another ignorant, modern meme is destroyed, namely, that the ancients believed the

⁸<http://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1400>

earth was the center of the universe and that modern men became disoriented with “new” scientific discoveries.

Charlotte on 2012-04-27 at 05:01 said:

I am not sure how this meme thread relates to the nun, maybe I'm being a bit dense?

so much of all this is a matter of perspective. From Earth – where we live, which must count from something in this equation – the moon and sun appear to be of identical size. Indeed, the moon can fully eclipse the sun at certain times. Yet we ‘know’ (now) that the sun is much larger than the moon and we cannot, therefore, believe our eyes. How strange! They ARE the same size and yet they are NOT! Does not the indisputable evidence seen by those same eyes reveal a great mystery? When spiritually awakened, the human soul is like the moon to the sun of divinity, which shines upon it and is given reflection, by the light of which it must complete its work of atonement. This inner enlightenment habitually leads the imperfect microcosmic moon self to perceive that it is as brilliant as the sun – the ‘same size’, so to speak – by simple virtue of the fact that it shines where previously it was darkened. Of course, a wise soul ‘knows’, intrinsically, that for all these fantastic perceptions, which give all the appearances and sensation of highest reality, it CANNOT in fact be of comparable brilliance to the divine light shining upon it. Logically this is impossible. The soul can only do its best to make the mirror of mysteries as clean as possible, thereby ensuring a true reflection when the Holy Spirit turns to gaze upon it. In this situation the soul cannot ‘believe its eyes’, it has to trust to a deeper wisdom knowledge that speaks truth directly to the heart, its core self and uncorrupted spark. The signs in the skies are there to help us understand the nature and pathways of our souls – and very simple to understand if one doesn’t think too hard! As for Earth being centre of the universe... ..well in a certain sense it IS, if one looks ‘down and in’ upon the cosmos, rather than ‘up and out’ from here. Something to do with the ellipses and angles taken by the various heavenly bodies, all moving in arcs and triangles into strange places and funny directions for all kinds of distances. Earth from the higher vantage points is like a glowing pearl around which everything revolves, like a precious egg. The first astronauts marvelled at how Earth appeared from space, remarking that in contrast with all the other planets it was shining brightly with a brilliant aura, the light of the world soul, apple of God’s eye.

Angolmois on 2012-04-28 at 10:38 said:

I think it was in RUNA in which there was an article – perhaps by Thorsson or Moynihan – that linked LOTR and Tolkien with ‘Radical Traditionalism’, and I think this is quite a justified assumption. Yet, I do agree myself that there is a convergence of Pagan and Christian wisdom & symbolism of the highest degree in LOTR. The transference of ‘Gandalf the Grey’ into ‘Gandalf the White’ can be seen as an aeonic transference from Heathenism to Christianity of the Traditional kind. And may I remember that it was the blasphemed outcast who became ‘The Golden-red

King' and the unifier of different races / traditions. Tolkien was a genius, one of a kind. His Catholicism reeks Paganism more than Dante's variety does.

The earth IS the centre of the universe, but only as a stepping stone and as a foothold!

Charlotte on 2012-04-28 at 11:16 said:

Interesting, we seem to agree on a lot to do with LOTR!

Regarding characters, tho, I had tended to see the King as being Christlike (the faerie bride his Holy Soul), with Gandalf in a more Holy Fatherly role? However, his transformation from grey to white is indeed telling, as you say. I wonder if this transformation is supposed to give a clue to the initiate about the changing essence of their interactions with the 'force', the divine One? In any event, the passing away of the old world is something we all have to face, along with the sacrifice of so many Shining Ones. Thank heaven for the sacred Earth given Sam-wise to tend, not to mention the benevolent ruling messiah, complete with bride... ..

Angolmois on 2012-04-28 at 13:25 said:

Of course the King is Christ; he wears the purple-red-robe and a golden crown, the symbols of royalty. Gandalf as a high priest relates to the pontificate, and thus LOTR is in agreement with Guénon rather than Evola. Internally we (must) have both Gandalf and Aragorn, together with others, within us in harmony and symbiosis. Saruman is clearly the fallen Lucifer, downtrodden by mans hubris, the black tower of pride and the main centre of mechanical titanic force, and Sauron is of course no other than Satan himself, da.

As regards "geocentrism" via a heretic's wormhole, this must be one of my favourite scenes from the LOTR epic:

http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6cdc_OaAZQM&feature=fvwrl

Balrog "the flame of Udun" reminds me of The Primordial Fire UR (the flame of Ur could be his name), "that old devil", a primordial material and animalistic force personified, whereas the brigde reminds me of the Antahkarana-rainbowbrigde in which the old ego must die in order to be born again. Gandalf's fight in the crumbling brigde together with the flaming sword and the magicians staff clearly symbolise the two-fold functions of Pater Jupiter and Venus-Lucifer, only the sword and staff are in wrong hands, but that's not important. Gandalf's fight with Balrog is his final battle with his own shadow and his lower animalistic self; he no longer has any human vices when he again appears in the scenery as Gandalf the White. And so on.

Charlotte on 2012-04-28 at 13:55 said:

ah I see what you mean now, makes me wonder what this symbol means for the papacy as it is now... ..the final pope is the one to take up the white robe, then? Part of me still thinks JP II went onto fulfill this function, another part of me waits in pensive doubt. Church is being

purified from within but they can't withhold answers forever. If they fail to understand themselves, they should say.

One thing I wondered about the film is why they missed out Tom Bombadil, which IMO was one of the best characters/episodes in the early book. I guess time ran out, but I feel it's a section that needs revisiting, the early part is very dense.

My own favourite scene, I think, is when Arwen calls up the river horses to keep the black riders at bay... good invocatory skills, perfect timing, great example :-)

Angolmois on 2012-04-28 at 13:58 said:

It seems to me that what you fear is a cage, Charlotte.

Charlotte on 2012-04-28 at 14:39 said:

well you are right there, everytime I visit I zoo that strikes me forcibly. Interesting to learn while I was in Guatemala that their national bird, the fabled, beautiful Quetzal, is the one creature that simply cannot survive in captivity – it dies when caged, which is fitting for something that signifies liberation above all else. Something about the truth, a little bird said, that is also meant to set one free.

Matt on 2012-04-28 at 19:04 said:

Angolmois,

Its been awhile since I've read the books and The Silmarillion, but isn't Melkor supposed to be Lucifer? Though I suppose once could say that all three figures (Melkor, Sauron, and Saruman) represent the same archetype.

Matt on 2012-04-28 at 19:07 said:

Oh and sorry for my earlier somewhat double post. Just noticed it in now. The first post didn't seem to register (but so I posted a shortened version.

Angolmois on 2012-04-29 at 03:12 said:

I haven't read Silmarillion myself (shame on me!) but I agree with you that there are many representatives of the same luciferian archetype in Tolkien's books. The monster Balrog can be traced back to this "dark fire" (Boehme) also.

strangelove on 2012-05-15 at 15:15 said:

More info on our geocentric universe here:

<http://christian-wilderness.forumvi.com/t39-stationary-earth>

13.4 On Hermetic Sublimation

In **Valentin Tomberg**'s discussion of *The Empress*, he quotes **Josephin Peladan**'s description of magic as “‘the sublimation of man’... of human nature”. Thereafter, Tomberg offers a detailed discussion differentiating Sacred Magic, from “personal and arbitrary magic”, the latter which explains became more or less the earmark of Renaissance “ceremonial magic”, of which he mostly looks askance.

This is of interest to the Hermetist for a number of reasons.

While **Marsilio Ficino** has been seen as “reviving” Hermetic magic in the Renaissance, it has been pointed out that this is a distortion stemming from Frances Yates' selective uses of Ficino's translation of *Asclepius*, and not *Pimander*. **Walter Haengraff** summarizes the situation:

We are not dealing here with a straightforward case of a magical text influencing a later magical approach, but rather of an innovative interpretation of a non-magical text (i.e. The *Corpus Hermetica*), resulting in a new perspective on how the attainment of a superior gnosis implies the acquisition of superhuman powers. Moreover the new perspective was not seen as magical either, but as something ‘better than magic’.

Thus, the *Hermetica* is not a “magical” text in the sense of what Tomberg calls “personal and arbitrary magic”, but rather a scripture inviting to gnosis, the “sublimation of man”, and as a by-product, certain “powers” might be arrived at—but not the other way around.

Wouter Hanegraaff, who is a scholar by occupation, has produced a critical edition of **Lodovico Lazzarelli**'s *Crater Hermetis*—for the academic/scholarly background, readers are referred to that work, Hanegraaff's “Better than Magic” essay, and his related lecture series produced by the Ritman Library. In reference to Tomberg's meditation however, we only wish to consider certain of Lazzarelli's doctrines in “Crater”, in

direct relation with the idea of “sublimation of man”. In his “Crater”, Lazzarrelli (keeping in mind that he is considering himself to be a transmitter in the true Hermetic lineage) begins to introduce the central motif of his doctrine in 6.2. This could easily be considered “divine procreation”, or “sublimation”:

Hermes says that God, having created all things in the beginning, exclaimed: “Increase, grow up and multiply, all you seeds and works of my hands. And you, who have been given an inheritance of mind, recognize your origin and take heed of your immortal nature, and know that the love of body is the cause of death.’ And that matches what Moses says in the book of Genesis. These words of Hermes contain the tree of life, by which we live, as well as the tree of knowledge of good and evil, which brings us death. And as you see, the main point of this precept is that we should know ourselves”.

It becomes quite interesting that the idea of “liberation” forms an element of Tomberg’s meditation on Sacred Magic, the goal of which, similar to Lazzarrelli’s above is “... to follow an ideal and be truly oneself”. This sort of “liberation”, which is a healing, Tomberg illustrates with example from the Gospel, where Christ produces miraculous cures. Perhaps a bit of synchronicity, or just broad overlap—but the second week of St. Ignatius’ *Spiritual Exercises*, focusing on the Via Illuminativa, the Kataphatic way, seeks to affirm everything that Peter denied; seeks to lead one into friendship with God, is intimately tied to the idea of “liberation”—and likewise concentrates on the healings performed by Christ, such as making the hunchback woman upright (sublimated) on the Sabbath.

Lazzarrelli later in 21.4, continues his discussion concerning what the “sublimation” and “self-knowledge” engenders:

Thus you will come to understand the excellence of your own essence, and will in no way disparage yourself, despise yourself,

will not trample in your own supper, but you will rise up out of the body. Free from yourself and from all the things of the senses, ascending absolutely and purely, to fly up to that transcendent and most shining darkness where God dwells, to take your place among the number of Powers, and having been received among the Powers you shall enjoy God, and henceforth begetting a divine offspring, you will procreate for God and not for yourself. Because like is always produced by like”.

Consequently, as opposed to bells and whistles style “ceremonial magic”, the “Sacred Magic”, or Divine Gnosis to which the Hermetic Art invites us, might be more similar in practice to the Eastern idea of “Bramacharya” — or, at least this appears to be what Lazzarelli is suggesting in his Hermetic transmission, as well as what we have read of Peladan above. In the applied Hermetism of Alchemy, just as on the Empresses’ shield, is the Eagle, emblem of sublimation, distillation, which when “flown” after sufficient purgation, leads to the production of the Azoth, the “Philosophical Mercury”.

Posted on 2014-03-13 by Frater M

* * *

nhm on 2014-03-13 at 22:55 said:

The actual name of the scholar you are referring to is Wouter Hanegraaff. He is one of the editors of Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism, a book that I recommend wholeheartedly to all the readers of Gornahoor.

Thank you, corrections made. — ed

JA on 2014-03-14 at 13:21 said:

I am very much interested in reading actual practical Hermetic exercises based on the ideas presented by Tomberg and the other authors discussed here... ..

13.5 Detraction, Soul Mates and Paranormal Powers

Detraction

Detraction is the unjust damaging of another's good name by the revelation of some fault or crime of which that other is really guilty.

This would include, for example, the public revelation of a private conversation if the intent was to damage the reputation of one of the parties. In recent days, there has been a very explicit example of such detraction. Yet, this is hardly the first time such an event has been deemed newsworthy. What has always surprised me is the lack of understanding of the role of detraction, which is a very serious moral fault. I have not heard any TV commentator mention the word, nor have I seen a blog mention it, despite the many words written about that event.

Someone pointed out to me that the news media run on detraction. That is, they are always gossiping or "digging up dirt" on someone. If that be true, then the media are evil. It is good journalism to uncover some crime or malfeasance in office; not so if the intent is simply to harm someone's reputation if there is no crime or other just reason involved.

Cloning and Soul Mates There hasn't been much talk about human cloning lately. Presumably, this will be available only to the wealthy who can afford such a procedure. That makes no sense to me, since the clone does not really benefit the original. Wouldn't it be better to clone one's soul mate, like Adam and Eve? Now you cannot get a man from a woman's DNA, but you can do the opposite. The female clone would have the exact DNA of the man, except that she would have two of his X chromosomes instead of the Y. Isn't that what a man is looking for? I mean a woman who is just like him in every way.

I may start a company to do this. You should buy in now, while the shares are priced low.

Freedom of Speech and Intolerance The ideal of freedom of speech has been severely tested recently. For example, there is that owner of a basketball franchise who was punished for his thoughts. In fairness, his ideas are inappropriate in a league that is 90% black. Condaleeza Rice was hounded out as a speaker at Rutgers; again, her point of view didn't fit into campus culture, if you can call it that. *Soi-disant* "conservative" commentators have defended Rice, but not Sterling.

Freedom of speech means, in practice, that expression of ideas is tolerated. Although seldom made explicit, the corollary of this point of view is that the intolerant are not entitled to such freedom. Although Herbert Marcuse promoted this idea in the 60s, I believe it can be traced back to Karl Popper. In Rice's case, the principle is that the alleged criminal has no right to speak of her crimes. The in-group defines itself in both cases by what it tolerates and what it rejects.

There is a lesson there for the various groups who claim to be "saving Western civilization" (or Occidental, if you prefer to sound pompous). I heard one such fellow interviewed this weekend. Unfortunately, he is an atheist. Since when has Western civilization been defined by atheism? There are others who promote various non-traditional lifestyles. These movements are intellectually incoherent as they are based, at best, on quite secondary issues. There needs to be more intolerance in this group, but few have the stomach for that. What then to tolerate? We stick to the principle of looking back to the time when well-bred men knew what was normal and healthy.

Girls Gone Wild Carl Jung identified the masculine qualities in a woman's psyche, which he called the "animus". Although essential for her psychological development, for the unindividuated woman, the animus

can take over the personality. In this case, the woman believes she is being as “tough”, for example, as a man, although in reality she is just being argumentative and domineering; however, there is a less polite term in common use for the same phenomenon.

Recently, for example, Sarah Palin made the claim that *waterboarding is our baptism for terrorists*. Leaving aside the blasphemy that everyone is ignoring, that is just some ugly caricature of what, she must believe, sounds like a “tough guy”.

This is yet another example of a really poor metaphor expressed by a public person. There have been worse. I’m sure they must have done poorly in the analogy section of the SAT. Maybe they should take a couple of years off to read poetry and literature, although we assume that the speechwriters have done so.

Dignity in Office Politicians have no sense of dignity, presumably because they were elected by the “people”. For example, Boehner did a poor imitation of a crying baby in a speech. Instead, he could have made an intellectually compelling and coherent case for his point of view. But, yikes, that would only happen in an alternative universe of well-bred men.

I won’t even mention the picture of Obama on a bicycle with a silly grin, short pants, and helmet. I am much more careful now about how I go out in public.

Paranormal Powers This was a topic in a discussion group several years ago, where we were discussing *Darwin’s Dangerous Idea*. The topic of psychic powers came up. I made the point that if psychic powers really existed, then they would be much more common today. Clearly, a population with such powers would have a reproductive advantage over their neighbors, and the relevant gene would have spread.

Of course, that assumes that genetics explains everything about man,

which we in fact deny. The existence of paranormal powers, siddhis, mind control, and the like, would therefore refute Darwinian evolution.

Old Gold I recently came across a large collection of notes and writings from around 1978 to 1985. I may put some of them online as examples of how thought develops. There were many of the same themes written about here, but I did not have the advantage of having read Rene Guenon at that time.

Posted on 2014-05-05 by Cologero

13.6 Do Dogs Go to Heaven

Like a Moth to a Flame The two primary conditions of elementary life are attraction and repulsion. A healthy organism will be attracted to whatever is good for it, including its genetic integrity. Likewise, it will be repulsed by anything that threatens its well-being, again including its genetic integrity.

In the animal soul, an emotional element is added to those conditions. Attraction and repulsion are no longer merely mechanical, but are reinforced by that strong emotional component. Since there is no abstract intelligence in animals, these emotions can be easily fooled. For example, the proverbial moth is attracted to light, which is good, but also to a flame, which will be its downfall.

Many people live primarily an animal life of emotion, with occasional forays into a true intellectual understanding. These emotions have quite a hold, so it is difficult to dissuade them from unnatural attractions and repulsions, because they feel so good. That emotional life is so sweet and appealing, except when it isn't.

The definition of love, for such people, is defective, since it is purely passive:

Love is attraction with a strong and pleasant emotional component.

True Love, on the other hand, is active, a matter of the will. The intellect must decide what is attractive and repulsive; the emotions and body will follow.

To Love is to will the Good.

Stray Dogs in the Intellect

If our intellect is inexperienced in the art of watchfulness it at once begins to entertain whatever impassioned fantasy appears in it, and plies it with illicit questions and responds to it illicitly. Then our own thoughts are conjoined to the demonic fantasy, which waxes and burgeons until it appears lovely and delectable to the welcoming and despoiled intellect. The intellect then is deceived in much the same way as lambs when a stray dog comes into the field in which they happen to be: *in their innocence they often run towards the dog as though it were their mother, and their only profit in coming near it is that they pick up something of its stench and foulness.*

In the same way our thoughts run ignorantly after demonic fantasies that appear in our intellect and, as I said, the two join together and one can see them plotting to destroy the city of Troy like Agamemnon and Menelaus. For they plot together the course of action they must take in order to bring about, in practice and by means of the body, that purpose which the demons have persuaded them is sweet and delectable. In this Way sins are produced in the soul: and hence the need to bring out into the open what is in our hearts.

Beyond Good and Evil Many people claim to have learned of “unconditional love” from their relationship with a pet. Now unconditional love is not necessarily desirable if the object of such love is not the Good. True Love is an act of the will toward the Good.

Now the dog is beyond good and evil, and has no interest in the moral state of its human companion. It is only interested in what is good or bad for its own well-being.

Oddly enough, such people like being the recipient of the pet’s “unconditional love”, but not so much as the giver of such love. A woman who took that lesson to heart would experience better relations with her lover. For example, she would give him three square meals a day, clean up his shit without complaint, and scratch his belly every night. Try that at home and let me know.

States of the Spirit in the World In *Heaven and Hell* #435, **Emmanuel Swedenborg** writes:

All this has been said to convince the rational man that viewed in himself man is a spirit, and that the corporeal part that is added to the spirit to enable it to perform its functions in the natural and material world is not the man, but only an instrument of his spirit. But evidences from experience are preferable, because there are many that fail to comprehend rational deductions; and those that have established themselves in the opposite view turn such deductions into grounds of doubt by means of reasonings from the fallacies of the senses.

Here is the key to understand Swedenborg. He is not really describing a visit to the spirits in Heaven or Hell at some future time, but he is describing phenomenologically the spiritual states of people in the here and now. This is a matter of direct experience and is called in Tradition “external considering” or “reading souls”.

This is obvious from this paragraph from the web site of the Swedenborg Foundation:

Swedenborg writes that each person self-selects a destination in the afterlife depending on what they loved most while on earth. Those who become evil spirits are people who love things like power and wealth and even being cruel to others at the cost of all else. After death, such people push away anything that was good within them and become completely focused on the thing that they value above all else—they become their emotions in tangible form. Spirits are grouped together into societies according to what they love.

Such behavior does not just happen “after death”, but right now in the life of such persons. The death referred to here is a “spiritual death”. Swedenborg’s colorful descriptions of the various evil spirits he encountered are his way of describing their inner soul life.

Continuing his discussion of #435, Swedenborg denies that pets “go to heaven” because, unlike man, they are not spirits. Nevertheless, many people have little self-knowledge of themselves as spirits in the world and remain entrenched in corporeal imagery. They can see little difference between themselves and animals.

People who have convinced themselves [of the opposite view] tend to think that animals live and sense just the way we do, so that they too have a spiritual nature like ours; yet this dies along with their bodies. However, the spiritual nature of animals is not the same as ours. We have an inmost nature that animals do not, a nature into which the Divine flows and which it raises toward itself, in this way uniting us to itself. So we, unlike animals, can think about God and about divine matters of heaven and the church. We can love God because of these matters and by engaging with them; and so be united to him; and anything that can be united to

the Divine cannot be destroyed. Anything that cannot be united to the Divine, though, does disintegrate.”

I don’t believe he writes about the destination of those who love their dogs more than they love God, other than that they will organize themselves together, probably into a pack.

Living like a Dog A year or two ago, I watched a short feature — whose title now eludes me — about a man who designed a pharmaceutical that turned him temporarily into a dog. His drug became very popular, so that clubs arose whose members became dogs, prowling the streets of the city, and rutting, for a night, only to return to the human state in the morning.

Eventually, the authorities regarded his drug as the cause of a public nuisance and ordered him to cease and desist manufacturing and distributing the drug. Instead, he found a way to make the effects permanent and turned himself — and his many followers — into dogs.

The Complete Man **Nicolas Cabasilas** (1320-1392) is a Greek saint and his writings appear in the Roman Liturgy of the Hours. According to **Mircea Eliade**, he considered the layman to be superior to the monk. The goal of the latter is the *angelic life* while that of the layman is the *complete man*.

[The Law of Love] demands no arduous nor afflicting work, nor loss of money; it does not involve shame, nor any dishonor, nor anything worse; it puts no obstacle in the pursuit of any art or profession. The general keeps the power to command, the labourer can work the ground, the artisan can carry on with his occupation. There is no reason to retire into solitude, to eat unusual food, to be inadequately clothed, or endanger one’s health, or to resort to any other special endeavor; it suffices to give oneself wholly to

meditation and to remain always within oneself without depriving the world of one's talents.

NICOLAS CABASILAS

This confirms our claim about the need, in our time, for the spiritual man to be active in the world. The complete man actualizes all his possibilities, not just the angelic ones. The spirituality of the monks has dominated religious discourse, although it is not necessarily appropriate for the man living in the world. It is to these latter men that the future belongs.

Christendom and Skillful Means Frithjof Schuon describes the spiritual state of European man, and why he had to overcome the ancient pagan religion:

European humanity has about it something Promethean and tragic. It therefore required a religion which could surpass and sublimate the dramatism of the Greek and Germanic gods and heroes. Furthermore, the European creative genius implies a need to “burn what one has worshipped,” and from this comes a prodigious propensity for denial and for change. The Renaissance offers us the clearest proof and the most stupefying example of this, not to speak of what is going on in our own time on an incomparably more dangerous level; it is still “Man” that is at issue, but with totally different emphases.

The new religion overcame the arbitrary forces, experienced as the whims of gods and goddesses, that seemed to dominate life. It added Providence to the forces of Destiny and Will, bringing warmth to the world. With the Logos, the world could be experienced as an ordered cosmos rather than the result of Fate or blind Will. Nevertheless, Schuon points to a certain tension, which has only become more exacerbated over time.

Christianity has a dramatic quality about it: it has the sense of the Sublime rather than that of the Absolute, and the sense of Sacrifice rather than that of Equilibrium. In this second aspect it extends to society as a whole a vocation that is properly speaking ascetic – above all in the Latin Church – something which, as a particular *upaya*, it certainly has a right to do, but which has nonetheless provoked historical disequilibriums that are both disastrous and providential.

Time, Space, and Equilibrium are the three preliminary conditions of manifestation from which the active, passive, and neutralizing forces arise. If Tradition is the Civilization of Space, then Time will tend to consume Space unless Equilibrium is established. The re-establishment of equilibrium will require the replacement of “skillful means”, that may have been appropriate at a given time and place, but are no longer effective. The tendency to accept *upaya* as equivalent to dogma must be avoided, since skillful means are appropriate to a particular time and place. Ultimately the goal is *prajna*, i.e., gnosis.

The Eucharist and Nonduality

The Tao acts and does not exhaust itself.

TAO TE CHING

About 6 weeks ago, I heard a sermon at mass on the Eucharist by a visiting priest. In retrospect, I wish I had taken notes for the 45 minute talk, but I had no expectation of it.

Ultimately, it was a nondual explanation of the Eucharist. The thought experiment for the priest was how the Christ can be present in all the hosts while remaining undivided. He compared Christ to the Sun, which is inexhaustible, while all the masses received the light and substance of the Sun. However, this is not a dualism. The priest himself represents

Christ, so that he is also present in the Eucharist. Moreover, the whole congregation, is also the Body of Christ, and so is present in the Eucharist.

The sacrifice of the Mass is not a repetition of Calvary, as the heretics mistakenly assert, but is rather the very *same* sacrifice. So the Eucharist transcends both time and space, and is a theophany connecting the world of being to that of becoming.

The Conversion of Russia At the end of the Latin rite mass, prayers are said for the conversion of Russia. The missal explains:

These prayers were introduced by Pope Leo XIII to obtain an acceptable solution to the Vatican's relations with the Italian State after the seizure of the Papal States. After its resolution by the establishment of the Vatican State through the Treaty of 1929, Pope Pius XI asked that these prayers should be said for the conversion of Russia.

So for over 80 years, these prayers have been said. Perhaps some have noticed a small change in Russia today, different from what it was in 1929. What Western ruler has asked his subordinates to study the works of such eminent philosophers like Vladimir Solovyov and Nicolas Berdyaev?

If the Orthodox still have a beef with the West, perhaps they should return the favor instead of engaging in useless carping.

Huxley on Love **Thomas Molnar**, in *The Decline of the Intellectual*, notes the fundamental message of **Aldous Huxley's** dystopian novel *Brave New World*:

Aldous Huxley had come to the disturbing conclusion that culture, that is, the inner man, cannot survive without tragedy, that is, outside traditional society, where human rapports and not scientific organization, prevail. This is the disillusioned statement of

the World Comptroller from which everything incalculable, the last ounce of freedom and hence the restlessness accompanying creative work, had been eliminated.

That is, the World Comptroller wants knowledge without gnosis, by which he will organize society. So-called scientific control of society is the dream of leftism, although it is a nightmare for those controlled. It tries to control the outward circumstance of life to replace the sense of inwardness.

It leaves out of the picture transcendence, darkness, the depths — or the abyss. Consider, for example, **Jacob Boehme**'s revelation of the Ungrund which is prior to Being, from which creative freedom arises, which cannot be anticipated in any scientific organization. The world is a mix, then, of Darkness and Light, and the darkness cannot be hidden by any technocrat. Nay, he actually is the darkness.

Unfortunately, Huxley eventually ended up California dreaming, that strange attractor. Molnar explains:

In a series of lectures sponsored by the University of California, he advocated the strengthening of love among people by suggesting that mothers all over the world, while suckling their babes should rub them against other people and animals saying “nice-nice, good-good,” and should point at everybody around repeating some incantatory formula like “this is a good man, we must love him.”

In other words, he thinks people should start acting more like pet dogs.

Loving your Enemies If true love is to will the good for someone, then the desire for justice, as the greatest natural virtue, is an expression of love. For example, a general would engage only in a just war with an enemy, not targeting women and children, nor anything without a military purpose. Such a general would become a complete man.

Now the principle of justice is “to each his own”, or in other words, in justice a man should get what he is entitled to. In particular, a good general will give the enemy exactly what he deserves.

Answer at the Back of the Book

The angels are the thoughts of God incarnated in the celestial flesh.

PIERRE DEGHAÏE, *La Naissance de Dieu*

Specifically, there is an angel of the dogs, which serves as the “group I” for all dogs, which lack an individual “I”. This angel will know all the dogs, in a supra-individual way, as non-formal manifestation. Presumably you can communicate with that angel and experience your pet “from the inside”, in a much more intimate way.

But first of all, you need to work out your own salvation.

Posted on 2016-09-07 by Cologero

* * *

William on 2016-09-08 at 00:33 said:

“According to Mircea Eliade, he considered the layman to be superior to the monk.”

Does Gornahoor also take such a view? I understand the need to actualize possibilities beyond the angelic, but how can the assertion of lay superiority over the monastics be reconciled with the eminence of the priestly caste, which is clearly above the laymen in the caste system.

Cologero on 2016-09-08 at 07:58 said:

So are you “off the hook”, William? Do you want a free ride, while letting the monks do all that hard stuff?

We accept them as teachers, so we posted a long excerpt from the *Philokalia*. How will you use that passage in your life today?

By the way, not all monks are priests.

In a very recent post, we made this suggestion in regard to some ideas from Joachim di Fiore:

Hence, the Age of the Holy Spirit is actually the beginning of a new cycle, not the final stage of some evolutionary process. If the first age was that of the fathers, then of priests, Joachim thought the Third Age would be that of an elite corps of contemplative monks. Actually, it is more likely that that corps will consist of men and women active in the world, while transcending it.

William on 2016-09-08 at 19:46 said:

My question has nothing to do with whether or not I'm off the hook. I know what my duties are in accordance with the caste system. I'm simply asking how we can consider the priestly caste to be higher in the hierarchy than most of us will ever reach, yet still consider ourselves as lay people to be superior to monastic priests. Also, what are we to make of lay brothers? Perhaps they are who the sentence in question was referring to and I'm just misunderstanding? Even then, though, wouldn't they be considered ascetics, which Evola described as a path of the Absolute Man?

Pepé on 2016-09-08 at 20:59 said:

William – as I understand it, that means a 'new caste'. so to speak.

Cologero on 2016-09-09 at 00:01 said:

The castes are all mixed up today, and few may be in their correct caste. So your point is irrelevant.

mleow on 2016-09-09 at 03:06 said:

Moving away from christianity, sanatana dharma which unarguably has more authority to it (from a traditional perspective) then some sayings from swedenborg, considers that animals definitely do have a soul life for example a short summary of the views expressed;

<http://www.hinduwebsite.com/hinduism/essays/animals.asp>

Besides cologero it is almost amusingly predictable how your canine hatred shines trough and resurface in every odd post you made here over the years. Were you bitten by a dog when you were young or something? Your knowledge and experience of dogs seems to be limited, "Now the dog is beyond good and evil, and has no interest in the moral state of its human companion. It is only interested in what is good or bad for its own well-being." Is it really cats you are referring?? St Roch would probably not concur with that statement..

Cologero on 2016-09-09 at 08:24 said:

No, mleow, but I did bite a dog once.

????? on 2016-09-09 at 10:13 said:

I recall hearing someone ask a similar or the same question at a sufi gathering, and the response concerned the dog who lived in the cave with the (seven?) sleepers. Since the dog was a good dog and a companion of saints, it will live on as a human in Paradise insha'Allah. IIRC. Because you will be with those whom you love. But will dogs be with those whom they love? That hadith wasn't directly addressed to dogs... This is a controversial issue among Muslims too.

It was narrated that Abu Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him) said: The Messenger of Allah (peace and blessings of Allah be upon him) said: "Pray in the sheep pens and wipe their dust (raghaam), for they are among the animals of Paradise."

Ulysses on 2016-09-09 at 13:44 said:

On the subject of experiencing pets "from the inside", Groucho Marx said "Outside of a dog, a book is man's best friend. Inside of a dog, it's too dark to read."

Matt on 2016-09-09 at 23:11 said:

Mleow,

The Church also recognizes that animals have a soul. The question is, do they have an intellectual/rational soul? Because the matter of immortality rests with the intellectual soul. From Tradition (christian or not), humans have all three soul layers: vegetative, animal/sensitive, and intellectual/rational. That's what makes us fundamentally different from animals and plants (a difference of kind, and not merely of degree). Swedenborg's statements are in keeping with the authoritative teachings of the Church, and also with those of the other legitimate traditions.

Just putting aside Tradition and doctrine, and instead looking at empirical studies (if that's what matters to some readers), the supposed evidence for certain animals possessing substantive(moral) reason and intelligence is rather limited and weak, with the concepts of reason and intelligence being poorly grasped by the researchers that make claims about certain animals.

Ultimately , how does one envision what eternal life is like? Is it the ever deepening-ascending contemplation and love of the Divine, or is it forever playing fetch with Fido?

William on 2016-09-10 at 11:27 said:

"The castes are all mixed up today, and few may be in their correct caste. So your point is irrelevant."

I've been reading Gornahoor for quite a while, and out of all the asinine replies you've given to readers, this has to be the least satisfactory one yet.

Cologero on 2016-09-10 at 14:39 said:

Apparently, William, my source is equally asinine:

Have we not arrived at that terrible age, announced in the Sacred Books of India, 'when the castes shall be mingled, when even the family shall no longer exist'.

As we have already pointed out, under the present state of affairs in the Western world, **nobody any longer occupies the place that he should normally occupy by virtue of his own nature; this is what is meant by saying that the castes no longer exist, for caste, in its traditional meaning, is nothing other than individual nature**, with the whole array of special aptitudes that this carries with it and that predisposes each man to the fulfillment of one or another particular function.

From *Crisis of the Modern World* by **Rene Guenon**

AC on 2016-09-10 at 18:48 said:

Two relevant excerpts:

According to the [evolutionist explanation of the instinct of animals], instinct is the expression of the heredity of a species, of an accumulation of analogous experiences down the ages. This is how they explain, for example, the fact that a flock of sheep hastily gathers together around the lambs the moment it perceives the shadow of a bird of prey, or that a kitten while playing already employs all the tricks of a hunter, or that birds know how to build their nests. In fact, it is enough to watch animals to see that their instinct has nothing of an automatism about it. The formation of such a mechanism by a purely cumulative . . . process is highly improbable, to say the least. Instinct is a nonreflective modality of the intelligence; it is determined, not by a series of automatic reflexes, but by the "form"—the qualitative determination—of the species. This form is like a filter through which the universal intelligence is manifested. . . The same is also true for man: his intelligence too is determined by the subtle form of his species. This form, however, includes the reflective faculty, which allows of a singularization of the individual such as does not exist among the animals. Man alone is able to objectivize himself. He can say: "I am this or that." He alone possesses this two-edged faculty. Man, by virtue of his own central position in the cosmos, is able to transcend his specific norm; he can also betray it, and sink lower; "The corruption of the best is corruption at its worst." A normal animal remains true

to the form and genius of its species; if its intelligence is not reflective and objectifying, but in some sort existential, it is nonetheless spontaneous; it is assuredly a form of the universal intelligence even if it is not recognized as such by men who, from prejudice or ignorance, identify intelligence with discursive thought exclusively.

-Titus Burckhardt, *Modern Psychology*

And:

We have seen reason to believe that not all animals suffer as we think they do: but some, at least, look as if they had selves, and what shall be done for these innocents?

The real difficulty about supposing most animals to be immortal is that immortality has almost no meaning for a creature which is not "conscious" in the sense explained above. If the life of a newt is merely a succession of sensations, what should we mean by saying that God may recall to life the newt that died to-day? It would not recognise itself as the same newt; the pleasant sensations of any other newt that lived after its death would be just as much, or just as little, a recompense for its earthly sufferings (if any) as those of its resurrected – I was going to say "self", but the whole point is that the newt probably has no self. The thing we have to try to say, on this hypothesis, will not even be said. There is, therefore, I take it, no question of immortality for creatures that are merely sentient. Nor do justice and mercy demand that there should be, for such creatures have no painful experience. Their nervous system delivers all the letters A, P, N, I, but since they cannot read they never build it up into the word PAIN. And all animals may be in that condition. If, nevertheless, the strong conviction which we have of a real, though doubtless rudimentary, selfhood in the higher animals, and specially in those we tame, is not an illusion, their destiny demands a somewhat deeper consideration. The error we must avoid is that of considering them in themselves. Man is to be understood only in his relation to God. The beasts are to be understood only in their relation to man and, through man, to God. Let us here guard against one of those untransmuted lumps of atheistical thought which often survive in the minds of modern believers. Atheists naturally regard the co-existence of man and the other animals as a mere contingent result of interacting biological facts; and the taming of an animal by a man as a purely arbitrary interference of one species with another. The "real" or "natural" animal to them is the wild one, and the tame animal is an artificial or unnatural thing. But a [believer] must not think so. Man was appointed by God to have dominion over the beasts, and everything a man does to an animal is either a lawful exercise, or a sacrilegious abuse, of an authority by divine right. The tame animal is therefore, in the deepest sense, the only "natural" animal – the only one we see occupying the place it was made to occupy, and it is on the tame animal that we must base all our doctrine of beasts. Now it will be seen that, in so far as the tame animal has a real self or personality, it owes this almost entirely to its master. If a good sheepdog seems "almost human" that is because a good shepherd has made it so. . . I am now going to suggest that . . . beasts that attain a real self are *in* their masters. That is to say, you must not think of a beast by itself, and call that a personality and then inquire whether God will

raise and bless that. You must take the whole context in which the beast acquires its selfhood – namely “The good man – and – the – goodwife – ruling – their children – and – their – beasts – in – the – good – homestead”. That whole context may be regarded as a “body”; and how much of that “body” may be raised along with the goodman and the goodwife, who can predict? So much, presumably, as is necessary not only for the glory of God and the beatitude of the human pair, but for that particular glory and that particular beatitude which is eternally coloured by that particular terrestrial experience. And in this way it seems to me possible that certain animals may have an immortality, not in themselves, but in the immortality of their masters. And the difficulty about personal identity in a creature barely personal disappears when the creature is thus kept in its proper context. If you ask, concerning an animal thus raised as a member of the whole Body of the homestead, where its personal identity resides, I answer “Where its identity always did reside even in the earthly life – in its relation to the Body and, specially, to the master who is the head of that Body”. In other words, the man will know his dog, the dog will know its master and, in knowing him, will be itself. To ask that it should, in any other way, know itself, is probably to ask for what has no meaning. Animals aren’t like that, and don’t want to be.

My picture of the good sheepdog in the good homestead does not, of course, cover wild animals nor (a matter even more urgent) illtreated domestic animals. But it is intended only as an illustration drawn from one privileged instance – which is, also, on my view the only normal and unperverted instance of the general principles to be observed in framing a theory of animal resurrection. I think [believers] may justly hesitate to suppose any beasts immortal; for two reasons. Firstly, because they fear, by attributing to beasts a “soul” in the full sense, to obscure that difference between beast and man which is as sharp in the spiritual dimension as it is hazy and problematical in the biological. And secondly, a future happiness connected with the beast’s present life simply as a compensation for suffering – so many millenniums in the happy pastures paid down as “damages” for so many years of pulling carts, seems a clumsy assertion of Divine goodness. We, because we are fallible, often hurt a child or an animal unintentionally, and then the best we can do is to “make up for it” by some caress or titbit. But it is hardly pious to imagine omniscience acting in that way – as though God trod on the animals’ tails in the dark and then did the best He could about it! In such a botched adjustment I cannot recognise the master-touch; whatever the answer is, it must be something better than that. The theory I am suggesting tries to avoid both objections. It makes God the centre of the universe and man the subordinate centre of terrestrial nature: the beasts are not co-ordinate with man, but subordinate to him, and their destiny is through and through related to his. And the derivative immortality suggested for them is not a mere amende or compensation: it is part and parcel of the new heaven and new earth, organically related to the whole suffering process of the world’s fall and redemption. Supposing, as I do, that the personality of the tame animals is largely the gift of man – that their mere sentience is reborn to soulhood in us as our mere soulhood is

reborn to [God] – I naturally suppose that very few animals indeed, in their wild state, attain to a “self” or ego. But if any do, and if it is agreeable to the goodness of God that they should live again, their immortality would also be related to man – not, this time, to individual masters; but to humanity. That is to say, if in any instance the quasi-spiritual and emotional value which human tradition attributes to a beast (such as the “innocence” of the lamb or the heraldic royalty of the lion) has a real ground in the beast’s nature; and is not merely arbitrary or accidental, then it is in that capacity, or principally in that, that the beast may be expected to attend on risen man and make part of his “train”.

When we are speaking of creatures so remote from us as wild beasts, and prehistoric beasts, we hardly know what we are talking about. It may well be that they have no selves and no sufferings. It may even be that each species has a corporate self—that Lionhood, not lions, has shared in the travail of creation and will enter into the restoration of all things. And if we cannot imagine even our own eternal life, much less can we imagine the life the beasts may have as our “members”. If the earthly lion could read the prophecy of that day when he shall eat hay like an ox, he would regard it as a description not of heaven, but of hell. And if there is nothing in the lion but carnivorous sentience, then he is unconscious and his “survival” would have no meaning. But if there is a rudimentary Leonine self, to that also God can give a “body” as it pleases Him—a body no longer living by the destruction of the lamb, yet richly Leonine in the sense that it also expresses whatever energy and splendour and exulting power dwelled within the visible lion on this earth. I think, under correction, that the prophet used an eastern hyperbole when he spoke of the lion and the lamb lying down together. That would be rather impertinent of the lamb. To have lions and lambs that so consorted would be the same as having neither lambs nor lions.”

-CS Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

Max on 2016-09-11 at 05:55 said:

We have anticipated the discussion of this intriguing question since it first appeared among the upcoming topics.

There are “mysteries” of the human condition that demand an answer as well, for example why some people are reduced to speaking baby talk as soon as they see a dog. I heard children of parents who speak to them in such a way grow up to become less intelligent and capable, so one can legitimately ask who is really benefiting from it since it is obviously not the children or the dogs? People may try to convince themselves that it is a benevolent concession to others, but it is more likely to correspond to their own projected needs.

Dogs does not understand “economy” and will not obey for moral reasons or to gain an advantage since they even stays with an owner who abuses them. Humans on the other hand, understanding economy, are always looking to gain one thing or another. What that is and how successful we are at it differs. I do not think that a hypothetical “dog heaven” would be very

appealing, but perhaps that is what some people aspire to.

Dogs do not choose whether to “love” or not, it is an instinct that they need for survival since they are not even capable of hunting their own meals. Humans are also generally a domesticated race that does not need to hunt for survival because of setting in place welfare systems providing for them. What a dog feels for a human provider is like humans “unconditional” loyalty to these institutions. This tamed nature gets expressed for example as childlike acting or being drawn toward increased socialization, the seeking of approval from the environment, or speaking in baby talk which is the equivalent of a dog’s immature bark retained throughout life (a mature wolf will not bark, it launches its deadly attack without warning, something that stupid zookeepers have repeatedly got the opportunity to experience).

The process as a whole involves certain advantages but it causes a higher dependency on the right upbringing, training, and so on to result in a well equipped and highly functional individual. Basically it allows for more “plasticity” and through that potential for freedom and self-direction, but at the same time also the risk of slavery, making it a kind of gamble. For example, the mental resources that are normally used for social approval can be redirected to the pursuit of knowledge. That does however not imply a lack of “social intelligence”, but rather the judgement of the direction (or lack thereof) of the majority as a meaningless evolutionary dead end. Humans mature at varying rates, and the longer the stage of childhood, the higher the potential intelligence of the mature man becomes, but with it the vulnerable formation period increases.

In North America, genetic testing has shown the existence of wild wolves bred with coyotes and domesticated dogs. It was speculated that this has resulted in a far more dangerous creature, perhaps inheriting the wolfs capabilities and merciless killer instinct, now combined with the other parts disrespect and fearlessness for the weak modern man, sort of like the animal equivalent of stealing the Promethean fire, serving to introduce new instincts into the wild population. As a veritable “age of the wolf”, this would be like the Caucasian race loosing its universal altruistic side, bred out of existence for lack of bringing any advantage in the current climate. The popular narrative always risks becoming a self-fulfilling prophecy when its inherent destiny proceeds to travel its course.

The technocratic attempt to minutely control the world has deprived our contemporaries of the feeling of a vast cosmos made up of various forces, wills, beings, an experience without which Christianity becomes difficult to approach. It seems that generally, and without an inevitable mechanical backlash to current trends bringing a deepened disclosure of reality, that higher view will remain closed to most.

Taxonomic species are often defined on the basis of whether they breed with each other or not. That however not only depends on physical opportunity but on will and intent, which could be both good or bad news depending on how you interpret it. For leftist egalitarians it would become possible to promiscuously become an “equal” to lower forms of life, which in turn

means that we can without remorse exclude them from the species. Humanity seems to be on the brink not so much of “breakaway civilization” as breakaway speciation, that is to say shifts in Intelligence. We are seeing not the widespread surpassing of the totemic level (from “Social Facts and Group Control”), but a return to it. Since the modern welfare state is not based on an equilibrated state of “social fact” that can persist for centuries, perhaps in a hundred years, all that will be left of it is a primitive dog cult in the outback mindlessly chanting the Law of the Jungle in baby talk...

“And the Wolf that shall keep it may prosper, but the Wolf that shall break it must die.”

The article on epigenetics that you linked to (I cannot find on which page) raises the point that genes, or the entire genesis of an organism for that matter, is much more fluid than previously thought – it can quite literally absorb from its environment the genes that are congenial to its aspirations, even by other means than reproductive sex. All of this is consistent with the ancients account of for example “genii” or “daemon”, and also makes much more sense in a worldview of mind over matter.

It also makes the point that “survival of the fittest” merely means “survival of those who survive” which is circular reasoning with no explanatory power. Now, we may in an exercise of conscious judgement choose to measure “fitness” by other criteria than reproduction, acquiring a view not merely of a vague “survival”, but what lives on and in which way.

Epigenetics tells us that the expression of our genes, influencing what we become, is partly dependent on our environment. As a spontaneous experience, thought belongs to the environment of the human organism. This means in practice, even in a materialistic framework where thought is nothing but chemical reactions (those reactions are no less fundamental an environment than chemical reactions occurring outside the body), that thinking something specific holds the potential of unlocking and activating, through providing the correct stimuli, aspects of our inheritance that were previously dark and inaccessible.

Cologero on 2016-09-11 at 11:22 said:

Thanks for finding those excerpts, AC.

The one from Burckhardt makes more sense, as it is closer to our viewpoint. The vegetable, animal, and intellectual souls interpenetrate. So even if an animal does not have an independent intellectual soul, the two lower souls do have an intellectual component. That is the manifestation of what we called an “angelic intelligence”.

Lewis is just speculating. Any “self” he seems to observe does not belong to the animal as an individual begin, but may perhaps be a vestige of that angelic intelligence. Of course animals suffer since they are sentient beings. We’re not in agreement with Descartes on that point.

13.7 Fabre d'Olivet on the Borean Race

An early review of two books by Fabre d'Olivet, translated into English, was published in New York Tribune, 7 Aug 1921⁹.

Besides his monumental hermeneutical study of the history of the Borean race, Fabre d'Olivet wrote an interpretation of the Golden Verses of **Pythagoras**. Born some 800 years after **Akhnaton**, Pythagoras was an initiate in Egypt and brought monotheism into Greece. While outwardly participating in the polytheistic rites of the city, the initiates of the Pythagorean school were secretly following a different path.

Monotheism and the Logos were taught in the ancient mystery schools. Later, Socrates was a bit too careless and was condemned to death in Athens for the crime of impiety. Nevertheless, these teachings were developed by Plato and Aristotle. However, it was the arrival of Christianity that made the esoteric teaching of monotheism as part of its exoteric teaching ... for better or worse. However, as we shall see in future posts, it was a necessary development in the Destiny of the Borean race, as it was more suited to Empire than the ancestor worship of the city-states.

The text of the review follows:

Pythagoras Revealed Through Medium of a French Disciple

New Light Cast on Theories of Greek Sage Who Believed in Supreme Deity 500 Years Before Christ By Grace Phelps

THE GOLDEN VERSES OP PYTHAGORAS By Fabre d'Olivet.
Done into English by Nayan Louise Redfield.

Published by O. P. Putnam's Sons.

HERMENEUTIC INTERPRETATION OF THE ORIGIN OF THE SOCIAL STATE OF MAN. By Fabre d'Olivet.

⁹<http://chroniclingamerica.loc.gov/lccn/sn83030214/1921-08-07/ed-1/seq-50/?words=Fabre+Borean+D%27Olivet+d+Olivet>

Done into English by Nayan Louise Redfield. Published by G. P. Putnam's Sons.

"What's the World Coming To?" is a question that the moderns are not alone in asking. The ancients discussed the subject rather fully, and when one of their wise men thought he had the answer he formed a cult and instructed his followers in a philosophy that enabled them to bear up under the social inequalities and various forms of injustice of the day. Today we translate the ancients.

Pythagoras was one such sage and D'Olivet, his French translator, was another, but their teachings did not endear them to the people of their time. Pythagoras escaped persecution in 510 B. C, though his followers were not so fortunate. D'Olivet incurred the enmity of Napoleon Bonaparte and was slated for deportation to Africa. Deportation still being in vogue, Miss Redfield may suffer a like fate, especially if the United States Senate ever delves into the Hermeneutic Interpretation of the Origin of the Social State of Man, wherein D'Olivet declared that this government is not merely indifferent to religion, but actually atheistic. No Senator who has stood up for two, four or six years under the invocations of the chaplain and his guests of all religious faiths will tolerate that accusation.

D'Olivet is not amiably Inclined toward republics. Although the United States at the time of his writings was barely in existence, he prophesied that liberty—which he considers a vital force in spiritual and political evolution—would not long endure here. He warns Europeans, inspired to hopes of a republic by America's example, that "such a republic cannot belong to Europe unless Europe consents to become the conquest of America and to be one of its dependencies." And if America becomes strong enough to attempt such conquests he prophesies its overthrow.

The reason for D'Olivet's gloomy outlook on republicanism lies in his examination of the history of the Borean, or white, race for 12,000 years. The conclusions he was forced to draw from that monumental study agree with his interpretation of the Pythagorean cult, of which he

was an Initiate.

In brief, he perceived that there was a metaphysical correlation of Providence, Destiny and the Will of Man, which is working toward the complete evolution of man until, "ascending into radiant ether, midst the Immortals, thou shalt be thyself a God." Destiny, according to D'Olivet, reigns over the past, the Will of Man over the future and Providence over the present.

If, he reasons, man belongs to Destiny, "he would be what shortsighted philosophers have attributed him to be, without progression in his course and consequently without future." But, as the work of Providence always mitigates destiny, man advances freely in the route which is traced for him, perfecting himself in proportion as he advances and tending thus to immortality. Providence he conceives as the expression of the Divine Will, and Destiny the domain of the individual, in which domain, however, man has the power to dominate and regulate conditions according to the efficiency of his will.

In tracing the history of mankind D'Olivet follows the course of the ancient religions and philosophies which, to him, are the mainsprings of progress toward the ultimate state of man as a god. Without consideration of the sacred books of the nation, he declares that history is meaningless.

However one may question his conclusions, the study of history in the light of the three principles which govern his philosophy is intensely interesting. Even fine print, which is the curse of the reviewer and sudden death to the casual searchings of the layman into philosophy, could not hide the fascination of these two books. But the fact that they are beautifully bound and printed in type that can be read as easily as the best printed novel is cause not merely for honorable mention but wholehearted rejoicing. The English translation, too, should come in for its share of commendation because of its clarity and simplicity, an end not lightly to be achieved in works of this character.

D'Olivet's interpretation of the Golden Verses, not being controversial—or perhaps we should say less so, for here we tread on dangerous ground—is more in line with popular aspirations of the moment. We may differ on politics, but, if no other sign were pointing in that direction, the number of books on the subject which pour out each month would convince us that the whole world is seeking for spiritual light. It may be rash to say we are in for a spiritual regeneration but at least it is safe to say that we are willing to be regenerated. If we don't need it ourselves, the other fellow does.

It is strange to think that seventy-one lines of verse, which are all that constitute the Golden Verses of Pythagoras, should have such tremendous effect as these esoteric verses have had in the world since the time they were written, more than 500 years before Christ. The secret of tolerance which the followers of Pythagoras, in common with the followers of Kong-Tse, or Confucius, have shown toward the gods of others is here revealed. Behind polytheism, or, indeed, the worship of any god or gods, was their belief in the essential unity of God. Consequently it didn't matter which quality the various cults deified. Pythagoreans could publicly worship the gods of the country in which they lived and know that they were really worshipping the Supreme Deity,

The laws that Pythagoras laid down for his followers were indicative of the highest standards. Since they were taught in secret, and their significance revealed only after years of probation, his doctrines were not for the general public, which is a point against the Pythagoreans and one for the Christians. Essentially, however, the moral teachings of Christ do not differ.

Pythagoras used the language of numbers (which was well known to the ancients but perfected by him) to conceal his teachings. D'Olivet does not go into this beyond a few statements which do not shed much light on the symbols.

Our chief criticism of this volume is that so much of it (the first

half) should have been devoted to a dissertation on poetry when there was so much left unsaid about Pythagoras. Not that we underestimate D'Olivet's discussion of poetry. It is a most exhaustive study and should be an eye-opener to the free versifiers of today who flatter themselves that they have discovered a new thing. But, entertaining as it is, it seems to us that it has no place in the volume. Beyond dividing the book in two we fear that the publishers have no choice but to print it as it is—that is, unless D'Olivet, who was a firm believer in the transmigration of souls in their progress toward immortality, should return to earth and reveal many things concerning Pythagoras which he has concealed.

There is one point in particular on which we would like to be enlightened. Pythagoras outlined a diet for his followers which D'Olivet mentions, but does not give in detail. Beans, however, were a Pythagorean aversion. We have a similar aversion. We recall the time at the distant age of seven when we went on a hunger strike for twenty four hours—the first hunger strike on record, we believe. Our parents were Christians, but they were Pythagorean in that they respected other folks' principles. We can't help regretting that we didn't have a principle—an esoteric one at that—for them to respect in the matter of beans.

Posted on 2011-06-21 by Cologero

13.8 Invasion of the Body Snatchers

The reason that people don't take the red pill is not necessarily because they are afraid to face reality, but rather because, if you do, it becomes really annoying to hang around blue pill people.

MOI

To begin with unlimited liberty is to end with unlimited despotism.

FYODOR DOSTOEVSKY

The wise person seeks what he lacks, and he considers not how much he knows, but of how much he is ignorant.

HUGH OF ST. VICTOR

There have been several versions of the film, *Invasion of the Body Snatchers*, most recently starring Nicole Kidman. The general idea is that aliens have infected the minds of human beings. They then become robotic, thinking and acting alike. A few who manage to avoid infection find themselves bewildered and confused. They are considered to be enemies of the state by those how are infected. They are pressured to conform to the others, or they at least have to pretend to conform.

If you accept the idea of the Revelation of the Method, then the film is not depicting some possible future, but is actually describing the present state of affairs. Some unknown “they”, in reality guided by demons, are able to alter attitudes and values of millions of people. Those unable or unwilling to conform then face intense pressure to do so. Of course, “they” reveal to us what they are doing by means of the mass media. Not that it makes any difference, since few people have a Real I, and must necessarily follow the latest fads.

The Idea of the Good Plato noted that we are guided by two principles: our inborn desire for pleasure and the desire for what is objectively best. The first desire is based on serotonin: if it feels good, it must be good. Of course, following the crowd, i.e., being on the “right side of history” might also feel good. The “pleasure principle” is the state of fallen man at birth, so it does not need to be learned. This is the unregenerate level of fallen human beings. As such, it is contrary to nature, although most consider it to be natural.

That is not the case for the preference of the good over the pleasurable. That must be learned and requires the rational intellect to determine and to will the good. **David Hume**, in the *Treatise of Human Nature* totally distorts this distinction when he asserts:

Reason is and ought to be the slave of the passions.

That is the complete opposite of Tradition which claims that the rational faculty ought to rule over the passions. Only then can a human being exist at a higher level, which is his true natural state. Such a person has a Real I.

The Classes of Men There are three karmic classes of men:

- **Third class.** These are the unregenerate people. They are blindly seeking the meaning of life, without a real inner direction. They think they have an I who speaks and acts, but that I is not permanent; it changes from day to day, or even from minute to minute. They are “tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine by the sleight of men and their cunning and craftiness.” They falsely believe they have a real I because all their subpersonalities respond to the same name and occupy the same body. Unfortunately, since their ideas do not come from their rational soul, they fall prey to the body snatchers. In extreme cases, as in multiple personality disorders, the subpersonalities have different names and often do not even know of the others. Those of the third class are not really different, although they may function better in the world.
- **Second class.** People in this class have become dissatisfied with the world of those of the third class. They then seek the meaning of life in science, philosophy, religion, etc., in short, in systems outside themselves. They may be quite intelligent and erudite, having

accumulated a large amount of book knowledge. They may even know a lot of what is written on esoteric and Hermetic topics. However, they don't bother with the exercises so they never advance. They console themselves with the claim that the teachings are for a "future generation". Hence, their lives, in practice, are not much different from those of the third class.

- **First class.** This class is composed of the few who have developed a sense of the real I. They understand that spiritual growth requires self-discipline and intentional suffering. It is essential to oppose one's faults, negative emotions, idle fantasies, etc., as we have often noted. Just reading about such practices is not at all effective. Such men will try to help others on the path, even if few respond.

The Three Forces or Gunas The traditional teaching is that there are three forces behind events in the world. In Hindu metaphysics, these are the three gunas:

- **Rajas.** The force to change, i.e., the positive force.
- **Tamas.** The negative force that retards.
- **Sattva.** Harmonises the positive and negative forces.

Empedocles came close to this understanding with his notions of Love and Strife, with Love as the attractive, or positive, force and Strife as the repulsive, or negative, force. Unfortunately, it seems that he was unable to discern the neutralizing or equilibrating force. It is always difficult to see the neutralizing force in the world. That is because the lower intellect is bipolar or dual, so conventional thinking finds it difficult to reconcile those opposites.

Boris Mouravieff called these forces the static, dynamic, and neutralizing principles. He describes them this way:

Where the third or neutralizing force is concerned, it often escapes our observation—either due to the bipolar character of our minds, or because of its own nature—which can in many cases leave it unobserved. It also sometimes plays the role of catalyst—far less conspicuous than the binding tie which is the most fundamental role of the neutralizing force.

The passive force contains all the possibilities for creating the phenomenon, while the active force intervenes as the realizer, and the neutralizing force as the regulator, of the relations between the two other forces, determining the dosage for both in an optimal way.

Mouravieff gives several examples of how these forces operate in different circumstances. The ultimate example concerns the relationship of God with the World. God is the universal I and the world is the universal Thou. Love, then, is the neutralizing force between them, as described in John's Gospel. That is the solution to the problem of the One and the Many.

The Lotus Flowers Valentin Tomberg takes a different approach in his discussion of the chakras or lotus flowers. The Heart chakra, which is the midpoint, is that of Love. The three chakras above the Heart relate to the Spirit and the three lower chakras to the body, or world. The Heart chakra, as Love, then balances the two forces. The Heart chakra lives according to solar law; it then harmonizes the unruly lower chakras to also follow the solar law. It will also bring warmth to the abstract intellectuality of the higher chakras.

Love, Fear, and Hubris In the 1980s, three interesting texts appeared: *Gnosis* by Mouravieff, *Meditations on the Tarot* by Tomberg, and the allegedly channelled text, *A Course in Miracles* [ACIM]. I immersed myself in all three. The text of ACIM was accompanied by 365 daily exercises. I

followed them for one year; I had a box of 365 cards and carried the appropriate one in order to remember to do the exercise. Obviously, doing such exercises has had a lasting effect on me. Primarily, the idea of doing a task at specified times during the day has stuck with me. It forces one to pause and question his habitual way of understanding the world. The text did not interest me as much, as it has some problematic elements; hence, I no longer have any interest in it. At the time, I knew several people involved with the course. I suspect, however, that few of them actually did the exercises.

The point I'm getting to is that I have some credentials to comment on Marianne Williamson, who, as a presidential candidate, has intrigued and confounded many. It seems to me to be difficult to reconcile ACIM with partisan politics. Specifically, the Course teaches Love which should obliterate dualistic thinking. Yet, like Empedocles, she divides the world into Fear and Love. Obviously, she claims to be motivated by Love, while Trump feeds on fomenting Fear. This is what the Course says:

Only love is strong because it is undivided. The strong do not attack because they see no need to do so. Before the idea of attack can enter your mind, you must have perceived yourself as weak. ... The opposite of seeing through the body's eyes is the vision of Christ, which reflects strength rather than weakness, unity rather than separation, and love rather than fear.

Gnosis is based on spiritual vision, not on our sensory perception of the World:

Misperceptions produce fear and true perceptions foster love, but neither brings certainty because all perception varies. That is why it is not knowledge. True perception is the basis for knowledge, but knowing is the affirmation of truth and beyond all perceptions.

Gnosis begins with self-observation and self-knowledge. Such knowledge is always certain and beyond doubt:

The Bible tells you to know yourself, or to be certain. Certainty is always of God. When you love someone, you have perceived him as he is, and this makes it possible for you to know him.

This applies, a fortiori, to our love for God. We only love what we know. When we love God, we love his commandments, which are simply descriptions of the Solar Law. To follow the Solar Law, then, is to serve God.

Ultimately, Miss Williamson has made the Course irrelevant. On the stage, she supported the exact same policies as all the others. This worldview is independent of any personal beliefs. We saw that Jews, atheists, liberal Christians, secularists, and so on, all came to the same conclusion. The impulse for this must be arising from a much different, and unnoticed, force. It's as though an alien force has snatched their bodies;

Since they have no explanation for their political viewpoint, they resort to confabulations, after the fact, to explain it. These confabulations lead to hubris, since they see themselves as spiritually enlightened, saviours of humanity, superior to their opponents, etc.

Unconditional Love Many women have told me that their dogs have taught them unconditional love. That is because dogs are poor judges of character: Hitler's dog loved Hitler, Stalin's dog loved Stalin, and Pol Pot's dog loved Pol Pot. A dog will love whoever feeds it and gives it attention. The dog's attitude is quite natural.

As an experiment in unconditional love, go to your neighbour's house and demand a free meal. Before you leave, drop a deuce on her carpet. If she is still showing you unconditional love, ask her to rub your belly before you go.

The Christian teaching is that we are commanded to love, so a dog is incapable of love. On the face of it, that sounds quite odd, since we consider love to be passive not active; e.g., one “falls in love”. Everyone assumes he knows what love is, but it is actually not so easy to understand. Even when understood, it is difficult to love, and the spiritual authorities have not been all that helpful.

God’s Kingdom Although it is true that God is Love, there are many misunderstandings about what that means in practice. But before there can be Love, there must be fear; fear of the Lord is the beginning Wisdom.

God rules, not just by love, but by these three factors.

- Fear of Hell
- Promise of Heaven
- God rules by love: persuasion and creativity

For most people, at least most religious people, the fear of Hell and the promise of Heaven are the prime motivating factors. To love God is to follow the commandments for their own sake, and not because of Hell or Heaven.

That is the path to self-mastery, which expels the body snatchers.

Posted on 2019-07-18 by Cologero

13.9 The Night of the Black Cows

There are two forms of darkness. One is where we encounter God. The other is the night in which all cows are black. That is, the night during which no one is able to make intelligent distinctions. The former is considered obscurantism by our educated contemporaries. The latter is considered “enlightenment” by the same people.

Divine Darkness Shortly after I posted *The Philosophy of the Future*¹⁰ last week, I received the journal of *Death to the World*¹¹. Through synchronicity, it contained a passage from Saint Gregory of Nyssa, titled *Divine Darkness*¹², on the prophet **Moses**. He wrote:

What does it mean that Moses entered the darkness and then saw God in it? What is now recounted seems somehow to be contradictory to the first theophany, for then that the divine was beheld in light, but now He is seen in darkness.

Although religious knowledge is first received as light, he continues:

as the mind progresses and, through an ever greater and more perfect diligence, comes to apprehend reality, as it approaches more nearly to contemplation, it sees more clearly what of the divine nature is un contemplated.

Gregory explains the method of “depth”, not to mention the trial to give up one’s false beliefs:

For leaving behind everything that is observed, not only what sense comprehends, but also what the intelligence thinks it sees, it keeps on penetrating deeper until by the intelligence’s yearning for understanding it gains access to the invisible and the incomprehensible, and there it sees God. This is the true knowledge of what is thought; this is the seeing that consists in not seeing because that which is sought transcends all knowledge, being separated on all sides by incomprehensibility, as by a kind of darkness.

¹⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7379>

¹¹<http://www.deathtotheworld.com/>

¹²<https://gornahoor.net/?p=6071>

Consensus Reality Jacques Ellul explained that the purpose of mass education is to make it possible for propaganda to be absorbed more effectively. Rather than the method of depth which requires the abandonment of all that one falsely observes and thinks, the method of propaganda is just the opposite. It seeks to fill the mind with unjustified and unjustifiable opinions. This requires a certain level of sophistication so that is why the intelligent and the degreed are nearly always in accord with modern consensus reality.

The under-educated and the less intelligent, on the other hand, are unable to attain that level, so are confused by it, should it ever cross their mind. In that case, they often gravitate to marginal, and often ridiculous, conspiracy theories. This does not challenge the modern worldview, but rather reinforces it, since the propagandized can gloat over their intelligence compared to the uneducated.

If we let X represent consensus reality and we define a set of mental assumptions that imply X, we can represent it like this:

$[A, B, C, \dots] \Rightarrow X$, where A is atheism, for example, and B, C, etc are other assumptions, whether explicitly acknowledged or implicitly believed.

The remarkable thing is that we find that certain assumptions, which seem to be foundational to one's worldview, make absolutely no difference. For example, Mary says she believes X because of her Christian principles, while the atheist professor Waldo believes the same thing. If the above formula refers to the professor, we can express Mary's world view in this one:

$[\bar{A}, B, C, \dots] \Rightarrow X$, where $\bar{A}$ is not-A

Then logically, assumption A is irrelevant to coming to conclusion X. Yet Mary and Waldo insist the opposite. If all the cows are black, then A, B, and C are irrelevant. Everything looks like X.

Gnosis The super-correct seem to think that gnosis is a threat to their religion. I'll quote **Frithjof Schuon** to help define the concept:

a key idea of Christianity is that it means "God became what we are, in order that we might become what He is" (**St Irenaeus**); Heaven became earth that earth might become Heaven. Christ re-enacts in the outward historical world what is being enacted at all times in the inner world of the soul. In man the Spirit becomes the ego in order that the ego may become pure Spirit; the Spirit becomes ego by incarnating in the mind in the form of intellection, of truth, and the ego becomes the Spirit through uniting with it.

There is clearly no threat here; the esoteric way is orthogonal to the exoteric way. Since the exoteric path is sufficient for salvation, it simply cannot see the point of esoterism. Hence, it can only be believed as irrelevant at best, or heretical at worst. Their eyes cannot penetrate the darkness.

What happens historically, is also experienced interiorly. As above, so below. As the inside, so the outside.

The Kaleidsocopic Bliss of Heaven Unlike humans, angels do not share a common nature; each one has his own nature, utterly distinct from every other angel. Moreover, they have no individual form. Hence, our way of experiencing them is different. Schuon explains it very nicely:

The angels are created of light, of a supra-formal substance; the differences between angels are like those between colors, sounds, or perfumes, not those between forms ...

That is what Heaven is like. It is a multi-dimensional kaleidoscope with constantly changing colors, sound, scents, and experiences undreamed of. As the Depth is Infinite, there can be no end to the chants of the heavenly

hosts, and no boredom. Only more and more profundity toward the Divine Darkness where God is hiding in plain sight.

Posted on 2014-07-04 by Cologero

* * *

Wayne Ferguson on 2014-07-05 at 21:37 said:

Apropos of "The Kaleidsocopic Bliss of Heaven", what do you make of this?

<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7agL-sNLXMI>

Cologero on 2014-07-08 at 09:16 said:

Wayne, I don't know if you are addressing that question at large or to me, since I wrote precisely what I make of this. The metaphysics, as described, is sound. The vision is personal and has no authority beyond that. But it can be compared to the rash of books out today about boys and men who claim to have visited "heaven".

Wayne Ferguson on 2014-07-08 at 16:06 said:

Thank you for the reply, Cologero—I was wondering what you (or anyone) might make of the YouTube clip of the housewife on LSD in the 1956 experiment (I shared the link in my first comment). Her description— and evident joy —in that clip, sounds a lot like the "Kaleidsocopic Bliss of Heaven" in your post. While I don't want to disparage anyone's personal experience or traditional faith/hope, I don't put much stock at all in booksellers like Eben Alexander, et al. On the other hand, your description— and that of the housewife in the YouTube clip —reminds me of William Blake, who I do respect:

"If the doors of perception were cleansed every thing would appear to man as it is, Infinite. For man has closed himself up, till he sees all things thro' narrow chinks of his cavern."

Thanks again...

Cologero on 2014-07-10 at 23:57 said:

Curious, Wayne. I suppose her experience is the material analog of authentic spiritual experience. That is, the experience is passive, caused from the "outside", without requiring any fundamental change in the woman. I recall in the 60s in Boston, when Leary and Ram Dass were at Harvard and LSD was not yet illegal, that there was a debate on public TV between Leary and some biologist. I don't recall what the latter said. Nevertheless, at most LSD can only indicate certain possibilities, and is no substitute for the real thing.

Max on 2014-07-12 at 12:10 said:

Drugs may function to break away from certain illusions, they may also cause worse illusions. In a previous age and through a regular tradition the hallucinogenic experience could probably be guided by a superior in the correct direction. This is not possible anymore or very unlikely. Shamans degenerated into solely dealing with demons and spirits, forgetting the All-Father. The risks increase with the amount of psychic residue as the age proceeds. Hallucinogens probably bring far more pitfalls than opportunities and should be stayed away from, which is the view of Charles Upton who has written about the topic in his books which I recommend on the subject.

There is reason to believe that those substances also contributed to opening and expanding "the fissures in the great wall" that Guenon writes of. Psychic experiments coincide in time with accelerating technological and nuclear developments: space exploration, computers, internet and so on which likely are connected in a manner most are ignorant of. As all cows are black for our educated contemporaries as you point out, they never ask themselves where new technology really comes from or what had to be offered for it. There is no such thing as something being discovered or invented just by chance at a specific moment in time.

13.10 The Critic and the Ideologue

We will lower the screens and drop the veils on the eye of the critic [one who uses logical proof] and the one who simply follows a creed [ideologue]. Both of them are among the forms in which God gives tajalli [his Self-manifestation], but He has commanded the veil for us in order that different levels of excellence of the predisposition of forms might appear.

IBN ARABI, *Bezels of Wisdom*

Recently, there was a comment on the *Five Elements of Manifestation*¹³:

While it is commendable to do amateur philosophy, but to include Eliphas Levi with Indian philosophy is unpardonable.

¹³<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=14558>

First of all, if your talking donkey tells you the truth, then it is still true, and a professional intellectual may talk nonsense even with a million followers. Levi was just summarizing **Paracelsus**, who has a better reputation, but it is easier to be snarky than to be informed. Nor is there any mention of “Indian” philosophy, because metaphysics transcends nationality. Either the five elements are qualitatively accurate everywhere or they are not so anywhere. We are not “doing philosophy” but describing reality. You see it or you don’t; the critic is veiled with illusion, but he is doing the best he can. God knows best what degree of self-manifestation is appropriate to each person.

A “professional” philosopher will tell you all about Plato, his various periods, his teachings, and so on. He may even mention that Plato taught that we live in a world of shadows and few bother to look for the Sun that casts the shadows. A fortiori, he does not even know how to escape the shadow world to the enlightened world.

The philosopher will read that there is a form of knowing, called “Intuition”, that is superior to what the rational mind can achieve. This is the case in metaphysics from India, to Greece, to Egypt, to Arabia, to the Scholastics. Yet the veil blocks his understanding so he ignores it. Intuition is akin to “seeing”, not to “thinking”, and certainly not to “arguing”.

The Culinary Arts Plato complained that the purpose of the culinary arts was to make unpalatable or unhealthy foods taste delicious. Analogously, the professionals try to make life in the cave palatable. The world is replete with distractions that make it possible to get through the day. (I leave it to the reader to make a personal list of such distraction.)

What does the one who has seen the Sun then do? He has become a gnostic, “one who knows”. Does he leave the shadows behind or does he go back to find some others, always a small minority, who would like to see the Sun? Perhaps you have an opinion. Keep in mind Aristotle’s sobering

claim that there are those—perhaps most—who are simply unteachable.

Professional Opinions I don't offer anything new, since I have referenced dozens of the best minds; I hope some readers have been motivated to return to the original sources. Perhaps some of the illustrations are novel; a diligent study may be able to repeat texts, but if he can't illustrate concrete examples, his understanding may be incomplete.

Physics studies phenomena and tries to derive principles that relate them to each other. Metaphysics starts with principles and understands phenomena through them. I will give examples from thinkers who have a much more sterling reputation than I. **Sayyid Nasr** explains it this way (using Islamic terminology):

The term "ta'wil," which plays a cardinal role in Shi'ism as well as Sufism, means literally to return to the origin of a thing. It means to penetrate the external aspect of any reality, whether it be sacred scripture or phenomena of nature, to its inner essence, to go from the phenomenon to the noumenon.

Hence, in that article, I started with the inner essence of matter, in its five forms, and illustrated how they correspond to various phenomena. I showed how the elemental beings are experienced as various psychic states. In this regard, I am simply developing ideas from Nasr:

In the religious cosmos of the traditional Muslim, which is filled with material, psychic, and spiritual creatures of God, the jinn play their own particular role. By the elite they are taken for what they are, namely, psychic forces of the intermediate world of both a beneficent and an evil nature: On the popular level, the jinn appear as concrete physical creatures of different shapes and forms against which men seek the aid of the Spirit, often by chanting verses of the Quran.

On the theological and metaphysical level of Islam, the order of the jinn becomes understood as a necessary element in the hierarchy of existence, an element which relates the physical world to higher orders of reality.

So apart from the jinn, there are other semi-material, psychic, and spiritual creatures. Obviously, the semi-material creature—in the sense that they do not incarnate with all the elemental qualities—manifest as various psychic forces. These forces are known to Indian philosophy, Islamic metaphysics, and, yes, even to Eliphas Levi.

Music The ethereal nature of music was noted by the professional psychologist, **Emma Jung**:

For music can be understood as an objectification of the spirit; it does not express knowledge in the usual logical, intellectual sense, nor does it shape matter; instead, it gives sensuous representation to our deepest associations and most immutable laws. In this sense, music is spirit, spirit leading into obscure distances beyond the reach of consciousness; its content can hardly be grasped with words — but strange to say, more easily with numbers — although simultaneously, and before all else, with feeling and sensation. Apparently paradoxical facts like these show that music admits us to the depths where spirit and nature are still one — or have again become one.

You can choose to “do” philosophy in the “usual logical, intellectual sense”, just like a professional, or you can follow music into “the depths where spirit and nature are still one — or have again become one.”

Jinns The related article, *Passing Through the Realms of the Jinns*¹⁴, illustrates several of these points. There is no essential distinction between that description and that of the professional Nasr:

¹⁴<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=14515>

Man was made of clay. The jinn in Islamic doctrines are that group of creatures which was made of fire rather than earth.

Actually, man was made of wet clay: earth and water, as we wrote. Nasr continues:

[Jinns] possess a volatile and “unfixed” outer form and so can take on many shapes. This means that they are essentially creatures of the psychic rather than the physical world and that they can appear to man in different forms and shapes.

As we pointed out, the fire element has essence but no particular form, more that you get from Nasr. Moreover, that article explains in detail why the jinn would appear in a particular form to a specific person.

The Gnostic Ibn Arabi describes the one whose understanding passes beyond reasoning:

When he is alone with himself after God’s self-manifestation [ta-jalli], he is confused about what he saw. If he is the slave of a Lord, his intellect returns to him, and if he is the slave of reasoning, God gives him back judgement. This is only as long as he is veiled in the dimension of this world from his dimension in the Next World. The gnostics appear here as if they possessed the form of this world by virtue of the fact that its principles operate on them. However, God has transformed them inwardly to the dimension of the Next World. That must be the case. *They are unknown by form except to whoever has had his inner eye unveiled by God so that he perceives.*

In other words, you won’t be able to recognize the gnostic through his outer appearance alone. I know that some authors like to pose sideways with a vacant stare into the unknown. That counts for little.

Posted on 2021-07-18 by Cologero

* * *

Cologero on 2021-07-19 at 06:38 said:

For more on how “professional” philosophers go wrong, check out *The particle collection that fancied itself a physicist*¹⁵ by Edward Feser:

It can be charming when a child pretends that he is a cloud, or a boulder, or a lion, or even – I suppose – a collection of particles. It’s considerably less charming when a grown man does it, and when he is a grown man with a Ph.D. and a tenured position at Columbia, it’s downright embarrassing. But you need only turn on the news to see that otherwise intelligent people believing ever more ridiculous things on the basis of ever more convoluted sophistries is the story of our age. There is a crucial but widely overlooked lesson here. When your basic assumptions are unsound, greater intelligence by no means guarantees that you will come to see this. On the contrary, sometimes you will end up only more hardened in error than a less intelligent person would be, because you will be able to come up with subtler fallacies and cleverer self-deceptions.

13.II The Life of Reason

Succession Bishop Kallistos Ware points out:

Alongside this apostolic succession, largely hidden, existing on a ‘charismatic’ rather than an official level, there is secondly the apostolic succession of the spiritual fathers and mothers in each generation of the Church—the succession of the saints, stretching from the apostolic age to our own day, which Saint Symeon

¹⁵<https://edwardfeser.blogspot.com/2020/08/the-particle-collection-that-fancied.html?m=1>

the New Theologian termed the “golden chain.”... Both types of succession are essential for the true functioning of the Body of Christ, and it is through their interaction that the life of the Church on earth is accomplished.

The West likewise has an esoteric hierarchy in addition to the exoteric hierarchy, although the history of the distinction is less precise. The charismatic succession has sometimes been secret, and then visible, sometimes in opposition to the exoteric Church, other times in harmony. **Valentin Tomberg** identified this as the *Hermetic Tradition*, a parallel succession to the visible church, but not in opposition to it.

Vladimir Soloviev recognized the hidden charismatic succession, seeing himself as the heir of Kabbalah, Neoplatonism, Boehme, Swedenborg, and the German philosopher Friedrich Schelling. **Wolfgang Smith** followed a similar chain, but replaced Swedenborg with Meister Eckhart.

Yet, as we have seen, it goes back further, even to the pagans by way of the Zoroastrian Magi. Solovyov pointed out that the primary doctrines of Christianity — the Trinity and the Incarnation of the Logos — were known to the ancients. Hence, what Christianity added was to make those doctrines historical, concrete realities. That makes all the difference.

In recent times, Solovyov, Tomberg, Mouravieff, and Wolfgang Smith, *inter alios*, are all laymen who have responded to the Spirit to keep the esoteric succession a living force. The Spirit blows where He wills.

The Life of Reason A common assumption is that the spiritual life is somehow irrational, relying on nothing but blind faith or arbitrary belief. Nothing could be further from the truth.

David Hume, the skeptic and alleged rationalist thinker, asserted that “reason is and ought to be the slave of the passions”. That is, a slave to whatever arises by chance. Essentially, Hume claims that man acts, and should act, like a highly intelligent dog. This is subrational. For Hume,

the function of the intellect is to choose the best means to reach an end determined by the instinctive life.

Many call this “living in the moment”, “life affirming”, and so on, all delusions to rationalize the need to remain a slave. Living like this is actually contrary to nature, since it is man’s nature to be intelligent, not instinctive, to be free, not a slave.

The spiritual life, on the other hand, is supra-rational. The intellect must be trained to dominate the animal and vegetable souls, i.e., one’s animal and instinctive life. Its nature is to rule over the passions. Specifically, the intellect chooses the ends, not just the means. This is living in harmony with nature.

Divine Will The Divine Will is the source of the cosmic order and is one with the Logos, or the Principle of cosmic order. So the Life of Reason — in which a person chooses not just the means, but also the end — is to live in harmony with that cosmic order.

No one can elude this Will, whatever he may think, so everyone is in the place suitable for him. In the *Symbolism of the Cross*, **Rene Guenon** points out that the Universal Will divides human beings into three categories, dependent on their reaction to the cosmic order.

- **The Faithful** conform consciously and voluntarily to the Universal Will.
- **The Infidels** obey the Law only against their will.
- **The Ignorant** have no clue.

Unfortunately, in our age, our “real” place in the cosmic order seldom matches our nominal place. Hence, it takes considerable intellectual effort to determine the real nature of things. We can no longer judge by outward appearances. Rene Guenon makes this clear in the *Crisis of the Modern World*.

Have we not arrived at that terrible age, announced in the Sacred Books of India, “when the castes shall be mingled, when even the family shall no longer exist”?

As we have already pointed out, under the present state of affairs in the Western world, nobody any longer occupies the place that he should normally occupy by virtue of his own nature; this is what is meant by saying that the castes no longer exist, for caste, in its traditional meaning, is nothing other than individual nature, with the whole array of special aptitudes that this carries with it and that predisposes each man to the fulfillment of one or another particular function.

Rhetoric

An argument based on knowledge implies instruction, and there are people whom one cannot instruct.

ARISTOTLE

Dialectic and Rhetoric are two traditional sciences of the Trivium (along with Grammar). Dialectic is concerned with Logic and the mechanics of thought. Rhetoric is about the means of persuasion.

Imagine a possible world in which journalists were skilled in Dialectic and Rhetoric. Then, in their political commentaries, they could point out the logical flaws and rhetorical devices in the speeches of politicians. Although journalists are seldom logical, they do, to some extent, understand rhetoric. Hence, they will judge whether rhetoric has been effective or not in its aim of persuasion.

However, we, as the “informed public” need to be the impartial judges. Dialectic deals with logic and rhetoric with facts. Unfortunately, Aristotle points out that rhetoric is little more than:

The arousing of prejudice, pity, anger, and similar emotions [which] has nothing to do with the essential facts, but is merely a personal appeal to the man who is judging the case.

It is necessary to ignore such appeals, for the only things of importance are whether

- Something has happened or has not happened,
- What will be or will not be.

Thus, in a contemporary political context, the primary concern should be with results, past, present, and future. The human race lives metaphysically far from the Center of the Universe. Hence, we are subjected to laws at several different levels: the natural law, economic laws, social laws, psychological laws, laws of biology, chemistry and physics. This must all be taken into consideration in judging what may or may not happen.

Ideally, then, in the Life of Reason, Rhetoric must be in the service of knowledge. Since people have different abilities and intelligence levels, rhetoric needs to be adapted to a particular audience. The audience will be swayed or moved by rhetoric to support a position or course of action. Of course, the expert is neither swayed nor moved, but is only concerned about the actual effects of that course. The speaker will use enthymemes, i.e., unspoken parts of a syllogism that the audience is expected to fill in. Enthymemes make the audience members feel “smart”, as though they were in on special knowledge. The intelligent listener will be on the alert for such enthymemes.

Posted on 2016-09-15 by Cologero

13.12 Men without Qualities

But because thou art lukewarm, and neither cold, nor hot, I will begin to vomit thee out of my mouth.

REVELATION 3:16

Robert Musil's novel, *A Man without Qualities*, is about

a 32-year-old mathematician named Ulrich who is in search of a sense of life and reality but fails to find it. His ambivalence towards morals and indifference to life has brought him to the state of being “a man without qualities”, depending on the outer world to form his character. A kind of keenly analytical passivity is his most typical attitude.

*The Man Without Qualities*¹⁶

The man without qualities suffers from *acedia* (state of listlessness, indifference to one's position or condition in the world) and *abulia* (lack of will). There is no lack of intelligence, yet his intellectual strivings have no purpose so can neither form a plan of action nor lead to any peace or certainty. Here is a self-description of such a man, which recently passed through my news feed. He identifies as an

agnostic with pagan sympathies

After a lifetime of thinking, that is a rather meagre result. There is no commitment to anything: neither to a purpose to the world nor to an acknowledgment of chaos. What is a pagan sympathy? If a man is squeamish about human sacrifice or infanticide, how sympathetic can he be to the pagans? The myths and legends of the ancient pagans are replete with patricide, matricide, squabbles, deceit, treachery, and so on. The same goes for the stories in the Edda. They are hardly sympathetic.

¹⁶https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Man_Without_Qualities

A Misnomer In an online public discussion, someone asserted:

Traditionalism posits a return to a mentality through intellectual means to which we, as modern people, cannot return, any more than a 60-year-old can return to the mentality of a 6-year-old. (Which is not to denigrate either mentality.)

It's a sad sign of the times that such a sentence is considered a marker of intelligence in some circles. It would be forgivable except that it was authored by someone who once claimed to be "sympathetic" toward tradition. We dealt with the misnomer "traditionalism" some 9 years ago in *Tradition and Traditionalism*¹⁷ and in *The Absurdity of Traditionalism*¹⁸ **Rene Guenon** addresses this topic nearly a century ago:

People described as Traditionalists ... only have a sort of tendency or aspiration towards tradition *without really knowing anything at all about it*; this is the measure of the distance dividing the "traditionalist" spirit from the truly traditional spirit, *for the latter implies a real knowledge*, and indeed in a sense it is the same as that knowledge.

RENE GUENON, *The Reign of Quantity and the Signs of the Times*

"Tradition" must be understood in its literal sense as something "handed down" or "given across", not as the "repetition of the past" for its own sake. What is handed down, then, is a transcendent knowledge which cannot be considered as just another perspective or worldview. Hence, the "modern" mentality must certainly be denigrated since it is the opposite of authentic knowledge. Rather it is a symptom of intellectual confusion. Guenon continues:

¹⁷<https://gornahoor.net/?p=383>

¹⁸<https://gornahoor.net/?p=728>

words are applied to things which they do not fit in any way, and sometimes in a sense directly opposed to their normal meaning. This is one of the most obvious symptoms of the intellectual confusion which reigns everywhere in the present world; but it must not be forgotten that this very confusion is willed by that which lies hidden behind the whole modern deviation.

Harsh words from the Master. The man without qualities may believe he is directing his life, but, as Guenon observes, his vaunted modern mentality is formed by hidden spiritual forces beyond his awareness. The modern mind has sunk into materiality, making it unable to perceive anything higher.

Archaic Consciousness and Eternal Return The correct formulation of a question often leads to the correct answer. The question, then, should be rephrased as whether a return to archaic consciousness, in **Mircea Eliade's** sense of the term, is possible. He explains:

In *imitating* the exemplary acts of a god or of a mythical hero, or simply by recounting their adventures, the man of an archaic society detaches himself from profane time and magically re-enters the Great Time, the sacred time.

Myths, Dreams and Mysteries

Of course, the modern man, unable to take such myths at face value, does so in a different manor from the primitive man. Paul Ricoeur calls this re-enactment the second naïveté. In any case, knowledge of sensory space-time events can never be more than a matter of opinion (*doxa*). Hence, sacred time refers to events in consciousness. **Hans Leisegang** makes this clear:

Every myth expresses, in a form narrated for a particular case, an eternal idea, which will be intuitively recognised by him who re-experiences the content of the myth.

DIE GNOSIS

Valentin Tomberg in *Meditations on the Tarot* points out the relationship between myths and archetypes:

myths reveal the archetypes which manifest themselves endlessly in history and in each individual biography – they are mythological symbols pertaining to the domain of time.

There is a method of Hermetic Meditation¹⁹ that enables one to re-enter into that mythological or sacred time. The goal is to regain the state of consciousness that existed before the Fall. Eliade provides this example:

The most representative mystical experience of the archaic societies, that of shamanism, betrays the *Nostalgia for Paradise*, the desire to recover the state of freedom and beatitude before ‘the Fall’.

This is true not only of shamanism, but also of the Hermetic teachings.

Intellectual Conversion Eliade offers this explanation of the Traditional point of view:

things acquire their reality, their identity, only to the extent of their participation in a transcendent reality.

Myth of the Eternal Return

¹⁹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=898>

Clearly, this transcendent reality is the realm of ideas and Plato is the philosopher who made this explicit. Hence, Eliade continues:

Plato could be regarded as the outstanding philosopher of ‘primitive mentality,’ that is, as the thinker who succeeded in giving philosophic currency and validity to the modes of life and behaviour of archaic humanity.

Julius Evola also distinguishes between the worlds of being and becoming. In the first chapter of *Revolt Against the Modern World*, this is made clear and explicit:

In order to understand both the spirit of Tradition and its antithesis, modern civilization, it is necessary to begin with the fundamental doctrine of the two natures. According to this doctrine there is a physical order of things and a metaphysical one; there is a mortal nature and an immortal one; *there is the superior realm of being and the inferior realm of becoming*. Generally speaking, there is a visible and tangible dimension and, prior to and beyond it, an invisible and intangible dimension that is the support, source, and true life of the former.

The modern mentality is tied to the physical order of things, or the inferior realm of becoming. He is the cave dweller in Plato’s myth of the cave, and can only see the shadow of reality on the wall. By assiduously wrestling with Plato’s text or similar writings, the modern man may undergo an intellectual conversion. He then escapes from the cave and discovers the Sun. Sadly, few are willing to make such efforts or may actually be incapable of it. It is the nature of error not to recognize itself as error. Such a man will disbelieve any rumours about the Sun and is like those living in The Country of the Blind²⁰.

²⁰<https://gornahoor.net/?p=7992>

Hence, Guenon opined that the future would be open to a small remnant, not by the restoration of past glory, but rather by adapting those principles to the current situation. He elaborates in *The Crisis of the Modern World*:

If it be objected that Christianity itself, in our time, is no longer understood in its profound meaning, we should reply that it has at least kept in its very form all that is needed to provide the foundation of which we have been speaking. The least fantastic venture, in fact the only one that does not come up against immediate impossibilities, would therefore be an attempt to restore something comparable to what existed in the Middle Ages, with the differences demanded by modifications in the circumstances; and for all that has been completely lost in the West, it would be necessary to draw upon the traditions that have been preserved in their entirety, as we stated above, and, having done so, to undertake the task of adaptation, which could be the work only of a powerfully established intellectual elite.

Postscript The point of this is not to single out any one person, but rather to answer a legitimate question in a complete way. There many so called ‘radical traditionalists’ or those ‘influenced by tradition’, etc., without any real understanding. Just as bad money drives out the good, so too do bad ideas drive out the truth.

We have defined the ideas of Tradition, the modern mentality, and archaic consciousness with precision. Ultimately, the answer to the original question cannot be proven by logic, but only by personal experience. The alternative is to live with ennui, confusion, and purposelessness.

Posted in 18-02-2019 by Cologero

13.13 Objective Reality

Our age is an age in which men rise painfully from effects to causes, in which they even concern themselves only with effects, in which they say it is useless to concern oneself with causes, and in which they do not even know what a cause is.

JOSEPH DE MAISTRE

The crown of the Emperor signifies the renunciation of freedom of intellectual movement, just as his arms and legs signify his renunciation of freedom of action and movement. He is deprived of the three so-called “natural” liberties of the human being—those of opinion, word and movement. Authority demands this.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Every possible world requires five conditions:

- Form and matter
- Space and Time
- Consciousness (or Life)

A world without consciousness is inconceivable; try it if you can. Space and Time are necessary for conscious experience. Although they may be experienced differently in different worlds, there needs to be some sense of synchrony and diachrony.

Anything that exists in the world requires matter and form, or essence. These two factors are related to our knowledge of the external world and the intelligibility of the world.

- The objective reality of the world is imposed on us through the senses

- The “crown of thorns” give conscience to objective thought
- Thought, in its pure state, is the organ of truth, not illusion
- However, the five dark currents of the will take hold of the thinking centre, thereby distorting it

The External World

A wound is a door through which the objective exterior world intrudes into the interior of the closed system of the subjective interior world. Speaking biologically, it is a breach in the walls of the fortress of the organism by which forces from outside the organism penetrate into its interior.

The eyes are open wounds which are so sensitive that they react to every nuance of light and colour. And it is the same with the other sense organs. They are wounds, i.e. it is they which impose on us the objective reality of the outer world. Where I would like to see beautiful flowers, my eyes make me see a pile of dung. I am forced to see what the objective world shows me by way of my eyes. It is like a nail from outside nailing my will.

The senses—given that they are sound and functioning normally—are wounds through which the objective world, without regard to our will, imposes itself on us.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

Hence, we create a representation of the external world in consciousness, seemingly against our will. Moral action requires a Not-I, in which there are objects in opposition to the I, and which pose a challenge to our projects. A weak will may deny aspects of the external world, and a strong will accepts the challenge.

The Intelligibility of the World

The head bears the “crown of thorns”, which is borne, in principle, by every person capable of objective thought — the “crown of thorns” being given to the human being since the beginning of human history. It is that subtle organ which is designated as the crown centre. This crown centre is a “natural gift”, as it were, to each human being and every normal person possesses it. The “thorns” of the crown centre function as the “nails” of objectivity, which give conscience to thought. It is thanks to them that thought has not become wholly emancipated and as arbitrary, for example, as the imagination is.

Thought as such is, in spite of all, the organ of truth, not of illusion.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

A process of mind is thinking only so far as it realizes the end of thinking, which is always to understand, that is, to see things within a system which renders them necessary.

BRAND BLANSHARD, *The Nature of Thought*

The senses show that things exist, but not *what* exists. In other words, the senses are open to the material condition of the world and the mind perceives essences. Initially it grasps the essences of individual things; this is so common that few ever become aware of it.

Living thought then sees things in relationship to each other, both synchronically and then diachronically, in larger and larger wholes, until ultimately it grasps the Absolute. This is spiritual vision and enables one to see the future.

Contrary to popular belief, no mere accumulation of facts can lead to an understanding of the world; only objective thought can do so. Facts do not create theories. This is most emphatically illustrated in the systems

created first by Newton and then by Einstein. Newton's theory, despite its effectiveness in predicting events in the external world, was replaced by Einstein's more comprehensive understanding. So if Newton's theory was NOT dictated by the facts, it must therefore be a free creation of the human spirit. The direction is one way: facts don't create the theory, but the theory creates the facts.

If thinking is the organ of truth, then how can we account for all the divergent differences in thought and opinions?

Evil Will

Imagine that the five organs of action—the limbs, including the head in its function as a limb—were to have analogous wounds, i.e. that the five currents of will of which they are an expression were to give access to an objective will which would be to personal desires what sense perceptions are to the play of fantasy.

VALENTIN TOMBERG

When functioning properly, the mind discerns the good and guides the will. Otherwise, the will controls the organ of thinking, using it merely as its instrument. Thinking, in this case, will then justify what the will desires; it sinks into subjectivity and fantasy, both opposed to its God-given function. Irrationality—that is, the denial of the Logos and cosmic order—and outbursts of anger are its bad fruits.

Those are the marks of an evil will.

Cause and Effect People tend to work backwards, from effects back to causes. As Hume demonstrated, however, this concept of cause does not arise through reason, but follows rather from a habitual way of looking at things. This is another way of saying the facts cannot create understanding, so knowledge of effects cannot dictate the knowledge of causes.

Nevertheless, through force of habit, men fantasize about causes in order to try to understand the world. Hence, in the past, the unknown substance phlogiston was assumed to create fire and spontaneous generation to explain maggots in garbage. In our time, there is no shortage of fanciful causes to explain events. One group will claim that it is white privilege or the patriarchy; another will blame Christianity or the Jews. Books are written to discover the hidden causes behind events. They are popular because men prefer easy answers, and it gives them the illusion of intelligence.

What is much more difficult, however, is to discern the effects, especially the long-term effects of causes. The effects of a policy embarked on today will usually not be experienced for a generation or more. It takes a rare intelligence to anticipate the future undesired consequences of what is done today.

Joseph de Maistre was not interested in the logic of facts, since, as he asserted, the Law of Gravity does not cause the rock to fall. Instead, he was concerned with the moral logic, or the moral cause of events. Science deals with facts yet can never answer the question, “Why?” Ultimately, therefore, it comes down to the moral will, which is the real cause. And an evil will results in evil effects.

A bullet or a gun is not the cause of murder, but rather the person who pulled the trigger.

The Spirit of Schism People take great pride in causing division through partisanship²¹. In the West, for example, there are repeated examples of schisms that broke up the spiritual unity of Europe. The illusion is that there are only two choices. Ultimately, another option comes into play, if for no other reason than to end the bloodshed of the warring factions. Even though everyone knows that “a house divided against itself cannot stand”, the will-to-greatness drives men to settle for half of the house.

²¹<https://gornahoor.net/?p=40>

Posted on 2019-05-12 by Cologero

* * *

Han Fei on 2019-05-16 at 23:28 said:

Hello Cologero, I wish to ask you this time about “black pills”? How does one address the creeping feeling that everything is getting worse and worse by the year, that the ability in people to perceive right from wrong is fading by the day, that all that is noble in man is being slowly replaced by spite, arbitrary vice and hatred. Is it true that the further one immerses into the world, the more of the evil, insufferable aspect of the reality is disclosed to him along the way – is this what the early Church fathers meant by their seemingly inexplicable denunciation to scientific means of enlightenment and pursuit of worldly goals? Whenever I encounter society around me, I do not perceive human beings as evil by nature and as such deserving to be hated, even as they utter the most soul crushing words, but they are misguided, driven into ruin by their leaders, engorged in madness by popular culture. I have to keep on reminding myself of this, otherwise I might fall into the same trap.

Cologero on 2019-05-17 at 17:00 said:

Han Fei, good points. I was going to respond, but it is turning into a blog post, hopefully this weekend.

Fallen Adam on 2019-05-17 at 19:17 said:

Can consciousness be described as being the Form of a being, when it is brought into actuality on the plane of creation, as in, that it's the fulfilling of a beings form and final cause in creation, when it lives according to it's nature? Using the terminology Mouravieff uses, is conscience the neutralizing principle between the active principle of the form, and the passive one of matter? Basically, i'm asking if consciousness is the flowing of the essence of a being in time.

Han Fei on 2019-05-17 at 21:28 said:

From the way I worded things, it would appear that some of the articles already posted here address this question. But I want to make it clear that I do not sense the world to be any way “evil” in itself. What is expressed here is a feeling of exasperation at the human element of the world, that is society, the creeping feeling of the falsity of men's motives, and of the painful realization of the lack of sincerity in societies and institutions which in principle should be the grounds of them.

This conundrum would be best served by an example. In one city the authorities want to build a large church. The cathedral will grandiose and beautiful in stark contrast to the

commercial and utilitarian architecture of this day. But it will be erected in the last park the city has, cutting its accessible area by around half. Naturally this draws huge protests from the city denizens for whom this park presents the last area of greenery in downtown. A rather ironic picture emerges – to save a grove of trees or build (or in the case I speak of, rebuild) a temple of God.

The fight that the citizens to put up against the, perfectly lawful I must add construction, isn't really about a couple of trees, but because we perfectly know that a church provides limited interest to the majority of the people who are not believers, where as a park represents a universally recognized practical value. From the perspective of one side, it is part of a state undertaken project to revitalize its traditional identity by sanctifying the historical center of the town and from the perspective of another, nothing but a cynical ploy to push state ideology of corruptocrats using "insane people who believe in fairy tales" (a statement repeated ad nauseam on social networks discussing this event) spending billions of dollars doing so. Both sides are right in their own way, and the reasons behind this interminable opposition is precisely the cause of my distress at the state of the world.

Of course this might all sound like a trivial reason to get worked up about. But let's not forget that a variation of this same tale left heads flying in other times and places.

Fallen Adam on 2019-05-19 at 06:15 said:

I've thought a little bit more about this question, and i can now express better what i meant. According to Thomism, every created thing must be created by an rational agent, being made towards a certain end, which is that created being final cause. If that being upon being created, already had his final cause "accomplished" so to speak, then is existence in creation wouldn't really be different from his essence or archetype. But if that created being had no causal or creative power of his own, only being acted on by his creator, then he wouldn't really be a distinct being, and there would be no reason to call him a whole, as any action done by it would need to be moved by his creator. Thereby, besides the form and matter which compose a being, there must be another principle to account for their living and acting on the realm of creation, which is consciousness and life. I don't know if there is any mistake in here, or if i have forgotten anything.

In regards to the question of knowledge, our intellect can grasp the form of things or their archetypes, there being an union between the subject and object, actualizing the potentialities of the intellect, when it comes to higher states of being, but when it comes to conscience, we can't really "have" the conscience of an angel, in the sense that we can't stop being a man, even if we actualize those potentialities of the intellect. So when it comes to conscience, it seems that the way for us to understand the life or conscience of other types of beings, is trough an analogy with forces and processes that happen within us, with this idea being given validity by the fact that man contains the macrocosm in the microcosm. Can it be said then, that while

knowledge of forms relates to the intellect, the understanding of conscience relates to the will? One can think here of the subject of magic, which is this control and directing of the forces of consciousness and life in creation, and which thereby is done by the will.

13.14 God and Life's Participation Trophy

Conversations about matters other than religion or art are always trivial and vain.

JORIS-KARL HUYSMANS

Life's Participation Trophy Aaron Rodgers, who is a major star in American football, was raised in an evangelical family. Lately, he has caused some consternation through his public admission that he cannot believe in a God who would send people to everlasting hell. Of course, no one should consult an athlete on theological issues. So a theologian like David Bentley Hart came to a different conclusion: he believes in God but not in hell, if that sounds better to you.

It solves the problem of hell, but brings in a more subtle issue. If heaven is everyone's ultimate destination, doesn't that trivialize life? In American youth sports, saturated with egalitarianism, in lieu of giving out trophies to the best teams, every player gets a "participation trophy". That seems to be the mindset of Rodgers and Hart²². They can only believe in a God who gives out participation trophies for having lived.

Sudden Conversion Someone recently asked me if I had a conversion or a deeper understanding of life after my recent surgery. As though I'm going to appear on a TV show with tales of discovering God or finally understanding the meaning of life. No, I don't trust anyone who has such a conversion, although, I suppose, one conversion would be acceptable.

²²<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5QbsvsxFyDo>

I've lived the life I want; I have no bucket list. I've gone on my adventures when I was young. I've met a lot of people, some rich and powerful, so I understand how they think and act. Not at all like you. Also many on different spiritual paths. In my work, I've learned about many commercial sectors: telecommunications, electronics, finance, manufacturing, banking, and so on.

Most readers here are young. Do what you want now, don't put it off.

True Esoterism Before you decide to embark on an esoteric way, consider seriously **Boris Mouravieff**'s warning:

The more man progresses on the Way, the more his feeling of being a stranger is intensified. Soon he will become boring; later still he will become unbearable, and finally, odious. That is why 'the prophet is despised in his country, among his close relations and in his own house.' That indication is precise and leaves no room for doubt. He who wants to start esoteric studies is invited to think it over twice, and weigh it all, before he rushes to cross the moat-threshold. We repeat that it will not be possible for him to return to exterior life and to find his place, his pleasures and his satisfaction there as in the past.

On the other hand, there are benefits and you will make new connections:

However, as well as the difficulties which are the first results of his evolution, such a man will receive comforting impressions, especially in his human relations. He will be surprised to perceive one day that certain faces which only yesterday appeared to him ordinary, today shine in his eyes with a bright beauty. It is because his sight, sharpened by esoteric work, has acquired the faculty of penetrating beyond the external crust. It is amongst these brighter beings that he will find his new friends. Their society will welcome

him as one of their own. He will be understood among them, and their community of common aims and interests will be a stimulus and a help for all.

Read this short poem *The Threshold*²³ by Turgenev.

Toxic Esoterism There are dangers in pursuing esoterism, especially without a guide. Valentin Tomberg warns against specific dangers, some of which are described below. The first danger of misunderstanding is relying solely on intellectual arguments without the mystical experience to validate it. The second danger is to desire wonderful experiences. The third is to confuse one's own stream of consciousness with higher knowledge. The fourth is to presume to have reached the highest possible state of being.

Misunderstanding: There is no authentic and sincere religious life without faith, hope and love; but there is no faith, hope and love without mystical experience or, what is the same thing, without grace. No intellectual argument can awaken faith; what it can do, at best, is to eliminate obstacles, misunderstandings and prejudices, and thus help to establish the state of interior silence necessary for the experience of the divine breath. But faith itself is the divine breath whose origin is found neither in logical reasoning, nor in aesthetic impression, nor in human moral action.

Spiritual drunkard: Passing on to mysticism which has not given birth to gnosis, magic and Hermetic philosophy —such a mysticism must, sooner or later, necessarily degenerate into spiritual enjoyment" or "intoxication". The mystic who wants only the experience of mystical states without understanding them, without drawing practical conclusions from them for life, and without wanting to be useful to others, who forgets everyone and everything in order to enjoy the mystical experience, can be compared to a spiritual drunkard.

²³https://novaonline.nvcc.edu/eli/evans/his241/Notes/Turgenev_Threshold.html

Charlatanism: This is why anyone who confuses lack of concentration with concentration without effort, and streams of simple mental associations with the vision without effort of correspondences by analogy, will necessarily become a charlatan.

Megalomania: It is not thought as such which allows the desire for personal greatness or the tendency towards megalomania, but rather the will which makes use of the head and which can take hold of thought and reduce it to the role of its instrument. Mystical megalomania, where one deifies the regulating centre of one's own being, one's ego, and where one sees the divine only within oneself and becomes blind to the divine above and outside of oneself. The "higher Self is then experienced as the supreme and unique Self of t h e world, although it is only higher in relation to the ordinary, empirical self, and it is far from the supreme and unique being... far from being God.

Esoteric Writing There are a few different understandings of what esoteric writing means.

Theosophical: New Age systems based on Theosophy assume that esoteric writing is the "real" teaching, so that the exoteric teaching can be ignored. The effect of this, in practice, is that the esoteric teaching just becomes a new dogma, replacing the exoteric dogma. That is the error of misunderstanding.

Leo Strauss: Strauss made the idea of esoteric writing acceptable in some academic circles. He understands it in a political sense. His premise is that philosophers faced dangers if they wrote too plainly about their views. Hence, they disguised their real intentions by writing in various ways (we can't go into those ways right now.) For example, Thomas Aquinas did not explicitly deny any exoteric teachings, but he wrote esoterically. His real views, seemingly quite different from those of simple believers, are in his philosophy.

Strauss subjected the writings of several philosophers to his theories.

There are some Straussian tricks even on Gornahoor, such as obscure allusions. They will probably die with me.

Rene Guenon: Guenon claimed that the exoteric teachings include rites, rituals, dogmas, and moral teaching. However, a valid exoteric teaching must be fertilised with a living esoteric tradition. Unlike the multiplicity of exoteric teachings, there is but one esoteric teaching common to them all. Nevertheless, the esoteric teaching does not exist in a vacuum so that the esoterist must also follow the exoteric teaching.

Valentin Tomberg: Tomberg regarded the esoteric teaching as a deeper understanding of the exoteric teaching. Hence, he does not reject the exoteric teaching, but expresses them in deeper, more subtle, ways.

Negative Critiques There is no end of the gnashing of teeth and the wringing of hands. There is criticism of everything, if you are impressed by such things. Few of those professional criticisers, however, are able to provide a convincing positive alternative.

Atheism Atheism is not a defensible intellectual position, rather it is a moral flaw.

Posted on 2020-01-23 by Cologero

* * *

Matt on 2020-01-25 at 19:27 said:

"The more man progresses on the Way, the more his feeling of being a stranger is intensified."

With the small progress I have made, my experience has confirmed this statement by Mouravieff. Yet, I can't turn back from the path, not only because I can't just forget/ignore what I have read – and experienced – but the benefits of the online group are clear.

Thank you for pointing to that poem by Turgenev.

As for Hart and universal salvation, I take what he has written and said on it seriously – but I'm not exactly convinced. He is essentially giving what most in the modern West want to

hear, just packaging it in theologically sophisticated language. There is a video on youtube of him speaking his case to an audience in an Episcopal church, rather than say, you know, a church within his claimed tradition (Eastern Orthodoxy); that is not a trivial fact. Of course, there are many in Orthodoxy – and the Catholic Church – that want to hear their universalist desires affirmed too, but it's telling that his platform is in an organization that ignores the teachings of the fathers, doctors, saints, and mystics of the Church and eats up whatever some contemporary theologian says on this or that. Hart, unlike his hosts, at least recognizes the importance of what the Fathers wrote, but the witnesses among them he has tried to marshal to his defense seem to be rather few. He will always assert there are "numerous", and sure, you can pose further questions and point at evidence clearly to the contrary, but you'll just get the (in)famous Hart response: sighs and face palms. With all that said, I'll still read his work and listen to him speak.

On the topic of an "eternal hell", it would be of value for both the universalists AND the super correct guardians of orthodoxy to read what Tomberg wrote on this matter in MOT. A David Bentley Hart would probably be open to reading the book; a Taylor Marshall would probably burn a copy if presented to him.

Michael on 2020-01-26 at 11:48 said:

Perhaps when Hart thinks on Hell there are problems from where his thoughts arise from in regards with Time, Eternity, and the Human Being that bring him to such a conclusion.

Thirteen years ago an excerpt from Strauss' *What is Political Philosophy* began a journey in a way that was not unlike the Parable of the Coach. The effect it had turned slowly into a path continues today, revisiting this will be interesting.

Nicodemus on 2021-01-23 at 15:40 said:

For what it's worth, Hart didn't choose the venue for the universalism lecture. It was part of a trip during which he also spoke on consciousness at the adjacent university. Both lectures were open to the public and attracted a wide array of audience members (academics, students, Christians of various stripes, a few esoterists, etc.)

Max on 2021-01-23 at 20:04 said:

It is said here that there is one common esoteric teaching. The exoteric teaching tends to change with time and place though. In the ideal case they are compatible, which brings situations like those described by Guenon and Tomberg, with clear channels of communication open between them. Public religious and political controversies compete about getting to define what the exoteric teaching should be. When it changes quickly or suddenly, the connection is more difficult to maintain and becomes irregular. It is easy to see how "also following the exoteric teaching", as Guénon says, might not really be a choice left to the individual at all. Having the choice would be an anomaly, perhaps afforded in periods of collapse. The question naturally

presents itself, especially in turbulent times, exactly what the exoteric teaching says, or even if it will stay the same from one day to the next. If not, it is not as if the esoterist would necessarily be eager to madly pursue every new opinion of the day, in an effort to “express it in a deeper subtler way”. The returns are diminishing. Tomberg seems to write for a social situation which does not presently exist, even if that does not stop us from learning what we can from him. If a once exoteric teaching becomes unlawful or unsupported in the worldly environment, it can still be reabsorbed into the esoteric current.

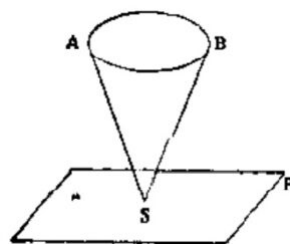
Matt points out that the theologian Hart “is essentially giving what most in the modern West want to hear, just packaging it in theologically sophisticated language.” This phenomenon is of course nothing new, but has repeated itself many times before. The issue resembles that faced by the Amish, basically arresting progress at a certain point, which necessitates a measure of worldly power to do the same.

13.15 Thanks for the Memories

You must know, Sancho, if you do not know it already, that with lovers, the external actions and movements, revealed when the topic of their love arises, are reliable messengers bringing the news of what transpires deep in their souls.

DON QUIXOTE

Memory is not mere reminiscing, but is a progress from the past to the present. In Bergson’s diagram, the base AB of the inverted cone is the memory. The Self S lives and acts on the plane P, bearing the weight of the past. If you forget your past, you will be driven by unconscious forces. Memory is real and actual only in the present, to the extent that it shapes our perception and understanding of the world.



Plato famously claimed that knowing is remembering. In particular, we have forgotten the world of essences, that is, the ideas in the mind

of God; Hence, knowing an essence is just a recall of that which was forgotten. A fortiori, knowledge of the Self, our essence, and our destiny must also be a form of remembering. But memory of the forms takes place in stages. We understand more as we rise up through the states of being. Boris Mouravieff explains:

Memory is a direct function of the being of the individual. The higher the level of being, the better the memory and the greater its capacity to contain. Loss of memory, which causes the notion of the name and the ensemble that is attached to it to be forgotten, makes a madman out of a normal man: the sense of continuity is no longer present.

The esoteric teaching is that forgetting is analogous to sleeping and to death, as they manifest on different levels. Valentin Tomberg makes it clear:

For our whole experience (outer and inner) forgetting, sleep and death are three manifestations of the same thing —namely the “thing” which effects disappearance. It is said that sleep is the younger brother of death. It is necessary to add: forgetting is the brother of sleep. ... One forgets, one goes to sleep, and one dies. One remembers, one awakes, and one is born. Remembering is to forgetting as awakening is to falling asleep, and awakening is to sleeping as birth is to death. ... Natural forgetting reduces man to animality; natural sleep reduces him to vegetality; and natural death reduces him to minerality

LETTER XIII, *Death*

Yet remembering is not simply bringing an image of the past into the present, since there are levels of depth to memory. You can remember solely with the intellect, with feelings, or even with the will. The highest is moral memory, based on love and all that accompanies it. Tomberg emphasizes the importance of the latter:

It is love which is at work in moral memory when it recalls things from the past. Here it is admiration, respect, friendship, gratitude, affection and a thousand other things which have deeply moved you, which render things from the past unforgettable, i.e., evocable at each instant. The more one has loved, the more one remembers through moral memory.

Moral memory — which can comprehend everything without exception — is all the more effective the less one is morally indifferent. Indifference, a lack of moral interest, is the fundamental cause of the lapse of memory which often takes place in old age. The less one is indifferent, the more one remembers of the past and the more one is capable of learning new things.

Moral Memory Moral memory predominates in old age. The young depend on mechanical memories, which arise spontaneously; this faculty becomes feebler with age. Hence, it must be replaced with intellectual or logical memory. This requires an active effort to remember things. People who neglected to learn how to make intellectual efforts in their youth, will become forgetful as they age. Tomberg goes even further, explaining that moral efforts are likewise necessary:

People who are able to and who know how to give everything a moral worth and to see a moral sense in everything will not forget anything: they will have a normal, if not excellent, memory to a very advanced age.

Moral memory — which can comprehend everything without exception — is all the more effective the less one is morally indifferent. Indifference, a lack of moral interest, is the fundamental cause of the lapse of memory which often takes place in old age. The less one is indifferent, the more one remembers of the past and the more one is capable of learning new things.

Love and Work

Love and work are the cornerstones of our humanness.

SIGMUND FREUD

To begin the experiment of “remembering”, one must first decide what to remember. If love and work are the cornerstones of our humanness, that is the place to start. When one loves, one cannot be morally indifferent. And our acts — our work, our projects, our adventures — only have significance when they are moral acts. So we turn to our favorite Knight Errant, Don Quixote, who had expertise in both realms, as a model.

Love was constantly on his mind, especially for the one special lady, who was the driving force, the creative force, for his life. He treated women with chivalry. Against men, he was prepared to do battle against iniquity and to protect the weak and helpless. He brandished his cold weapons to make a point. He did not carry around a copy of the constitution nor did he propose to reason with his enemies to make his point. That is why his deeds have been recorded and are remembered.

Pointillism Most people live their lives as an accumulation of points, one after the other. Events in their lives are unrelated to each other since points are unrelated. They are stuck in time and not in simultaneity. If you desire to live your life as a work of art, whom would you commission to paint it for you?

The realist will plan it in advance: he will make a detailed drawing, calculate the perspectives, choose the colours, lighting, etc. The end result is known even before the artist begins. The unsophisticated viewer prefers realism because it requires little or no effort from him.

The better choice is pointillism. As you live your life day to day, it is difficult to grasp it as a whole. Instead, your life appears to you as a series

of points of various colours, almost at random, and it may not make sense as a whole at any given time. However, as the points are painted at various spots on the canvas, gradually the full image of your life can be discerned. But this takes more effort — and patience — by the viewer to wait for the points to begin to make sense.

So that is how to start, each memory is a point or set of related points. Over time, as they appear on the canvas of your life, the whole picture of your life should come into view.

Life is Short They say that life is too short. Your memories should be relevant; they should be predominantly moral memories. If your fondest memories are watching TV or hanging out at the pub, then your life is actually too long and you are trying to fill it up with trivialities.

To develop a moral memory, you must live by principles and your acts must have a point. This should be obvious, for the alternative is live a life that is unprincipled and pointless.

Dislikes, Fears, and Accidents The first step in deep remembering is to ascertain one's earliest likes, talents, and proclivities. This exercise is preferable to most people because it seems pleasant. However, one can gain more self-knowledge by remembering the things you did not like. What events transpired in your life that you did not desire? Can you see what role, however subtle, you may have played in bringing it about?

This applies also to what you most fear. How has the avoidance of this fear shaped your life?

Another consideration is to remember everything that occurred, seemingly by chance or accident. From the human point of view, that may seem to be the case. But can you dig even deeper to see if there is a state of being from which you willed those events.

Meditations like these will often bear great fruit.

Encounters with Others Your life is a world line in the cosmos. And everyone else has his own world line. Mathematically understood, a Point is where two Lines intersect. In other words, the points don't define the line, but the line defines the points that constitute it.

So when I see a Point, I don't ask what it means in isolation. Instead, I look for the two lines. Of course, you are one of them, and the other is a person you encounter. Why are two distinctly different world lines meeting at that point? From that perspective, you can experience the event in its wholeness, all at once, simultaneously.

There are natural reasons, of course, for the intersection of lines: family, jobs, food, love, revenge, and so on, i.e., all the things involved in human life. But that does not exhaust all the possibilities.

Nevertheless, some lines meet for no human purpose at all, yet you can't dismiss it as pointless because the Point is there and is unavoidable. You may choose to look away. That is possible because it is so ethereal. But that decision has its danger, since you may miss one of the most important moments in your life.

How many of those life events have you forgotten? and you may even be glad they are forgotten. How few of those memories will endure through eternity? It is imperative to know what to forget and what to remember.

Why have some people made an impact on your life and others not so much?

Things forgotten You will find memories best left forgotten. Something that had seemed so important and so impactful at that time, appears now in retrospect to be so distant, so far from your current level of being, that it may as well have been the memory of a different person. It may remain as an intellectual memory, but it no longer has any emotional impact, and it most certainly does not induce you to act.

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Michael M on 2021-01-31 at 10:26 said:

"They say that life is too short. Your memories should be relevant; they should be predominantly moral memories. If your fondest memories are watching TV or hanging out at the pub, then your life is actually too long and you are trying to fill it up with trivialities. To develop a moral memory, you must live by principles and your acts must have a point. This should be obvious, for the alternative is live a life that is unprincipled and pointless." You describe exactly my experience lately when I hear someone say "killing time". Internally I watch my cage intensely when I see it in others and am watchful for it in my own domain. Quite insidious a phrase especially when understanding time as part of the compound nature of experience, life, and the unfolding of ideas. Don't want to fall asleep in a dream and dream our life away... Has anyone found it more difficult at times to remember "facts" (academic / intellectual) memories when focusing on moral memory intensely? Or perhaps there is some type of learning curve or displacement of useless knowledge for rewriting of moral orientation?

13.16 Midnight Meze

Some midnight snacks for the contemplative.

Knowledge of the Heart

This direct perception of the truth, this intellectual and supra-rational intuition, a notion which the moderns seem to have lost, is truly "knowledge of the heart", to use an expression which is frequently encountered in Eastern doctrines. This knowledge is in itself something incommunicable; you have to have "realized" it, at least to some extent, to know what it really is; and all that can be said about it gives only a more or less approximate and inadequate idea. Above all, it would be a mistake to believe that one can actually understand what the kind of knowledge in question is when one is content to consider it "philosophically", that is to say from



the outside, because we must never forget that philosophy is only a purely human or rational knowledge, as is all “profane knowledge”.

RENE GUENON, *Fundamental
Symbols*

When I was younger, I preferred philosophy of the grand type, like Spinoza or Francis Bradley. By a process of reasoning, beginning with the manifest world, they reached up to God (Spinoza) or the Absolute (Bradley). For the former, God is the sole Substance and, for the latter, the Absolute, the sole reality. Individuals therefore are less real.

On the level of profane philosophy, Ibn Arabi can be understood as the same type. For him God is Being, so beings are somehow less real. But Ibn Arabi is not doing philosophy but rather something far more profound. Following the Wisdom of Adam, there is the Manifest world. However, God Himself is Hidden, unlike the God of the philosophers. The True God can only be known through “*contemplation which is far from the results of thought*”. God reveals Himself as He sees fit and it is hubris to try to reach him solely through thought.

Anima Dreams Few men allow the Anima to roam freely. Rather they have distorted images of women in their mind. When they meet a real woman, they get confused. They say they can’t figure her out, but that just means she does not fit into one of their categories. They don’t know how to let go.

The quality of my Anima dreams has altered over the years. In one of the first that I recall, I was in the audience of a “Reality” show. The female hostess called me down to the stage, presumably to reveal reality to me; at that point I awakened.

In the next I dreamt of a woman asleep in a shallow creek, but water barely covering her. Clearly, I was awake in the scene, but the Anima was

unconscious. The water is the symbol for the soul.

More recently, under the influence of another party, the Anima has been becoming more dominant. Just last week, I dreamed that I was asleep; I knew I was asleep although I had awareness. That sounds like being in the causal state.

Seated on a sofa a few meters away was a female figure, who seemed a little stiff. Some unseen person was asking her questions. When I realized that this Anima was taking over my soul and was speaking for me, I panicked and woke up screaming.

This path is not easy and can be threatening; otherwise it would be more common. The final dream will be the Alchemical Marriage.

World Cycles

The Krita Yuga Golden Age may well have been on “earth”, but that does not necessarily imply that the earth itself was then what it is now; one could even wonder if it is not the changes of conditions which have occurred at certain times in the terrestrial world which prevent finding, by any research, truly “primitive” vestiges. — I would say gladly also that “on earth” does not exactly mean “on this earth”; the Islamic tradition speaks very clearly of the “seven lands”, manifested successively or alternately, and which are moreover the same thing as the seven dvipas of the Hindu tradition. Of course, all this does not prevent considerations of origins in a more universal sense; but they must always be able, by appropriate transposition, to be applied at all levels, including that represented by the history of earthly humanity.

RENE GUENON, *Letter to L C d'Amiens (22 April 1936)*

Guenon provided precious few concrete details on the great cycles of Kalpas, Manvataras, and Yugas. In the letter above, he makes clear that

these cannot be understood historically, archaeologically, nor scientifically. Rather they are states of being, and the “Earth” — the planet we inhabit — will differ from the Earth on another plane.

These cycles repeat each other. Eternal Lovers, or Polar Beings, chase each other across cycles or states of being. Situations and conditions repeat from one age to the next, with small variations. It is frustrating; it is exhilarating.

They may have to spend time wandering in a forest before they find each other. By then, karmic choices may weigh heavy on them, making their encounter all that much more difficult.

Devious Professions Some professions are inherently immoral because they are unnatural. For example, money is the medium of exchange. But to make it the product, as do the moneylenders, is what makes it unnatural.

Similarly, language is the medium of communications. But journalists, and similar professions, make it the product. Thus a writer may get paid by the word or by the size of the audience he attracts. That makes it immoral. True journalists, therefore, should be paid on the quality of their work, but there are very few of them.

The purpose of Law is to mediate between two disputants, not to take advantage of either party. There was a creepy skinny classmate from Tufts, who told me he wanted to become a divorce attorney because he thought he could get laid at a time when the women were feeling vulnerable. The next time, in a moment of weakness, you hold out any hope for the human race, keep that image in mind.

Posted on 2021-04-21 by Cologero

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Santiago on 2021-04-26 at 21:01 said:

“Seated on a sofa a few meters away was a female figure, who seemed a little stiff. Some unseen person was asking her questions. When I realized that this Anima was taking over my soul and was speaking for me, I panicked and woke up screaming.”

Why does this happen? It seems that the Anima, like the Absinthe green fairy, ‘wants your soul’. It ceases to be a figure worth romanticizing or lusting after, precisely at the moment when it becomes terrifying and domineering.

I think it tries to get us to confront certain things. I don’t know why it does this, but I’ve noticed certain patterns, certain strategies it likes to employ for me. Yet, despite initially provoking me to lust, she will rarely if ever grant me control. I think she controls a good amount of the dream itself, to be honest. This may be why she got sloppy when you started to become lucid; her grasp on you and on the dream was rapidly slipping. Mine does similar things; the pretext of agency is gone and she fights for control and saps me of everything.

Cologero on 2021-04-29 at 07:52 said:

Or else the Anima is your soul and She is demanding her rightful place in it.

13.17 The Two Hands of God

God brought the universe into existence as a Visible world and an Unseen world so that we might know the Hidden by the Unseen and the Manifest by the Visible. He described Himself with pleasure and wrath, and so He brought the world into existence as a place of fear and hope so we fear His wrath and hope for His pleasure. He described Himself with majesty and beauty, so He brought the universe into existence with awe and intimacy. It is the same for all that is connected with Him, may He be exalted, and by which He calls Himself. He designates these pairs of attributes by the two hands which He held out in the creation of the Perfect Man.

IBN ARABI, *The Wisdom of Adam*

Visible world includes the conditions of Manifestation: form and matter, space and time, life or consciousness. All the forms of things are ideas in the Divine Mind. Matter is pure possibility since matter cannot change unless acted upon by an outside force. In terms of physics, the totality of the possibilities of manifestation, i.e., the “universe”, is like a universal Schrodinger’s cat: it is neither dead nor alive until infused with form. That is vertical causation.



Since mathematics is the divided line between the unmanifest and the manifest, this can be understood by set theory. The things of the world are sets of certain ideas. Since there cannot be an actual infinity, the things of the world are always countable. However, in the unmanifest Divine Mind, which includes all possibilities of manifestation, there are increasingly higher and higher levels of order.

In our time bound state, we can only experience the order of the universe as an unfolding in space and time. That is why we usually miss the significance of events and things in the flow of time. As **Rene Guenon** explains in *Symbolism of the Cross*, everything happens out of necessity and according to higher principles. For example, he writes:

the laws of a lower domain can always be taken to symbolize realities of a higher order, wherein resides their own profoundest cause; which is at once their principle and their end.

By the **Law of Correspondence**, everything in the world derives from, and therefore also expresses, a higher metaphysical principle. So the world is the expression of ever higher principles. Ultimately, all of manifestation is the expression of the complete idea in the divine Mind, from the beginning of the world until the end of time. At every instant, then, God is forming the world from the ideas and matter. One can develop the vision to see that the entire cosmos is a theophany, the manifestation of God’s Will in space and time. The world is thus in God’s hands,

Divine Providence is active everywhere, even during what seems to be the darkest hours and times of tribulation.

Just as there is no set of all ordered sets, God is beyond Being and Time. He remains Unseen since we cannot know him in his Essence, such as we are.

The Perfect Man God created man as the perfect state of individual manifestation. The animals have as gross body and the subtle states of sensing and feeling. The angels lack sensory apparatus, so they cannot experience manifestation through the senses. Moreover, they do not have access to all of God's Names and Attributes, but just those appropriate to them.

However, man has the thinking functions in addition to the gross and subtle states of the animals. Unlike the angels, he has in potential the ability to understand God's Names. Ibn Arabi expresses it like this:

God is your mirror in which you see yourself, and you are His mirror in which He sees His Names. His Names are not other than Himself.

IBN ARABI, *The Wisdom of Seth*

Everyone comes into the world with a defined essence which includes talents and other qualities. There are no accidents, so even the time and place of our births are necessary. But essence is insufficient. Our task is to actualize our possibilities, based upon our essential features and the opportunities that present themselves.

To some, that may seem unjust, although God is not unjust. Our specific accomplishments in the world are individualized and cannot, and should not, be compared to others.

Hope and Fear God brings us blessings but He also brings us tribulations. They each require a different response. We need to feel gratitude for the good time, but patience and acceptance for the bad times. On the contrary, we usually take the good times for granted, as if they are normative rather than the exception.

In times of tribulations, the temptation is to recite platitudes similar to this: “all things work for the good.” Another response is a cynical pessimism common to the cultured sophistication of shallow men. Rather, tribulations warn us not to take comfort in the things and pleasures of the world; nor should we be embittered by the world.

Soren Kierkegaard develops this theme in the *Edifying Discourses*. He says that obedience to God is the one thing needful. That requires faith in God’s authority over the world and in His Providence.

Posted on 2021-05-06 by Cologero

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Auld Wat on 2021-05-07 at 17:37 said:

God has created me to do Him some definite service. He has committed some work to me which He has not committed to another. I have my mission. I may never know it in this life, but I shall be told it in the next. I am a link in a chain, a bond of connection between persons. He has not created me for naught. I shall do good; I shall do His work. I shall be an angel of peace, a preacher of truth in my own place, while not intending it if I do but keep His commandments. Therefore, I will trust Him, whatever I am, I can never be thrown away. If I am in sickness, my sickness may serve Him, in perplexity, my perplexity may serve Him. If I am in sorrow, my sorrow may serve Him. He does nothing in vain. He knows what He is about. He may take away my friends. He may throw me among strangers. He may make me feel desolate, make my spirits sink, hide my future from me. Still, He knows what He is about.

Saint John Henry Newman

Angolmois on 2021-05-13 at 03:08 said:

What about theodicy, as if the Absolute would not contain also evil? I can’t understand how someone could portray God as “wholly Good” etc. as if God wouldn’t be above the questions

of good and evil which belong to the order of created beings. The greatest theological error of the Abrahamic faiths springing from Mazdaism has been to posit two insoluble principles – one wholly good, one wholly evil – as the foundation of “monotheism”. Satan is nothing but the other face / hand of God, who also brings tribulations, as in Job.

13.18 Where Truth Will Dwell

Possessing these new faculties, freed from excessive labour, the new man will have the power to organize life in the new society and, with the help of his clairvoyance, he will establish a new order where *truth will dwell*.

In the brief monograph, *The Problem of the New Man*, **Boris Mouravieff** describes the historical conditions leading up to the issues of today and the necessary solution that will usher in the next Golden Age, ending the current cycle. Mouravieff claims to be revealing the esoteric teachings of the Eastern Churches, which have not been made public until now.

Four moments of the Spirit He identifies four dominant trends, which we are calling the moments of the Spirit since they are the historical manifestation of a single idea. These are: Philosophy, Religion, Science, and Art.

Philosophy Philosophy is based on the concept which is both universal as idea and concrete as it is expressed as the judgment of particular states of affairs. This judgment is the unity of subject and object, or essence and existence.

Religion Religion denies that reality can be fully expressed conceptually. For the religious consciousness, the concept and the thing, essence and existence are no longer statically givens, as objects of

contemplation. The ethical will connects the ideal to existence, which it actualizes.

Science Science, the child of nominalism, then reduces the concept to the practical. Bracketing out any reference to the transcendental, it is autonomous with respect to the ethical. The will is replaced with volition, or desire, whose aim is merely practical. Ideas, concepts, and theories are tools to manipulate the world for practical ends.

Art Art is knowledge of the individual, not the universal concept of philosophy. Its method is intuition, a direct, unmediated, unity. But intuition is real only to the extent to which it is expressed. For intuition, the ethical is the aesthetic.

Historical Relationships Mouravieff does not begin his story with the unity of Spirit and virtues of the archaic Greek and Roman kingdoms, but with the philosophical era that came to dominate in the period of the Empire. Besides the four main streams of Platonism, Aristotelianism, Stoicism, and Epicureanism, there were many minor movements that sprang up such as Cynicism, Skepticism and so on. Plotinus marks the end of philosophical moment and his students Boethius and Augustine mark the transition to the religious moment.

After the ideal of the contemplative thinker, the knight became the new elite. The knight was distinguished by his physical strength and martial prowess²⁴. The knight acted according to the ethical will of Christendom.

Military technology and the rise of nominalism replaced the power of the knight and the authority of the Church. The “intellectual” class became the new elite. Exploration, discovery, and economic activity began to dominate. No longer bound by the ethical precepts of the Medieval

²⁴<https://gornahoor.net/?p=277>

period, money become the new power. Thus an economic and ideological superstructure was imposed over brute reality, becoming in its place a sort of “second reality”. The manipulation of this second reality is now the dominant interest of the elite, despite the many irruptions of first reality that upset its most ambitious schemes.

In our time, we see that money has changed from the medium of exchange to a commodity itself. It is no longer the industrialist who generates wealth, but rather the financier who knows how to manipulate money instruments. This is almost a third reality, hence it cannot endure in its present form. The question is whether this collapse will be gentle or chaotic, and whether something higher can replace it.

The Age of the Spirit Art includes the three preceding moments without deforming them. Just as the gadgets of the technocrat of today would appear as the product of supermen to a Knight, so the coming age of the Spirit will require a new elite of supermen. The principle faculty of the elite man to come “will be the capacity to distinguish the real from the false, the truth from lies, spontaneously, without evidence or other support,” that is, a direct intuitive understanding. The problem today is that man is unable to distinguish truth from lies; all his leaders lie to him, whether deliberately or *de facto* since they themselves don’t even know what is true.

A New Beginning

Looking for and hasting unto the coming of the day of the Lord, by which the heavens being on fire shall be dissolved, and the elements shall melt with the burning heat? But we look for new heavens and a new earth according to his promises, in which justice dwelleth.

Just as the Knight dominated by muscular power and the technocrat by intellectual power, the new man will lead through the power of Spirit, which will give him new abilities. First of all, Mouravieff makes clear that Jesus made the distinction between his disciples and the “world”, those on the “outside”. He prayed to God not for all men, but for those “whom thou hast given me.” The incarnation of the Logos is a process that unfolds over time. It is the task of the disciples to facilitate that unfolding through their own efforts. Mouravieff writes:

Between hope and realization there is still a path to travel. This distance must be covered by ourselves, by our own efforts. Nothing is given free. Everything must be paid for.

Interestingly, Mouravieff claims that the natural man will continue to lie as long as his thoughts are private. Hence, the ability to read minds will be a faculty of the superman. To gain these faculties, the new elite must be “twice born”. While the current age seeks the transformation of nature through technology, the new age will transform man through a Positivism of the Spirit²⁵.

The Projection of the I Mouravieff writes that the Eastern Orthodox esoteric tradition

teaches that all civilization is only the projection on the outside world of the consciousness of the I of the elite man.

Thus, the elite of any era are able to impose their world view on the masses. In the past, this has not been the real I, but “unstable, composite and multiple” counterfeits, in conflict with each other. The new elite man will have consciousness of the “real I”. What had been privation previously will now come under the dominion of this elite.

²⁵<https://gornahoor.net/?p=1189>

Thus the edifice of the future civilization will no longer be built by him on “sand”, but on the “rock” of his self-consciousness, on the divine spark.

References:

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Western Philosophy Vol 5, A. Robert Caponigri

Originally appeared in the Meditations on the Tarot blog on 9 April

2011

Posted on 2023-02-07 by Cologero

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Ismo Meinander on 2011-04-09 at 05:58 said:

This sounds like ‘a true new age teaching’.

If I remember correctly, Evola spoke about this coming age and the real superman – or the New Man – in ‘Ride the Tiger’ and in reference to the ‘third age of the Spirit’ which is a conception made by Joachim de Flore. I think that in these weird transitional times there are many signs of this happening and the ‘new age fallacies’ are a somewhat naive and many times dangerous symptoms of this: new faculties are developing and they are in many cases spontaneous, and in the general climate of our times they lead especially young people without effective means of understanding and protection of tradition to madness; since the new faculties are not given proper spiritual orientation they lead up easily to the most distressing developments of psychism.

13.19 Nostalgia and Death

What a shame that one must give up life. I was finally getting used to it.

CHARLES PEGUY

If you do not meditate on death upon waking in the morning, your entire morning will be wasted; if you do not meditate on death at noon, your entire afternoon will be wasted; and if you do not meditate on death in the evening, your entire night will be wasted.

Tibetan Buddhist teaching

Thanks for the Memories

The truth is that memory does not consist in a regression from the present to the past, but on the contrary in a progress from the past to the present.

HENRI BERGSON, *Matter and Memory*

I am letting go of memories. Why do the oddest events stand out? Seemingly insignificant past events create vivid memories. What was so important 20 or 30 years ago is meaningless today. Do I want that an ancient event risks salvation?

The future is a horizon that we cannot see beyond. We approach it. Younger men look forward to it. I see death, an ugly death. Lying in a hospital bed, hooked up to tubes, a ventilator, and electronic equipment. First the kidneys fail, then gradually other organs, one by one, until the end.

Nowadays, death is expected to be safe, legal, and rare. It is not morbid to envision one's death, but rather it enhances life and offers perspective.

Maya

If the soul's mystical union with God is forgetting of the phenomenal world and recall of God, death is simultaneously the call from above and forgetting below.

VALENTIN TOMBERG, *Meditations on the Tarot*

Maya is the world of phenomena. It is called “illusion”, not because our senses are mistaken, but because we assume it is the real world. That is because Maya is persistent and forcibly intrudes herself into our consciousness. Sights, sounds, smells enter our minds uninvited. Are they good, evil, neutral? Do they evoke fear, hunger, desire, lust? They force a decision: Attack, retreat, hide, ignore, or perhaps enjoy.

Despite efforts at detachment, I find I am still deeply in love with Maya. The world of sensory experience can also be beautiful, delightful, enticing. Children are thrilled with each new experience, and want to repeat it. But at what point does repetition no longer produce the desired effect? Or, more likely, we will eventually learn to see that our judgments of this world were all too often far off the mark.

If you want to detach from Maya, then try Freddie’s suggestion:

You go to women? Do not forget the whip!

The Call from Above Since the world of Maya is so dominant, it is impossible to ignore. In contrast, the Call from God may be faint and is often missed. The first task is to silence the mind, which is difficult given our attachment to Maya. Even if there has been some success in that task, we are then faced with a more subtle problem. The inner life is still in a turmoil, not from Maya, but is self-caused. There are negative emotions, useless fantasies, unfulfilled desires, and so on. These need to be overcome, in turn. Tomberg explains what happens next:

We must renounce the joy of living in the richly filled images that arise before one’s inner vision and obliterate the imaginations that have been reached. In their place darkness and emptiness must be created. And in this darkness and emptiness one must immerse oneself with one’s entire soul.

That does not sound so great; moreover, it does not feel so great. Tomberg goes on:

The soul feels itself in complete and absolute inner loneliness. One experiences oneself as if forsaken by all human beings and by the gods.

This emptying process needs to continue, until the soul learns to hear in the spiritual world. This process actually describes the traditional states of purification, illumination, and union.

Inner life is opaque **St. Augustine** asserts that the truth is found in our interiority. Unfortunately, he also shows that our inner life is opaque to us; and *a fortiori*, the inner lives of others are likewise opaque. Nevertheless, it is all too common in public discourse to claim to know and understand the hidden motivations of others, an easy way to dismiss them and their ideas.

In our particular judgment, our hidden motivations will be revealed to us; only then, will we fully understand God's justice. In the general judgment of all, the inner lives of all people will be revealed. Once, God's justice will be full known and accepted. In our current situation, it is difficult to see God's justice, which explains the depth of the resistance to this understanding.

Resurrection Body There are four qualities of the resurrection body:

1. **Impassibility:** It does not suffer pain or death
2. **Clarity:** It is free from deformity and is filled with beauty and radiance
3. **Agility:** The body obeys the soul and can instantly travel from place to place

4. **Subtlety:** It has a spiritual nature and mastery over the physical. E.g., it can pass through walls.

One of the most important insights of **Wolfgang Smith** is the distinction between the corporeal plane and the physical plane. Hence, the resurrection body is *corporeal*, i.e., it has the qualities and appearance of a body, but no longer *physical*, which is associated with quantity.

Gethsemane Jesus finds himself alone at Gethsemane, lost in God's silence on the one hand, and the sleeping disciples on the other. His friends, one by one, prefer sleep to consciousness. And in the most important spiritual decisions, God is silent. That is because a man must choose freely to follow God's will, without coercion.

Washing the Feet In *Inner Development*, Tomberg describes the effect of meditation:

The general effect of meditation consists in the fact that what is spiritual in a human being descends. That is, the superconsciousness – the higher I – descends in the human personality, and the angel sends down the stream of illumination in the form of “washing the feet”.

This is understood as the spiritualization of the lowest parts of the human. The incarnation, the descent into hell, demonstrate that. This can be contrasted with older systems, such as Vedanta, Neoplatonism, or Gnosticism which sought instead to escape the material world and merge into the Absolute.

This descent of the superconscious is the opposite of the ascent of Kundalini.

Rene Guenon describes deliverance this way:

If the passage to certain superior states in some way constitutes a progress toward 'Deliverance' relative to the state taken as a point of departure, it must nevertheless be understood that when the latter is realized, it will always imply a discontinuity with respect to the immediately preceding state of the being that achieves it, and that the discontinuity will be neither more nor less profound whatever this state may be, since in all cases there is between the 'undelivered' and the 'delivered' being no relation such as exists between the different conditioned states.

Yet there is a higher state than annihilation. While not denying the experiences of the yogis, Tomberg describes an even deeper understanding of union with God:

Union with the Divine is not the absorption of being by Divine Being, but rather the experience of the breath of Divine Love, the illumination by Divine Love, and the warmth of Divine Love. The soul which receives this undergoes such a miraculous experience that it cries. In this mystical experience fire meets with FIRE, Then nothing is extinguished in the human personality but, on the contrary, everything is set ablaze. This is the experience of "legitimate twofoldness" or **the union of two separate substances in one sole essence**. The substances remain separate as long as they are bereft of that which is the most precious in all existence: free alliance in love.

This union exemplifies God as Being and God as Love. The conditioned states are not annihilated but retain their substance, while at the same time, the essence of the mystic encounters God's essence. Their wills unite:

The work of the Redemption, being that of love, requires the perfect union in love of two wills, distinct and free —divine will and human will.

The person does not become extinct; rather he becomes fully and truly what he is, as conceived eternally in the Mind of God.

Posted on 2020-04-12 by Cologero

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Balder on 2022-04-12 at 17:39 said:

This came as a good synchronicity, since today I heard about the death of my ex-wife's father, who was for long very close to me. I remember thinking again, that the last thing I how I want to die is in a hospital, in shitty diapers, into some terminal illness. Maybe it's that Mars energy I felt today so strongly, but I started to envision more preferably a violent death in battle than the fate of a sickly old man whose quality of life has deteriorated into terminal state God knows for how long; the worst part is that it is usually relatives who wish to keep the elderly as medicated zombies for years. What is this other than an ill response to the fear of death caused by the society who so dearly venerates so called "life" in all aspects and wishes to be done away with the reality and sanctity of death by all possible means.

Pekka Ervast also wrote in Finland that the task of the initiate is to "build" an immortal corporeal body; the part where you described Smith's categorization of the physical and corporeal world struck me, and I think now finally understand what Ervast was speaking about. I recently read again some of Smith's work, and I quite like his insights of science in light of traditional metaphysics.

For long time the idea of a "immortal corporeal body" sounded ridiculous, since I didn't quite understand this difference between the physical and corporeal universe. Maybe we can understand this also by the reference to the so called etheric or energetic body, the "real corporeal body". In the Finnish epic Kalevala there is the so called "kirjokannel" which I think is a reference to the five (or seven, a kannel is usually five-stringed) principles and elements making up the etheric body of man and also the so called chakras. Anyway, I think what the old Finns meant by the Kirjokannel is the same thing as the resurrection body of the Christian tradition.

13.20 Sympathy for the Devil

I will no longer talk much with you, for the ruler of this world is coming. He has no power over me.

JOHN 14:30

Council of Evil **Mary of Agreda** had a vision of the coming of the Prince of this World. The world is depraved, that is, good and evil are not easily separated. Science is concerned with events that are immediately verifiable. Humans seldom think further than a five or ten year plan. However, the Prince plans over the course of centuries, longer than what science can process. People act from motives and reasons of which they are seldom fully conscious. Their views of world events are no deeper than a script for a Batman movie, replete with good guys and evil villains. Solange Hertz describes Mary's vision:



Whoever thinks history “just happens” needs to read the *Mystical City of God* for proper perspective. Called on for their opinions after the Crucifixion, the higher ranking demons agreed that it would be impossible to reverse the Redemption now accomplished by Christ, but they could labor to prevent the application of its fruits. They advised that, “in accordance with the new order of assistance and favor established by God for the salvation of men, they should seek new ways of hindering and preventing the work of God by deceits and temptations so much the greater.” Sinful men’s lives are too short, their wills too weak, their thinking too limited. Bound to bodies shackled by recurring hunger and fatigue, they are incapable of an effort which must be sustained at white heat literally through centuries.

SOLANGE HERTZ

Lust for Power

The devil took him to a very high mountain, and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory; and he said to him:

All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me.
Then Jesus said to him: Begone, Satan! for it is written, "You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve."

MATTHEW 4:8–10

This third temptation in the desert was resisted by Christ, but is too tempting for most in power today. The secret power of the temptation is that it denies that God is the creator. The corollary is that man is the creator of the world. Just as the Logos speaks the world into existence, man tries to create his own world by the redefinition of words.

Virgil and Dante Note this painting of Virgil and Dante visiting hell by Gustav Courtois. It shows two contrasting attitudes toward the evil in the world. Virgil shows a Stoic detachment while Dante is holding onto Virgil for dear life. Unlike Virgil, he shows interest in their suffering.

Death and Immortality Vladimir Solovyov appeared on the world stage at the end of the 19th century as a new beacon. He was not understood, and his thought is still being digested. As we mentioned last time, the Common Task inaugurated by Nikolai Fyodorov, was his starting point. Death is the ineradicable evil in the world. However, Fyodorov's proposed solution of a physical, medical resurrection of the dead is untenable. What is the point, Solovyov asks, is bring the dead back into the world of evil?

There is no war of the good against the evil; they cannot be so easily separated. Rather the world itself is evil and is in need of salvation. The opposite of death is immortality, specifically, immortality in Christ. Just as the telos of animals (he wrote to Tolstoy) is rationality, immortality is the telos of humankind. This will be spearheaded by a higher order of evolved Christians. They will create intentional communities of spirit based not on blood, nation, or family ties, but on spiritual development.

A divine-human interactivity provides the motor forces. He identifies them as godmanhood, Christ the Logos, Sophia the World Soul. Godmanhood is the divinization of the human being, Christ is the uplifting force, and Sophia is active in the world, the opponent of the Prince of the World, envisioned as stomping on the serpent.

Evil in the World

We Christians should search our consciences and see whether we do not tend to pay too little attention to the spiritual powers of genuine mysticism and so let many people of real spiritual depth drift away from us. That is something which we should always bear in mind, even while rejecting, as we must necessarily do, the whole movement as it presents itself to us today.

FR. ALOIS WIESINGER, *Occult Phenomena*²⁶

Fr. Alois Wiesinger was speaking of Rudolf Steiner, who appeared at a time of cultural decline to adapt spiritual knowledge to the modern age. But there are two Steiners. The first is Steiner the philosopher and metaphysician who writes often lucidly on those topics. The second Steiner is prone to dreamy, fantasies, which he described as “Spiritual Science”. However, his close student, Valentin Tomberg, came to the realization that it could not be a science because his visions were neither verifiable nor repeatable. To Steiner’s credit, he recognized the significance of Solovyov long before Western academicians. Hence, I will simply quote from the essay previously mentioned. The significance of resurrection for Solovyov is made totally clear.

His idea is this: There is evil in the world, wickedness in the world. If we, with our senses, behold the evil and wickedness, we

²⁶<https://www.gornahoor.net/library/occultPhenomena.pdf>

cannot deny that the world is full of both. This, says Soloviev, refutes the divinity of the world, for when we behold the world with our senses, how can we believe in a divine world, since a divine world can certainly not exhibit evil! But the senses perceive evil everywhere and the extreme evil is death. Because death is in the world, the world is revealed in all its evil and wickedness. The arch-evil is death!

Look at the world with your ordinary senses; try to understand the world with your ordinary mind. You can never deny the existence of evil in the world, and to desire to understand death would be absurd! Death exists. Knowledge acquired through the senses reveals a world of wickedness, a world of evil. Can we believe, asks Soloviev, that this world is divine when it shows us that it is full of evil, when it shows us death at every step? Nevermore can we believe that a world that shows us death is a divine world. For in God there can be no evil, no wickedness, above all, not the arch-evil death. In God there cannot be death.

If, therefore, God were to come into the world, if God were to appear, should we be able immediately to believe him to be God? No, we should not! He would have to establish his identity first. If a being claiming to be God were to appear, we should not believe him. He would have to prove his identity by producing something of the nature of a world document that would enable us to recognize him as God! Nothing of the kind exists in the world. God cannot prove his identity through what is in the world, for everything in the world contradicts the divine nature. By what means, then, can he prove his identity? Only by showing, when he comes into the world, that he has conquered death, that death can have no power over him. We should never believe Christ to be God if He did not prove his identity. But Christ did so, inasmuch as He has risen, inasmuch as He has shown that the arch-evil, death, is not in Him.

It is a consciousness of the divine that is based solely upon

the actual, historical resurrection of Christ, Who, as God, proves His identity. Soloviev goes on to say: Nothing in the world, with the single exception of the Resurrection, enables us to realize that a God exists. If Christ had not risen, all our belief would be vain, and everything we could say about a divine nature in the world, this too would be vain. Soloviev quotes these words of St. Paul again and again.

If we look at the world, we see therein only evil, wickedness, degeneration, senselessness. If Christ had not risen, the world would be meaningless, therefore Christ has risen! Note this sentence well, for it is a cardinal saying of one of the greatest thinkers of Eastern Europe: "If Christ had not risen the world would be senseless, therefore Christ has risen." Soloviev has said: "There may be people who think it illogical when I say, if Christ had not risen the world would be senseless; therefore, Christ has risen — but this is far better logic than any you can adduce against me."

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GgnClrx8N2k>

Posted on 2022-03-17 by Cologero

* * *

Auld Wat on 2022-03-18 at 05:40 said:

I finished a Canticle for Leibowitz yesterday. The last abbot of the order is talking with an atheist doctor who just wants to ease the pain of his patients through euthanasian, he admonishes him thus "you are a soul, you only temporarily have a body." A helpful reminder which chimes with traditional Catholic teaching as in the daily prayer, "Remember, Christian soul, that thou has this day, and every day of thy life ... a body to mortify and a soul to save".

There's no surprise that Our Lady called on us to repent of our sins at Fatima, and that in the last two destructive centuries two long held beliefs of her greatness became dogmas. The world might not see it but Sophia is moving behind the scenes in parallel to Satan, captured brilliantly at the beginning of the scene where Christ carries the Cross to Golgotha in the Passion of the Christ.

Oswald Spengler on 2022-03-18 at 22:11 said:

If you're going to post the Rolling Stones, I'm surprised you didn't give a nod to Mikhail Bulgakov whose novel inspired that song. Bulgakov was very much in the Russian spiritual continuum descending from Soloviev

Cologero on 2022-03-18 at 22:18 said:

You are confusing Mikhail Bulgakov with Sergei Bulgakov. That is not an uncommon mistake.

Balder on 2022-03-19 at 04:13 said:

That RS song is really bad.

In the Bulgakov novel Satan merely gives men what they desire the most, ergo, he has an educational function for the souls of man. A late Finnish esoterist Pekka Ervast said that the angel Satan has as his kingdom the planet earth and in his function as the prince of the world he cannot do otherwise than give man his powers, knowing at the same time fully well that they misuse it for selfish ends. At the same time he said that we as humans are incapable of understanding such holiness and this is why men throw their own faults in his shoulders, and that Satan is always "happy" when men don't fall for his temptations and overcome themselves, and after Christ came the scepter of Satan (Justice/Rigor) is being slowly but steadily given into the hands of Christ (Love/Mercy). I guess this is more in line with a theosophical conception of Satan and goes against the grain of Christian theological thought where his function is that of an evil anti-god. But the same line of thought can also be seen in an esoteric interpretation of Job, for example.

Balder on 2022-03-27 at 18:55 said:

Perhaps the mystery of Satan can be explained in kabbalistic terms by the bright and obscure faces of Metatron aka Satan in this picture would be the "fallen Metatron", so like unto Him that man does not recognize his bright face until he knows himself?

Balder on 2022-03-27 at 19:05 said:

Just as God is surrounded by the "cloud of unknowing", the holy darkness, so is Satan surrounded by the "unholy darkness", the deeds of evil in which man projects the "devil" that is in reality only his own working.

Taivasvaeltaja on 2023-10-28 at 13:56 said:

"I have never understood men don't appreciate civilized table conversation and the Company of beautiful women."

– Master Woland

13.21 Meditation of Thais

Me and God The 2009 movie *The Answer Man*²⁷ starts with an interesting premise but then deteriorates into a saccharine boy meets, loses, regains girl story. Arlen Faber wrote a best selling spiritual book titled *Me and God*, in which he poses questions to God and records the responses. This led to spinoffs like the “Me and God Diet”, “Me and God for Teens”, etc. A cultlike following arose from the books. Arlen, however, is reclusive and makes no public appearances. Actually, his persona is arrogant, flippant, cynical, and unfriendly.



That is supposed to be off-putting, but it is actually endearing. He refuses to play the role of a spiritual guru gazing off into the Infinite. When it counts, however, he is kind; he took care of his Alzheimer diseased father in his final days. Nor does he live extravagantly although he could, and he lives a celibate life.

In a reversal of traditional wisdom, God was useless in Arlen’s life. Only his new girlfriend could save him from himself.

The Master’s Voice

The sheep hear his voice, and he calls his own sheep by name and leads them out. When he has brought out all his own, he goes before them, and the sheep follow him, for they know his voice.

JOHN 20:3-4

The mind of the masses is by nature inchoate. A leader is the one who is able to articulate their thoughts; they then recognize his voice. But the

²⁷<https://www.imdb.com/title/tt1187041/>

Good Shepherd calls out his own from among the masses. That is the voice that they recognize. Many are called but few are chosen. The rest have gone astray.

The film shows how an articulate voice can inspire the masses. In a scene at a bookstore, he implies that the authors of such books are more interested in the sales figures. In “real life”, Arlen is mocking figures like Rick Warren, Eckhart Tolle, Neal Walsch, and others like them, who not only sell books but run expensive seminars.

Vedantic Christianity Edward Feser picks a fight with the latest book of his nemesis David Bentley Hart²⁸. Hart. DBH defends a position he calls Vedantic Christianity which he vehemently opposes to Thomism. Feser defends Saint Thomas and criticizes DBH for talking about God.

They are both weak on modal logic. Feser seems to believe that free will is the gnomonic will, or the ability to make a choice.

Objection 1: Either the choice is arbitrary, in which case it is unfitting to God. Or the choice depends on some other factor, in which case God is not free.

DBH claims that the world follows necessarily from God’s nature.

Objection 2: Free will means a will that arises from one’s nature and is not dependent on something else. Hence, God’s will does not depend on the world. The world therefore is not necessary since it is contingent on God’s will.

We answer that: The fellows missed the mess call and are eating crumbs. Evola called Guido De Giorgio a “Vedantic Christian”²⁹.

Moreover, in *Man and his Becoming*, Rene Guenon described the metaphysics of the Vedanta and asserted that in essential ways, Aristotle and the Scholastics were in harmony with that metaphysics.

²⁸<https://www.thepublicdiscourse.com/2022/03/80430/>

²⁹<https://www.gornahoor.net/?p=1267>

Professional Thinkers The rise of the Internet has given rise to a new type of professional Christians and public intellectuals. 100K views on youtube can bring the author as much as \$1800; that does not count income from Patreon or superchats. The masses cannot juggle too many ideas at once, so these professionals have to repeat themselves. Once they have an image, it is costly to change it.

Jordan Peterson's IQ The fellow is obsessed with IQ and in a recent video he announces his IQ. The GRE used to be a good proxy for IQ. Me. Peterson says he scored in the 75th percentile on the quantitative part of the test and that somehow equates to a 150 IQ. Now a person at that level of intelligence will be incomprehensible to the masses, even most college graduates. Or perhaps he is so intelligent that he understands that the masses will understand metaphors about lobsters and cleaning up your room.

He seems to almost megalomaniacal, claiming expertise on virtually any subject. Pseudo-intellectuals are recognized by their obsession with quantum mechanics, and that seems to be his most recent obsession.

Why ask why I often get very nice feedback from readers who understand what is going on here. Casual readers think we are encouraging a debating society. The Why of things are not amenable to debate. For example, an encyclopedic article on glass would describe its chemical composition, its history, its production. But the real question is "why is there glass?" It's really convenient that such a substance exists in the world.

Superimposition of Thought Intuition is a direct experience of the world, unmediated by thought. Its most basic form it is our sensual experience of the world, which is the fundamental form of knowing. We have a direct representation of the world in consciousness, which is prior to thinking. This then is covered up with a series of running thoughts,

or “narrative” as it is called. This interpretation of reality displaces direct experience, as the commentary displaces the direct experience.

The *ratio* is the first moment of the mind, but there is a higher form of knowing than that. Analogous to sense experience, there is direct, unmediated experience of higher realities. That is called “intuition”. But even more noticeably, intuitions are mediated by running thoughts from theories, debates, etc. No matter how subtle the theories are, they can never achieve intuitive knowledge. Esoteric training requires mastery of the thinking function.

Thinking and Science If thinking and science are all that is required, why have all problems not been resolved by now? Of the approximately 50 billion humans who have ever existed, only an insignificant number have contributed anything of value to the human race beyond their own progeny.

Knowledge of the Gods From the above, it is obvious that the human race could never have survived in the wild. What are called “primitive people” are not an early phase of human existence. Rather, they are the residues of higher civilizations.

Civilization, and the technological means to achieve it, came from a higher source. There are competing theories about how that happened. The Hollywood version is that aliens from intergalactic civilizations brought that knowledge to earthlings. Occultists claim that ascended masters taught such things to the elites of the human race. The *Book of Enoch* claims that angels brought technology:

Azazel taught men to make swords, and knives, and shields, and breastplates, and made known to them the metals of the earth and the art of working them, and bracelets, and ornaments, and the use of antimony, and the beautifying of the eyelids, and all kinds of costly stones, and all colouring tinctures.

But the human race became corrupt, and knowledge became more ambiguous, with the possibility of evil. Enoch continues:

There arose much godlessness, and they committed fornication, and they were led astray, and became corrupt in all their ways. Semjaza taught enchantments, and root-cuttings, Armaros the resolving of enchantments, Baraqijal, taught astrology, Kokabel the constellations, Ezeqeel the knowledge of the clouds, Araquel the signs of the earth, Shamsiel the signs of the sun, and Sariel the course of the moon.

So the gods were reluctant to reveal too much, too soon. **Prometheus** had to steal knowledge from the gods, for which he was punished. We today benefit from our technology, yet are punished for knowing it.

Meditation de Thaïs Athanaël, a Cenobite monk, confronts Thaïs, a beautiful and hedonistic courtesan and devotée of Venus, and attempts to persuade her to leave her life of luxury and pleasure and find salvation through God. Following the Meditation, Thaïs tells Athanaël that she will follow him to the desert.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Af0AxQyuEUs>

Posted on 2022-04-19 by Cologero

13.22 The Holy Ghost Movement

Around the 11th century, there was a manifestation of a new spirituality, attributed to the Holy Ghost. However, this led to commotion and agitation. Carl Jung describes it:

Everyone felt the rushing wind of the pneuma; it was an age of new and unprecedented ideas which were blazoned abroad by the

Cathari, Patarenes, Concorricci, Waldenses, Poor Men of Lyons, Beghards, Brethren of the Free Spirit, “Bread through God,” and whatever else these movements were called.

CARL JUNG, *Aion*

There beliefs can be summarized:

- they believe themselves to be God by nature without distinction
- they are eternal.
- they have no need of God or the Godhead.
- they constitute the kingdom of heaven.
- they are immutable in the new rock, that they rejoice in naught and are troubled by naught.
- a man is bound to follow his inner instinct rather than the truth of the Gospel which is preached every day
- they believe the Gospel to contain poetical matters which are not true.

In summary:

They were made up of people who identified themselves (or were identified) with God, who deemed themselves supermen, had a critical approach to the gospels, followed the promptings of the inner man, and understood the kingdom of heaven to be within. In a sense, therefore, they were modern in their outlook, but they had a religious inflation instead of the rationalistic and political psychosis that is the affliction of our day.

In that milieu, **Joachim of Fiore** announced the coming of the new Age of the Spirit, following the preceding Age of the Son and the Age of the Father. This third age, he claimed, began with Saint Benedict. Although his theology was ambiguous, his life was pious. Dante even recognized him in Paradise. Nevertheless, the effects were real, as described by Jung. The Age of the Spirit is upon us, as well as the seductions of the Antichrist. Deep discernment is necessary to tell the difference. So he cannot be held responsible for the excesses of that movement. It took a while for the best theologians to digest the Holy Ghost Movement.

The repercussions of the Holy Ghost movement spread, in the years that followed, to four minds of immense significance for the future. These were Albertus Magnus (1193-1280); his pupil Thomas Aquinas, the philosopher of the Church and an adept in alchemy (as also was Albertus); Roger Bacon (c. 1214-c.1294), the English forerunner of inductive science; and finally Meister Eckhart (c. 1260-1327), the independent religious thinker, now enjoying a real revival after six hundred years of obscurity.

Levels of Being

Man is as if he were three men, an **animal man**, as he is according to the senses, then a **rational man**, and finally the **highest god-like man**. . . One is the external, animal, sensual man; the other is the internal, rational man, with his rational faculties; the third man is the spirit, the highest part of the soul.

JOHANNES TAULER

Although Tauler's remark is consistent with St. Paul's teaching, it is never heard in exoteric preaching. Although in most cases this teaching is either unknown or poorly understood, there are sound reasons for

suppressing it. Obviously, it is incompatible with the egalitarian attitude so prevalent today.

The main problem is that people will tend to overestimate their own progress. Anyone can claim, for example, to be the highest type of man, apart from any actual attainment. The Cathars used it to create a privileged class. Although people of the spiritual class claimed to transcend personal desires, in actuality they were libertines. This was justified by the claim that such liberties had no effect on them. The greatest danger is that the “animal man” may be associated with a particular race or ethnicity, i.e., a biological rather than spiritual state.

We had a recent comment from a reader who asserted that his spiritual director advised him not to read the mystics directly. This demonstrates the point about suppression.

There are Greek terms—hylic, psychical, pneumatic—for Tauler’s classification, although “carnal” is often used for “hylic”. The effect of religious teachings is different when they affect the different types. For example,

- **Hylic.** The hylic personality will be most impressed with material and physical issues. For example, he or she will be interested in miracles or other unusual phenomena, patterns of clouds in the sky, historical events (which are for some reason called “literal”), and so on.
- **Rational.** This type loves to argue. He misunderstands spiritual combat to be some sort of intellectual battle of ideas. Instead of seeking wisdom like the philosophers, he enjoys “making a case”, as the sophists would do. He maintains centuries old divisions, regarding them as inspired somehow, instead of looking for reconciliation.
- **Spiritual.** The spiritual man wonders whether he should laugh or cry.

Psychic Reality Like **Meister Eckhart**, Tauler understands that the real birth of the Son is in the soul when he writes:

God accomplishes all His works in the soul and gives them to the soul; and the Father brings forth His only-begotten Son in the soul, as truly as He brings Him forth in eternity, neither less, nor more.

That would disturb the materially minded, the hylic personalities, who believe that the physical is more real than the psychical. Whatever his faults and limitations may be, Carl Jung seems closer to Eckhart and Tauler in his insistence that the psyche is *real*. For many, the notion that something happens in the soul means that it is less real, it is imaginary, it is all “in your head”. In opposition to that notion, Jung makes this claim:

It does not matter at all that a physically impossible fact is asserted, because all religious assertions are physical impossibilities. If they were not so, they would necessarily be treated in textbooks of natural science. But religious statements without exception have to do with the reality of the psyche and not with the reality of *physis*.

Now a **Rene Guenon** might object that religious statements are disguised metaphysical statements. Nevertheless, Jung’s observation is a good half way point, and bears more fruit in practice.

Science and the Carnal Man Rudolf Steiner, in his commentary on Tauler, describes the limitations of science:

Man is entangled in the world of the senses and in the laws of nature, by which the world of the senses is dominated. He himself is a result of this world. He lives because its forces and substances are active in him, and he perceives and judges this world of the senses in accordance with the laws by which it and he are constructed.

This is the circularity of the deracinated, secularized, rational, scientific man. He is fundamentally a carnal man, a highly intelligent animal. However, all his science is self-confirming, so he is never able to break out of the circle to reach transcendent, or higher, knowledge. Steiner notes this anomaly:

Do we not stand above all mere conformity to natural laws when we survey how we ourselves are integrated into nature? We *see* with our eye in accordance with the laws of nature. But we also *understand* the laws in accordance with which we see. We can stand on a higher elevation and survey simultaneously the external world and ourselves in interplay. Is not then a nature active within us which is higher than the sensory-organic personality which acts according to natural laws and with natural laws? In such activity is there still a partition between our inner world and the external world?

A recent example is this study that *Finds It Might Not Be Consciousness That Drives The Human Mind*³⁰. The research notes that the carnal mind “gives us a feeling of ownership and control over the thoughts, emotions and experiences that we have every day”. On the contrary, the esoterist, the Hermetist, the yogi have known that for millennia, so the scientists are wasting their time. The mystics understand that thoughts and feelings spontaneously arise, in a manner not unlike our experiences of the external world, so that they are not part of our “inner being”. They have developed practices to observe the arising of thought and the means to resist the internal programming that they represent.

Their conclusion is quite odd:

the contents of consciousness are generated “behind the scenes”
by fast, efficient, non-conscious systems in our brains.

³⁰<https://www.sciencealert.com/research-finds-it-might-not-be-consciousness-that-drives-the-human-mind>

We are left wondering how exactly does the brain produce thoughts. Is there some chemical formula or equation of physics that describes each thought? Since our lived world is the creation of our thoughts, it would be incredible if someone could describe a modern city as the result of some efficient system in the brain.

The denial of the immateriality of the soul is a misuse of intelligence.

Posted on 2022-05-01 by Cologero

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De Bosit on 2022-05-02 at 00:55 said:

I like the studies conclusion.

I think of it as frequencies, where you let the higher regions do their thing in peace and I just say what comes to mind without deliberation.

If you make those higher regions known to yourself you will come off like coked up Charley Sheen, well at least that is my experience.

Better let it do it's thing in peace and enjoy the comfort.